The Inimitable Meowmeow

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/48300766.

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Mature

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

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The Inimitable Meowmeow

by SleeveGartersSapphic

Summary

'For Greyskull's honour, Meowmeow! Who the devil are they?! The fellows staring at us, I mean.'

'Those would be our potential readers, sir. They wish to assess our story. We must inform them that the tale updates regularly and content warnings are listed in the relevant chapter's notes. Volume 1 runs to Chapter 26; Volume 2 to 39; Volume 3 from 40. Mature chapters are flagged in their introduction, the rest are Teen and Up.'

'Ah, yes! Readers. What Ho! Smashing to meet you - I'm Adora. Sir Adora de l'Horde, third Baronet, to be quite exact. And that other dashing madam? My gentlewoman's gentlewoman, Meowmeow. Oh... hang on. Old habits, old bean! I should rather say--- my girlfriend Catra. You're about to learn just quite how that came to be, from the very beginning. Plenty more thunders on around it too, what with my pal Bowregard, Her Ladyship Glimmer, and the whole cadre of lesbians we stumbled into. Oh, and the gender business. It all starts with the um... How do you say it, Meowmeow?'

'Indictment for theft of a marine vehicle, sir.'

'No, no, not that. The um... The meet-cute! So strap on your buckled shoes, dust down your pinstripes, and away to the city streets of London in our year 1930.'

Chapter 1

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VOLUME 1

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PART 1

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Just why in the blazes had they moored a row of skiffs there anyway, that's what I wanted to know. Any reasonable fellow would assume the same as I – namely that property double-knotted to the Club boathouse was fair game for the membership. It's plum unreasonable to go about lashing this seafaring wood to that sea-adjacent wood and not expect the lightly oiled gentlewoman to take the initiative.

Departing the Regatta on foot was out of the question, anyhow. With the Paddington express scheduled for the hour – and damn sticklers for punctuality those Great Western guards are, let me tell you – the onward route simply had to be one of dashing fortitude and reckless disregard for one's summer linens. Lady Glimmer was already aboard, you see, and looking quite tremendously impatient. Well it's not for Sir Adora to inflict
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rudeness on her betters. I picked up the old paddle and did my duty, like any patriotic Etherian!

The magistrate was having none of it, when we met the following morn. Now, granted, the previous evening had progressed towards the natural libations. And one might not have put on quite the show that an Oxford education should guarantee, but I maintain my point was saliently argued. Perish the soul who forgets their social obligations to the Chesham Place Brightmoons. There but for Her Ladyship’s grace go I, and all that. I could hardly refuse.

The price for such gentlewomanly consideration? Twenty pounds fined on the spot, and a jolly stern rollicking. My misdemeanour – to use the legal lexicon – was priced at ten bob but the fellow in the powdered hairpiece added the same again when I had the initiative to questions his finer points. 'Let that be a lesson to you,' he said. 'Authority is to be respected, more than to be understood.' Well, I say. In what an age we live, where the intrepid spirit is no longer entitled to a robust defence. And Glimmer started it.

In this final pronouncement, I may have strayed. The shouting that followed certainly suggests as much. Ears stewed to near rhubarb, I found myself bundled from the courthouse and ejected out onto the cobblestones, my fall only ending when I collided with the back seat of a passing jitney.

Lurching dawn would do little to lift my mood – and rather more to raise my supper. ‘By the Honour of Greyskull, my good man,’ I exclaimed, as my driver cut a particularly troubling impression of the Brooklands Double Twelve. ‘Might you consider that we

weren't all born with an iron constitution!' He met my cries with deaf ears, and before you could say Leather Lane, I discovered the truer meaning of "gimlet". Short, sharp drink, my eye. This lime and gin concoction had surely been named for its uncanny ability to bore through the stomach. With a half dozen working on my composure, one could only bow to the inevitable…

Coat and cab repainted a fetching technicolour, what more was there to do than ascend to my rooms? An Etherian's home is her castle, and all that. I disrobed to the best of my blunted abilities and – unsure of what vittles might remain in the homestead – called upon my trusty manservant. 'Kyle? Kyle!' The blasted fellow gave no reply. 'Goddammit Kyle, where in the blazes are you? I could really do with some help here.' Silence, still.

I retreated to the chaise longue with a weary sigh. Kyle really was as much use as a sealed chimney. If he thought another raise might be forthcoming… Reality washed over me with the grey chill of a Scarborough seafront. No less than a week had transpired since Kyle had wadded his resignation into a bundle of papers. He'd announced that his future lay not in service but upon the stage.

Well, good luck to the brute, his strapping gentleman Rogelio and their fair lady Lonnie. After the last sorry season, London theatre could do with the fresh blood, there was no doubt about that. Alas, the West End's gain was a loss to Belgravia. Heavens, I'd have to starch my own collars. Quite how that might be achieved I really couldn't say.

None of the items in the various oddment cupboards appeared all that self-explanatory. I settled on the electric iron, which at least

showed an interest in the technical advancements of the day. I liked its pluck. Plugging it into the wall, I ventured to place the rapidly heating metal atop a shirt sleeve, already assured of my success. And, for a moment, all was well. The silk flattened, the device gave out a satisfying hiss and Kyle was but a distant memory.

Then the smell started, wafting a heady aroma that echoed my one attempt at a cooked breakfast. Fearing a repeat, I lifted the iron away and revealed ash and sackcloth, where once had been my clothing. Why one would own such an actively dangerous device was beyond me, but then Kyle had always been a figure of domestic mystery.

Any further ruminations would have to wait. The sleeping hour was upon us. Rifling through the first mail did little to dissuade me of the notion. A mixture of bills, invites and pre-typed piffle, not one envelope aroused sufficient interest or bone-shaking terror to keep the eyelids from their inexorable droop. I took aim for bed. My sheets were unmade – damn it, Kyle – yet the Capital was soon but a distant hum. What bliss.

Bzzzzt. The door ringer shocked me awake. I had half a mind to let it ring, and serve them right for rousing a respectable figure at such an ungodly hour, whatever hour it might now happen to be. Bzzt. Bzzzzzzzzzzt. Damned persistent, aren't we? Well. Sir Adora, third Baronet to the good house of Greyskull is not so easily won! The ringing continued and I continued remaining precisely where I bloody well was.

Minutes passed and I sat there, bolt upright and perfectly still. I would not be leaving this bed, and nor would I so much as

uncross my arms in the face of that incessant ringing. Kyle, the milkman, the newspaper boy. It could be any one of them and they still would not prevail! At last, the sound rattled its completion and – victory assured – I sank back into the linens.

Swaddled like the proverbial lonesome babe, the thorns of yesterday slowly unpricked my weary heart. No more would I think of the Thames, of the boats or of that worrywort Bowregard. His retreating features rather soothed me, and then, sleep.

'Good day, Adora.'

I started to the clink of crystal and the slowly focusing vision of a strange fellow leaning against my armoire.

'How the devil did you get in here?'

'Through the door, sir.'

'Pish! I keep my door locked bally tight, I'll have you know. This flat is at the forefront of home security.'

'I'm afraid I have to disagree, sir.'

'And what are you doing with my whiskey?'

‘I appear to be drinking it, sir. Having acquainted myself with the general meilleur of the apartment, my intoxication commended itself as a fitting course of action. Would you rather I put myself to some other use, sir?’

‘Um, well, no. Do carry on.’

Blast that infernal Etherian politeness. Some reckless cad was bouncing through my rooms and all I could do was feebly approve. As the mental gears began to mesh, rounding gradually on a fitting course of action, my intruder regarded me with one yellow eye of restrained amity and a blue peeper filled with polite inquisition. She was entirely inscrutable. The time for words was over. I reached for my faithful sword cane.

‘By the Honour of…’

‘I advise against that course of action, at least in your current condition, if sir might permit my boldness. Perhaps sir would prefer that I prepared eggs…’

‘Wait! Just… hold it a second!’

My lately-arrived boudoir buddy replaced her tumbler. ‘Yes, sir?’

‘Who in Jove’s name are you?’

‘Meowmeow, sir.’

‘What?’

‘C. Applesauce Meowmeow. Your new valet.’

It hardly seemed credible.

‘Like Kyle?’

‘No, sir.’ Meowmeow seemed to wrinkle slightly at the suggestion, like a shirt askew on its hangar. ‘I think you shall find me most unlike Kyle.’

‘Well, pardon my indiscretion.’

‘Am I to assume you endorse my engagement, sir?’

‘But… Well…’

‘Thank you, sir. I shall begin preparing your breakfast at once.’

‘Now listen here, Meowmeow!’

‘I’ve taken the liberty of organising the first post – and you appear to have a luncheon engagement with a distinguished family member. It would be well within my duties to accompany you.’

The colour drained from my face.

‘It’s not… Aunt Shadowtha, is it?’

‘The very same, sir.’

‘On second thoughts, you’d make an absolutely capital addition to Maison d’Adora, old chum. Meowmeow, consider yourself engaged.’

‘Very good sir.’

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Chapter 2

Chapter Summary

'Every silver lining has its cloud, eh Meowm--- Catra?'

'A vivid and not inaccurate maxim, sir.'

'Reader-people! Behold our preliminary perambulation, across two miles of Capital cobblestones. Quite the walk it was too... Pity about its destination! Family affairs do rattle the spirit somewhat.'

'Hey! Adora. You don't have to see her ever again, not if you don't want to.'

'Thank you, Catra, I know. But let's not skip these fine fellows ahead, eh! Our ripping yarn lays down its second thread...'

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PART 2

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Aunt Shadowtha is nothing if not a permanent fixture in the life Adora. One really has no choice in the matter. When the Sixth Marchioness of Greater Horde sends a ‘gram down the wire, the planets themselves hop to re-aligning or rather live in fear of the consequences! So what is a humble rake to do, if not wolf down a capital breakfast – champion work, Meowmeow – and do her utmost to face down the spiralling dread with gritted gumption? The true Etherian holds a stiff upper lip, and all that.

There was no use in putting it off, old chap. I stood at the wardrobe mirror and repeated the maxim until the words ceased to make the first lick of sense, feeling all the while like I'd found my way back to the Headmaster's office. What wondrous, terrible fear! I could almost see my knees knocking but Meowmeow was having none of it. She snapped me from the shakes in short order, by thrusting a cane and sober leather gloves into my clenching palms. Where in heavens my customary stringbacks had gone, she simply couldn't say.

By elevenses, we were striking the Fitzrovia flagstones. The weather had seduced me to cross town by foot – the sun was out, the birds chirping with gusto – but a blackened mood overtook me with each passing step. Wimpole Street was a decidedly shabby destination for the woman-about-town looking to enjoy a sunny day, and each thought of the shadow-stricken stucco filled me with something approaching dread.

Palpitations ruddy well erupted as we crossed Hyde Park and cracked through my helpless porcelain complexion. Needless to say, I was well prepared. Sir Adora doesn't tour the Smoke without picking up a useful attitude or two along the way. Out came my most dependable companion, a monogrammed handkerchief decorated with prancing horses.

As it went about its business, I spied Meowmeow watching on with a new level of interest. Well, that was only to be expected. From the moment she'd burst into my life – all of around two hours ago – my de facto valet had set herself apart as a fellow sartorial non-conformist. Her dusky plum tuxedo cut a simply magnetic dash, uniform regulations be damned! Perhaps this

could be the topic that broke down the fusty assumed hierarchies of our blossoming sir-to-servant relationship. I could feel my icy mood beginning to thaw already.

'Come now, Meowmeow! No need to be so coy – you're welcome to a closer look.'

'Excuse me, sir?'

'Of my handkerchief! My handkerchief!!'

'The pattern is certainly striking, sir. Though I must confess myself uncertain of its meaning.'

'Here you go, look closer! They're tiny, rampaging mares in all these different colours, Meowmeow. Magnificent beasts, don't you think?'

'But what do they represent?'

'Blast it, they don't represent anything! I just really love horsies. And I wanted the handkerchief to match!'

'Very good, sir.'

The silence that followed was positively rotten. Function is something for the engine driver or the farmhand, not a pleasant stroll amongst the topiary. A valet in a magenta silk shirt should know that, if nothing else. I was having a Dickens of a time working her out. At one instant she staked a vibrant claim on the modish, the next she was spouting such confounded logic. For all that, I still had little clue what she thought of my wardrobe. And damn it, I felt a curious drive to impress.

'I say, Meowmeow,' I began, innocently enough. 'Isn't it odd that my driving gloves vanished this morning? And damn unfortunate, with it.'

'I must disagree, sir. With sir's autos remaining in the garage, there really is no need to wear such… particular fashion.'

Her inflection could have cut me, so disparaging was her tone. Further clarification was required!

'Is that so, Meowmeow? And what precisely do you so dislike about my choice in gloves? I happen to think they're damn jaunty!'

'Sporting clothing does not befit a gentlewoman in polite company, sir.'

‘Oh! I suppose that explains why you couldn’t find my cricket whites, either. It’s summertime, Meowmeow, and I happen to think my whites look rather natty at this time of year. Everybody who’s anybody was wearing them at Cheltenham, and again at Henley, just yesterday!’

‘Quite right, sir. They wore such clothes at leisure. If you might permit my indiscretion, on observing the hunch of your shoulders in response to the morning post, I concluded that attending the Marchioness should not be considered a frivolous affair. As such, the formal suiting I presented should be more appropriately dashing.’

Our conversation was cut short by the looming Gothic presence of Aunt Shadowtha’s abode. Situated doors from the finest living doctors and dead poets London has ever seen fit to produce, Auntie selected her city apartments, she said, in hopes such greatness might rub off on her youthful charge. After an upbringing amongst its portraits and antiquery, not to mention a certain hallway that still conjures a case of the squicks, I do believe I’ve absorbed all the place has to offer. But Auntie disagrees, and one doesn’t say no to Auntie.

‘Sir Adora of Greyskull, what a pleasure to make your acquaintance.’

‘I beg your pardon? It’s me, Auntie, your little Dorie.’

‘Impossible, Adora. The girl I raised would never bring her family name into disrepute.’

‘Heavens, no! Why, I was saying, just this morning, what pride swells my chest when I hear the words ‘de l’Horde’. The old moniker brings a tear to the eye and… Ow!’

Meowmeow, so far a silent partner in my descent into accusation and a hopefully probable luncheon, chose precisely this moment to stamp down on my right wingtip. She spared not one Newton in the operation.

‘Why the devil did you do that?’ I hissed damply.

‘Your speech evokes a certain poignant emotion, sir. I calculate that the Marchioness may be swayed by a practical demonstration of the feeling.’

‘By mangling my tootsies, Meowmeow?’

‘Like Iphigenia in Aulis, a regrettable sacrifice to summon forth the winds and the water.’

‘What?’

‘To make you cry, sir.’

‘Oh, right. I’ll get straight to it.’

Bless the woman for trying – and let’s not forget my robust dramatics, ably recalling the time I played Orsino in the Fifth Form play – but Aunt Shadowtha would not be swayed, even by such shrewd tactics.

‘Do not lie to me, Adora. I know all about your trip to the Regatta.’

‘In my defence, Auntie, the skiffs had been moored without so much as a noticeboard signifying their proper ownership,’ I gasped through the final saline spasms. ‘And possession is nine tenths of the law, don’t they say?’

‘I am far more concerned by the contents of the boat.’

‘Oh, just rope, oars and a sole Wellington boot, Auntie. Nothing to worry about.’

‘You will not crack wise in my presence, Adora! I mean the poor wretches caught up in your criminal behaviour.’

‘Of course, Auntie. Sorry, Auntie.’

‘An apology will hardly be enough. Even you must understand the black mark you have brought upon your family. After all the years I spent raising you, Adora, this is how you repay me?!’

Aunt Shadowtha spluttered as she stumbled to her feet, her mask slipping in a flash of atavistic fury. Crikey. I was really in for it this time. Time to turn on the old Adora charm, and not a moment to waste!

‘Auntie, you’re quite right, of course. And if I’ll go an inch, I’ll go a mile to avoid the same egregious errors in future. Really, Aunt Shadowtha, is my face red. It’s just that you always taught me to act the gentlewoman, and no less than Lady Glimmer Brightmoon had to make it onto the last train home. Now, curse my natural politeness but I thought it was best to…’

‘Enough! Insolent child. The Duchess Brightmoon telephoned me this very morning, to enquire why her eldest daughter had been entangled in your larceny. And so publicly, Adora. The whole Thames has seen your shame and I dread to think what her grace thinks of de l’Horde now. We may never recover.’

I was shaking like a leaf. Auntie had given me dressings down before, naturally, but rarely one of such ferocity. It was so utterly flabbergasting that I found myself dumbstruck, flapping my lips like an Atlantic salmon. I could say nothing to satiate my matriarch, literally, and stood there helpless as matters accelerated out of my control.

‘If it pleases your Ladyship, I may have a satisfactory solution for all involved.’

‘And who are you? Another of her wretched friends?’

‘Alas no, my Lady. Sir Adora recently employed me as her valet.’

‘Well, you can’t be any worse than that Kyle fellow. Speak.’

‘My heartfelt thanks,’ Meowmeow purred, before bowing deeper than I previously thought possible. But – by golly – she had Auntie’s attention.

‘Your Ladyship, it has come to my attention that the household Brightmoon intends to leave the city this afternoon to summer at their Shugborough estates. They shall be departing Euston by the three-thirty this afternoon.’

‘What a relief. Adora shan’t be able to haunt them any further.’

‘Quite the opposite. I believe sir should visit the family forthwith and apologise, unreservedly, in person. The sincerity of such an action would be inarguable, while the forthcoming village fete gives sir ample opportunity to offer her service to house Brightmoon. If that fails to do the trick, as it were, the Midsummer Ball should provide the fitting context for atonement.’

‘Intriguing. Adora, it would appear you have a chance to redeem yourself. Now away with you! I won’t have you become the topic of my bridge club.’

Blinking back on the street, I felt the relief of a doomed man spared the gallows, and I owed it all to Meowmeow.

‘Smashing work in there, old chum. The ticker really pounded before you swept in with that countryside idea.’

‘I am pleased you approve, sir.”

‘Yes, yes. What a splendid escape route you’ve plotted, and the run north is simply ideal for the Nash. The girl needs a proper run out – but not before we run home to pick up the right outfit for the trip.’

‘That would be so, had I not arranged the train tickets while you bathed this morning.’

‘Beg pardon? You mean you already knew we’d be going to old Sugar… somewhere??’

‘Yes, sir. And, tragically, there will be no need for your driving gloves.’

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Chapter 3

Chapter Summary

'You and I were fireworks that afternoon, eh Meowmeow?'

'I felt a certain spark, you might say.'

'And added a jolly great wodge of kindling to it! The train, the taxi, the gravel path. Each one had me burning deeper than the last, only you didn't seem too eager. A valet's code of conduct, and so forth. I can't tell you how silly I felt when I finally realised you'd spent the whole day pitching woo.'

'When was that, sir?'

'...'

'Come on, Adora.'

'Last week.'

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PART 3

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How had it come to this? The sun shone and evening invitations were piling, no doubt, on the homestead Wilton, yet here I was, letting myself get dragged onto the Euston platform by a woman I scarcely knew. In another world, such a development would be dashed exciting but the aforementioned madam was my valet,

Meowmeow. No matter how intriguing, one simply didn't trifle with the serving class. Aunt Shadowtha would have my head!

Idle thoughts evaporated as Meowmeow returned from the newsstands with a couple of books. Weighty things they looked to be, too. Staffordshire was some distance north – far beyond what could usually be considered worthwhile civilisation – but surely she wasn't planning to read so much during the journey? Meowmeow noted my curiosity and met it with a bow.

'I understand the Chesham Place Brightmoons are prominent members of the aristocracy,' she replied. 'One may reasonably expect their summer visitors to be similarly prolific. Sir may benefit from a revision session.'

My incredulous palms received both books, before my valet marched me towards the first class apartments. She'd got that right, at least. Once safely ensconced in my chair, lighter luggage stowed overhead and tea secured, I recovered enough composure to wish her a pleasant trip.

'You'll be wanting to get off to third class, eh Meowmeow? Only a couple of minutes now until full speed ahead!'

'Not to worry, sir. Should the LMS demonstrate its usual punctuality, our departure will be imminent.'

After a brief examination of her pocket watch – and to my utter amazement – she dropped neatly into the seat next to mine.

‘Meowmeow!? I’m all for a little fun and games, but you simply must go and take your seat.’

She cocked her head slightly and fixed me with a perfectly placid gaze.

‘I am already sitting in it, sir.’

‘But this is first class, Meowmeow! Valets travel back in third, separate from their employers, last thing I heard. Kyle always did, certainly.’

‘I am aware of the convention, sir. Though I cannot speak for… Kyle, I think it more important that a valet remains at her employer’s immediate disposal. To that end, I’ve taken the liberty of ordering afternoon tea. I’m reliably informed it should arrive before Watford Junction.’

Well, there was nothing I could say to that. I shuddered to think what mess I’d make affixing clotted cream to my own scones at eighty miles-per-hour, so Meowmeow would have to stay. Noggin swimming with emotions I really didn’t quite have the lexicon to voice, I sought solace in the books.

I'll tell you, I've made better choices – even the covers were confusing. Bound in red leather, picked out in gold, the blasted things read 'Who's Who' and 'Who Was Who', in an act I considered wilfully aggressive to the novice reader. Within were spiralling paragraphs on people the books told me were important, the ways in which they were important, and myriad ways they connected with the other important people.

It was no use. Even the revelation that I'd somehow made it inside one of the tomes wasn't enough to keep my mind from wandering back to my companion. Less the minutes she spent surgically measuring the jam and pouring the Darjeeling, Meowmeow spent the entire journey peering out the window with a distant, satisfied smile. The woman was utterly intriguing, and I couldn't help but sneak a look. Or several.

As we alighted at New Street, she looked back and I went the ruddiest shade of rhubarb. Cripes. Had I not fumbled a question about our connection, fabricating a reason to glance down at the timetable, I'd have been straight into dire straits. Crisis averted, I could barely stammer out a word until we transferred to a local taxi.

'So do you know anything about this Snug-barrow place, Meowmeow?'

'Shugborough has been the ancestral seat of the Chesham Place Brightmoons since the first Duchess received her title from Queen Anne in 1707.'

'What precisely did she do for old Queenie, eh?'

Meowmeow smiled ever so slightly, her twin-tone eyes glimmering.

‘Historians debate the precise nature of the women’s relationship, sir.’

‘Ah, um. Very good. Well, could you let me know when we motor into the Brightmoon stomping ground, as it were?’

‘We entered the Shugborough estate 20 minutes ago, sir.’

Another quarter hour must have passed before we zipped round the final curve and came face-to-face with the place. Big Romanesque thing it was too, with all the steps and pillars I just about remembered from that summer trip Auntie stipulated to the Bay of Misenum. Damned imposing, I must say. The grey stone and velvet curtains made the whole place look frightfully unwelcoming, and I began to remember why it was we’d come here.

I turned to Meowmeow, in the vain hope that this was all some misunderstanding she was about to rectify before we went home for supper, only to find she’d vacated her seat. My valet had already hopped up and out, raced around the car and started to open the door.

‘Sir Adora de l’Horde, third baronet of Greysk…’

‘Adora, Adora! Hey!’ Bowregard L. Georgeson bounded into view and cut off my announcement before Meowmeow could ring out the final syllable. My, she didn’t take at all well to that. Without sacrificing an inch of her upright composure, my valet turned out her left foot and tripped my boating buddy, sending the man stumbling towards the taxicab. Operating on the rugger player’s instinct, I flung my door open and rushed to grapple Bowregard before any real harm could be done.

‘I didn’t know you were a hugger!’

Bowregard squeezed back, so hard that I could no longer count on the location of my kidneys. If they weren’t thrown up into my ribcage, I’d eat my hat, if only my compacted organs still had the capabilities to pull off such a feat.

‘Well, you know how it is, chum. I’m rather overcome with the emotion of it all. It’s just such devilishly good luck to see you here, all in one piece.’

‘I don’t know what you mean, Adora. Glimmer’s got me going everywhere with her this season. I’m at Shugborough more than I’m anywhere else – I’ve never known a friendship like it.’

‘So the Duchess hasn’t called for your head, as it were?’

‘Not as far as I know! An arching lesson or two, perhaps, but nothing else that I’ve heard.’

‘What a relief! I’ll be honest, chap, Auntie dispatched me up here on a sackcloth and ashes mission but the heart isn’t in it. I’ve been frightfully afraid all the way up that the Duchess wanted us ground into star dust for the whole skiff business.’

‘Oh, no. Adora, she’s still mad with you for that. Very mad. I’d stay out of her way, at least until more water has passed under the bridge. Huh? Get it? Water! Bridge!’

I met Bowregard with an expression flatter than a Norfolk potato field.

‘It’s a pun, Adora. Because we were seen rowing by all those people on the bridge in Henley?’

‘I get it, Bow.’

‘Okkkaaayyy… Well. You shouldn’t go in and see her right now, so I guess I could give you a secret tour of the estate? Introduce you to some of the other guests?’

Not for the first time today, I found myself wrenched off in a direction not even slightly of my own choosing. This business really had to come to a halt, and pronto. Apollo was burning away up there, rendering us Etherians just toasty enough to reap full benefit from the upcoming cocktail hours, and old Adora was caught meeting a gaggle of country-bound strangers. Strangers, worse still, who had travelled to Staffordshire of their own free volition. The blood chilled to think of it.

'Bowregard, my good fellow, you can't expect a respectable gentlewoman to introduce herself before divesting herself of her travelling suit, eh?'

'Nonsense, Adora! You'd only just stepped off a train when you met me, and that didn't stop me loving you. It's going to be fine.'

'Ah, yes, but back then I was dressed with my own rapscallion zeal. Not like today. Um, no, not at all. You see, this outfit is the work of my new valet, Meowmeow, and she's so terribly fresh to it that I haven't had a moment to tutor her in my sartorial code."

The chap was seeing sense, at last. Bow turned to face me and – bless the gent – our progress seemed to cease. His fizzgog bisected like the Cheshire Cat, so I thought to venture a cautious grin in return.

'Don't say another word, Adora! I get it – I get it entirely.'

‘Thank you, Bow. Now we can forget this whole silly---’

‘You’re afraid there are going to be girls there! Well, you don’t need to worry. I mean, yes. Glimmer has invited a lot of her friends, and a lot of her friends are women, but that doesn’t mean you need to worry. Just be yourself and I’m sure they’ll like you. You’re kind, you’re courageous, you’re handsome… Hey! Some of them might even like-like you, huh?!’

‘Geeee… Eeeeee…. Aaaaaah…. Well. Good heavens.’ I felt myself turn redder than a student rally. ‘How--- how did you know, Bow?’

Sniggering broke out scant feet to my rear, growing damned capricious as my exasperation reached for new and inventive vowel sounds. That was something to shut down, I’ll say. I pivoted to meet my snickering assailant – and found myself face-to-face with Meowmeow.

The horror.

Quite without instruction, my valet had followed in every one of my footsteps. She could have heard the whole darn thing. Well, I’d suffered plenty at her hand today, but this wouldn’t stand.

‘Meowmeow, that’s quite enough. Really, how would you respond if a trusted friend accused you of visiting the Greek island?’

‘I would congratulate their perceptivity, sir. I am an unapologetic Sapphist.’

Meowmeow smirked whilst she enunciated the term, as if it brought her some immeasurable quantity of pride. And, you know, perhaps it should. So raffishly dressed and socially polished was she, so easily redolent of Colette, Baker and Dietrich, my valet arriviste no doubt commanded the heart of every Lesbian in London. It wasn’t a matter of attraction – merely an objective observation. If I were to find myself in such a position, then surely---

Wait a minute. Was it just me, or was the weather turning awfully toasty? One simply couldn’t be too careful around this time of year – and Meowmeow had dressed me in Harris wool! The material was alright enough in Auntie’s drab, drafty corridors but woefully out of place in the afternoon sun. Yes, the suiting had to be it. I was feeling ever so flustered. Just how difficult could it be to remove a suit jacket? Swimming from deep inside my spinning skull, a protestation faintly formed on my lips:

‘You know, I think I need a quick lie down.’

Both my tormentors rushed forwards, Meowmeow muscling a lead that let her catch me in her arms, only adding to my tumult.

‘Does sir feel unwell? If you might permit me to say, you feel notably warm to the touch.’

‘Meowmeow, you do have some odd notions. If you would just unhand me…’

‘Are you quite sure, sir?’

‘Yes. Yes, blast it.’

‘As you wish, sir.’

Surrendering both palms in an instant, she drew herself up to full height and retreated a half-step, only to watch me – her gentlewoman, no less – fall to the floor. Honestly, the woman was impossible. Bowregard ran the final steps of his race and swept to my aid in response. I would have bloody well refused it, if only I’d known inquisition that came with it.

‘Adora! Are you okay?’

‘No need to worry old chap. I just came over all hot and bothered.’

‘I’ll say so! Who was that?’

‘Who? Oh, that’s the new valet I was telling you about. Goes by Meowmeow.’

‘So you’re sharing a flat with that long drink of debonair sass?’

‘I suppose so. Quite right.’

‘Come on, you don’t have to lie to me Adora! Are you two, y’know, roommates?’

‘Bow! No! Nothing like that. I simply awoke to Meowmeow in my apartments this a.m. and she made me breakfast, before we agreed on the exact nature of our arrangement. And, well, we seem to be rubbing along, all things considered.’

‘Adora.’

‘I can’t see why you’re gasping. That’s the truth of the matter, chap. When a gentlewoman finds the right fit for her domestic arrangements, then she must strike while the iron is hot. Unconventional she might be, but I’m rather taking a shine to her. I outline the facts out of trusting friendship and here you are, peepers gleaming like the stars themselves.’

‘Eeek! Sooooo… Do you like-like her?’

‘Oh, do give it a rest. No, I don’t like her that way, but---’ I wasn’t sure how best to complete what could turn out to be quite the monumental sentence. It transpires once can manage quite the measure of historic self-reflection when prompted by heatstroke

and a dashing woman's embrace. Screw one's courage and so forth.

'But I do like girls. Like-like them, I mean. Looking back, I've been like-liking girls for as long as I can count. And I've never said that out loud to anyone before.'

'Adora, that's wonderful! Thank you.'

'For what?'

'For telling me, silly. Glimmer is going to be so excited too. If you want to tell her, I mean. She's been wondering ever since you kissed her.'

'Oh yes, I suppose I did. More than once.'

'Are you ready to kiss some more? If you want to, I mean, and they do too. There are so many women here who love women – and I just know they're going to adore you.'

'You did say. Well, that sounds like a jolly good bit of fun.'

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Chapter 4

Chapter Summary

'A tea-time of firsts, this! My premier She-Ra moment, plus my first deliberately Sapphic steps.'

'Look at you, sir. Dizzy with every dame you met - even when you'd only just met them. Should I be jealous?'

'You're a fine one to talk! Reader-people: when I walked into that greenhouse, Catra had a half-dozen women clinging on her every word... or admiring her... well... her décolletage.'

'Really? I counted seven. Adora, are you blushing?'

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PART 4

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‘So, Bow, how’s it been with you, old fellow? Any happenings to report since our last encounter? I’m dashed curious to learn how you ended up in Staffordshire of all places.’

‘You mean, what’s happened since you made me accessory to a crime?’

‘Oh, don’t be like that. Borrowing a boat is hardly the work of a remorseless felon, no matter what Auntie and that damned magistrate might have you believe.’

‘That’s not how my paters see it, Adora! They’re insisting I motor down to the Bodliean and assist them in their research. I’m meant to be researching 14th century Breton-Cornish Arth-Redian chivalric myth--- for the summer. The **whole** summer, Adora. They think it’ll teach me to be a true gentleman but it’s soooo dull.’

‘Arthurian, eh? Rum luck. How did you get out of it?’

‘I told them I was heading over to Christs, so I could study a new research paper one of the DPhils has just finished. You know, keeping up to date on the latest developments.’

‘By Jove, I bet they love that. But isn’t Christ Church still in Oxford, chap? Won’t they get suspicious when you’re not in evidence, pootling about and all that?’

‘That’s the brilliant bit! I sent them a letter just this afternoon to “clear up the confusion” and let them know I’m all safe at Christ’s College, Cambridge. They won’t expect me back for days.’

‘And you’re sending the note from here? From Shugborough?’

‘Absolutely! I’m pretty proud of the idea, if I do say so.’

‘But Bow--- What about the post mark? Won’t it read Shugborough village, or Cannock in the best case?’

The chap went as shapeless and insipid as last night’s veal escalope. It was enough to turn the strongest of stomachs, Bow despairing that his subterfuge would be revealed in little over a single terrestrial rotation. Less, if this desolate place had an evening collection. For reasons quite unknown, treacherous, teasing Meowmeow chose the depths of our present melancholy to break her silence.

‘If I might venture an opinion, sir, your friend…’

‘Not now, dash it! The poor wretch is crushed, with no hope of happy resolution, so why don’t you shoot off wherever this path winds up and prime the ladies on our unfortunate situation? Go on! Do something useful for once!’

‘As you wish, sir.’

‘And Bowregard L.?’

‘Uh? Huh?’ My friend snuffled through a bundle of well-wetted cotton. A sorry sight, I have to say. One considered the great camaraderie of handing over my own handkerchief and

commiserating with the doomed, but an Etherian is made of sterner stuff. Not to mention the disamelioration he'd inflict on dear Horsie. Matters – I decided – were not yet so very dire.

'Bow, my fellow, there's no use crying over spilt milk. Especially when the gold top has already dripped through the letter box, as it were. But rest assured! Sir Adore de l'Horde, third Baronet of Greyskull, is on the case – even now I can hear the neurons whirr as I close in on a plan. We shall shield you from your fathers' wrath, no matter the cost.'

My sword cane quivered aloft as I struck out the words and – just for an instant – I rushed with the heated of inner conviction. I would get this done and save my friend. Quite how, I didn't know, but such trivialities always worked themselves out in time. Bow certainly seemed impressed, and wasn't that half the battle?

'Adora, you're glowing!'

'Well, I was a leading light in the Oxford Oratory Society.'

'No, you're literally glowing. And your stature---'

'Ah yes. I suppose you've never heard my full title. I'm technically a Lord too, ever since Auntie named me her heir.'

‘Listen to me, Adora. You just grew taller for a second. How did you do that that? How would anyone?’

‘Oh Bow, you do flatter me. That’s just the old de l’Horde conviction sparking to life. Forever Forwards, Never Bowed. We’re warriors, chap. Unstoppable!’

‘But Adora…’

‘Yes, yes. I can’t manage anything right this moment but just you wait for inspiration to strike. I’ll be ready, I assure you. We’re going to win in the end.’

Tough a time as he was having, decisions had to be made. One doesn’t just stand about with a farm-fresh sexuality realisation and do nothing, not when there’s a cadre of Sapphics close at hand. Grasping Bowregard by the cuff, I marched our two-strong party off up the garden path. A quick enquiry of a nearby groundsman shaped my steps and, in a scant quarter hour, we found ourselves in sight of a hothouse. Robust thing it was, too, riddled with all that Gothic ironmongery Aunt Shadowtha liked so much. Through its shimmering walls I sensed foliage, fruit and the delicate sighs of intrigued ladyfolk. My moment had arrived.

‘What ho! Ladies, if I could steal a moment to introduce myself, I’d be most obliged.’ Bursting into the room with a most dashing introduction, I prepared myself for the interests of perhaps half a dozen, maybe more, based on the glowing commendation Bowregard had given me but minutes earlier. In its place, I

received not a bean. Backs were turned, their corresponding faces nosing towards plants, ponds… and my blasted valet.

Amongst the fruitiest vines stood Meowmeow, who, to my utter horror, had entirely forgotten the fundaments of her outfitting. Until now her bow-tie had been impeccably finished but, amidst the humidity and bonhomie of this sweltering enclave, she'd seen fit to undo the thing. The informality struck like a hammer blow, so at odds was it with convention. And if I felt so strongly, surely those not yet introduced to my gentlewoman's gentlewoman would be entirely unable to look away. I had to put a stop to it.

'Now, Meowmeow, listen here.'

'One moment, sir. I am currently engaged with this charming woman.'

She turned inquiringly to a figure of draping dress and soft inflection.

'Would madam permit me to continue in present company?'

Meowmeow's chatting partner scrunched her forehead to scrutinise me more closely.

'Oh! Is she your…'

‘The gentlewoman for whom I am resident gentlewoman, madam.’

‘And you feel comfortable around her?’

‘The matter of comfort is yours to decide. Sir has given me no reason to doubt her chivalric nature.’

‘Then yes, please do go ahead.’

I was quite at a loss to the situation, and fast forgetting why I’d strolled over here. But one knows better than to turn down a compliment, especially one uttered in proximity of such striking beauty. Meowmeow assented, then began.

‘Expanding on my earlier point, Germany has provided me with the greatest advances, madam. Schering recently debuted a conjugated oral oestrogen under the title Progynon, which, though primarily directed to the relief of menopausal symptoms, has been found to be quite efficacious in our circumstances.’

‘How wonderful!’ the woman replied. ‘But is there any way to get the medication over here?’

‘Certain methods can be explored, though I strongly encourage a personal visit to Berlin and its *Institut für Sexualwissenschaft*. A

Dr Hirschfield and his team operate a pioneering clinic there – the first to focus pre-eminently on our specialist needs.'

The woman rushed forwards and wrapped Meowmeow in just the largest hug.

'Oh thank you, Catra! The sun just radiates from you!'

I was quite taken aback.

'Catra, Meowmeow?'

'My prenom, sir. You shall not have to hear it again.'

'Ah, yes, quite right. And who's that with you? Care for an introduction?'

'Of course, sir. May I present Lady Perfuma Plumers of Ashford, recently appointed gardening consultant to the Brightmoon estates.'

'Well I must say I'm charmed. It's a pleasure to make your acquaintance, Lady Plumers, how do you do?'

I dropped to bended knee – tweed be damned – and requested her gloved hand, much like the knights of old. Somewhat hacky, I'll grant, but I wasn't about to forestall Meowmeow's medieval overtures. Think of it as a reputational restorative, if you will – a return to the noble Adora of self-perception, and the less said about so-called boat thievery, the better. Anyhow, the good lady assented and I planted the deftest peck on her fingers. I flatter myself but I do believe I saw her blush.

'It is such a pleasure to meet you!'

She clasped her hands together with such bally fervour, I really believed it was, until a storm cloud blotted her freckled visage. 'But what do I call you?'

'Oh-uh. Adora.'

'Hey, Adora!' She jumped in place and her jangling pearls were the very model of flapperly enthusiasm. It was becoming rather infectious. Even Meowmeow joined in.

'Sir shows becoming modesty, madam. Her full title is Sir Adora de l'Horde, third Baronet of Greyskull.'

'Oh, how exciting! Well, Baronet, I hope you've bought a wealth of riches for the fête. We're going to paint the whole village in flowers, and the greenhouse will be the finest garden of all: an

exhibit of horticultural wonders from the finest collections in all Etheria! Do say you've brought something?'

What wretched labour it would be to let down such a dainty soul. I hadn't the heart to do it. But nor had I the first posey to lay down at the good lady's feet. Green fingers are in short supply within the de l'Horde lineage, you see. Everything we grow tends towards the grey and withered. The only specimen I'd ever kept ticking was my windowsill pot plant, a gift of Kyle's that seemed to thrive on my forgetful watering schedule.

'You can count on me! I'll have a chum send up Mr Potts in a jiffy.'

'Wonderful! What kind of plant is--- he?'

'You'll quite like this, I hope. He's a Bunny Ears.'

Her demeanour collapsed like an overbaked souffle.

'I don't do cacti – they're too unpredictable. I hate them, I hate them!'

She then raised her arms to her shoulders, eyes shut, inhaled, then pushed both wrists back to the floor. When Lady Perfuma re-opened her peepers, she was once again the cheerful gal from before.

‘I’m sorry. I mean – could you possibly consider bringing another plant to the fête? A cacti wouldn’t really fit what we’re trying to achieve.’

‘Blimey – what was that you just did with your arms? Seemed to flush the stress right out, what.’

‘I was repeating one of my mantras – it’s part of my morning meditation. We’re setting up a group right here at Shugborough – we’ll be meeting the sun on the formal lawn tomorrow and it would be just lovely if you could join us.’

‘Meditation, eh. What do I need to bring with me?’

‘Just bring your beautiful self, Adora. And a smile.’

‘I’ll be there. And – you know what – I’ll use the time between to find another flower for your exhibit. There’s got to be one around here somewhere.’

‘Oh, Sir Adora, you are funny! May Gaia bless your every endeavour.’

‘And the same to you, good Lady Plumers. Tally ho!’

I hooked my valet by the arm and went to lead her away. A striking job it was too – Meowmeow clearly hadn't caught my meaning.

'May I assist you, sir?'

'Why yes, Meowmeow, you might. I have quite the quest from Perfuma and it's only proper that my loyal squire assists in its completion.'

'My apologies, ***sir***. I thought you wanted me to maintain respectful distance from your grace, and engage the female guests of young Lady Brightmoon in conversation. You find me fulfilling such instructions to the utmost.'

'Yes, well, that was then. Situations change, Meowmeow.'

'Such inconsistency does surprise me, sir.'

'I'm asking you to come with me now, just to make things crystal clear. Instructing you, even.'

'Is that so, sir?'

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Chapter 5

Chapter Summary

'Quite the grumpy goose, weren't you Catra?'

'More, sir, that you believed I could be told what to do. You were mistaken.'

'Rather! But that wasn't the most muddled I'd get in that greenhouse! Reader-folk, behold our first spat, the quest for a new houseplant, and proof that I really don't know my fruits. Mortifying stuff. I'm still apologising to old Scorps now...'

Chapter Notes

Content warnings apply for the below chapter only - Spoilers may be present in the warnings. This story does not include any of the four Archive Warnings topics, but does occasionally feature other topics that may require content notes.

Chapter 5 Content Warnings:
Objectification of a woman's body, accidential and unintentional

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PART 5

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The mood shifted on a sixpence. Meowmeow, so sanguine a moment ago, snatched back and placed her hands upon her hips. An invisible wall was rising between us.

'Very well. Quite understood.'

'Meowmeow, please! You know I don't mean it like that. It's only that there are certain standards to maintain, conventions to uphold. Things like your outfit. The unknotted bow tie might look awfully dashing, but it's damned distracting to all the women here.'

'*All* the women, sir?'

'The proper thing to do is to tie it up, toasty as that might be.'

'In that case, sir…'

Meowmeow stared me right in the eye, and slowly uncoupled two more shirt buttons. I could find but one word to utter.

'Goodness.'

She followed me, though. I'll give her that. Our path weaved out and back through leafy warrens and glass-plated reliefs, bouncing

between flowers of every shape and size imaginable. But none of them did the trick. Delicate petals, sweet perfume. It's just not the Sir Adora way. Too damned ornamental, that's the problem. And the less said about trees, the better!

Succulents could have been the thing: simple shapes, nothing too flashy about them, and tough enough to withstand even the touches of a de l'Horde. There was just the one problem. The fellows grew in the same arid rockery that Mr Potts called home and, truth be told, one simply lacks the horticultural knowledge to identify whether these things were also cursed under the name Cacti.

I could have asked Meowmeow – she seemed the like the type to know more of anything that I ever thought wise – but I was still a trifle miffed about our chat. She'd done well enough at picking my outfit and plotting me a course that might mollify Auntie, but one suggestion that she tighten up for the team and all hell had broken loose.

It was a rum situation, no doubt. Seemingly the woman couldn't comprehend that I was the one in charge here, nor that my interventions were designed to grease her passage through the ritzier stations of Etherian society. Dammit, I only wanted what would bally well be best for her. Fury tickled at my throat, tempting me to give this turbulent valet a piece of my mind.

'Now listen here, Meowmeow,' I began.

But the words faltered as I turned towards her. That bow tie still hung loose, crumpled beneath the split satin of a billowing shirt. Anger bubbled up through every sinew – I couldn't look at her. The feeling was crushingly intense, smouldering across each inch of my skin. I'd never felt rage like this before; it full vibrated through the old giblets.

What was it Lady P got up to? The breathing Dickens. Yes, I'd try that.

In; Wait; Cactuses Are People Too; Out.

I can't say I felt much better but just that brief thought of the good lady had recalled me to my role. The chivalric knight was I, Meowmeow having intoned as much herself, and those hallowed First Ones of the Round Table wouldn't have been caught dead hollering at their lieges.

'Dearest Meowmeow,' I restarted, drastically changing my course. 'None of the plants we've seen so far quite summon forth the creative saliva, as it were. I'm really at a loss for what I might pop out and purchase for the good Lady P, so the moment has come to pick your brains. Do you know much about botany, Meowmeow? I'm looking for something functional, something with a real usefulness about it.'

'Might I recommend a fruit tree, sir?'

'But of course! Plants you can eat – why, there's no higher purpose. Just how did you think of that?'

‘I’m something of a fruit myself, sir.’

‘Uh, well, I…’

‘And the relevant glasshouse is immediately to our right, if you care to follow me.’

‘Ah, yes. Very good.’

Dash my valet’s whiskers, what a place this hot house turned out to be. A veritable fruit salad, if you will, with vines and shrubs and all that hanging from every surface. Banana plants thrust their great clusters down from the ceiling, and the kiwi fruits held a certain hairy appeal, yet it was the roundest, rarest delights which monopolised my sweaty attention.

‘Golly goodness, what a remarkable pair of melons!’

‘That’s really, well, thank you, I guess? But I’d uh--- I really would rather you didn’t objectify my appearance, gees. If you wouldn’t mind.’

‘Crikey, no! I mean nothing of the sort. I promise I hadn’t given your personage the first consideration. You might say I blinded by these pert, luscious beauties. How did you make them so sizeable

– they must have taken an age to grow? And the way you've presented them is just exemplary.'

'I really don't think you should be making these comments about me, or any other woman, or anyone really.'

'No, no, you misunderstand me. It's mighty rare to meet a woman with such ample talents, especially in a country where we spend so much of the year swaddled up in coats and all that. Yes siree, it's got to be steaming hot when there's melons around.'

Meowmeow stepped in before I entirely tied my tongue in ribbons.

'Do excuse my vernacular, but sir appears to be digging herself into a hole. Might I presume to resolve this situation with our fellow gardening enthusiast?'

'Well, if you think it's wise, then of course.'

'In the first instance, sir, I must insist that you apologise unreservedly.'

'I don't quite understand what I've done, Meowmeow.'

‘You’ve spoken unbidden on another person’s appearance, sir.’

‘But I just wanted to talk about her fruits!’

‘Sir, this is no situation for post-modifying conjunctions. Having caused such tangible discomfort, you must make full and immediate amends.’

My valet crossed her arms tight to snap. She gave me no choice but to accept the blame for what I’d done, and quite in the right she was too.

‘Very good.’

Obedient as one can be, I pivoted on a co-respondent and addressed our melon-farming acquaintance.

‘Madam, please do accept my humble and utmost. I’m quite sorry to have caused the first shred of upset, naive as I may have been to its cause. It’s quite unbefitting of my knightly nature – and I apologise for complimenting your melons.’

Meowmeow winced, and again saw fit to intervene.

‘May I introduce my gentlewoman, Sir Adora de l’Horde. Sir wishes to express her admiration of your fruitery.’

‘Yes, yes! I’m rather taken with your melons,’ I rejoined, pointing with emphatic clarity. Meowmeow and our tall, shorn-haired third looked at one another, then at me, eyebrows raised.

‘Should I---?’ asked our new acquaintance of my valet.

‘I believe it could be for the best, madam.’

‘Uh--- Sir Lordy person--- Hi! Erm. Hello there. Hi. Those are mangoes.’

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Chapter 6

Chapter Summary

'Our readers are in for a treat today, sir.'

'Oh yes, Meowmeow? Why's that?'

'We've reached the chapter where the brave knight - claiming no affection for her squire - vigorously rubs her thigh against my---'

'CATRA!! They don't need to know that! Don't listen to her, reader-people. It's just me receiving a nice lesson about how to go on a date.'

'With a practical component.'

Chapter Notes

Content warnings apply for the below chapter only - Spoilers may be present in the warnings. This story does not include any of the four Archive Warnings topics, but does occasionally feature other topics that may require content notes.

Chapter 6 Content Warnings:
Vehicle accident, observed
Queerphobia, reported
Dry-humping

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PART 6

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‘So what brings you to the strange and scrumptious end of the glasshouse, eh? Oh, and I suppose I should ask your name.’

‘Oh… Uh, hi. I’m Scorps – Scorpia Blackwell. I’ve never met a knight before. Do you go on quests?’

Well, how could one disappoint such an earnest, wide-eyed countenance as this? State-supplied my title may be, but surely I could rustle up something. If only the old memory banks hadn’t found themselves so devilishly overdrawn.

‘Hum,’ I said, then followed it up with ‘Harrrr…’ None too satisfying, if I do say so, but what good an intellectual conversation without the pausing for breath, the mulling over of things? It’s the de l’Horde way, after all. Basically a catechism with Aunt Shadowtha – barely an hour goes by without her reminding me, so it really must matter very much. “Think before you speak, Adora!”

‘Say--- I did recently commandeer a mighty vessel – to convey the comely young Lady Brightmoon, no less.’

Though Meowmeow sniggered, I found Scorpia entranced.

‘How romantic! Are you sworn to uphold chivalric values and fight for true love itself?’

‘Us de l’Hordes are renowned for our robust, pugilistic spirits, if I do say so myself.’

‘Okay, okay… What about the butterfly tinglies? Because I’ve got a bit of thing for someone. That’s why I’m out here – I want to find some way to show how much I appreciate everything she does and, well, you know--- Shucks, to see if she might want to share a little of her special, sparkling brightness. With me. Just if she wants to, you understand.’

Bleeding hearts and girl scout biscuits! A good deed ripe for the picking, and one sure to show Duchess Brightmoon my upstanding, public-spirited character. It was the stuff of story books.

‘Well, spit it out! Who’s the lucky fellow?’

‘She’s a pretty famous gardener, and her hair’s like flowing sunlight. Um, well… Actually she’s just up in the main greenhouse. Maybe you’ve met her? You’d know if you had, she’s just wonderful. She’s called Perfuma.’

‘Lady P?! Smashing! And, for the record, I’m a lady of Lesbos too. I’ve known since this lunchtime. Scorps, old chum, I pledge my assistance unto the very death!’

‘Hooray?’

‘That’s the spirit, Scorpy. Just leave it to old de l’Horde and you’ll be necking Plumers before the week is out. I swear it on my honour!’

Blast it, if ever there was a moment to kneel. I dropped to the floor and donned the steely expression of the medieval warlord. Scorpia blushed rather, and I worked bally hard to hide my grin. This was perfect. True love would unite the charming Lady P with the lovely Scorps, atoning my conversational sins with the latter, all the while displaying to Duchess Brightmoon my pure and giving heart. One matriarch would then surely chit-chat with the other, such that Auntie would have no choice but to reinstate my allowance.

And not a moment too soon, I reflected, as I stepped out into the Staffordshire sun. Muck spreading season was very much in evidence. How the odours might cling to my wardrobe, I dared not think. Devoted instead to Cupid’s musing, I found myself considering the best ways to organise a date. Never having enjoyed any romantic engagement – at least, not one I’d recognised as such ahead of its conclusion – my knowledge rather lacked. How fortunate, then, that my valet carried herself with the air of a flambeuse romancer.

‘Say, Meowmeow, how would one go about asking another woman on an excursion of the heart?’

‘I beg your pardon, sir?’

‘A date, damn it. What has to happen for two ladies to end up in a relationship?’

‘Would you like me to show you?’

‘Rather. I dread to think what happy endings might go unwritten if I sell Scorpy short.’

‘Very well, sir.’ Meowmeow grinned like the cat who had got the cream. Then she winked. ‘If you might permit me to proceed?’

How dashed familiar! I was quite unable to summon up the words for it, and scratched out the smallest nod in their stead.

‘One begins by establishing a connection with the would-be woman of one’s dreams. I take great pleasure in crafting an opening compliment, which must be most sincerely meant. If I might give an example, I could not in good conscience praise the… vivid contents of your cravat drawer, but there would be no falsehood in my commending your conviction. Truly, sir, I have never met a more vivacious woman, nor one who swears such devotion to her friends. That you would do the same for the slightest acquaintance demonstrates a heart far greater than my own.’

‘You make me blush, Meowmeow.’

‘So a compliment should, sir. One aims to hold up a looking-glass, encouraging a woman to see in herself the wonder she may routinely overlook. Said first comment might quite often be modified with a question or other opening. Our desire is to engage the woman in equitable and mutually enjoyable conversation. In your case, sir, I might ask details of when you last intervened to aid another.’

‘Well, um, it’s the Henley incident. Most unfair business, that. I was only trying to help Glimmer and look how it’s all blown up! I’d do it again, mind. Perhaps, as you say, I really am minded to put friendship first.’

‘As conversation finds its natural flow, our next task is to determine whether one’s enchantress holds Sapphic leanings.’

‘Well, that’s simple, isn’t it? You ask them!’

‘Not quite, sir. While our present environs are quite accommodating, such freedom is far from universal. If courting in public, one must choose their environs with the utmost caution. Balls offer the cover of demi-masquerade, where the dominants attend to walk amongst our number. Acceptance of a sort can be found in these places, though I can never shake the feeling that our existence is reduced to mere titillation. No matter the joy one might experience inside, such safety from fellow partygoers rarely lasts beyond the venue doors.’

She went awfully quiet for a moment, refusing to meet my gaze.

‘Meowmeow, are you quite alright?’

Offered my horsey handkerchief, she scrunched the fabric into her fist and cleared her throat.

‘I wouldn’t wish these experiences on you, sir. If I might be so bold, greater security is to be found in our own spaces.’

‘What if I were meeting someone outside of these mystic locales, eh? It’d be smashing if the whole world was a Lesbian club, Meowmeow, but it simply isn’t.’

‘Quite, sir. In public scenarios, discretion is of the utmost importance. Work subtle identifiers into conversation, covering topics such as fashion, hobbies, literary leanings and preferred nightspots. No one of these is necessarily indicative, though they each can offer a stroke of the wider masterpiece. Some women offer fewer clues but fear not, sir. One quickly builds a sense of intuition.’

‘Seems damned tricky, I have to say.’

‘Perhaps working through a trial situation will create clarity, sir. Were we to meet outside our current context, I might identify your sartorial preferences as a potential signifier of your identity,

as you might mine. Savile Row can be rather Sapphic. The manner in which I incorporate red and violet tones into my daily dress creates a deliberate marker, which is known to many Lesbians while remaining invisible to the wider public. To the Parisians, a monocle is the present voguish trapping…'

I scurried for a pen and started scrawling, jotting every little pearl on the back cover of my diary.

'Slow down, would you! You're setting one hell of a pace, Meowmeow.'

'Very well, sir. Are we ready to continue?'

'Oh, yes, just about. Do carry on.'

'As we stepped closer to one another, I might ask whether you've visited Montparnasse or caught one of the more compelling articles in *Die Freundin*. Perhaps you read *The Well of Loneliness* in the few months before the censors swept in---'

'I did, actually. Curious thing that book, at once clearly depicting one sort of Lesbianism and condemning it, while failing to display any others. Where were the feminine homosexual women? And what must we pay for a Lesbian tale with a happy ending? If that's the price of…'

‘Salt one’s discussion with these topics and each woman can somewhat confirm the other’s identity, all the while discovering a rapport. One can then navigate through other topics, finding and exhibiting shared interests, before arriving at the moment that requires a certain fortitude.’

‘That’s all very good, Meowmeow, but I don’t see how it helps with my cherubic role regarding Scorps and Lady P.’

‘You mean to say, sir, that you enquire solely on behalf of your friends, such Lesbian curiosity deriving solely from your generosity?’

‘Well, yes, dash it! That should be perfectly clear. And these two ladies already know one another, so presumably have a base understanding of one another’s inclinations, not to mention a shared interest in gardening. What I mean to say, you see, is that your advice so far has focused entirely on achieving first advances, which seem to have been made already. Cut to that chase, and all that!’

‘You mean to ask what occurs once two or more Sapphics agree to undertake a romantic date?’

‘I wouldn’t say it had to be romantic to be Sapphic, but yes, Meowmeow, in so few words.’

‘Very good, sir. In my experience, the participants seek multiple distinct sensations, namely the further establishment of rapport; a sense of private intimacy; and, perhaps, the opportunity to send heartbeats racing.’

‘Thundering ventricles, eh.’

‘Precisely, sir.’

‘Well, no need to be coy. Do explain how one achieves all these various aims in a single event. It seems dashed impossible.’

Meowmeow smirked and half-stepped in my direction, shoulder forwards, hips low and carriage urgently upright. She raised a gloved hand to shoulder height, letting it float in the space between the two of us, my confusion growing all the while. It must have been writ large across the old visage, for she shot a guiding glance to her palm and then my own. I hesitated for a moment and her tight expression turned into a smile, her eyes sparkling.

I spied a warmth in them – or something else I could trust – so finally lifted my fingers to match. Our palms touched as she guided us away and together, in murmurs like the low-tide waves at Nice. Something deep in my chest made tight and urgent noises. Bending her spare arm tight behind her back, shoulders still so tight and level that she looked every inch the *Vogue* illustration, Meowmeow led me in a circle that filled the tight confines of the garden path. The space was ours, all of it. Yet,

when she pointed her chin and locked her gaze in mine, there was no space at all.

'I don't know about you, sir, but I'm having a blast. Dancehalls can stimulate the most overwhelming emotions.'

Our loop completed, Meowmeow drew me closer then thrust her arm towards my hip, her fingers swimming tantalisingly close to the sweat-soaked wool. The expectation of her touch weighed heavy, its agonizing static never crackling through to a clear signal. My tonsils were welded to my closing throat. If this was my valet's idea of a mock date with her gentlewoman, I could only imagine how the real thing would affect poor, earnest Scorpy.

'Whatever it is you might be planning here, I have to say that I don't see how it can work.'

We drew back together and scribed ever tighter rotations, Meowmeow tightening her gaze with a single and singular raised eyebrow.

'Is that so, sir?'

She broke away, floating her hand skywards with the delicacy of a Muscovite ballerina. Quite entranced, I mirrored her move to the best of my limited capabilities, as I had every part of our *folie au deux*. How she twirled, liquid and curving as treacle ribboning away from the tin, each movement floating like a snowflake

caught in a winter's breeze. I was transfixed. Kyle had never produced such art in my service – one scarcely thought valets capable of such things. I really had to wonder.

Then Meowmeow crashed plum into my clavicle, knocking the wind from my chest as she tipped her gaze to the skies. I staggered under the weight but held her there, one hand crushed into her suit shoulder to keep our unorthodox silhouette from shattering. The material was light, expensive and close-cut – her soft heat oozed through it.

'Perhaps my plan won't work, sir,' she sighed in rueful regret. 'Though, on the other hand---'

Flicking her head right, her eyes were so close I could see nothing else. We were but an inch apart, and perfectly capable of naming the other's toothpaste brand if we so desired. Pepsodent, unless I'm very much mistaken. With all this going on, I can be forgiven for missing the gloved hands that now rested on my **own**, the fingers within them gripping gradually but undeniably tighter.

Meowmeow pivoted up and out of our impromptu embrace. My arm went taut, then arced above us, the valet leading again as she pirouetted to face me. Tension throbbed between our open palms; my skin burned and prickled. I'd never danced like this before – Meowmeow's Lesbian nightspot business inflamed the senses to the point of no return. Scintillating, absolutely, but why would we look to replace the dependable, if less tremulous sway already known to every true blue Etherian? Boat thief or not, I still held some things sacred.

Not content with destroying the very concept of dancing, the woman swept forward to silence the old brain murmurs. Her right hand slipped from mine and darted into the small of my back, sending a sharp crack buzzing up through my skull. It rather reminded one of the time I endeavoured to fix my Frazer-Nash's battery myself, with nothing more than Bowregard's hastily jotted advice. I rather wondered what he'd have to say now, considering the events that had not two hours past transpired on this remarkable walkway. In any case, the flames coursing through my chest flickered with the same irresistible heat as those that had burnt up the old car's wiring that day and cost me several inches of hair.

My current position felt damned near as dangerous. Meowmeow held me frozen, her billowing locks the only extant measure of time and motion. Chestnut with sections of fuzzy grey-white, they framed her as a shieldmaiden. She darted at me with the same terse precision, thrusting us down, only to cradle me in her embrace.

How long we hung there, I simply could not say. Levitating bare inches from the ground, spine and ribcage alive to the hands moulding them in place, the world took on an indirect quality. Nothing outside our tango seemed to matter all that much. She filled my gaze with the sharp lines of her jaw, her snarling smile, the languid, ceaseless arc of her back.

Heat fluttered through me as I took account of it all. I was sweating, naturally, and blushing with it, but that couldn't account for such ribald intensity. The true source had its home in far more foreign climes. By accident or unconscious design, on looking down I saw that Meowmeow and myself had thrust our suit legs

into the most remarkable of locations. By Jove, what a thing this dancing was!

‘Perhaps it already has, sir.’

Meowmeow looked up and I raised my chin to match. I was completely in her thrall, still striving to follow her every move. Laura to her Carmilla, there’s no doubt I’d have followed her to the ends of the Earth. If such feelings – quite fleeting and circumstantial, you understand – could be provoked for my valet by following her three rules of dating, then two women with a natural affinity would doubtless fall in the deepest love imaginable. Scorps and Plumers would be left with nothing to fight over, but for which bride would claim me as their best woman.

Basking in the glow of a job soon to be well done, I saw no reason for ending the revelation a moment too soon. As for the indiscreet entanglement of our thighs, their structure was quite necessary for us to hold position. Dancing can be dreadfully forwards like that. And I wouldn’t want to seem the unwilling pupil, not when there might well be more left to learn. Meowmeow looked higher still, I strained my neck to match her, and something streaked through her massy mane.

‘I say, Meowmeow, did you see that? Up there?’

‘Unfortunately not, sir. My attentions are currently otherwise engaged.’

‘It jolly well looked like a private aerocraft, and a spiffy one with it. Why, if Aunt Shadowtha only advanced me the trust, I could get one to go with the Invicta and the Nash. Think of that – de l’Horde of the skies!’

‘A most striking proposition, sir.’

‘Now, if I went for a two-seat cockpit, then you could come with me. Serve the necessary refreshments and all that. That’d really make a splash at Brooklands. And we’d repaint the fuselage of course, to match---’

My idle musings were cut short with a crash, a bang and the unmistakable sight of a de Havilland DH.60G Moth interfacing with Shugborough’s front lawn.

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Chapter 7

Chapter Summary

'The heat! The confusion! Two women stumble into a sordid scene! It's heart-pounding stuff this time, eh Catra? A shimmering wonder fell from the heavens and into my life.'

'Awh, Adora, you're too kind. But we danced last chapter.'

'Obviously I mean the 'plane crash!! How I swooned over that aircraft! Not so much its moustache-in-residence mind, nor the whole fire-putting-out fiasco. And to think... You thought your twirling was the most memorable bit of that afternoon. Isn't that funny, Catra? Catra. Catra... Catra? Ow! What did you just flick me for?'

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PART 7

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The ‘plane was in no great shakes. That much was clear long before we’d squelched towards the wreckage, and only got more obvious as we came closer. Landed – in the loosest sense – by jamming nose-down into the dirt, the sporty two-seater had carved through the cricket pitch and ploughed through a topiary that, until very recently, had born passing resemblance to Glimmer’s Saluki. Now it looked rather more interpretative. You know, like that Dadaist rot. The aeroplane was leaning more Cubist, having abstracted itself to a halt in the rose garden, where it was presently leaking fuel over everything in sight.

‘I advise you not to get too close, sir. The slightest spark from the Cirrus engine may ignite the spillage and everything around it. Presumably a mixture of methanol, nitromethane and acetone, the liquid will, in any case, prove alarmingly corrosive.’

Meowmeow placed a hand on my shoulder. It didn’t quite have the heat I’d felt just minutes earlier, and felt curiously lacking for it, but the unshakeable conviction was quite the same. What then, but to do quite as she said? We stood aghast, staring at the crumpled airframe and figuring out just what the Dickens to do next. I harboured a suspicion that I now had competition for the coveted title of Duchess Brightmoon’s least favourite individual.

‘Am I late for the party?!’

A pair of jodhpurs shot from the rear seat, followed by the rest of a miraculous aviator. Dressed in cloth cap, sheepskin jacket and goggles, standing wide-legged as the Eiffel Tower, he was the picture of a Boys’ Own pilot.

‘What’s the matter? Have you two never seen… ADVENTURE? I’ll tell you, kind land folk, the legendary story that leads me to this mighty shindig. It all begins on the Italian lakes, where I was enjoying a coffee, the local men… and the local laaaadddiiees?!’

‘Not on your life. *Sir*.’

Meowmeow stood between me and our advancing aviator companion, her tail positively bristling.

'Fair enough! The *belle donne* and *uomini* belli of Lake Garda showed a similar disinclination--- at *first*. But then I started to siiinnnggg…

Ladies of the lake so fair,

With flowing dress and tussled hair,

Come board my plane, then you will see,

A future just for you and me.

Up in the clouds,

We'll sing aloud,

I love you now, forever more,

'Cause life together ain't no chore.

It dazzled them, my dears – not one of their number could find the words!'

'I can *quite* imagine that, eh Meowmeow?'

'One can scarcely credit the scenario, sir.'

‘Well!’ hollered the fellow. ‘You’d better believe it. One by one, the men and women came rushing headlong.’

‘Why were the individuals hurrying?’ Meowmeow enquired. ‘Perhaps there was some kind of fire they had to escape?’

‘They were rushing towards me, towards me!!’ A polished riding boot stamped into the gravel, the fellow hanging his arms with am-dram exasperation. ‘And my moustache, which is naturally shiny.”

He turned towards us, sweeping round to give us all angles of the jet black curls sprouting from his upper lip. The man paused in an exaggerated pose. If he was waiting for an ovation, he’d be there a bally long time. His eyebrow arced ever upwards – I dare say I folded my arms in reply. Meowmeow offered up a single, derisory clap.

‘Thank you, thank you. Now, back to my ribald tale and its morale-boosting theme of ADVENTURE! Having found no lasting security in the tanned arms of the Alpine populace, I sneaked panther-like from the bar to turn my rapt attentions to the opal waters of a nearby lake. There I communed with my other greatest love, the aeroplane! Radials and reciprocals, inlines and tumultuous vees, manifold motors thumped overhead in their respective airframes, vibrating the skies and my very soul as they ripped past, afore crashing their pontoons ‘pon the icy drink. The sound! The waves! The sense of *joie de vivre*, as the Italians term their content with continental life.’

‘If I might interject, sir, your de Havilland---’

‘Is not a seaplane! Damned good eye you’ve got there, for a land-lubber. Since the Ripley incident in Napoli and the mysterious Cannes affair, I’ve found myself forlorn of ocean-faring aircraft, but that wouldn’t stop as crafty a cloud jockey as I! The going was no longer good in Italy, what with my various business affairs, so I planned to get out under the cover of darkness. By any means necessary…’

My valet examined the quality of her manicure; I reflected on the quality of my valet. Undeterred, the gent continued.

‘Swindling a local Count in a dockside game of a poker, I purloined the lire I’d need to flag down the night express and bribe its driver to run me over the border to Switzerland, and on to freedom. Jumping onto the footplate, I set right to it, shovelling with twice the speed of the regular stoker, before hiding betwixt the coals as we crossed the border. I jumped off soon after, then braved the scree and screeching rain to reach Locarno.’

‘What was in Locarno, eh?’ I was quite getting into all this now, unlikely as it seemed. Daring do and that. My valet rather harumphed but, damn it, since when did I care what Meowmeow thought of me?

‘Again, sir, I must highlight that your Moth is---’

‘Save your questions to the end, darling temptress. Now. Locarno, Locarno… Yes! To the naked eye, the town held nothing! But the trained aviator, using their flight-hardened cunning to track down the right hangar and whip away the concealing barrels and boxes, could pull back to oilcloth to reveal the most wondrous sight in the world. The *Dragon’s Daughter IV*!’

He gestured to the wreckage behind him, which was now very clearly ablaze. Tutting audibly, Meowmeow started walking towards a nearby potting shed, where her rummaging produced a pair of buckets and copious quantities of sand. Laying her jacket ever so carefully across a bench, she dropped to her shirtsleeves and set to work. It must have been a minute or two before I realised – I’d lost all track of what the pilot was saying.

‘… Drive the nose hard into the ground, while taxiing as fast as a sports car… Ice on the carburettors, and nothing but a chisel to hand!… The Matterhorn… I flew faster than they could pursue the payment… Even *Dragon’s Daughter IV* can’t outrun the telephone… Who the devil would know it meant **that** in French anyway?… Six days in a Lyon jail… Busted out by an old acquaintance… Terrible business… Champagne towers, and a nip of coca… And I bet Hemingway… From the Eiffel Tower, just certain I would die… Seemed to have misplaced my passport, so landing near Dover was out… And that was a right scare for the boys in green… Not that they’d know what the eggs are worth… Ever since, I’ve been known as the mighty Skyhawk!’

‘Sorry,’ came my re-focusing interjection. ‘What the devil happened to the *Dragon’s Daughters I* through *III*?’

‘I set them on fire!’

‘What?!’

‘Not on purpose, old chum. Mostly not on purpose, anyhow. Number one was shot down over the Adriatic by the twitchy Italian navy. The next during, or rather *after*, a dogfight. I tried to out-race a Peregrine falcon and made a fatal miscalculation. Fatal for the bird, that is. Then the third? The third… Oh yes! It was the glorious signwriting episode that did for that one. I tried my hand at writing across the heavens and got damned frustrated at the results! Or lack thereof.”

‘For your plane, sir.’ Meowmeow returned with the buckets. ‘Will you be requiring further assistance?’

‘Whyever would I need your help? As this one knows, I’m the mightiest lone wolf aviator to take to the skies since the Great War! A one man whirling, twirling, moustache curling machine.’

‘Be that as it may, *sir*, the left wing of your de Havilland is at an advanced stage of self-immolation. The flames are gradually progressing towards the airfoil, wherein I’m given to understand the fuel tanks reside.’

‘Ah, yes. I may be a liiiiittttttllle tiny bit rusty at landing – one does it so less often than one takes off! It’s not the worst I’ve attempted, and it keeps the streak going, if nothing else. Think of

the stories I'll tell about the four planes I've lost to Prometheus' prickly gift! Why, I'd start it something like…

The smoke, the haze, the fire's heat,

Would have a lesser pilot beat.

But not Skyhawk, Skyhawk that man,

Who bare-fists danger, never planned.'

'Instead of singing, we could always try to put out the flames?' I offered, trying to be helpful. 'I've don't doubt it'd save you a lot of time and cost. Over getting a new airframe, that is.'

'Intriguing… Attempting to save the 'plane, you say?'

'A substantial blaze would likely also see any invitation to the Midsummer Ball rescinded, sir.'

Skyhawk paled at Meowmeow's suggestion, then rushed headlong towards the stricken *Dragon's Daughter IV* and started hurling sand in random directions.

'Well, come on, hurry over and help, won't you?

I'm Skyhawk, I am, I am,

Want to meet a flying hero, then I am your man.

Save the plane and save the day,

Then suit up for dinner and be *enchanté*!'

The singing went on for quite some time, and I won't pretend it didn't rather start to grate. We emptied, passed and re-filled buckets in monotonous rhythm, the boredom only broken by glimpses at my stylish valet. Even in such disarray, her satin shirt shimmered, its shifting ripples visiting every shade of pink and red. It was a vibrant ocean, its borders staked by tight tailoring. I couldn't stop staring, really. There was no doubt about it – I needed a private word with Meowmeow. I just *had* to get the details of her tailor.

'He's Skyhawk, he is, he is,

Left the seafaring life back in old Cadiz.

Water won't save a smould'ring boat,

And a hull so richly holed isn't known to float.'

Our travails had aroused the attentions of a passing Bowregard---or perhaps it was the fire that did it. In any case, he came racing towards us, vaulting over the topiary to grab me by the arm. The man's touch lacked the delicacy of my valet, I have to say.

'Adora! What are you doing?! Why is there an aeroplane on the front lawn? And why is it on fire?'

‘Bow, old chap, there’s really nothing to worry about. Meowmeow and I are a long way towards putting out the flames.’

‘Is that the Duchess’ prize rose garden?’

‘It was, I suppose.’

‘And what’s that caught up in the propeller? It’s really smashed up...’ He stepped in for a closer look, then recoiled at twice the speed. ‘The Brightmoon Rodin?!?’

‘And there I was thinking it was an ordinary garden gnome! Damned bad looking thing, anyhow. Perhaps now she can get something prettier replace it. Ooh… like a rearing horsey! Now wouldn’t that be swell?’

‘No Adora! That would not be swell! Oh no. *Oh no.* I can’t be seen here – Glimmer is going to *kill* us. And that’s nothing compared to her mother. She’s going to double, triple, super-duper kill us. We’re going to be completely and utterly dead, and then my dads are going to find out I’m in Staffordshire, then I’m going to be dragged back to the university. Just think what they’ll set me up for this time, Adora. If getting in your **crime boat** earned a summer of medieval literature, this is going to be even worse. Way worse. How could it not be? There’s a plane, and it’s on **fire**. They’ll send me into the archives, Adora! To translate First Ones texts!”’

‘What do you mean, translate? The stuff’s as clear as modern day Etherian.’

‘What? No, no Adora. It isn’t. Nobody can read it, not fluently and not without years of academic study.’

‘Are you sure?! That--- that doesn’t seem right.’

‘Stop changing the subject! Why is there a ‘plane burning up on the front lawn?’

‘A common ‘plane? Do you hear yourself? Wash out your mouth, scoundrel! This is the *Dragon’s Daughter IV*, my renowned skyward swashbuckler. Speak her name in any pilots’ bar from Oslo to Innsbruck and the occupants will shiver in awe, such is her reputation for…’

‘And who. is. this?’

‘An excellent question, sir,’ Meowmeow intervened. ‘May we introduce the aviator Skyhawk, whose de Havilland Moth made contact with the Brightmoon gardens during landing, much to his regret. Sir Adora and I – passing the area – were first to survey the wreckage and offer our assistance. On this, sir, I swear my dignity.’

‘All of your dignity?’

‘In its entirety, sir, retaining not even a shred for a loincloth.’

Dashed hot work, all this. I could feel myself flushing again.

‘Okay then. But you’ve got to see how this looks, Adora. You’re *persona non grata* up at the house, so your arrival is a big enough shock for the Duchess as it is. If a Brightmoon – or a Brightmoon staff member – spots this wreckage before you can get some safe literal and figurative distance from it, they’re going to put two and two together, and we both know what they’re going to make.’

‘Four, isn’t it?’

‘No. They’re going to think that you crashed it, or caused it, or in some way continued to besmirch the young Lady Brightmoon’s name.’

‘But I didn’t! I’ve never flown an aircraft before. I’d jolly well like to, mind, and I know exactly what paint job I’d go for. How does canary yellow over polished Duralumin strike you? Racey, eh?’

‘This is serious, Adora. If there’s the slightest suggestion your arrival is in any way responsible for this, then you won’t even get through the front door tonight. Or any night. And then you’ll never, ever, **ever** get to see Glimmer again.’

‘That would be a bit of rum luck, eh.’ And just when I was cultivating a hunch that our recent sojourn to the Porchester Hall baths hadn’t been quite entirely platonic in nature. ‘Wait a minute, old chap! I had nothing to do with this smash – and it’s not like we can undo the accident. The best we can hope for is delaying the Duchess’ discovery of the thing.’

‘Mighthaps there is a place we can relocate my stricken ‘craft, far enough away that it evades detection yet sufficiently close that it may form the life and soul of the party?

Skyhawk, Skyhawk,

He’s the do-or-die Hawk,

See his brave crash-landing path,

Then ask him for… an autograph?

ADVENTURE!’

The aviator jumped three feet in the air, legs akimbo, then landed in something approximating a fencer’s lunge. He looked tremendously pleased with himself, then pivoted into a series of squats. When he noticed no-one was paying much attention, he stopped, self-consciously styling himself against the remains of his fuselage. Bow moved us forward from whatever all that was.

‘You know, Skyhawk might be onto something.’

‘About the party?!’ the aviator gasped. ‘I’ve been banned from more than I’ve attended!”

‘No, about the recovery. We’ve got to get the ‘plane out of the way, and fast. It’s not doing any good sat here, where the Brightmoons can stumble on it unprepared and with Adora in such visible proximity.’

‘I like the way you think, ‘Reg old sport! A true spirit of ADVENTURE flows through your veins after all – and it’s my job to nurture it. Our next and greatest challenge? Taking the *Dragon’s Daughter IV* for inspection! And repairs! Substantial, costly repairs! Would anyone like to offer me a loan?!’

‘I’m a just a little bit more concerned about the Brightmoon roses!’ Bow spluttered. ‘These cultivars are some of the rarest and most valuable in the country. Maybe even the world!’

My turn to cough and whinny had arrived.

‘The flower petals, Bow, old chap? What about the very real jeopardy re. my ongoing relationship with Glimmer? People trumps plants, you know. It’s evolution and all that.’

Well, in the spirit of authorial integrity, I’ll tell you that we bickered quite a while, in something that developed perilously close to a contretemps. Voices were raised; various gestures were

made in the spirit of emphasis. The boat incident was raised again, and Bow asked some quite probing questions about appropriate carburettor jetting. But it was Meowmeow that forced resolution, by dropping a sand bucket at – and ever so slightly on – my feet.

'If I may, sirs, the flames continue to take hold. In my experience, it is best that we finish extinguishing them.'

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Chapter 8

Chapter Summary

'What ho, reader-folk! A new chapter, in which I transport the Dragon's Daughter IV. I save the day; I un-save the day; I save the day again. Emotional and physical sensations well up, we bicker over books, and I spy Meowmeow in her greatest degree of undress yet. Mangled parts and tangled hearts abound.'

'Just which parts would those be, Adora?'

'You know, the bits and pieces... We had a sweaty old time getting them all where we wanted!'

'I believe we're still some way from that *particular* chapter, sir.'

Chapter Notes

Content warnings apply for the below chapter only - Spoilers may be present in the warnings. This story does not include any of the four Archive Warnings topics, but does occasionally feature other topics that may require content notes.

Chapter 8 Content Warnings (INCLUDES SPOILERS):
Vehicle accident, aircraft - instigated, in process and observed
Vehicle accident, aircraft, risk of collision with people - instigated, in process and observed (no collision occurs)
Risk of personal injury - instigated, in process and observed (no personal injury occurs)

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PART 8
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Damned weighty thing, an aeroplane. You wouldn't have thought so, what with the canvas and the clever alloys and the empty space, but if *Dragon's Daughter IV* was as light as a bird, the feathered flapper in question would have to be one of those frightful prehistoric things they so love drawing in textbooks. It took all our strength to extricate the blasted Moth from the undergrowth, and in rather more than a jiffy I was up against a tattered wing. Putting my back into it and what have you.

From manifold different corners came the soulful grunts of my fellow transportation crew. Bowregard was my opposite, struggling manfully on the starboard side, while Skyhawk put his top muscles – tongue most unfortunately included – to work at the stern. Or was it the bow? No, that's boats, isn't it? At the back, anyhow. And still within hearing distance of the delicate de l'Horde ears…

'Pushing my 'plane, and I can't complain,

For such great feats do my muscles train,

The fibres twitch and the core does strain,

When it comes to beauty, oh the pain means gain,

Soon I'll be wooing the boys and the girls again!

ADVENTURE!!!!
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Now! What do you think of that, my lovely chap and lady chaps? Quite the dashing, strapping and heartily moustachioed ditty, eeeeehhh? Just the thing for a plunge into despair and straight out of it again, only to be back in the bar by suppertime. Your heartstrings are plucked with the forces of primal attraction, I know, but try not to fling yourself on me without warning!'

Bow let out the kind of low, guttural howl I haven't heard since we were on the inter-college boating team, way back in those halcyon student days. Whether his pain now hailed from exertion or aural assault, I simply couldn't say, but I felt damned minded to holler out in much the same fashion. Not like my redoubtable valet, who was squaring up to the task with remarkable forbearance. Dashed impressive, that, and quite the thing that calls for a little encouragement.

'I say, Meowmeow. You're doing a mighty fine job and all.'

'Thank you, sir. Your appreciation rather flatters me.'

Well, I twisted round like that fancy French corkscrew Kyle impounded after the Beaujolais incident. The serrated purr of my gentlewoman's gentlewoman was coming from my left, a good four feet away from the fuselage. Meowmeow was strolling along like a Sloane Street dandy, smoothing her shirt sleeves and adjusting her cufflinks. Something deep and grumbly moved within me, rather jangling the B-team organs. Quivering kidneys and irritable bowels and all that. I couldn't help but stare with jaw unhitched, such was the sight unfolding before me.

‘Is something the matter, sir?’

‘I should jolly well think so, Meowmeow! Here we are, established members of a certain social set, hulking the wreckage of this great beast onwards towards who knows where, and I think to call out to my valet in appreciation of her fine efforts. Trying to show a little bonhomie, you know. Aiming to recognise that you and I, distant and disparate as our backgrounds might be, can bridge the class divide when it really matters and come together---’

‘I would certainly hope so, sir.’

‘But do you? Do you Meowmeow? Because it doesn’t bally well seem like it. I’m putting in spades upon shovels of back-breaking labour, working up a sweat on the proverbial brow, and I look up to see you utterly unflustered. My servant floats above it all, while I’ve got my head down and I’m giving it my all, thrusting forwards with this steady, selfless rhythm.’

‘Do go on, sir.’

‘Why it’s that old Christmas thingy where the ordinary fellow gets promoted to the peerage. You know the one. It’s part of that play with the twelve knights who play around with gender quite a bit, then it turns out the main man is quite riotously bisexual but isn’t sure what to do about it, and it all finishes with a song about the weather… *Festive misrule*, that’s the ticket!’

‘Ah yes, sir, the Bard. I didn’t know you were such a scholar. If I might provide a counter quote from eight years further into Mr. Shakespeare’s career, “How beauteous mankind is! O brave new world, that has such people in ‘t!”’

‘“In ‘t”, Meowmeow? What the devil did the fellow mean?’

‘A flick of the playwright’s quill to better fulfil his preferred pentameter, sir. Iambic, if I’m not mistaken. As for the meaning, our greatest writer means to invoke the simple prepositional and deictic phrase “in it”.’

‘Well why couldn’t he have just said that, then? Such people in it… Who are these “such” people, Meowmeow?’

‘I flatter myself to believe I stand within their number.’

‘Eh? What are you going on about – and how does it get you out of pushing the dashed de Havilland?’

‘The matter is quite simple, sir. Having made your acquaintance only this morning, I might be said to convey a certain novelty into your world, while my autonomy in certain actions since our arrival in Shugborough demonstrates fortitude, or so I’d say.’

‘Like being the first to put out the fire? That sort of sport?’

‘Amongst other things… Sir may notice, furthermore, and if I might indulge in momentary immodesty, that I possess a certain measure of beauty---’

‘Rather! How could I miss it?! You’re an objectively attractive woman, Meowmeow!’

My valet turned towards me with a growing smirk, and a twinkle in her eye that was definitely saying **something**. If only I’d packed my translation guide to body language. Though that would require me to have made up my own cases. And for such a book to exist. Perhaps not too practical an idea, then. In any case, I could sense that tight, knotted and quivery feeling that had so overcome me when my valet had undone a few many of her shirt buttons. Now, what was that about? Yes! The clothes, I think, and how to wear them.

‘I mean to say, hmmm… er… Meowmeow. Yes, Meowmeow, that you, like many snappy dressers, have… let’s see… a measure of the, how to put it, the pleasingly aesthetic. But there are society rules to obey, you see…’

‘We are somewhat in agreement, sir. The beauty of the person is integral to the idyllic vision our greatest writer creates, and as such I hold myself to a strict personal sartorial code, that I might form part of the Earth anew that he describes. Unfortunately, the strictures of our recent flame suppression forced me to momentarily abandon that standard. I felt it of paramount

importance that I rectify the situation at the first opportunity. You do want us both to create that brave new world, do you not?'

'Hang on! So you mean to say, if I've got this quite straightened out, that you've left us lugging the 'plane so you can pop on your suit jacket?'

'In a baser turn of phrase, sir.'

'And you're telling me that some fusty old playwright wants you to do that, more than he might want you to, say, tend to the needs of your gentlewoman? Sounds awfully fishy to me. Positively pongy, even.'

'Literary theory can be a matter of interpretation.'

'Oh, for the honour of Greyskull, Meowmeow! Interpretation my eye. You're just skipping work. You scoundrel. You, you… Bounder.'

'Sir, you appear to be undergoing---'

'I don't want to hear it. You're a bounder. A female bounder, obviously. A boundette, let's say. *Boundette!* I'm sorry, but there's no other word for it. I mean, really, Meowmeow. You simply cannot pull another trick like this and think I. Won't. Catch. On.'

I can’t say I’ve ever pushed a ‘plane so hard in my life. Not that I’d cosied up against any cockpit before, you see, but rather that I doubt there’s been any prior occasion, in any part of this de l’Horde’s existence, upon which I’ve exerted myself with such tremendous results. Were that not enough of a shock, the whole action felt so organic it was positively easy.

My heart dictated and my arms followed, if you will, with the kind of simplicity one can only really attribute to heightened emotions. Really, it’s just another way to say I was utterly bloody fuming at my valet. A tempestuous furore, Meowmeow might have called it. Well kittens to what she’d say – and to her “losing” my favourite string-backs – I’d had enough. Why, I should tell her… I’d say… She had to know… I… She…

The dashed impotence of rage! I needed a moment to turn my teeth grinding into articulated groaning, yet my pause just surrendered the floor to Skyhawk, who filled it with another accursed anthem.

‘When did my DD get so light,

I must be getting my training right,

See how she floats as we step round,

Wait! Shouldn’t the ‘plane be on the ground?’

‘This is bad,’ Bow clamoured. ‘Really bad.’

‘I have to agree, old chum. If the fellow’s so set on singing, couldn’t he go off and join a choir, so he’d do it safe within the muffling confines of a church?’

‘No, not that, Adora. The *Dragon’s Daughter IV* is flying – look!’

He was right too. You wouldn’t think charred wreckage was all that airworthy, or that any aeroplane could start gaining altitude *sans* pilot and functioning motor. But you’d be wrong. For those few seconds, the Moth soared above our eyeline and kept on climbing, provoking in me a sort of serenity the day had done little thus far to provide. It didn’t last long. As we jogged after our riderless steed, a gaggle of onlookers swam into sight in the near distance, right under the ‘plane’s course.

Now, that’s all very well if the de Havilland flies over them. They’ll ooh and ah if they’ve any appreciation for modern technology. Frankly, it’s their loss if they don’t, for what else provided Etheria with its lofty global standing, eh? Before you know it, the craft’s swooshed past, and you’ve got a corker of an anecdote spreading itself about. “Did you hear about the spiffy number that did a quick lap of the estate?” our onlookers might coo. Or words to that effect. With Shugborough sufficiently distracted, us ‘plane pushers would have but two tasks left: bundle Skyhawk somewhere out of view, then knock our remaining heads together and explain the gardens. We’d say a badger did it, perhaps? Rum things, those badgers.

Quite the hypothetical response I’d cooked up there, I must say. Alas, my cunning would be all for naught should the *Dragon’s*

Daughter IV renew its interest in rare cultivars and manicured lawns. With a great shuddering roar, the remaining parts of the aeroplane began to do just that. Blast. Bloody badgers. It was a slow descent at first, one that could have coasted over the stables and out of sight, which one dared to hope could be out of mind also. But firsts have such an irksome habit of developing into seconds, as so many nights at *The Garrison* had taught me.

Just like at the clubhouse, the change in attitude was sudden and drastic, not to mention drenched in all manner of noxious fluids. Nose hard down and gathering pace all the while, the airframe dropped precipitously towards its clustered spectators. This could be many things, but it couldn't be good. Well, let it never be murmured that a de l'Horde stands idle in the face of disaster. I got right to it – and no delay! That's more than I can say for my chums, whose huffing and puffing belied their treacly progress. Enough of that lollygagging, eh! Breaking into the quickest trot my brogues might manage, I'd barely made a stride before I left them lengths behind.

Naturally, I made a beeline in the only obvious direction – right at the poor pair standing in the flight path. Or should that be fall path? I scrunched up my eyes, just to get a peek at who I'd be saving. Not that my heroism was at all in doubt, you understand, but there are means and ways of engaging with certain sorts. If Duchess Brightmoon was to witness me shouting and towards her, for instance, then it'd be better the Moth got me than I faced the consequences. And what if it were Aunty? What then? Now there's a thought to make even the pluckiest gentlewoman pale…

Neither of my greatest ill-wishers stood before me, thank the First Ones, but the sight still caught the breath in my throat. Lady P! And her feet as fixed as her gaze. Cripes! I'm no professional

matchmaker, but I can guess that squishing Scorpy's beau before she's even had the chance to ask her out is something of a blot on the chivalric copybook. Pretty key then – even more so than it already was – that I kept Plumers from nibbling the eternal biscuit. One still had to remember, however, that our figure of green-fingered gentility was a high-born Lady. Etiquette must be observed.

'I say! Lady P, I say! Dreadfully sorry to bother you, but I need you to step away from the dahlias.'

Not a dickie.

'Lady Plumers, there's an aircraft falling towards you! Could I please persuade you to run, now? Please?'

Still nothing.

'Plane crash! Run!'

A trifle less polite, that last line, but I couldn't make matters much clearer. The other fellow got the message and darted rather neatly for cover in the nearby stable block. Not the future Mrs. Scorps, though. And the Moth had just shed its final vestiges of uplift, opting instead to plummet like last October's stocks. Decorum, then, would have to be damned. I leapt at the gardener and tackled her headlong, flinging our tangled mass towards the farthest throws of the courtyard.

Not a moment too soon, either. *Dragon's Daughter IV* crashed to Earth for the second time today, its loosely-defined landing throwing up a veritable quarry of gravel. The stones pinged off my back as something momentous drained from me, such that I could swear I was shrinking back into myself. Lady P was no less discombobulated – markedly more so, I'd say – and it was she who broke the silence.

'She-Ra?!? Stop it, stop it! We don't throw 'planes at our friends!'

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Chapter 9

Chapter Summary

'Time for us to take a journey inside Adora's mind - who knows what we might find there?'

'Destiny, on this occasion! And a new meal I dreamed up, which I call lunkfast.'

'You're thinking of brunch, sir.'

'Too right I am. How about it, Catra? I'll have poached eggs, with a side of boiled eggs, with a topping of scrambled eggs. Thank you, love! ... ... Alright! Reader-peeps! Now she's stepped off, you and I can share a little secret. If you read this chapter very carefully, you might just see some hints that Catra liked me!!'

Chapter Notes

Content warnings apply for the below chapter only - Spoilers may be present in the warnings. This story does not include any of the four Archive Warnings topics, but does occasionally feature other topics that may require content notes.

Chapter 9 Content Warnings (INCLUDES SPOILERS):
Vehicle accident, aircraft - observed
Unconsciousness - experienced, observed
Risk of major character death - perceived, extensive (no major character death occurs)

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PART 9
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‘Are you quite alright, sir? Drink up.’

Everything was pretty dratted shaken up, I have to say. Her perfume gave way to a flask pressed into my shaking grasp. With her guidance, I got the thing to cracked lips and drank. A rather expensive tipple. Brandy, maybe cognac. It ricocheted through me, touching the sides without too much sticking, the only real, warm thing in a snowstorm fuzz. My tentative sip turned to a gulp, then her hand wrapped ‘round mine and encouraged me to take another. Well, I was hardly in a position to refuse.

Good old Meowmeow. Never one to steer me wrong, as long as I’ve known her! The second portion embraced the de l’Horde bones in that marvellously emotional way French drinks do, rather insulating me from all my troubles. Troubles I couldn’t quite remember right now. Heat held me tight in its embrace, and I felt somehow very--- *correct*. Like a critical piece had just slotted home into life’s great jigsaw puzzle. Clever stuff, this top end liquor. I smelt warmth, and my body vibrated to a second beat. I was home. Not sure about the dampness dappling my cheek, but these continental vineyards do work in awfully mysterious ways.

Well, being so safe, it couldn’t hurt to get a little shut-eye. The sands were running down with remarkable acuity, and it felt like I hadn’t slept for weeks. For all its curative properties, my valet’s elixir was pitching a losing battle against the fatigue radiating from the old skeleton. My bones ached something awful, each rattling like the last train home on the Bakerloo. And that’s to say nothing of the sharper pains which were fast coming back to me, like a school life of rugger tackles descending in a knotted mass.
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I'd drained a pint from a quart pot, to put a phrase on it, and darkness was rolling in, anyhow. Just a quick nap before dinner. Twenty winks ought to do it…

Oh, what relief to quit shouldering the daily burden! So long to the trifles of criminality, country manors and valets who couldn't be trusted to do as they were told! I'd need not a lick of those where I was going. Fare thee well, blurry and sun-dappled surroundings. To dreamland. And whatsoe'er treats tonight might have in store. Perhaps that one where Glimmer and I are snowed into an Alpine chalet together, eh? That one's always rather capital.

Hang about, though--- Here I was, waking up back home, crisp sheets all about me and morning 'paper on the bedside table. Folded and turned to the funnies too, just the way I like it. Never the news too early. One can have quite enough of that Prime-somebody fellow going on about the strengths of conformity or the conformities of strength and that rot. I'll save getting all stirred up for my lunchtime Martini, thank you! On second thought, better make it Martinis plural today, on account of my recent exertions.

'I say, Kyle? I mean, Meowmeow! What time is it? If it's awfully far through the morning, might as well skip the whole breakfast business and go straight to lunch. I'll have two Martinis, dry as you can. You know what? Better make it three. A gentlewoman can never be too careful. And some scrambled eggs, if it's not too much bother.'

Silence. I mean, the cheek of it! A new valet breaking in and drinking the top shelf stuff was one thing, but failing to heed the

cry of an Etherian as she calls out for her daily vittles? That was quite the sackable offence, if done without a damn good reason. I called again – pillar of leniency that I am – and waited. Still no reply. Well, Aunt Shadowtha would have made a dreadful fuss at that point, positively turning the air black. But I'm not Auntie. I'm a practical, modern woman-about-town who understands that mistakes sometimes happen, and one must occasionally be prepared to muck in, like that time Kyle got trapped in the laundry chute.

Not that I didn't call a third time before setting my day in motion, you understand. Meowmeow deserved at least one more chance to serve me breakfast-luncheon in bed. It was, alas, for naught. I rolled one leg out from the under the sheets, went to nudge the other, got a mite stuck, tugged at the sheets with a half-trapped hand and fell rather impressively to the floor. But I was, by some measure, up. Or, perhaps more accurately, down.

'Sir, I--- we need you to come back.'

'Meowmeow?'

From my freshly revised vantage point, I could gaze up at the impressive figure sparkling in my doorway. This was not my valet, unless she was attempting something from the more outré elements of the Parisian mode. Which, I suppose, wasn't entirely out of the question, and no less sensible than deducing that I really *was* looking at a hovering sword cane. Nice example of the breed it was too, what with its braided gold handle and twin inset opals. Quite the thing for the autumn season, and sure to perfectly set off the reversible opera cape I'd so had my eye on.

Of course, I reached out to touch it, and it really did delight in that metric too. No sooner had I placed a finger upon it, than this great feeling of being a strong and very real knight surged through me. I must confess, I even stammered out a heartfelt, ‘Spiffing!’

‘BALANCE MUST BE RESTORED.’

Well devil my eggs and call me a kipper, the thing spoke! I supposed I’d better answer it, lest a captivating new presence dictate my morning toileting for the second day in a row.

‘Excuse me, but I’m damned well trying, Ms. Floaty-Stick-Know-It-All. As you can no doubt see, I find myself entangled in the undersheet and could do with your help quite a bit more than your criticism. Can’t you cut me loose or something?’

‘ETHERIA MUST SEEK A HERO.’

‘I suppose that means you think I should get myself out of this sticky wicket?’

‘ADORA, ADORA.’

‘Sir Adora? Adora?!’

‘ADORA, ADORA.’

‘One moment, Meowmeow. There’s something here I need to figure out. It’s quite the big deal, I’m minded to say. Best round it up to a nice even four Martinis, there’s a good chapelette.’

Ms. Floaty-Stick began moving away from me at that, which felt a touch momentous or portentous. You know, whichever of those describes the feeling one gets when making the acquaintance of magical weaponry before coffee. Or gin. Naturally, I followed it. Showing a little pluck is part of the de l’Horde knightly duties, or at least the version I’d invented to comfort Scorpy. Come to think of it, where was old Scorps? I couldn’t remember saying goodbye to the old girl or her melons. Nor any of the rest of the Sugarbruh crew.

‘Stay with us--- stay with me.’

Onwards and upwards, eh. With a hop, skip and stumble, I dragged half of my bedding out into the pitch-dark corridor. No Meowmeow to be seen; no anything to be seen! Then the hat-stand exploded with light, and I found myself amongst wonderfully rich colours and pointed, geometric shapes that bore not the first shred of practicality. Art Deco, they call it. It’s all the rage down in Soho, and in the two Mrs. Neto-rellas’ flat downstairs. Here’s hoping I hadn’t accidentally wound up there again.

‘Please. I need you to stay.’

‘In the downstairs flat, Meowmeow? I got quite knotted up last time I tried that, if you catch my meaning. Better all round, I think, if I head back up.’

‘HELLO, ADORA.’

Oh good! The swordcane had found me! Either I was where I needed to be or, at the very least, I had someone – something? – to intercede on my behalf. I wouldn’t want a repeat of last time. Netting is all well and good as a thief deterrent, but it’s dratted difficult to escape when you’ve just made an honest mistake. With the sheets already restricting my movement, I didn’t much fancy my chances, particularly now a strange figure was appearing from the stylish murk.

‘I say, identify yourself! And, if it’s quite alright, would you mind telling me just what’s going on?’

‘I SENT THE SWORDCANE.’

‘Oh, and here comes the receipt, eh? Well, I didn’t think I’d have to pay for it, you can convey that to your outfitters or wherever you’ve come from. Smashing bit of kit, mind, and I’m sure Auntie will understand if I just take a little advance---’

‘THE SWORDCANE IS MEANT FOR YOU.’

‘Sir. Sir!’

‘Now there we’re in agreement! I think it’ll be quite the conversation piece, and maybe even juice my luck with the ladies.’

‘YOUR COUNTRY NEEDS YOU, ADORA.’

‘Don’t leave! Don’t you dare leave!’

‘Steady on, I thought we’d cleared up that whole war business over a decade ago now. All *wasser* under the *brücke* and so on. Why, I even ordered Glimmer’s birthday truffles from this place in Zwickau last year.’

‘ETHERIA NEEDS YOU, THE TRUE ETHERIA.’

‘Now, I don’t like the sound of that “true” business. I’ve seen the Imperial Fascist League rallies, more’s the pity, and your rhetoric sounds a little too much like that. Let me be perfectly clear. Sir Adora de l’Horde does not swing that way.’

‘BUT DOES SHE FIGHT AGAINST SUCH DARK, OPPRESSIVE FORCES? WILL YOU FIGHT AGAINST IT, WHEN YOU WERE

RAISED WITHIN IT?’

‘You need to come back, sir. I know what I’ve seen in you, and you can beat this. Fight, sir, for the people who--- who lo--- care for you.’

‘You’re not making a lick of sense, and that’s a pretty rich, rum line to take when you came to me, and rather bamboozled me with your sharp-edged style. If you think you’re heading home content today, then you’re sorely mistaken. I simply do not understand---’

‘YOU SHALL.’

‘Oh, I shall, shall I? Well, we’ll see about that, whoever-you-are and wherever-you-went. All I’m going to do right now is tuck myself back into bed and await whichever of the day’s meals Meowmeow sees fit to provide. Ms. Floaty-Stick? Please take me back to my rooms. I’m feeling… really… rather… whacked.’

*‘Please. **Adora!**’*

‘Meowmeow, would you stop fretting for just a moment? I’m on my way back to the grand old sleeping quarters, if only I could find them… Perhaps? Have I?’

Now, this really was all getting out of hand. I'd be writing a scathingly stern note to the sub-unconscious mind, once I unthreaded myself from this whole sorry scene-shifting business. The modish apartment had warped itself into a brick wall and flooring to match, which seemed a dreadful downgrade. And yet the front of me was all bound up in softness and warmth, bundled like the proverbial swaddled babe. That I didn't mind, but it was turning awfully tough to breath.

'I say, could you possibly back it off a little? I'm only mortal, you know?'

'Ador--- Sir, you're awake!'

'Meowmeow?!?'

'Yes, sir?'

My valet retreated like the proverbial scaled cat. In a jiffy, she was back up on the balls of her feet and quite composed, which made the moment all the stranger. Clearly, I'd been too liberally partaking of the midnight Stilton. The whole thing made about as much sense as the Dali exhibit Bow had dragged me into one joyless March evening.

'Just what do you think you're doing, eh, old chapelette?'

‘I have been working to restore you to consciousness, following your remarkable display of physical exertion, sir.’

‘Vigilance is all well and good, Meowmeow, but one mustn’t let it degenerate to mumsy over-concern. I’m hardly a maiden in need of chivalric protection.’

‘Is that so, sir?’

‘No need to turn the egg into an omelette, that’s what I always say. Unless you want an omelette, that is, which I seem to recall I did. Or do. How’s that coming along, eh? You’re awfully far from the kitchen but I’m sure that’s no handicap for a valet of your distinction.’

‘I beg pardon, sir. An omelette might fall outside of my immediate capabilities, though if I were to call up to the house---’

‘The flat, Meowmeow, we live in a flat.’

‘Quite correct, sir, but I must inform you that we currently reside upon the Shugborough estate of the esteemed Duchess Brightmoon and family.’

‘The Chesham Place Brightmoons?’

‘The very same, sir.’

‘Might be best to cancel the eggs then, don’t you think? Rotten luck that. Though I suppose it means I haven’t repeated my unwarranted incursion into the Neto-rellas’ residence, so we might call the whole thing a clean draw. Now then, any chance of a celebratory nibble?’

‘Our environs may muster as much as a cup of tea and a digestive biscuit.’

‘Smashing stuff, Meowmeow! Now, while I’ve got you, just why is that patch of ground over yonder covered in metal and fire?’

‘Do you not remember, sir? You caused a remarkable commotion.’

I knit my brows tight in concentration, assembling what little recollection I had of the last few moments. Pinched myself too, just to check I’d made it out of that damnable dreamscape. The skin snapped and welted, so I was either awake or the hidden depths of my psyche had undergone quite the spit-and-polish. Either way, the jerk was enough to set my upstairs humming.

Bow… Ms. Floaty-Stick… Jodhpurs – I made a mental note of how dashing those had looked, regardless of their wearer, and endeavoured to purchase a set of my own, should I ever make it back to London… A big voice with a small world view… Some hideous little statuette… Indiscreet valets… Atonal singing… Damn

Kyle not bringing the Martinis… Lady P calling me her She-ro, which was dashed nice of her but rather set me back in the Scorpy assistance stakes…

The whole thing was useless. I've never had the first lick of luck with jigsaws, never mind puzzles that don't have the whole picture stamped on the cardboard. But Meowmeow was looking persistent and, dare I flatter myself, concerned, so I pushed on. Start with the corners, de l'Horde, then the edges next. Ah! There it was!

'Oh, the old heave-ho with the whirlybird, you mean! Nothing that any other upstanding knight wouldn't have done for a chap in a spot of bother.'

'That would be the self-styled "Skyhawk" and his *Dragon's Daughter IV*, sir, an aeroplane we undertook to deliver for repairs, following its first regrettable crash landing. There has since been a second.'

'Quite literally smashing stuff, then!'

Always a risk, a joke in a sticky situation. A line that lightens the mood in one scene summons the social hangman in the other, and, curse the Ancients, I've never quite unpicked the difference between the two scenarios. Drives Auntie up the wall, I'll tell you that. Glimmer and Bow are a measure more indulgent, but Meowmeow comes from quite the different world and puts out such a tremblingly powerful persona. Dash it, I wanted her to be impressed, and couldn't quite say why.

I watched her like a hawk or, rather, how a hawk would stare if their eyes pointed forwards and their guts were swimming in liberally-applied liquor, and did what I could to read my valet's expression. Her eyes were inscrutable as before – they summoned this indescribably squirmy feeling in me – but her lips held the answer. She smirked, her face the sculpture of knowing, flint-edged whimsy, then broke out in peels of giggling, girlish glee.

What a sound! Imbued with all the levity of the music halls and the unguarded joy of old and ever closer friends, the notes flicked her face into the most wondrous grin. She smiled with her whole countenance, her cheeks shifting into a thousand ever-shifting dimples, her cheeks cresting high to frame her gaze as something soft and profound. And that before we speak of the number this moment did on me, her music warming the air between us and lodging in my chest. Tingly, it felt. Deep too. Quite a thing, this camaraderie. A gentlewoman really does come to appreciate her valet!

'I regret to inform you, sir, that you caused the more recent incident, leading to further substantial deterioration of the airframe. Your exertions threw the de Havilland into the air, whereupon an errant gust directed the aeroplane across the Shugborough estate.'

'I'm dreadfully sorry about all that, Meowmeow. I certainly can't see how we'll get the thing to its destination now.'

'Fortunately, sir, you have delivered the 'plane to exactly where it needs to be. Its constituent parts now stand outside the workshop

of a talented engineer in my acquaintance, who has undertaken to repair the craft to its former glory. Once, of course, the remaining flames have been extinguished.'

Sure enough, my right hand was, well, right. In the sense that she was correct, naturally. Adopting the kind of blink-and-squint combination one generally associates with a sandy beach, a windy afternoon and the eyeward encroachment of a dash too much sunscreen, I slowly brought the blurring backdrop back to its customary focus, and spied within it a piece or two that might conceivably have once been the *Dragon's Daughter IV*. About this wreckage hopped a figure animated and diminutive in equal measure, tapping this and measuring that. At last, the setting sun glinted off a pair of goggles, and a shout rang out across the courtyard.

'Emily, bring the camera! The carburettor has homemade twin fuel feeds! They lead to separate reservoirs, each containing a different fuel. From my initial observations, these liquids have diverging viscosities and flammabilities at ground level, suggesting the pilot puts them to different uses. But why? It's FASCINATING!'

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Chapter 10

Chapter Summary

'Meeting the friends. It's one of the hardest parts of any relationship, don't you agree? The How-To dating books I got out of the library certainly think so! Now. Catra and I weren't actually coupled at this point - but helloing her chum Entrapta was still a sticky situation, not least because they kept insisting I was this ancient magic warrior person. Small talk is one thing, but this was bloody big chat indeed! About positively--- HUGE--- muscles---'

'Sir, your brunch is... Flrfgh!'

'Welcome back, Catra! I'm just showing the reader-folk my She-Ra form... I say! Are you alright? You look awfully flushed. And you've dropped the dining tray!'

Chapter Notes

Content warnings apply for the below chapter only - Spoilers may be present in the warnings. This story does not include any of the four Archive Warnings topics, but does occasionally feature other topics that may require content notes.

Chapter 10 Content Warnings:
Unconsciousness - recalled

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PART 10

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‘Hiiii!! What’cha got there?’

Meowmeow grinned as she bowed to the scientist bounding toward us.

‘Nothing escapes you, Entrapta. Whilst endeavouring to rescue Mr. Skyhawk’s de Havilland, I took the liberty of removing a section of fuselage for your study, fearing that any part not captured in that moment would fall prey to the conflagration. I noted its rigidity and pristine condition, retained despite its highly saline coating, and thought the material might interest you.’

‘Oooh… And it does!! How can an aluminium-esque material show the weight and strength benefits of an alloy, while also retaining the corrosion resistance of the base metal? Ah-ha! Do you want to know the answer? Come on, Catra, take a look! Can you see? It’s not one material! It’s two! Isn’t that *fascinating*? You can see the join line, where layers of the outer coating have been rolled onto the main alloy. It’s *very*--- *technologically advanced*. Oooh! It makes me *shiver*. I’ve never seen anything like this up close before! If I had to advance a theory, I’d say this is an example of Alclad, the Alcoa product used to build the Detroit ZMC-2. It’s brand new! It’s the cutting edge! Thanks, Catra!’

My valet rapidly side-stepped the impending embrace of fearfully-stained engineer’s gauntlets.

‘An embrace won’t be necessary,’ she yelped. ‘I simply thought the material might interest Emily.’

‘Heyyy… Yeah! Think of the places she could go! I mean, Emily is really happy with me here on land, but what if she could go to the seaside? Or I could make her completely aquatic!? She’d be unstoppable!! Let’s see if she likes that. Emily??! EMIILLLLYYY?? Can you come over here please?’

The travails of the good knight Sir Adora were going rather unremarked. As my multifaceted assistant revealed another, well, facet of her protean personality, I’d found my feet and placed them under me, regretting to my very soul the scuffs that had somehow befallen my brogues. But the upstanding, chivalric sort rises above such personal woundings, no matter how unrepairable or how likely to give Aunt Shadowtha the perfect opening to suggest I purchased something more ladylike.

I swallowed the ensuing shudder like a champ, dusted myself off rather literally, then struck a pose of casual insouciance. ‘Charming to meet you, old chap,’ I began to ooze. As refined a creature as Meowmeow would, I was sure, associate only with those that offered similarly accomplished conversation. Well, I couldn’t make a dent. The pair kept nattering on about their dratted metal shard. Well, I wasn’t to be stopped on the charm offensive. No sir. I regrouped, then hit them with a rather fine, ‘Any friend of my valet is a friend of mine. There’s no doubt about it!’

‘Ummm… okay? I don’t understand your logic. But I do know that you’re the Sheeee-Raaa!! So let’s talk about *that*. Ooh, watching you throw the dH60 was fascinating – do you know which muscle

groups you engaged to achieve that much uplift? And how did you calculate the locus of the flight to ensure the apex avoided the chimney crests? So many factors were changing at once, and you computed them instantaneously! It's a triumph of calculus and super-human athletics in equal measure. Eeee! I just love it!'

'Yes, yes, I think that's rather enough about mathematics and all that head-spinning rot. Why do Plumers and, er, *you* think I'm this She-Ra fellow?'

My latest conversational partner cocked their head and squinted a little, as if I'd just asked something more singular and intriguing that I'd intended. They cocked an eyebrow rather impressively, the googles affixed to their forehead jumping up to the jauntiest of angles in reply.

'Errr... Because you *are*. My early research says so, and data never lies! I analysed your appearance during the unscheduled earth-vehicle interface, then cross-referenced my findings by interviewing everyone around the impact site. Weeeeellll… everyone except *you*. You were a tiiiinnnyy bit too unconscious. But now you're not, so science can continue! Tell me, how long have you been She-Ra? Your appearance exactly matches historical descriptions of the She-Ra. Or, perhaps, *a* She-Ra. Is that a requirement or a deliberate choice? Why did you make it?'

'I didn't! I'm not! If all this confusion is about my outfitting, then you can blame my valet for that. To think, Meowmeow! If I'd had my proper say, it would have been cricket whites, to match the spirits of the season, not this collection of herringboned restraint.'

‘I happen to find your outfit rather fetching, sir.’

‘Well, you would, wouldn’t you?! If you love it so much, you should have worn it yourself. Then you could have been the one suffering this arch embarrassment.’

‘I don’t know what you mean, sir.’

‘Just listen to this swot, Meowmeow, then you’ll find your answer. There is somebody else out there, seen by Lady Plumers and, it seems, our current conversational partner, who wears the exact same weeds as I. It’s an offence to the proper de l’Horde spirit – a venal sartorial sin. In abandoning myself to a new valet’s distinctions, my appearance has become… *ubiquitous*.’

Something of a shudder ran through me. As well it might! To lose my style was to lose my tongue. And that was something of a tragedy, when both were so well adored on the London 'club scene.

‘I beg your pardon, sir. I regret to inform you that I did not select the outfitting to which our engineer companion refers.’

‘Ah-huh! I’m not talking about *this* suit,’ the engineer confirmed. ‘It shows no sign of being scientifically advanced. The only interesting thing about it is how it appeared on you, approximately 172 seconds after you lost consciousness.’

‘Hold on there, chap. Do you mean to say that somebody dressed me?’

‘Noooo, not some*one*. Some*thing* is a possibility, but far from the only available thesis. Variations caused by light refraction or other unusual – but entirely possible – movements of tinnnnyyyy atoms way, way smaller than our capabilities of visual perception could be the cause, so that you could appear to change outfit without actually doing anything. A mass psychiatric situation is another potential scenario – maybe something like a mirage or a shared delusion? – because everyone present witnessed the alteration. I made notes. See?’

Entrapta rifled through an oil-stained notebook. It came from an oil-stained apron and its pages were flicked by oil-stained fingers. The latter was a particularly impressive feat as, until a mere moment ago, the hands in question had been safely tucked inside oil-stained gloves. I was noticing both an emergent theme and the vigilance with which Meowmeow kept herself out of smudging radius.

‘*Ah-hum*,’ Entrapta began reading. ‘“92 seconds post incident: Subject appears unconscious, unresponsive to verbal and tactile stimuli. 127 seconds post incident: Same. 169 seconds post incident: Subject surrounded by instantaneous white light, possibly incandescent, no known source. Duration: estimated two to three seconds. Following light dispersal, subject appears markedly diminished in stature, white close-cut clothing no longer visible, formal woollen suit apparent.”’

‘Now that can’t be right. Unless, somehow---’

I tugged at my shirt collar. Finding its pristine starch as unyielding as it was admittedly dashing, I shot a hand instead through my placket and set hunting for an explanation. A tentative rummage revealed nothing of note. There was no secreted second outfit to be found. All I could perceive down there were the things one expects when staring chestward ho.

Ever the gentlewoman’s gentlewoman, Meowmeow had the grace to blush quite beetroot at my indiscretion. Her hue turned a darker shade of ruby when I protested, by reminding her that I had yet to search my trousers. She grabbed my wrist after that. For some reason, I wasn’t at all minded to admonish her. She was only looking out for her employer, after all.

‘Sir. Before you achieve public undress, may I describe the outfit to which Entrapta refers? It is rather--- bold, even by your standards. I perceived a gold-over-white overall with pronounced epaulettes in place of sleeves and a central jewelled detail. The lower section of said garment resembled a skirt sewn over a pair of shorts.’

‘A skort, perhaps you’d call it?’

‘I choose not to engage in portmanteau, sir. The outfit was complemented by matching riding boots, a red cape, a pair of archer’s arm guards, and a stylised coronet.’

‘Sounds a sprightly collection, and just the thing for Midsummer. Only a few days away, you know. How did I come to be wearing it? And whereabouts is it now?’

‘The first point I can answer quite simply,’ Meowmeow soothed. ‘While transporting the aeroplane, you entered a state of heightened mental and physical exertion, during which you disappeared inside a spontaneous rainbow. You remained within for a period I would estimate between ten and 90 seconds, before emerging with said clothing and matching stature.’

Shiny droplets flicked from Entrapta’s notes, as they raced to explain the latest in a growing queue of formidable head-spinners. ‘I have notes! More notes! “Subject appeared over two feet taller than human form in possible She-Ra form: exact measurements pending. Subject as She-Ra also exhibited longer and lighter hair with wind-creation phenomenon. Interviewees who viewed She-Ra while conscious report eyes as ‘piercing’, ‘luminescent’ or ‘very, very blue’. Also observed: ‘very big muscles’.”’ They snapped the foolscap shut for emphasis. ‘Catra was especially clear on that last point.’

I stared at them blankly. Entrapta pointed a spanner in my direction, grinning, while endeavouring to place a fraternal gauntlet upon Meowmeow’s shoulder. My valet evaporated discreetly from the threat of greasy embrace, but the two now faced me as a wall of abstruse, if not flat out unbelievable, truths.

‘Catra’s description of the initial transformation completes the contemporary dataset,’ said the scientist. ‘Unlleesss you have anything else to tell me??? About what if feels like to be a

hypothesised She-Ra?? Anything you've seen or felt or noticed?'

'Between the Lesbian realisation and some tremendously confusing emotions, I've barely had pause to draw mental breath, I'm afraid. Apart from the whole daydream business. Though I don't know what sassy, levitating accessories could teach you---'

'The item in your dream!' Entrapta positively bounded towards me. 'Was it a sword? Did it have a large, clear jewel in its hilt?'

'A sword-*cane*, actually. But yes. And how did you know that?'

'I'm *so* glad you asked! The answer lies in the second dataset. For the last several years, I've been tabulating information contained in the historic documentary objects of Shugborough and its surrounding area. It was part of another project, to track the development of prototypical assembly lines in nail manufacture. But why stop there when you're having fun?! I wanted to know *everything*!! Books… diaries… pamphlets… religious texts… lewd graffiti… fine art… pottery… folk songs… oral traditions… lewd graffiti of *oral* traditions… formal music… stained-glass windows… *gravestones*.

'All that data – and so little of it catalogued or analysed with modern research methods! Eeee! I can't keep myself away from it. The learning opportunities are limitless! Old and Middle Etherian societies didn't commonly adhere to formal scientific principle – not as we understand it. But they observed trends, recognised patterns and crafted explanations for the phenomena that fell outside of those systems. And I've collated it all! It's an entirely new perspective, allowing the trends of centuries to be

viewed together! At once! Collectively! I can see what no-one else has ever seen before – what no mortal could previously perceive!! Bwah-hahahahahah!'

When a new acquaintance throws back their head to cackle, hands flung out towards the sky, the going can be said to be something less than good. With Entrapta doing just that – and executing the act with an aplomb that suggested this wasn't their first rapscallion rodeo – I began to have reservations. Hmm. Actually. Let me amend that. More accurately, I started to have *more* reservations, to pile neatly atop the several I'd already logged. Meowmeow, for her part, was suavely unperturbed. She's a remarkable woman, that valet of mine!

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Chapter 11

Chapter Summary

'The elder Pliny once said to the younger: "All time is wasted that is not spent in study".'

'Then why are you squeezing my arm like that, Catra, babe?'

'I'm *studying* the interaction between your bicep and tricep when you flex. How can I become an expert, Adora, if I don't do my homework? For my next research project: What happens to your muscles when I kiss them?'

'Ooh! Ah-hum. Shouldn't we tell the readers something about the next chapter? They're in for an avalanche of what story-writers call "lore" - She-Ra, King Arthur, various cultures, ancient languages, etymology, and how it all comes together to explain me, the present She-Ra!'

'Readers, you may wish to check this chapter's preceding notes. Very extensive content warnings apply.'

'Yes, good point, Catra! Now... what are going to do about what's left of the eggs? They're starting to stink out the carpet...'

Chapter Notes

Content warnings apply for the below chapter only - Spoilers may be present in the warnings. This story does not include any of the four Archive Warnings topics, but does occasionally feature other topics that may require content notes. Chapter 11 has extensive content warnings. If you just need a quick overview, please find a shorter list of the chapter's content warning themes below the main list.

Chapter 11 Content Warnings (CONTAINS SPOILERS): Transphobia - detailed, present - Perceived, unintentional,

apologised for, not aimed at another character (No intentional transphobia present)
Fear/trauma reaction to transphobia - narrated, detailed, present (No intentional transphobia present)
Misgendering - detailed, present - Perceived, unintentional, apologised for, not aimed at another character (No intentional misgendering in this element)
Deadnaming - alluded to, present - Perceived, unintentional, apologised for, not aimed at another character, stopped before it occurs (No intentional deadnaming in this element)
Misgendering - related, detailed, past - Historic, deliberate, intentional, state-imposed, not by or aimed at main cast
Misnaming - related, detailed, past - Historic, deliberate, intentional, state-imposed, not by or aimed at main cast
Non-binary erasure - related, brief reference, past - Historic, deliberate, uses real life example of British academic/cultural practice, not by or aimed at cast
Autistic character misunderstood - narrated, detailed, present - Character's infodump is perceived as potentially transphobic by another character, but is not intentionally transphobic. Second character later apologises for misunderstanding autistic character
Autistic character overwhelmed - narrated, detailed, present - Character is overwhelmed by above, separates from group to sooth self
Colonialism - related, detailed, past and some present - Based on real life English and British colonial practice
Imperialism - related detailed, narrated, past and some present - Based on real life English and British imperial practice
Dominant culture privilege - related, narrated, present - Narrator indicates and articulates belief that the dominant culture (her culture) is benevolent, most civilised, most advanced, paternalistic. Narrator shows limited understanding of other viewpoints, colonial-imperial wrongdoing. Other characters educate narrator extensively
Cultural suppression - related, detailed, narrated, past and some present - Based on real life English imperial practice,

uses real life example of Welsh language suppression
Cultural control - detailed historic, referenced present - Partially based on real life English and British imperial practices
Misogyny - related, detailed, past - Partially based on real life English medieval events and practices

Chapter 11 Content Warnings, Themes:
Transphobia
Autistic character has difficult interactions
Colonialism/Imperialism
Cultural Control
Misogyny

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PART 11

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'Humans!' Entrapta bellowed. 'Humans are flawed recorders of their environment. They assume things and treat their own perception as absolute. I've seen it so many times in the documentation. It's insidious! It goes back millennia! So many of these civilisations – even individual people – came across something they hadn't seen before and concluded that it must be entirely new. But the data! It never lies! Take a long enough view and even exceptional events are part of a larger pattern. Like comets. Or eclipses. Or *She-Ra.*'

'Manners maketh man. Or woman, in my case,' I spluttered. 'But this has gone on quite long enough. How did you know about the

sword? And are you ever going to tell me why you think I'm a She-Ra?'

'Okay, okay,' they nodded. 'Have you heard of King Arthur?'

'Knights of the Round Table, sworn protectors of Etheria, went off to get some fancy cup or other. I think there's a dragon in there somewhere? Fine stories – stirring medieval fantasies. Why, I used to prance around dressed as Lancelot when I was aged seven or so, dreaming of the day I'd defend the good folk of Etheria. Smashing training it was too, given the knightly de l'Horde duties I shoulder now.'

'Lancelot du Lac was a later addition to the prose cycle, sir,' Meowmeow purred, 'coming from our continental cousins to the south. Several other knights were subtracted over the centuries that followed the compositional period, not least the non-binary hero Silence.'

'You'll be telling me Arthur wasn't part and parcel of the thing next!'

'Abooouutttt thhhaaaaatt,' Entrapta hummed. 'My research indicates there was no such *man* as Arthur.'

'Of course there wasn't! The whole business is made up, for telling round the campfire and such.'

‘Errrrkk!! Noooooo!! It wasn’t. Approximately 157 of the artefacts I collated contain direct reference to the Arthurian figurehead – another 49 are less clear about it, more oblique – but none dated before 1065 use the name “Arthur”. Not one!’

Truth be told, I tend not to detect the finer subtleties. It really does drive Aunt Shadowtha loopy, and Glimmer with it! Let’s just say that I spotted more summer fruits on the signage than my palate when we chanced a joint sojourn to Berry Bros. & Rudd. Style and sporting autos aside, you could wallop me with a house brick and I’d tootle off without a single scrape. But even I knew an unhappy Meowmeow when I saw one. As her friend kept chattering, my gentlewoman was getting increasingly unsettled. Her ears pricked, slanting ever-so-slightly back, and her back began to arch.

‘Isn’t that *fascinating*?’ Entrapta thundered on, straining my capacity to keep up. ‘And the term “King” isn’t universally affixed to Arthur until---- I want to say… 1142? Plus-minus two years. Definitely during the civil war to oust Matilda. Definitely. Ooooh! And the first document to gender him as a man doesn’t appear until either 1070 or 1071. The exact date is sllliiiigghhttlly unclear. But it can’t be earlier, not with the astrological events it references.’

‘No,’ my valet breathed in a sharpening whisper. ‘Entrapta, no.’

If only I’d processed her murmur lickety-split, I could have kept the de l’Horde kisser from spitting out, ‘So if Arthur isn’t *Arthur*, who the Dickens is he? Or… Ummm--- they?’

‘*She*.’ the scientist replied. My valet’s eyes shot wide as dinner plates. ‘Wellllll… mostly. *Predominantly*. The pronouns aren’t entirely consistent before the records converge on he, him and himself. Oh! But when they do! That final pronoun set is established *strikingly* quickly. Just two decades! That’s all it takes to make consensus across every major Etherian document. It’s he and him all the way, plus consistent referencing to Arthur as a man. Not that those two are automatically connected. Though they are linked in *this* case. Several older sources also exhibit alteration, where prior pronouns have been obscured and replaced. I observed the same with names---’

‘*En--- Entrapta. Stop.*’ Meowmeow was much louder this time; her tail was creatine lightning. ‘Just stop! What are you doing? Why are you misgendering him?! How--- how *dare* you? I can’t let you deadname him. I’m warning you – I won’t take that lying down.’

‘No no no no nooooooo!! Catra, that isn’t my intention at all. I’m really, really, *really* sorry that I gave that impression. I'm sorry I upset you. I--- I’m trying to explain that the mythical man King Arthur is an *invention*.’

‘Yes, because he and everyone else at the big circular sideboard were works of fiction.’ I added. I was getting the hang of this now. ‘*But* you’re telling us that the characters were twiddled around over time, so they could distract and delight new generations afresh. You know, to compete with the rise of the morning crossword. Or is that a bit advanced for early Middle Etherian? A wordsearch, perhaps.’

‘That isn’t *right* either,’ Entrapta replied. ‘I’m going to take a walk; I’ll be back in ten minutes.’

‘A mighty fine mess, don’t you think Meowmeow?!’

‘Adora. I can’t--- I need to not talk right now.’

We waited in silence. Not the best thing for the de l’Horde mind, that. Too many thoughts to think. Weighing them one at a time would be challenge enough, but the process is rather more like pushing ripe brie through a colander. The matter goes off in any number of directions at once, few of them predictable and all of them urgent, with quite the mess to clean up later. Capes fought with ‘planes fought with talking swords fought with Meowmeow. Buttons undone on Meowmeow’s shirt… The way said shirt billowed when she dipped me… The indescribable yet perfectly articulate sense that---

‘Okkkaayyy, let’s try again,’ the returning Entrapta suggested. ‘If you want?’

We nodded, though Meowmeow’s tail swished low.

'Thank you for apologising,' my valet replied. 'I, too, am sorry, for not taking the time to understand you.'

'I really appreciate that, Catra. I *really* didn't mean to upset you like that.'

'I know.'

My gentlewoman was shivering slightly, her silhouette vibrating against the evening warmth. I offered her my jacket. Meowmeow refused, crossing her arms tight across her chest, exaggerating the jolting movements. Chivalry compelled me to ask again and, this time, she assented. As I draped the wool across her shoulders, the sun's setting rays lit up a single tear on my companion's cheek.

'The mythical man King Arthur is a fabrication,' the engineer re-commenced. 'He was designed to fictionalise and obscure the actions of an earlier, very real woman or group of women. My research indicates that the name "Arthur" was established by a powerful Etherian Earl, who commissioned at least seven documents throughout 1065 that quote or recount a "Legend of Arthur". These are the very first references to that name in the entire dataset.'

'He was very *demanding*. The Earl, I mean. All seven papers begin with the same proclamation, mandating that the "legend" is shared as widely as possible with the general population. But his "legendary" stories?' Entrapta guffawed. 'They were nothing new at all. Noooo… Strip away the nonsense about the noble right to rule, reinstate the sections about community and connection with the earth, and you're holding a copy of the Arth-Red Tales!'

‘It’s on my to-read list,’ I ventured, weakly. ‘Quite far down, if I’m honest. What’s it about?’

‘Errr--- *Arth-Red*, mostly. The tales are a collection of historical folk stories about her life, which appear in prototypical form around 900 and get *reallllllyyyyy* popular before they’re banned. That comes down to the pronouns and Etherian cultural control. What with the invasion, and the war, there was a new King by 1070 and the use of “he” and “him” in the “Legend of Arthur” actually comes direct from the Royal Court. There are illustrated manuscripts, then a royal decree, then in 1081 it becomes law. A really *grizzly* one, punishable by flogging and burning and all the fun stuff.’

They were warming to their theme and Meowmeow had perked right up, nodding along with enviable gravity. I mimicked as best I could, but, alas, my head was spinning. It was deportment lessons all over again, with alien verbosity crashing down upon the psyche, but my gentlewoman’s restraining hand forestalled my attempt to interrupt. Entrapta went on.

‘That makes the pre-existing canon illegal, which is why a lot of my dataset shows signs of amendment or attempted destruction. But not all of it! Smaller, less formal groups kept telling the real stories, which get added to over time with new arcs and encounters. I’m still researching those, to see if they’re embellishments or evidence of further, more recent interactions!’

Silence reigned between us again, this time as a blessed belief. I was befuddled as a St. Bernard in an aquarium. After a moment to gather my reckonings, it dawned that my curiosity had been, at best, imperfectly resolved.

‘Well and good, Entrapta, I’m sure. But who was this Arth-Red? The one whom Arthur pretends to be, or stands in front of, or something?’

‘I’ll only answer if I get to ask you a question *first*. What is Etheria?’

‘Here?’ I took a moment to consider. ‘Here.’

‘But what does that *mean*?’

‘Etheria is the country in which we three stand – and jolly lucky we are to do so!’

I thumped my chest with the fitting fervour. Meowmeow pursed her lips.

‘An imprecise definition, sir, if I may say so.’

‘You’ll say so anyway, no doubt! Go on then, old chapelette, tell us what Etheria really means.’

‘I fear you may not yet be prepared for the full intensity of my answer, Sir Adora. We will content ourselves, for now, with the legal and sociological definitions. Etheria does, indeed, refer to the country which spans between Lizard and Marshall Meadows, Lowestoft and Land’s End. This is the central application of the term.’

‘So I was right, is what you’re saying? Much obliged, Meowmeow!’

‘You are partially correct, sir. Two further definitions must be considered, each entrenched in *synecdoche*.’

‘The Brightmoon pile? Just round the corner, isn’t it?!’

‘That would be Shugborough House. I refer to the ancient rhetorical technique, wherein a sectional part is used as substitute terminology for its whole. If you were to ask for my hand, sir, you would be employing synecdoche to request every part of me. Or so I would *certainly* hope.’

Blasted inconsistent evenings they have round here. But a moment ago, I’d been wind-nipped for lack of my jacket – not that a knight ever regrets her chivalry – yet here I was cooking like the holiday goose, ears prickled as gooseberries. I know the sun sets later over the northern hinterlands but, until now, I’d thought one had to trek somewhere Scandinavian before the fire-ball falls demonstrably later than it does in London. And all this before I even tried to comprehend the fluctuating temperatures! We were in a curious state indeed. But my valet only wanted to chat grammar…

‘Most telling,’ she went on, ‘must be its literal translation. *Simultaneous understanding*. To see the vital part is to the know the whole. Am I coming across clearly, Adora?’

‘Urk. Eep. Frh?’

Drat it, this heat really was getting to me. I tugged at my collar and tie. Conventionality had long since left this conversation and, hypocrite that it made me, I toyed with trialling Meowmeow’s much-flaunted chest aeration techniques. Just for a moment, you understand. And only in a location where word wouldn’t get back to Auntie. Tentatively loosing the top button, I drew my fellow chatterers’ gazes, thought better of it, hesitated, then decided to go ahead. My education continued anon.

‘Etheria is commonly employed as shorthand for both the Etherian Kingdom and the wider Etherian Empire, despite being only one country in each of these structures. One is hardly overlaboured imagining why.’

‘Because it’s the main country!’ I chipped in. Huzzah! The conversation had come back to the firm ground of de l’Horde instruction. ‘The founding state; the leader; the seat of our envied strength, law and authority!’

‘Etheria is regarded – *by Etherians* – as the over-ruling power and culture within the aforementioned structures, yes. The widespread

employment of synecdoche, by state and citizenry alike, reinforces its dominance.'

'We lead the way as we lay down pathways across the world,' I cheered. 'Don't worry yourself, chapelette, I'm well briefed in that business. Aunty made sure of that. Been learning it since my babyhood nursery rhymes! Dratted odd little songs, but terribly instructional in the core Etherian values. Truth, honour, duty, industry, self-reliance, modesty, civilisation. All of that. And the best de l'Hordes must share them widely, sure of a grateful reply!'

'If I might be so bold, sir, such positivity is far from universal.'

'As usual, Catra is correct!' Entrapta grabbed me by the wrist. 'I'm not a biiiggggg fan of what post-invasion Etheria stands for. Or what it does. Or how shows no signs of stopping. Or how it taught to you to make all those nasty jingoism noises. *Buuuutttt*… Etheria does have the best tech. It's ethical dilemma ah… sixty-three.'

'Wait, aren't *you* Etherian?'

'No no no no no. *Noooooooo…* No. I'm Welsh. That's why I had to ask you about Etheria. I don't want another misunderstanding. Because Wales – although it *is* within the Etherian Kingdom – is a nation in its own right. One which used to be entirely independent, while participating in elements of shared culture that spanned a group of similar civilisations. Adora? Have you got that? It's *viiiitttaaaalll* to understanding Arth-Red.'

‘Yes?’ I was agreeing to something and hoped, in time, to discover what.

‘Soooooooooo… Arth-Red is Welsh. Her name combines the word “Bear” and a suffix used to abstract, so it translates as “Bear-like” or something like that. There are hypotheses on how she got that name – so *many* of them! – buuuuttttt… We don’t really know. Not yet. It could reference her strength, or her affinity with wildlife, or the Celtic association between bears and physical transformation. Arth-Red first gets mentioned around 875, then by 880 she starts popping up across Wales *and* various kingdoms of pre-invasion Etheria.’

‘What does she do?’

‘Good things! *All* the good things! Helps people… preserves nature… fights baddies… pushes back against feudal lords… So people start to notice! Circa 878 she saves a whole Marches village from flooding and ka-boom!! Arth-Red is into the Sagas. People have been talking about her ever since. The Tales were a biiiiiggggg deal – and they don’t just get written down and repeated. No! Time after time after time, there are new stories, new sightings, new interactions, with different people and in different places. Arth-Red appears across the nations, then across the *centuries*. I can see it all! With the secondary dataset!!’

‘Wanna know what else I can see?’ They pointed a screwdriver against my chest. I was aghast to see that the heretofore-unseen tool dripped just as much oil as its siblings. ‘I’ll give you a clue. Alongside the stories and the letters and all the rest of the writing, I’ve also catalogued the *visual* record. It’s *so* much easier to process – and at least as informative. And that’s where I

established the reeeeeaaaallllllyyyy vital pattern. The one that makes me so sure you're *YOU*!! Do you wanna take a guess what I saw? In. Every. Single. Image?'

'Trees? No, wait--- Arth-Red!'

'I meeeaannn… *yes*. But what is she wearing?'

'Clothes?'

Entrapta cackled again, flicking back through their notebook. They slapped it down alongside a box, from which they extracted two paintings, a photograph of a stained-glass window, and what appeared to be part of a wall.

'White one-piece,' they pointed. 'Gold cross. Cape. Billowing hair. Recognise them?'

'But you claimed I was a She-Ra. Am I an Arth-Red now?'

'The answer lies in etymology! Are you ready Adora? Let's get *word.*'

'Hurrah?' The question mark was doing a lot of the work there. One really wants a hot bath and a piping roast after a day's

travails, and today was proving travaillier than most. If, indeed, that was a word. What even was language, at this point? Entrapta appeared to be speaking good, proper Etherian, yet no fewer than half their words refused to sit down and make sense.

I'll save you the torture of wading through the following explanation, having subjected you to quite enough of this head-melt business already. The gist – as far as I could make it out – was that the somewhat-linked ancient cultures of what is now either the Etherian Kingdom or Ireland each had their own language, but that these distinct tongues shared quite a good deal. *Cognates* were bandied about, ditto *derivations*. Long story short, they all back to a common ancestral tongue: First Ones.

But one has to be a cunning linguist! The original language and early variants of its offshoots are equally untranslatable – though no-one told me! – so modern academics bundle everything beyond comprehension under the First Ones banner. Then there was some blather about how the split-up languages kept evolving, and how modern variants are still spoken today. I'll confess I was losing interest here, until Entrapta brought up the Welsh Not. That--- That can't be true, can it? Did they really hang signs around kiddies' necks to ridicule them out of speaking their first language?! It's rotten. Barbaric, even!

Still, the She-Ra explanation persevered. As did I, though I was getting awfully tired… History took up its stint, detailing how stories and cultural phenomena move between different societies. Dragons shared skies with floating ships, the latter sending down crewmen who drowned in fresh air. Arth-Red was back at the table too, under which Arthur had buried her, due to her witchcraft. I guess his boyfriend couldn't handle the competition! Oh, and something about Etheria wanting a monocle-culture. This,

I recalled, meant more Lesbians. I expressed the fitting support, only to find myself scolded!

It all came together – and I came apart – in a final spiel, which swapped from *-red* to *-rad* to *-radh* to *-ra* at bewildering pace, dancing between languages, eras and meanings. Pronouns strafed in several tongues, screwed to various modifiers and sometimes swapped out entirely. Arth-Red came back up, but so did *Hi-Red* and *Sí-Ra* and *Ee-Rey* and cetera. They were similar and different and the same and stories and one person and lots of people and myths and… and… and… and I had something to do with it?

'Quite fascinating, as you would say,' Meowmeow purred, applauding Entrapta's triumphant curtsey. 'If I might make one request, could you more simply explain the connection between Sir Adora's present experiences and the historical She-Ra? I fear our discussion over-taxes her nerves.'

'Adora? You… are… the… latest… She-Ra.'

I staggered backwards, vaguely desiring to make more room for the enormity of the concept. Events overtook me, followed by a low and unseen wall. I stumbled, fumbled, hung in the air like a brass bust of a noble heron, then surrendered to gravity. My eyes gazed up at dusky, retreating skies. At least, I found time to muse, the arriving gravelly embrace had borne my unconscious form already. It would know what to do. I closed my eyes.

Thud. I re-peeled my peepers. I had not hit the ground. Instead, I was hanging in mid-air, with a pair of medal-hued gauntlets

thrusting from my armpits. Was this what the ceaseless day now had in store? Would it ever end? Did Me-Ra get more arms, to fight more villainy?

‘Eeeee!’ Entrapta bounced. ‘You made it! And right in the nick of time. She-Ra? I’d like you to turn around – and meet Emily.’

‘Gynoid--- Robot--- Maschin--- Metr--- For the Honour of Greyskull!’

Horror and a half-hewn rainbow crackled about me and then--- nothing. Not even Ms. Floaty-Sword.

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Chapter 12

Chapter Summary

'Did you know I went to Oxford, Catra?'

'Really, sir? You never mention it.'

'I did! Rowed, punted, got lost in the Bodleian. The whole nine yards! Well, this is the story of my uni years, how I met Bow and Glimmer, and my *very* healthy relationship with my family!'

'Readers, welcome to Adora's Flashback Sequence.'

'Does that mean we'll have a Catra's Flashback Sequence?'

'Not quite yet. All in good time, sir.'

Chapter Notes

Content warnings apply for the below chapter only - Spoilers may be present in the warnings. This story does not include any of the four Archive Warnings topics, but does occasionally feature other topics that may require content notes.

Chapter 12 Content Warnings (INCLUDES SPOILERS):
Emotionally absent parenting - observed, experienced
Emotionally manipulative/abusive parenting - observed, experienced
Connection-starved, touch-starved narrator
Narrator reflects on historic CompHet
Violence, threat of violence - observed, historic
Drug use - observed, historic
Vehicle accident, bicycle - narrated, historic, minor injury

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PART 12

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‘Hey, Sir Adora.’

That purr punctuated what little rest I’d marshalled over the previous who-knew-how-many hours. The night had scored no restful hours, stripped as it was of the thread-counts and sheep counts of home. And where was that pal of mine-o, Swiftie the stuffed palomino? I very much needed to find him – and pronto! A gentlewoman stays true to her time-honoured companions. No matter the infantilising overtures of a certain Auntie.

‘I have taken certain liberties this morrow, sir. I do hope you understand.’

What delight! The felted muzzle of my oldest, dearest friend nuzzled against my ribs, and I was suddenly safe. Come to think of it, I hadn’t felt this special, pulse-slackening sort of security since my girlhood. Stroking Swift’s mane, it seemed, somehow, that I was utterly protected. And accepted. And… *loved*. Wowzers. There’s a big word. Little Adora didn’t feel it often, you see. Without the help of her loyal horsey, she might never have enjoyed that emotion in a full, purely positive sense.

Wait. Did I have a bad childhood? I certainly received everything a kidling might require, if not the flesh-and-blood pony I desperately
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wanted. I never knew hunger, thirst or out-of-date clothes. I got taken to the theatre from time to time. The fundamentals seem shipshape, don't they? And let's not forget all those years I was packed off to school. The boarders' dormitories are mighty effective at building character! Or so I was told.

Now, I can't say I've ever been held or – what's the term for it – *hugged* by Aunt Shadowtha. But whatever would a hug achieve that a firm handshake doesn't? That's what the Hord High Akmiral de l'Horde, my other family, always said when I was growing up. I even received a 'shake from him, twice! The first was on my thirteenth birthday, when he measured the strength of my nascent adult spirit. He did say I lacked the fortitude and endurance required of a true de l'Horde, but what was that if not a spot of paternal guidance? It was a friendly ribbing, you know, once the stung wore off. Only took a couple of years before I could look in the mirror again. That's a small price to pay, isn't it, Adora? Stiff upper lip!

You know, his Hordship actually did me a favour. Look at it this way. If he hadn't said that, perhaps I never would have thrown myself into sporting endeavour. My teens were full of derring-do, let me tell you! I mucked in with ruggers, cricket and lacrosse – each fought at Schools or County level – before we even mention swimming and cross-country runs.

Truly, I've never been happier than I was on those long, solitary hacks across Dartmoor, with nothing but Aunty's words echoing through my skull for company. "You must take life more seriously, Adora. The weight of the de l'Horde name will soon descend on your shoulders. It would sadden me greatly if you were crushed." Valuable advice, again. And I knew what I had to do. By the time I'd hit Sixth Form, I was utterly transfixed on hitting the

gymnasium. You don’t get my kind of physique from nowhere, after all!

All good stuff. Yes. The best, in fact. How else could I have rowed the Boat Race in freshman year? That was no simple achievement, if you’ll let me be a little boastful. I charged head-long into the collegiate sportsman’s strife and came out on top! We won! Naturally, my full-blooded upbringing takes much of the credit. Who would I have been without it? Not the most famous chapelette in all Oxford, I can tell you that.

Oh, the second handshake! That traces back to my university days. Well, not exactly. I’d finished studying by then. Thankfully. It was the day I rose to my degree, in fact. Bowregard and I had been out on our ‘cycles for the morning, testing some theory he had about brake cabling, which resulted in quite the usual amount of blood. I was gushing somewhat by the time we turned for home.

Bow stopped off at the Chemists for a little iodine, but, given a group of gentle ladies were standing outside and my wounds were full-on fainting material, we took back off to college for the actual swaddling. Which is when I saw him: the de l’Horde patriarch. Wheeling our machines oh-so-subtly past the Grounds Keeper’s hut – the maintenance staff didn’t much appreciate our spiffy Dunlop racing tyres for some reason – I chanced a glance over the adjacent offices. The hallowed glazing contained the most seriously senior Masters and their ilk. And grabbing their attentions rarely boded well for me. Least seen, I felt, would be soonest mended.

And there he was. His Hord Akmiralship, I mean. The great man stood in his pomp. Medals, epaulettes, all the shiny-danglies! He faced a far smaller, much more anxious fellow I vaguely recognised as important. Bow identified him as the college Dean of Degrees. To put it another way, he's the chap who nominates students to the Vice-Chancellor for receipt of an undergraduate degree. It's an Oxford thing, you know! The whole thing is done in this strange, tripping Middle Etherian take on Latin, yet everyone seems perfectly happy to treat it as the real deal. Damn bunch of baby talk, if you ask me. It really did take me out of the moment.

Or rather, it would. Right now, I was agawp at the silhouette of the grand gent, which glowed and throbbed in shades of reddish-purple. Or purplish-red. Take your pick! In any case, he boasted a positive Aura Borealis. It glimmered with power and rage. Bowregard said "Eep". Well, eep indeed, old fellow. His Hordship is quite the imposing figure once he has an aim between his sharp and ancient gnashers. The Dean of Degrees stood--- no--- *cowered* in his way. Shouting occurred; Bow ducked for cover behind a gargoyle. Always a bright chap, that one. Not me. I stood entranced by an unprecedented sight: one of my relatives had come to visit my university.

I'd been quite the lonely pup in first year, sending home despondent postcards and reams of carefully cursive updates, so my family's refusal to reciprocate had plunged a dagger through my heart. The blade festered there until Michaelmas was nearly through. When, at last, Auntie did reply, she reminded me of my duties. Oxford, she said, was the proper venue for learning, instruction, and the right sorts of novel connections. I carried the de l'Horde name on my back and she knew I dare not fail. Never was I to forget my duties and responsibilities to the family, whose dignity depended on my university success. It would not do, continued Aunt Shadowtha, to muddy the crystal waters with mawkish sentiment.

There was simply no need for her or His Hordship to traverse the midlands counties, her type-written missive concluded. I was a fool for asking! The holidays would come soon enough, and with them a very clear expectation that I return to Marylebone and participate in Town duties. Their outline was as you'd expect: the usual whirl of civic events, dinners, galas, plus meetings with the various State functions for whom the de l'Horde heir might pledge her service upon graduation. If I had anything that I really *had* to tell her in person, it could wait until then. Each thought in its compartment and all that. Should the family require my personal attendance during any given term, her note concluded, then she would send for me. She never did, of course.

What exceptional guidance I'd received – and how kind of Aunt Shadowtha to send it! I was once again indebted to my first teacher and matriarch, for brightening the eyes and bushying the tails. No good moping around. Feelings never solved a problem yet, nor rumination. Action is the tonic! It's as true today as when I first thought it up, and it only sometimes puts me up against a sticky wicket. The beauty of the thing, of course, is that just keeping on with the keeping on invariably bats me out of trouble again. So long as I continue driving onwards, hoisting up the loads I've been allotted, distress can never make it across the mental threshold. Not too far, anyhow. Not often. Pah. Swiftie knows. Every eve of those troublesome Oxford months, I'd whisper those words to him as I turned out the lights.

It gets awfully dark in those dorm rooms, you know. The windows are medieval cubby holes – often literally, in the older buildings – while the walls are formed of coarse, thick stone. My chamber had a stepped-drunk floor in the same material, so it turned blasted cold when the leaves started shrugging off the trees. I shivered something rotten, teeth a-chatter, with only myself to blame, eh! I

really had started turning quite lean by then. Still, forwards was the watchword. I'd lay there in the dark, night after night, reminding myself of the noble path that lay before me.

No longer was I a schoolgirl, hand-held and herded each night into the boarders' bunks. I had a room of my own, and the newly adult life to match. I would make my family proud. The year picked up, you know, in the end. I rowed, I punted, I lodged some rather spiffy marks in a subject or two. Tutorials were a shocker, it must be said, but all that extended eye-contact? What was that about? If you ask me, staring at students does nothing but restrict their academic progress. It certainly slowed mine – until I invested in a pair of tinted glasses. Those really were the ticket! My marks rocketed overnight.

Social success came creeping up on me, too. My standing was my greatest asset, Auntie always said, so I took aim at the loftiest of my fellow matriculators. And who could do better than the twin delights who fast became my friends? At my left hand, Bowregard, the esteemed son of two noted Oxford classicists. One of his fathers was a Reader then, since ascended to full Professorship, whilst the other led an entire department. He's the Jesus Chair of First Ones. Even Auntie was impressed. I think.

Anyhow, Bow's path in life is already planned. He'll proceed to a Doctorate of Philosophy, then on into his own academic career, either Oxfordian or, if needs must, Cantabrigian. He doesn't want to do any of that, but I don't think he has the power to change it. Destiny, and so forth. His dads are very set on him becoming the first modern Etherian to chat fluent First Ones. Of course, I can do that already. But clearly that doesn't count, for some reason. Maybe they mean the first academic to speak it? Or the first in the family?

Spiffing bloke though he is, Bow's status falls rather short of our group's figurehead. Ironic, that, given she spans a blink over five feet at the most. Touchy topic, mind. I learned damned quick not to bring it up. *Though she be but little, she is fierce*, as Shakey B intoned in that play of his. You know the devil, one of the comedies. The one with the group of well-to-do youths who sneak into the forest for a bump of dope and a jolly good time, only for a rum mythical lot to spoil the fun. Or enhance it. I clean can't remember. A donkey featured, of that I'm pretty sure.

Why? Well, you'd need an Etherian Literature student to tell you that, though I'll wager the Tudor fellow just wanted to call someone an ass. Perhaps the Bard suffered under some ancient Kyle. I've always found the whole shindig about January by far the more scintillating farce, anyhow. Now there's a play! Viola is Cesario is Viola, with weeds and ways in constant limbo. I can't look away, no matter how many times I see it.

I felt the same on that fateful night, when Bow introduced me to his closest friend. And the Capital Chum Crew came to be. I knew her on sight. Aunt Shadowtha had schooled me on the de l'Horde equals, lessers and, vitally, our betters. I can't say every name stuck, but so few families top ours on the feudal totem that the creamiest cream clotted itself indelibly across the memory banks.

And the Chesham Place Brightmoons are decidedly dairy. We de l'Hordes are no Johnny-come-latelies, but my noble name can't claim to have stepped off the conquering ships fully formed. The Brightmoon Duchy can. With ever passing century, their blood got bluer, instating the name as minor royalty.

Dry history aside, the society pages bristled with sketches a-plenty of this smoke-eating vamp, who eyed me from under her glittering, kohl-caked lids. The Lady Brightmoon, heiress to the Duchy and something-teenth in line to the throne. I struck stammering politeness and correctness. Her Ladyship winked. I blinked, having momentarily forgotten all I'd ever known about one-eyed flutters, their meanings and the bio-mechanical process for achieving one of my own. Lady Brightmoon clasped my cheeks between satin gloves. I blinked again. And then she kissed me.

It was the top. I'm not afraid to say it. She tasted of nicotine; her hair reeked of lavender. Stale sweat oozed from her skin, which would make more sense if I'd told you we were at a dance. We were at a dance. She broke away, eventually, to kiss our mutual chum with the same fervour. Very continental. Knowing she'd been schooled across the great European institutions – thanks again to Aunty and her rote-teaching of the almanacs – it seemed only natural that she met everyone this way.

For the Honour of Greyskull! What a rollicking way to live, no doubt, if not one available to my rigid Etherian principles. I had duties and they demanded my formal introduction. Bow looked on in utter perplexity when I made a stab at articulating the matter. It's not his fault. We can't all have titles, I suppose! He recoiled in horror as I went down onto bended knee.

'The Right Honourable The Ladyship of Brightmoon, heiress to the Duchy of Brightmoon,' I began.

She chuckled from behind her champagne loupe, then ruffled through a small, gilded box for something to stick on her gums.

‘Call me Glimmer.’

‘Your Ladyship, Glimmer---’

‘Just Glimmer, ‘kay?!’

‘Might I present myself, Sir Adora de l’Horde, third Baronet, unto your service and your grace.’

‘What are you, a knight?’

She laughed. A jewel was set in one of her teeth. It danced under the light, glimmering rather. Ah, how about that! Glimmer glimmering! I’ve just realised that might have been the point. Symbolism and all that artistic business.

‘I’m whatever you might wish me to be.’

The old mouth really can outpace the squishy head director sometimes. I could only watch as the words flowed out with a breathy ease I hadn’t at all expected. It was much easier than talking to boys, which invariably ended in arm wrestling. A more reflective figure would have seen something in that – and in this instant, the one I’m right now describing, when Glimmer stooped down to kiss me again. Alas. I still thought myself heterosexual.

Somehow. My consolation prize? An entirely undefeated wrestling record against the marriageable men of Oxford.

'Devote yourself to me, then,' she whispered. 'I need a right-hand and a protector. Have you got the chivalry? Do you got the guts?!'

I arose with purpose and palpitations both. For the next two years, I offered myself over to Glimmer entirely, giving myself but the scantest and slightest of consideration. The de l'Horde name had hit the ascendency. Aunty was proud, when I finally had a chance to tell her. I think. "Good, Adora. You have uncovered a golden opportunity to advance," she told me. Over scones, which showed just how well things were going. Aunt Shadowtha has always felt sugar dreadfully gauche, unless allied to a chit-chat of tremendous importance. "Secure our introduction to the Duchess, and never pass an opportunity to serve Her Ladyship. I trust you will not disgrace your family name."

Rarely has a missive been so easy to follow, and never so downright pleasant. We had a Moby Dick of a time, the three of us. Breakfast at The Ritz, luncheon at The Ivy, then onto The Forty-Three for the evening. Or The Blue Lagoon, should our night continue unto the dawn. Definite articles were the definite article, as Glimmer remains so wont to say. And whatever she says goes. It must. There simply is no other way.

I do try to argue with her – one has to nurture some spark – but one would have better luck convincing our Earth to revolve about the moon. Truly, I've never made a friend with a greater gravitational pull. We step into any place, at any time and the room ricochets inwards. All eyes cling to her; her name tumbles from every lip. On the rarest occasion that it doesn't, she will

literally demand the missing attention, from strangers if she must. Which works, every single time. It's the damnedest thing.

What can Bow and I do, in the face of such sheer force of will? Our roles are on the second string and there we stay. It's quite natural, really. Glimmer is the most wonderful woman, but a born leader with it. "Knights clamour for the attentions of a princess," she once reminded me. "And *never* the other way round." She made a good point. We each hold a role in our little triangle, with the Brightmoon rightfully at its peak.

Whenever a satin black Rolls-Royce screeches into view, regal insignia stencilled across the door, us two know what to do. We drop everything and we clamber aboard. Sometimes our chum is already draped across the upholstery, antique snuff case in one hand and secret plan in the other. Others, we meet an empty cabin, never sure when Glimmer might finally cross our paths. Mystery rather abounds, either way. The chromed colossus bears us away on faith: no questions asked! Not by us two, anyhow. I've heard rumours that the Domestic Bursar is still investigating the front quad incident. But we don't talk about that.

Oh, yes! Academic staff. The very root of our rumination. Peek-a-booing into the Decanal chamber, I spied His Hord Akmiralship pause, slick back his hair, then put a gauntleted fist through the desk. My relation stepped forwards, into the splintering chaos, to brandish a scrap of paper. He held it like a weapon. The Dean swelled defiant, pointing at what was looking awfully like one of my essays. His Hordship glowed red at his eyes, then scarlet over the skin. The colours just kept on growing, filling the room. Bowregard, I think, tugged me away by the collar.

We sheltered – blood still galloping down my shin – until I heard the customary metallic click. It's a sound that often rung out in the corridors of my youth, invariably prompting Aunt Shadowtha to tell me that Little Dory should be seen, and not heard. Well, not this time! Even Bowregard's cautious grasp couldn't hold me back.

'Your Hordship, sir,' I cried. 'So devilishly wonderful to see you here at College! And just in the nick of time. I wrap this whole degree business up this afternoon, don't you know?'

He gazed levelly into me.

'Congratulations. A de l'Horde never falls short. Prepare for the ceremony.'

All afternoon I was giddy on the interaction, verging damned ecstatic when both he and Auntie took seats in the Sheldonian. I *do fidem*ed with the best and positively burst as I bowed in hooded splendour. Finally! Three years of higher toil stood atop twelve seasons of boarding, that I might return to Maison de l'Horde in splendour. Surely, now, I had made the family proud.

Except--- That evening we received our certificates. Stumbling late into one Final and spilling water over the back page of another had clipped my prospects, I knew, but I'd fought back with a fervour that really swelled the chest. A Second Class degree was my reward and I basked in the knowledge that I had done my very best. Only, when I looked down at the piece of paper, I'd graduated First Class. It shocked me something rotten. I cross-

referenced my scores and even met with the Academic Registrar. There was no way; I hadn't earned that mark.

But it was no mistake. That dawned some hours later, in the dark, as I clutched Swiftie tight. My cuddler was seeing less action by then – Glimmer having pronounced that no knight should embarrass herself with a cotton-stuffed steed – and had I been the worse for it! Lady Brightmoon had instructed me to throw the old thing away. To think! I hid him instead, in a hatbox. Most nights he stays there still, unless there's utter certainty we won't be overlooked. I can't betray my Swift. He's the only one that's always there for me. The real me. And never have I felt that keener than my final night in Oxford, as I realised my efforts had been over-ruled. House de l'Horde excels – at any cost.

'Oh. Adora. I'm so sorry.'

'Arrhh! How long have you been there? And confound it, Meowmeow, how are you peering into my thoughts?'

'I'm afraid you have been speaking them aloud, sir. Would--- would you like a hug?'

'From Swiftie?'

'If you wish, Sir Adora. But I was offering to hug you myself.'

‘Oh.’ I looked up at my gentlewoman through suddenly blurry eyes. ‘Yes. Yes please. I’d like that. Very much.’

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Chapter 13

Chapter Summary

'Sometimes you're up, sometimes you're down, sometimes you're snug as a bug in a rug! And that's the best one of all!'

'An unusually uplifiting intepretation of Gregor Samsa, sir.'

'What's that? No, no. I'm talking about our first cuddle! For most of this chapter, reader-doodles, I'm talking about our first cuddle. It's also Chapter 13 - unlucky for some! Would it be unlucky for us? Or would we be lucky in hug?'

'I believe we make our own luck, eh Adora?'

Chapter Notes

Content warnings apply for the below chapter only - Spoilers may be present in the warnings. This story does not include any of the four Archive Warnings topics, but does occasionally feature other topics that may require content notes.

Chapter 13 Content Warnings (INCLUDES SPOILERS):
Chest dysphora - onset, narrated, experienced

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PART 13

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Champion cuddler, that Meowmeow. One squeeze and you knew you were home, fed, supplied with a Napoleon brandy and seated

in a quiet corner of the library. Squeeze two then bursts a log fire to life and swaddles you in fluffy blankets, perhaps depositing a faithful beagle at your feet. But squeeze the third? That's the money squeeze. As Meowmeow wrapped her arms that little bit tighter, holding me in triplicate, the latest missive from an imagined lover landed betwixt my fingers, her name still fresh on my lips. *Meowmeow*. You really have outdone yourself.

If Entrapta tells the truth – and I truly am the magical, mythical She-Ra – then I'd use all of my enchantment just to make this moment last. I'll trade my powers away, if I must. Here, Jack, have the magic beans! Take them by the tin, for all I care, so long as you can sell me time. Another day in Meowmeow's arms. Another week. Let me build my home in this embrace.

Farewell to my troubles, and her rudeness. So long to every stress of the last cursed week. I forgot them. They'd run off, racing away from this lace-laden bed, taking the world I knew with them. We two remained, where our ribs swelled in time and she held me.

Now. I'm no old hand at the snuggling game. In fact, I've never started one of my own volition. Not once! Aunt Shadowtha schooled the impulse out of me early doors, you see. Ask her and she'll call the concept of passion terribly Maida Vale, and proclaim that touch is better left to its homes in the East End. I got all the way to my collegiate days, in fact, before I first felt arms thrown around me in unsporting – or should that be non-sporting? – endeavour.

Capital Chum Crew assemble, and all that! Those two can't pass up a chance to pinch me between their pits, not even if their lives depended on it. And, of course, they can always count on me to

be a good sport. I wouldn't want to seem standoffish, so that's how it goes, whenever we meet. One, other or both will a-spy me and, boom, I'll be caught up in the whole hugging business, gripping back to the best of my abilities. They bring the gusto; I offer the backdrop.

With Meowmeow, I was beginning to realise, the whole show ran rather differently to the two approaches I knew. Whenever Glimmer clutches me, she more drapes herself across my frame than anything else, shaping her hands with the conscious artistry of a masterpiece that's in the process of sculpting itself. Bow provides an absolute opposite. Just like Lady Brightmoon, there's no doubt he's taking the lead, but he does it by bounding up and clamping on. In other words, he squishes my skeleton with brightly bouncing bonhomie. The chap goes off like a friendly firework!

Neither such approach cut much mustard with C. Applesauce – or any other sauce, for that matter. She rum wasn't interested in making herself the centre of attention. Instead, for quite the first time, I felt myself becoming a worshipped, integral centrepiece to the cuddling act. It all began by not beginning at all, when Meowmeow fixed her glistering dinner plates on mine and asked: "Where do you like to be touched, sir? And where do you not?" I was flat flabbergasted – I can't say I'd been asked any such thing before.

Ever the intellect, I replied with a fishy gawp, followed up by a prickly blush. Looking my new gentlewoman dead in the eye, it seemed, was guaranteed to produce either or both effects. Yesterday, then, had been no first-acquaintance fluke. Twice, if not thrice, we went back around the cycle. The de l'Horde gaze wavered, averted, then snapped back, like iron filings flitting

towards an especially curvaceous magnet, and then on came the reddened skin and the parted lips.

Meowmeow smiled encouragingly when I hit lap four – and my organs turned into hot mush. Entirely. Forget about kidneys, or livers, or heart. I was just my mush. Something was clearly wrong with me. Very wrong indeed! My head span, my bones swirled. My mush palpitated. I took the deepest breath of my life to date, then ceased respirating entirely.

'Adora?! Sir, are you concussed? Please don't be concussed. Your Aunt Shadowtha will quite literally kill me!'

'Ohh… arrmm… euh…' quoth I in response. No matter my other failings, I could at least claim proficiency with the International Phonetic Alphabet. 'No, no, Meowmeow, I'm quite alright. Just a little tossed asunder by the bold novelty of your question, that's all!'

'Nobody has ever asked before touching you, sir?'

'It's a dashed unusual thing to query, chapelette! I'm used to doing business the wham-bam usual way, where it just kind of happens, no chat needed. I hope you don't mind me saying, but you're a dashed strange duck for doing otherwise, Meowmeow.'

'Thank you, sir.' She giggled with her whole visage, hiding her gaze behind myriad good-natured crinkles. Her laugh twirled like

Fred Astaire, gliding over the air between us. Oh, how I loved the way she--- she--- applied her eye pencil! Yes. That's it. So boldly, unapologetically striking. 'I would just die if you thought I was ordinary, Sir Adora,' she continued. 'Do you have an answer to my question?'

'I don't know. I don't think so.'

'If I may, sir, perhaps we can try a few areas first? I want you to be certain. How does it feel when I hug you here, across the shoulders?'

'Nice enough, I suppose.'

'Very good, sir. I'll work down to the waist now. How's that?'

Something fuzzy throbbed through me.

'Oh, yes, that feels just divi--- really rather nice, I mean.'

'I'm glad to hear it, sir.' Meowmeow smirked out the corner of her mouth, just for an instant. 'And now, the hips?'

'Cracking business there, too. You're really rather gentle when you want to be, aren't you Meowmeow?!'

‘All part of the service an exemplary valet provides, sir. For our final check, I’m going to work gradually up from the waist.’

‘Ooh, quite nice… Still good… Very pleasant… A little less so… Wait, no. Stop! Not there. Please. Don’t touch there!’

I pushed blindly away, but Meowmeow had already and instantly disengaged, then stepped far back. Her hands were up, where I could clearly see them. She made no movement. When she spoke, a beat later, her voice came soft and quiet.

‘You’re safe, sir. I’m here.’

‘What was--- I never--- I don’t know what just happened!! Sorry. *Sorry*. Meowmeow, I’m sorry.’

‘Adora, don’t apologise, please. *Adora?* Listen to me, you have done nothing wrong – and I promise I will not touch you there.’

‘Damned kind of you, sportette.’

‘Not kind, sir. Right.’

‘Yes, this method of yours seems to have a way of driving at the correct answers, though I really can’t say what they all are yet. Not in my own case, anyhow…’

‘You do not need to rush on my behalf, sir.’

I took a moment to gather all my fractured and jangling parts back together. She’d said I was safe and, you know what, I really felt I was. I could make myself clear and know she would listen.

‘I would very much like not to be hugged *there*, Meowmeow,’ I clarified, ‘but full speed ahead on the waist and cetera! Oh, and is there anywhere of yours I mustn’t squeeze back?’

‘Not anymore, sir. I gave my last penny to be sure of that.’

And she smiled wider than I’ve ever seen.

How long we lay atop the horsehair, history shan’t record, chiefly because I’d somehow lost my wristwatch. I doubt I would’ve looked at it anyhow, being quite frank. I had no desire to rush this moment to its conclusion. Propped up on three cushions, I lay ahead of my gentlewoman and her one. I promise you, I did my utmost to steer her towards two-by-two equality, but, alas, she would have none of it, preferring to put my comfort first. Meowmeow was no pillow princess, apparently, and harboured some suspicion that I might be.

Her arms wrapped about me in perfect security, bearing weights physical and metaphorical, melting my unseen, unknown shell with each fresh instant of her touch. I wax poetic, granted, but one simply doesn't see good service these days, as the Lady Brightmoon is so wont to despair. Kyle certainly never evoked a strong emotion in me during his sorry tenure. Not a positive one, anyhow. And here was Meowmeow. She was so newly I arrived I hadn't even had a spare moment to explain which rubber duckies are the main characters of my bath times and which ones only make occasional appearances, yet she'd already figured out how to practise alchemy on my heartrate.

My chapelette tailored herself around my back, becoming my very own living, breathing, purring suit of armour. For the first time in a long time, I began to believe again. To really believe what I told myself. Held in her hug, I felt sure my life really might turn out alright – or even *happy* – just so long as I kept hold of Meowmeow.

'There, there, sir,' she murmured across my hearing hole. 'I've got you.'

Yes, old sportette. Yes. You do. Magically – for what else could it be but magic – my neck drooped and one shoulder, then the other, fell away. Her breathing burred, sure and steady as a half-speed ocean liner. My eyelids fluttered shut. "Etheria need you." A flash… A burning field… No, a garden… A cross-looking woman in old-timey costume… Auntie… Glimmer… Blood… A blade… Meowmeow… And she's injured… Meowmeow… *Meowmeow!!* I crashed metallically awake.

‘Sir Adora, I’m here. Is everything okay?’

‘Meowmeow?! The fire. The inferno. Did you get out? Where are you hurt?’

‘I’m here. You just had a bad dream, sir; I’ve been here all along.’

‘Could we move? So I can see you? Just, you know, to verify the situation with my own two peepers?’

‘As you wish, sir.’

With some difficulty, I tried to right myself in the gloom, knocking knees in the struggle. Meowmeow swept in soon enough, her able assistance plumping my cushion collection, before slotting her gaze mere inches from mine. We were really very close. The proverbial cigarette paper could scarcely have slipped between us – except around my aforementioned area. There, where Meowmeow had sworn to stay away, I had acres of space. She’d turned contortionist to keep her word.

‘Are you satiated, Sir Adora? Have you seen enough of me, for now?’

Here came the blushing again, and a dense throbbing too… Good Greyskull! I simply had to get these symptoms checked when I next passed a doctor’s practice!

‘No. I mean--- Yes. Yes!! That’s enough. I’m dreadfully sorry, chapelette, you must think I’m being terribly silly.’

‘Not at all, sir. Your needs are my chief concern. If you have any more requirements, here and now, then just ask away.’

‘I would like to be held a little closer, down *here*.’

‘Certainly.’

‘And I’d do rather better if I knew where we are.’

‘Lady Plumers’ master bedroom, sir. Her Ladyship was kind enough to volunteer the suite last night, in recognition of your bravery. Ms. Blackstone and I escorted you to bed, evading further detection as we did so. Your presence here remains a mystery to Shugborough Hall – and to the Brightmoons.’

‘Not even Glimmer knows?’

‘Her Ladyship, The Countess of Elberon, is not presently in occupancy, sir.’

‘Then where in the blazes is she?’

‘I couldn’t say, sir.’

‘Ah, well. Very good, I suppose. There just… ahhmm… There’s just one more thing, old chapelette.’ My innards slurry turned, churned and surged up my oesophagus. Nevertheless, I bally well pushed on. A deep conviction told me that the following statement needed to be said. ‘Now, cuddling is all well and good. Very good, even, when performed by a pro like yourself! You’re tremendously accomplished in the matter, Meowmeow, if my experience is anything to go by. But I was wondering…’

I paused, she nodded, and I found some inner, unmacerated strength to push me onwards. A quick cough and, once again, my words were off.

‘Well, you see---’ I restarted. ‘Of course, you *see*! It’s silly of me to go around like that, asking you to use your peepers. What don’t you see? In fact, I’d go so far as to say there’s no-one better looking--- **better at looking**, rather. You’re dashing--- **dashed** prett--- **perceptive**. Dashed perceptive. That’s what I meant to say. You can’t prove otherwise! Not that you’d need to. Yes. Dashed perceptive, that’s you! And I’m… *me*. Not the me I was before we met, of course, but that’s by-the-by right now.

‘What I mean to say, though, as you no doubt see, is this…’ My deepest breath record, set bare minutes ago, tumbled to a new contender. I gulped half the room down hard, willing it towards the chunky soup that had once been my lungs. Meowmeow sent a

grin warmly my way, smiling from her eyes. I needed more air. There were spots showing across my peripherals. But I'd made it this far. By Greyskull's honour, I just had to finish. Steel yourself, Sir Adora. Just one more sentence. Gird those loins!

'Catra Applesauce Meowmeow, if I'm not making too terrible an imposition, and only if you're entirely A-okay tickety-boo with being touched there, I would very much like… to kiss you. On the lips.'

There was an awful lot of awful silence. Meowmeow stared into me, very deeply.

'Hey, Ador---'

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Chapter 14

Chapter Summary

'We left last chapter, readers, with Adora on the verge of kissing me. Not wishing to spoil it, what can I say? This is what happened next - for better or for worse. After that, the two of us venture into the countryside, together.'

'They know we're girlfriends now, don't they? So how could you be spoiling it, Catra?'

'Because romance can be about the steady build, the journey, the unexpected moments that sweep a woman off her feet...'

'But they know we're girlfriends, because that's what we are!!'

'Is that so, sir?'

'Yes. Wait. Wait just a minute here! Catra! When did you--- Why are you kneeling down???'

Chapter Notes

Content warnings apply for the below chapter only - Spoilers may be present in the warnings. This story does not include any of the four Archive Warnings topics, but does occasionally feature other topics that may require content notes.

Chapter 14 Content Warnings (INCLUDES SPOILERS): Vehicle accident, car - narrated, experienced (No personal injury occurs)

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PART 14
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‘Ah! Ah-ha! Ha-ha-chortle and all the rest of it!’ Back I shrunk, skittering across the bed sheets, unable or unwilling or un-*something* to hear another letter of her reply. Sorry, Meowmeow. I’m so terribly sorry… She’d been right – those few minutes ago – when we’d discussed the nature of controlling everything to do with one’s body. I saw that. Very clearly. And I should follow her concept, too, down to the last footnote of the final sub-section. Whatever her answer might be, I pledged myself to respect it. Entirely.

But I couldn’t bear to hear her response, not right this instant. If she said no, or expressed any level of hesitance, then that was going to be alright by me. I wouldn’t gripe or grumble, and nor would I go about asking her again. Just to be clear. All the same, loathe as I am to admit it, even the nebulous concept of rejection was frying my fusebox. My palms clammed, my heart raced. My mush froze into a stabbing, scaring lump. She’d come to me with kindness and I’d misread it as something more. Our professional relationship was ruined forever. And if we’d ever been heading towards friendship, surely that chance was gone for good. I was a wretch and a letch and a fool for asking.

I spiralled splendidly, then surfaced with an even chillier prospect. What if she was about to say yes? What then? I’d be unveiled as an ingenue and a debutante, utterly underskilled in the Grecian arts. Her sharp, skilled tongue would flicker against my lips, my cheeks, my who-knows-what and uncover rubbery confusion. Sure, I *had* kissed before, and kissed women at that, but my past tonsil tennis partners had always batted the serve for me. Would
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Meowmeow expect me to make my premier first move? And would she laugh, the way Glimmer did, her eyes flinty? My gentlewoman. So knowing, so practised. Would she like me less, when she saw how little I'd done before?

'You look so worried!' Meowmeow purred, her tail sweeping gently skywards. 'It's okay, Adora. I'm still here. Now… About that ki---'

'A very funny joke of mine, wasn't it? Ha-ha! Ha… It's alright, you know, if you'd like to giggle too. Truly! Have you ever heard such a silly notion? Whatever would an accomplished and stunningly aesthetic Sapphist, like yourself, see the fumbling, stumbling likes of freshly homosexual I? That's the punchline, you see. The humour derives from the trifling absurdity of the thing, like when one tries to pour a pint into a quart pot. Or whichever round that saying is supposed to go. A mouse to a cat and son on!'

'Adora---'

'Yes, comic genius! I'm only sorry the humour might have been at your expense. It wasn't meant to be, I promise. There's only one fool here and she's me. Foolish, foolish Adora. I really can't apologise enough if I've made you uncomfortable. I don't know why I said what I said. Really I don't!'

'Please. Can I---'

‘Anyway or anyhow,’ I thundered. Cursing myself, I simply couldn’t stop the words from coming. Not hearing her was its own agony, but the certainties she might be about to show me felt so… *untethering.* How I missed the hug. If only we could go back to it – but my voice kept droning on. ‘You said this was Lady P’s place, didn’t you? Awfully large number of shiny rocks in here, aren’t there? We might as well be down a cave, were it not for all the greenery. And if these are her rooms, come to think of it, where’s the girl herself hiding? I could go for a little more yoga advice before we step out onto the front lawn.’

‘That won’t be immediately necessary, sir.’

‘Whyever not?’

‘The hour of that class has passed. I thought it best, sir, to let you sleep. It is presently… seventeen minutes past three in the afternoon.’

Well, such hefty news plays havoc on the constitution. Fear propelled me up and about the place, stooping hither and thither to scoop up any clothes that might make up an appropriate outfit, all while keeping my head ducked low. I couldn’t risk catching Meowmeow’s gaze. I’d tapped the keg of diversionary tactics and run it down to empty: there were no more apologies or falsified face-savers primed on my tongue. If she brought up my kissing query again, there was a terrible risk I’d have to both tell and hear the truth.

‘Sir?’

‘A joke, Meowmeow. It was a joke! *Please.* Believe me.’

‘No, sir.’

It was over. I was rumbled. They might as well lock me up where I belonged. Without a doubt, my actions fell far, far below my personal standards, let alone my knightly aspirations: I had lied to the woman who’d shown me so much kindness, for no better reason than my personal vanity. Pulling up a pair of crumpled linen trousers, which I’d somehow paired with a patterned shirt, I raised my eyes to hers, feeling them well up with tears of bitter regret. She saw me and sighed, softly. Her face flickered with inscrutable something, and she glanced away.

‘Not to worry, Sir Adora, I have other enquiries.’ She sighed a butterfly breath. ‘Why are you rushing around the apartment, in what I fear might be a waterfall-knotted cravat? Is there any way I can help?’

‘Don’t you see, chapelette? The plants.’

‘I observe several, sir. This one appears to be a young yuzu tree: a citrus rarely seen outside of its native South-East Asia.’

‘That’s all capital, but explanations will have to wait! The shops shutter at five sharp – and I promised Lady P two more specimens

for tomorrow's fete!! So, if it's all the same, chop-chop!'

'These are those plants, sir.'

'Eh? How did you do that? And what got my secret softie into your hands, come to think of it? I left Swiftie safely ensconced at home. In London!'

'I'm so glad you asked, sir.'

Meowmeow wrenched back the curtains with what I can only describe as a flourish. Beyond the windowpanes stood a lesser-used curved of the Shugborough Hall driveway, upon which glistened a full-blooded racing automobile.

'Meowmeow?!' gasped I, momentarily forgetting the whole smoosh suggestion situation. 'I didn't know you drove a Blower Bentley!!'

'More precisely, a Birkin Blower, sir. Despite its unmistakable ancestry – and the trademark Flying B emblem on its nose – Walter Owen Bentley wants nothing to do with it. Since the idea to supercharge a 4.5-Litre was not his own, nor was its development carried out within his factory or under his supervision, he regards the Blower as a corrupt perversion of the Bentley name. His words, sir, not my own. Mine would be *quite* different.'

‘I bet it’s fast, though! Phwoar!!’

‘Indeed, sir. Last June, a Mrs. Mildred Mary Bruce used a Blower to set the present world record for driving 24 hours unaided. Competing on the Montlhéry racing circuit, just outside Paris, she raised the mean speed for the feat beyond 89mph, or so I have been informed.’

‘You bally well are informed, chapelette! How long have you had yours?’

‘Since last night, sir. I temporarily acquired the machine from its custodian, though it must soon depart for the Circuit de la Sarthe.’

‘Le Mans?!’

‘The very same, sir.’

‘But that’s this weekend! In France! Whyever have they let you take it?’

‘The chief mechanic wishes to make amends for your interaction with Emily, sir.’

‘Then… Can I have a go?’

My valet looked me over with a certain strained consideration, then started to smirk.

‘Why the rush? Do you *not* want to know what else your gentlewoman achieved last night? I ask only a moment of your time, sir, and I promise you won’t be disappointed.’

She cocked an eyebrow, then wiggled it about, her eyes half-closed and teasing.

‘I’m sure it’s wonderful stuff, dearest Meowmeow, but just look!’ I replied. ‘I hardly imagine your final odds and sods, though doubtless well meant, can measure up against fruit trees, Swiftie, and a racing Bentley!! That thing has 240 horsepower – which is more than twice what my own Frazer-Nash sports car puts out – in a machine with competition everything, no windscreen, and a bloody great number eight painted on the front. Just looking at it makes my heart race, so I’d jolly well like to razz about it pronto! Pretty please, Meowmeow? Quite honestly, right this moment, I want to drive that Blower more than I want anything else in the whole wide world.’ Weighing my words, I paused to correct myself. ‘Well. *Almost* anything.’

‘There are exceptions, are there, sir?’ Her grin deepening, Meowmeow unbuttoned her suit jacket. ‘Would an object belonging to young Master Georgeson be one of them?’ Agonisingly slowly, she folded back the fabric and reached behind a sumptuously exaggerated peak lapel. She clasped something

hidden and then, in a practised flick, brought a gold-fringed oblong into the light. A letter. She held it steady, giving me a chance to take it in, the envelope resting up against her cutting-edge cloth.

Today was a day for a double-breasted crimson suiting with a wide, draping cut, in case you were wondering. I was certainly caught up in wonderment myself. She looked astounding – we can take that much for granted – but I marvelled just as much at the paper in her hands. I read the envelope over and over, but once would have been enough. I'd recognise that round, upright handwriting anywhere: the letters spoke to me, and they said Bowregard! The words they spelled out left no further room for doubt. The address said Jesus College, Oxford – and bore fresh franking for a trip from here to there.

Evidentially, it was a journey the letter had never completed. My word! I tore myself between singing and dancing and offering a thankful note to some minor deity. Valet dearest had done it! She'd pulled off the impossible and saved my chum from the only fate worse than death: fact-checking, writing and footnoting a comparative medieval literature research paper. I shuddered at the thought. Bow might never know how closed he'd come to questioning the very nature and meaning of his own existence. From the looks of the envelope, its stamps and whatnot, Meowmeow had intervened in the very nick of time. I raised an eyebrow to her. It spelled out "How?" in eyebrow language.

'One becomes *very* charming when equipped with the right accent, the right appearance, and the right automobile.'

She winked and, dash it, I still wanted to kiss her. Very much!

‘Sir Adora---’ mewed she. We were paired in proximity again, though I’d swear I hadn’t crossed the distance between us. But footprints rarely lie. Twin casts stepped across the shag to accuse me. One belonged to a plimsole, the other a brogue, so there was a chance that some third party had made the marks, but one glance at my feet put paid to that idea. I wore the very same. And if the unmatched shoes fit… Maybe this time I could wear them?

‘Sir Adora, I would like---’

‘To hold onto the letter for the time being? Naturally! Very shrewd of you, Meowmeow. For how could I keep it in my clutches, when I’m just about to wrap my palms around the bonded cord of yonder mighty steering wheel?’

HORDE DAMN IT, KYLE!! Arrgh! That wasn’t what I wanted to say, and you know it!

‘As you wish, sir.’

‘Speaking of which, I don’t suppose your travels unearthed my driving gloves, eh? They’d be just the thing for this.’

‘I regret not, sir.’

‘Rotten luck.’

‘In their place, may I present this pair of doeskin gauntlets? Their subtle terracotta hue complements your eyes, I feel.’

‘You do, do you?’

‘I can check again, if sir prefers?’

Ah, yes. Welcome home rhubarb, my flecked friend. Was she opening the pathway to a kiss? Did she want me to ask her again? What would happen if I screwed up my courage? Could I---? I closed my eyes and puckered my lips, heart pounding fit to burst.

‘Meowmeow. There’s a question I asked you earlier. Given it never really got answered, not properly, I wanted to see if I could put it to you again?’

‘Of course, sir.’

‘So,’ squeaked I. ‘Would you ki---’

‘Yes?’

‘---ndly agree to head out on that drive now?’

Sorry Kyle. You’ve been unfairly maligned. What I mean to say is… HORDE DAMN IT, *ME*!!

Sigh.

Good Greyskull, Sir Adora, why do you make these things so hard? It’s just like Aunt Shadowtha said--- No. Adora. Don’t do that. Just. Keep going. Back to the story.

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Now! The first thing to know about a Birkin Blower is the whole door situation. It only has one of them, see, and the aspiring pilot isn’t equipped with it. I stood alongside the right-side coachwork for some time, utterly unaware of said fact. Meowmeow silently observed. That was embarrassing enough, but I had no designs on straining the situation between us any further. I couldn’t ask any more from her, I decided. *Forwards Always* would guide my way.

With a tyre-assisted heave-ho, my left toes stamped onto the whirligig amidst the rear wheel, giving me sufficient leverage for my right footsie to spread-eagle across to a long, silvery lever that looked dashed significant. The haughty pole screamed something fierce as I touched it, shaking the de l’Horde pelvis as it graunched away-wards. Goodness. I teetered, then tottered, only
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for the thing to halt with a mighty click. It had nowhere else to go now, surely, or so I tried to tell myself. I just needed to get myself a better foothold. Shoe leather screeched and scrabbled against chrome footholds, my hips opening to angles I'd never shown another lady before.

Oh, what ho! There was more security in this stance than one might imagine. We were making progress. Of a sort. Shouldering against the scuttle – the bit between the engine and the cab, for clarity – I surveyed my options. Yes, that was it. I slapped my spare palm against the body side, thrust up from my haunches and gave one final, assertive haul of my upper limbs. Off I flew, doing the Uptown Lowdown! My destination, if this haughty hop worked out? The crackly green leather of the driver's pew.

Let it never be said that a de l'Horde squiffs her goals! I'm proud to report I landed exactly where I aimed – and only a little bit entirely upside down! My head hit the hide just in the nick of time… to make close visual acquaintance with Meowmeow's---*Well.* Meowmeow's upper inseam, shall we say?

'I prefer a more conventional means of entry, sir.'

Looking between her legs, I spied the small but surprisingly commodious opening. From what I've since been told, my shins blushed deep enough to obscure my sock garters. Chalk that one up to experience, old chap… Rightfully righted, my Blower induction could commence. Meowmeow chatted quite the business about moving parts that strained under extraordinary force, tyre treads thrown under full throttle, and the perils of stone strikes to the front-mounted twin carburettors.

On she went, warming to the topic. My gentlewoman smiled something lovely. She really was in her element. Would I be interested in her finer personal theory, borne from the drive to the City and back? The extra engine revs employed in sporting use, she hypothesised, were speeding up the crankshaft so much that its additional centrifugal force was counteracting the gravity-fed lubrication system, effectively stopping oil from entering the engine.

Naturally, that's very bad, so how could one fix it? Meowmeow had an answer for that too, whose explanation she aided with tremendously exact hand signals. She'd recommended that Entrapta upgraded the Blower to mechanically pressurised oiling, apparently, but they were still sifting the data on how best to achieve that. A venting system for excess supercharger boost pressure might follow but, for now, we'd just have to pick our peak power moments carefully. All very fascinating – and I do love to hear people chew over their specialist topics – but I just wanted to get on and drive the thing!

'Compared to your Invicta and Frazer-Nash, sir, one Bentley control may present a particular challenge,' she eventually added. 'The accelerator is in the middle.'

'So where's the brake then?'

'On the right.'

‘I see. How about the clutch? Wait. I’ve got this. Right is done, centre is covered so--- ah-hah! It’s on the left!’

‘Naturally.’

Away we jerked, a veritable ball of sound and speed. If only I’d had the first clue where we might be going. Not to fear – Meowmeow was here! The claw-like keratin jabbing urgently into my left thigh served as a bally good reminder of that. “The clutch, sir!” she ground through gritted teeth, as I took a sporting whack at third. It was a swing and a miss, granted, but one can’t win them all. I tried again, then a couple more times, and once more on top. *Skrrrkk* went the car. *Erk* went Meowmeow. But the gearlever slotted home in the end, didn’t it?

Over bridge and round bend we flew and slew respectively, my talents gradually honing to the hard-blowing behemoth. It was smashing good fun up here, towering over and tearing through everything in our path. Now I’d picked a gear and stuck to it, I even had control of my left leg back. And not a moment too soon, as far as my blood flow was concerned! My pins and needles started abating. Gradually. Meowmeow, for her part, buried herself in a gigantic Ordnance Survey map, while my thoughts fluttered towards Auntie and how best to sell her on this ribald racer.

‘What say you, Meowmeow?’

‘I fear tyre technology is less advanced you presume, sir. If I might offer some advice… We only have so much grip!’

‘No, no, about owning the car, I’m meaning. I’d like Aunt Shadowtha to buy me one.’

‘That may not be wise, Sir Adora.’

‘Oh, what would you know, eh? Face in a map and all.’ The Blower growled a furious parp of attestation. ‘Well? What’s your response to that?’

‘I understand the nearby Cannock Chase provides impressive glens and vistas. We could take a stroll there together? Gentle exercise can help tremendously after strain and exertion – and yesterday was extremely hard on you.’

‘Meowmeow! Do pay attention! I’m trying to get Auntie to purchase this wondrous Birkin contraption. That’s the matter we’re discussing – not walks and wondering! Now. How about this for an opener? “Aunt Shadowtha,” I’d begin. Or perhaps “Your Lady, Marchioness of Greyskull,” would be better for such a critical venture---’

‘The next junction is a half-mile away, sir.’

‘Hmm. Can’t imagine I’d say that. I imagined something more along the lines of… “As I’m sure you appreciate, dearest matriarch, London and Oxford and some distance apart.”’

‘500 yards.’

‘They’re farther apart than that, Meowmeow! Quite a bit farther!’

‘400 yards.’

‘Try going the other way, chum. Are *you* suffering a bump on the noggin?’

‘300 yards. Sir Adora – brake.’

‘I’d go on… “Should you really wish me to pursue a DPhil, your favoured niece really must shrink the distance—”’

‘Brake, Adora! Brake!’

‘Now why would you…?! Oh. Cripes!’

The famed de l’Horde vehicular talents slammed at the brakes and pushed the pedal as far as it would go. The front two wheels locked solid. Smoke billowed into the cabin. Ah. Then the rear axle stopped rotating too, taking the engine with it. Hmm. I threw the steering hard over and prayed for the best. We skidded into

the junction. And quite stylishly too, I'd say. We'd almost made it! If only that pesky signpost hadn't jumped out at the last sec…

As we surveyed the damage – observing that one wooden arrow now suggested travellers might reach Stafford through the car's radiator grille, and another that you could find Lichfield via the offside headlamp – my gentlewoman offered to save my graces.

'Perhaps I should drive, sir.'

'You know, Meowmeow, that might be for the best…'

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Chapter 15

Chapter Summary

'Adora, we've been together for a while now, and I've been thinking so long about how I'd do this--- I had so many plans! But why not here? Why not now? We don't need champagne or caviar or diamonds. It just has to be... True. Real and true: like Chapter 15. Do you remember, my love? It's when I finally got to answer *that* question - and you finally understood why you'd asked. It - us - started right then, right there.'

'In a Cannock Chase car park, falling out of a Bentley...'

'Our first first dance.'

'But not really my best!!'

'Then how about we have another, but with the whole world watching this time? On our wedding day, Adora?'

'Catra!! What are you saying?'

'That I really, really love you, and I want to be your wife. Sir Adora, will you marry me?'

Chapter Notes

Content warnings apply for the below chapter only - Spoilers may be present in the warnings. This story does not include any of the four Archive Warnings topics, but does occasionally feature other topics that may require content notes.

Chapter 15 Content Warnings (INCLUDES SPOILERS): Deliberate fall - narrated, experienced (Character falls approx 1 metre to avoid a social situation, sustains mild/superficial injuries, no intentional self-harm)

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PART 15

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We were really motoring! The Blower tore through the forest and dashed across the plain, swaying to the slightest commands Meowmeow twitched through her hands and feet. Valet danced with vehicle. She melted into her trusty steed with each caress her touch played upon the steering wheel, and every loving squeeze she arced across the accelerator, loving the car to living, breathing life. And all I could do was watch. Our unlikely threesome writhed and bucked – heads and hips arcing utterly divorced axis – vibrating in a kind of ecstasy.

A guttural growl sighed from the exhaust and Meowmeow knit her brows, mouth clamped with caddishness as her grip tightened around the gearlever. The rod bucked, then kicked, then yielded beneath her fluid wrist flick. There were no grinds and zero graunches. She asserted utter, imperious control and the stick slid home. The Blower bucked in reply. Its supercharger dissolved in gasping screams. I ask you – is it quite right to envy an automobile? Because, regardless of the rights, wrongs and lefts of the matter, I wanted the daringly deliberate attention the car was getting! Really wanted it.

‘I say, Meowmeow. Wherever did you learn to drive like that?’

‘Any good valet possesses several skills, sir. And *I* am more than merely *good*.’

‘Yes – you bally well are!’

‘Indeed, sir, I aspire to be the best. And the best valet must know the most.’

‘Rather, chapelette! Meowmeow, is there anything you don’t know?!’

‘I really don’t know, sir.’

A very sly grin came with that. Ah. I was blushing again.

‘Oh, Sir Adora! You look very flushed. Might I touch your forehead and check for a fever?’

‘I’m sick with something, certainly,’ I replied, in what I hoped might fashion itself as a debonair chuckle. It came out as more of a hacking cough; I still wanted to kiss Meowmeow very much. ‘You know, maybe we should take that walk, after all.’

‘Very good, sir.’

The Bentley crunched to a halt atop a sandy spit, followed shortly thereafter by the fug of its brake linings. My valet laboured over the controls – tapping dials and pulling levers – before the engine finally died away. We sat in an itchy kind of silence. Portentous, if you will. Neither of us spoke. Eyes a-water from fuel vapours and emotion, not to mention the stones so recently established amidst my right tear-duct, I surveyed the Chase. In all its blurry glory.

I blinked, painfully, then rubbed. Also painfully. Neither proved the wisest course of action but the Etherian stiff upper lip prevailed. Biting its lower brother, I grinned and bore it. Saline streaked from prickled orbs to angry, sun-caught skin, then oozed a little further, to mingle with various and curious nasal secretions. Solid, liquid and noxiously gaseous all at once, my car-borne cold demanded my handkerchief. I tried to find it, thinking frantically.

Horsey! Horsey? Where now art thou Horsey?! Oh. That's right. You're balled up in my right-hand trouser pocket. Sorry about that. I was in quite the rush when we left. Hmm. Looking at it now, I really wish I'd put a bit more thought into where you went. Smushed up silk is one thing, but your location is causing me quite a bit more agitation. In a car cabin this small, you see, my thigh is wedged hard up against Meowmeow. So I *can't get to* you *without touching* her*. And I'd like not to do that, because it only highlights how much I* want *to do that.*

I could ask her to move, of course. A little wiggle is a perfectly ordinary thing to ask, even of a stranger. I wouldn't think twice if we'd met in the theatre and I needed the elbow-flapping space to remove my jacket. But this isn't that, is it, Horsey? She's really very dear, dashing, kind and smart, and it's starting to flavour my

every thought, despite my snowballing recognition of the screwy power imbalance that sits between our official roles. A knightly fellow shouldn't think like this!

And who can forget the real silence between us? The questioned kiss. The unknown answer. I can't stop thinking about it. About her. But I can't not think. I can only think less, can't I? Horsey! That's it, you educated equine! If it's our proximity that scrambles my mental eggs – and my inability to get at you which is frying my central nervous bacon – then I've got no choice. I need to get out of the car – right now!

Oozing a glance towards Meowmeow, I tried to make sure she wasn't looking my way. Her blur was static. That was good, I thought, but I couldn't be sure. A lot of road was still stuck in my eyes. This must have been why Entrapta wore goggles. I shot out a shoulder, then looked over again. She was a very beautiful blur. But she was still, well, *still*. Marvellous. Now all I had to do was open the door and step out, which just meant finding the…

Hang on. There was no handle here. No clasp there. How the Dickens did you open it? Panic rattled at my sternum. I started stroking the door with the jerking speed of a not-very-good safecracker, groping around at anything that stood out from the surface. Wait! Meowmeow! I stole a look, and her shape was still mostly where it was. Phew. I threw my back into it, knocking and tapping almost at random, hoping that pressure might spring the door free. Or at least give off some telltale thud that betrayed the lock's location…

'*Sir*. May I be of assistance?'

Ah, yes. Sight wasn't the only sense. I saw – or rather *heard* – that now.

'Thank you, Meowmeow, but not right this moment.'

'Sir Adora, you are *clearly* in pain. Might I, at least, remove the cause?'

'I… I really don't think that you can,' I blustered, just as I discovered the door release. Why it was a lever – and why Bentley or Birkin or Blower or whomever had placed it inside the cabin – I really couldn't see. But I had it in hand! Success and a speedy exit would have been mine, were it not for my anaesthetised digits. Numbed by their recent encounter with a high-speed hurricane, their rubbery bluntness flat out refused to grasp the clasp.

This was must have been why Meowmeow gave me the gauntlets, which I now bitterly regretted removing when I swapped to the passenger seat. So many fashion *faux pas* today, and all of them mine! Silence fell between us. Again. Difficult feelings spiked my chest. They made me think of the bedroom, the hug, the… the thing that didn't happen, but had come up… and I jumped desperately back to work. The de l'Horde mind abhors a vacuum. *Idle minds make pointless thoughts*, eh Auntie? I'd heard it so often, it was almost her catchphrase.

My fingers rattled wetly against the quiet, achieving nothing. I started hammering at the blasted latch. That didn't work either.

I'd have to go big. Bunching up a fist, I pulled back for my fateful and very final blow. When craft fails, there's always force. Here goes--- Except--- *Here would have gone* fits rather better. As my elbow jagged up, urgent with my need to self-extricate from an increasingly cramped cabin, it met a silk-soft touch. Light as feathers but unstoppably insistent, Meowmeow shuddered me to a halt.

'What seems to be the problem, sir?'

Oh dear. This simply would not do. Crashing into interpersonal contact threw my issue into even greater clarity. I had to get out. Now. My voice sparked out in a snap that I'd instantly regret.

'I thought permission was *everything* to you?'

Meowmeow shot back, pupils turned to pinpricks.

'Sir Adora, I am *so* sorry. I was too impulsive, but I will not let you suffer in silence. Could I please examine your eye?'

Our stares clasped together, like a ball bearing sucked into its socket. Only more emotional. So like the time I trapped a fingertip while reassembling a 'cycle hub. Meowmeow looked into me with incredible earnest, brows bouncing on high, opening her scandalously-sharpened lids to contours I'd seen just once before, when I uttered the word *kiss*.

‘Sir. What can I do to help? What do you need?’

The familiar prickling daubed my ears, as I stammered out what my organs were shaking for.

‘Our bodies-physical must commune.’

‘Oh?’

‘In nature. The drive was very stimulating, see. Full of revelations. I just think we’d remove a lot of heat from the situation if you and I took each other in the forest. Never hurts to raise the heart-rate, that’s what I always say!’

‘A very bold proposition, sir.’

Meowmeow smiled. One eyebrow was standing far above the other, her left mitt wedged into the divinely complex curves a blink above her hip.

‘Clear something up for me, Adora. Would you like that kiss during, before or after?’

‘Umm. No. Not that. *With* nature. A walk with nature nearby, Meowmeow! How else could I mean it?! Haha! Ha?’

Oh. Oh no. The door was still stuck. I eyed the rather daunting drop to ground level and started weighing the pros and cons of jumping over the bodyside. Anything to avoid my rapidly unspooling chat with Meowmeow. My dearest Meowmeow. The woman had already outstripped the wildest dreams a gentlewoman might have of her valet. *Well*. Perhaps not the *very* wildest. But damnably near! And my traitorous lips had implied – heavens, outright stated – that I still wasn’t satiated. Chivalry was dead and Sir Adora de l’Horde held the dagger! Goodness and, indeed, gracious. It couldn’t be too far a drop, could it?

Sure, the ground was carpeted in a gritty, compacted dirt which looked especially unyielding and, yes, the gap between said floor and the Blower’s hidebound perch seemed taller from this perspective than it had when I clambered aboard. But the good knight must go on undaunted! After all, getting in had netted me nothing more than a scuffed knuckle, a ruddy complexion and this sort-of stabbing pain up my shin. And a count of three injuries didn’t seem too bad right now. In all honesty, the figure was more like two-and-a-bit, anyhow. I rather doubt I’d have gone so red in, say, Bowregard’s presence.

How much simpler adventuring used to be, I mused, back when ‘Reg and his dauntless chumliness was the voice at my shoulder. The fellow was a champion fretter, of course, but his objections faded into a very uncomplicated enjoyment, if you only gave him a minute. Our ‘cycle expeditions and Brooklands bashes and *cetera* really were the peak of friendship, as far as I was concerned. Just him and me. No complicated feelings, no lines in utterly novel sand that I could completely fail to see coming.

When he'd worried over the Henley business, dearest Bow was acting entirely as I'd expected.

Had it just been the two of us, of course, the hull would still be in its dock today. Glimmer had been a complicating factor. She always was. Or she had been, prior to my Meowmeow adventures. Not even the sparkle-strewn Countess held a candle to the woman sitting immediately to my right, whose actions I simply could not predict, yet wanted to know and to see and to experience in granular detail. What if Meowmeow had been at the fateful regatta? Would she have upgraded my aspirations from dinghy to teak-decked steam yacht? Or might she have gotten me off?

And why, pray, did I want her to do both? This had gone too far. A good knight denies themself, which meant I needed out of this situation pronto. Close your eyes, Sir Adora, and think of Etheria. I clambered up my seat, stood up to my full height, then stepped one Goodyear-welted sole free from the chassis. The shoe swayed in the open air. I primed myself. The moment had arrived. I would fall and fall hard, I knew that, but I'd gladly pay the price to mend my knightly reputation. How else could I become Sir-Arthur-But-Sort-Of-Not? Smile-grimacing, I stepped off.

Down rushed my noble noggin. Towards the ground I tumbled, peace starting to spread across my turbulent chest. Disembarking a car is such a simple business – usually – but my principles needed rebuilding brick by trivial brick. Today I'd scuff and bruise, wounding little more than flesh and appearances, so that tomorrow I might, say, rush heroically into a burning castle. Maidens would be rescued! Dragons slain! I might buy some armour, then engrave it with the family arms. Yes, the medieval

order was my guidebook again, with Chapter One in progress. *Hey nonny now then, see how our hero stumbles from the sports car!*

Say, this fall was taking quite a while. I noticed a pattern, it must be said, when weighing the present predicament against the end of last night. Maybe it was a Sir She-Ra thing? I really wish I'd taken more notes in the moment… I flat couldn't recall what we'd covered… Had magical falling come up at all? I'd have to check in with that Entrapta fellow – and figure out whether a round table came free with my Arthurian role. Was it in storage somewhere? Or would I be buying my own? That'd take a trip back to London, surely. I couldn't have my knights flocking around something second rate. It'd need to be American walnut or better… or did it have to be an Etherian wood? Maybe Liberty's or Heal's would have something in stock. I'd have to wire them…

My molasses-sticky descent gave me time to reckon all of this, and more besides. Vertical progress had stopped entirely, in fact, just after I'd made my way to the horizontal. Getting out of the car was proving less glorious than I imagined. Rainbows were nowhere to been seen and a din of grunting groans was flying about behind me. Geese, probably. Hmph. I've said it before, and I'll say it again: waterfowl just do not appreciate the profound!

Not that philistine Canadian honkers were my greatest problem. That title belonged to my lower right leg, which hadn't even left the car. In fact, it felt like I'd knotted the knee to the dashboard and my ankle inside that giant steering wheel. What rum luck! I tried to wriggle myself loose, to no avail. Re-up-standing my morals was proving tougher than it looked!

‘There are easier ways to ask my feelings, sir. I still won’t let you hurt yourself.’

‘Meowmeow?! Unhand me! You’re keeping me from a dashed big dose of profundity.’

‘By jumping off the side of a car, sir? Did a philosopher suggest it? *Please* tell me you haven’t been reading Kant. Is something wrong with the door?’

‘Yes. Rum thing won’t open! But that’s not the point! I’m re-establishing my chivalry before you’re… you’re… injured by my impure intents.’

‘Sir?’

‘The kiss, Meowmeow. What else? I should have known you wouldn’t want one, yet I boundered ahead with caddish abandon and some foolish notion that I’d have a shot with someone as… Well. As utterly *divine* as you! And it only gets worse with every second I spend in your close proximity, so out of the Bentley I need to hop. Don’t worry, chapelette. It’s nothing *drastic*. I’m just taking the quickest route to a spot of fresh air.’

‘Adora---’

‘I know, I know! A great lady like you has smarts and sass and looks and tenderness enough to snare Sapphics by the score. Lesbians of the highest calibre must queue round the block, just to take your hand in theirs! How could they not? It really is a very pretty hand. And those nails…’

‘They’re more claws than nails.’

Meowmeow ran one down the back of my left shin and… *Goodness!* Just. Goodness. My legs stopped shaking but, truly, I’d never been more aquiver. I could actually feel the force of her smile. I swear! It was a kind of cruelty, telling myself that a lady of such intrinsic quality stood so far out of my league.

‘*Quite*,’ I yelped. ‘Quite. Those single-minded spikes are so entirely *you*, if you catch my meaning. Achingly wonderful, deliciously feminine, and completely, utterly, entirely out of my reach. I’m the most unimaginable rotter for even imagining that their owner could ever, well--- stoop down to my level. No! That really is too much! Forgive me. I forgot myself, Meowmeow.’

‘I’m sorry. What?!’

‘No, no, the fault is entirely mine, chapelette. I’m a fool. A plum dope, if you will. How silly I’ve been! What made me fantasise that my gentlewoman’s gentlewoman would ever accept an advance from her employer? Can you imagine?! My grey matter was off in the clouds – and I got far too encouraged by your consoling embrace. You were just being the superlative wom---

valet you are. I mooned over a woman at her work! I'm a scoundrel!'

'Power dynam---'

'I know, I know. Naturally, Meowmeow, you're free to pursue fresh employment. I'll give you the warmest recommendation a valet has ever received, plus the largest departure stipend Auntie will permit. And I really *am* sorry for wondering whether you'd be up for a smooch.'

'You asked. You never let me reply.'

'Spare me, please, if you've the first shred of compassion for a wretch. I'm sackcloth and ashes here, Meowmeow! I know I don't deserve it, but can we just agree that I was tremendously silly and you, quite obviously, never have and never will see me in that way. Let me down easy, eh?'

'Literally or figuratively, sir?'

'What's that?! Oh. The jumping-falling operation! I'm afraid you'll just have to let me get on with that. If the door won't open, how else can I give you some well-earned space?'

'*Yes*.'

‘Very good, old sportette. If you could just get let go of my legs, I’d have a much easier time completing my quest.’

‘*Adora*,’ she intoned, in a voice that was somehow purr and crystal clarity all at once. ‘Let me be clear. I am saying *yes*.’

‘Then drop my trousers! Umm--- Not like that, I hasten to add. Just… let me fall. Much obliged!’

‘I’m not agreeing to let you go. I simply believe your question deserves an answer, before you do something you might regret.’

‘Question? No, no. I’m making more of a chivalric statement of intent. My falling out of the Bentley will do this predicament a world of good, I swear it.’

Meowmeow sighed. Her nail bored into the back of my leg, pressing down with each subsequent syllable.

‘You asked for a kiss – if I wanted a kiss. Yes. I do.’

‘Oh. With whom? Lady P took quite the shining to you, if I recall.’

‘*Really*, Adora?! I want to share a kiss with you.’

‘You like me? *Like*-like me?’

‘Yes. So far.’

‘And I wouldn’t be a terrible heel if I looked at you? Really looked, I mean?’

‘I appreciate you asking, sir. I would say no, you’d be doing nothing wrong, so long as you are respectful, and I am consenting. And to clarify, yes, I do consent.’

‘Umm--- Huzzah! What do we do now?’

‘That depends. Do *you* still want to kiss?’

Pride go-eth before a fall. And how I wish it hadn’t. Heart swollen three sizes, beating fit to burst, my entire assembly of squishy internals danced a heretofore unknown mambo of utter, absolute, ridiculous joy. She liked me! She wanted to kiss me! The feeling vibrated through my every cell, heating me up like the twelfth drink on a snowy eve crossed with the nervous energy of an ocean liner’s dancefloor on a rough sea. Our lips were going to touch! It was just too tremendously exciting, in a way pecking Glimmer… and Marcy… and Patricia… and Edaline, the coxswain of

the Oxford ladies' team… and Josephine from my term abroad… and my boarding school bunker Rayla never quite had been.

My enthusiasm burst into three dimensions. I just couldn't keep still! I positively fuzzed with glee, Meowmeow scrabbling to hold me aboard, until a paroxysm of shock joined the party. The depths of my previously unacknowledged yearnings, I think that was. It came out as a sharp, short kick. Which wasn't ideal. My shoe hit could-be-kisser's cashmere-clad arm. She yelped – grieving the delicate material – as her claws retracted in surprise. And that was that. Upside down in every way imaginable, I headbutted the ground. "Ouchy!" doesn't begin to cover it…

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Chapter 16

Chapter Summary

'Catra, look over there! The reader-folk need Chapter 16 introducing!! Quick!'

'Really? Now? Fine. Readers, below you'll find Sir Adora waxing lyrical about me - entirely consensually - before we flirt like mad and go on our first date. She doesn't seem to know it was a date though, just like she hasn't noticed I just proposed to her. It's--- It's SO Adora.'

'But is it, reader-folk? I'm whispering in your direction so Catra doesn't hear me and see *this*...'

'Adora, you silly goose! You don't need to kneel down too - that's not what we're--- Why are you holding a box?'

'Catra Applesauce "Apfelmus" Meowmeow, will you---'

'ADORA?!'

'---Marry me?'

Chapter Notes

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Chapter 16 Content Warnings (CONTAINS SPOILERS):
Deliberate fall - aftermath, narrated, experienced
Physical injury - mild, narrated, experienced
Description of a woman's body, narrated - WITH consent
Allusion to gender role discomfort - narrated, experienced, brief and mostly implicit

Gunfire - narrated, experienced, gun fired at major characters (no injury occurs)

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PART 16

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If I'd known falling out of a car was this easy, I'd have done it years ago! My palms were scraped and my eye felt fluid, but those were barely scratches, honestly. Pah! Who'd complain about that? They only hurt when I touched or held or looked at or blinked towards things. So long as I stayed away from all that for a day or two, maybe a week, then I'd be right as rain. They do say rest is the best medicine!

I managed a good ten seconds of recuperation, too, before my gaze began to wonder. Meowmeow was stepping out of the car with her customary grace, so healing would have to wait. Watching with unconcealed glee – delighted that I'd sought and received her permission – I worshipped the perfect illustration of her posterior. One suspects she'd removed her jacket just to show it off better. It really was a stunning rear. Its every angle defied me to look away. And I absolutely could not. Whomever provided the lady's tailoring was worth every penny. Each stitch articulated the beauty who wore it without ever overshadowing her.

But what could? With that mind and those looks, she'd shine in a solar eclipse. Not to mention her heart. I'd never know absolute

darkness again, so long as I saw that heart. *Meowmeow*. The cavalier cock of her shoulders, the way her hips bumped wordless questions. I drank it in, all of it, and let myself find her physically attractive. That was new, for me. Like a fresh-starched shirt, straight off the shop floor, the feeling was angles and oddness, yet it rustled with promise. It would get smoother and freer, in time. More my own.

Perhaps Meowmeow felt like this, with that wonderful self-possession of hers. That self-determination. She was author of her own fate – and she was about to pen a story where she was going to kiss me! My head spun, gloriously caramel drunk with glee. She was going to kiss me. I was going to kiss her back. She liked me. *Liked*-liked, even. These were all real, established facts and I wanted to keep knowing them.

Yes, yes, I'm well aware. I stated all the above in the last chapter; you're *au fait* with the situation. It's true, too, that repetition is an awful misstep in the narrative arts. Ditto self-indulgent spiels. But--- you see--- Just give me this one, reader, okay? Quite simply the most godlike girl whom I – or, I'm willing to wager, *you* – have ever met had declared her interest in Sir Adora de l'Horde. The world around me swirled, but what did I care? I'd grin until my head burst!

Meowmeow rushed over, giving my seated self the most wonderful view of her thighs. Those were rather scrummy too. She clearly worked out. I do too, you know. Perhaps we could chat about that, if we got as far as a date. I do like showing off how many eggs I eat a day. It's upwards of six! Right now, however, was no time for ovoid factoids. My sweet gentlewoman's voice was wavering, her eyes spark-riddled with watery and detectable concern.

‘Sir, may I examine you for breaks and contusions?’

‘You can do whatever you like to me.’

Meowmeow staggered back slightly.

‘I’m really starting to worry about you.’

I blinked unevenly. If one feels more generous, we could call it a pair of consecutive and complimentary winks. Viewed that way, I’d say I was dashingly debonair. The very dapper darling bending over me seemed less impressed. Which was a shame. Because her--- well--- her *decolletage* was making *quite* the impression on me.

‘You’re really VERY beautiful!!’ I blurted out. ‘Goodness, did I just say that?! Well. It’s exactly what I was thinking – and I won’t be apologising for it. You, madam, are achingly gorgeous. So there! My… What’s gotten into *me*, Meowmeow? I’m actually *feeling* my emotions! The nice ones!! Do you know what I mean? They’re all right there – so vivid and alive – in this curious new way where I don’t have to strangle them or bottle them all up…’

‘Now, sir, I *know* something isn’t right.’ She sounded stark, but her tail flickered low and slow as she fought back… could it be… a *blush*. My jaw hung wide. *I* had flushed *her* cheeks. She tried to

brush it away with a fake cough – but we both knew what I'd seen. Shaking out her hair, pulling at her waistcoat, she fought her lips back to a neutral line and hit me with: 'How many fingers am I holding up?'

'Three. Unless the thumb counts. I'd say it does, but Bowregard makes such an awful fuss when I do.'

'Your friend is right.'

'Boo and, if I may, hiss. Humbug, even. If I put my nose here,' I scoffed, pointing to my ear, 'would it still be a nose?!'

'I couldn't say, sir. Perhaps you should ask a philosopher instead? What I do know, sir, is that your nose would still look *very* dashing, no matter where you put it.' She paused, eyeing me over. And she was really, tremendously welcome to do so! Oh. Wait. The prickling-pickling impulse… I went far redder than Meowmeow – perhaps the reddest I'd ever been. 'Very good, sir. Your circulation is fine, and you don't appear to be bleeding anywhere critical.'

'Meowmeow!! That's a dirty trick. I'd say I deserve a nip on the old hip flask for that.'

She cocked an eyebrow, placing a firm grip on her waist. It made me feel things. Wonderful things.

‘Don’t play coy with me, chaplette! I know you’ve got one about your person… Somewhere…’

‘You can have the flask – if you can tell me where I hide it.’

Tricksy minx, wasn’t she? I pondered the options. Her boots would be the obvious answer, since they rose to her knees, providing plenty of space to stash the hooch. But the drink wouldn’t be there. Not if I knew Meowmeow! Which I suppose I did, now, a little. She wasn’t the sort to take the main road – or the minor. No sir! Her wit made its own way, so I could disregard all the first places anybody else would stash their stash. My mental pen struck out the shoes, the jacket’s breast pockets, inside *and* out, and front fellows of her trousers.

It's all very well saying where the flask wasn’t, but a positive identification takes more cunning. I stroked my jaw and pursed my lips, cocking my head like a spaniel and dissolving Meowmeow into fits of giggling. You laugh now, madam, but Detective Adora was on the case. Now then! Hadn’t stunningly Sapphic she just driven us here? She had! And that made her rear trouser pockets all the less likely. Furthermore, I mused, even the best thread-slinger this side of Savile Row couldn’t hide a bottle amongst her rear’s closely-covered curves. So only one possible spot remained – and it implied that the flask was forever in flux.

‘It’s in your waistcoat watch pocket, Meowmeow,’ I pronounced. And dashed triumphantly, too. Why not? I’d earned the cockiness.

‘Very good, sir.’

She handed over her screw-topped friend and I took the deepest swig. Then another. Today, for reasons known only to my soon-to-hopefully-be-more-than-an-acquaintance, the container sloshed with white port. A less conventional tipple than brandy, but a measure more Meowmeow! After glug the third, I offered up the finest vintage of Sir Adora and her majestic mentality.

‘Should I put the bottle back where I found it?’ I began, pointing for good measure. Whether you’re into Holmes, Marple or Whirlpool Mermot, all the best detectives come armed with a finger jab. ‘Or would it be happier in one of its other homes? Because, *Meowmeow*, I put it to you that your flask has no fixed abode. Let me explain… You change your suits daily, madam. Of course you do: you’re not an animal! But the ‘flask never ports directly across. Rather, it dashes from place to place as your mood dictates. And how do I know that? Elementary, old sportette. You weren’t wearing a waistcoat yesterday.’

‘I didn’t know you paid such close attention to my tailoring.’

‘That’s only the start of it, my dearest Meowmeow.’ I winked devilishly, and she went redder. ‘While *I* have *your* attention, for a change, might I bring you the most wonderful news?’

‘Of course.’

‘Alcohol has healed me! I’m back to myself – just with a bit more throbbing – and my trip out of the Blower is just a distant memory. You needn’t be my nurse for another second, unless you prefer that role? As well you might… Seeing you inhabit that blend of authority, care and attention was quite *something*…’

‘*Sir?*’

‘I--- Let’s--- getting walking!! I don’t know about you, but I could do with a gentle preamble. The *like*-like revelation left me all a-tingle!’

‘I’m glad to hear it, sir.’

‘Not as glad as I was! You like-like me!! It’s very exciting… but is *here* the right place to lock lips? An ad-hoc automobile repository isn’t the most romantic location, is it? And that, Meowmeow, is why we need to trot off and find somewhere nicer.’

‘You have to be comfortable, sir. I wouldn’t have it any other way.’

‘That’s very kind of you, Meowmeow. And, um, I think we can dispense with all that “sir” business now, don’t you?’

‘I thought you liked it?’

She cocked her head towards me as we began our stroll. A starkly tranquil place, this Cannock Chase, by-the-by. Aching eyelids aside, even I could see the value in my chapelette's suggestion. It reminded me of running over Dartmoor, way back in my teens, just with less of the bleakness and risk of a grimly impending, isolated, desperate death at the hands of some hidden bog. The Staffordshire sandstone was firmness itself. Blooming a sandy confectioner's dusting behind us, Meowmeow and I lost ourselves in this strange, dry place, wending our ways between jagging cliffs and iron-stained streams.

I can't think of a better place for a first date. Wait, *was* this a date? We hadn't called it that – though we *had* agreed to put ourselves somewhere on the smooch-to-snog scale. Where was the outline for this afternoon? What was I meant to be doing? I really, really wanted to hold Meowmeow's hand too, but could I ask about that without answering her last question first? Probably not. Damn it, Ky--- Adora! We'd emerged upon a vista of crinkling orange and purplish, smoky whisps – prime kissing country – and I was using the plants as a distraction technique. My hands kept pointing; my mouth made cheerful inanities.

I was getting nowhere! And I'd stay stuck in this nothing place until I gave her the realest of my real feelings: the ones I have about myself. Which meant figuring those feelings out. Oof. That didn't come easy. Asserting one's sense of self is a strange, amorphous business, it turns out, not to mention dangerous. Try it too often and you end up kissing your sexy valet… I hope.

My brows knitted and my old grey goo hunted for answers. "Sir" was certainly my convention, but did using it bring me joy? If I wanted it, I had the noble right to use "Lady" instead. That would be a lot more… normal. And I'm pretty sure Auntie would be

happier with me. But… But. It wasn't *right*. Aren't I a knight? Isn't "sir" the right title for a sword-swinging hero? Yes and yes, as far as I'm concerned. So "Sir Adora" I'd stay. Logic demanded it, plus I just really love the way it sounds, if we're being totally honest.

'You're absolutely right, Meowmeow. Can we stick with using sir here and there, if that's alright? Could we get rid of all the other feudal formalities, though? They show the proper spirit in an employer-employee relationship, but I don't think we've got quite that connection anymore, somehow…'

For a second, we walked in silence, a state I still did not enjoy.

'What *do* we have, Meowmeow?'

'Only time will tell, sir.'

'Ah, alright. Two more questions, if you'll indulge me? One – would you like to hold my hand?'

She put her part-gloved fingers in mine. The connection crackled through me, just like it had on yesterday's path-top practice date. Wait. Did that mean?! I reckoned it did…

'Meowmeow!! You were flirting with me!'

‘Yes, sir, I was. Which occasion have you figured out? The train? The green-house?’

‘You were flirting then too?!? Knock the First Ones down with a hanky, Meowmeow, when have you not been pitching woo?’

‘Aren’t you an investigator?’ She winked; I melted. ‘*Investigate, sir*.’

‘I jolly well will, but it can wait until after question two. Meowmeow, what should I call you now?’

‘Catra. Call me Catra.’

I leaned against a tree, copying Catra’s lazy yet authoritative curves. The trunk had a lot of sap on it. My hand was sticky. I tried not to let that show. Raising one eyebrow, smirking with the opposite corner of my mouth, I fixed her with my icy blues and made my best impression of her sultry Sapphism.

‘*Hey Catra*.’

‘*Hey Ado*—ra! Get down!!’

Wood evaporated in a whirring crack. Claws hurled me into the underwood, breaking our fall behind a sandstone barrier. Catra held me very still and kept us there. Two more shots rang out across the valley.

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Chapter 17

Chapter Summary

'Yes, YES!! Of course I'll marry you!! Will you marry me? I asked first, Adora!'

'Absolutely! Yes! And you're right, you were quicker on the draw than me... just like our hidden adversary in Chapter 17. Reader-people, while Catra coos over a ring I scoured London's Hatton Gardens *and* Birmingham's Jewellery Quarter to find, go read about how we almost died. But didn't! I'm very romantic, veering fatalistic; Catra is very, very clever. You'll have a blast!!'

'Is that an opal?! Like in your sword?'

'That's right, Catra. Because you're *my* Princess of Power!! Do you know how hard I had it finding a colour-match? Turns out every opal on the planet is unique...'

Chapter Notes

Content warnings apply for the below chapter only - Spoilers may be present in the warnings. This story does not include any of the four Archive Warnings topics, but does occasionally feature other topics that may require content notes.

Chapter 17 Content Warnings (CONTAINS SPOILERS):
Threat of major character death - narrated, experienced (no major character death occurs)
Fear of own death - narrated, experienced
Fear of loved one's death - narrated, experienced
Character plans to sacrifice her life for loved one - narrated, experienced
Gunfire - narrated, experienced, gun fired at major characters (no gun-related injury occurs)

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PART 17

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One was going to die. What jolly rum luck! Moments before, Sir Adora de l'Horde had styled herself as the steely embodiment of the Etherian ideal, content to fall when and wherever fate required, so long as her passed on gloriously. For Prime and Country! As a captain goes down with their ship, or the doomed battalion falls in behind a general who's just as fixed on oblivion, so my name carried the hefty luggage of responsibility. Cowardice, you see, would tarnish the family name far more irreparably than my kicking the bucket.

Another shot whizzed over our heads, wedging itself into a pine tree two feet from my heels. The bark detonated and Meowme--- Catra squeezed my hand so hard I'd swear a vacuum formed between us. Her eyes were full and large and portentous. I was breathing fast, covered in a clammy pallor. My chest collapsed in on itself. The gun cracked again, somewhere far off yet dreadfully close. The bullet tore the sky. Ripping an eerily similar trajectory, it slammed home a scant inch from its predecessor. I did not want to die. Not today.

His Hordship had lied to me. So had Auntie. There was no dignity in this moment, no touching of the immortal in the instant before one departed our Earthly plane. Every year, every birthday, for as long as I can remember, the de l'Horde Patriarch has gifted me a tome-like missive, designed to guide me through the life aristocratic. Perhaps you'd call it an instruction manual. A military
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man to his heart, he extols Stoicism and the utter unimportance of the individual to the Imperial project. The souls who fall, says he, make a noble sacrifice – but a necessary one. I'd taken the matter as read – accepting, unquestioning, that my future lay in the Officers' Mess – but, if I can be frank, the present situation showed his words to be bullock's manure.

It was the randomness – the unfairness – that really rattled my skeleton. We'd done nothing to deserve this, whatever *this* was. Neither Catra nor I had erred, possible vehicular thefts excepted, yet now our twin souls would fall without trial or recourse, our only company the worms beneath our knees. And each other. For Greyskull's sake! There could have been an *each other*… I had made it so close to kissing Aphrodite, Artemis and Persephone all in one, only for the Fates to cut my ruddy string.

For an instant, the world around us went dead silent. There was a weighing, muffled kind of pressure in the soundlessness, as if the gun had stripped the life out of the branches all around. No bird chirped, no squirrel chittered. Even the creepy-crawly do-dads that live under decaying lumps had ceased their wiggling ways. There was no soil, only dirt. The leaves did not rustle; the grass did not sway on the plains. We held each other in the stagnant windless-ness. I dared to think. We might make it out. Might.

A plosive drop and the moment broke, jangling our selves in horrid anticipation. The noise came again, rushed through by a dying click. And then all hell broke loose. The sky ripped with powder, thick and choking. Every smell was burning. New, angry sound slammed towards us, boxing my ears with mechanical laughter, terrible and mocking. The sort of noise you just know emanates from the underbellies of a Fritz Lang cityscape. Death, mechanised. It rattled and echoed and tore. Rat-a-tat-a-tat-a-tat.

On and on, and on top of it, flying on its banshee wail? A hail of bullets. They sprayed indiscriminate and unstoppable, tearing aimlessly at every object in sight. It was a restless, senseless violence, with not one shred of nobility. Whither restraint and precision? Neither were here, I'll tell you that. Whatever this weapon was, it made its mark through brutish quantity.

Neither of us needed to say it. We both knew exactly what this would-be murder spree meant for Sir Adora, the good--- no, the *great* Lady Meowmeow, and our ill-fated Hougoumont. Napoleon had rocked up with heavy artillery – and our *canard* was good as cooked. We were going to cop it without a single living soul even knowing where we'd got to. Death looked an awful lot more terrible and less respectable than my upbringing ever promised.

One decision remained, it seemed. I had to choose how to go out. Which principles, witnessed by Catra alone, would carry me unto oblivion? I took a very deep breath. Blessed deep indeed. A lifetime best, most likely. I almost smirked at that. Life throws its challenges and depravities at any knight, probing the sincerity of her protection, the depth of her chivalry, and the purity of her heart. A sole, righteous path stood ahead of me. I would not come up short.

'Catra… I really was looking forward to kissing you. Smooching you something rotten, in fact, then perhaps even venturing further, had we ever both fancied it. I suppose that's out of the picture now! Damn, and all that.'

She laughed a little, but weakly. I went on.

‘You’ve had me in your thrall since the moment we met, and I’m damnably sorry that we’ll never discover what that really means for either of us. I know it’s been, well, not even two days. But meeting you really has been a privilege.’

‘Oh, *Adora.*’

‘It’s true. And I’ll tell you something else, while I’m at it. I’m sorry. So sorry. I dropped you into entirely the wrong box, back when you sauntered into my bedroom. You introduced yourself as *valet* and I – fool that I am – took you at your word. Just another Kyle. Another squire to attend upon the aspirant knight, aiding her in derring-do and good deed alike. An *aide-de-camp*. A hard worker. The assistant who would always stand at my side. Sweet Etheria, remembering it makes me sick! Catra--- I had you all wrong.’

‘What are you saying, Adora?’

‘Back in old Provence, sometime in the Troubadour years, they had this concept called *Domnei*. Knights swore it as surely as the finest and grandest Ladies of the land received it. The simple cut of this French jib was that every truly chivalric knight upheld a sacred duty to protect the greatest noble women in their life. Unto the very death, if needs be. And I always thought, for me, that Lady was Glimmer. She’s a friend, yes, but also the highest-ranking aristocrat amongst my set. Something like twelfth in-line to the throne, you know? All this to say… I had too narrow a definition of nobility. You aren’t just some *valet*, Catra. You’re truly the grandest woman I’ve ever met. And I pledge myself to you.’

I nodded. Very solemnly. There was nothing more to say. Dearest Madam Meowmeow scrabbled for some language but came up short. She pressed her forehead to mine instead. Then a strafe of bullets hit our stone. The lead rang and cracked into the structure, shaking echoes through our bracing ribs. Catra started crying. Wailing, I tell you. Saline dripped from her sapphire and citrine wonders, tanging itself all up in her whiskers. Now that--- That *really* creamed my crackers. This simply would not do. I started to stand up.

'ADORA?! NO!! WHAT THE **FUCK** DO YOU THINK YOU'RE DOING?!?'

'My chivalric duty, Meowmeow.'

She wrenched my arm so hard I had no choice but to give way. It was a case of falling back or feeling the bone pop out of its socket. As my rump thumped down to the dirt, my glance caught Catra, still weeping dreadfully. But – and I hadn't seen this before – hers were tears of laughter. The girl was giggling fit to burst. Perplexity descended on me. I just couldn't see how any part of this situation was even slightly funny.

'Meowmeow? Is something the matter? You do understand the gravity of the situation, eh? You're literally laughing in the face of death!'

‘Oh, *Adora.* We’re not dying here. Not if I have anything to do with it.’

My feet rattled to the impact of a stout branch. Catra grinned with that bewitching, lopsided surety of hers. Her eyes burned with renewed conviction. Unless a passing badger fancied whacking me across the shins, her hands bore the blame for the impact. I peered back at her with some degree of reproach. Bruising my shins was hardly going to help us.

‘I don’t know what game you think we’re playing here, chaplette, but there’s no time for it. I’m pretty fixed on, oh, I don’t know, saving your life instead?’

I rose to go – and she fairly tackled me back to the floor. Our embrace shocked through me. Very sensory it was, too. I smelt of mud and muck and perspiration, underscored by the heady musk of righteous exertion. With enchanting inexplicability – and despite our low surroundings – her aroma still oozed a polished burr of walnut, basil and lime peel, sweetening to a final note of Tahitian vanilla. One really regretted that heroism would likely keep me from inhaling these heady notes ever again. Well. That’s the life of a knight, I guess. Onwards to destiny.

Or not. Bucking her affectionate but dashed misguided embrace from my ribs, I levered myself against the rock, literally kickstarting a clamber up and out, only for Catra to sink all ten foreclaws into my flesh. *Fhhuu-arrrgh*. What ho! What *divine* agony! I wasn’t going anywhere.

‘Might I suggest,’ she panted, ‘that sir at least looks at this stick?’

She loosened her grip and I did just as she said, kicking the assemblage towards me for closer inspection. I picked it up. A hefty bit of business, eh! This was no humble tree-fall. That much was clear. Turned smooth, swelling from chamfered edges to an enhanced, central fullness, picked out and banded with a subtly dawn-kissed lacquer, its four-and-change feet of rosewood were dashed spiffy. There was yet more to observe about its extremities. Almost filigree in their detail, rings of looping and studded gold wrapped either end, clearly hand-worked.

‘A remarkable cane, Catra,’ I mused, just looud enough to make myself heard over the onslaught. ‘But is now really the time for a present?’

‘More than a cane, Adora. Have you looked at the inlaid section? You’ll know it when you see it, I think.’

Well, I hadn’t peered too closely at that area, what with it residing almost entirely beneath my initial clutches. Her urgency being so pointed – and her gaze so terribly intense – it seemed churlish to resist. Pinky to pointer, my fingers unwrapped to reveal… the outline of a scabbard. And a flipping gigantic opal. The stone glinted in its sea-foam glitter flawlessness. An immense conviction rushed through me, warming and keening me.

‘Ms. Floaty-Cane!’

‘The very same, sir. I recognised the device from your description.’

‘Where in Arth-Red’s kingdom did you uncover it?’

‘Didn’t you see it, Adora? It fell off your side of the bed after we hugged. I wasn’t certain what it was, sir, not straight away, but I knew you’d want to drive the Blower, reckoned you’d want open roads and calculated our most likely route would take us here, where we could take a walk. As a… first date. And a gentlewoman on a countryside stroll just *demands* a walking stick, so I collected it as we left our--- *your* chambers. Your--- unorthodox manner of entering the motor-car gave me time to examine it further, cross-referencing the design with a copy of Mx. Entrapta’s papers.’

‘And why didn’t you hand it over earlier?? That’s what I want to know.’

‘Between your driving and mine, your launching yourself at the floor, and this rural Armageddon, when, *Adora*, do you suggest I should have done that? I wanted to pick a calm, considerate moment, *actually*. I was trying to give you time to process the shock.’

‘Where does the giggling fit in?’

I’ll confess I was turning rather defensive. My arms were very tightly crossed; my back stood insensibly upright against our cramped hiding space.

‘Sir… The *irony*. I could scarcely believe the irony. To be quite clear: I was laughing at myself. It isn’t like me to be this slow planning my gentlewoman’s route out of a situation, particularly when I researched a very similar situation as last night’s bedtime reading.’

Impressed, frustrated, confused. Aroused. Take your pick. I felt all of the above.

‘I’m sorry, sir. I should have filled you in, since I’ve read around the subject. The thing is… My friend did a pretty imperfect job of explaining just how much significance is tied up in your dream-world encounter with the sword. So… First, do you wish to accept the role of She-Ra?’

‘Umm… I thought it was fairly mandatory. Do I get a choice?’

‘*Yes*. You always get a choice. No-one can force you to be She-Ra or de l’Horde or Adora. And *FUCK ANYONE* who tries to.’

‘Language, Catra!’ I stewed on it for a moment. ‘What do you mean, I don’t have to be Adora?’

‘You are yours to define.’

‘Hmm. That’s quite the concept – I’ll have to think on that. And if I choose to define myself as She-Ra, am I stuck with ‘til death does us part?’

‘I don’t think so. I saw two tales of Arth-Reds retiring from the role.’

‘Ah. Very good. Well. Nothing ventured and all that. Yes, I think, I’ll have a crack at being Lord She de la Ra!’

‘Okay. Adora? You’ve got my support, whatever you decide in the future.’

‘Terribly lovely of you, Catra. But I’d still rather have your lips on mine, if you catch my meaning!’

‘Now may not be the time, sir.’

‘Yes, yes. Naturally. So. What do I do now?’

‘A She-Ra must forge a connection with the blade. Place one hand around the handle and the other across the pommel, then give your trust to the weapon. Completely.’

‘Then what?’

‘Each She-Ra finds a phrase that seals the link. If we can believe the literature, the words will come naturally.’

‘Alright. Here goes, madam.’

My hands shook against the metal, rattling to the frantic fluctuations of my chest. I was hollow with fright yet anchored down with conviction. I went, well, I *think* I went somewhere inside my forehead. Limelight white flooded the eyes inside my mind, and I met the presence there with all the sincerity I could muster. *I am scared*, I told this shapeless somebody. *But I will not surrender. Help me fight. Help me protect my friends. Help me save Catra. I* ***must*** *save Catra.* The being rushed into me, strengthening and sharpening my every last synapse. It asked for another reply. Out roared my answer.

We can do it. We will uphold the right, the good, the just and true Etheria. We are going to win in the end. And I am the She-Ra.

‘FOR THE HONOUR OF GREYSKULL!’

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Chapter 18

Chapter Summary

'So, like, Catra and Adora have stepped out for--- let's say for some *Catradora* time, okay? And they've asked me to introduce Chapter 18. And... Wow. Okay. WOW. Those ladies are NOT okay in this chapter. There are guns and shooting and magic and, like, a happy gender congruence moment, then two pretty major characters I don't think you've met yet and - get this - TWO twists. That's one more twist than normal, so it's a really good number of twists.

I guess you'd call the second one a cliffhanger? 'Cause it's right at the end? I mean, whatever. I liked it. It's pretty twisty. You can make up your own minds. This is Mermista, by the way. I know - you've heard of me. From the tags. I'm, like, super important to this story, but not till later. You're not there yet. So... Yeah. Later.'

Chapter Notes

Content warnings apply for the below chapter only - Spoilers may be present in the warnings. This story does not include any of the four Archive Warnings topics, but does occasionally feature other topics that may require content notes.

Chapter 18 Content Warnings (CONTAINS SPOILERS):
Threat of major character death - narrated, experienced (no major character death occurs)
Gunfire - narrated, experienced, gun fired at major characters, guns fired by secondary characters (no gun-related injury occurs)
Gun violence - narrated, experienced. Guns described, guns aimed at major characters by secondary characters, guns used to threaten, guns used to control conversation, guns and gunfire actively enjoyed by secondary characters
Threat of physical injury - fall, narrated, experienced (no

lasting injury occurs)
Non-consensual touching - narrated, experienced, brief, no intimate areas touched. (Secondary character touches major character without asking. Major character okay to be touched, but unhappy to be given no choice)

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PART 18

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Light and heat and power and hue rushed through me, around me, *into* me. I was floating. I was *flying*. Warm winds of absolute trust spun up into hurricanes, cresting in dauntless infinity. The Chase was gone. The *Earth* was gone. Facsimile sky wrapped around me, a light kind of dark. Stillness crackled, then cracked, bursting into rainbows of dauntless dimensions. I had to touch them. I had to swim beneath their waterfalls, fuzz in their foam, taste the spray. They were infinity. They *knew* me.

Plunging through their translucent warmth, I dropped into colourful embrace, loosening my borders. Fear fled, and stardust flooded back. Shade and shape consumed Adora. They were changing me. I was asking to be changed. I was the She-Ra. The thought bound us; the rainbows roared hope and legacy, clarifying into a single, brilliant ray. I saw myself, glistening. Forget the custard, the Swiss roll, and the strained raspberries encased in a matching jelly: this was no trifle. It was a *transformation*. I was taller, bigger, stronger. New.

My mirror image buzzed with utter, boundless glee. I'd never even *seen* gains like these before. My biceps and triceps bordered on the unbelievable; my posterior, to use the vernacular, positively popped. My thighs were topaz; my shoulders corundum; my glutes diamond. As for my abdominals, their defined solidity made a mockery of the Mohs hardness scale. But the forces of She-Ra-ness had saved the best for my recently realised no-touch area: infinity had straightened out my curve. Counting ribs, squeezing pecs, running my hand over and over, I could barely believe it. What a weight off--- I was flat!! My chest was completely, utterly, no caveats *flat*.

I landed back on the forest floor, grinning like the Chesire. Sweet Lady Meowmeow beamed in return. She literally jumped for my joy, in fact. Unfortunately, that sent another shot ringing out. And crashed my mission straight back into my consciousness. *Save the Catra*. We – Sir She-Ra and the forces of infinity – would have to fight our way out of this corner, apprehend the wrongdoer, then return the woodland creatures to their natural freedom, all without snapping the first thread of my chapelette's outfit. It was just like chivalry – with attitude.

'Straddle my back.'

'Sir?'

'You heard me, Catra. Climb on and wrap your arms around me. Tightly. We'll have time for your *entendres* later.'

'With pleasure, Adora!'

‘Spiffing work! Ready? Right. What Ho and Let’s Go!’

Leaping over our rocky protectorate – an unnecessary display, granted, but ripping good fun – I charged onto the field of battle. Being She-Ra felt tremendous. What the Blower was to my own well-intentioned but ultimately amateur Frazer-Nash sports car, so my new form was to the old. And I felt *fantastic*. I could have won the Boat Race singlehanded, then bench-pressed the benched sportswomen as an encore. Bounding towards oblivion, the fire and the flying metal made a dreadful sight, of course, but is it too terrible to admit I was enjoying myself?

Amongst the searingly turquoise lake and its pebbled beach, the jutting cliffs and strutting sandstone, the sparse plains and crowded trees, my analysis spotted just one likely line of attack. Our opponents were all bunched up or, better yet, might number just one or two. And there they were! High above us, the enemy staked out a far-off holt, betrayed by the way their vehicle jutted side-on through the copse. Good gravy! I could see like a hawk. Was this how one’s eyes were meant to work? Did I need glasses? Would that explain the headaches? Queries to ponder later, not now, as I kept on running.

Leaps later, their conveyance spilled its secrets. It wasn’t khaki or draped in camouflage. The thing didn’t even have dazzle paint. It was an open-top auto of preposterous proportions, decked out in silver over purple. And it had just two fellows aboard, both dazzlingly well-attired. One wielded pistols and the other… The other stood astride a Thompson submachine gun. Well. You can call me many things, but an ingenue is not one. I’ve seen enough newsreels and crime flicks to know what we were dealing with

here. Bored of Brooklyn, the Mafia had descended on the Etherian Midlands.

Not on She-Ra's watch! I drew my sword aloft and screamed with all my might, plunging the blade forwards and throwing my shoulders in behind, for the final race to their position. Bullets thundered down – but such little bagatelles meant nothing to me now. I laughed at them, pirouetting around their paths with lightning pace and flicking the rest away with shrugs of my arm-guards.

Yes, indeedy!! This was the way to be. A sturdy old tree stump popped into my peripherals and the white light coursed through me, confirming I could do exactly what I'd just imagined. I threw both legs at the wood with unparalleled force, compacting hard, dense energy into my legs, then flung myself into the skies. We were flying. Or very close to it. The villains were below me now, my sword racing towards discernible fizzgogs.

'Look on my Sword, ye Mighty, and despair, for I am---' I began. And then stopped beginning, when I got a really good glance at the shooters' faces. '*GLIMMER??!??!?*'

Course correction has never happened so fast, let me tell you! I hurled myself backwards, letting my tail bone lead the way, only to rapidly realise the move would impale me on the bonnet mascot somewhere… unpleasant. Cripes. Perhaps a barrel roll might be better? Dropping a clavicle, I started to swirl. The yelped "Sir!!" bursting behind my skull confirmed that to be a similarly bad idea.

Forwards it was then. Launching myself over, then beyond the baddies, I thanked my lucky twinklers that the magical forces of She-Ra thought to line my skirt with shorts. History had not confirmed the nature or, indeed, the presence of Arth-Reddian undergarments. And I hadn't thought to check. Still, the present moment had bigger problems! Like the ground. That particular issue was getting larger by the second.

Try to stay loose, Adora. This was bound to hurt, but such are the costs of chivalry. A safe Catra would be my just reward. Thrusting my sword back into its hidey-stick, I threw out my palms and soles, aiming at evoking tentpoles, and gulped a bracing breath. *Thud*. We landed, hard. My grip filled with gravel and, one could only assume, no small amount of blood. There was no time to check, mind. Not while my valet was still in peril, her back turned to our surprising aggressors.

'Catra. So sorry. Can I sweep you behind me? For safety's sake?'

'Yes, sir. Please do.'

Her suiting was in devilish disarray, I noticed, as I secured her safety. More was most definitely the pity. What a dashing cut it had been, and how good it had looked on her. I'd have to bankroll a replacement, curse the cost, no matter what Auntie had to say. Think of it as an investment: one both Catra and I could appreciate!

And who knows? In another, more romantically propitious timeline, perhaps we'd have torn the original off her another way

by now… What a kiss it would have been! Consider my trousers well and truly pressed that *Glimmer* – of all the persons on Brightmoon's blooming Earth – had caused the Sapphic stalemate.

'Your Ladyship,' I sighed, rather rolling my eyes. 'Could you jolly well stop shooting at us? It's getting wearisome.'

'Err, you're the one charging at Etheria's best and brightest with a god*damn* sword. *Fuck*.'

Glimmer liked to say "fuck".

'*FUCK*.'

Told you. Don't say you weren't warned.

'*Fuck*,' she said, again, daubing the last strokes of her sweary triptych. 'Do you even know who I *am*?'

Her acquaintance – the second shooter – coughed, theatrically. The movement required most of the figure's upper body, ligaments unfolding in a stylised performance, which was rather the turn up for us. Becoming so occupied with their vexation, the fellow took both hands off their tripod-mounted weapon.

‘Ohhh… Humph. *Fine.*’ Now Glimmer threw her gaze at the skies. We had been here before: it was going to be one of *those* conversations. ‘Strange glowy lady, do you know who *they* are too? They want to know.’ She dropped her gauntleted grasp from one of her guns, to faux-whisper with that conspiring fury of hers. ‘It’s fine if you don’t, honestly, so long as you recognise me. You *should* recognise me. Ever read a book on royalty?! Or… or a London newspaper?’

‘Hang about, glitterbug,’ I spluttered. Even in my Amazonian form, it appeared, I still met the farcical with loudly liquid surprise. You can take the Adora out of the de l’Horde, after all, but not the de l’Horde away the Adora. ‘What do you mean, who are you? I know dashed well who you are. How many years have I spent at your side now? Or does the Champion Chum Crew mean nothing to you?’

‘How do you know about that? You… *YOU*…

‘Fluorescent tumescent, darling?’ her companion cougher suggested.

‘Hush it! I’m *busy*!’ she snapped back. ‘As for *you*, you… *wank stain.* What have you done with Bow and Sir Adora? Unhand them. Dickwad.’

And just like that, plural guns were once again pointing my way. The first tracked straight to my head, with the clinical certainty exhibited in the aforementioned gangland flicks. Number two took a more Glimmer angle: its barrel bulls-eyed my indiscreets. I

squirmed like a fresh-plucked trout. Mere moments after I'd resolved to stop being so bashful about them – and their desires – it looked like my giblets were in for the chop.

Fate really does smart sometimes. Speaking of which, shouldn't my crash-landing contusions have been bleeding? Or at least smarting? Putting my hands up, I saw the skin was perfectly calm, clean and unbroken. Even my fingernails looked unchewed. Curious stuff…

'Well? Answer me, *peasant*!'

Ah. Yes. I'd drifted off again. Attention span, you old foe! Curses on my predilection for mid-conversational drifts!

'Glimmer…' I warily ventured. A pistol cocked.

'Are you really using my first name? *That's* a risk you want to take?'

'Your Ladyship, Countess of Elberon and Lady Brightmoon,' my tongue endeavoured. My goodness, the gal's full name was a chore when you weren't in a mood for lexical levity. 'I--- apologise. Your knight has erred. But do you not recognise Sir de l'Horde when she stands before you?'

‘Dory?!’ The lady’s face crumpled through about thirty emotions over the next five seconds. It settled on amusement. ‘Ohmigosh! Is it really you?! You look so different! Did you do something with your hair? I *like* it.’ Tip-toeing over the boot lid and sliding a ways down its chromium luggage rack, Glimmer leapt from her car with rather more dignity than the Blower and I achieved. She took two steps, then stopped, pivoted, and tugged the cuff of her acquaintance.

‘Cuz? *Cuz*! Come ooooonnnnnn,’ she moaned. ‘You just *have* to meet my friend. It’s so fucking funny that we nearly shot her!’

Height and slenderness unfolded themselves through the passenger door, throwing their automatic death stick aside with airy nonchalance. They looked expensively exquisite, and very much aware of the fact.

‘I suppooooosssse, Sparkles,’ they exhaled. ‘But it simply MUST be better than that time you insisted I meet the Earl of Northumberland. He was a bore, darling. I SUFFERED for you. Really, I did! There’s only so many times I can stamp on a man’s foot before I stop having FUN.’

‘Nah, Adora’s worth meeting. Pinky promise!’

‘Adora, you say?’ They grinned something dreadful. ‘Could you mean THAT Adora? Might our paths finally have crossed? She CERTAINLY has the protagonist bearing you told me about.’

Glimmer sashayed towards us, nodding back at her buddy. By the time her neck cracked back, her path had taken her to exactly where she'd expected me to be. Which was a place I very much was not. She looked at the ground, then at me, then at the ground again. Tiptoeing forwards, her furrowed brow marked the extra distance in stomps. When she arrived, the inspection continued. She looked up, then down. And then some more up. She went a ruddy puce.

'*Adorrrraaa*,' she whispered. 'You aren't this tall. Or muscular. Have you…'

She vaulted onto her toes and ran two fingers across my arms, dropped back, and cupped my rigid abdomen. Glimmer always has been a handsy lass, you see, which I'd never thought to be a bother before. But that was pre-Meowmeow. So soon after my gentlewoman's courteous, carefully-mapped embrace, her Ladyship's attentions rung a little less than tactful. I wasn't uncomfy, I don't think, but Catra had illustrated a much better way.

'…been working out? Just for me, I hope? A Lady's got to have the biggest, strongest knight she can lay her hands on.'

'Well, um, that's certainly me, glitterbug! I doubt you'll find anyone beefier!'

'Or more courageous, my knight! Did you *see* how you ran through our target practice?'

‘Truth be told, I was rather busier with not getting shot. Whyever did you bring guns to a public forest, anyhow?’

‘Adora!’ she shrieked. ‘Ha-ha-ha-ha!! HA! This isn’t *public* land. The normals just have some crappy little right of use deal. Cannock Chase was planted for royalty, so they could go hunting. Which got me thinking… Shit, I’m a sort of royal, aren’t I? And don’t I want to try out *all* the things I’ve been keeping in the armoury? Don’t I *deserve* to? So here we are. Pretty sweet, right?’

‘What were you shooting? Why did you have such big weapons? And what did *this* nature do to deserve *that?*’

‘Poor sweet naïve Adora! Animals are just dinner the cook hasn’t caught yet, and we were only aiming for rabbits or pheasants anyway.’

‘How many did you kill?!’

‘I only shoot guns to amuse myself,’ replied Glimmer’s late-arrived companion. ‘Which is WHY I fired at YOU. I don’t aim to kill, darling, just to laugh.’

‘It wasn’t very funny for *us*.’ The sparkling sensation was rising through me again. A palm rested on my sword-cane. My mission

flared before me: keep Catra safe. Call it She-Raian intuition, but I sensed my task was far from over.

'Oh, but it WAS, Adora,' the fellow cackled. 'Sparkles here missed every shot she took! Even with the machine gun!'

'Can you just *shut up* already? Fuck. You're only *here* because I invited you anyway.' Glimmer gripped me, hard. 'And nothing from you either, Adora. *I'm* the one asking questions here, *okay*? Like… Why are you wearing that? Didn't you go to jail after the boat thing? And how did you get up here? Isn't your Aunt Shadowtha fucking *furious* with you?'

'Umm… Right… Hmm…' I mused. 'Guess I can give those a shot. In order… I don't know but I like it; I don't know but I got a fine; the train, I think; Auntie always seems peeved, honestly, but I think she approved of my heading up here. To make amends and all that. Not that I can take credit for the idea.'

Glimmer doubled over in laughter.

'That's *SOOOOO* funny!! 'Cause my mum is going to be *super mega ULTRA pissed* when she sees you!'

'I should head home, then? Lay low and so forth?'

‘Noooooo!!’ she screamed. ‘You *HAVE* to stay. I *insist*. I don’t care what mum says; you’re my friend and I want you here. Please don’t go?! Ohmigosh. Her response is going to be *EPIC*. Right. Get in. We’re going back to the house.’

‘I’ll make my own way there, if it’s all the same?’

‘By *yourself*?! What, have you got shit for brains??’

‘Darrrrllliinnnggg,’ crooned the lanky luxuriant. ‘She WASN’T by herself. You had a helper, didn’t you, Adora?’

‘Adora? Is that true? Where are they?’ Glimmer stamped forcefully into the floor. ‘I want to see them. I demand you show them to me. *Now*.’

Every element screamed that this was a bad idea. Right here, right now, surrounded by a firecracker friend and her lofty arsenal, seemed like quite the inopportune moment to reveal the newly-installed centre of my affections to a wider world. Glimmer didn’t strike me as somebody who liked to share, let alone concede that another woman might soon hold a higher place in my perceptions than she.

‘*Adora*. Are you refusing? I am your *princess*. I’m going to count to *fucking* three. One… Two…’

The situation felt tight. Ditto my chest. Protecting Catra was my first and foremost ambition, but our progress together, should any ever occur, would have to include these prickly chats. Courage, Adora. Remember your knightly ways. Frightened as I felt – quaking before social rebuke, sick-to-the-tummy-pit at the dangling sword of Aunty's wrath – I was done with hiding. Sweet Lady Meowmeow deserved the best – and I would never conceal my bonds with her. Sensing the incoming moment, Catra filled my lug with a whisper, consenting to be seen.

'*Glimmer.*' I started. 'I am a Lesbian.'

'*Duh*. We've kissed *SO* many times. Straight girls don't tongue like that.'

'Beg pardon?! Can't a self-realising Sapphic get a bit of support when she discloses?'

'I've got to agree with Adora, Sparkles. By the way, brave knight, I see and CELEBRATE your coming out into our little world. Congratulations! May your days be filled with all the amorous, glamorous maidens your heart desires. It's the least anyone deserves.'

'Okay. Fine. I'm…' Glimmer mumbled into a trailing off. 'I did the wrong thing, okay. So. Adora, well done for figuring it out. You're gay.'

‘Which is why I’m a few shades of nervous to tell you my next bit of business,’ I went on. ‘The person here with me – the woman – is one of the most remarkable beings I’ve ever met. She’s thoughtful, smart, stylish, clever, well-read, quick-witted and all the rest. Plus dashed good looking! I really did worry about what you’d think. But faint heart never did win fair maiden, eh? So do, please, say a cheery what ho to the inimitable C---’

‘---yle’s replacement. Thank you, sir. Your Ladyship, and Your Esteemed Nobleship, it really is an honour to make your acquaintance. I fear Sir de l’Horde flatters me. She has lately engaged me as her gentlewoman’s gentlewoman. You may call me Meowmeow.’

‘Oh no, kitten,’ oozed Her Ladyship’s high-heeled friend. ‘I think I’ll call YOU Alley-Cat.’

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Chapter 19

Chapter Summary

'Sorry to leave you hanging there, reader-folk! It's just--- we're quite tremendously in love!! I couldn't keep kisses from my soon-to-be missus for a moment longer! Speaking of... Sweet, dear *fiancée* Catra, would you do the segmental honours?'

'With pleasure. Who was I before I entered Adora's life? And what did it have to do with Glimmer's acquaintance? You're about to find out, just as I promised in Chapter 12. Truth and lies, bright lights and late nights, class politics and queer liberation... Welcome to Catra's Flashback Sequence.'

Chapter Notes

Content warnings apply for the below chapter only - Spoilers may be present in the warnings. This story does not include any of the four Archive Warnings topics, but does occasionally feature other topics that may require content notes.

Chapter 19 Content Warnings (CONTAINS SPOILERS):
Threat of physical violence - narrated, present; related, past; hypothetical, past
Physical violence - related, historic, explicit, bare firsts, injury occurs
Verbal abuse - related, historic, implied, implied sexualised content
Threat of non-consensual touching - related, historic (no non-conensual touching occurs)
Queerphobia - related, historic, based on real British and German events
Gaslighting - related, present, historic

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PART 19

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Catra stiffened, her tail jagged to spikes. She hissed. I stepped half-ahead of her, sword drawn.

'What's the matter, kitten? Don't recognise me? I guess I DO look a little different… AMAZING what a good wardrobe can do. But you'd know all about that, wouldn't you?'

'It's a pleasure to see you again… *Flutterina*.'

'Oh, please. You think she doesn't know about that? I tell Glimmer EVERYTHING. Well, the version of everything I benefit from revealing, anyhow.'

'Of course, liege,' Catra hissed acidly back, 'philosophers continue to debate the nature of truth.'

Flutterina – I think – pivoted into profile, tossing their head until their pointed chin jutted at the heavens. Draping a bejewelled hand across their chest, extending each finger onto a considered, seemingly pre-designed mark, the fellow shook their hair a little,
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flicked a glance to make sure we were both watching, then let out a floating peal. Stage laughter, I'd call it. Hollow, mocking stuff.

'KITTEN! So sophisticated! You never do disappoint. I just LOVE how you intellectualise away your wrongdoing; it's what makes you such a fascinating… *CHARACTER*. Just what goes on in that little head of yours? Beneath it, of course, you're still a filthy little filcher.'

I hooked an arm around my Lady Meowmeow, ready to sweep her safely off the battlefield. Glitterbug and Flutterina may have put their guns away, but this, I was certain, constituted a new tier of fighting talk. Catra twitched a little. It was the only movement she made, her every other muscle frozen solid in the instant before flight. Her pupils were wavering pinpricks. Overwhelming fury urged me to fight for her honour.

'Now, see here, you chum of Glimmer. I won't have you spreading lies about my Lady.'

'Haha! Ohmigosh, Dory, you say just the funniest things,' Lady Brightmoon intervened. 'Is this one of your little mix ups? Are you feeling okay?'

'I'm fine.'

'You can't be! Do you hear yourself? You called that servant your *Lady*! That's like… It's absurd, Adora! And SO funny. *I'm* your

Lady. She's just a fucking *valet*.'

'Meowmeow is a woman of honour and integrity. Your friend has a choice. They can take back their words – or answer for them.'

My squishy bits were pounding fit to burst. Every word left my lips with a heretofore unknown and wanton precision. I'd defied Glimmer, then threatened another presumed noble, and I felt not the first twinge of regret. Not yet, anyhow. I raised my sword until its tip stood inches from my foe's throat.

'What's it going to be, Flutterina? Are you going to apologise of your own free will? Or do I have to make you?'

'Oh, I'm *quaking*, really.' The fellow took an exaggerated breath, then tutted their tongue between their teeth. 'You do know I haven't said a single thing that's untrue? Hmm? OH! That SURPRISES you, I can tell. Why don't we let your… hmm… *serving girl* tell us what really went down at the Eldorado?'

'Adora.' Catra signalled for me to step back. 'Do you want to know?'

'Do you want to tell me?'

'If she doesn't, DARLING, I will.' Flutterina laughed again, catching Glimmer's attention.

‘Is it juicy, cuz?!’

‘Glimmer, darling, I can’t make every German fairy story exciting. And I’m FAR more concerned about the impact her dirty fingers had on ME. Tick tock, kitten! You know how I REALLY don’t like to miss my mark.’

The pair of them stared at Catra, who, in turn, looked at me.

‘Sir?’

‘No. You never have to do anything because of someone else. It’s a little mangled, but that’s what you said, isn’t it chapelette?’

She nodded.

‘You’re not doing it?’ the second noble began. ‘Goodie. Okay, okay, everyone give me room. I need to get into my characters… I’m beauty, I’m grace, I’m talent. Okay, good. Now the second… I’m annoying, I’m dull, nobody likes me…

Arrgh-hum. The MUSES are singing to me; prepare to be graced by my theatrical art!

The year was 1928! I had made my way to Berlin, the capital of Germany. A city… with many secrets! Most of those secrets are gay cabaret venues, darlings, to which I was drawn like a moth to a stage. Of course, I quickly established myself as one of the finest performers in the city, and I was overwhelmed with offers of work. And where could my stilettos lead, if not the most famous address of all? Motzstraße 15, the home of Eldorado!

Hier ist's Richtig! *sings the sign over the grand entrance… and it's TRUE. Everything went right for me there. I always make a point of really INHABITING my characters, living each of their little intricacies. That's art! And I have such a cornucopia of them, spanning so many genders, presentations and time periods. I really do go the extra distance and my patrons always appreciate it. They're SUCH connoisseurs!*

It was so elegant there, so fitting for me. Crowds flooded in each and every night with roses and chocolates and adoration. Yes! There it is: the appreciation I deserve! My public clamoured for my greatest creation of all. Who was I to deny them? They came to see the twirling, girlish bundle of femininity I call FLUTTERINA. You couldn't even get a seat for my shows without pre-booking. Adored by cognoscenti and colleagues alike, I was a celebrity!

And then she *came. The Etherian Alley-Cat. I don't know how someone like her found a way into our den of opulence. Honestly, I don't! We dined on caviar and drank champagne, drying our lips with silk handkerchiefs. SHE was always worrying about the price of bread, or something. It was such… a… bummmmeeeerrrr. Uh. I'm sorry! I get down when I even think about it. Oh, the PAIN!*

I tried to ignore the thorn in our rose garden, I really did, but she was always there, going on like---'

Far be it from me to interrupt a ripping yarn mid-flow – even one this dastardly and fallacious – but I really must let you know that, at this very instant, Flutterina gave me the fright of my life. At least, I *think* it was fright. Something urgently electric thumped through my chest, and I all but jumped out of my skin. In barely the 'ji' of a jiffy, you see, Flutterina turned their seven feet of louche aristo into a younger, scruffier, less curvaceous cameo of Meowmeow. There was no mistaking it. The eyes were dead on.

'*---**I don't know how I'm ever going to overcome my struggles! I face so many challenges! I want more money! Angry claws! GROWL!** She was such a fateful little kitten, which I really don't go for. If she wanted extra cash, she could have just become an overwhelmingly talented stage star, like me. Not at the same club, of course! I don't appreciate the competition. I'd have poisoned her or broken her legs!*'

Back to their earlier form, the actor fixed us with a glittering grin of about three dozen teeth. My indignation was swelling up again. I simply couldn't keep the stuff in.

'How dare you?! You… You blackguard. I'm jolly well warning you to get her name off your tongue.'

'Or what? You'll cut it off? Pur-leeeaaasse. Don't you KNOW it's rude to interrupt in the middle of a play? Now, do me a favour,

and save your adulation for the curtain… Hmm… Where was I? Oh! Yes!

I would have hurt her terribly and felt no remorse at all, but I admit I'd admire the hustle. If only she'd had any. She did not, darlings. Instead, the Alley-Cat went to work on all the jobs I didn't even know we had there: peeling potatoes; mopping bathrooms; and all that cetera*. Eventually, it got through to her that those tasks are terrible, so a kindlier manager put her on floor duty. It was… Ah! … A MOST terrible mistake!*

Darlings, the Eldorado floor girls have the simplest task imaginable. They flit around between the tables and just make sure the customers are happy. The richer the patron, obviously, the more content they should be. Easy, right? Oh no… Not for the Alley-Cat. She's sizing them up with her envious, heterochromatic GAZE, because she wants their nice things. I saw her… staring about whenever I was on stage. And, well, I know light fingers when I see them.

Which brings us to the fateful night. The air was sun-flushed warm; a gentle breeze whispered; but, oh! The sky glowed a portentous crimson. I KNEW something was afoot. If only, darlings. If only I had listened to the actor's finely-tuned appreciation of time and place. Alas! Alack! It makes me weak. Glimmer, please, your flask!'

Flutterina supped a mannered gulp or two, holding a finger aloft for the duration. We were not to talk. And for some reason, we didn't.

'Thank you, thank you. Ah. I'm recovered. I shiver to recount the affair BUT, in the spirit of sacrifice, I must go on. Our little song must have its end. Imagine the scene! The velvet curtain bunches, rising to the heavens. Spotlights flare, their wavering aim trained on the most coquettish mademoiselle you have EVER seen. On me! My entrance awaits; my latest and greatest production is ready to begin. I click patent leather from stage left, darlings, dropping a single finger from my unfurling reach, striking up a thirty-piece band. The notes blast, I step back, the machinery whisks me skywards… And I lift my voice, to sing! All eyes are on me, Flutterina, flying over them.

I am a dream, I am a fantasy! And then? And then kitten*? I am IGNORED. At that VERY moment, the Etherian stray darts out of the shadows and races across the carpets, pouncing on a Count! A Count who was one of our best tippers! Out came the claws, didn't they, kitten? You couldn't take it anymore, so you took from someone else instead. THEFT, darlings. She robbed the man of his pocket watch, his cravat and his money clip, and sent his teeth SCATTERING across the room. There was uproar. We were closed for a week; we were in all the 'papers. And, worst of all, not one of them mentioned MY performance! She had stolen my greatest show from me and, truly, I have never recovered!'*

The figure flopped to the floor, waving one hand over their forehead, waited a beat, and stood right back up again. Glimmer positively vibrated with excitement; I did not.

'Haha! *SHIT me!* Adora, you've been harbouring a dangerous fugitive. And you just sung her praises, like she was somebody who *mattered*. That's! So! Funny!'

‘Balderdash.’

‘Sorry, darling, what was that?’ Flutterina examined their nails at stretched-out length.

‘You know what I said,’ I replied. ‘But I can repeat it, if you like. *Balderdash*. I fancy I know Meowmeow well enough to say she’d never do anything like that. She’s a figure of refinement and intellect and subtlety. Plus plenty more asides!’

‘Now that IS interesting.’ They turned to me with that terrible grin, resting their chin on folded fingers. ‘One person plays are divisive, I’ve always found. Some audience members are guaranteed to miss the point and you, darling, seem especially… stubborn. Oh, I can see you twitching. A lovely detail, thank you. I’ll be taking that for one of my next characters. It’s so very REAL – and TRAGIC! You heard it all, didn’t you, but you still don’t believe me… even after I orated it so beautifully. Adora, darrrrlinggggg… Your valet is a *thief*.’

‘You’re a bally liar.’

‘*Sir*.’ Catra twitched.

‘Just a minute, eh, chapelette? I’m about to give this old acquaintance of yours a bit of what for. Defend your honour and all that.’

‘Sir. While I appreciate your nobility, the story Flutterina relates is not entirely untrue.’

‘Pretty words, kitten, like always,’ the lanky noble hummed. ‘Of course, what you *mean* to say is that I rendered your sordid affair with ABSOLUTE accuracy. I demand credit for the impersonation, if nothing else! Yours is *NOT* an easy voice to mimic.’

A very clipped Catra spat back.

‘My apologies, liege, for your confusion. I must have erroneously given the impression you were involved in this conversation.’

‘*Me-owww*, kitten.’

If a look really could kill, Flutterina would have dropped dead there and then. The authorities would have had a diamond-hard time figuring out which of Catra and I had to answer for it.

‘The narrative you have just heard, sir, contains several errors. If you permit me, I wish to correct them.’

‘Ah-ha-ha! Ohmigosh. What a *cunt*!’ Her Ladyship interjected. ‘I can see why you didn’t trust her, cuz. She’s so fucking *rude*.’

Glimmer whispered in the way actors do, when they want to make sure even the back row of the upper circle can catch their enunciation. I tried to blot her out and increase my shield around Catra.

'Several fundamentals of the tale are correct,' dear Lady Meowmeow continued. 'Over the last few years, I have spent substantial time in Germany, basing myself within the capital city. Though I was then, as now, a trained valet, my employment there ranged more widely. I tried, where I could, to remain within the *demi-monde* of what is termed, somewhat restrictively, "Gay Berlin".

This was not as difficult as you might imagine, sir. As in the United States, our kinds are currently enjoying a barbed Berlin prominence. In the eyes of the social majority, we are the latest risqué fashion: something to see and to drape around themselves, loosely, always at arm's length. They reduce us to… an acceptable scandal.'

She took a deep breath, her eyes closed. Cacti really are the worst, eh?

'Sir, I do not like the way some people treat us there, but it is by no means all of them. For someone like me – and for the person you could be, if you shared my world – Berlin is safer than anywhere else I know. London pushes us into threadbare Soho corners, and it's the same throughout the rest of Etheria. The few places we do have here get raided. The people inside get beaten,

prosecuted, criminalised. That was just--- *life*, before I made it to the Teutonic capital.

'Hundreds of queer cafes, bars, nightclubs and revues have grown up throughout the city, many publicly announcing themselves. Lesbian venues are especially prominent… *Naturally*, these haunts consumed my leisure time.' A wry grin from Catra, there. Wry and very dry. My heart calmed a little to see it. Until then, she hadn't shown the first flicker of a positive emotion since we'd left the shield-stone. 'Good memories, sir. Forgive me for indulging them?'

'In a city where gay films, gay music, gay books and gay periodicals all circulate freely, I soon gained the confidence to do the same,' she went on. 'I found community in the streets of Schöneberg. I found safety and new ways of living. I found *vital* medical care---' Catra paused for a moment, rubbing a thoughtful finger along her cheekbone. She dropped to a whisper. 'How can I help you feel the *difference*, Ador--- *sir*, without taking you there? Hmm. Maybe I'll just have to plan us a trip.'

'Maybe I'd like that,' I grinned back.

'For now,' she resumed at ordinary volume, 'let me use dates to demonstrate. Berlin has hosted the *Scientific-Humanitarian Committee* – a community organisation devoted to our protection and dignity – since 1897. Dr. Hirschfield opened his clinic in 1919, pioneering and expanding his gender-affirming treatments continually in the years since. Public demonstrations against our mistreatment began in 1922. Even the *Reichstag* couldn't ignore us. Last year, 1929, the country considered legislation to decriminalise sexuality, although, regrettably, elected officials have

not yet completed that particular task. Flutterina is mistaken. I had never been happier.'

'Why come back then, chapelette? That's what I don't understand. I mean, I'm jolly glad you did – rejoicing, even – but I really can't see your reasoning.'

'Hark, darling,' Flutterina emoted. 'For peripeteia APPROACHES!'

'As you know, sir, I eventually took up a position at Eldorado. A past colleague commended me to the role, after witnessing my work at several Lesbian bars. Prizing thoroughness, I spent my first weeks at Eldorado sampling as many roles as management would allow. Our correspondent is quite right… in some matters. I did peel vegetables and I could be found polishing commodes. Elsewhere, their recollection errs. What… a… *shame*. Flutterina must have missed my stint in the orchestra pit and the period I spent as their wardrobe designer. As for my performances---'

'*Kitten*. You really can't help yourself! Whenever your mouth moves, you lie.'

'Help me, if you'd be so kind, liege? What does it take for me to be the *Apfelmus* of your *Auges*?'

Flutterina staggered back. As they did, the fellow seemed to clutch at an invisible dagger poking out of their heart. A fanciful notion, I have to say. It presupposed they had one.

‘No? You, kitten? NO. It can’t be!’ They paused, flicking their head this way and that, taking in Catra from every conceivable angle, plus some I wouldn’t have thought up in a month of Sundays. ‘Oh? Ohhhhh! O-*kay*. I enjoy the surprise; I have to give you that. But your performances? Mundane. Amateur. I know it hurts, kitten, but you’ve GOT to hear it from someone. You should give it up.’

‘Respectfully, Flutterina, the newspapers did not agree.’

‘Oh, *what-EVER*. You can keep that fantasy, little Alley-Cat. I sustain myself with the knowledge that I, alone, was the star.’

‘Quite a number of the Eldorado crew did not believe in the celestial status of its headline acts,’ Catra continued. ‘This became *very* clear as I worked my way through the departments, forging friendships. Less visible staff felt starved of resources, security and income. Tensions grew and – by this time – I was well-known around the ‘club. If I may, sir, I was also well-liked. My colleagues asked me to speak with the Eldorado’s owners. They hoped my delivery would help their words resonate. It did not.’

‘Then what happened?!’ I was hooked, I’ll freely admit it. ‘Whatever did you do next?’

‘The workers formed a trade union, Sir Adora,’ she smiled, ‘and then they elected me as their captain.’ Glimmer scowled; Catra grinned, coughed and continued. ‘Honestly, this placed me in a

tricky position. It was a *real* balancing act. My voice needed to be effective, often tactful, and always true: a task for a gentlewoman's gentlewoman, if ever there was one. It required all my intuition to navigate. Flutterina forgets that they and I discussed workers' needs no fewer than five times… They *courteously* allowed me to outline current grievances and requests, so long as I paid for their dinner…'

'Just words, kitten! Pretty LITTLE words. Honestly, you have too much faith in your speeches. Maybe, if you took an acting class, you wouldn't need to rush to the *PUNCH* line.'

'Oh yeah!' Glimmer gasped. 'That's what this was all about, isn't it cuz? Adora's got herself all tangled up with a hardened jailbird! I mean, really, my knight?! I didn't think it was even *possible* to pick shittier servants than Kyle. And you have! Just look at how much she *clearly* loves herself--- and how much she *shouldn't*. She stands there with her big words and her tailored shirt – which she probably stole – and gives us some cunty story about facts, and dates, and Communism. Err, I don't know about you two, but I don't want to hear it! *Valet*. I demand you tell us how you ended up as a criminal on the run. Did you break out of jail? Did you?!'

Her Ladyship's countenance lit up with a diamond-like twinkle. Never one to skip the sensational, Glimmer was absolutely enjoying herself. On one side, this was champion news. Jaw had beaten war – in the sense that Catra and I were no longer looking at new careers as colanders. The second side, I fear, reflected on the Countess less brilliantly.

'As you wish, madam. It would be helpful, I feel, to finish correcting the narrative.' My valet took a moment to adjust her

cuffs, then re-hang her watch chain. Her audience keened forwards, Flutterina feigning disinterest, Lady Brightmoon doing nothing of the sort. 'Some weeks before unionisation, I completed my backstage tour of the business. I knew Eldorado intimately, just as I'd proposed when I started. It was information I needed, alongside my prior experience as a valet and at other venues, to really excel there---'

Glimmer scuffed and stamped her feet. 'Euuurrrrgghh! Boring! You haven't hit anyone yet. Get to the good part!! *Fuck*!'

'I embarked on my contracted role: Head of the Floor,' Catra continued, unperturbed. 'Each night, I patrolled the tables, the dancefloor and any other areas we opened to the public, making my presence clear to fellow staff but unobtrusive to our visitors. I oversaw the floor, though *not* in a managerial sense. It was my duty to keep the floor girls, persons and boys safe, intervening where needed. Quickly.'

'Ah! I get it entirely, chapelette. Barely seen but bally vital, just like the gentlewoman's gentlewoman!'

'Indeed. Flutterina told you I worked as a floor girl. I did, but only for a fortnight. Instead – once I'd finished my training – I protected the floor staff. They trusted me nip threatening scenarios before they could bud. Sir Adora, I did everything I could to deserve that trust.'

'So *nooooobbbble*, kitten, if it IS true. I can't say *I* remember you doing ANYTHING like that.'

‘Nor do I expect you to. Liege, with appropriate respect, you very rarely joined us on the floor and, when you did, you only stayed for the length of your standing ovations.’

‘And I had so many of them, didn’t I?’ Flutterina sighed. ‘Sparkles, just try to imagine a hundred, no, a thousand people entranced! What is the sound of two thousand hands clapping? I used to wonder. Then I started performing at Eldorado, and I found out, for show after show after SHOW! Until THAT night, when *Alley-Cat* here made sure no-one applauded at all. Oh! It’s too much!’

‘As I was saying,’ brave Lady Meowmeow continued, ‘the Head of the Floor had to be discreet but effective. I built myself a fitting reputation, and it did most of my work automatically. Within a few weeks of starting, I just had to walk between the tables and guests knew to behave themselves. Some didn’t take the hint, true, but I could usually make things clear with quiet conversation. Words are very powerful.’

‘Get! To! The! Fight! *Fuckstick*!’ Glimmer almost exploded from her impatience.

‘*Unfortunately*,’ Catra pointedly announced, ‘some gentlepeople choose not to hear them. In those situations, actions speak louder. This brings us to the night in question---’

‘Fucccckkkkiinnnggg finnnnnaaaalllly!!’ Lady Brightmoon gasped back.

‘---when my talents were sorely tested. Eldorado was busy. For all our disagreements, Flutterina was a major attraction, especially on the opening night of their latest show. The floor, therefore, was full. Every seat was taken, making our roles more challenging. The unfortunate Count sat on his preferred Table Five with three friends, an acquaintance and a trio of strangers, who shared it with him only because we had no other room. One floor girl was asked to focus on tables Three through Five all evening, in recognition of their high probable spend. She appeared happy with the request; no problems jumped out at me.

‘During my first sweeps, the table seemed boisterous but not immediately dangerous. The Count and his friend were drinking quickly, sir, so I made a note to pay them closer attention. About an hour later, I noticed the floor girl looking awkward, distressed even, around the Count. Sir, I do not believe in standing idle when anyone may be in danger. I removed her from the table immediately, found her a spare room to rest, and let her know that she could go home immediately without losing a *reichsmark* of her wages. What I didn’t tell her, sir, was that I planned to cover the shortfall from my own funds.

‘In the end, that didn’t matter. She wanted to go back to working the same tables – so we agreed a system where I’d flank her whenever she passed the Count. This did not stop his lewd remarks. I had to step in and *gently* remind him of our house rules. That didn’t work either. I cut his group off from floor services, then took him aside for a more… explicit conversation. Any further misconduct and he’d be expelled. Permanently. I made that *crystal clear*.

‘Regrettably, he didn’t see fit to reconsider. I left Table Five to handle a developing dispute on Table Two. As soon as my back was turned, the Count threw himself towards another floor girl and threatened to take out his frustrations on her. I saw red. She needed protection. *Now*. I sprinted across the hall, making his options clear. He could walk himself out the front door, permanently. Or he could stay and face the consequences of his actions. The Count entrenched. He looked like he was balling up a fist.

‘I had no other choice. There *is* no other choice, when someone tries to make a woman unsafe. He pulled back his arm. I pushed myself between him and floor girl. His arm rushed forward. And I scratched him, fast and long. Sir, please believe me when I tell you this was a minor attack, designed to dissuade the Count and protect my floor team. It was not enough. He tried to lunge past me, so I stopped him.’

‘That’s more like it!’ Glimmer cackled. ‘Then what?’

‘Hang about, C--- Meowmeow. Do you mean to say you boxed the bounder?’

‘I hit him twice, sir. Once to the solar plexus, to stun, then once to the throat, to incapacitate him. I did not punch him in the mouth, as Flutterina incorrectly suggested. The mouth is not an especially vulnerable area and teeth are harder than action stories make them seem. Striking someone there and you risk damaging your own hand more than you hurt your assailant. One must also question how our liege observed the altercation so clearly from a distant, brightly lit stage.’

‘I checked in later, kitten, with EVERYONE that saw you. Are you calling the club manager a liar?’

‘Liege, I merely highlight that the man lost no teeth. I swear it. You may also wish to know the Count and I met on a Black Tie evening.’

‘Not everyone cares as MUCH about suits as you, Alley-Cat. Are you rueing how you couldn’t strip the shirt off his back?’

‘The Black Tie dress code is synonymous with the tuxedo. As convention demanded, the Count wore a bow-tie and cummerbund with his suit, leaving him with no place for a cravat, and no room for a watch-holding waistcoat.’

Flutterina crumpled slightly, their tongue trapped between their teeth.

‘You’re… *right*.’

This was either the best acting they’d shown us, or no acting at all.

‘Kitten, you said the Count was acting inappropriately towards two of the girls? Two of us? Is that really, genuinely true?’

‘I swear it, liege.’

‘A lot of the Eldorado performers still say the most ATROCIOUSLY good things about you, Alley-Cat, darling. And I always thought they were all liars too. But--- But--- Oh, this really is the WORST. My side was awfully compelling, but you’ve swept in with the compellingly awful. I--- I--- Oh! It’s TOO terrible for words. Forsooth! *Kitten*. I--- I--- BELIEVE you. I owe you an apology. Alley-Cat, my darling kitten, I may have been slightly, momentarily, just the slightest hint of… WRONG!!’

‘What?!’ said all three of the rest of us, for three different reasons. The object of our awe lit up at the attention.

‘And can we stop with the Flutterina nonsense now?’ they continued. ‘Her character is on hiatus. Call me by my off-stage name, why don’t you? *I* am the German royalty and Etherian Marquioness J. T. Trubel-Brightmoon. And I’m something Danish too, but I’d have to go and check what it was, and I don’t WANT to. Because, darlings, who CARES about Denmark?!’

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Chapter 20

Chapter Summary

'I never thought I'd see someone so happy to meet Marquioness Trubel-Brightmoon, Adora, but Chapter 20 proves me wrong. By the time it ends, our readers might understand your enthusiasm. Or my lack of it.'

'You did get to drive a second terribly spiffy speed machine, though!'

'Indeed, sir. A brand-new Duesenberg Model SJ Phaeton. A wonderful car... in abstract. But is life ever abstract? Costing approximately $19,000, its value could pay the average Etherian salary, in full, for the next 32 years. It was--- a very Brightmoon automobile.'

'Speaking of which... Have you started planning our wedding, Catra? And can I pick the wedding car? Can that be my job? Pretty pretty please?!'

Chapter Notes

Content warnings apply for the below chapter only - Spoilers may be present in the warnings. This story does not include any of the four Archive Warnings topics, but does occasionally feature other topics that may require content notes.

Chapter 20 Content Warnings (CONTAINS SPOILERS):
Threat of gun violence - narrated, present (no gun violence occurs)
Verbal abuse - related, present, implied sexualised content
Gender dysphoria - narrated, present and historic, brief
Gender role compliance discomfort - narrated, present and historic
Dangerous driving - narrated, present, risk of accident (no accident occurs)

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PART 20

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‘Brightmoon?!’ enquired I, the de l’Horde grey goo abuzz. ‘How dashed unlikely that you share a surname… It doesn’t take a detective to see how you two first chummed up, does it?! That’ll be something to chatter about. And over champers, no doubt, if I know Glimmer.’

‘Adora! Ha! *Ohmigosh*. You’re too funny sometimes! We’ve known each other a LOT longer than that. Me and J. T. go way, waaaaaayyyyy back.’

My three conversational partners looked hard into me, as if something about the situation was plain as boiled potatoes on a sad Tuesday evening. Withering under their expressions, I felt quite the beige, unsalted tuber myself.

‘Wait a minute… Brightmoon. *Brightmoon.* Really not the most common moniker, is it?’

They kept looking. I looked back, blankly, until a thought arrived and strained itself out of the starchy waters.

‘I say! What ho! Meowmeow, old chapelette, these two could be related.’

‘I think it highly likely, sir.’

‘BRAVA, darling,’ Trubel-Brightmoon proclaimed. ‘OR bravo… Sir Adora, I do NOT know your pronouns.’

‘One fancies there’s quite a bit you wouldn’t know about this humble knight. Sir Adora de l’Horde, third baronet, at your service. Devoted chum and sworn protector of Glimmer here, plus plenty more besides. Let’s see… I’m a rower, a rugger forwards, a fellow about town---’

‘Oh no, darrrllllling. I’ve heard ALL sorts about you, my brave baronet.’ The Marquioness smiled something impenetrable. ‘Glimmer has filled… me… in… with OUTSTANDING thoroughness. And *length*. Really, she’s been most ELUCIDATING, especially when it comes to---’

‘*Cuz*! Shh. I told you that in confidence.’

‘A-ny-wayyyyyy… You do NOT disappoint, Adora, but I HAVE to know how to call you. Self-determination is so VITALLY important.’

A curious question to ask so soon, it seemed to me. In all my memory, only Bowregard had done the like. Back then, I'm afraid, my reply had amounted to little more than noiseless gum flapping. That really wouldn't do here. Not a second time. I'd learned a fair bit in the years since, you see. I knew what personal pronouns *were* for one – plus the various options a fellow could opt for. What I couldn't tell you was which especially applied to me.

"She" always seemed perfectly fine, though never amazing, so there was no compelling argument to change it. But was that reason enough to retain the thing? I'd certainly had my fill of "Dame" and "Lady" and the like. Just thinking of them makes me shudder. Yes, of course, they're accurate in the official sense. But I will *not* be called by them. Even Auntie got the message – and double quick – once she'd seen my honorific horror firsthand. Not that it stops her recommending me ballgowns---

Which, I suppose, brings us to the thorny matter of clothing. Now, I'm not one for skirts or dresses where avoidable, but who's to say that even the nattiest, most sophisticated clothing has a gender? That's an awfully close-minded view, isn't it? Lady Meowmeow is a superlatively attractive woman, but I hadn't seen with her trousers off. Emm. Ah. *I mean to say*--- I hadn't yet observed my gentlewoman in a more conventionally feminine mode. Also, I was still some way from seeing her naked. But don't worry! Both occur in time.

My gaze gravitated to Catra. I was beginning to realise it did that, well, pretty much whenever I could see her. And that's no issue. Except, right then, when it was. Because my ponderous delays had got J. T. all a-flap.

‘Adora? Darling? PLEASE tell me I haven’t OFFENDED. Do you need me to rephrase the question?’

One hungers for a little extra language at a time like this. The query was fine. Respectful, even. But how does one articulate that “She” and “Her” are perfectly alright – and womanhood my bag – while cautioning the ways certain threads and titles jangle? Catra understood it all instinctively, but she was special. Ditto the Capital Chums… sometimes. Would J. T. get it, though? And what of the sparkling, floating feeling borne by my She-Ra form? Or the dread so suddenly tied up in *that* area shifting back? Where were the words? And did I have to talk about it at all?

‘*She* and its siblings do the trick,’ I eventually ventured. No point in overcomplicating when I was still searching for the detail myself. ‘But not in the ordinary way, you see? I’m not *girly* – perish the thought – yet I’m not *not* a girl.’

‘Understood, darling,’ the Marquioness oozed. For someone so savage at first glance – somebody whose Catra-based contempt knew no bounds – they were bending over backwards to show kindness and consideration to *me*. Our knife-point fight didn’t mean a thing, apparently. I couldn’t make heads nor tails of them. Not in any lasting way. As I kept assessing, they kept talking.

‘Your wish is my COMMAND. To return the favour, I use *they* and *them*, though I’ve no objections if a role demands otherwise. As for genders, I experience those in a shifting, dancing, multi-dimensional way you can’t REALLY write down. Not that too many people have tried to, of course. I *would* do it myself, darling, but these hands have more important, PRETTIER uses.’

D. T. flourished them. They were delicate digits, alright. ‘Who I AM takes just as much explaining. I play plenty of parts, but I SUPPOSE the Trubel-Brightmoon one is the most relevant. You see, Sparkles and I are COUSINS, darling. Which I’m sure she finds delightful. Frankly, though, it’s the other barrel I’m asked about most often. Trubel… Trubel… *Trubel*.’

Catra briefly hitched her eyebrows and pursed her lips. Quite right. It was an even rarer moniker – and one I knew I’d heard somewhere before. J. T. leant forwards, index fingers arching, their whole being riven by a crescendo of an… ti… ci… *pation*. My mind flickered smoked cigars and tickled gin, swimming in jewel-hued velvet.

‘Give me a helping hand, would you Meowmeow? I’m so quaveringly close!’

‘I remind you that Marquioness Trubel-Brightmoon is an experienced and apparently *popular* professional performer, sir.’

‘Butter my crumpets and call me a boarding school breakfast! You’re Trubel from *Double-Trubel*!! Of Double-Trubel and The Transformations!’

‘THE very same. You’re delighted to meet me, I’m sure. Do you want an autograph? Because I would LOVE to give one!’

Well, I couldn't say no to an offer like that. One was mighty star struck. The mythical white light flashed with my surprise, dropping me home into plain old Sir Adora, which I took to mean chivalric duty and derring-do were over. At least for the time being. Catra, though grievously, fallaciously defamed, had received something approximating a full apology. And – dash it – is it really a crime to go giddy at the sight of a celebrity?

'You know, Your Royal Highness,' I babbled, 'I've seen you twice at Berkeley Square, then thrice more in the 'clubs. At least! Smashing shows, every last one. Your May residency, liege, was something *else*!! I was nibbling from the palm of your hand by the encore.'

'Glimmer WILL be jealous, darling. But thank you, of course. *Charmante.* Now, what am I signing?'

Hectically, then frantically, I searched my pockets. Pear drops, string, pennies, roll of sticking plaster… but nothing for scribbling, short of a masticated HB pencil with a snapped lead. Worse still, this ropey rod was short any surface to scrawl upon. My diary and journal were safely tucked into my cases; my planners stayed strewn across my London flat. Lady Meowmeow had the rest. She'd relieved me of the train tickets, timetables and those ghastly bloodline books days ago. If the woman had any sense, she wouldn't be carrying any of that rot now. Oh! But wait a minute! Catra was clutching *something* I could use.

'Meowmeow, madam?' I checked. 'Any chance you could pass me that letter you acquired?'

‘Are you sure that’s wise, sir?’

‘Can’t see why not! It’s been intercepted… it’s out of circulation… so… crisis averted!! And I just need one little corner of the envelope. Pretty please?’

‘If you insist.’

With treacly reluctance, my gentlewoman handed the paper over. Playing the perfect postman, I shunted it onto its next step, where it hung languidly in Double-Trubel’s grasp. They dangled it there, stepping themself back until they’d reached their auto’s far-off front bumper, beckoning me out of the others’ earshot. I followed, all the way down the Duesenberg’s very, very, *veeerrryyy* long bonnet. Or was it *hood* when a car was American? What matters is I handed them the pencil.

‘Not so fast, my QUIZZICAL Quixote. I have a question for you first, if you’ll indulge me? How about it?’ They didn’t wait for me to answer. ‘Two questions, *ac-tually*. Hmm… Which order has the right – the maximum – the complete – *DRAMATIC* effect?? Oh! That isn’t one of my queries, darling. To be clear. It’s rhetorical. And I have my answer to it… *now*. Darling, you better be ready--- you’d best be primed--- you should fizz with eagerness to assist!! Because I ONLY ask what I’m desperate to *DISCOVER*.’

‘You do this whenever you meet a fan, do you?’

‘Oh, Adora, darling, *no*. Only when I’m interested. And I am SO *rarrreeelllyyy* interested.’ They stroked back their hair and winked. ‘You should take it as a compliment.’

‘Thank you?’

‘You’re WELCOME, darling. Are we ready? Can the curtain RISE? No? Yes? Yes!’ Double-Trubel hurled up their hands in shivering delight. ‘Question the first! ADORA, darling! How did you end up “rooming” with the Alley-Cat? You two DON’T seem a likely match, if you don’t mind me saying--- And even if you do. Because it’s true.’

‘Steady on! You make it sound like we’re an item.’

‘Aren’t you? You CLEARLY like her…’

Oh goody, the beetroot was back.

‘I--- I don’t--- Of *course* I like her, but I don’t know if we *are* anything. I couldn’t say that. Not without asking her first. I’m not going to speak *for* her.’

‘*Very* admirable. Darling, I know that sounds sarcastic, but I promise it’s not.’

‘And what we *are*--- it’s beside the point! You just want to know how I made her acquaintance. Which is really very simple. I woke up one morning, two days ago, and there she was, lounging across my bedroom, smirking at me. We spoke, she fixed me breakfast, then we agreed she’d be my… *valet*?’

‘Are you ASKING me or TELLING me, dear?’

‘Telling! Because that’s what happened. She helped me pick out an outfit, then we went to meet my family. That--- that went better than I thought it would, actually. But that isn’t saying much. And--- it isn’t what you asked. Look. After that, she booked us some first class tickets on the LMS and she buttered my scones in the dining car. Did a ripping job of it, I must say! Then so more things happened, and I… um… woke up today to… see her in my bedroom… again. Which was pretty lovely.’

Double-Trubel raised an eyebrow to their hairline.

‘And you called ME a liar!’ they gasped. ‘You’re really sticking to the domestic HELP line, are you? Pur-llleeeeease. I’m not buying it for a second. Hmm-*mmmm*. It might grab you a little time with Sparkles, but you don’t HONESTLY expect to pull the wool over her eyes for long with a lie like THAT? Darling, some advice: that’s the worst gamble since October on Wall Street. Even then, even if you *do* SOMEHOW leave Sparkles in the shade, what’s your next move? I can NOT see your pretty kitty agreeing to HIDE behind closed doors. What! A! Pickle! I’d pity you, honesty, if the whole affair didn’t FASCINATE me. Oh, *Adora*, I’ll be watching!’

They were, so unfortunately, correct. Her Ladyship wasn't taking to Catra, but I'd pledged myself to protect Madam Meowmeow, which meant watching out for her happiness as much as her physical health. And I couldn't see her smiling much if I only kissed her in secret--- But nor would Glimmer thrill at ceding an inch to my new Lady. Well. There's only one thing to say at times like these. Forsooth!

Two ladies, both alike in dignity, at fair Shug-Borough, where I'd laid our scene. I could see where it was going from here. *Nascent grudge would wake to blue-blood mutiny, where civil mud makes civil brogues unclean*. It was all very--- Of The Roses. The two houses I served were at war: the friend I'd kissed against the… um… the… *Catra* I really wanted to. I'd sandwiched myself between two strong women. And not in the good way I dreamt about that time I woke up sticky! Star-crossed lovers, indeed…

'Never was a tale of more woe, darling. You'd look less wounded if I HAD shot you. So! Moving on! My second question. Ah-hum. ADORA! Just like me – like all the BEST people – you're a shapeshifter too, *right*??'

'What?! No! … Maybe! I can be this – which is me – and I can be She-Ra or Arth-Red or King Arthur or what have you. So just the two shapes. I guess you'd say I *shift* between them, but I can't do any others. I think.'

'YOU are the new SHE-RA??!? Ah! *A-dddoorrrraaa*, you really DO deliver and keep… on… *delivering*.' They folded their arms over the radiator grille and cupped their chin, taking the time to see me better. Drumming fingers, flickering lips. Suddenly, they were shaking me by the hand. 'I BELIEVE I've just decided to stick

around. Cancel my appointments, darling! This is going to be a DISASTER. I simply HAVE to see it!'

Double-Trubel flashed behind me before the words had even landed, scooping my form into their candy-chrome auto. Then we were off, all four of us aboard. The car whooshed like a luxurious eagle made of cream. You know, the sort of dessert eagle a king might eat? If that makes any sense, which I'm increasingly aware it doesn't. The passengers fussed and shrieked like its eaglets, myself possibly included. I can't say for sure. Everything was a blur. We were sweeping up the main road before I'd sussed out that Glimmer and I were sharing the back seat, with Catra and the Marquioness installed up front.

The leading pair conducted an animated conversation, punctuated by Double-Trubel's shrieked laughter and flailing limbs. They morphed between various shapes, then froze, returned to their favoured look, and pivoted around to greet me. With a flourish of pencil and paper, the fellow began writing. 'To my DEAREST Sir Adora,' they scrawled and narrated in synchronicity, 'May I go on entertaining you, as much as you're guaranteed to entertain ME. And may I go on ENCHANTING you, as much as you enchant Sparkles. With love, Your D. T.' I was shocked.

But not as shocked as Catra. You see, the Marquioness had been driving. Notionally, they still were. Their rump was still in the captain's chair. Their feet were still somewhere near the pedals. But the rest of Double-Trubel had abandoned the role in favour of my impromptu and high-speed meet-and-greet, sending Lady Meowmeow scrambling for the steering wheel. We snaked, we slithered, we got a jolly good view of an oncoming lorry. Finally, heroically, Catra took control. Neither Brightmoon appeared to

notice. They'd embroiled themselves in one corker of an argument.

'What do you mean she *enchants* me, *shit-stain*?'

'Why lie? I have EYES, darling, and SO has she.'

'She's never talked about it, though, has she? You think about that AT ALL, *fuck nugget*? *She* doesn't know. And I don't want *you* to be the one to bring it up.'

'So AFRAID of your own feelings… I pity you, darling. But it's too late now, Sparkles. The truth is DOWN in ink. Hmm. Almost ink. Down in graphite, anyway.'

'Fuck you, you utter *CUNT*.'

'What are you going to do about it, cuz? The pencil is mightier than sword.'

Glimmer picked up the Thompson machine gun – and rested its barrel against her cousin's head.

'GIVE ME THE FUCKING LETTER RIGHT THIS FUCKING MINUTE!!'

‘Temper, temper! Don’t you think the envelope should go to its RIGHTFUL owner? HERE you go, Sir Adora. It’s ALWAYS a pleasure to meet a fan, darling.’

‘DON’T YOU DARE GIVE HER THAT, YOU *PIGFUCKING BASTARD*! MOVE ONE MORE INCH AND THE NEXT SHAPE YOU SHIFT INTO IS A SHITTING COFFIN!!’

She started to fumble towards the trigger. Double-Trubel placed a finger over the barrel, asking it quite politely to just hold on a moment.

‘You will be *DELIGHTED* to hear that I’ve had a change of heart. There YOU go, Glimmer, my dear. All you ever need to do is ask nicely.’

‘Fuck you.’

‘Thank you, was that? WHY, you’re welcome!’

Her Ladyship grabbed the letter and turned it over, then over again.

‘You know, grand chum, I’d really rather like that back. I can’t say I’ve ever met a famous band-leader before. To think, all this time,

you had one in the family! Just their signature alone would spark some gossip at my club, let alone the rest of their message.'

'*Adora*. This letter. The address is in Bow's handwriting. And there's a postmark over the stamp. Bow sent this to his dads, didn't he? So why the FUCK did your little law-breaker lackey have it in her waistcoat pocket?!'

'Ah. Well. You see. Your Ladyship, you really are going to laugh about this in a moment, I promise. There's a perfectly good expl---'

'I don't want to hear it, Adora. This *twat* of a servant DARED to confront my cousin with her *bullshit* story, and it turns out she's still a *fucking thief*. So guess what? She can walk from here. If she's got any sense, she'll keep walking until she's as far away from me as she can POSSIBLY *fucking* get. Cuz! Stop the car! Right now!'

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Chapter 21

Chapter Summary

'I see how it was, eh, Adora? For Catra it's the bum's rush - and for you it's the berries. Chapter 21 is pretty enlightening! I disappear for five minutes and you're zozzled nines ways from Sunday, you're spifflicated on giggle water, you're spitting up horsefeathers, you're living the life copacetic---'

'Slow down, my love, um, what?'

'This chapter. It's a real tale of the Jazz Age. Are you always this exciting when I'm not around? I don't know whether to be proud or annoyed...'

'Oh, Catra! It would have been much more fun with you there. Maybe we can---'

'I don't think the owner is going to lend us the Duesenberg, Adora. Not after what happened.'

Chapter Notes

Content warnings apply for the below chapter only - Spoilers may be present in the warnings. This story does not include any of the four Archive Warnings topics, but does occasionally feature other topics that may require content notes.

Chapter 21 Content Warnings (CONTAINS SPOILERS):
Threat of gun violence - narrated, present (no gun violence occurs)
Threat of violence to animals - narrated, present (no violence to animals occurs)
Drink-driving - narrated, present

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PART 21

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Unfolding from the auto, Meowmeow stopped, dusted herself down, then folded again, this time from the waist. The bow was an art piece amongst its kind. Cold. Formal. Aimed sharply at Glimmer. Double-Trubel and I shot each other enquiring peeks, forming for ourselves an uneasy entente. Without passing a single word, they and I decided that two heads really are better than one, when it comes to scolding an opalescent scoundrel. We stared hard into Lady Brightmoon. *Why, it's beyond the pale*, we unspeakingly said. *The very nerve!*

She – the madam we were quite cross at, not the other – refused our gazes. The nearest either of got to acknowledgement was a chin-flicked *Ha-umph*. Unbelievable. Glimmer really meant to maroon a woman in the centre of a 3000-acre forest, leaving her with no recourse to maps, compasses, or even a robust pair of shoes. And Catra was letting her do it! I'd say the mind boggled, but burned is more like it. My newly-installed sense of She-Raian justice wasn't having any of it. Either all of House de la Meowrde departed or the whole homestead remained – but a serviced apartment divided cannot stand.

'If you're getting out, Meowmeow, then I'm disembarking too, damn it.'

'YES, darling. Mark ME amongst the Alley-Cat's number.'
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‘Sir.’ Catra bowed. ‘Liege. I appreciate the sentiment, but there really is no need. Her Ladyship has made herself plain. She must, therefore, receive exactly what she *requires*. I shall see you all again, at Shugborough.’

‘You should be so *fucking* lucky.’

‘I do hope so, madam.’

Catra bowed again, then strode off with enviable purpose. Her feet trod a mud-strewn and barely-there pathway with the kind of conviction to which my sorties down the Strand will always aspire henceforth. After a minute or so, she faded from view, ushering first the ferns, then the firs from her path with stately sweeps of her manicure. The forest gloom had claimed her. Would it ever let her go, or would some sensational centaur within its depths romance her, claiming her heart for a life of Lesbian woodland bliss? It might sound fantastical but I was quite genuinely concerned. If *I* could be an ancient magical being, who couldn’t?!

‘*Glimmer*,’ I asserted. This was rapidly turning into an Honour-Of-situation. ‘Would you mind awfully not treating my gentlewoman so flipping poorly? What has she done to you, eh?’

‘Um. *Adora*. Ohmigosh. Did you just shove your nose into my affairs? Shit, that’s not very *chivalric* of you. Just sayin’. Cuz. *Drive*.’

‘Sparkles, this is a new level of coldness. Even for *you*.’

‘I’m *sorry*, what was that? Because it sounded like you gave me your crap-flecked opinion – when I didn’t *ask* for it. Get moving.’

‘Whatever you say, my ICE queen.’

The motor burred expensively. Glimmer produced a pair of mirrored glasses and her snuff box, chewing on what might have just been tobacco. And equally well may not have been. She stared at the sky unfurling above us, sighing at intervals. Shoulder braced and elbow locked, her left hand aimed a gun at the heavens above, its barrel pointed at a cluster of Canada Geese. She mouthed the ratting-tatting sounds of shooting them, grinning a little, then squeezed curiously at the trigger. Her finger waivered and she threw the whole thing down.

I was silent, not knowing at all what to say. The Marquioness was almost the same. After five minutes of this exhibition, they dropped a finger back to beckon me, whispering into my bended ear.

‘Not going very well, IS it Sir She-Ra? And we’re deep into Act One now, darling, so most dramatic models would say your situation is about to get much, MUCH worse. Then even worse. Then maybe better.’

‘An improvement wouldn’t go amiss, eh. How do we rush to that bit?’

‘Darling! We don’t. Theatre canNOT be hurried. Events must unfurl at their proper, *scripted* pace, or you’ll destroy the tension. And the *pathos*, with it. You want me rooting for you when you achieve *catharsis*, don’t you?’

‘That’s a dashed strange term for bedroom stuff, isn’t it? And it won’t happen unless she wants it too. And why would we tell you about any of that, anyhow?’

‘And there *I* was, thinking *Sweet Lady Meowmeow* was JUST your household help…’

‘Oh. Rats.’

‘In case it matters, darling---’ Double-Trubel drew themselves back, shook their head, then laughed at three of their own fingertips. ‘What am I SAYING, Adora? Obviously, it matters! It is the *THEATRE*, darling, and it holds all life, truth and secret scandal!’

I stared, blankly.

‘ANYWAY… *Catharsis* is an ancient Grecian dramatic term for the letting out and purifying, usually of a strongly emotional nature.

To think, darling! That *I* would engage in something as DEPRAVED as innuendo!'

They winked, smiling from an upturned corner of their expression, then mouthed that they were having great big globs of fun. Which was just as well. Someone ought to be. Before Trubel-Brightmoon could burr additional ill omens in my direction, Her Ladyship beckoned me rearwards to my seat. Inhaling from a jade-hued cigarette holder, she blew a kiss towards me, leant back and slammed a fist against the upholstery. Swish went a hinge and down crashed a door to delight.

'Urrgh. That was just the worst, wasn't it, Adora? Let's take the edge off.'

Out came several twinkling decanters. Cut crystal to a man, they sloshed with temptation. Now. Don't get me wrong. I was still steamed about turfing out Catra – a wrong remains a wrong, after all, no matter how much liquor enters the equation – but my palette was parchment. A fellow is only so strong, see? Discombobulated as my day had been, my suppings so far had numbered nothing more than a few hauls on Lady Meowmeow's flask and an earlier, bedside Darjeeling.

My gentlewoman had presented my waking tea perfectly: warming the cup; timing the brew; and tickling the saucer with the daintiest confectioneries imaginable. A truly touching moment. The best I'd had today, in fact, given the odds of our kissing seemed to lengthen by the minute. But even Pu'erh won't do the trick when bullets rend the air. Damnation, I deserved a drink! No matter that it was served by the source of my recent strife.

Betraying my latest Lady went down as an awfully bitter pill, mind. Hmm. This two mistresses matter was getting tougher by the minute. Plus points and minuses needed weighing – and I had only until Glimmer picked out her nectars of choice to make up my mind. Cripes. Hadn't Meowmeow left the auto somewhat voluntarily? And wasn't it an unbelievable etiquette blunder to refuse the offers of a kindly Countess? More pressingly, hadn't the little hand just clockwork-clicked its way past six? Matters would be seriously amiss if I entered the Cocktail Hours without a tipple in hand. Dash it. Let bygones be bygones. For now.

'Oh, my devoted knight,' Glimmer sighed. 'Could you do a little something, just for me? Press that clip on the floor, babe, then get your feet out of the way.'

Another case swung open, sending an icy blast up my trouser leg.

'Glimmer?! Is that… a refrigerator?!'

'Yup. Get me the Cobbler, a bar spoon and the crushed ice. Thanks, babe! Actually, Adora… You know what? Just shovel it in for me. Don't worry if it goes everywhere, someone'll clean it up. I guess.' I ducked under the cowl and got to scooping, labouring under a deep apprehension of any upcoming swerves or bumps. High above, her Ladyship held sway. 'Hey! Cuz! You want one?'

'Sparkles. I'm DRIVING--- so don't fill it as high as last time. Put mine in a deeper chalice or something.'

Lady Brightmoon grabbed the shaker, cheek-kissing a thank you, then slammed away at the liquids. Scotch, brandy and Italian vermouth sloshed home in equal measures, topped with a matching glug of orange juice. For the shake, she chose violence. The metal slammed part-inches from my skull, before depositing an angry amber elixir into triplet coupes.

'Thanks a bunch, glitterbug. Looks smashing. But just what the devil is it?'

Glimmer drained her first in a blink, then busied herself fixing another.

'Oh, Dory! Haha. Auntie been keeping you locked up?' she laughed. 'Where the shit have you been? It's a Blood and Sand: they're all the rage at *The Savoy* this summer! I order one *every* time I'm there. So ultra trendy, right? Plus they fuck you up *good*. Why aren't you ever around to drink them with me?'

'Henley was less than a week ago, wasn't it?'

'It seems soooooooooo much longer. Uhh. Why can't you stick around with me all the time? You've really missed out these last couple of days. And I've been missing you. So, so, so, *soooo* much!!'

‘Well. I’m here now, aren’t I? Bottoms up and so on!’

I forget how many we hammered back, which itself indicates something about the number. Nor can I recall exactly what happened over the next little while. Somewhere within the blurry snatches – speeding, swerving, kissing, quarrelling – we stumbled inside Shugborough and deposited ourselves in the Red Drawing Room. The chamber was remarkably rose-tinted and very Austen-tatious. You know? Super showy in a Georgian sort of way. We’d traded Double-Trubel for Bowregard along the way, squeezing the Capital Chum Crew together on a not-quite-large-enough settee. Glimmer was in the middle, grinning, naturally.

Plates clattered into view, silver rattling against porcelain. We had, apparently, ordered a very late afternoon tea. Chomping into tartlets and cucumber sandwiches, underpinned by the usual dispute around whether one properly pronounces it “scone” or “scone”, conversation gradually coalesced into something I *can* remember. One moment, in particular, jolted me and my Doctorate-destined chum to the rafters. Which is saying something, when the roof is quite so far from the floorboards.

‘Bow?!’ Glimmer hummed. ‘Can I tell you something really super fucking *scandalous*? Remember how you wrote a letter your dads? It never got sent out.’

Bowregard lit up like a spotlight.

‘It didn’t?! Really? Somebody stopped it? Adora. *Adora*, tell me. Is it true?’

‘Absolutely, old chum. Intercepted at the post office itself.’

‘Ohhh! Hug time! Come here, you.’

The fellow shot up and squeezed me with vice-like conviction. A downcast Glimmer folded her arms.

‘I was *trying* to tell you a story. Bow, can I please finish?’

‘Oh, yeah, sure. Glimmer, go for it!’

‘Adora isn’t telling the whole story. Your letter was *stolen*… by that new Alley-Cat valet she’s got.’

‘Meowmeow?!’

‘She’s the fucking worst, right? It was just wedged there in her pocket, for everyone to see. She didn’t even try to deny it. What a *bastard*. But don’t worry. I did what our “brave” knight couldn’t and disciplined the servant-girl. She’s still trying to find some way off the Chase, I guess, while *I* saved the day and sent one of the footmen out with your letter. By now, your note should be safely back with the Royal Mail. I even gave strict instructions for their staff, to make sure they don’t hand it over to *anyone* except your dads.’

‘*Glimmer?!*’

‘I know, I’m the best friend. You’re super welcome, Bowregard.’

‘No, Glimmer!! I mean, yes, sure, you’re a really, really, *really* good friend and I appreciate you being in my life. But I *asked* Adora to get the letter back. I told my dads I was in Cambridge. If I send them anything from here, they’ll know I’m, like, *here* instead. And they’ll make me do library research. *Advanced* library research. Oh gee. Oh no. I’m in so much trouble.’

He’d jumped up and started pacing, fast enough to send a breeze across the room. The teacups tinkled, while her Ladyship morphed from triumph to upset perplexity.

‘But--- But Adora hired a *thief*,’ she stammered. ‘Doesn’t she make you suspicious? Cuz knew her from Germany. And not in a good way!’

‘Meowmeow was *helping*.’

I nibbled awkwardly at a slice of Battenburg, too sozzled to fight Catra’s corner and too fed up to acquiesce to Glimmer’s point of view. At a time like this, I mused, peeling the marzipan off each side of my squared slice, one rather prays for a dash of divine intervention. Anything had to be better than trying to fix the

situation single-handed. Unseen, in the corridor, Fate was quietly slipping lead into an opera glove.

'GLIMMMM-AHH!'

'*SHIT!*' our friend shout-whispered. Stalking to her feet with as much subtlety as the heavily inebriated might muster, she frantically swept various liquor bottles beneath the furniture. They crashed and clinked against the parquet flooring, summoning a barrage of shits and fucks and craps and pissflaps and cocksuckers and arsewipes from our host. 'No, no, no, no, no, no, no. NO!! She's not meant to get back until Wednesday.'

'Uh, Glimmer,' Bow ventured. 'Today *is* Wednesday.'

'Pearl Bonnibel Glimmer Luna Amity Terrington Brightmoon,' the Duchess intoned. Crisply furious, I'd call the tone. 'I know you're in there. Get out here, this instant!'

'Just a mi--- *hick*--- minute, mater.'

'The staff reported a tall, blonde woman visiting the house. I *do* hope you haven't invited that shameless de l'Horde girl.'

'Oh no, oh no, oh no,' Bow continued. I grabbed him by the elbow and guided us towards the largest window.

‘Get the latch, would you?’ I murmured. ‘Before we’re both sent home to angry authority figures?’

‘Uhhhh. *M-uuummm*,’ Glimmer hollered back. ‘I get it, you don’t like Adora. No, I deliberately didn’t send her an invitation, just like you said.’

‘Well!’ I hissed. ‘Thanks for the bite and the drinks and the not shooting me and so on. Smashing stuff, really. But the time’s come for Bow and me to skedaddle, if it’s all the same? Ta-ta!’

‘No! Adora! When will I see you again?’

‘Don’t worry, glitterbug. We’re not going anywhere, not if I can help it.’ I ventured a smile. ‘See you first thing tomorrow, just before the fete. Knight’s honour!’

And away we went, vaulting the window-frame just as the drawing room doors burst open.

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Chapter 22

Chapter Summary

'What and Ho, readers. In the following missive, Adora does her best impression of me, Catra. She plots and she plans. She is easily, Sapphically suave. She cares deeply for others, and helps them. Of course, that last point is no stretch for her range. In return, I've decided to introduce the Chapter by channelling her. To wit: It is very much cricket... Protein is vital... Horses... Jolly hockey sticks... I would wear the same suit for a week, if Catra did not intervene... I worship my fiancée as a goddess... I should learn to let her do the same... Cocktails... Sports cars... I must keep internalising that my worth is more than I might give to other people...'

'CATRA!! I don't sound like that! Do I?'

'You sound, sir, like a symphony divine, which I will never tire of hearing.'

Chapter Notes

Content warnings apply for the below chapter only - Spoilers may be present in the warnings. This story does not include any of the four Archive Warnings topics, but does occasionally feature other topics that may require content notes.

Chapter 22 Content Warnings (CONTAINS SPOILERS):
Vehicle accident, boat - referenced, historic (no injury occurs)

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PART 22
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When one has her back against the wall, it's time to turn around and fight! Let not my sword sleep in my hand, and all that. My surviving hours at Shugborough could be dashed scarce, so I had to make every second count. Treading the flagstones with my fleetest feet, I inched sideways, wedding my shadow to the lengthening gloom that began to pool across the veranda. Head jerked, and eyebrow raised, I beckoned Bowregard to follow.

The chap shook both arms in frantic disengagement. He wanted out. He wanted to go no further. But tough biscuits, Georgeson! Surrender was no longer an option. We could hardly step back through the window and into the fanged jaws of a Duchess, nor should we walk 'round to the front door, pull the bell rope and subject ourselves to the same, only with more formality. Decisions had been made. And I was about to make more. So. Chap. Hurry it along, already!

All this I conveyed in a pair of chin flicks: one to the pane from whence we came; and another to my own shady position, hidden amidst a leafy trellis. Bow kept shimmying. Huff and humph. He had to hurry his uptake, else we'd both stand in the stocks before the night was through. I rolled my eyes, channelling my best Double-Trubel, then gestured with my every element at the window, cupping a hand to my ear for good measure. Within, Countess and Duchess were really going at it.

Roses were the current hot topic. More specifically, the elder Brightmoon demanded to know how her prize-winning patch had turned to mud, plus just what, precisely, Bow and I had to do with it. Ever the attentive listener – having finally caught on – the
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fellow jumped out of his skin. He mouthed something urgent. I can't offer specifics, but I wagered he meant something along the lines of "What are we going to do, Adora?!"

Well. I couldn't answer him out loud. One word and we were curtains. One sound, even. Which is precisely why I'd ducked left, facilitating an easy concealment behind the early-season ivy. Poison ivy, if the welts developing across my knuckles were anything to go by. I shoved my hands in my pockets, then pulled them straight back out. They were the answer. For what does the festively-inclined Etherian know better than a fraught round of charades? Thank you, Auntie! The icy silence of Christmas Past was about to save the day.

Bow, you see, had darted right. He now stood stranded against the masonry that separated the twin drawing room windows, risking detection if he so much as stepped forwards, back or out. Tricky stuff. Three parts, my fingers gestured. I wasn't miming a book, song or flick, so we could dispense with that bit. A risk remained that he might confuse my triplicate digits for a title. Pointing at him and running stealthily on the spot, I tried to nip that in the bud. He needed to follow my actions.

Dash it, I'd been too smart for our own good. Bowregard peered at me in confusion, then shrugged and started walking. Now it was my turn to wave back, begging him to stop. He snapped to a halt and here was my moment. I acted a lasso, spinning it high and fast, then throwing the rope over him. And pulling it. Tight. Second bit, I signalled. I slammed the bound Bow to the patio. A gasp, then he complied. Part three was all elbows and knees. Dropping to the same squat, I indicated the direction of travel and demonstrated my desired wormy-squirm.

Anxious minutes after, the fellow was at my side. He drew himself up and started on an indignant, “Adorr---- mmmpppfffh!!” Sorry, old chap, it had to be done. Mouth smothered and wrist grasped, I jerked him down a step, then hauled us both beneath one of the distinctive drops which form Shugborough’s back lawn. Odd things, of no other use. But perfect for this purpose. Holding a shushing finger to his lips, I let go, then begged my friend to follow me. We were going through the hedge. I got some pushback on that, orbiting around its fir-based construction. Thick, pointy, impenetrable. These are just some of the facets Bow may have articulated with his indignant pointing. He didn’t look too happy.

Fair enough, I suppose! I belly-slunk forwards and unsheathed Ms. Floaty-Cane, making mental pleas against She-Raian transformation. Not now! Please! The last things we wanted were blinding lights and glimmering rainbows. My blade acquiesced – I think – and set to secateur action. Swish and smash, we soon had our escape route. We were through. Out of sight and, I dared hope, sufficiently out of mind. A busy evening laid ahead, and I wanted entanglements at a minimum.

Tip-toeing along the topiary, us two emerged on the riverside path. The West Wing and much of the upper floors might still perceive us, but only from a substantial distance. I didn’t intend invisibility tonight, anyhow. All Bow and I needed was to stay away from the Duchess and – by extension – from Glimmer. Sorry, glitterbug. Whenever those two got into it, they wouldn’t disengage until they were each unconscious. Going back was just too risky. For now, the obscuring shrubbery was our shield. Neither Brightmoon could see us.

But that wouldn’t last. One room is one room, a star within the cosmos of their entire estate. Dashing out, I pulled us left, into the treeline. Dinner and dalliances awaited family Brightmoon, no doubt, so our time within the mansion grounds was short. Pause and it was over. Focus, Sir Adora! Too much was on the line here. Glimmer stuck in Staffordshire. Bow the dust-flecked docent. Adora the finishing-school filly or the Naval officer, depending on which relative got to me first. I shuddered. Fates barely worth considering.

‘Our goose? … gooses? … geese?’ I hissed as we strode off, trying for all the world to look like a couple of chums on their evening constitutional. ‘Our pluralised goose are cooked if we don’t get on the road, pronto. You have to get that letter back, again, and I need to find Meowmeow. I swore to protect her, Bow! But she’s out there on the Chase, facing who knows what, without even a suit jacket.’

‘Adora? How could you just leave her there?’

‘I *didn’t*. It was Glimmer’s idea and Catra just… went along with it. She wouldn’t even let me stay by her side, so now she’s out there alone, and it’ll get dark soon, and there could be all kinds of dangerous wildlife, and she doesn’t have a map, and I drank most of what she had in the hipflask, and we were so close to… We never got to…’

‘Wait. Just wait a minute. I’m *really* confused. Am I the only one who’s confused? Who’s Catra?’

‘Meowmeow--- Sorry--- Catra is Meowmeow.’

‘Oh!’ Bow gasped. ‘You’re on first name terms! Adorrraaa…’

‘I… um… could you just… quit it already? This is NOT the time!! I knew Kyle’s name too, didn’t I? For all *that* was worth.’

‘Hey!! I *liked* Kyle.’

‘Well, good. Because we need to make like the chap and vanish. Fast. How do we get out of here?’

‘Hmm.’ Bow rubbed his chin, glorying in the strands that now sprouted there. ‘Hmmmmm. If we keep going until we’re almost at the blue bridge, we can curve back on the outer path, through the pinetum. That brings us out just west of the servants’ quarters.’

‘Windows?’

‘Not on that side. They face into their courtyards or out to the south.’

‘Champion! I knew I could count on Brasenose Bow, best back-street navigator in all of Oxford!! Where would we be going next?’

‘Umm. South. We’d be going south. And the main house has a really, really huge number of windows in that direction. Come to think of it, the west wing has loads of windows going, well, west. And a door. They wouldn’t see us until we were past the other buildings. But then we’d be, like, *super* obvious.’

‘Ah. Bobbins. Any way we can do that without being spotted?’

His stroking extended down his neck. Can’t blame the fellow – he was on the cusp of cultivating quite the marvellous beard.

‘We could cut through the trees and over the field. There’s a line of sight to the house when we cross the drive and pass the tower, but we’d be too far away to identify. Unless they had a telescope! *Adora*. Does the Duchess have a telescope?’

‘I don’t think so.’

‘Okay. O-kay. Then we keep going, cross the farm and we’re free!’

‘Actually, it’s more difficult than that,’ I rued. It really was too. ‘If we don’t pull this off without a hitch – and if Glimmer can’t sufficiently placate her warpath matriarch – then I won’t be treading feet in Shugborough for a good long while, don’t you think? And that’s just the stickiest wicket. I’d have to abandon my

apologising, of course, but I'd also be making a mockery of my word.'

'Oh. Is this a chivalry thing?'

'The very same, old sport. I promised you a way out of your postal predicament, and Catra my protection. But I also swore an oath of Lesbian assistance to Scorpy, to aid her in asking out and hopefully securing a date with Lady Plumers. And I will not leave a peer in the lurch! Ergo we're going to locate those two women, and make sure they come with us.'

'How, Adora? How are we going to do that?'

'Don't worry, dearest Bow. I have a plan!'

'You said that at the Regatta---'

'I solemnly swear this scheme involves zero boats,' I confirmed. 'Besides, I've had far longer to think of this one. It's been stewing in the mental cavities for upwards of three minutes, encroaching on four, and I've yet to detect a single flaw.'

Cross my heart, every word was true. Taking my inspiration from Meowmeow herself, I'd dreamed up a scenario where the world was my chequerboard and the critical players my chess pieces. In a short series of interconnected moves, each glued to the next by

yours truly, our fates would be switched about by bedtime. It'd be a late lights out, by some measures, I'll grant. But my certainty grew by the second. We'd have settled heads on satin pillows before dawn came a-calling.

Bowregard refused to see it quite that way. In fact, the chap fretted awfully. My track record, he proclaimed, was nothing to boast about. I was bound to break more than I mended. The interventions I'd planned would only make things worse. Yes, yes. All of that. None of it swayed me. So far as I could see it, my chum had the worst prospects possible already. When a boat hits the riverbed, I reminded him, there's simply nowhere further for it to sink. We'd learned that in Henley. He grimaced rather, then set into a full scowl when I explained that my plan had already sparked into action.

Why else would I have plucked him from the palace, eh? His presence at Shugborough was entirely above board, daddies dearest aside. And I hardly required the fellow to identify his own handwriting. I'd seen its geometric flicks aplenty, not to mention how I very much doubted the village post office bore more than one envelope with a note scrawled from Double-Trubel to me across its obverse. For what purposes, then, was Bowregard here with me? He was very keen to know. Well. That was simplicity itself. I could hardly help Scorpy without a mind that knew her location, and a face free to commute there.

'Oh!' he replied. 'Adora. That--- that's pretty smart. You know, it might actually work.'

Off the good chap trotted, our mutual trusts restored. We set our watches and a rendezvous. A quarter-hour to communicate with a

respective maiden and transport them to the outer boundary of the walled garden, ready to venture far further afield. For my part, that meant picking through the aforementioned route, cursing the brambles as they nipped at trouser legs, then summoning my inner Glimmer to eviscerate a cow pat that snuck up on my innocent boots. Bow had not made my going easy! I lost two or three precious minutes just wiping my shoes clean, putting me right up against it.

I strode into the glasshouse with renewed purpose, eager not to waste a moment more. Charming Lady P was snipping and snapping at some frightfully geometric flowers, which she'd positioned along the back wall. They were all aligned by colour, forming a fragrant rainbow, overseen by buckets of bunting. *Welcome to Shugborough!* said a central banner. *It's Blooming Nice To Meet You!*

'How brave peonies are,' I ventured. If quotations worked for Lady Meowmeow, then why not for me, eh? 'O beautiful new world, what has in't things in't.'

'She-Ra?! You're up!' Lady Plumers dropped her trowel in her surprise. It tinkled to the floor, followed by her gardening gauntlets. The pearl-studded princess rushed over to me, tears twinkling at the verges of her watercolour eyes. 'Thank you, She-Ra!! Thank you so much… for saving my life. You really *are* a hero!'

'All in the day's work of a righteous knight, your Ladyship.'

‘Oh! You silly sausage! You don’t need to be so modest, She-Ra, not when you risked your body to save mine! Thank you. Thank you so much! I don’t know how to say thank you enough… I don’t think I ever will. I always knew there was something special about you. I can see it! In your aura!’

She did the clappy-smiley routine, freckles dancing about her dimples. I let her hug me and her embrace was gentleness, sensitivity and respect combined, underpinned by delicate florals.

‘Yes. Well. Quite. Now, the thing is, Lady P, I’ve come here tonight with a question. A dashed urgent one. I can scarcely waste another second without spitting the thing out, if you’ll allow me.’

‘Of course. Anything for my She-Ra!’

I bowed full length, then thought better of it, and nudged myself into kneeling. Scorpia dreamed of romance, so romantic my proposition must be! What more to do? I cleared my throat, shook out my hair, and offered my hand to the green-fingered goddess of Scorpy’s desire. My gaze met Perfuma just long enough to see her eyes a-quiver, before I looked modestly aside. Spying a dead-headed rose, I scooped the snow-white bloom between two fingers, then offered it up. The passionate planter took it, placing her fingers in mine.

‘Lady Perfuma Plumers, would you please accompany me to Cannock Chase to watch the sunset? A certain woman wants to spend the evening with you. It would mean the world to her.’

She gasped.

‘Oh, my *goodness*! Of course. But when?’

‘Now. Right now. It has to be now! I can’t help thinking you’ll adore the way the dusk prickles across the blushing heather and the purple bracken, as the new life emerges from the fiery remains of a winter passed.’

‘How *romantic*!’

Trust Catra to come up with the goods. Her dating advice was working wonderfully, without Scorpia even setting foot in the room. I’d articulated the inescapable and relational Sapphic feelings at the heart of the matter, set a location safe from prying eyes, and articulated fascination in Perfuma’s interests. Lady Meowmeow gets the credit for that last sentence of mine, too. Beautiful, evocative and all the rest, she’d invented the utterance during the first few, uninterrupted moments of our walk. Just thinking back to it made me all gooey! If I’m any judge, the magic words had Lady P feeling much the same.

‘But what will I wear? I don’t have time to change!’

‘The certain woman worships you like a goddess, no matter your clothes.’

‘Awwhhhh!!’ Perfuma sighed a smile. ‘How will we get there?’

‘We’ll walk, taking in every inch of the forest along the way. That’s we why have to leave this instant, your Ladyship. I can’t keep sundown waiting, and I know the precise spot where I want you to see it.’

‘You’re so *sensitive*! And so brave! She-Ra, you have *sooooo* many depths!’

‘Chivalry is my watchword, madam. And when the walk is through, I’ve already thought how to whisk you home. Whether you want to nap on that certain woman’s shoulder, or squeeze her hand as your hearts race, your loyal knight will be at the wheel. I’ve got a car out there, ready and waiting.’

Lady P dusted down her skirts and ducked out of her apron, then skipped off and out the doorway. I looked on in confusion, unsure just how well I’d handed off my middleman missive. As if to answer, Perfuma pranced back in, sticking her head around the door.

‘Come on then, Adora! You don’t want to leave your gal waiting!’

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Chapter 23

Chapter Summary

'...'

'Adora, what are you doing?'

'Well, Catra, you copied me last time, so I thought this Chapter I'd do my impression of you. But you aren't in it. At all. Which is a terrible shame. Hence the silence.'

'So what does the Chapter contain?'

'An awful lot! Your wisdom, my concern about you, crossed wires, a renegotiated friendship, and a passage in not very fluent rodent-ese.'

'That's my fiancée - always full of surprises! It's just one of the reasons I can't wait to marry you.'

Chapter Notes

Content warnings apply for the below chapter only - Spoilers may be present in the warnings. This story does not include any of the four Archive Warnings topics, but does occasionally feature other topics that may require content notes.

Chapter 23 Content Warnings (CONTAINS SPOILERS):
Major character's conversational boundaries disrespected - narrated, related, present, highlighted, full apology follows

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PART 23
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‘Oh! Look, Adora! The eve is young, and the day walks away from us. See how the flowers turn their heads, swaying to follow those low, last sunny rays just as far as they can! Hark! Listen closely, over there, where the shadows stretch. Can’t you just hear the bugs and the beetles and all the other little wrigglers as they rustle to the surface, ready for their turn on our hallowed turf? Isn’t it lovely? Nature and me – and you – in perfect balance! I can even smell the dust as it dances off to the heavens, leaving us just the smallest shiver as its parting gift.’

‘The humidity is curling and swirling, don’t you think? My chest is all pitter-patter! It’s rising fast, Adora: we’ve got a muggy night coming. Feel my arms, won’t you? The hairs are all on end, like I’ve got goosebumps. But don’t worry, She-Ra, my sweetie! The rain’s going to sweep straight on past us, I just know it! Tonight and tomorrow are like girlfriends out on the town. They’ve got such different personalities but they’re each so beautiful, and linked together by smiles and smooches, which only makes them prettier still!! Aren’t you *so* excited for the fête? I know I am!’

Lady P skipped across the grounds in honest, earnest leaps. She was so set on Sapphic cheer already, I reckoned, that the imminent sight of Scorpy could only generate all out glee. Romantic rendezvous, here we come! I was feeling pretty smug, in all honesty. My schemes were playing out perfectly and – though I’m loathe to curse a work in progress – the operation’s toughest stint was almost through. Once we trotted o’er the boundary fence, trouble could barely touch us. Until we got back to Shugborough, that is. And I’d cross that bridge when we got to it, both figuratively and literally.
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For now, the de l'Horde shoe leather slipped down easy street. I mean, just think about it! Who ever came to grief on a countryside ramble? Apart from Catra and me, earlier this afternoon. Or Catra, again, right now. Yes. Mulling on that really brought my mood down. In the present moment, for all I knew, sweet Lady Meowmeow was wandering through field and over heath, her shirt sleeves billowing in the breeze. They flapped to a frenzy as she trekked up a rocky outcrop and lifted one hand to her eyes, shielding a gaze that swept across the valley below. Her eyes – her bewitching stare – searched oh-so-plaintively for her road home, back to her gentlewoman.

The thought troubled me greatly. Why else would I spend so long thinking it, going back and over its ever detail? Our group, then, would venture much more carefully, sticking to the marked and mapped-out public footpaths. When Cathy was lost and forlorn on those Yorkshire Moors, Heathcliff could have grabbed a far happier ending, if only he'd availed himself of an Ordnance Survey map. That's all I'm saying! What use losing four more bright young things in a forest, especially with the summer equinox almost upon us?

I'd suffered through enough theatre to know what happened next, if we were foolish enough to waylay the waymarkers. We'd all be married to each other by morning. Possibly that was good news for Scorps and Lady P – but not so much for me! Bowregard is a fine fellow, no doubt, but my amore hardly flowed in his direction. And a wedding band would fatally wound my chances with Catra. Of course, stranding her somewhere wouldn't augur too well either… and she was certainly the sort to beat her own path. Hmm. This was turning tricky. My brows knit hard together. I had to do some thinking.

Perfuma glanced over me with concern, or awe, or some mingling of the two. Quite inadvertently, I'd become the strong, silent type. She gasped and cooed, her delicate fingers knitting over each other as she wove daisy chain distractions. Every now and then, the Lady would ask my opinion on something. Not being the height of rudeness, I murmured vague positives in reply, without ever really understanding what I'd been asked. I simply didn't have chit-chat capacity. My every spare synapse was hard at work. How, I wondered, could I save Catra from her Brontëan fate, without abandoning our night to middle-summer dreaming?

There was nothing for it. We – or I alone, if the route looked perilous – had to walk in the wilderness. Not for the whole trip, you understand, but at the critical junctures. Forks, splits, likely hidey-holes. It might even make sense to check the copse where she'd been turfed out of the car, to get a glance of her footprints. Or make a plaster cast of them! Wait. No. We couldn't do that without the right materials, and the village shop wouldn't re-open until morning. Then what could we do right now? Track her scent? How did Lady Meowmeow smell?

Heavenly, that's how. To breathe her in is to be enchanted and desperate to learn more. I could conjure her scent precisely – its sophistication and femininity, its warmth and safety – but none of it boiled down into a term my chums knew how to sniff. Tricky stuff. And with scant odds of onlookers, our only other option was chatting to the wildlife. Could Lady P speak with squirrels? Could Scorpy? She-Ra might, come to think of it. My usually chipper features were still scowling from the consideration when I bumped into Bow.

‘Ow,’ he said. ‘Adora! Are you feeling okay?’

‘*Squeak-squeak chiirrruuppp*, old chum. *Ch-chup squeak fu-fu-fuh?*’

‘Adora?’

‘*Skwee? Nu-fuh, squeak squeak: fu-fu-chir. Chiiiiiirrrrrruppp!*’

‘We’re okay. It’s okay. Is everything okay? You’re scaring me, Adora---’

Damn it, was squirrel a tonal tongue? It felt like it might be. There’s little trickier for a mouth weaned on Prime’s Etherian than needing to exactly inflect every single letter. What if I made a mistake? What if that mistake offended some poor critter, who was only heading off for a nibble at the local nut shack when she stopped by to help me? I’d need a tail, I reckoned. For emphasis.

‘*Chirrrp*,’ I added, flicking my nape hither and thither. ‘*Chirrrupp! CHIRRURRRPP!!*’

‘Ohhhhh!’ replied Scorpy. Finally! Someone was getting it. ‘Hiya, Emily! It’s good to see you too, girl. But when did you learn to look like Adora? Wait, have you even met Adora? And does she know about this? I don’t think you should be taking other people’s

forms without asking them first – that's not very nice. Me and Entrapta talked about it. After last time.'

'*Brrrpppphhh?*'

'I know, I know!! But Emily, the mayor didn't see it that way. We got in trouble. And Adora is in a LOT of trouble already, I think. She doesn't need any more.'

I nodded. Crossed wires or none, she'd hit the bullseye there. Hence practising my squirrel.

'Wait a minute--- Emily, is Adora even a real person? Or is she just the new form you're taking? She is, isn't she?! Oh, Emily! I'm so happy for you! You look like such a cutey-pie--- I hope it's exactly how you want to look. But--- Oh, gee. Where are my manners? I really didn't mean to offend. What do I call you now, Adora or Emily?'

'Scorpia!' Lady P intruded. 'I don't think that's right. We've spent the last few *divine* minutes together and Adora couldn't be less of a robot. She's more connected to the natural world than you could possibly imagine!'

'What? Is? Happening? Why won't Adora speak Etherian? And why do you both think she's somebody else? You don't even think she's the same somebody else!! I've known her for years, and she's always had flesh, and blood, and the ability to kill every plant she

looks at, but apparently that's all wrong? Then who is she? Oh no. If she's not Adora, then who am *I*?'

'She's Emily, unless she's Adora,' Scorpia nodded.

'That doesn't help. Who's Emily?'

'Entrapta's friend and helper. And my friend too! She's a robot with a resistor of gold!!'

'No, no, sorry Scorpia, I really don't agree. She *is* Adora, Bowregard, but she's also my saviour! She's the new She-Ra!'

'What? WHAT?? ADORRAAA!! You're the She-Ra?! The ancient magical being of First Ones myth, who appears in troubled times to fight monsters and save people?! The giant woman? With the glowing sword?!'

'Well, yes, old chap. I thought you knew?'

'NO!!'

'Oh. I suppose you weren't there for that bit. Well, you know now, I suppose! Ditto Scorpia. Charming to see you again, by the way,

Scorpy! Give my regards to the mel--- mangoes. Shall we get going? There's a sunset to see, and all that.'

I went to go – for all of us to go, actually – but Bow threw an arm across my path. *That* was hardly going to stop me. Ducking under the errant limb, I beckoned our fellow adventurers and, to their credit, both women were hot on my heels. Perfuma floated towards the boundary fence, humming merrily to an apple tree, while Scorps tread my steps exactly, right down to the footprint. A stirring show of camaraderie, if ever there was one. Her stylishly-shaved noggin bumped against Bowregard, summoning sorriness, but she would not be deterred. In a second, she was at my side.

Shaking off Shugborough, both I and the night ahead felt free. I grinned at Scorpia. Scorps nodded back at me, flicking her chin with enviable self-assurance. Lady P smiled generally, at pretty much everything. Things were going swimmingly, and I bubbled with fresh bonhomie. I whistled, which just felt belting, then ran my hands through the miscellaneous hedgerow that lined our path. It was prickly, but in a happy way. Jolly holly, if you will!

'So, Scorpy, old pal, have I done a smashing job or what?'

'What?'

'I said: Have I done a smashing job or what? It was a question, meant for you. Not one of those rhetorical blighters. I genuinely wish to know your opinion.'

‘I thought I’d given it… Have I not given it? This happens all the time! My choices were “smashing job” or “what” – is that right?’

‘A dashed perfect rendition of the question, yes!’ I was warming to my knight-consultant role. Plucking an errant but lengthy blade of grass, I stuck the fellow between my teeth, letting it jut like a toothpick in a Western flick. Sir Adora is: The Problem Solver. Has a nice ring, don’t you think? With my spare hand, I twirled Ms. Floaty-Cane, trying to affect disaffectedness. I wanted Scorpia to think I’d seen it all before.

‘Then I answered, didn’t I? “What?”’

‘Hang about!’ My daydreaming shuddered to a halt. ‘Are you saying I *haven’t* done a smashing job? I’ve got you and Lady P in the same place, at the same time, en-route to the most romantic location around. What have I missed? Spare no detail, Scorps. Sir Adora doesn’t leave a job half-done.’

‘So. Sooooo. Umm. How to put this? I don’t think you’ve made it very clear what I’m trying to do. At least, not while I’ve been around. Not to Perfuma. Hrrrr… Hmm. Did you maybe forget? Because I can remind you! I want to ask her out. Oh! And I want to tell her I like her.’

‘A good point, very well made,’ hummed I. ‘It wounds me to the fleshy bits that I’ve fallen at the final hurdle, but weeping into the athletics track never solved anything. Aunty made sure I learned that lesson! You need Lady P to know this is a date. Or that it

could be a date, rather. In any case, the word "date" needs to be clearly articulated, if I'm understanding you correctly?'

'Yes?'

'Then it shall be done. Never fear, your chivalric sword-swinger is here!'

Purposeful strides propelled me across the path in a kind of diagonal. Her green-fingered Ladyship was just two steps ahead, wherein I'd find the first of tonight's salvations. One word from me and these superb Sapphics could couple up, which was important for my standing with the Duchess Brightmoon, I think, for reasons I very vaguely remembered. Something about Cupid never stealing a vessel? Was that it?

'What h---' I started. And did not finish, courtesy of a quivering mass of Bowregard. All sweat and clamour, my Oxford chum zig-zagged me back a bunch, fixing me with a haunted gaze. He'd been jogging to catch up, his haggard breath suggested, so we spent the next little while in silent stalemate. His eyes were trying to tell me something big. Portentous, even. Bow's eyes had a habit of doing that.

'Spit it out, there's a good fellow!'

'Wait--- Wait.'

‘We’re already standing still, aren’t we? Scorps and the good Lady’ll be out of sight if we loiter much longer.’

‘That’s… Not… What… I… Mean… Adora.’

Alrighty. If motion wasn’t the cause for his upset, we might as well get on with it. Asking first, then scooping an arm under his lagging form, I hobbled our joint mass into the forest proper. Perfuma was looking awfully interested in a patch of morels, which could easily tempt her off-track, so I needed to keep an eye on her. One wrong move and we’d be trapped here forever, stuck as actors in a meta-play. Perish the thought. Scorpy, for her part, seemed very lost. Not promising.

‘Come on, chum!’ I tried to hurry Bow along. ‘I’ve got fates to fenagle, so get down to brass tacks, would you?’

‘Adora, what you said back there. Who you are. It’s HUGE. Are we just supposed to keep walking through the forest like nothing happened, and not even START talking about how you’re secretly the most powerful mythical figure in Etherian history? Or how that means that the First Ones Sagas aren’t allegories? Or how *that* means that my fathers’ favourite thing in the entire world – the foundation of their CAREERS – is built on a bundle of lies?’

‘Yes, we are. Because this walk won’t last much longer.’

‘What do you mean YES?’

‘I mean, Bowregard, that I’m not going to talk about it right now. Maybe we won’t talk about it ever! I don’t know! So butt out, alright?’

‘What’s gotten into you?’

‘Catra is still out here… *somewhere*. I’ve got no way of reaching her, no way of helping her and one of my closest friends is to blame. That’s what, Bow. Now my other best bud wants to dissect something I hadn’t even heard about until yesterday and only got onboard with this afternoon. And I shouldn’t have to justify myself by telling you any of this, unless I want to. Catra taught me that. Boundaries and consent, she calls it, and I don’t feel totally comfortable exercising them yet, but I am *trying*. Because she views me as the ultimate authority on me, and she’s been right about everything else so far.’

‘Adora---’ Bow started. He stopped straight after, staring at his feet. We trod our ways through the thickest treeline. He didn’t say anything else, and time was running short, so let’s call that conversation imperfectly complete. We could always come back to it later. I dashed towards Perfuma, the peculiar sand-soil tripping and clipping my steps, until we stumbled into inadvertently close contact. She hugged me back, going “Uwwwwwwwuuuuuhhhhhhhhoooooohhhhh!” as she tightened to a squeeze.

‘I was starting to miss you, my darling She-Ra! Coming here, tonight, was such a *romantic* idea!!’

‘You know, Lady P, that’s precisely what we need to chat about. Remember that “certain woman” I mentioned before?’

‘Of course I do, silly!’

She – and there’s no other word for it – *booped* me. On the nose. And then she giggled, which threw me rather off my stroke.

‘Umm. Going on--- While we’ve walked, said “certain woman” has turned into a nervous wreck. She’s grieving terribly, I think, for all the opportunities she’s missed so far. She wanted to spend the whole walk here talking with you. You know, discovering your dreams, identifying your ideals and… um… discussing your favourite salad recipes?’

‘She-Ra! It’s so nice of you to ask! It’s a Waldorf!’

‘The one with nuts and mayonnaise?! Um. Well. Very good, I suppose. But the “certain woman” doesn’t just view you as a question-and-answer sheet. She wants to get ever so close to you, and you to her, so you can snuggle and cuddle and share a special bond. Naturally, all of the above only applies if you want it to. Do you want to go a on a romantical Sapphic date with her?’

‘Yes! Yes, of course I do!’

‘Champion stuff, your Ladyship!’

I positively rushed back to Scorpia, giddy with the good news. Pinecones slipped my stance but I screeched to a halt in the swordsman’s perfect A-frame. Flicking an eyebrow, channelling my best Meowmeow, I rested one palm on my pommel and fixed my gaze on the date-to-be.

‘Lady S! Have I got news for you!’

‘“What?”’

‘What?’

‘Oh, right! That wasn’t an option this time. Um. What are my choices for this question?’

‘Ah, no, Scorpy. It wasn’t an interrogative: no question marks were in play!’

‘I couldn’t tell that, because it wasn’t written down.’

‘Fair point!’ I swished my blade around a bit, recapturing the gravitas my ambiguous arrival had so far squandered. ‘Did you see what went on down there? Between Perfuma and I?’

‘I saw you hug her? Is that a normal thing knights do when they’re trying to get someone a date? I’m asking because I don’t know.’

‘No, it isn’t, but let the record show that I sort of fell onto her, Scorps. Physical contact was not intended! With me, it very rarely is, but these forest floors are so damnably slippery. Be that as it may, I’ll tell you what you saw: you saw the gardening goddess give her enthusiastic assent to romantically dating you, right here and now!’

‘Oh, wow. That’s great! Can I hug you? As a thank you? I’d really like to, Adora!’

‘I’m not sure. But I certainly appreciate you asking. We could give it a go, then stop if it isn’t my scene?’

‘Sounds good, brave Sir Buddy!’

She checked the wheres and hows of embracing me, then wrapped me in something tremendously respectful and genuine.

‘Scorpia, you give great hugs!’

‘Aw, gee! Thanks, Adora. Um. What do I do now?’

‘You go and date your Lady, that’s what!’

The successes were rolling in, so I pivoted my heels and marched back towards Bow. The fellow looked distraught. Which was not in my plan. He grabbed my hand, then kneeled down, his head against my palm.

‘Adora, I am so, so, sooooo sorry!!’ He mumbled, sadly. ‘I’m an awful friend! Maybe the worst person in the world! All this time I’ve known you, I just assumed you were happy with what we were doing together. I never asked! Not properly! I’m so sorry.’

That didn’t seem quite right. The young Mr Georgeson was one of the most considerate people I knew, most of the time. He was no Lady Meowmeow – but who was? A trim here, a tweak there and he’d be the best bud I can imagine. He’s thoughtful, smart, engaging, and enduringly glad to see me, occasional panics about the de l’Horde chivalry aside. Perhaps he hadn’t used Catra’s words, but he obviously considered things. Shepherding our quartet downhill, towards a pair of gold-rimmed turquoise pools, I tried to put the above into words and settled on:

‘I’m not always jazzed about your hugs.’

‘You don’t like hugs???!?’

‘Steady on, fellow, I didn’t say that. Why, I’m only just returned from cuddling Scorpy.’

He gasped. My clarification seemed to be making things worse.

‘So just don’t like MY hugs??!??’

‘I *sometimes* like them,’ I persevered. ‘Equally, sometimes I don’t. Have I asked for a hug? Have you asked me before initiating the hug? Have you checked where’s best to touch? And so on. I hate to break it, Bow, but you never really ask those questions.’

‘I don’t??!’ He gasped, stared into the middle distance, stood up, and adjusted his tone. ‘You’re right, I don’t. Adora. I’m really sorry.’

‘It’s all about the context, as Catra would say. There are minimum two sides to a squeeze, so every party needs considering, if you see what I mean? It’s like the conversation we had earlier. You were, from my perspective, prying into uncomfy territory. Right now, I’m just your plain old friend Adora, and I don’t want my chums only seeing me as---’

‘She-Ra! Oh, She-Ra! You-hoo, my daring darling. I can see the sun glimmering against the water! Don’t you want to watch it together?’

‘Hold that thought, Bow. Must be off.’ I scarpered up a pebbly path, wondering just how many surfaces Cannock Chase could have. As I did, a stone shifted underfoot, catching my toe-box in its pinching embrace. Scorpy, alongside, was just as stuck. But in a more metaphorical way.

‘Scorps! Whatever’s the matter, chum? The gal of your giddiness is mere paces away, and you’ve not made a single step towards her. Is it the path? Are you getting cold feet? I know I am. The old circulation is cutting off, or some such.’

‘It’s not that,’ she sighed. ‘Adora--- What do I *do* now?’

‘You go on a date, then maybe more dates, then marry, then have lots of cute little babies, then sit on a lawn swing together and watch squirrels dismantle the bird-feeder.’

‘But how?’

‘They hang down from the top and lever off the lid, from my experience.’

‘Oh! That’s--- Wait, that wasn’t what I was asking. I meant: how do I go on a date?’

‘Haven’t you been on one before?’

She shook her head.

‘Hmm. Me neither. But my valet Meowmeow had three thoughts on the matter: rapport; priv-imacy; fast heartbeats. I’ve got you covered on the last one – just you wait and see! But the first two are up to you. Go! Chit-chat! Dance until your legs are rubbing… places!’

‘Can you come with me?’

‘Regarding the rubbing?!’

‘Oh! No. I was just asking if you can, you know, introduce me. Perfuma was asking for you anyway, and I don’t want to stop her from getting, *gee*, anything she needs, just because I wanted our date to start faster!!’

‘Ah, okay. Very good. In the interests of completing chivalry, I shall prime and pre-empt your what ho, just as soon as you lift me out of here.’

We strolled together, right up to Perfuma. She hugged me, then said a demure “Hallo!” to Scorpia, taking me something by surprise. A delicate dance of disentanglement followed, wherein I escaped the embrace while keeping the relevant class structures intact. Both women were looking at each other, then at me, then

at each other in utter confusion. Leading our clamber up a final cliff, minutes from sun-dip and metres from my selected vantage spot, it fell to me to lay the scene.

'Lady P! Look out, if you'd be so kind, and gaze across the grandest vista Cannock Chase has to offer. Quite the amorous spot, don't you agree?'

'It's beautiful!! The walk was so worth it, and I can't wait for our date to start.'

'I'm sure a "certain woman" is terribly relieved to hear that. Don't you agree, Scorpy? That's why we're here in triplicate, actually. Moral support was required! We've had a tumultuous time of it and I've struggled to get the words out – let me tell you! – but I can finally reveal the identity of your secret admirer. This "certain woman" of yours is none other than your fellow nature-lover, Sc---'

Perfuma kissed me on the cheek, her right leg bent and its foot flicked up to the sky.

'She-Ra, I knew it! All along, I knew it! You can't hide your feelings from me, you silly goose!'

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Chapter 24

Chapter Summary

'For a treatise titled "The Inimitable Meowmeow", sir, I feature in surprisingly few chapters.'

'And just who is to blame for that, Catra?!'

'Glimmer. Glimmer is to blame.'

'I--- um--- Well--- You know, my love, you're right. I'm sorry. I should've done more to stop her.'

'That's okay, Adora. We're here now. And you did *plenty* while I was away, for Bow, for Scorfuma, and for yourself. Look at you asserting your boundaries! I know I say it a lot, but I still don't tell you enough: I'm SO proud of you.'

Chapter Notes

Content warnings apply for the below chapter only - Spoilers may be present in the warnings. This story does not include any of the four Archive Warnings topics, but does occasionally feature other topics that may require content notes.

Chapter 24 Content Warnings (CONTAINS SPOILERS):
Threat of injury/death - narrated, related, present, secondary chatacter (no death or major injury occurs)

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PART 24

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Perfuma gasped giddily, stepped back, and stumbled against the scree. She wobbled there, for a moment, on the precipice of a 100 or 120 foot drop into the brine below. Her eyes shot wide, staring out from her wobbling shadow. I Greyskulled good and proper, summoning She-Ra, dashing forth to rescue Lady P. Again. But I wasn't first to the draw. No sir! My heroics stood on the shoulders of giants, thanks to the fast thinking, fast pinching Scorpy. Strained to bursting, she spanned the path with one arm snapped to the rockface and the other cradled about Her Ladyship.

'Adora! Get a good grip before you lift her! I--- hrrrr--- I can hold Perfuma until then!'

Scorps was sweating buckets, saving the day by sheer force of will. I'd have taken a second to drink it in: genuine heroism, out in the wild. But duty called! A swoop, a sweep and we fumbled back to the path in a jangled ball. As Scorpia's elbow ground against my eye socket and Lady P stuck a foot into my stomach – both quite accidently, I've since been assured – I began to reconsider my choice of hip and happening date spot. Inching out from under them, I scoped our safest steps up to the plain above.

Roped together, courtesy of Lady P, we inched to surer ground. I took a group count. Ah. We were one short. Wailing something rotten, Bowregard re-asserted his presence with gusto. "Adora!" he called. "Cliff!" Yes, quite, old friend. I knew all about the drop, thanks to our heart-thumping encounter. Good of him to warn me, though, I mused. He really does look out for me! "Hellllpppp!! Someone! *Any*one!"

Oh, now I got it! The chap had been behind us, hadn't he, so he wasn't warning our trio at all! Which meant he was--- Ah. I leaped off the higher ground and scrambled across the rock, savouring the She-Raian ability to almost but not quite fly. Never letting the fellow stray from my view, I kept my truest bluests trained on his figure, as he shifted from quavering ant to full-size dude-in-distress. I landed by punching the ground. Because I could, largely. It's dratted good fun, I can report, and well worth a go if you ever have the chance.

Fortune favouring this second strife, the chap was still well and truly planted on the pathway. He'd simply reached a point where the road ahead seemed slim and crumbly, causing his nerve to evaporate. Ah, yes, I remembered. Bow's terrified of heights. I thought back to Catra's maps and rued my general disregard of this spot's squiggly, wiggly contours. The chap looked at me in wonderment, his eyes almost literally a-sparkle.

'Um, Adora. You looked like this before. On the garden path. When you promised to help me.'

'Did I? Well, I suppose that makes quite a bit more sense now! You know, back then, I hadn't the foggiest I possessed these capabilities. I hadn't met Ms. Floaty-Cane or made my pact with the blinding light or anything!'

'We don't have to talk about it if you don't want to.'

'Bow, I really appreciate that! But now might not be quite the right time to sketch that exact line. We need to get you safe so…

um… hop on, I guess?'

'Are you sure? It isn't too much like a hug?'

'I like some hugs, Bow! You just need to ask first. And this isn't a hug; it's a rescue!!'

'A rescue within your boundaries?'

'Yes. Please get on. And hold tight, around the waist. Not the chest!'

With the maybe-no-longer-destined-to-be-an-ancient-historian in place, my existence having destroyed the discipline and cetera, I shot as high and vertical as I could muster, shouting back that I'd also been She-Raian when I'd thrown the 'plane. Bow retorted that this made a lot of sense, provided he was allowed to say that. Yes, I confirmed, he was. The chap appreciated the clarification, then asked for another. Elbowing between outcrops – armguards a-plink against the sandstone – we mulled whether I'd also been She-Ra when I first proposed to stop Bow's post.

It made a lot of sense, looking back. The idea got me glowing all over – *not* in the Lady Meowmeow way – plus my pal reported I'd stood a lot loftier. Had I been quite this tall or muscular, I queried. He replied in squeaks, which was awfully modest of him. I flipped and twirled, pirouetting around the dangling shrubbery. Eep, said

Bow again, so I articulated how I very much wanted to know. He needn't hold back on my account!

'No, Adora, it's--- it's--- are we flying? Is this SAFE?'

'Oh, yes,' I beamed. 'I can do all sorts in She-Raian. I positively flew over Glimmer this afternoon – and her bullets all-but bounced off me!'

'She knows you're She-Ra? And she was SHOOTING at you? I mean--- *hrrllggh*--- if you're happy answering those--- *clllk*--- questions.'

'Hmm,' I pondered, leaping us to a wider, flatter ledge. 'Bow, are you alright? Do you need a break? You're sounding a little green.'

His chin nodded into my back. I put him down very gently, checked his vitals, and constructed an earthworks wall around him, hoping it might mollify his fear of falling.

'Hold those questions until your stomach settles?' I suggested. He nodded again, then made a series of hand signals that implied his desire for my informed consent, then relieved his gullet of late-afternoon-tea, then nodded again. 'Sit tight, chap, I'll be right back! Sunset is in progress, so Sapphics need surveying.' Preparing for lift off, I recalled one final, vital point for the time being. Leaving the fellow physically aloft was one thing, but I wasn't about to leave him in emotional suspense. 'By the way,

Bowregard, you're doing a smashing job with respecting the old boundaries. I feel a lot safer.'

What Ho! and let's go! With a devilishly satisfying *shing*, Ms. Floaty-Cane raced from her scabbard and cleft an awkward stone in twain, clearing the space to drive her blade into the cliff itself. She slotted the sandstone like a hot bench saw through butter and I pivoted away. Gambolling with a Golden Retriever grin, one pluck removed my impromptu crampon, one hip-bone bump nudged my course, and a second, third, fourth twirl threw me atop the peak. Four eyes widened at my arrival; four hands clapped as I nailed the dismount. Arms straight out, sword already stowed, I was every inch the swashbuckling gymnast.

'That's my She-Ra!!' Perfuma sighed. She seemed bally elated by my arrival. 'I knew you wouldn't leave me hanging!'

'About that, Lady P… I've no plans to make myself the centre of attention. I just want to see how the whole date deal progresses. Do let me know if anything's the matter: I'll do whatever you require, so long as you savour sundown to the fullest.'

'So brave! So modest! So considerate!'

'Those are your thoughts on the good Lady S so far, I hope?' I enquired 'She's the hero of the hour, alright!'

‘Yes, yes you are, silly!’ Plumers giggled. ‘I didn’t think you’d need reminding. But it’s okay, my lovely!! I’m delighted to keep telling you, over and over, just as often as it takes. Your aura is radiant; your spirit is pure; your heart is true. Not forgetting that you’re so tall, so strong, so *reassuring.* And I’m so happy to be here, tonight, on our first date---’

So far, so good. I nodded along, sagely, reassured that Scorpy was sealing the deal and the cliffside miscommunication was far behind us.

‘---She-Ra, you’re my hero!’

Rats.

‘Scorpia, you mean?’ I tried. We could still course correct; the night could shift back to being a success. Couldn’t it? If a train could re-rail itself, after slipping its steely bonds, then clearing up a crossed word or three was surely within my powers. ‘Her speedy snippers did far more to catch you than I did.’

‘You don’t have to do yourself down!’ Lady P laughed. ‘It’s not boasting when you tell the truth!’

‘Your Ladyship, I’m not speaking a word of a lie! Our rubbly rescue was a two heroine job, where Scorps shouldered the lion’s share! It’s her that did the heavy lifting! Umm. Not that I’m saying you’re heavy. Not that I’m saying it matters if anyone’s heavy. Not

that I think my opinion matters. Err. That is to say--- What was I trying to say? Ah! Yes! Scorpia Blackstone should not be overlooked! She deserves the hero's due.'

Lady P turned and executed a very mannered, very practised curtsey. 'Thank you, Madam Blackstone.'

'Errrr---' Scorps blushed the kind of red I recognised from my own tongue-tied entanglements. I mouthed the words "Thank you, Perfuma" to her, gesturing towards the object of her affections.

'Great weather we're having, right? It's, like, really warm, but it's nighttime!'

Even Sir Adora, for all the prompts that pass me by, began to recognise that all was not going swimmingly. I looked out, across this beautiful place, at the sinking orange orb. Its full circle was still in view, but the lower quadrants were doing that shivery horizontal dance they do in the last instants before the final plummet. Curses. I'd have to act fast. Drawing, once again, on my parlour game prowess, I mimed Scorpia a question. Did she need help? Yes, her ceaseless nods replied. A lot of yes.

'Sweet Lady Plumers, might I have your attention?' I could, as it happened. Smashing. I went on. 'On a night very much like this, long ago, back before trousers, there was an Act 1. And in said act, there stood a Scene 1, where the course of true love never did run smooth. Four velvet-clad aristos and their fairy friends spent the next three-odd hours trying to chamfer down its rough edges, but they never thought of having a proper chin-wag about

it until the very end. I missed my train home. I had to get a jitney. Do you see what I'm saying?'

'No, She-Ra, I don't. But you're saying it beautifully!'

'Much obliged, but not the feedback I was hoping for. Hmm. I'll have to go on. Madam Perfuma, in that same scene, while I was still paying attention, another character announced that "Love looks not with the eyes, but with the mind". And I think she meant this: the grey goo can have an awfully huge emotion all it likes, only for our fleshy bits to refuse to play ball, leaving the thinker frustrated and their thinkee oblivious. It's a tragedy, except this play was actually a Comedy.'

'I'm still confused, but I like how you like theatre.'

'Then let's get out of the abstract,' I decided. 'I know these feelings all too well. There's a girl out there who jangles my nerves and flushes me through, whenever we speak. I'm all a-shake just thinking about her! And today I finally found the words to begin expressing myself. Though, that said, I guess I've only known her since yesterday…'

'Don't worry, sweetie, I love a whirlwind romance!' Perfuma clapped. 'They're so adorable!'

'Quite. Well. In this case – a case concerning you, your Ladyship – the words haven't yet been said, I don't think?'

Scorpy shook her head. Okay. At least, then, I knew what I was working with.

‘How to put this---’ I hummed. ‘Aha! Let’s take that quote I quoth and hack it about a bit: Love speaks not with the lips, but with the mind. There’s a certain woman out there – right here, with you, right now, in fact – who adores you. She wants nothing but the best for you, she’d love to participate with your hobbies and interests, and I dare say she’d like to hold your hand, if you’d enjoy the same.’

A nod of assent from Scorpia; an extended palm from Lady Plumers. If only it hadn’t been reaching for me…

‘Ah. No. It’s not me, Lady P. I’m awfully sorry. I think you’re sweet and stunning, heck, I’d count myself a fortunate fellow to have you on my arm, but I don’t have romantical feelings for you.’

She deflated.

‘But what about the proposal, She-Ra? The kneeling, the flower in my hand? Our enchanting walk in the woods?’

‘All on behalf of another, your Ladyship. I was the third party, setting up a shy lover’s scene for them.’

‘There are only four of us up here! If I’ve got an admirer, and that person is up on the Chase, then you’re saying--- Did you mean to say womanBow likes me? No, that can’t be right, can it? Earlier you said it was a certain *woman*…’

‘Oh, muffin tins! Bowregard! Spare me a second, would you?’

I launched myself off the cliff, again, cherishing the air that eddied between my fingers. Goodness, being She-Ra was great. No wonder it never went out of fashion. Flip, flop and down I flew, slotting myself next to my heights-hating friend.

‘Bow, your mushy bits. Have they settled enough for the last jump up? Say, we can climb it if you’d rather?’

He shook his head. More vomit came out.

‘Is that a negative to the improving health, or to scaling the slow route?’

‘Either? Both? I don’t know. I don’t feel good, Adora. Can you stay with me, please? Just for a minute.’

The sun showed a squared-off bottom. It would have to be just one minute.

‘I’ll time it, alright? Duty also calls up top – and even She-Ra can’t be in two places at once! I think.’

‘Okay.’ Bow exhaled deep and slow, then glanced over. ‘You were definitely taller than usual on the Shugborough path, and by more than you’d get by just standing up. But I don’t think you were this big. And your hair wasn’t so windy.’

‘Yah, that is new. Looks spiffy, though, right?’

‘It does look pretty good… Adora. I don’t want to make things weird, but what’s going on with Glimmer? If she’s shooting you, then that’s not being a good friend!’

‘I wouldn’t say she was aiming *at* us – more that Lady Meowmeow and I happened to stumble onto her firing range. At precisely the wrong moment. Her cousin, Double-Trubel? Now, they *were* putting bullets our way.’

‘Adora!’ Bow stroked his chin for a second. ‘Actually, that tracks. Sometimes. They actually bought me a really good scar cream last week.’

‘I don’t have a handle on them… But they do know I’m She-Ra. Does Glimmer? I’m not sure.’

‘I won’t tell her, Adora, unless you ask me to. I want to make that really, *really* clear.’

‘Look, chum, it’s not that I don’t trust you. I’m just not too keen to chat right now, when I don’t really understand She-Ra that well myself yet. It’s all turning up in bits and pieces. Like… these eyes. They look amazing. But I don’t know when I got them. Maybe it was as I grabbed Ms. Floaty-Cane… or when I made my pact with the powerful light to look after Etheria… or during the saleswoman dream-argument-thing… or when I swore to keep Catra safe. Which--- isn’t going too great.’

‘She’s really something special to you, isn’t she?’

‘*Bow*… not this again!’

‘I’m just saying: I’m really glad you have someone like that looking out for you.’

‘Bow! I have two people – I’ve got you too!’

‘Hug?!’

‘Oof, time’s up. When I’m back! Oh! One last thing--- Do you like Perfuma?’

‘Loads!’

‘As a friend?’

‘A really good one!’

Ricocheted into another return, I spied two Sapphics staring into, away from, into, away from and so on, regarding each other’s eyes. The sun had half-gone, and what remained was falling fast.

‘Right!’ I pronounced. ‘Bowregard likes you as a chum, Lady P. I dare say he’s fond of you too, Scorpy, for I’d really struggle to think of anyone who wouldn’t be. In any case, Bow isn’t the fellow in need of a knight. That falls to Scorpia here. She’s the one who likes you! She’s the “certain woman”! But I’m sure she’s said as much, in the minutes I’ve been gone! What have you two been talking about?’

‘The weather,’ Lady P offered.

‘It has been, like, awfully dry recently, don’t you think?’ Scorpia observed. ‘And isn’t it warm for an evening?’

‘Anything else?’ I ventured. ‘Shared interests? Intimate privacy?’

‘Ooh! I told her about the jam I’m entering for the fête tomorrow! It’s gooseberry flavour!’

‘And I was so happy to hear that,’ Perfuma clapped. ‘Just because she’s so fuzzy, prickly and tart, our friend the wild gooseberry never has her turn in the spotlight… It’s so sad! She has so much to offer, if people only take the time and get to know her!’

‘Can I take it that the conversation flowed forth from there, you two?’

‘Oh, no, She-Ra! I had to stop it. I’m judging the Woman’s Institute tent tomorrow with Glimmer, so I can’t be doing anything that compromises my impartiality, whether I was enjoying my chat with Scorpia or not.’

Scorps looked a little wounded; Lady P itched with what could have been cold, but just might have been inner turmoil. There was no other option: sidebars must suffice. If those two kept up with the clamming up, we’d be trapped in the inky black before the first flirtatious “Hey, Insert Appropriate Name!” had been sounded. Chin jutting like a Wimbledon umpire, I weighed which to ask first. Lady S got the nod.

‘We’ve got to get three things straight, Scorpy, and quick. Do you still want this date? What’s stopping you? What can I do to help?’

‘Err… Can I have my options?’

‘I’m looking for essay style answers, old bean. Say whatever your heart is thinking. Extra marks for working out, but you’ve got to keep it brief!’

‘Hmm. Yes; I don’t know if she likes me, or what to talk about; find out if she likes me, and give us something to talk about.’

I nodded, then fleet-footed over to Perfuma, granting her my knightly bow.

‘Lady P, if isn’t too awkward, we need to chat about how this date is going.’

‘The bit when you said you didn’t fancy me was bad,’ she started, ‘and I don’t think I loved falling off a cliff.’

‘Understandably.’

‘Getting rescued was nice, though, and you were so right about this view! It’s poetic… The purples and the oranges are dancing like a heartbeat!’

‘But what about Scorpia? The woman you’re here with?’

‘Oh, She-Ra, it’s awful. I like her too – just as much as I liked you, but in a longer, deeper way – but she’s barely spoken a word to me. Everything I’ve said about you has put her off me, I just know it! Her chakra is all askew, and mine too!!’

‘“*Dancehalls can stimulate the most overwhelming emotions!*” Lady P, I’ve got it! She does like you, and you like her, but neither of you can say it, because sometimes our date-destined feelings sit somewhere our words can’t reach! Not right away, anyway.’

‘She-Ra? I don’t get it.’

‘Perfuma, your yoga, this morning. I’m sorry I missed it, but I’m positive you invited me to greet the sun. If you can do that on the daily, is there a yogic way to wave the big burning fellow toodle-oh too?’

‘Yoga connects us with nature, She-Ra. It lets us do anything, so long as we respect our Earth.’

‘Not to excessively come over Meowmeow, but might I suggest, madam, that a one-to-one yoga class would make for the ideal date? You lead, she follows, and the sentiments just start flowing. Naturally, Bowregard and I’ll leave you to it for half-an-hour or so, before bounding back with your transport home. All you two need to do is enjoy each other’s company. What do you think?’

‘She-Ra!’ Perfuma wrapped her arms around my trunk, with a grateful squeeze. ‘Oooowwwuuuwwhhh! It’s just *perfect*!’ And off she skipped, my job very well done. After a brief bask in the glow – one has to allow oneself some congratulations, even when one happens to be a selfless mythical being – I scooped Bowregard up and onto the road. My plan had entered its next phase. Stepping onto the tarmac, I began to narrate.

‘Like all brilliant plans, whenever we’re doing one thing tonight, we’re really accomplishing something else. Take our route through the forest. It was a beautiful, meandering path from civilised to countryside, which made it perfect romance fodder, but it’s also the very route my gentlewoman might have picked back to civilisation.’

Gasp, went he. I don’t blame him. I was pretty darn proud of myself, and I sure hoped Catra would be too, when I shortly, but triumphantly, whisked her back to safety.

‘How do I know? Because Lady Meowmeow is a stickler for her maps, and I chanced to glance all over this area as she drove us down the Chase this afternoon. *This*,’ I clicked my boot, ‘is the main road where Double-Trubel swept us home, which means we screeched to a halt *here*,’ I pointed to a nearby evergreen, ‘alongside a sole, distinctive Monkey Puzzle tree. Catra stepped out, said her goodbyes, then strolled off into the undergrowth.’

‘*Very* impressive!’

‘Much obliged, old chum. There’s just one, not-so-tiny fly in the ointment… From all the adventure stories I read as a nipper---’

‘*Adora*---’

‘Yes, okay, I still read them now too. My point is… They make tracking somebody seem easy. You look for footprints, scraps of clothing, and discarded sandwich crusts; you find them; you save the day. It hasn’t worked out that way. I’ve been searching – constantly – without seeing anything! So I need your help. Does anything here catch your eye, Bow? Anything at all? I swear this was where we stopped. I can conjure up Catra, closing her door and ducking between the branches, plain as day.’

We scoured the roadside something rotten, heading back and forth by an hundred metres or more, eyes trained on our task. As the light faded – my hope and patience going with it – I turned over mulch and berries, stones and cigarettes, then started hacking into the undergrowth. Come on, Ms. Floaty-Cane. You know Catra; you want me to save her. Just. Find. Something. *Please*.

‘Adora?!’ A hand caught me at the elbow, holding tight to quell my rampage. ‘Catr---- *Bow*??!??’

‘*Sorry*!! Can I touch you there? Is that okay? Um. Don’t be mad – and I can’t stress that enough, don’t be mad – but I just had a thought. Which car did Glimmer take you home in?’

‘The giant two-tone rag-top with all the chrome. Hadn’t seen it before, myself, so I figured it belonged to her cousin. It sort of suits a band leader, if you see what I mean? Not that it matters much now. Meowmeow went out the passenger door and just---disappeared. I’ve found *nothing*, even after we tailed her back to the very first step.’

‘Adora, you genius, that’s it! We haven’t searched her path at all – because Double-Trubel was driving the Duesenberg, which Glimmer just imported from New York, where they put the driver on the left!! Unless Catra climbed over whoever was driving, she *couldn’t* have started her walk here, so we need to make a mirror image. If you’re right about this location otherwise, and I think you might be, then that would mean---’ He raced over the blacktop, neglecting to look one way or the other before he crossed. ‘---Bingo!!’

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Chapter 25

Chapter Summary

'I'll cop to it - Bow explains systemic discrimination here and I don't do a perfect job of helping or understanding. I'm very sorry about that. He knows. Public life as a white able-bodied Etherian aristocrat is pretty easy, ditto my ability back then to conceal my queerness, and I didn't appreciate that enough. Not then. I would learn. Rapidly. You'll see that soon. And, well, I'm grateful he and Catra took the time to explain what they did.'

'Adora, my love, I really appreciate how you listen. Otherwise, readers, this chapter re-visits our established themes: Bow's letter; Scorpia's love for Perfuma; my own sentimental Sapphism; and the terrifying prospect of Adora aboard the Birkin Blower.'

'It's our longest chapter too! It even has a footnote! But it misses something vital--- You still weren't back with me, Catra!!'

'Patience, readers...'

Chapter Notes

Content warnings apply for the below chapter only - Spoilers may be present in the warnings. This story does not include any of the four Archive Warnings topics, but does occasionally feature other topics that may require content notes.

Chapter 25 Content Warnings (CONTAINS SPOILERS):
Vehicle accident, car - narrated, related, present, substantial car and building damage (no death or major injury occurs)
Insitutional anti-Black racism - related, societal, impacts secondary character, poorly understood by white major character

See the end of the chapter for more notes

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PART 25

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Galloping their little equestrian hearts out, my pocket prancers flapped from a branch, high above. Horsey, my handkerchief! My own ba-bumper skipped a few, waiting for my eyes to confirm what the de l'Horde spirit already knew. I couldn't be too careful, you see. All too often, if the railway station paperbacks were any judge, a clue could be coincidental or concocted. Some malingerer might have known my pocket square's identity and sought to buy another from the same batch, hurling us off the scent. Or this quiet corner of the Chase might hold top secret, tremendously dapper fashion expos under the cover of night.

Anything would remain possible, until I'd done my best Holmes, and over-analysed an object for gay reasons. Bow's travel telescope stood in my hand. He always had told me it would come in handy, one day, but I somehow doubted he'd had this exact end in mind. Still, we mustn't begrudge the fellow a win. 'Very interesting,' said I. 'It's no cheap knock-off. The thread count counts, and the colouration is simply divine. Get a load of that purple!'

'Yes, Adora! Because it's your hanky!'

‘Now, now. Let’s not get too hasty here. I need to look deeper.’ Dropping into a meditative trance, utterly in my element, I started to examine the individual mares and stallions. For what does Sir Adora know better than her horseys? If this fabric was really true, the majestic beasts would have personalities to match, letting them all-but leap off the silk. Hmm. Here was Horace, always good in a crisis. His dapple hid the blueing remnants of an ink stain, from that time I bit my fountain pen to bursting. There was Henrietta, whose pure white mane made her the *prima donna* of the piece. But where was--- Ah-hah! Hermes, my Pegasus and my consultant. He always knew what to do!

‘Would it be okay if we got it down now?’

‘The correct horses just winked at me, so yes.’

‘Could you---?’

‘Huh? Oh, because of the heights thing! And because I’m in She-Ra mode!’ Stretched out to the seams, and not at all sure how Lady Meowmeow made it up so high, I twiddled with a dainty knot, sensing something yet more elegant within. One last tug and the parcel gave, fluttering a soft white square onto the breeze. It flittered like a butterfly, only at night. A moth, I think they call them. It was certainly about the same size. My companion caught it in a pounce, which played out with him and the item in very close proximity. He rotated it twice. The other side was green, Bow showed me, while he squinted at the obverse. Finally, he proclaimed: ‘It’s for you?’

“Sir d l H,” the white side started, in some of the most minute lead lines I’ve ever seen. Regardless of its shrunken scale, the handwriting stood out, with its self-assured and arcing certainty. No skimping on the cursive flourishes here! Each capital was rendered with novel, detailed sweeps; lower-case lower-hangers curved for as far as they bally well felt like. Considered, I’d call it. Stylish too. Meowmeowian, even, were that a word.

Clearly, I had my hopes and suspicions about the author. Before reading any further, however, I had to ascertain just what our mystery scribbler had used for a surface. This could count Lady Meowmeow out, you see, since I knew precisely what she’d had in pockets, thanks to our scintillating game of Hunt the Hooch. When I’d snaffled away Bow’s letter, I’d deprived her of the only scraps or sheets about her person… or so I’d thought.

I flipped over the square and came face to side-profiled face with the Prime, his head cruelly bisected by a franking mark. Unbelievable! Jolly good show, Catra! She’d only gone and peeled off the postage stamp, giving herself the smallest of scribbling tools and shoving Bow’s letter into a bureaucratic limbo it might never escape, provided the absent item wasn’t spotted before it reached its next post box!

Steady now, Adora, I cautioned myself. It was only a theory, even if I could sniff the whiff of plausibility on it. We had to keep an open mind. Swivelling the stamp, I plunged into the text with no small deal of trepidation. It read:

“Sir d l H,

Thank you for searching for me, sir, but there really is no need. By the time you read this note, adjusting for your twin journeys and sufficient pause to digest the various liquors clinking behind my vacated Duesenberg seat, I calculate I will be out of the forest and away from danger. Later tonight, under cover of darkness, I shall re-enter the house, awaiting you in the place where you asked for a special something. A something I intend to provide. Immediately.

It means the world that you came looking, just as I suspected you would…

Anon, Affectionately,

A Squire and a Lady."

Melting ever so slightly, I tucked the note into my breast pocket, where it could lay closest to my heart. Please let it be a love note, I incanted. Well. Maybe not love. It was early days, after all. Amending my statement – not wanting to sound too terribly besotted – I dropped my plea to simply hoping that Horsey swaddled a stamp of Sapphic intentions. 'Bow!' I said, much too loudly. 'We need to get moving! Now! Find the car! I've got to get back to Shugborough! And… um…' Burning so deeply red that even the arriving dimness couldn't hide me, I fumbled for a suitably euphemistic turn of phrase. 'A pressing engagement awaits me, you see, and I really don't want to miss it.'

'Oh. *Ohhhhhhh!!*' Bow crooned. 'Don't worry, Adora, I get you. So Catra's okay then?'

‘She’s fine, she’s safe, and I don’t know what you’re implying!’

‘*Noth-ing!!*’ he sing-song-sang. ‘It’s just--- the way you blush around her! It’s so *cute*!’

‘Can you focus? We’ve still got situations to sort out – or do you not want that letter back? Something needs be something else a few more times---’

‘Like when you said Catra was your valet, but she’s actually your gi---’

‘Bow, quit it, okay? For now?’

‘Sorry.’

‘Accepted, thanks. If we just cut over the road again here, then up the diagonal path for a quarter mile, we… should… come… to…’ Ah. I’d used all my words up too soon. For dramatic effect, I’d need to keep quiet for the next several steps, while we traversed raised roots and mole holes in our off-piste excursion towards… ‘Our transport! And are you okay, chap? We were away from the beaten track for a while there, but I promise you it’ll be worth it.’

‘*Adora*. Is that a Blower Bentley?! Since when have you had a Blower Bentley??!’

‘Since this afternoon, in one manner of speaking. In any other? I--- suppose I still don’t. It isn’t mine.’

‘Oh no. No, no. It’s the boat all over again! Adora--- did you “liberate” this car?’

‘*Bow*! What do you take me for?! No – I didn’t steal it. The Blower merely came into my possession as a loan from Catra, who got it as a loan from Entrapta, who has it under their care for a client, who granted them full and flexible use of the thing while it was in their workshop. It’s like a game of musical whispers, except the tune comes courtesy of a 4.5-litre engine and a bloody great supercharger. Be honest. You’re excited, aren’t you?’

‘Of course I’m excited – but that’s not what we should be talking about right now! Adora. Does the actual owner know you’re driving their car? Who even *is* the owner?!’

‘Hmm. You know, I don’t know.’

‘Which question does that answer?!?’

‘The first one? The one about the driving?’

I nodded, to better fill the fellow with confidence. Clearly, though, something went awry. My chum seemed even less reassured, and even more agitated. Wait. Had I confused nodding with shaking again?

'Then what about the second one?' Bow burst. 'How are you so cavalier about this?!'

'Eh? That wasn't your other enquiry, was it?'

'It's a third one! *Adora* – you need to get how serious this is for me! My letter is travelling to my dads' FIRST THING TOMORROW MORNING. And that means they're going to see it by afternoon tea at the LATEST! Here's what's going to happen: the third post is going to drop through the letterbox and onto the floor; Colonel Woofers is going to pick it up; he'll trot over to the French windows; my dads are going to be sitting right there; Woofers will drop off the post thumping his tail happily against the rug; Papa will warm the teacups, add a slice of lemon, then pour Dad his Darjeeling; Dad is going to take a butterknife and spread his homemade whisky marmalade over Papa's toast… And then they'll take turns choosing envelopes to open!'

'Awh! I have to say, old chap, that sounds really lovely.'

'No, Adora. No it doesn't! Because then one of them is going to pick up *my* envelope and see it's from the wrong place. The *really* wrong place. The HERE place. Either Papa takes the first look and

calls it "unusual" or Dad is going to read it and deem the situation "curious" – and then they'll both try to figure out what's going on!! Do you know much they like puzzles? Do you know how much more they like it when the puzzles are real?! Just the envelope alone will make them put down their daily cross-words! What do you think they'll do when they actually open the letter?!'

'They'll read it.'

I nodded sagely, certain that the up-and-down one was definitely a nod.

'Yes. They'll read it. And my life will be over. The tea won't even have time to steep before they've tested all the alternative hypotheses. Dad will probe whether the letter could have got lost for hundreds of miles in the wrong direction, using his comprehensive knowledge of the Travelling Post Office system. And he'll conclude no, it couldn't. Then Papa is going to examine the various outposts, non-resident professors and field trips that might have led my Cambridge-bound steps to Staffordshire. And I don't think he's going to find any. Right that moment, when they look back up at each other after their pondering, they'll know I LIED to them. Why did I lie to them, Adora? I'm going to break their hearts! Their kind, accomplished, intelligent son is just a great big dirty fibber!!'

'Not if I have anything to do with it!' I intoned, swinging myself up into the driver's seat. The doeskin gauntlets sat snug on my hands; my peepers peered through a spare pair of goggles. I flicked and clicked, screaming the Blower to life. I peered down at Bow with a flicked eyebrow, as if I'd already known the switch would do that. 'What Ho! And let's go!'

‘Umm… Adora? How do I get in?’

He asked an excellent question, the likes of which I wish I’d asked myself. But no, Sir Adora. You had silently assume Catra didn’t like you, didn’t you? Well, didn’t past me look foolish now?! Not only did she like me, she was waiting in my rooms for a clandestine liaison, before one or both of us got caught by our relevant angry Brightmoon and exiled from Shugborough Hall forever. It was all terribly exciting. Leaning towards the release lever, my pulse thumped even faster, as my gaze fell on what Lady Meowmeow had left behind: her suit jacket, complete with my muddy boot print.

Harps and love hearts danced around me when I picked it up. The fabric was stylish, strong but bewitchingly soft beneath it all, just like her. Breathing in its heady aroma – vanilla and basil, cashmere and confidence – I made a silent pledge. *I promise you this, Your Ladyship. With She-Ra as my witness, I will get this jacket back to you, and end tonight in your arms.* Employing exaggerated care, I placed her jacket on the back seat – with the sleeves popped to preserve the shoulders, just as she preferred – then remembered I was meant to be looking heroic. One airy wham, one disaffected slam, and I ushered Bow onboard.

‘There’s your door. You’re welcome.’

‘Before we actually go anywhere,’ he replied, ‘are you going to tell me, oh, I don’t know, *anything* about your plan? Or answer my questions?! At all?’

‘Okay, chum, let’s bullseye your bullet points. Does the car’s tasteful but nebulous owner know I’m slipping behind the wheel? No. Could I give you any indication of whom that person might be? It isn’t you; it isn’t me; it isn’t Catra. Beyond that--- No. Where do I find my fighting spirit? Bowregard, old chum, you knew that one already: conviction runs strong in the de l’Horde blood! Plus this isn’t like taking the boat at all! Catra explained all the reasons that make driving the Blower fine.’

‘Which were??!’

‘Hmm. You’d have to ask her. I just know it’s damned good fun – and that I’ve got a very precise plan for the rest of the night. Bow, you know I’d never try to rush you, but I have calculated that we really need to scoop up Scorps and Lady P in the next five minutes or so, else we’ll have no way of catching your letter before it’s scooped up for the train trip south. So… What are you thinking: no or go? Have you got my back?’

‘What the heck!’ he announced, tugging his goggles tight. ‘Capital. Chum. Crew.’

Which is just what I wanted to hear. Pedal hit metal and the Blower burst away in a gargling scream, spraying jets of churned-up sand in its wake. Shrinking distance to seconds, our renegade racehorse had us in front of my fellow Sapphists in a blink, ready to sweep them away on the rest of their date.

‘Ladies. I was told once – yesterday afternoon, if we’re being precise – that a good date has three parts: rapport; priv-timacy; and hearts which beat a good bit faster. You’ve done the first two, I hope?’

‘Yes, She-Ra, we have!’ Lady P bounced. ‘Scorpy is so thoughtful and sensitive and wonderful!’

‘Smashing stuff! Then you’ll be glad to know that your good knight Sir She-Ra is here to provide the third. Your carriage awaits! Bowregard! You’ll need to get out, so they’ve got a way to get in! Now I think about it, are they just meant to climb over our seats into the back?! I’m beginning to wonder if this car isn’t very practical…’

Next thing I knew, the daters had got themselves aboard. Scorpy and Lady P were claw-in-hand, Plumers using her spare mitt to drape Catra’s jacket over her lap.

‘Hang about!’ I gasped. ‘Please, please be careful with that, your Ladyship; it’s Catra’s!!’

‘Catra?! Oh, She-Ra, I just knew you two had a beautiful energy! Your aura colours are so complementary.’

‘Um, well, yes, thank you. Um.’ I stammered. ‘Let’s not chat about that right now, eh? What I want to know is… Just how did you two get in without the door?’

Scorpia squinted at me. ‘Sorry, Sir Adora, I don’t know what to say. Gee. We definitely--- I definitely helped Perfuma up through *a* door. And then I think I climbed through that door myself. I didn’t know there was a particular one we were supposed to use. Sorry!! Was I not meant to go in this way? We’ll get out again and do it your way, if you want?’

As she spoke, she flicked the catch and proved herself absolutely right. A squat, narrow but unmistakably door-shaped door flew open, clearing a path to the rear bench seat. On the car’s right-hand side. Well, there you have it. I *was* a fool, after all. It was a subtle little flap, but it had hinges, a doorframe, the whole caboodle! And I’d never so much as seen it. I’d been much too wrapped up in Meowmeow, if such a thing were possible.

‘That’ll be quite alright, friend!’ I replied. ‘What matters is we’re all here now – and I’m ready to take you on the ride of your lives. Have you ever experienced a full-flight racing car before?! Because you’re about to.’

‘Umm… She-Ra? Would it be okay if we didn’t? I don’t really like speed all that much: it leaves me all shaken up.’ Lady Plumers fluttered her eyelashes in my direction, tabling a compromise. ‘But a top-down trip through the woods as evening appears? That sounds magical!’

‘Oh, gee! Great minds think alike, Lady P!’ Scorpy grinned. ‘Adora, do you think you could maybe take us home at snuggly bug speed, so we’ve got time to cuddle? Pretty please? Umm. If Perfuma wants to, that is.’

‘I’d love to!’ Her Ladyship clapped. ‘What do *you* think, She-Ra?’

‘I think I swore to do whatever it takes to get you two lovebirds flapping along together! Buuuttttt…. I also think I promised to rescue a letter and save Bowregard’s day, so we need to pass the post office within the next 30 mins or so.’

‘Hmm.’ Bow added. He stroked his beard, enjoying the action as much as ever. ‘How about we make a compromise? We drive the car there at a medium speed – and Adora focuses on being as smooth as she can be. And no showing off. How does that sound? Scorpia? Perfuma?’

They were all in agreement, so chivalry bound me to be the same. Forget about the automotive derring-do and stirringly evocative descriptions I had planned: we motored towards Great Haywood post office with moderate urgency. The Sapphic sweethearts cooed and wooed. Bow fretted at me. One exceedingly pleasant but never pleasingly excessive country drive later, we sidled up to the relevant public utility, putting the Bentley parallel with a pair of fetchingly faux-Grecian columns that marked the office entrance.

‘Now what, Adora?’ Bow asked with keen urgency. He was raring to go. That was good; I could use that.

‘Well,’ I began. ‘First thing’s first: we’re not getting Scorps or Plumers caught up in this. Unlike me, they haven’t consented to

aid or abet this hopefully legal recapturing of your personal property. Ladies?' I queried. 'Would you be quite alright to hop out and take a gander at the River Trent over there? You know, to give you plausible deniability and all that?'

'A dusky waterside walk?! We'd just be delighted, wouldn't we Scorpy!!'

'Good stuff! Now, Bow, can you get us inside? I know you'll have your lockpicking kit on you!'

'Hey, I wasn't going to take that class for nothing!' He flourished his confection of sharp little sticks in my direction. 'How many doors are there? Where are they? What kind of locks are we facing? How many doors do we need open?'

'I do *not* know. There's one on the front there, can you open that?'

'The main door? Right off the street? Before it's even properly dark?!'

'Okay. Fine. I'll come with you, if you think a fancy-talking white lady is more likely to get away with very well justified breaking and entering?'

‘Yes, Adora, I DO think that. I think that a LOT. If I’m even seen getting walking past that door in a “suspicious” way, then that’ll be it for me tonight. Curtains. *Custody*.’

‘Really, chap? Isn’t that overstating matters a bit?’

‘*No*.’ He fixed me very firmly with his tone. ‘No, Adora, it isn’t. You can’t even imagine. You’re a white aristocrat with a famous name: you could burn the place down and get away with it if you gave the authorities a “terribly sorry” afterwards. Maybe even if you didn’t.’

‘Come now! I went in front of the magistrates for the Henley business!’

‘Yes, you did, and what did it cost you?’

‘Ten bob. But,’ I conceded, ‘it would have just been a stiff telling off if I hadn’t sassed the judge.’

‘And what was the maximum penalty?’

‘You know, I don’t fairly know!’

‘Theft is an indictable offence, Adora. That means it should have been tried in Crown Court – and you weren’t. Getting convicted means jail for a LONG time. I would’ve gone to jail. And you didn’t.’

‘Why do you know that?’

‘Because I need to.’

‘Oh.’

‘Yeah.’

‘Sorry, chum. That isn’t right.’

‘No, it’s not.’

‘Then I’ll help you. Here and now, I mean. But also later. When I work out what good help looks like. So, um, what are we waiting for?!’ I leapt from the auto – making my first door-aided dismount – and bounded up the single step. Leaning against one pillar like Glimmer drapes against me, I did everything I could to hide a busy Bowregard, while trying to look inconspicuous. It was a short-lived act. Before I’d even had chance to mime-masticate my imaginary chewing gum, the lock cracked open and Bow was in. I followed.

‘Where are we meant to be going?’

‘Bowregard, old chap, this might surprise you, but I don’t own a schematic of this particular rural post office. Look. There can’t be more than a couple of rooms downstairs, so let’s just search those. Glimmer only sent your letter down here this evening, so it should have been too late for the overnight dispatch, right? Which means it’s still here… *somewhere*.’

‘Maybe we can narrow it down from there, just a bit?’

‘There can’t be that much mail kicking around, can there? How much late post can this small village and the other, smaller villages next to it produce?! Finding yours is going to be a piece of cake, I promise. Or it should be. Once we know where to look. Bow, check this desk with me? Oh! Or can we see any half-full postbags?’

‘I can’t really see anything, Adora. It’s really dark in here.’

‘Okay, Bow, I’ve got it. You--- *ow*--- You get behind the big desk I just walked into and start checking its drawers, then hide behind it if anyone comes. Meanwhile I’ll go and get the Blower---’

‘You’re leaving?!’

‘Well… Yes.’

‘You’re leaving me, alone, in the post office we’ve broken into, right after we the conversation we just had? Adora. I’m sorry. But you need to do better.’

‘Come on, chap, I won’t be long. It’s not like we can turn the lights on in here – we might be spotted!’

‘Okkkaaayyy---’

‘So I’m going to turn the car around and aim its headlamps through this window.’

‘How, exactly, does that draw LESS attention?’

‘It’s more expected, isn’t it? Seeing a car all lit up at night is normal, but you couldn’t say the same about a post office.’ Bow had no riposte. He folded his arms. My logic was clearly flawless. ‘And if it all goes wrong, you just run through the door, jump in the seat and we motor away! Quickly! All clear? Good. Then without further ado---’

I stalked through the door, keeping myself to the shadows, then realised just how futile that was when the Blower ripped to life. Loudly. Aunt Shadowtha, prepare your chequebook! Surely the old matriarch would *have* to buy me one after tonight. What right-

thinking relative could possibly deprive me of the tool I'd used to save several days? We'd have to do something about this steering, mind. The wheel was set-solid cement as I pootled away, binding even my biceps as I tried to get the car to change direction.

There was just one thing for it – and that thing was speed! I backed up, reversed some more, then added an extra house or two of run-up for good measure. Once the post office junction was almost out of sight, I judged that I'd probably gone far enough. *Crunch* went a forwards gear. *Skwee* went the supercharger. *Yippee* went me. The Blower was made for this. Its controls snapped to lighter lucidity, and I arced to triumph in a nifty swan's neck curve that pointed straight at the post office windows.

Caged half-moons glittered in the glazing. That was my signal: the Bentley was on the perfect bearing. It was time to slow down. Already congratulating myself on some heroism well done, I started to apply the brakes. Hmm. We didn't seem to be slowing down. *Well*, scoffed I, *there's an easy fix for that!!* Hard down went my foot… and the Blower snorted forwards. Not great. The white-washed walls were really closing in now, which called for urgent, decisive action. It called for She-Ra.

FOR THE HONOUR OF GREYSKULL!

This was more like it! Rushing through the whole transformation fandangle, the powerful brightness deposited me back in my bigger, beefier self with a second or three to spare, which I planned to use very wisely indeed. Disaster could still be averted. Summoning every shred of my magical strength, I threw it all into a mighty lunge at the middle pedal---

Now. In my defence, the car stopped very soon after that, which is just *one* of the ways one could read the situation as a success. It's all about keeping a sunny disposish! Consider this: Bowregard now had all the light he needed. In fact, I doubt the Great Haywood sorting room will ever look gloomy again, so I'd call that a second objective met. And the third? That was the biggest slam dunk of all… No matter how I imagined the next few hours, I really couldn't see how anyone was going to pay his letter the slightest bit of attention. Not when they'd all be asking why half the post office was on top of a Bentley.

'*ADORA?!?* What made you think this was a good idea?'

'I DIDN'T!! It's the pedals! The accelerator moved!! Look. Bow. That doesn't matter right now. Do you have the letter?'

'Yes---'

'Congratulations, chum! Another Sir Adora mission accomplished!'

'This isn't funny. We need to get out of here.'

'Don't you think I know that, Bow?'

‘Then why aren’t you in the car? We need to be in the car. Leaving. Now.’

He made a good point, as he so often does. But not a complete one. Given the post office façade now contained a load-bearing bonnet, departing wouldn’t be quite so simple a job as just driving away, unless we wanted to add demolition without a permit to our lengthening list of pending charges. Hadn’t Entrapta highlighted how the legendary She-Ra helped the common man? Destroying local public services ran fairly counter to those objectives, accident or not.

‘Jump in, chum, you’ll have to drive the thing out. I’m going to hold up the wall, then we’ll… um… we can find something to prop it all up.’

‘Like what?!’

‘The spare tyres? I don’t know, Bow! Just--- It needs to be something. Are there any fenceposts around? Oh! And I need to leave a note.’

‘Which says?!’

‘That I’m really sorry, and here are my insurance details.’

‘Oh! Does that cover you for crashing racing cars you don’t really have permission to drive?’

‘Maybe! … No. Probably not. Just--- Give me--- I need a second to think.’

Taking a beat to breathe, the basics of the matter came back to me. I was She-Ra the folk hero, Sir de l’Horde the chivalric knight, and Adora the friend… and more than friend? Standards had to be upheld. And right now that meant upholding a building. Core engaged and stance taken, shoulders at the ready, I shouted at Bowregard to hit it.

‘Err… Adora? It won’t start.’

‘Eh? Are you sure? I’ll come and have a look.’

He was certain alright. So was I. It doesn’t take a mechanic to know that engine oil works better when it’s inside the engine. Our options looked slim, and getting slimmer, but a good She-Ra always knows to consult her magic stick. With a snick-snack flourish – there really was no other way to release her – I opened out Ms. Floaty-Cane and started tapping tentatively at the bodywork. No dice. Knowing that our mystical bond had its base in unimaginable power, that could mean only one thing. I wasn’t trying hard enough.

Bow darted back as I raised Ms. Floaty-Cane over my head, gripping her pommel tight in both my hands. I screamed into a jump, eyes ablaze, and put my whole weight behind the blade, plunging it deep into the bonnet. The pool of liquids beneath the car got bigger.

'Why did you do that?! What is meant to achieve?'

'Magic… fixes things?'

'Does that look fixed to you?'

'No.'

'And, Adora, does your sword cane *glow in the dark*?'

'Of course she does, chum. Light, dark, you name it! Glowing is just her natural state.'

'And you had the cane with you all along, including when we were in the post office?'

'Yes.'

‘And the sword-cane glows?’

‘Yes. We covered that. Why are you asking again?’

‘Okay, Adora. I know you were trying to help… but WHY did we need the BENTLEY to light up the office when your She-Ra sword was RIGHT THERE?!’

‘Listen here, Bowregard! The thing about that is--- That’s a really good idea--- Why *didn’t* I think of that?’

‘I guess it’s just one of life’s little mysteries,’ my chum mused. Either he was taking this awfully well all of a sudden, or he’d passed through his conscious anxiety and arrived at the eye of the storm within. My money was on the latter. ‘I’m sorry for shouting, Adora. If the car won’t move, can we get your sword and go now? Pretty please?’

No better options availed themselves, so it seemed like a good enough idea to me.

‘Fair enough, good sir. Someone’s in for a tough time tomorrow, but I guess there’s not much we can do about that ‘til morning. I say, I wonder whose Blower it is, anyway…’

I wouldn’t ponder much longer. As I leaned in to grab Madam Floaty-C., her luminescence let me know exactly where our blow

had landed. She was wedged deep into a row of letters. Letters split by her slash and a signwriter’s dash. “Double” read one side of them. And the other spelled “Trubel”.

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Chapter End Notes

What Ho! - SleeveGarters here! Breaking the habit of 25 chapters to duck in and say thanks for reading so far. I'd never written fic before Meowmeow - I really appreciate every kudos, subscription, bookmark etc. etc. And especially all the comments!

When I started all this for OpiumPoppy, I didn't think my little bit of Queer-but-make-it-Art-Deco nonsense would get even ten views... topping 1000 hits today is beyond my WILDEST hopes. So thanks so much! This love-fest to Catradora, Wooster, nice suits, country houses, fast old cars, exacting historical research, British eccentricity-turned-dysfunction and all the rest is going to full novel length (and then a bit further...) Really hope you enjoy the rest too!
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Chapter 26

Chapter Summary

'We kiss! Chapter 26 is here and we finally, finally smooch something Sapphic! And, um, do some more things than that. It was really rather exciting. On that note, reader-doodles, please note a change from our Teen and Up norm: CHAPTER 26 IS RATED MATURE. Now! Let that precious first Catradora night commence!'

'And only half a Volume after you asked my consent, Adora. Aren't you a fast mover?! By my count, including formatting, summaries and notes, our readers have waited 45975 words for us to lock lips. A *very* slow burn. Chapter 26 also marks the conclusion of The Inimitable Meowmeow: Volume 1. Volume 2 begins with Chapter 27, later this week.'

'Um... Catra? Just so I know. When did you first start hinting that you like-liked me?'

'Rather earlier in the story than you noticed, sir.'

'Well--- I can make up for that now--- May I? I always thought you looked hotter with that bow-tie undone...'

Chapter Notes

Rating Change: CHAPTER 26 IS RATED MATURE

Content warnings apply for the below chapter only - Spoilers may be present in the warnings. This story does not include any of the four Archive Warnings topics, but does occasionally feature other topics that may require content notes.

Chapter 26 Content Warnings (CONTAINS SPOILERS):
Internalised Homophobia - narrated, first person, main character (resolved during chapter)
Nudity - narrated, light detail

Sex, Lesbian Outercourse - narrated, major focus, some direct bodily detail, mostly euphemism and emotional response (no penetration, intercourse, genital contact or genital mention/description)
BDSM, Mild - Clawing/Scratching, narrated, some detail, brief (no bleeding, bruising or laceration)

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PART 26

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'*Catra, I need you*,' I imagined announcing, '*you and no-one else*.' I mouthed the words at the dark and silence, trying to sense how they might sound if or when they stumbled out of mouth, and into my existence. My stomach quivered somersaults. The night throbbed with fraying potential, desperately crammed into this single, tastefully-appointed corridor. Somewhere, away and across the Shugborough estate, a bell struck one. Flat and dull, the chime revibrated through me. The witching hour was through. Tonight had passed into tomorrow, and my plans had run their course.

All that remained was a confusion of promises, strafing beauty with terror. We four – and my missing, wordless fifth – had thrown down our cards. Dawn would show us where they laid. Briefly heard but scarcely seen, another game progressed within this house, linked to our own yet beyond our control. Its players dealt their own hands, working from personal card tables. They could be at it, even now, disguised in dusky silence. Sleep was easily feigned behind thick walls.

Stone hummed with pressure, wavering at the edges of visibility. Schemes and scans. A building neither dead nor alive. I steadied my rattling breaths, counting out the aches that rimmed from my sternum. The night weighed on me with what I could not see, and what I could not see *yet*. I leaned my head against the door, pushing into its solid chill, tasting its polished forest-fumes. Catra was lost and found, free and threatened simultaneously, until I turned that handle. The bedroom returned to me; its agony of unknowing made talons of my grasp.

Fear held me. Again. My afternoon anxieties were nothing, swaddled up by our mutual like-liking, but vulnerable reality stayed my hand. To kiss her was to destroy something precious and fragile – and to do it voluntarily. Spiking heart and clamouring skin, I whirled with its recklessness. Once our lips touched, we could never go back. She and I would throw off the life rings: the daters we imagine we can be; the *lovers*. Farewell our safety of what might have been. Hints and hunches wither, dying alongside untested potential. We would be real and amorphous and alive, together.

Shaping chaos and scrambling hope, faith in place of guarantee, she and I would emerge in a world anew. A private garden for us to make and tend and keep, as much and so long as we desired. It might be one kiss; it could be forever. I don’t know which scared me more. Stepping through this door would begin it, whatever it would be, transforming twin dreams into a realness we as a both, we as individuals, and so many unknowable features of the outside world might shape. My ribs stabbed again. The silence shattered to watchmaker clicks, as a house of sumptuous, ancient clocks rang out the hour.

Intricate, concentric mechanisms, spinning and striking towards a whole. Counting down every stately second, advancing irresistibly towards the Midsummer Ball and the reasons for our visit, which parts did Catra and I play? Daybreak was four short hours away. I itched with anticipating dread. The unreadable Marquioness Trubel-Brightmoon, soon to discover their load-bearing sports car. A furiously focused Glimmer, hellbent on folding me into her latest fun, and fencing Catra out. The returning Duchess Brightmoon, preoccupied with respectable order.

Three adversaries in the other game, plotting and acting moves I neither saw nor understood. Their successes could use mine, or dash it. One or more – and quite possibly all three – might be progressing right this second, staking new soil in a familial arms race. Even the idea of me and Catra could be doomed already. Until I saw more, in the blinding light of this next, fast-approaching day, I had no way to know. And when that happened, *they* would see *me*. *They* would see *Catra*.

Four short hours before the traitorous sun. Five before Perfuma bounced towards an early breakfast. Seven before Shugborough's less relentlessly healthful residents greeted the tea tray. These could be all we ever had, and I was wasting them. Come on, Adora. Either she was inside, awake, an hour into a so-far solitary vigil, or she was abed and asleep, rendering my panics moot, or she was nowhere to be seen, which demanded an instant She-Ra reaction. Stalking the corridor, treading with cotton wool calmness, the options ran me ragged.

The last elaborate timepiece completed its ritual, letting silence once again descend. Breath and mild tinnitus were all I heard. No room stirred. Whatever Machiavellian machinations the Brightmoons plotted were going on somewhere else. The time

was now, Adora. Seal the evening with a kiss. I rushed back, hand plunging to the handle, when realisation crashed across me. The door was blank: unnumbered, unnamed. It looked like every other door down this corridor.

My heart froze. Walking in on a sleeping or – heavens forfend – a disrobed Catra was serious enough. A Lady must have her modesty, and a knight must maintain her chivalry. And that was only the beginning. With no idea which room held her, I risked far worse. Intruding on a stranger or, at best, partial acquaintance, armed and unannounced, with no formal invitation or right to remain in this property, would paint a very dark self-portrait. Auntie might actually kill me if I tried that, right before she died of shame. A sigh dismantled me. The risk was too great; I had to forego the kiss.

Sinking to the floor, elbows on my knees and chin melted to my knuckles, I mourned her warming laugh, her smile, the promise of her touch. '*Catra*,' I pleaded to the air, '*I need you*.' I dreamt of her here, with me, now: the way she'd chide and care; the look from the side of her eyes as she giggled, leading me out of despair. I fished the stamp from my pocket and read it again and again, then flicked it over to analyse its topside. More secrets, I lied to myself, might lie on its surface. Perhaps some code or cipher, to show me the way.

This was the Lady Meowmeow, after all, I reasoned with a hefty squint. *Didn't she think of everything?* The paper vibrated inches from my left eye, in a vain hope the perspective could show me something I hadn't seen before. It didn't. I sniffed the stamp, paused to check for passers-by, then nibbled at an inconspicuous edge. Alas, the gustatory and olfactory gave me nothing more than whiffs of glue. Still, I persisted. Catra had peeled the post

before she'd even stepped aboard the twin-tone Duesenberg, already predicting and planning for her exile. If she could see *that* coming, I just knew she'd have accounted for *this*.

It hit me like lightning cracking awake a desolate moor. The stamp was the answer, just by being the stamp! My ingenious gentlewoman didn't need a hidden, second note to make her point, provided I knew the price of postage. The bottle green bagatelle I twiddled between my forefingers fronted only half the delivery fee from here to Oxford, so it must have had a sibling, once upon a time! And that second stamp was *not* on the envelope now. I'd confirmed as much with my own two eyes, on the long, awkward walk away from the rubble-infused racing car.

That second stamp was missing – and I had to find it. I was the detective. She'd said so herself. Hunching slowly up the corridor, scanning the gloom for a matching square, my desperation flicked from ceiling to flagstone, straining for anything out of the ordinary. Door five was my reward. There, tucked between the jamb and the bottom hinge. There stood the stamp. Oblong green and pushed in so far that no other eye could spot it, unless they were already on the hunt. It was perfect. It was--- *Catra*.

Heat and joy and fear flushed through me, coursing a vee from my seat to my shoulders. I wanted to knock. I *couldn't* knock. The other rooms might hear. But I had to do… something. I had to get inside. I'd wasted so much time already, and even a goddess like her couldn't stay awake forever. But I wouldn't break my oath. Or my chivalric, She-Raic code. Moving was impossible; waiting was agony. Fussing and futzing, I pivoted through mute, rejoicing angles, joyfully and agonisingly aware that she was *here*. We were planks and air apart. I leant into the slightest gap between door and frame, breathing my presence as loud as I dared.

‘Catra, I need you,’ I incanted. ‘You and no-one else.’

No answer, a muffled bump, swishing fabrics. Light sparked and burned around the door, low and golden. Almost soundless, the door clicked unlocked, shivering slightly. I stood aside, my ear cupped to my thou-wide confessional booth.

‘And I *need* you, *Adora*,’ she purred. Oh, sweet Catra. She was safe; my pulse beat harder. ‘Come to me.’

She was a siren song, and I was a sailor. Barely conscious of the actions, I threw off my jacket and swaddled the door handle noiseless, turning it so quietly that even I didn’t know it had unlatched until I tried my spare hand against the rails. I stepped inside, eyes on the floor. I didn’t know where else to put them.

‘I’ll give you a second for your modesty, Catra.’

‘And *I* will throw that moment away.’

She laughed a sigh. Out the corner of my eye, I saw her arch a sumptuous curve. I ached to see her. *But that is not how a good, upstanding young woman looks at girls, is it Dory?* Auntie, please… Not now. It isn’t like that. I was never like **that**. She… she **wants** me to look. Doesn’t she want me to look?

‘*Hey, Adora---*’

‘Catra… Am I alright to take a peek? At you?’

‘Adora? Are you okay?’

‘I… want to be. Can I look?’

‘So long it’s something you’d like, I *really* want you to see me, yes.’

‘Aunt Shadowtha always said---’

‘*Adora*. Fuck your aunt.’

‘*Catra?!*’

‘I mean it. Fuck your aunt, fuck your Hord Akmiral or whoever, fuck your whole *shitty* family.’ My peripherals showed her gentle arc harden into flicked italics. ‘After everything they’ve done, how *DARE* they control you *here*?! You are who you are, Adora. You love who you love. I see you. I’d really like you to see me.’

I gasped a halting glacier crack, feeling my throat give way. Wet spots crowded the carpet. A case I'd never known I was carrying slipped from my grasp, forever. Elastic lightness pinged across my waist and cracked a lifetime of limescale stress from my vertebrae. I wept openly. Busy in the blur, Catra skittered across the room, rapidly wrapped in a gown. There was thumping and rattling, followed by her support.

'Sir, Adora, sit down. Please.'

I did just as she said.

'Good, sir, good. Shall we get those shoes off, and that waistcoat? Would that feel better?'

Nodding, I stumbled up against the offending items. She was right. Shedding the damp, the cold and filth made for a marked improvement.

'Beautifully done, Adora. I have some helpers in mind for the next few minutes, if you want them?' She looked me over with rapt, anxious attention. 'How do you feel about some blankets? Or these velvet cushions? Here are some of the marbles I like to roll around, sir, and I've brewed you the mint infusion on the side table. Are you going to be okay if I step away, just for a minute?'

'Uh---' I sniffed. '---huh.'

‘I promise I’m coming back, Adora. No-one here is mad at you. I still like you,’ she said from somewhere over in the darkness. ‘I just need to fi--- Ah! There they are! What’s a knight without her steed?’

She placed Swiftie in my grasp, and everything felt suddenly easier. Perching farther along the bed, Catra checked me over, then sat silently nearby, which was perfect. The formless mental noise thronged my head out of shape but, for once, I got to simply feel my way through it. Nobody was shouting or demanding; none of my waves went inky or jagged. Heat seeped off into the space around me, leaving increasing clarity. I blinked back to sharpness and saw Catra was offering me another helper. Silk and velvet flowed through my fingers as I held them.

‘Who’s this, Catra?’

‘Melog. My Melog.’ She smiled, oh so gently. ‘We go everywhere together – no exceptions. We look after each other. She’s… my Swiftie, I guess. That’s why I had to bring *your* Swiftie when I saw him. I knew how much he might mean. You’re never too old for a cuddly confidante.’

We hugged, all four of us. I felt better. Gradually. My aunt fell silent. Embracing and embraced, we chatted softly, my safety establishing itself. Here, now, I was free. There was no more pressure, and portents belonged to some other space, far beyond the doorway.

‘How did it go tonight, Adora? Tell me your plans.’

‘That’s what I don’t get, Catra. What let you guess I had any plans at all?!’

‘This,’ she gestured. ‘All of this.’

‘Eh? You took the stamps because of where I’d woken up?! I’m sorry, sweet Lady Meowmeow, I just don’t get it. The whole business looks as clear as a kipper smokehouse on a damp Whitby morn. And just as forebodingly non-linear.’

‘Was that a *Dracula* reference, sir?’

‘No!’ I’d grown too used to wearing my reading lightly. Glimmer found long books dully unbecoming, you see, so I’d taken to not taking them with me places. But Catra was not Glimmer. ‘Maybe…’ I shifted slightly, jangled not unpleasingly by the sensation of revealing myself. My inner self, that is. You know, reader, I’m afraid that means I’ve lied to you, back in the earlier throes of this recollection. It’s true that I surround myself with quick flicks and crosswords for my day-to-day reading, but I’ve always got something more substantial on the go too.

‘Yes,’ I finished. ‘That’s my final answer. Yes, it is.’ The certainty thrilled me. Conviction budded where it grew: I was ready to smooch her. ‘*I feel in my heart a burning desire that you would kiss me with those red lips.*’

Catra grinned, blushing gently.

'*There is a smile on your face*,' she replied. '*Is it evident that no bad dreams come to disturb your piece of mind?*'

She was a reader! Of course she was a reader. Catra collected knowledge, after all, so my gentlewoman was hardly going to reject *literature*. Still--- What a treat to match wits with a fellow bookworm!! If it were possible, I was more attracted to her than ever. Fighting off a giddy grin, I sifted through Stoker's crypt, searching for the right reply.

'*I have been so miserably weak*,' I tried. '*To be able to think and move about is like feeling sunshine.*'

'*Knowledge is stronger than memory*,' she instructed. The bed was cleared; she kneeled upon it. '*We should not trust the weaker.*'

'*I am all in a sea of wonders*,' I confessed. '*I doubt; I fear; I think strange things, which I dare not confess to my own soul.*'

'*I want you to believe.*'

'*To believe in what?*'

I thrilled at the dialogue; she drove a single claw inside the knot holding her gown closed.

'*To believe*,' she purred, '*in things you cannot. Let me illustrate?*'

'*I throw myself on my knees before you*.'

The ribbon fell, and the satin followed, shrugged from her shoulders. She was the cat's pyjamas, minus most of the pyjamas. I throbbed; I swelled; I fought for her breath. She was stunningly beautiful. And then she kissed me.

Three fingers weaved and stroking through my hair; a cheek cupped in the warmth of her palm; the sweep of a gentle thumb, gliding away a last, involuntary tear. Catra kissed me with all of herself. Freeing my lips with a bare caress, she flew honey to fire, she sketched my cheeks as if she knew their every subtle contour, beckoning me to try in return. Honest and earnest, I gave what I could. My tongue skipped, blunted, but its passion burned, mirroring hers. She rose up, back, by subtle fractions. She sang assent and I replied, a question in my eyes.

The subtlest nod and her eyes sparkled, twin venturing universes. I dropped a hand to her waist and hips, mesmerising myself in their interplay of swept curves and breathing, vivid nuance. They shook me beyond the place I thought my senses stopped. Words were not here – but I whispered worship, ringing out. My touch told her who she was, to me. She purred and shivered abstract

depth, eyes swimming into mine, recognising what spoken language wouldn't let me show. I adored her.

We bound tighter together, gasping breaths, flushed with frantic, lapping rhythms. Our foreheads touched; our gaze flicked with them. She smiled her twin jewels to a brilliant set, crumpled with softening joy, as we kissed again. An enquiry and my smallest nod, then half her touch broke free, ribboning back in a two-finger trace. So slow, so urgent, she mapped my chin, my neck, my collarbone, pondering on the cusp of my shoulder with one, questioning point. I kissed her deeper, answering in a moan, muffled but real.

Her claws shot and raced my back, bucking me with wild truth. Tension shattered from my ribs; I hauled down a breath like I'd never tasted air before, crashing and heady. Shifting invitation, rolling my fluid form to newer, fuller freedoms, I opened the next few inches, asking for her response. Catra caught our kiss, staring steadily. 'Are you sure, Adora? Just to be clear, what would you like us to do?'

'Hold me there, like you felt my back, if you want?'

'I *do* want,' she smiled, brushing stray hair from my eyes. 'How do you feel about cupping me here… just a little… this time?'

'Yes, I'd like that.' I sank her through her thighs, savouring their taut precision. She astounded from this angle, her ankles flicked out to reveal glistering, sharp-toed high-heels. Peeling off enough of my own clothes, pulling back to syncopated overlap, she

consumed me. Lovers in amber, our beauty preserved the moment. Our lips touched, again, completely. We were making ourselves afresh. Together. Our hands paced and melted, moving us as one, a river cascading our connections.

My touch found her chest, tracing its proud, curving intoxication, its vibrancy, its soft weight. She leaned us closer and her nipple grazed flush, full heat, blossoming as her claws carved towards my rear. We paused, fluttering our assents. My slightest touch and her nipple snapped to pinprick sighs. One squeeze and she spiked delight. We flooded. Breaking free, neither of us asked. Neither of us had to. This was a beginning, not an end.

'*So full of life*,' I purred, unable to look away, '*and voluptuous beauty, that I shudder as though I have come to do murder.*'

She laughed, smiling, as she touched my hand.

'*The brave lover, I think, deserves another kiss, which she shall have presently.*'

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END OF VOLUME 1

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Chapter 27

Chapter Summary

'Welcome, reader, to our second volume. Our world has changed - and so has the question. You don't need to wonder whether Adora will kiss the smartest, most stunning woman she's ever met. We answered that one last chapter. But how is she going to keep this *goddess* in her life?'

'You can't see or hear it, chapter-chaps, but she's pointing to herself and purring. At her own beauty.'

'Can you blame me?'

'... ... No.'

'Just for interrupting me, you can tell them about the chapter.'

'Okay--- We're back to Teen and Up content, for starters. And do you like a locked room mystery? Because we've got one corker of a cranium-scratcher! Just how did Catra sleep through the below??!?'

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VOLUME 2

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PART 1

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Count Drac, that champion chap, knew how to go about getting into places. You wouldn't see the pointy-toothed fellow step such much as one foot over a threshold without an explicit invitation. Very caught up on consent was our famed Transylvanian. There's a pretty compelling case to be made, too, that he extended the same ruleset to his lunch ladies. Every woman bitten by Dracula went knowingly to her fate, after all.

And knowledge *is* power, isn't it? So the scholars incant. Bunched up beneath the covers, awareness certainly wasn't my problem. I knew what the coming day would send my way. I just didn't want it to. The cockerel crowed and the clocks clinked, announcing the sixth hour. A fiercely cheerful sun eviscerated the curtains. Breakfast was barely an hour away – and I had no way of getting at it. My stomach growled. The acid-splashed organ had a case, given the last things I'd eaten were Scotch, vermouth and, I think, about two-thirds of a cherry scone, sometime around six yesterday evening.

I pulled satin sheets over my head. More school play ghost than classically canonical vampire, I pondered how much easier it must be to live the un-life ethereal. Sweeping through walls solves a lot of problems, I imagine, ditto disappearing in a puff of smoke. Various Brightmoons wouldn't have a hope of tearing me limb from limb, either, if I no longer had arms or legs to rip. That *would* be nice. You see, unlike the aforementioned Dracula, my arrival at Shugborough hadn't been agreed by the hosting parties. At all. Neither had my departure. Nor my re-arrival, if such a term can be hyphenated into being.
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Back when Stoker penned his premier novel, the Count hadn't crashed any cars either. Not even slightly! The automobile had only been around for a decade, granted, but that still showed remarkable restraint. I was starting to feel like I could precipitate a mechanical mangling just by looking at a vehicle askance. I'd done a bit more than that with the Blower. Even if my Shugborough-bound existence could be explained away – and it most *definitely* could not – express mailing a Bentley left an undeniable paper trail. The enormity was starting to press on the old psyche a little…

'Catra---' I started. Then stopped. She was less than awake, which rather impedes one's capacity for intelligible conversation. Snoring the mannered effervescence more often observed from very expensive bottles of a fizzy water, my heavenly honey shifted softly, nuzzling into my ribcage. Her sprawled form took three-quarters of the bed, plus most of the sheets, but I wasn't churlish. I'd pay that price to have her near. I'd pay more. One hand nestled under her head, the other clasping Melog to her chest, I let her sleep.

Whatever else occurs today, I reminded myself, *there was and is still Catra*. I smiled, quite possibly for the last time. Because this circuit around the sun bore the Great Haywood village fete. The name was enough to drive any chap to bacon, eggs and blood sausage. I doubted I could face the fixture without them, but nor would I withstand the travails of the breakfast table without prior sustenance. You can, I'm sure, see my conundrum. Slipping out of bed, I tipped and toed across the room, looking for the merest nibble.

Stumbling on the Lady Meowmeow's cases, I immediately vetoed the concept of their inner exploration. Resourcefulness could be

Catra's middle name – if it wasn't already Applesauce – but a gentlewoman does *not* rifle through another gentlewoman's things. Under any circumstance. The same principle denied me a peek or poke into the drawers of Lady Plumers. Ditto the cupboards. Restricted to my own effects, I scowled at my encroaching disappointment. Bits of string and ticket stubs really aren't that edible. Still, eh, it had to be worth a look. Past me might have been accidentally practical. You never know.

Maybe ten minutes later, I sat pretzel-legged behind my quarry. Two strips of gum. A mint humbug of indeterminable age. Half a toffee bonbon, fetchingly upholstered in pocket lint. I grimaced again. One might as well get the practice in before going public. By any ordinary measure, this was not a meal, which made my agonising all the stranger… But which detritus formed what course? The twin chewers made the main, through virtue of their multiplicity, but I just couldn't decide whether the humbug formed the starter or an after-eight refresher.

This was all getting much too difficult. Impetuosity personified, I slammed the totality into my waiting maw. Maybe the flavours would meld. They did not. A saccharine textural nightmare unfolded in chew and suck and snap. Swallowing unsteadily, my throat rasped with the question of whether the gum should have gone down that way. Possibly not. Dry as the desert – and no more replenished – I hunted for other options. Two stood by the door. The trees.

Being more notanist than botanist, there was no way I might identify these overgrown shrubs on sight, so I swerved away from the right-hand specimen with the ingrained suspicion of a bovine by an electric fence. It bore fruit, but that fruit might be terribly poisonous. With no identification label and less knowledge, I had

no way of knowing. Thank Lady Meowmeow, then, for naming the other. Its lemon-like bounty were yuzus, the celebrated citrus of south-east Asia. Orange was a citrus. And orange *juice* was a smashing breakfast accompaniment. It doesn't take a logician to conclude that…

When life gives you yuzus, make yuzuade! Mine might be a simple genius, but aren't all the best ideas basic once you get wind of them? Except for the drinking glass, a juicer, a knife and some kind of sieve for the pulp, I was teetering on the cusp of my greatest breakfast breakthrough since my aged-seven intro to *pain au chocolat*! Plucking a leathery, grellow rugby puck from its branch, this would be no day-starting confectionery, but then, what was? The yuzu replied with silent, perfumed weight.

Sticking a fingernail into the rind was my first port of call. This achieved one smarting nail, plus a barely dented citrus skin. Doubling, then tripling the infantry numbers did little to shift the situation. A quick incision with the door key came next. Or so I hoped. The reality was more of a blunt splat, releasing a rich salt-cream tang and concaving the relevant fruity segment beyond repair. What I wouldn't have given for a pocket knife in that moment! Searching and snooping, I found none.

But I did recall that I was the She-Ra, something one really shouldn't so easily forget! Duh, and all that! Naturally, my mind reminded, the ancient role came with an ever-loyal, ever-sharp blade, ideal for preparing a delicious, nutritious pre-breakfast. Ms. Floaty-Cane, where art thou?! The sword snapped to my attention, unsheathing in a second, then hovered atop my head as I whisper-shouted "For the Honour of Greyskull!" as quietly as I could and as loud as I dared. Thank the ancients for tall ceilings!

Tossed about on chest-rightening lightning, Sir Adora de la She-Ra was ready to show this tree who was boss!!

A quick kick rolled the yuzu unevenly towards the centre of the carpet, just as I lofted the glowing blade behind my shoulders. Looking just beyond my upcoming refreshment, I honed towards a gap in my breathing… a space between my heartbeats… the perfect moment to announce a very hushed "Yaarrrrrrrggghhh!" Three, two--- There! Back thrown into it, I crashed the blade floorward with all my might. The citric orb didn't stand a chance. Surely, finally, victual-ry was mine.

Splat. Fire-flecked with the righteous fury of ancient Etheria, infused with the dignity and cultures of the First Ones societies, and just really bloody sharp, Ms. Floaty did what any unstoppable force does when meeting an un-unmovable object. Like a thundering Flying Scotsman kissing a bowl of fresh-set raspberry jelly, saccharine viscera detonated into every corner of human contemplation. Pips pinged against windowpanes. Chalk-white rind draped from the lightshades, forming the sea form atop a gelatinous yellow wave.

Tinted mist swirled around me, hinting at my sweet Lady's signature scent. That was nice. I took a second to enjoy it. Unfortunately, the smog did what all clouds eventually do and cleared, unveiling a clearer view of the carnage. It was a *very* thorough redecoration. Sweetish slime ringed the blast radius, peppered by waxy dandruff that flew even farther, tangling into our bedsheets--- and Catra! Crumbs. Rushing over, almost upending myself won the water-logged rugs, I scrambled to ready all my apologies.

They weren't needed. Not yet. Nose wrinkled with the smallest sigh, she'd slept through it all. And she was still dreaming now, incognisant of the seeds weaved through her grey-brown locks. That put me in a pickle. I never wanted to lie to her – and keeping something from her was a form of that dishonesty – but nor dared I wake someone still working their way through wink thirty-nine. Skulking back, I plonked myself on a once beautiful, twice unsalvageable chaise longue. Sorry, Perfuma… Its rose-tinted velveteen squelched reproach, guiding my gaze to a sword now firmly welded to the ground.

Sighing out my spirit, I trudged over to Ms. Floaty, placing a hand either side of her hilt. I groaned, I grunted. I risked lasting medical damage. It was no use. Pervasively insistent pulp coated the handle and my palms alike, seeming to sink so deep it might never come out. A Physicist will tell you that no frictionless state exists outside a vacuum. Said scientist hasn't tried pulling a magical sword out of a stately floorboard while everything is covered in exploded yuzu fruit. But isn't that always the problem with lifelong academics? They so rarely consider real world applications.

And problems rarely come more genuine than serving oneself a little snack. Hands slipping off my hips, I considered what I might do with the minutes before Catra awoke to my confession. There was no use in self-censure, and I was still hungry, in a room rich with remaining citrus. I'd try another yuzu. Wiping sodden mitts down my She-Ra assembly, watching the white turn mottled mustard, hoping its "skort" was somehow stain repellent and self-cleaning, my steps led me back to the tree. Off plucked a fruit, whose gnarled visage looked mockingly back at me.

Oh, but the citrus was clearly no reader! If it were, the sort-of-spherical fellow would know the wisdom of one Count Dracula, which tingled still so vividly across my short-term recollections. Literature expands the mind through new perspectives, you see. Old Vlad never let himself be stymied by an absence of cutlery: he just threw his trust in the knives of the mouth! Teeth, I'm meaning. Most likely the canines. If they could pierce a consenting neckline, then even the most slammed-shut rind should pose no challenge at all.

Cackling terribly, terribly quietly at the easiness of my final answer, I raised the fruit aloft and chomped. We fought for a second, the yuzu and I, but the teeth won out in the end. Pulp hit my cocky palette. Fruit-to-face was the new farm-to-table! I bit again, again, swelling my cheeks with sweet success, skin and all. Reaching, almost breaching, oral capacity, I tried a first fantastic chew. And my face folded in on itself…

Sweet *Greyskull*. I tasted everything. Lemon tangs and lime---also tangs, but in italics. Wedge a slice of either on your evening cocktail and you've got a pleasant little extra: a footnote beneath an enjoyable article in the 'paper. Yuzu wasn't that. Yuzu wasn't even the headline. It was the gigantic advertisement, painted or pasted full-height on a factory wall. Sharp citric flick danced over cherry blossom gardens, where rich, green thymes and sorrels sprouted on the banks of a dairy river, whose own tight, fuzzy sweet crashed into saline oceans. The food critic would have a field day – but I was a bit over occupied by a final, furious flavour that demanded I taste it.

Startling starling murmurations, up and down and back again, the yuzu crashed its revenge in lines of biting sour-bitterness. It plunged down my throat, burned the buds off my tongue, thinned

to a ceasefire, then bucked back to newer, saltier depths, over and over. Enamel fizzed off my molars. Moisture evacuated. Mix chard with old coffee grounds, throw the lot in a sourdough starter that traces its lineage to at least the Medievals, knock the result back in a single bite and you might – just might – be getting close. I needed a drink. Desperately.

Teacups and cut crystal loomed at the bedside, dusted in eternal citrus. Rind sludged against minty dregs and bloomed, cloud-like, through the hydration Catra had so carefully drawn for us mere hours earlier. I winced. Fire cannot be fought with fire. It held that yuzu would not be beaten by yuzu. The open containers were tainted. Rats. My mouth clamoured for a beverage drunk from some receptacle that had – somehow – avoided the blast. Something enclosed. My eyes alighted on a squat hexagon, stood on my sideboard, equipped with the elusive, all-important screw top.

Eureka, or whatever the old Greeks said when they meant "close enough". Half the size of my palm at most, the bottle wouldn't do more than a sip, but its lid was tightly closed. Relief raced through my desiccation: something still existed beyond the yuzu-ed realm. *That's Catra for you*, I told myself, *always a dozen steps ahead*. The diminutive tincture was an odd choice, mind, when her hip flask wouldn't be far from hand. Perhaps she hadn't seen the sword in the slime coming from a mile off--- which meant I might be manhandling her personal goods.

Oh goodness, oh cripes, and all the other "oh" phrases!! That wouldn't do at all. Hunting for prompts – desperate for some direction to either fill the bottle or put it back – I peered at its papered front and spied the script "Progynon". The name sounded dimly familiar, though I couldn't say how. I tried shaking it, like

I'm told children do when receiving Christmas presents. It rattled. And Catra shot awake.

'Hey, Adora,' she yawned. 'That's my oestrogen. You don't want that. Can you put it down, please? Those pills cost a *fortune* – I can't lose any.'

I stumbled them back whence they'd came, nodding apologies and blushing from the unintended privacy violation. Mouth clamped zestily closed, my hands mimed their way through a grovelling *mea culpa*.

'There's water on the side, remember?' she blearily directed. 'I thought you'd get dry in this humidity. Have a drink if you need one, bab--- *Adora*, I can always pour you another.'

I acted with more pronounced intention. Catra slowly blinked away her sleep.

'What do you mean you can't?'

Larger, incredibly specific gesticulating.

'You got *what* in it?'

Pointing at the offending tree, I waggled my fingers for extra emphasis.

‘Jazz? Door? Shugborough?’ Thumb and finger astride her nose, the gentlewoman pulled her vision taut. ‘Yuzu. The drinking water has yuzu in it.’

I nodded.

‘Everything has yuzu in it.’

I nodded again.

‘Very good, sir. Let me fetch a fresh carafe and a mop.’

Gulps and swept-off pulps occupied the next bunch of minutes, grease trickling from my elbows. *I was the one who made the mess*, I declared, *so I was the one who’d clean it up*. Catra insisted otherwise; I riposted with the other-otherwise. We settled on her dusting down the smaller solid matter, provided I hacked away at the slop. Sorry dropped from my lips time and again, until Lady Meowmeow, combing the last of the pips from her hair, asked me to stop.

‘But you don’t even know what I’m apologising for, chapelette!’ contested I. ‘Each and every sorry is for a different thing.’

‘I highly doubt you’ve got that much to apologise for, sir.’

‘Really, Meowmeow, you don’t know the half of it. I let Glimmer push you out of the car… I evaded the Duchess Brightmoon, the very reason we came here… I very nearly shacked myself up with Perfuma… Then almost sent her plummeting to her death… Terrified Bow… Told several people how much I like you…’

‘You shouldn’t be sorry for *that*, Adora. I like you too.’

‘That’s smashing! But do you know what else smashed? The Birkin Blower, into a public utility, with yours truly at the controls, while aiding and abetting what *I* think is absolutely justified, but the law might see as fraud or robbery. I’m not sure which. Add to that taking a car with flimsy-to-nil consent, driving without insurance, and failing to provide those none-existent insurance details at the scene of a smash. Then I stabbed it, for reasons that seemed strong in the moment. Is that illegal? It definitely doesn’t look good. Well, to top it all off, though I didn’t *break* Shugborough on the way back in, I definitely *entered*.’

The gentlewoman stayed entirely laconic, picking and brushing out a green-blue tartan wool suit as I spoke. While my worries rushed on, she selected a pinstriped pink-and-white shirt to go with it, equipped with devilishly pronounced darts and pleats. Swaying behind a dresser, she emerged in the closing stages of dress, stylish as ever.

‘Sir Adora, I’m impressed!’

‘Save your feelings for the big finish, Catra. Only you, Bow, Scorps and Lady P know I’m here. I’d wager fewer still have any clue you’ve made it back. The Duchess is on the warpath – and still blames me for everything conceivable – and Glimmer isn’t much better. But that isn’t the end of it--- Want to guess who owns the Blower?’

‘The Marquioness Trubble-Brightmoon, sir.’

‘How do you know that?!’

‘It came to me during my… unscheduled walk. They drove a Mercedes-Benz SSK when we crossed paths in Berlin, showing a clear preference for supercharged sports cars, while Glimmer walked straight to the rear seats of *her* Duesenberg. One does not generally place onboard refreshments where the owner does not plan to sit. The Duke and Duchess have little reputation for tolerating fast, loud, compromised automobiles. Since Entrapta works almost exclusively for the Brightmoons, the list of possible owners whittled itself down to one.’

‘So you’ll recognise that none of the family are going to be all too happy to see me! What--- What am I---’ stuttered my conclusion. ‘What are *we* going to do?!’

‘That’s easy.’ The clock in the corridor twinkled seven. Catra housed her silk tie in a contrast collar, then fitted her jacket precisely to her shoulders. ‘I believe, Sir Adora, we should finish dressing and go to breakfast.’

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Chapter 28

Chapter Summary

'They say it's the most important meal of the day, don't they, Catra?!'

'A concept popularised by John H. Kellogg, sir. It has no basis in fact. The man himself is a racist eugenicist who opposes vaccination.'

'Oh. Well. This chapter's breakfast was the most important meal of perhaps the most important day I've ever lived through!'

'Even more than today, Adora, my dear *fiancée*?'

'Ah. Oops! I suppose not. Let's say it was the most important day up to that point! It'd take a LOT of chapters to explain everything that happened... all the things I learned about myself... how Mermista finally arrived and justified her place in the Tags... so it's a good thing we've GOT a lot more chapters! And it all starts with kippers!'

Chapter Notes

Content warnings apply for the below chapter only - Spoilers may be present in the warnings. This story does not include any of the four Archive Warnings topics, but does occasionally feature other topics that may require content notes. Chapter 28 has extensive content warnings. If you just need a quick overview, please find a shorter list of the chapter's content warning themes below the main list.

Chapter 28 Content Warnings (CONTAINS SPOILERS):
Physical injury (first), minor - Narrated, self-inflicted, accidental
Physical injury (second), minor - Narrated, by third party, targeted deliberately at another person, hits narrator

accidentally, remorse implied (no lasting injury)
Food waste - Narrated, related, predominantly accidental, some purposeful
Drug use - Observed, present
Verbal abuse - Observed, related, profane, includes swearing, belittling, denial of others' feelings
Bullying, of major character - Observed, related, includes swearing, lying, belittling, denial of others' feelings, gaslighting, shouting, class-hatred of working class and domestic staff, deliberate refusal to use character's name (not motivated by transphobia/queerphobia) (Several other chatacters intervene to stop bullying)
Targeted attempt to remove other's food - Observed, purposeful, brief (target receives replacement food)
Vehicle accident, boat - Related, historic, brief
Violence, targeted attempt to cause physical injury - Observed, purposeful (no injury of targeted person, very minor injury of another person)

Chapter 28 Content Warnings, Themes:
Physical injury, minor
Targeted violence (minor injuries)
Bullying and Verbal Abuse
Food Waste

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PART 2

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The dining room was disturbingly tranquil, when I stepped through its threshold at ten past seven. Striking a forced, jolly air, I skated across the marble, picked up a hopefully appropriate

chair and, failing to figure any better use for the item, sat down. Squiggling a conversation with the seat base, I found myself rapidly informed that there was no way to get comfortable, so one might as well stop asking. Suitably chastened, there was little left for it but to spread a napkin over my legs, tuck another into my collar, and get to work on demolishing the menu.

One of the great strengths of the great families resides in their zeal for chow. Leave the chattering classes to crumpets and cornflakes, and us lower aristos to our tailored single dishes. Breakfast with the best means courses. And I do enjoy a meal with multiple plates. Grinning greasy anticipation, I reached out for this morrow's folded cardstock of earthly delights. I'm not sure I forgot my duties, necessarily, nor that there was truly less terror heading my way than there had been the night before. But all the involved emotions were fairly well squished by the dazzling and imminent promise of bacon.

No point facing fears on an empty stomach, that's what I always say! Shooting out a sleeve, my touch ventured towards news of multiple kinds of sausage and, one could only hope, a fish dish or two. I vibrated with excitement. A finger scraped the gold-flecked curls that cried out "Breakfast" – my shaking shimmied on. And yet! Alas! It was for zilch. Craning and straining and all the other musculoskeletal present participles you can imagine, I swiped heartily at the menu, but the truth remained. I couldn't *quite* reach: my stomach was bally displeased. The old acid-splasher growled like a guard dog trapped in a tumbling cement mixer, only twice as angry.

Yes, tum-tum, I murmured at my own anatomy, begging for stately decorum, but willing to settle for anything short of a scene,

I do hear you. And I quite agree, so why don't we simmer down and let brain think? Yes? Very good. Steady now.

Hrrrrr-fu-GRRRRR, came the reply.

Um. No! Bad tum! I hissed back. *Down boy!*

The staff were looking. Hidden somewhere amidst the fuss of Delftware and butter bowls, wine glasses and coffee cups, tchotchkes and floral arrangements, fruit and lace, silver and paper, and all the rest, I'm pretty sure the upstairs crew were staring too. Catra came running, breaking her usual glassy float to halve the distance between us double quick. Alas, she jogged in vain. My stomach snapped a third, fierce time and I shocked back, forcing polished wooden chair legs against polished wooden floor.

There's some family drama going on between those two matching surfaces, I reckon. They screamed and screamed to a dry gurgle. Loudly. The sound echoed the way only large noises in even larger rooms can. Any eyes which weren't on me before snapped across, and sharpish. So much for civil introductions. Who's who was looking at me remained a mystery, mind. I was too busy stumbling to a part-way squat, tucking both hands below the seat, and sort of sitting down again, crashing the whole arrangement into my knees, in the hope we'd garner enough momentum to drive our collective into easy reach of the cutlery.

In that, we succeeded, excessively. With a mightily Lords-like *cur-whack*, Miss. L. Patella made her forthright advance to a Mr. Table-Leg. She threw herself at him, honestly. Who can blame the

bloke for staggering back a bit? The tabletop bucked and shook overhead, strongly suggesting that its lighter, more imbalanced or more vertical guests might prefer the life horizontal. Vases crashed into side plates, jettisoning petals into jam jars and billowing a nectar-sweet waterfall down a stack of cereal bowls. Two or three cafetières breathed their last. Not to be outdone, a hideous and no doubt terrifyingly valuable cherub took flight for the floor.

He landed with a tinkle-smash. A fairly grim prognosis, that. No-one darted for the fellow. Downstairs and up were too engaged in keeping the table topside. Thrown off by its own momentum, the acres-long lozenge was building its sway into something awfully like a northwards teeter. Cracks and crashes swelled into a choir. Desperate, scrambling grunts sung back, my own amongst their number. We heaved. Sweet agony engulfed my kneecap, doubling down when Mr. Leg returned L. P.'s affections.

The table thudded home. Biting away the pain, I finally glanced up, meeting the looks of my fellow guests and residents. Their eyes were wide; their mouths were open. Their clothes were… Well. Hopefully they had more clothes. Nobody spoke, which seemed like an open invitation, from my perspective. I've always been told to wait for a chattering lull to introduce myself, and this *was* an especially complete hush. I cleared my throat, trying to remember my lines. Catra had consulted on the script before we walked in. I felt pretty good about it.

'What Ho! Aren't we having a positively *smashing* morning? Might I take a peek at the menu?'

The table stared back in wordless horror. Eventually, a maid fished a typeset survivor out of the condiments, wiped off the worst of the mustard, and handed it to me. A mechanical curtsey accompanied the action.

'Much obliged, thanks!' Whistling jauntily – much against Catra's advice – I showed my bonhomie with cheerful tunes and flicking pages, interspersed with proclamations like "Oh my!" and "How spiffing!" I meant every word. The Shugborough Hall kitchens had thrown off their mortal forms and transcended, so far as I was concerned. Here lay a breakfast that spanned up to ten courses! Naturally, a strapping chap like myself intended to taste them all, thereby proving my heartiness in the process.

'What may I get you, Ma---'

'*Sir*, if that's no trouble!' I beamed. 'And thanks a bunch for asking!!! I'll have… the fig compote to start, followed by the grape nuts, then try to see if the kitchen can get the fried smelts and some kippers out in one go, if it's all the same. Then the sauteed ox kidney! I see you've got "eggs" listed next – what styles does the chef suggest?'

'Thank you, sir. We offer eggs fried, turned, soft-boiled, hard-boiled, scrambled, and poached.'

'Those all sound great! Once I'm done with those, I'll move on to something approaching a full Etherian, featuring another fried egg, Gloucester sausages, mashed potatoes, plus the Wiltshire and the Ayrshire Pale bacons. Oh, and fried bread! Lots of fried

bread… Capital stuff, thank you. From there, let's navigate to a cold cuts board with watercress… griddle cakes with golden syrup… *croissants* and toast with marmalade… *pain au chocolat* and… I think that's it! To wash it all down? Hmm. How about… orange juice, Earl Grey and a Cadbury's cup chocolate, very many thanks again.'

She nodded and quoted a handful of minutes for my first course, which seemed terribly obliging of her, given the circumstances. I turned back to the main table, ready to re-embark on a bit of tailor-made nattering.

'I say,' I smiled, 'it's quite the collection those kitchens have going! What a credit to Shugborough Hall – and to the Brightmoons! Why, if you don't mind me saying, it hardly seems like all that could fit on the table---'

'Erm,' said Scorpy, between bites of porridge. She sat behind the empty space where the wine glasses had been. 'I--- Well. Gee, Adora… It *did*. I don't know how to tell you this, but it all stayed pretty much where it was meant to be until you sat down.'

'I'm sorry,' cooed her neighbour. Dabbing a napkin at an herbal infusion that infused a touch too far, Lady Plumers stared out and over a felled ceramic creamery with genuine upset. Her voice trembled as she tried to save her dress. 'Breakfast really was quite a *lot* easier before you arrived. It was--- it was--- a lot more *centred*, She-R---'

‘Regrets disturbing your breakfast, greatly.’ Lady Meowmeow cut purringly in, ‘She understands how *close* the situation *just* came to permanently *destabilising* the day.’ Catching my gaze, Catra flicked her head to the left, twice, towards a spectacularly fragmental chaos of Wedgwood, coffee grounds and peaches. I looked back in perplexity. She went on. ‘Your words reveal the *consequences* to her, Your Ladyship, which *light the night* towards her next steps.’ My confusion grew. Lady Meowmeow walked behind the table, standing herself behind a bearded gent deep in his *Financial Times*. ‘Of course, sir seeks to make this right. She will meet all attendant costs.’

‘*I will?!*’ I coughed. Eternal, internal chivalry kicked me into correction. ‘I WILL!!’

‘I’m glad to hear it,’ said the gentleman, between bites of his croissant, masticating with considered thought and regal bearing. Choking it down with a coffee-stained gulp, he turned to me with a ruddy, outdoorsman smile and slapped a calloused hand across my shoulder. ‘You don’t see that kind of responsibility amongst you kids too often nowadays! How good to see etiquette living on – as it should! That’s the world I want my darling girl growing up in!’

‘Think nothing of it,’ I returned, scrabbling towards some script. ‘The knight swears allegiance to her people and her code. I live to uphold both.’

He laughed a country squire boom. His cheeks bloomed red; his beard bristled the maybe-four-maybe-five coat colours of a time-served beagle. A hound answering the same description napped at his feet, unphased by the jammy, caffeinated pools either side

of their paws. The gent kept cackling, slamming a gold-heavy fist cheerily against the tablecloth. Rudely roused, the pupper looked around, sleepily, spotted my Spectators and made a new bed.

'Kiddo likes you, chap!' my new friend roared. 'And so do I! How come I've never seen you at Shugborough before? Noble bearing, righteous mind… You're just the right kind of fellow to have around!'

'Even after I ruined your breakfasts?'

'Ha-ha!! Don't worry about it! Ethyl, Mildred, Steven,' he called off, in the direction of our nearby attendants. 'There's a guinea a head if you can get us a tablecloth and fresh coffee in the next five minutes. No! Make it ten! I wouldn't want you moving too fast too early, and why should you?! Say! I'll throw some extra shillings at it if someone finds a mop!' He beamed after the scattering staff, then raised a querying finger towards Catra. 'You there, madam, in the chequers!! You set to it quicker than the rest when the food went flying. That's the right kind of pluck! Name your prize. I'm thinking two guineas… but I can be argued up!!'

'That really won't be necessary, sir,' Catra replied. Her modest bow sealed it.

'Hey now! I insist!!' the gent laughed. 'Shall we make it three guineas?'

‘Thank you, but helping others is its own reward.’

‘Well, I never!! That really is something rare and true. It’s a dining room full of dignity!’ The fellow smiled even wider, pointing a second half-chewed pastry my way. ‘Let me guess, friend? She’s yours?’

Burning through the day’s first blushes, I shook my head.

‘She is her own, sir, but she can always be mine too – if she wants.’

‘NOW *THAT*’S WISDOM!’ he thundered. ‘A good woman can never be trapped, and a good fellow never seeks to restrict her.’ It was entirely unclear whether I’d revealed that Catra and I were dating, or if I’d made an unintentionally insightful comment about the nature of sir-staff relations. Whichever, my words induced the chap to throw out a blistered hand, which I shook. We crushed each other’s grasps, his pinkie twinkly with a cygnet ring. Lady Meowmeow raised her eyebrows. Meaningfully.

‘About the table,’ I ventured. This was not a sentence I’d practised. ‘Should I be making that out as cash or cheque? And payable to whom?’

‘Ha! HA-HAH! Don’t you worry about any of that!’ My breakfast buddy smiled as he plucked the pen from my hand. He spun it in his fingers, laughed again, then slammed down the implement

with firm finality. ‘We don’t need your money – and you’re the right kind of chap for offering!! So put that coin purse away, won’t you? Meeting a fellow like you leaves me with just one vital question---’

Darting inside us, Catra took a very deliberate pleasure in offering her hand to our new acquaintance. He rose to his thunderous height and bowed deeply proper, declaring himself entirely charmed. Lady Meowmeow responded in kind, so far as anyone else could see. Her smile was grace and purity; her curtsey came perfectly choreographed.

The country squire took her hand in his and bore it high, dropping his kiss to her outstretched fingers. So, so deftly that the chap himself never knew, she pivoted their connection just a few degrees, sighing an honoured, comely and deliberately distracting refrain, until she’d put the cygnet ring in my full view. A crescent moon. A four-pointed star. A problem.

‘A true pleasure to meet you, madam,’ he boomed. ‘Now, where were we? Ah! Ha-hah! The one question, fellow to fellow! You know---’ he paused, leaning in, getting so close we had no option but very direct eye contact, ‘---what do you think of bringing your Lady in on the business, chap? Sounds good to me!’ I blinked. He took that as an answer, uncreasing himself and throwing his arms wide. My insides quivered. Catra wasn’t getting caught up in Brightmoon business. Well. No more caught up than she already was, at least.

‘Right! You two! Just looking at you, I know exactly what kind of people you are!’

I had to take control, script or no.

'Sir,' I tried, 'you have to know, I take full and complete---'

He kept going. I spoke, the words came out, and they had precisely no effect.

'Why else would I ask the vital question? You there, chap – and you, madam---'

Seeing no other options, I began the laborious, contorted process of kneeling from a tucked-in seat. Prostration looked like my only option. He stopped it short, lifting me back into my chair, and thundered:

'HOW'S ABOUT YOU GO RIDING WITH ME?? WHAT DO YOU SAY?!'

All my limbs were intact. Every bit of Catra stood where it should. No-one appeared to be threatening us with an oyster fork or, for that matter, with an oyster. I gawped slightly at the statement, replaying it, trying to take it in. Had the morning's first Brightmoon-based interaction gone… *well*?! I didn't have an answer for that. Luckily, and predictably, Catra did.

‘A very kind offer, sir,’ she mewed. ‘I would be delighted and so, I predict, would my gentlewoman. Sir is something of an equine connoisseur.’

‘Yes!’ I snapped, back to my senses. ‘I *LOVE* horsies!! But Auntie never let me have one. Why, I can’t tell you how dearly I’d love a day in the saddle… I’d be over the moon… I’d be over the ***Brightmoon****!!*’

The pun was neither entirely riskless nor entirely voluntary. I sat there, waiting to see how it might play out. My first slew of breakfast crashed into place. Somewhere amidst our chatters, the table had been fixed, entirely outside my comprehension. Deluxe deliciousness played on my nostrils. The compote was getting warm and the kippers were getting cold – but I daredn’t turn around. Our Brightmoon fellow snatched a sharp, deep breath, as if fit to sneeze. He wavered and paused. I waited some more. Then guffaws and backslaps rained forth.

‘Over the Brightmoon! HA-HA!! I **LOVE** it! Guess that means you’ve worked me out – isn’t that right, chap? Hahaha! It’s a fair cop… I’ll come clean… Duke D. D. M. K. Brightmoon of Mystacor, at your service!!’ He leaned in again, cupping the back of a conspirator hand. ‘But you can just call me Micah! That’s the M.’

Micah winked, half-bowed at Catra, then beckoned her to sit with us. She demurred, but he insisted. More fish arrived. If all apologies went this smoothly, I mused, then I had to find a damn sight more to be sorry about! We ate; we chatted; we enjoyed bally chipper bonhomie. Scorps and Plumers made it into the conversation too, as the former dismantled a mountain of porcine products and the latter worked at the citric demi-monde of a fresh

grapefruit. I stamped down thoughts of yuzu. Catra held my hand. I squeezed back. A jolly good time was had by all!

For about five minutes.

'*FUCK*-a-doodle-do *FRIENDOS*!' Glimmer emerged from a cigarette fog, dressed in the kind of impracticality that said no, she hadn't done a day's hard work in her life, and, *no*, she did *not* think trying it out for a change would be fun. 'Bugger me gently and whisper sweet shit in my ears, it's time for fun at the fair. *Perfuma*! Did you finish the arrangements like I asked?'

'Yup! I got them in every colour you asked for – and more!'

'I *loooovvvve* it,' she drawled back. '*Bow?* Babe? How about those special stalls I wanted?'

Silence.

'Glimmer?' Lady Plumers spoke up. 'Bowregard isn't here.'

Never taking her eyes off the ceiling, Glimmer chuckled out a smoke ring.

‘Well, *some*one *is*. Yuuuummmm. I can smell them.’ She slammed the air back like a daiquiri. ‘Yah, that’s it… *Hey, Dory*… When did you get back?!’

‘And a good morning to you too, Glitterbug. Sorry about the whole running out thing… We got back in the early hours… It’s just… Bow and I thought we could do with some fresh air… and some not seeing the matriarch quite yet…’

‘Wait.’ sounded Micah. He looked concerned. ‘Is there some reason you don’t want to meet my wife?’

‘*Eeeuurrrrrrrr*,’ Glimmer foot-stamped. ‘*Daaaaadddd!!* Why do you *think* Adora doesn’t want to see mum?? The *BOAT* thing, maybe?!’

‘Oh. You’re *that* Adora,’ the Duke deadpanned. I had a sneaking suspicion we weren’t going to stay on first-name terms much longer. ‘The Adora from university – and the Henley regatta.’

No use denying it. I nodded.

‘*WHY* didn’t you *say* so? Are you a hugger?!’ Micah wrapped me in his arms, wringing me out like a poolside towel. ‘ADORA!! Welcome to Shugborough! I can’t tell you how good it is finally meet you, after all these years. My little moonchild has the best friends a father could ask for in you and Bow! Glimmer talks about you constantly, don’t you, my dearest?’

‘Err! Dad, stop! I talk about them *sometimes*, I guess. That’s all.’

As much as the fug tried to obscure it, I noticed something I can’t say I’d ever noticed before. Glimmer was going gradually, relentlessly rose pink.

‘It’s alright, glitterbug,’ I called back. ‘I chat about you too. All the time, in fact!’

‘Of *course* you do, Adora. I’m a *princess*.’

‘You very well are,’ I nodded. I turned to Micah, then nodded again. ‘She very well is. Now. Your Grace. I don’t know how to put this--- Aren’t you cheesed about the boat thing? Or hopping mad over how I swanned into your house? I’m really, *really* sorry---’

Micah shrugged.

‘It’s okay in my book. We’re all friends here! Glimmer told me how the boat thing happened, and I think it’s cute. Admirable, even! You really go the distance for her, chap, and that means the world.’ He smiled, taking a hand off my shoulder just to clap it down again. ‘As for getting in here? A friend of Glimmer is a friend of ours, isn’t that right moonchild?’

‘*DAD!!* You don’t have to be so *NICE* all the time. Mum still *hates* Adora, *remember*?’

‘Your mother’s a reasonable woman, kiddo! If she gets to know the chap I’ve met this morning, then you can rest assured it’ll all work out. Now, now, my little songbird, I hope you’re not too slick to sit down to breakfast with your old man?’

Glimmer twitched slightly. She was still very pink.

‘I had the cook make your *favourite*!’

Well, that did the trick. Her Ladyship raced forwards, tripping smiles into the seat opposite.

‘Oh *DADDY*! You DO love me!’

A bowl and a hush descended. I peered over. In this house, for this woman, Eton Mess was a breakfast food. Nibbling meringue and gnashing strawberries, Glimmer had eyes only for her daybreak dessert. Until she didn’t. Looking up, she saw Duke Micah, and smiled. She saw me and smiled differently. And then she cast her gaze over Catra.

‘What is *she* doing here? *Dory*?’ Her pupils raced. And scathed straight through me. ‘Adora. Answer me.’

‘Ha-ha! I don’t think she’ll answer if you put it like that, moonbug,’ Micah chortled. ‘They’re delicate, these matters of the heart.’

Glimmer stuck a fork in the table. It emitted a tuning fork hum. F sharp.

‘Oh… really… *father*? Are… they?’

‘They are, my dear daughter. There’s nothing more serious than a woman’s affections! Adora had the most beautiful way of putting it. Help me out here, chap… What was it you said? About that Lady of yours?’

The light burned inside me. Catra squeezed her consent and confirmation. I would not hide her.

‘She is her own, yet she need only ask and she is mine.’

‘It’s romantic. It’s perfect. It’s… IT!!’ an enraptured Micah beamed my way. ‘She’s a lucky woman, that girlfriend of yours.’

‘*GIRLFRIEND??!?!!!*’ Glimmer was shaking, shrieking laughter, armed with a fish knife. ‘No. ***NO!!*** **FUCK NO.** Father… *NO*… That… fucking… *thief*… is… ***NOT***… Adora’s… *girlfriend*!!’ Lady Brightmoon laughed unevenly, grabbing the grapefruit straight out

of Lady P's bowl and popping it to pulp in her spare hand. '*SHE'S HER MOTHER**FUCKING** VALET!!*'

'Erm… Glimmer, hi.'

'SCORPIA, I SWEAR TO *FUCK*! IT CAN WAIT.'

'Um. No. *No*, actually. It can't. You broke up my girlfriend's breakfast and, well, ah, gee, you can't do that.'

'WHAT, HAS THAT MANGEY PISS-STAINED *FLEA PIT* SUNK HER CLAWS INTO YOU TOO?'

'Excuse me,' Lady P cut in, 'but you don't talk that way about Catra!'

'WHO IN THE LIVING **SHIT** IS CATRA?'

'Charmed, madam, I'm sure,' my gentlewoman purred back. 'You remain free to call me *Meowmeow*.'

'I'LL CALL YOU WHAT I FUCKING FEEL LIKE – ***ALLEY-CAT***.'

‘Ladies,’ Micah attempted to intervene. ‘Do we need to be doing this? And on the day of the fête? Can’t we all get along together?’

‘*Glimmer*,’ Perfuma added, ‘she *really* helped me out. And have you *seen* her aura?’

‘Perfuma. Is who I’m dating.’

Scorpia’s clarification did not meet a willing audience. It met a Glimmer, which, at that moment, was the dictionary definition of an exact antonym. She turned to Scorpy and roared:

‘SO???!?’

‘Um. Right. So you’re going to give her another grapefruit. And an apology.’

‘OH I *AM*, AM I?’ Glimmer picked up a pair of the fruits, weighing the first in her palm, then grinned something fierce. She rolled them hard Meowmeow-ward. ‘SHIT, I’M SORRY *SCORPIA*. LOOKS LIKE I’M… TOO… BUSY… *DISCIPLINING* THE ***STAFF*** TO HELP.’

Stepping aside, taking me with her, Catra moved us out of the firing line. Solid and massive, the citruses fired off the tabletop like a pair of cannonballs. They landed with a *thud-splat*. Lady Meowmeow went after, ducking down and turning round to grab them. Glimmer spotted her moment, scrambling up onto the

dining cloth. Plunging one hand deep into the Mess bowl, she came up laughing, swinging, with a sordid chunk of dairy. Her arm wound back.

'*GLIMMM-AHH!!*' echoed a shout from the saloon. '*What* is going on in there? We do NOT raise our voices at breakfast.'

'*Nothing, mum!!*'

'Now you've done it, moonbug.' Micah was on the table now too, trying to release at least one weapon from her daughter's grip.

'Pearl Bonnibel Glimmer Luna Amity, that is *no* way to speak to your mother. I'm coming in on the count of three. One…'

Catra straightened up, smiling her kinship with Perfuma.

'All yours, Lady Plumers. I just despise wasting food---'

Glimmer hurled her hand forwards.

'Two…'

White and red and sort of purple, the masses of summertime pud started to swing. There was nothing for it. Sweet Lady Meowmeow wasn't getting any more saccharine on my watch. Oh, stuck fast Ms. Floaty-Cane, hear me now!

'*FOR THE HONOUR OF GREYSKULL!!*'

Micah gawped. 'You're--- You're---'

The dessert floated through the air, slipping the surly bonds of my friend's right mitt. Glimmer's gaze popped out of her eyes with a dreadful understanding. Of what she'd just done. And what she could not now undo.

'Oh. Fuck.' she said, very small. 'Fuck no. Adora. I'm so, *so*---'

'Three!'

The door slammed open. Draped in silks, furs and silver, the Duchess Angella Brightmoon of Mystacor threw her hands on her hips. '*GLIMMM-AHH!!* I *demand* you tell me what is going *on* in here. And *who* is that woman in white?'

Two strawberries and a splodge of jam collided with my cheekbone, duking me round with a double cream follow through. Squinting through a fine, fructose mist, my blazing blues said their

What Ho! to the one woman in the room who wouldn't be happy to see me.

'Sir Adora de l'Horde,' the Duchess hissed. One tightened chin muscle aside, she did not move. She was very sharp and almost silent. 'Just *what* are you doing in--- my--- *house*? Glimmer, what is going on here? Consider your words *carefully*. They may be your last.'

'Angella! *Cara mia*!'

'Yes, Micah, *mon cher*?'

'My love, believe me! This chap, Adora, she's one of the finest fellows I've ever met!'

'She embroiled our daughter in a national scandal.'

'Come now! Angella! You know our little moonbug can do that all by herself.'

'*DAD!!!*'

'Micah. The de l'Horde girl is trouble.'

‘My turtle dove, cut the de l’Horde girl some slack. She’s just young and in love.’

‘With our *daughter*? Micah, do you have any idea what that---’

‘Oh no, Your Grace,’ Perfuma smiled.

‘NO. ***NO!*** Don’t you fucking say it, flower girl,’ Glimmer panted. ‘It’s not true. **IT’S NOT FUCKING TRUE**.’

‘I’m pretty sure it is,’ Scorpia nodded. ‘We spoke about it. Perfs and I were going to invite them on a double date! Wouldn’t that be sweet?’

‘*HOW CAN IT BE SWEET, SHIT-BRAINS, WHEN SHE’S… JUST… A… FUCKING… THIEVING… **VALET**??!*’

‘Hold on,’ sighed Angella. ‘Glimmer, explain yourself. Who is your friend in love with, and how did it impact the Regatta?’

‘It *didn’t* impact the Regatta, mother, because Adora is not *in* any relationship. Yet.’

‘No, no, I think you’ve got it wrong,’ Perfuma cooed. ‘Isn’t Adora in love with Catra?’

Glimmer threw her head at the heavens – and the rococo plasterwork – and let out the longest, loudest, most primal scream I might ever hear from a woman holding handfuls of meringue.

‘She’s always had big feelings,’ Micah confided. ‘That’s it, my honeybunny moonbug, scream it out!’

Angella turned my way, looking me up, and up, and down.

‘Sir de l’Horde, why are you dressed up as Arth-Red? Do you have a booth at the fête?’

‘Sorry.’ There was no good way to answer: only a choice between headaches now, headaches later, and my script. I chose the script. ‘I am very, *very* sorry.’

It turned out not to matter. Micah was back on the table, fruitlessly trying to render Glimmer fruitless. The Duchess was embarking on a strident conversation with her Duke. Perfuma was crying over spilt grapefruit juice; Scorpy bounced between consoling her date and cursing Her Ladyship. I stood motionless, atop my chair, dripping dairy.

There was a brief knock at the door, which Madam Meowmeow obligingly opened. The Marquioness strode inside.

‘Darlings! Has anyone SEEN the keys to my BENTLEY?’

Nobody answered. Double-Trubel looked around, and then at Catra, who was idly adjusting her shirt cuffs.

‘Is this not a GOOD time, kitten?’

‘It is hard to say, my liege. The household is entering the festive spirit.’

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Chapter 29

Chapter Summary

'Let me tell you about the birds and the bees, reader-folk!'

'ADORA!! We aren't at that point in the story yet, are we?! I thought we were writing that chapter together!'

'No, no, Catra, it's not the... the... *y'know* scene. I'm telling them about that time my hairdo turned all creepy-crawly. Then it's just a matter of you and Lady P and Glimmer all being important this chapter, and you all being women. A lady can also be a 'bird' and there you have it - a pun, or play on words. 'Birds', to wit, 'bees', to wit.'

'Even educated fleas, to wit. Let's do it, let's fall in love.'

'Oh, Catra! I'm several steps ahead of you. I already love you.'

Chapter Notes

Content warnings apply for the below chapter only - Spoilers may be present in the warnings. This story does not include any of the four Archive Warnings topics, but does occasionally feature other topics that may require content notes.

Chapter 29 Content Warnings (CONTAINS SPOILERS):
Violence, targeted attempt to cause physical injury - Related, historic, brief (no injury)
Targeted attempt to remove other's food - Related, historic, brief
Gun violence, shooting at people - Related, historic, brief (no injury)
Threat of gun violence, gun pressed to target's body - Related, historic, brief
Food waste - Related, historic, brief

Incomplete apology - Narrated, related, perpetrator fails to acknowledge their intentions

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PART 3

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Fair is fair but this was fête. Candy-striped tents chained for chains and buzzed humanity from their open sides, spilling fabrics light, bright and, where applicable, rolled up to the elbow. The Etherian summer uniform. I wore the same. I couldn't very well continue with my breakfast-time outfit. Catra and I had scrubbed with all our might, but the strawberry jam whiff just wouldn't shift. Even sparking in-and-out of She-Ra from didn't dislodge it. The first-flight clothes had to go.

Lady Meowmeow, quite naturally, and quite fortunately, had come prepared. Time was of the essence. Entering minute three, the gentlewoman's gentlewoman extraordinaire was teasing open bags and brushing garments, all at once, in the same series of wrist-driven flicks, disgorging a chipperly cheerful second-choice look for the day. Thirty seconds more and I was quite undressed. I'd have started blushing, or kissing, or both, but there really wasn't the time. Instead, my attention fixed on the stylish combination she'd assembled. I liked what I saw. Very racy! Village fêtes were clearly one of the few places where Catra gave my gaiety her sartorial stamp of approval.

Soberly plain white shirt installed – the one subtle nod that, she assured me, accentuated everything else – it can't have been another ten seconds before she was pouring me into sage green linen slacks, affixed by a brass-studded belt, then teasing horse-heavy socks over my feet. She capped that crew with tan-tending-orangey brogues, but they were just a tease for the finale. For the *jacket*.

My latest, and favourite, purchase, this giddily contemporary construction is just the thing for the knight around town who wants to cut a dash in the most dashing style. Or so the salesperson had told me. It's a giddily contemporary construction, very much in want on the right event to wear it at. Wide, padded shoulders meet a dropping waist and double breast, you see, cheered on by gold-plated buttons and a near-triangular collar that just makes me fizz! Were that not enough, it's quite exactly the colour of a mint humbug, striped vertically in white and green. I love it. But I couldn't begin to tell you how to wear it.

Catra knew. Unbuttoning my shirt deep, *deep* down my – minimised – chest, pinning twin lavender sprigs to the jacket's breast pocket, draping a loose-tied, burnt-yellow ascot teasingly about my throat, she made me the model of rakish relaxation. Just as well. I had to inhabit the look entirely if I was going to have even the first chance of making it through the upcoming festivities.

Our massed amble away from the Hall had been a frosty affair, you see. Nobody let themselves get caught talking to anybody else. Breakfast hung heavy in the air. Literally. Wasps and bees – all the buzzers, basically – took ever-strengthening interest in my confiture coiffure. I fretted about the Staffordshire ecosystem. My hair was sending it irreparably askew.

Only my pocket plants were escaped unscathed. That was strange. Notable, even. But a home engineer knows her mantra: it doesn't matter why something works, so long as it does. I bent down as we passed the farmstead and crushed as much lavender as I could, smearing it gingerly across my nogging. For dissuading the wasps, this worked stunningly well. The bees? Not so much. The friendly bumblers flocked my way. So, mercifully, did the welcome attentions of Lady Plumers.

'Ah! Don't you just adore the aroma?!' she smiled. 'And they're such easy flowers to grow. And so friendly to the wildlife! Oh, She-Ra, honeybees just *adore* them!'

'That's rather the problem, Perfuma dearest. Any idea how I can encourage them back somewhere more flora than Adora?'

'Yes!' she clapped. 'I have just the thing! She-Ra, do you mind if I spritz you?'

I did not, so she did, producing a repurposed perfume bottle with a handwritten label. Curlingly cursive, with little hearts over the dotted letters, the writing left little doubt she'd summoned it forth from her own pen.

'There you go. It's peppermint with a little clove: *really* essential oils! The bees we get here in Etheria don't like strong smells, so my little concoction encourages them to flutter away without hurting them. Isn't it just the best? But you have to be careful

with the aromas you choose… Some discourage bees but attract wasps – or vice versa, just like lavender. No need to worry with my personal blend! It's specially formulated to shepherd every insect off to where they'll be happiest. And it doesn't harm a hair on their fuzzy little thoraxes!'

'Dashed smart stuff,' I mused. 'But--- well--- Lady P. Aren't there bigger matters at play? If you don't mind me asking, are you okay? Since breakfast, I mean? I'm mighty apologetic for all the commotion.'

'Hmm--- It wasn't---' Perfuma weighed her words exactly. 'I prefer a more peaceful start to my day, thank you for asking, but I can tell you didn't do any of that on purpose. And you stood up for Catra, of course!! Glimmer, on the other hand---'

We glanced, united, at the Lady Brightmoon, who did not look back. For our walk's duration, the Countess had stepped alone and unerring, a ghost in daringly Parisian couture. From the instant she'd stepped down off the dining mahogany, Glimmer had hung in place, expressionless, her arms limply by her sides, her glassy eyes fixed somewhere in the distance.

'Quite,' I found myself replying, more annoyed than I'd realised. 'Quite.'

'She'll have to talk soon,' mused Lady P. 'We *are* running the fête together, after all.'

‘About that, your Ladyship. I did get you some replacement plants, as it happens, but I seem to have left them in my--- your--- my--- *the* bedchamber. Two trees. One yuzu and one… um… other interesting fruit.’ I paused. I was not about to falsify myself. ‘Look. I’ll be honest, Lady Plumers. Catra saved my skin – she’s the thoughtful one, not me.’

‘Oh, She-Ra, silly! You’re plenty considerate too. Remember last night?’

‘Vividly!’

Her gardening Ladyship looked at her practically pretty shoes. Whichever meanings she’d parsed from my one word answer, she tactfully side-stepped discussing them.

‘*Any*-way,’ she continued, ‘Catra actually already told me all about it! But I really do appreciate you being so truthful. You’re such a good egg! And the trees are going to make it here in time, so there’s reallt nothing left for you to worry about. So…. Thank you! Thank you, thank you!’

She hugged me, cheerfully, pearls clattering.

‘Steady on! I doubt I’ve done enough to deserve that.’

‘Oh, but you have.’

‘I haven’t, chapelette, and I won’t rest until I’ve paid the debt in full. Lady Plumers, what can this knight do for you?’

‘Hmmm… Hmmmmmmmmm… Hmm. Now that you mention it, Adorra, do you know how the Great Haywood fête works?’

‘I thought it’d be down in the village itself but, looking around us, it very much isn’t. So I’d have to say no, I don’t.’

‘Oh, being on the Shugborough Estate is part of the whole tradition! Reeally, it’s the main part, so far as the Brightmoons think about it. The Duke really appreciates everything the local communities do for him and his, so he organises this annual shin-dig on his own grounds, with everyone who’s anyone at the Hall providing the attractions. Isn’t that sweet?’

‘So it’s festive misrule, is it? The common man is the King, and the King clips coupons. I could get behind that! Only – I don’t think I’m down to really *do* anything.’

‘That’s what I was going to ask, you silly goose! She-Ra, my brave knight, I’d like you to come with me to the judging tent. Then we can see what roles are left and find you something fun!’

What I hadn’t appreciated was the nature of that “we”. It wasn’t simply I and she. The plural also included event co-coordinator

Glimmer. Her Brightmoon presence stood watery and wounded beneath the canvas, boxed off by the whitewashed trellis table that divided us. Its slats wobbled with a cash box and a clipboard, a bunch of daisies and four fondant fancies on a florid tea plate. This was it. The heart of operations. The epicentre of twee.

'Hey Adora,' Glimmer choked across at us. 'Hi Perfuma. I'm sorry. I'm so, so, SO *really* fucking sorry. About breakfast. About *all* of it. I don't know what came over me. Really, Dory. Perfs. I *don't*. I'm SORRY… okay? I fucked it. Like really, reaaallllyyyy fucked up. It's all gone to shit. Completely. To shit. I'm sorry.'

We gawped over our folding chairs. Glimmer is awfully fond of sartorial shock tactics, but she'd never worn anything that jarred like genuine contrition. Even her Elsa Christaelli collection couldn't compete. I had no idea what to say. Somewhere deep beneath the furs, the gems, the gold, the scorpion shoulders and the bandage-tight bodice, Lady Brightmoon peered out with something terrifyingly real.

'*Glimmer*,' Plumers tutted. 'You destroyed my morning meal and threw yours at my *friend*.'

'I'm sorry, really--- I didn't mean to hurt you. Either of you.'

Oof. There it is. That sentence. The one that really Meltoned my Mowbray.

Now, it's one thing to open fire at a friend, or to plaster them in pudding, or to encourage them to leave behind the one family member who had ever given them peace and comfort and unconditional love. I could forgive those. I mostly had. But to treat your actions with bare-faced dishonesty, failing to acknowledge them for what they really were? That was something else. That was *lying*. And Sir Adora de l'Horde does not stand for lies.

'You and your cousin,' I coldly metered out, 'stood up on a hill and shot *at* us. Repeatedly.'

'SHE DID WHAT??!??'

Ah. I had neglected to remember this was new information to Perfuma. She was taking it about as well as could be expected. She was taking it badly.

'Dory, I *knoowwww*,' Glimmer implored. 'I'm SORRY. You've got every right to be pissed off! But I didn't *hit* you. *Fuck*. I didn't mean to---'

'Just what didn't you mean, Glimmer? Because it sure felt intentional when you held one pistol up against my head and the other to my… my… *country garden*.'

'I thought you weren't you! Shit, Adora, we've been *over* this. *FUCK*.' She was crying now. 'I was *so* afraid that some impostor

had taken you and Bow! I was *angry*. Don't you get it? I was ready to literally fucking kill to get you back. That's how much you mean to me, Adora.'

'But it wasn't just me you were aiming at, was it? There's a whole living, breathing woman you haven't even mentioned.' My voice was eerily steady, the only anchor in a bursting emotional storm. '*Glimmer*. What about Catra?'

The Countess met my gaze. Her vulnerability washed away. Her eyes were level, cold and strangling.

'What *about* Catra?'

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Chapter 30

Chapter Summary

'Oof.'

'What is it? Catra?! Catra, are you okay?'

'Adora, are you? Glimmer falls *so* far below what'd I expect of a friend.'

'Well. She was no Entrapta that afternoon-slash-story installment, that's for certain. But do you see? I stood up for you! And I'd do it again! I have! I will keep doing so! Think of me as your fête marquee - I'll keep you warm and dry, no matter the weather!'

'And I you, sir. Speaking of which, we appear to have received an invitation from the Horde Prime Minister. What would you like me do with it?'

Chapter Notes

Content warnings apply for the below chapter only - Spoilers may be present in the warnings. This story does not include any of the four Archive Warnings topics, but does occasionally feature other topics that may require content notes.

Chapter 30 Content Warnings (CONTAINS SPOILERS):
Possessiveness - Observed, related, extensive
Gaslighting - Observed, related, extensive, attempt to create doubt of major characters' relationship
Property damage - Observed, driven by anger, brief
Incomplete apology - Observed, related, perpetrator fails to acknowledge their intentions

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PART 4

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‘Really, the *valet*?’

Glimmer prickled. Quite frankly, I didn’t give a monkey’s biscuit. This had to stop. I measured my words onto the conversational kitchen scale. Just three of them:

‘You abandoned her.’

‘I can fucking well *choose* who I have in my *own* fucking car, *Adora*.’

‘Are you sorry? For what you did to her?’

‘*Ha*.’

A hollow noise on mocking lips. We weren’t laughing. Glimmer balled two fists.
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‘I’m sorry for what *she’s* doing *to* you. And that you don’t even *see* it. Adora. *Shit*.’

Fury spiked through me like a hedgehog accidently stepped upon, or a porcupine flung from a catapult.

‘I **beg** your pardon?’

Four slamming palms rattled the trellis table. I glowered at my so-called *friend*. She puffed up, pulled back and returned serve, heaving towards me. But. The words hit a fault line, spinning wild and away before they made it out, smashing the mask to dusk.

‘I’m *SORRY*. Fuck. Crap. Cunt. Adora. *Dory*. I’m… so *sorry*… for what I said… about… your valet… It’s just--- Perfuma, can you give us some privacy? Please??’

‘Yes!’ the gardener quivered. ‘Of course! I’ll go um… check on the maypole. Yes! That should do it! The maypole. Um. Bye!!’

Lady Green-Fingers tore off with palpable relief. One can’t blame her. The tension and the temperature inside this tent were spiralling past what any hobbyist might reasonably expect to endure. Now it was just me and my princess. The Great Etherian Face Off.

‘What?’ I snarled. ‘What is it, Glimmer?’

‘Dory…’ she deflated like a souffle whose inner aeration whisked one reach too close to the sun, souring oven-wrapped victory into the cold, flat light of day. And kitchen worktop. Oh, but contraire. Dignity still lived amidst the squished confection. Lady Brightmoon had broken eggs – a dozen, at least – so she wasn’t stopping now. Not until she’d cooked the whole sugar-soaked omelette.

‘There’s so much I *really* want to tell you – things I’ve been hoping to show you for such a long, *looooonnnngggggg* fucking time. Crap. I was going to do it that day we went back to Oxford. Then I was going to try at Marcy’s New Year’s Eve Party. Then the Regatta. But--- but--- It never happens. I can never ***make*** it happen. SHIT. What is *wrong* with me? Why do I do this? That’s not even the right question. It’s more like: How can I keep on not FUCKING doing it?? You’re so here. And you’re so here. And it’s not ***FAIR***!!’

She twitched hungrily. A lioness about to pounce at oblivion. At me. Was she going to eat me? Or go one word further? I honestly couldn’t say. She did, though. She spoke and spoke on:

‘After the boat thing – *ohmigosh*, the boat thing, Adora – I thought that was it. Just *IT*. Forever. I thought I’d lost you. For the whole summer. Maybe more. And that was it. Fuck. I’d missed maybe my final chance. You’re not going to be in the same place forever, right? You’ll get that Naval commission, or your Aunt is going to get you a job at the foreign office, and you’ll be gone. And then what? *Dory??* What then? I won’t see you for a month, then a year, and before you know it we’re shitting *thirty* and we run into each other at a gala and you introduce me to your tall,

pretty, elegant wif--- No. I can't say it. I *WON'T* say it. It isn't happening. It **ISN'T**!!'

She sniffed and something snapped my insides. I fumbled for Horsey and offered him unto a grateful grasp, taking the tactical decision not to reveal that Catra had so recently blown her nose into the self-same hanky.

'Those aren't reasons we'd lose touch,' I let the Countess know. 'But attacking me – and *lying* about it? They might be.'

'I know – I know! I'm SORRY, Adora. I don't know how many times I've got to say it, but I'm *sorrrryyyy!!* I'm sorry, I'm sorry, I'm sorry. Sorry. Please can things go back to the way they were, please? No. Wait. Not that. Can they be better than that? Be… more? Sir Adora and Lady Brightmoon, right?! We could be perfect. If I got my act together, we could be perfect. And I'm *really* fucking trying here.'

'I can see that, Glimmer, but what you've been doing… It's big. You can't always get things just because you want them.'

'I don't just *WANT* them,' she wailed. Into her fox fur collar. 'I **NEED** to show you how much you mean to me. And I *will*. You don't know how happy I was when I discovered you'd made it up here for Midsummer. *Ohmishittinggosh*, Adora. It showed me how much you really care – and that you'd got out from under your Aunt Shadowtha's grey and withered up thumb. When I saw you, I was like, *HOLY CRAP*!! I had another chance. And if you could be

brave enough to get away, maybe I could do it too. Get it together and finally tell you that--- *that*---'

Her Ladyship went still and silent as a statue erected in her honour. Given the lofty heights of the Brightmoon family nobility, such a sculpture likely already exists. Or will, soon enough. She was bally motionless – that's what I'm trying to say.

'Tell you---' she trailed repeatedly off. '*Tell*---'

I was moved. Remarkably.

'Spit it out, glitterbug,' I offered up in encouragement. 'Tell me what? It isn't that bad, surely?!'

'I can't,' a small, scared dormouse replied. 'I want to and I really thought I could do it this time, but I was wrong, Adora. There was something new I hadn't factored in. *Her*. All I want is to get you alone. Just the princess and her knight, together, by them*selves*. The two of us, Dory, the way it used to be. Like it *should* be. Do you remember? Do you even know what I *mean*?'

Her manicure clawed tight into my forearm; I looked back at her with a sort of dumbfounded incomprehension. She sighed:

'Of course you don't. You've got her now.'

The fierce and ancient twisted her features.

‘Wherever I go, it’s *HER*. She’s Perfuma’s friend. Cuz knows her from years back – and *reconciled* with her. That’s so fucking big! J. T. never makes up with anyone. They’re still pissed about that time I took their silver hair-brush when we were *six*. But *she* turns up and it’s all smiles and reminiscing… It makes no sense!! And I can’t escape it. Bow – BOW for fuck’s sake – won’t stop saying how grateful he is to her: how *she* was right and *I* was the one in the wrong. Even Daddy thinks she’s the bee’s *fucking* knees.’

A particularly ornate teacup exploded against a tentpole. It’s fair to assume that Glimmer had throne it.

‘FUCK!!’ Then, again, quieter. Seething. ‘*fuck*. I’ve just about had it with this shit. Because, over the last day, that *woman* has appeared from nowhere and *STOLEN MY LIFE!!* How am I meant to spend that special time with you, Dory, when she’s *always* there? Huh?! How am I meant to tell you how I feel? I’ve finally got there – I’m finally *ready* – and ***Meowmeow*** is standing in my way.’

‘Glitterbug,’ I ummed. ‘I don’t think I see the problem. What I have with Catra – it doesn’t have to affect the bond between me and you. I mean, I’m a bit cheesed off with you presently, but we still have a very special gals-who-are-pals things going.’

‘Friends,’ Glimmer intoned, tonelessly.

‘Very good ones! We still can be, especially if you apologise to Catra herself. That really would mean a bunch! She’s a great sportlette, you know, so I’m proper and positive she’ll appreciate the olive branch. Say! Why don’t you come around the fête with us? Bonhomie and bunting, good will and goods grilled, and all that. It’s a spiffing chance for you to make things right, and show Catra where you and her really stand.’

‘*Oh*, I’ll do *that*, Adora. Yes. How could I resist?’

‘Spiffing.’

The tent flaps did what they’re wont to do – the clue’s in the name, after all – and Perfuma bustled inside. Her travels had changed her. She was wearing a pinafore and a straw boater. The hat was bedecked by a goose feather and a *boule de neige*. She bristled with the jumpy cheer of a woman kept busy, but not in business.

‘Sorry to intrude!’ she clapped, a Pentecostal kind of penitent. ‘I’ve been waiting outside until the noise died down. Glimmer, Adora, I have the best idea for what to do with our last minute star!’

‘Who’s that?’

‘You, silly! And you’ll be needing this!’

‘She handed me a wooden blade, four feet long, with a string-wrapped pommel, and went on:

‘She-Ra is a folk hero, a protector of the downtrodden, and a master swordswoman! So what could be better than giving the villagers a chance to measure their own heroism against our very own chivalry specialist?!’ Lady P bounced in place a little. ‘Is your heart pure? Is your aim true? Find out at booth twelve in *Fight the Knight*!’

‘So I get to see my knight – my *protectorate* – my precious Sir Dory – show everyone what she’s made of…’ Glimmer chewed. ‘It’s *perfect*.’

‘It is?’ I wasn’t so sure. I gave the girls a blanched, worried sort of look.

‘Almost, Adora,’ Lady P assured me, as she rummaged through her tote, plucking out an almost-rigid-almost-bendy rubber tube, which she slipped authoritatively down my blade.

‘There! That’s for when you spar with the kiddies. We don’t want anyone getting hurt!!’ She stepped back to admire her handiwork. ‘Now that’s a good She-Ra!’

‘No, Perfuma, not quite,’ hummed Glimmer. Her tone was shadows, but her eyes were mist. ‘That’s my knight. *My Adora*.’

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Chapter 31

Chapter Summary

'Catra - what does it say?'

'News of your... "discussion" with Duke Mystacor has reached the Horde Prime Minister, sir.'

'My discussion? Bless your whiskers, what *does* that mean?'

'I believe the letter refers to events at the fête, Adora. Events our readers are just about discover. The Horde Prime Minister goes on. They wish to meet the She-Ra, and discuss her place in Etheria, the way they see it.'

'You know how tone is a Dickens for me to interpret, my love... What's your general impression of what the letter's trying to say?'

'Honestly, Adora? I think it's a threat.'

Chapter Notes

Content warnings apply for the below chapter only - Spoilers may be present in the warnings. This story does not include any of the four Archive Warnings topics, but does occasionally feature other topics that may require content notes. Chapter 31 has extensive content warnings. If you just need a quick overview, please find a shorter list of the chapter's content warning themes below the main list.

Chapter 31 Content Warnings (CONTAINS SPOILERS):
Violence, wooden sword fighting - Narrated, experienced, participated in by narrator
Injury from above violence - Bludgeoning, minor injury of narrator (bruises), narrator does not cause injury (No major injury, bloodshed or bladed fighting occurs)
Violence, sword fighting - Narrated, experienced, participated

in by narrator, extensive, narrator causes minor to moderate injury, bladed fighting (No major injury or bloodshed occurs)
Injury from above violence - Bruising, standing on chest, asphyxiation, all caused by narrator, intentional
Threat of major injury from above violence - Sword held to throat, intentional
Threat of death - Perceived by several characters, observed, related, major character as perceived to-be murderer (no murderous intent, no death occurs)
Possessiveness - Observed, related, brief
Forced apology - Demanded by narrator, during episode of violence, not complied with
Refusal to take responsibility - Observed, related, extensive. Personal and generational. Refusal to apologise for topics in below:
Brief mentions of following topics: Slavery, Slave Trade, Organised Violence, War, Colonialism, Entitlement, Theft of Resources, Cultural Desecration, Cultural Restriction, Cultural Destruction, Tribe Destruction, Community Destruction, Land Theft, Enfroced Border Creation by Western powers, Language Denial, Language Destruction, Enforced Use of Oppressor Language, Identity Destruction and Pre-Colonial Queer Identity Destruction, Imperialism, Famine, Land/Resource Hoarding, Poverty, Hunger, Abusive Employment, Physically Dangerous Employment, Slumlords, Unfit Housing, Property Hoarding, Fuel Poverty, Systemic Oppression, Class System, Healthcare Poverty / Restricted Access to Healthcare, Trans Healthcare Poverty / Restricted Access to Gender-Affirming Healthcare
(All above topics historically accurate to British Empire and/or 1930s Britain. Several topics still relevant in 2020s Britain)

Chapter 31 Content Warnings, Themes:
Violence, sword fighting (not graphic, no blood)
Physical injury, minor
Threat of Death
Discussion of, and Refusal to Take Responsibility for, several historic and ongoing elements of Colonialism, Imperialism,

Class System, Economic Inequality, Working Class Suffering, Trans Suffering

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PART 5

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Ten. Sharp. From the instant the gates swung open, the villagers of Great Haywood and its surrounding areas spotted the obvious allure in hitting a posho with a stick. Equipped with little more than a small child's toy, a pair of borrowed falconry gloves and a ceremonial helmet – which Glimmer gamely purloined from her family collection – I looked like a cut-price crusader as I faced my first 90 minutes of all-comers.

The ticking clock was a blessed relief. Recognising that my "voluntary" task demanded more brawn and delivered more brows sweated than any of my other, fellow stalls, Lady P had decreed mine to be a game of two halves. One before elevenses and a second, dreaded, run to close the show. Pacifistic down to her trowel, Perfuma had also devised an initial ruleset. Two minutes. No winner. No loser. Don't draw blood. Try to let them get a hit or two in.

Easy to say, that last point, when you're not the one boxed in by four sides of shin-high picket fence, receiving centuries of a painfully class-conscious vengeance. Good swordsmanship was an alien concept to the maids and the miners, the secretaries and the

schoolkids, the farmhands and housewives who took up my challenge. I'd bow, invite them aboard my battlefield, and outline our outlandish grievance in my best schmock-Shakespearean, giving my opponent the chance to settle the quarrel amiably. Not one of them took it. By the time I'd taken my stance – and often before – it was attack, attack, attack.

Shin, neck, ankle, groin. Nothing was off-limits in their pursuit of glory, and *their* sword was not wrapped up to cushion the blow. I barely let a hit through – head of the collegiate fencing squad, don't you know – but those pretty few that struck? They struck hard. Wood might not cut but it makes for a mighty effective bludgeon. Wood hurts.

Fighting back proved no easy feat. Lady Brightmoon insisted I battle with the visor down, my grilled and pointed fizzgog mimicking the knights of old, restricting my vision to the smallest, tallest slit. Just seeing my foes was a challenge. Striking them was like scrawling an address on a soon-to-be posted envelope from inside the mailbox, all while the weight of four plump dachshunds plopped down on my head.

Sweat streaked and I reeked but, whether by luck of innate, absolute talent, I dug bally deep and established an impressive winning streak. If anyone had been keeping score, that is. Which we weren't. Because Perfuma had told us we weren't. But I was.

Closing in on the end of my stint, it all changed, when a noble decided he couldn't let his commoners have all the fun.

‘I think we can dispense with *this*,’ Micah boomed, ridding me of my headwear. ‘Old thing isn’t the real deal anyway! Just a lead-lined Victorian replica my grand-daddy put on the lion to scare guests!’

The cursed device rolled out of sight and Duke Brightmoon cocked a mischievous eyebrow. In that moment, he looked just like Glimmer. But with a beard.

‘I don’t want to spar against some made-up medieval,’ he declared. ‘Not on your life, my chap! I came here to pitch myself against the courageous fellow who took it on the chin to protect a Lady at the Battle of Breakfast.’

‘DAAAADDDD!!! You’re SO embarrassing!’

‘GlimmAH! You do not say a word against your pater in public. Apologise, this **instant**.’

‘Muuuuuuummm! It’s MY event and MY friend. I *organised* it and he’s *changing* it.’

A new voice.

‘Glimmer *is* right, your Grace, I--- *We* designed the game so there wouldn’t be any risk of injury – and that way everyone can have just the most wonderful time!!’

Then another.

‘Is that RIGHT, darling? Well… *I* say we’ll have a better time if those two EXPERIENCED combatants are let off the *leash* to fight for their HONOUR. The HONOUR of Greyskull, perhaps. I know *YOU*’d like that… wouldn’t you kitten??’

Then another.

‘I couldn’t say, liege. The decision lays with Sir Adora – it is in her hands alone. I support her, whatever she chooses.’

Oh goody. A substantial proportion of everyone was here.

‘What do you say, Adora?’ the Duke crackled. ‘To first blood?’

‘I promised Lady Plumers I wouldn’t. To first touch?’

‘Very well! London rules, 18th century?’

‘How about late 17th?’ I burred with conferred gravitas.

‘So be it!’ Micah burst out, taking a very real, absolutely not at all timber weapon in both hands and dropping into his stance. ‘En garde, young chap!’

Duelling with a glorified stick suddenly felt a bit silly, and really quite liable to produce my untimely death. What a sticky crumpet.

‘Adora!’ called that precious voice in the crowd. ‘Catch!!’

I thought I hadn’t brought her; I thought I wouldn’t need her; I thought sliced carpet and splintered floorboards were enough damage for one day. But Catra knew better. Ms. Floaty-Cane flew through the bucolic June air and clicked straight into my left palm. I drew her blade with a willing flourish. The crowd gasped.

‘En garde!’

The Ducke had come to play. He twirled and flourished, wrapping a hand behind his back, chatting with the crowd. Twice, he left his flank wide open, and twice her parried with split-second, blood-tanged precision when I went for the gap. We were nowhere near his limits. No. He didn’t want to fight me – not yet. He was beckoning me to join in.

Experimentally, I pushed a chunky block into a lazy, overambitious riposte. The move was never on. It left my lower arm stretched and vulnerable, with nothing but a one-in-a-thousand trick move left to save my bacon. *Well*. What do you know? He came in

cocked at just the "right" – i.e. very, very wrong – angle and I crashed him out of the way.

If a dancing partner was what he wanted, then strap on my soft soles and show me to Blackpool. Micah threw his sword high in the air, catching it in his off hand to sweep me off-balance. I twirled all around to compensate and clashed back, forcing him to leap up onto a travel case. I made to follow, spotted a weak spot and kicked the luggage pile from under him. The crowd gasped. He dropped to the floor and rolled, slashing at my knees, timing the drive so I could jump clean over his blade. I was starting to enjoy this.

'Impressive stuff Sir Adora! Ha-ha!'

'I might say the same, Duke Micah,' I drawled. 'There's a roar in the old Etherian lion yet.'

'Aye, but you'll have to do better than that if you plan to woo my daughter.'

'*Ohmigosh*, DADDY!!' screamed Glimmer, away in the crowd. 'This is SO fucking *mortifying*!!'

'The good knight fights for her Ladyship unto eternity,' I replied, 'no matter the cost.'

Catching Micah off-guard, I turned my blade flat side up and held it long, long away from me, putting its point just beneath his jaw. I started to raise it. He lifted, then strained his chin higher in return.

'Make your peace. I battle to the death!!' I panted. The crowd cheered. I was *really* getting in this.

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'She-Ra, please, be careful. Think of the little children---'

'No, *no*! Slay him, darling. *Think* of the DRAMA!'

'That's *my* Dory! *Ohmigosh*! That's my Dory. She's doing this for ***me***!!'

'Micah, *mon cher*, don't go too far! Not again!'

'Sir Adora, do not *ever* underestimate your opponent.'

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Goodness, was this what it was like to be in theatre?! No wonder Kyle had abandoned me for the West End. Fair enough and *bonne chance*, old chap.

'So be it,' the Duke gargled. Thunder cracked the sky and it started to drizzle. The fallacy was mighty pathetic. 'But know this. A new lion cannot lead the Pride until he defeats the old in battle. And I do not go down easy!'

Metal tanged the air. Micah dropped back and rushed in. It was frantic. The air pushed heavy against my ribs.

'Adora! Quick!'

Curse my cockiness. I sprung back, with just one solution left to my name.

'FOR THE HONOUR OF GREYSKULL!!'

Micah didn't stand a chance. Bouncing and flitting from one side of our enclosure to the other, I played with his Grace like a sadistic child with their ant farm on a wet November afternoon. Wherever he fled, I got there first. Whenever he turned to fight, he found fresh air. Building move upon move, swapping sides faster than the Brightmoon patriarch could counter, my plan snapped steadily into action. Micah stepped himself into a corner, stumbled once, fumbled twice, and tripped to the ground,

centimetres from the baying crowds. The infinite light screamed to me, and I replied:

‘D. D. Micah K. Brightmoon, Duke of Mystacor – Repent.’

The heavens split; lightning slammed into the grass, bare feet behind us. My heart slammed against my throat and my wrists hummed like a live wall socket. I glowed head to toe. My hair, I’m fairly sure, billowed. The world was infinite and contained within three feet of my gaze. Barely conscious, my left boot tread vengeance into a crackling balloon. Both palms wrapped around my ancestral sword, and her point tracked slowly, irrevocably earthwards.

‘Repent! Brightmoon, repent!’

The words echoed, automatic. The faces clamoured. They were a mass of humanity, distended by rejoicing or grief. Or bloodlust.

‘Stirring stuff, young chap! Very believable. I think we can say you win. You couldn’t back off my chest a little, could you, Sir Adora?’

‘REPENT!! Repent for yourself, your ancestors, your family.’

‘Come on now, that’s going a bit far. Let’s call this to an end and shake hands while we’re *still* friends.’

I wanted to – but the She-Raian forces had me now.

'REPENT.'

'NO.'

'*REPENT!*'

'*NO!*'

'*THE SHE-RA ORDERS YOU TO REPENT!*'

'No. No!'

'*Repent for the lives uprooted, the lives controlled, the lives bought and sold and shipped so the Brightmoons could build their palace to luxury!*

Repent for the bloodshed!

Repent for war borne of greed!

Repent for colonialism!

Repent for entitlement and senseless, endless enrichment!

Repent for the cultures you have ransacked and forcibly destroyed!

Repent for the tribes torn apart!

Repent for the lands stolen!

Repent for artificial borders cut like surgical scars!

Repent for the languages erased!

Repent for the people forced to learn their oppressor's tongue and strangle their own!

Repent for the identities and selfhoods and community structures you humiliated and wiped away!

Repent for Empire!

Repent for the farmers ruined when their crops fail, while you jealously protect the largest tract of green land in the country!

Repent for the children who have nothing!

Repent for the parents torn between feeding themselves and feeding their families!

Repent for the death machine!

Repent for the staff who work themselves sick tending to your every need, while your family treats them with inhuman contempt!

Repent for what you take and take and take!

Repent for the poisoning mills and the mangling factories and the dark tombs of the mines!

Repent for damp and crumbling housing, rented and never owned!

Repent for the dark and the cold, while you squander heat and light!

Repent for your world that insulates and protects your own, while never raising a finger to lift the systemic oppressions that other and destroy the different in every other social class!

Repent for the ill, the disabled and the desperately in need who deny themselves healthcare or go to impossible lengths to get it, all because they cannot afford to be well or to be themselves, while you fritter your wealth away on another luxury automobile!

REPENT FOR THE LIFE CATRA HAS HAD TO LEAD!'

Ms. Floaty-Cane touched something part-solid and gurgling.

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'Oh my Horde, she's going to kill him!'

'She-Ra! She-Ra, no! It's not too late. Put the foam guard back on your sword! Remember? Oh She-Ra, please remember. For *safety*!'

'Micah, *mon cher*, fight back!!'
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‘*Wow*. Kitten, this is *so* DRAMATIC! *Your* girl is getting VERY k.527--- Any thoughts, Leporello?’

‘Excuse me? Adora *clearly* takes after Don Ottavio, Trubel. How does that make me Giovanni’s aide, exactly?’

‘*OH!* I NEVER knew you took opera so PERSONALLY.’

‘I don’t like to see her works misrepresented, liege.’

‘*HER*? Is that *right*, darling?’

‘A personal theory, liege. Consider the sensitivity of *Idomeneo* to its heroine, the rabbit-trap female sexuality of *Figaro* and *Giovanni*, the subtle shift that places Pamina and her empowerment as the chivalric redemption arc of *Die Zauberflöte*, then read, frankly, any of the private letters to Constanze and tell me Mozart *wasn’t* a Lesbian.’

‘Okay, *okay*… *AMEOWDEUS*. You’ve CLEARLY thought about it. But I still hold by *my* convictions. You’re Leporello. Like it or not! You and him are both “household servants” of plausible DENIABILITY, wouldn’t you AGREE? Neither he nor *you* EVER leave your
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"master's" side – not voluntarily, anyway – and you both boast *terribly* requited feelings for your emploters. Oh! And who can FORGET? My little Leporellette, both you and Wolfie's charming character get your kicks from wearing your "master's" wardrobe, *don't* you?'

'That's inexcusable! *Liege*. A suit is tailored to its owner. I would *never* wear another woman's clothes.'

'*That's* the part of my point you're rebutting? Telling, kitten. VERY telling. Not that it'll *matter* in a minute, darling, once Adora has got herself 15 to life…'

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'Glimm-AH! Do something!'

'Daddy, daddy, you can push *back* against Adora! Ohmigosh. But *don't* hurt he! Adora, *ADORA*! Fuck!! You've proven your point. You're good with a sword. Shit, you're the best. But fucking let daddy go *now*! Fuck! *Please*!!'

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'Adora, you really love her, don't you, kiddo?' Micah gurgled from deep below. A little fire dropped from my eyes and I saw him. My

boot was on his chest. Ms. Floaty-Cane was hard up against his throat. ‘Then what say you we end this amicably?’

I nodded, jumping back slightly, and helped him to his feet. The Duke threw my free hand aloft, cracking a humongous grin.

‘Good show! Folks, we have a worthy champion! I know when I’m beat.’ A hearty handshake pulsed between us. ‘No hard feelings. Right, Adora? How about a victory speech for the people?’

The infinite rainbows surged through me.

‘Great Haywood village fête, I am the She-Ra. I’m going to save Etheria, no matter what it takes. Your sacrifices will not be in vain. I promise.’

‘A mighty swordsman and a top-notch orator! What a chap! Everyone, please, give it up for Sir Adora de l’Horde. We’re honoured to have her with us today. Now! Everybody! Go – enjoy the show – drinks are on me!’

The crowed erupted in cheers and chat, gradually breaking apart like candy floss in a summer storm. Micah hugged me, made sure there were no hard feelings, then stomped off to reassure the remaining onlookers that he and all were well. Only one woman refused mollification, never wavering her anxious stare through me.

‘*Glimmer*,’ she enquired with measured, trembling terror or distaste, ‘how long have you known the de l’Horde girl is the true Arth-Red?’

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Chapter 32

Chapter Summary

'How do we respond to a threat? I'll tell you what I'll do, Catra. I'm going to march right up to that Horde Prime Minister fellow and say, yes, I am entirely, unapologetically Sir Adora - and this is the woman I intend to make my wife!'

'Are you sure that's wise, sir? Remember what happened when you told Glimmer.'

'Oh--- We're at that point in the story, are we?'

'Yes. I always appreciate you standing up for me - and I *never* want to hide - but maybe this time we should think up an escape plan *before* we need it.'

Chapter Notes

Content warnings apply for the below chapter only - Spoilers may be present in the warnings. This story does not include any of the four Archive Warnings topics, but does occasionally feature other topics that may require content notes.

Chapter 32 Content Warnings (CONTAINS SPOILERS):
Possessiveness - Observed, related, extensive, directed at narrator
Gaslighting - Observed, related, extensive, attempt to create doubt of major characters' relationship
Relationship invalidation - Observed, related, extensive, attempt to create doubt of major characters' relationship
Relationship envy and jealous - Observed, related, extensive, directed at major characters
Unsolicited comment on major characters' sex life - Observed, related
Incomplete apology - Observed, related, perpetrator fails to acknowledge their intentions

Belittling, shooting, abandoning, exposing to physical danger - Historical references, brief

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PART 6

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'It looks like it's clearing up!' came the skyward cry, and a hundred faces flew to check. A thousand perpendicular palms groped tentatively for the absence of rainwater. The fête hushed in an anticipation nobody was quite ready to break. Sunlight shimmered; blue broke through. But you'd ride a long mile or three before you might find anyone willing to state those facts. To a man, the crowd quaked at the prospect of too much optimism. They didn't want to curse the day or become the death of hope.

That's the thing about the Etherian summertime. You can't let it know you're looking forward to its appearance, lest the season get stage fright and never show up. Yet our nation still dreams! Quietly. Our collective consciousness dares to believe – and sometimes your fellow man just needs permission to share a little optimism. Some fool has to lead the charge. Dash it, I was going to be that fool! I cleared my throat and reached for Catra's hand, which she gladly gave.

'That's right!' I confirmed. 'It's never looked better! Take it from me – the day's set to be a dazzler. One of the best of the year, if

I’m not mistaken! No, scratch that, one of the greatest of my entire life.’

Oh, how little did I know…

Promenading over the rapidly-drying turf, all appeared right with the world. A beautiful, smart and caring woman was on my arm, I was on hers, and the Great Haywood annual jolly was proceeding perfectly to type. Roasted meats fought boiled sweets for the tastebuds as we hand-in-ambled our way to a roped off clearing, where two local sports teams, each named after the fightier types of local fauna, laboured at a tug of war. One beat the other, everyone clapped in copacetic politeness, and a balsawood box was brought to bear on the land sporting strife had just vacated. It rapidly sprouted a microphone, to which a comb-over in a symphony of beiges swiftly attached himself.

We had stumbled on the speech. Every village fête has one, and they’re all the same. Must be something to do with the bylaws. The man began to talk. He was a pillar of the community, despite nobody having ever seen him before or having the slightest confidence they might ever see him again. He praised the nebulous concept of “village values” – Catra shivering at that part – and everyone else murmured approvingly.

That we weren’t actually in a village didn’t seem to matter. With fêtes, it never does. Whether you’ve got a field, a city street or a suburb at your disposal, you can still have a village fête, true blue and Ethrerian, just so long as you follow the conventions. You know how it goes: the real fête was the friends inside us all along or some such…

Chief amongst must-dos stands the Maypole. No-one knows why. Not one Etherian I've ever met seems to like the thing, nor know what positive part of local life it maybe represents. It was up next. Tapioca trousers shuffled to the side and a brass band struck up to usher two score tottering little girls into view. They were all dolled up as wedding cakes. It was my turn to shudder.

Sufficiently encouraged, each welded herself to a silken tentacle and waddled laps around a white-washed plank, growing ever more apprehensive, until the community elder plucked one out to be the May Queen. Even though it was June. As she was crowned and her purity praised, ever adult present felt vaguely nauseous, yet unable to stop it. Because it is tradition.

As is also traditional, Catra and I – and many others – plotted our escape before the business got that far. We cooed over tables of knick-knacks with no earthly use; we politely murmured excuses not to donate money towards a new church roof; we entered a raffle run by the Boy Scouts; we took a sporting guess at how many things were inside another thing. Good cheer and commonality flowed between all of us, for the blue skies persisted and the lunching hour was upon us, allowing one and all to engage in that rarest yet most quintessential of Etherian summertime occupations: the one desire, so scarcely fulfilled, that unites our Sceptred Isle from Third class to Pullman car. We were going to day-drink – outdoors!!

Lashings of cloudy, brown, room temperature ale met lashings of cloudy, brown, room temperature cider, washed down by the single scotch egg that gave the whole endeavour the veneer of being a meal. I kissed Catra, romantically but, I fear, not well.

Suddenly, it seemed vitally important to take a donkey ride. I'd only seen kiddy-winks in their saddles so far but, damn it, there was no signpost forbidding adults their share of equine delight, was there? Alack, the operator knocked me back, even when Lady Meowmeow intervened in favour of my cause.

Morose, my weary feet tread into the tent of the Women's Institute, where a certain kind of lady will go to any lengths to achieve victory. We trudged past clearly store-bought carrots, rubbed in allotment dirt to creation the illusion of green-fingered prowess, and fought our way past a pile of apple pies, all entered by a Mrs. Respectable of Place-Name, in an attempt to drown out the competition. Craftiest of all was the sole cheesecake, sweating it out by the marmalades. By contesting an otherwise moribund category, its baker had plotted a path to certain victory. I felt a sudden impulse to check if Aunt Shadowtha was loitering nearby.

Perfuma flitted between them all, tutting and humming and trying desperately to keep the wildlife away until the judging ceremony. At her side, an unusually reserved Glimmer, who shrunk back as we approached.

'Hi Adora.' She shifted uneasily. 'Meowmeow – I'm sorry.'

'For?'

'For shooting at you, and throwing dessert at you, and leaving you on Cannock Chase, and---'

‘And?’

‘And for calling you a thief. I was wrong,’ she added, mechanically. ‘Cuz was wrong too.’

Catra folded her arms, cocked her head, and broke her silence.

‘Marquioness Trubel-Brightmoon has noted the inaccuracy of their recall, yes.’

‘So are we okay?’

‘Glimmer!’ I snapped.

‘*What*?!’

‘Is that really all you’re going to apologise for? You called Catra “just a servant girl” and a “fucking valet”. And I don’t think that’s very nice.’

‘But she IS your valet, *isn’t* she? Meowmeow. You’re *just* the de l’Horde valet, *AREN’T* you?’

‘I don’t believe there’s any just about it, your Ladyship. Sir Adora and I are building a deep and meaningful relationship.’

Something in Glimmer, just mended, cracked.

‘Oh? No shit… I guess the brave knight needs someone to *occupy* her when her fucking *princess* isn’t around. Isn’t it *great* that you’re there to fill the… gaps.’

‘We occupy different places in Sir Adora’s life, certainly.’

‘Yes!’ I interjected. ‘That’s right! Glimmer, you’re my very dear friend, and Catra is my… my very, terribly close… um… you know, we haven’t set a term for it yet, but she’s absolutely precious to me and I’m already struggling to imagine life without her. Valet isn’t the right word for it at all.’

‘Certainly not, sir.’

Catra smiled glossily, assertively into Glimmer, who held herself up against the trellis.

‘You’re--- NO. You’re--- Adora, you and ***her***, you’re--- *NOT?!*’

My gentlewoman lifted a perfectly plucked eyebrow.

‘Madam, Sir Adora and I cannot answer an incomplete question. What is it you believe us or *dis*believe us to be doing?’

‘Dory!! Ohmigosh. FUCK. I never thought I’d see the day!’

‘Thursday?’ I ventured.

‘Don’t play coy, Adora. It doesn’t fucking suit you,’ she cackled back, lighting up like a Christmas tree. ‘But I *never* thought you’d do something like *this*, so what do I know?! Did you, Perfuma? Like, shit, could you imagine Dory *doing* this, if we weren’t watching it happen?’

‘Falling in love?’

‘Love?! Bwah-*ha*! HA-HA-HA! What *crap*. This *isn’t* **LOVE**. How---Ohmigosh! How could it be *love* between *these* two? This is real life, not some shitty romance novel. Adora is a *noble* – and she’s indulging in an ancient tradition.’

‘I am? I mean, Sappho was a while back, I suppose---’

‘Yes, you *are*. Dory, you’re boinking the help!’

‘I am not!’

‘It’s okay. *Shit*. We all do it.’

‘But really, Glimmer, I’m not. Umm. Currently.’

Her Ladyship and her Ladyship each shot me through with opposing looks, neither of which I knew how to resolve.

‘Um. Perfuma.’ I said, turning to the only hopefully neutral party in the room. ‘Help?’

‘Oh no, She-Ra, you got yourself into this mess. I don’t think I can pull you out of it.’

Sensing my discomfort – or perhaps just experiencing buckets of her own – Lady Meowmeow paced forwards, dovelike, with olive branch extended.

‘Shall we let Sir Adora define her own relationships, madam?’

‘*Fine*. Yes. Dory, tell us how I’m more important and she’s just your *bit* on the side.’

‘I fear, madam, that you still speak for her,’ Catra growled back. ‘Sir, please go ahead.’

I’d promised to be true – but where did true become blue? One hardly felt that narrating what we did last night could be construed as protecting Catra, but one must not diminish a relationship to naught. Especially when our like-like was so young, and I’d been allowed to do so little during the car-chucking episode. Three women gazed unto me expectantly. Unlike the lawyer Jonathan Small, I harboured no delusions that a certain Count was about to save the day. Not this time.

‘A gentlewoman never boinks and tells,’ I began. It felt like a good, respectful start, couched in the lexicon of a pubertal schoolyard, ‘but nor does she shirk and shrink. Lady Plumers, Countess Dryl, know this: I am dating a wondrous lady – and the experience is quite toppy. That lady has a name. And that name is Catra Applesauce Meowmeow. So long as she’s here by my side, she is and shall remain one of my top priorities!’

‘That’s *great*, Adora. I *understand* completely.’ Glimmer smiled with cousinly devastation. ‘Say, Dory, now we all know where we’re coming from, why don’t we try what you suggested earlier and go round the fête together? You, me, and Meowmeow. As *friends*.’

‘But Glimmer, what about the judging?’

‘When is that? Five? Don’t worry, Perfuma, I’ll have *everything* worked out by then.’

‘How about it, Catra, my love?’ Cripes! I reproached myself. What a moment to show her, for the first time, that I was falling in love with her. Dammit Ky--- dora! But no. Maybe damn nothing. Lady Meowmeow smiled. She squeezed my hand and then, tentatively, brushing back the stray hairs, kissed me on the forehead, once, gently.

‘Sound delightful, Adora. How can I resist?’

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Chapter 33

Chapter Summary

'Escaping Etheria… That's really not an easy task, Adora. Do we walk through it or do we just walk away? It's like this chapter. Now… I *love* how much you compliment me – that deserves a kiss---'

'Thank you, Catra. I love you too.'

'---But what were you into really? Was it the new world I want to make us… or was it the chance to get away from where you grew up? They both matter. Not having them hurts – still hurts – and I won't *ever* take you anywhere you don't actively want to go. So I guess I'm asking--- Fight or Flight?'

'It depends. Do we have to take the Dragon's Daughter IV?'

Chapter Notes

Content warnings apply for the below chapter only - Spoilers may be present in the warnings. This story does not include any of the four Archive Warnings topics, but does occasionally feature other topics that may require content notes.

Chapter 33 Content Warnings (CONTAINS SPOILERS):
Diminshing self, special interest denial – Narrated, major character, extensive
Gaslighting – Reported, aimed at major character, brief
PTSD response / trauma response – Reported and narrated, impacts major character, extensive
Transphobia – Reported, confirmed historic inc. violence, suspected present, impacts major character
Lesbophobia – Reported, confirmed historic inc. violence, suspected present, impacts major character
Bigotry towards perceived GNC clothing, attitudes – Reported,

confirmed historic inc. violence, suspected present, impacts major character
Diminshing own experience / needs – Reported, ongoing, major character, linked to queer identity
Class / wealth impacts on queer experience – Reported, ongoing, major character: lack of wealth and money negatively impacts character's safety and access to queer expression

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PART 7

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'*Ohmigosh*,' sighed Lady Brightmoon. 'We're going to have so much fun! Where should we go? How about we try out some of the games?'

'Smashing concept, glitterbug, but there's a little something I'd quite like to dabble with first.' I scuffed my heel against the dusty, conceptually indoors dirt. Always an awkward point, this. It was Swiftie all over again. You see, being such an advanced society, us Etherians have had the time to organise every object and activity in the nation into its proper place, so that we participants have a way of working out what we can do while being *right* – and what we absolutely cannot. Regrettably, the only way to learn which concepts fall into which boxes is to float them, tentatively, into conversation and see what happens.

Think of it as an unwritten guidebook.

Which I dearly wish someone would write down.

As it is, whenever an Etherian stands on the precipice of enjoying, well, *anything*, three paths present themselves. Number one is a classic of Aunt Shadowtha's age: deny, deny, deny, even to oneself, unto death. Recent events had shown a few flaws in that one. The whole directing my body as if it belonged to a third party routine had outlived its welcome. Ergo, second choice might be more choice: conduct the fun in private, hiding any evidence utterly and desperately, unto death. Hmm. A theme was developing here.

Last – both in numeral and in desirability to any conversationally-constrained Etherian – comes trial by chit chat. By teasing details drip by drip, preferably over multiple conversations and myriad years, the diligent fellow can affect a disinterested, incomplete, just about passing interest in the object or action that cheers their very existence and fills a goodly number of their waking thoughts, thereby allowing them to access it occasionally, to very limited degree, in front of other people.

But. This is a treacherous path. Overstep and the Etherian gets tarred as an oddity, a hobbyist, a figure and classless or, worst of all… an *eccentric*.

Disinvitation from parties and posses is guaranteed to follow. Polite tutting too. Soon enough, there's no other choice but to take up as an academic or retire to a large, remote country

estate, receiving politely terrified guests once to twice a year. I doubt I had the smarts to do the first and, so long as Auntie kept control of the purse strings, Sir Adora lacked the requisite moolah for the latter. Moreover, I *like* London. My work there wasn't done. Nor, really, was it started. That was the wonderful thing about the place! It had so many distractions!

For all the words I've just wittered, there is a fourth route, accessible to the special few: be RICH. Capital letters wealthy. Dripping with Denarii, as the Romans might have put it. Swimming in shillings. Gold-plated to giddy goodness. The kind of independently well-renumerated that gets statues put up and, later, taken down in your name. What I'm saying, if you follow my meaning, is there comes a point where you fan out so much folding that no-one Etherian in their correctly conformist mind would dare to question you:

Brightmoon Rich.

But the thing about Brightmoon Rich is that I'm not it. Sure, the de l'Horde name goes back a good generation or twenty-something and, yes, there's no doubt my digs are worth a shekel or two – never mind Auntie's gaping mausoleum or the scary marble place where Uncle resides – yet it was all as ashes in the here and now. Perfuma was pretty much an equal – and Glimmer simply existed on another planet. Option four wouldn't work on them. And I didn't *want* it to work on Catra. I never wanted to be more than her. Only equal.

What would Madam Meowmeow do at a time like this, eh? That was the real question. How did this convo go when one rejects the puppet-string quartet? Well. I didn't need to ask her to know:

Catra would step forwards, disavowing the entire rulebook – visible or not – and announce exactly what she wanted. And then she'd do it. No matter what the people around her were saying. Should I not aspire to the same?

Don't worry. I'll answer that: *I jolly well should!* Little Dory didn't have to play with dollhouses and dresses if she didn't want to! The de l'Horde heir could thrill at more than frills!!

'Give me the chuff and choo,' I pronounced. 'I want to ride the tiny train! Possibly more than once!'

'Absolutely, sir,' purred one of my audience.

'Really, Adora?' said the other. '*Fuck*. Are you *sure* you're feeling okay?'

'The best, Glimmer, old chum,' I beamed, 'because I'm about to experience exceptionally small engineering.'

Her Ladyship Brightmoon shifted slightly, looking to all the world like she was cursing herself. She shook her head and mumbled. "This is…" was part of it. "You always…" was another. "Why don't you…" formed a third.

'Okay!' she surfaced. She found a smile and hoisted it to the heavens, willing damp eyes to follow suit. 'If that's what you want,

Dory, that's what we'll do! Lead the way! Wait---' Glimmer pivoted back, clutching Perfuma by the arm. 'What we discussed. About the cheesecake. *Think* about it.'

'But, Glimmer! It's SO mean!'

'*They* put it in for judging. And we're judges. So, *Perfuma*, that's what we're going to do. We're going to judge that pissing dessert.'

Without another word, Lady Brightmoon swept out of the tent, canvas flapping in her midst. Spotting us amidst the crowds, she flitted straight over and fitted herself to my side. "Okay!" said she. Looking over us both, maybe taking in my ebbing tension and Catra's easy, crumpled eye smile, but most probably noting how my date and I were holding each other's hands, Glimmer batted the air with friendly forearms and said "OKAY!!" again, but louder.

Three more okays conveyed us to the queue, where we did the Etherian thing and, well, queued. Politely. We made small talk with our linemates fore and aft. About the weather, which looked good. About the harvest, which apparently looked less good if the weather didn't turn. About what a lovely day everybody was having. A few fellows stared our way longer than I'd like, worrying me that someone was going to chatter about my being the She-Ra.

Tut! I needn't have worried. That was large talk – and no Etherian enacts medium or upwards talk in polite company, unless they have an upper hand over everyone present. And, possibly, a private militia. Truer words, Aunt Shadowtha always reminds me,

are spoken only in private. *You can walk through the ballroom freely, Adora, but* carefully *measure your drawing room tread.*

Yet Catra looked uncomfortable. I wondered why. Her face was closed, inscrutable, just like when we met. A shield had gone up. And I couldn't tell which side of it we stood. Yellow and blue flicked through the group, fish knife sharp and banshee brief. They settled on nothing yet saw everything. She twisted slightly, shifting the exact angle of our interlocked palms. Was this Micah all over again? Was she trying to tell me something? Mindful of Glimmer standing nearby – and the inauspicious start between maybe friend and maybe girlfriend – I leaned towards a velvet ear and whispered:

'Adora! No!' Lady Meowmeow shot into the ropes, tangling in the twine. It could have been an electric fence. Her hair was on end; her tail was up. 'Sorry, sorry, Adora. I'm sorry. What do you need, sir?'

She was hurting.

'Just---' I started. Then I stopped, ruminating the right way to finish, still at a whisper. 'Catra, what's wrong? How can I help?'

'I thought…' She gulped, still glancing around. 'I thought… I *thought* someone out there was looking at… us… at *me*.'

‘Don’t you like that? Your suits are always supreme, Catra, so I reckoned you’d be used to catching attention. Was I wrong?’

‘How do I tell you---’ she hummed, blinking back a tear. ‘There’s being looked at in a kind, respectful, complimenting way. And that’s great. Sure. I won’t say I don’t enjoy *those* glances. I do. But the looks I saw in the crowd? They’re a different kind. They’re the looks you get when someone thinks they clock a lady dressed “unladylike” or girlfriends holding hands or a trans woman just… *being* and hates what they see. *Who* they see. It’s the look that gets violent.’

‘Who was it? How DARE they?! I’ll--- I’ll She-Ra!’

‘Adora! Adora, *no*. I hate to break it to you… but that *glance* could be for you as much as it is for me. Don’t get hurt, please. And… and maybe the look wasn’t there.’ She gulped. I wanted to hug her – when she was ready. ‘Maybe… Sometimes… I see it in places it isn’t. I’ve been caught too many times before. The feeling gets me when it shouldn’t, freezing out my chest, grinding on my forehead, *here*. And I know that isn’t rational. But I’m not over it, not yet.’

‘I’m here. Catra, take my hand.’ She did, tight.

‘I don’t want this for you,’ she continued. She smiled emptiness. ‘Hey, Adora, perhaps you’ll get lucky. If you can call it luck. You can keep it far away, being House de l’Horde.’

‘What do you mean?’

‘I’m not trying to insult you, sir, but you’ve got more money than an average Etherian could even imagine. Take my advice: do what Glimmer does. Make yourself an island, for you and the queers like you, where your titles and your bank accounts can keep you safe. I’ve got to give her credit. She’s making it work. Maybe I’d do the same… if I could. But I can’t. Not now, probably not ever. Dating me, Adora, *loving* me, means stepping out of that safe and perfect garden… and I’m… *sorry*.’

‘Catra, don’t apologise, please. *Catra?* Listen to me! You have done *nothing* wrong – and I still like you. *Like*-like you. Maybe… *love* you.’

‘Don’t be silly.’

Those were the words that crossed her lips, but the deepening shade on her cheeks betrayed her. She played with a ringlet of her hair and bit her lip a little, fighting a smile. The space between us relaxed. Her gaze dropped from the distance, to me. She-Raian conviction ripped through me.

‘I’m serious. I mean it. Lady Meowmeow, I swear to cherish you, to protect you, to respect you, whatever might come our way, just so long as we both shall date. Till death or mutual incompatibility do us part!’

She giggled. That was nice. And a relief. After what she'd just been through – and whatever dreadful business went before – my gentlewoman deserved a stint in sunnier climes. I offered the hug again. Catra accepted. It was a ripping embrace, if I do say so myself, snug in all the right places, her hair stroking softly against my cheek. One inhalation and I was… *home*. Warmth flooded between us and, gradually, she softened. Her frame curled inwards. I only hoped she felt some safety here too.

'I'm sorry,' she repeated, 'for what I can't be. *Adora*. I need you to understand what that means. I have no house or flat to make our home. No car. I can't give you diamonds or silks or summers in Provence. The world I came from has hurt and hardness.'

'I can scarcely imagine what you've lived through---' I began.

'*No*,' she sighed. 'You can't.'

'And I won't pretend to. Even I recognise the differences between being a de l'Horde and being a Meowmeow. But my noble name doesn't *ever* make me better, you know? Can I tell you what really stands out when I look at you? Will the mighty Lady Meowmeow permit her knight to woo her?'

Catra blushed again and draped a hand behind my neck. Her thumb worked lazily over my nape. 'Go on. Tell me.'

‘You’re clever upon clever… you’re kind… you see the best in people and get that best out of them… you’re lung-punchingly good looking… you really know how to dress…’

‘Thank you,’ she purred. ‘Don’t those also apply to you?’

It was my turn to simmer scarlet, which I did, promptly.

‘Well, um, perhaps!’ I hummed. ‘But there’s one more thing. Or maybe it’s a bunch of things, all wrapped up and working together so perfectly that they look like a single object. Either way… Catra, you entrance me. You imagine a better world and live from there – and it doesn’t matter whether anyone steps over to join you. You’re going to stay there anyway. I see it in your words and in your actions. You give without limit. You break the rules because you know they aren’t enough.

‘I’m so sorry for the places or people that hurt you – the ways you’re hurting still – and so grateful you never gave up. That you’re so certain. That you dreamed and still dream of better.’ An arid breath screeched into my lungs. Little had I known, I’d started crying. She meant so much to me. Even then, even there, in the queue for a small train, Catra Applesauce Meowmeow had my heart.

‘No,’ I gasped on. ‘I don’t understand where you had to be before. I never will, not in the way you know it. But I will listen. And we won’t ever go back there again. Because you, Catra, don’t let the darkness win. You turn to the light and keep on walking towards the good, saying “Dickens!” to the detractors and the, well, the

bastards who try and drag you down. When I wonder how to be the She-Ra – and I do that a *lot* right now – I think of you. *Never* apologise for who you are.'

'Very wise,' she drawled. I half-expected a wisecrack. I didn't get one. Straightening slightly, smiling with real and renewed zeal, my Lady met me with unparalleled sincerity. 'Thank you, Adora. *Really*. Thank you. That was just what I needed to hear.'

'Good,' I replied. 'It was just what I needed to say.'

'*So*,' she slank back into her customary confidence, 'this new way of being? What do you think it says about kissing *hard* in public?'

'I'd have to check my notes, but I think it's A-okay, so long as both parties feel safe. I heard you, and I understand the risks, but I do, I feel good. How about you?'

'Right now? Yes. I *want* us to be us, Adora, where the whole world can see.'

Her hands linked behind me; mine cupped her in hushed reverence. Our lips met and I smiled against her, melting into the velvet trace of her tail against my thigh. We kissed from the bottle, drinking deep and full, not caring who watched. She held me close. I protected her. Together, our touch knew safety. We spiralled deeper and glee whispered me a mirror I couldn't resist.

Sliding my leg between hers, I cradled the woman of my dreams and it just seemed right. I dipped her. Catra shivered.

And Glimmer cried:

‘Ohmigosh! *Look*, you two, we’re at the front of the line. So you’re gonna have to cut that out. I know! What a *fucking* pity!!’

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Chapter 34

Chapter Summary

'Behold, Catra, reader-doodles! The chapter where I go within touching distance of transport - get behind the controls, even - and no disasters occur. Not even a little one!'

'So proud, hon.'

'*That* is the *worst* joke you've ever made!! My darling fiancée puns, of course, about my ongoing political awakening. Twist new character alert! We chat about anarcho-mutualism.'

'ADORA!! You've been doing your homework!'

'Well, I need *something* to say when I meet the Prime Minister... And in the note we're going to leave Auntie... After we do... THE THING...'

'Terribly mysterious, sir.'

Chapter Notes

Content warnings apply for the below chapter only - Spoilers may be present in the warnings. This story does not include any of the four Archive Warnings topics, but does occasionally feature other topics that may require content notes.

Chapter 34 Content Warnings (CONTAINS SPOILERS):
Special interest denial – Attempted, historic, reported, towards main character
Special interest denial – Attempted, present, reported, towards main character

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PART 8

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There was huffing, there was puffing, and somewhere in it all I punched Catra's ticket. And *she* punched *mine*. A whistle blew when she did. A bell tolled. I shook with excitement from the kind of relief that follows age upon age of grinding anticipation. Red met black. Metal met leather. Oils oozed their varying viscosities. I was torn. I itched to take control, balancing firm hands against sensitive inputs, playing with every parameter as I coaxed the utmost from our time together. But another, no smaller part of me wanted to lie back and be taken on the ride of my life. It was steamy stuff.

'Adora? *Adora?* Ohmigosh. I can't just stand here waiting for you forever!'

Glimmer snapped me from my fugue, but the heat and the power dragged me back.

'Eh? What was that chum? I'm… I'm… Sorry. I can't take my mind off--- *her*.'

'I'm flattered, sir, but we do need to board.'
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‘No, Catra, not you. Well. *Usually* you. But not right this second.’ This felt very much like the most accurate, but most wrong thing to say. Flinching right, I dared to check on the woman whose clasped fingers still wrapped about my neck. ‘I need--- I *want* a minute. To look at the locomotive. Please?’

Lady Meowmeow didn’t glower. She didn’t glare. Nor did my madam tut. No. Instead, the woman I’d so recently welcomed into my world smiled, encouragingly. Glimmer huffed her arms folded. Just as I’d expected. More than once or twice over the course of our chumship, the Brightmoon heir had all-but wrenched my arms out of their sockets to stop me gawping at the soot-stained and full-scaled real deals. I was used to it, mind, and from a dashed young age. Aunt Shadowtha felt the same – and felt it loudly. Tradespersons, physical labours, dirt. These were not for little Dory! The tut if I even turned towards the front of a train was devastation itself.

When the same sound tripped from the glitterbug lips, my light wavered. Catra saw it. She looked devastated, furious. Taking my hand, she pivoted something fierce at Glimmer, showing teeth, *en route* to a girlfriendly word at my hip.

‘Take your time, Adora. I like you for all of you.’

And I did. I marvelled at the smokebox that loomed almost too big for the frames, cooed at the boxiness of its boiler, hummed over how it looked so strange yet so very familiar. My gentlewoman, bless her, showed touching interest:

‘What do you like about it, sir?’

‘Well. I’m pretty taken by the whole idea! How do they replicate the grandeur of a top-link express loco in such miniscule and minute detail, do you think? And what’s the deal with its shape? It looks a quite a bit like a Royal Scot, yet a lot not like that at all.’

‘I believe my friend can answer that, sir.’

As she spoke, a spright, slight oil slick vaulted off the tender and bounced across, smiling their way towards us with a flea-eating grin. Their teeth were the tombstones of an insectoid graveyard, but life sprang anew amidst their purple hair. I knew how that felt. Not the hue, you understand, but the follicular buzz-buzzing. Lavender still filling my pockets to the brim, I sorely needed another Perfuma spritz. Perhaps Entrapta did too.

I say that like I knew for sure this grimy figure was they. I did not – though the muck, in hindsight, provided a bally great context clue. Tramping over in hefty boots and dark-stained workwear, spotted balaclava and elbow-length gauntlets so infused with carbon shards that they were really more coal than glove, the fellow all made up of work clothes and dirt, topped by a pair of gigantic goggles. They held a scaled-down shovel in one mitt, and a pair of spanners in the other. The tools were oilier than one generally expects really *any* object to be, dripping oleaginous rainbows onto the flagstones. Catra flinched. I was about to serve as a human stain guard.

Deeply green and barely penetrable, twin orbs stared up at me, unblinking. I mean, the fellow behind them presumably had to moisten their eyeballs now and again – be it for business or pleasure – but I had no way of knowing if or when that happened. Not that lingering on anybody but Catra's gaze filled me with much joy anyhow. A spanner flicked my way, depositing a greyly permanent muck on what, until now, had been a rather fine piece of stripey olive linen.

'Hello!' said they as the droplets landed. 'Again! I see you have been admiring my latest locomotive. It's something of an experiment. So risky! So many difficult, intricate parts! And a three-part steam circuit that's utterly FASCINATING!! Ahh! SO! Adora. Do you want to know how it works?'

I glanced around. The Glimmerian lips were puckered tighter than a pair of pantyhose at a New Year's Eve party. But Catra – now she'd removed herself from the splash zone – smiled with ceaseless warmth and encouragement. Apologies, old capital chum, but I knew which of the two was on my side right now, and it wasn't the one who owned half of Staffordshire.

'Yes,' I told Entrapta. 'Yes I do.'

'WONDERFUL! I REALLY like sharing my special interests. Proud queer autistic solidarity! Wooo!'

'I--- I'm not autistic?'

‘Um. Um. OOPS. Okay. Maaaaaayyyyybe think about that? And definitely hold this!’

They handed me a screwdriver. Hang on. That sentence doesn’t quite get across the situation, and I fear I’m running an awful risk of being misconstrued. We’ve already established that our Welsh welder-fabricator had tools in both hands – which was absolutely true – so I don’t mean to imply that they put any of those bits down. They didn’t. Instead, the engineer used their hair to deposit an unctuous six-part hex set between my fingers, a follicular feat not even a She-Ra could perform. Colour me very impressed. They went on:

‘Locomotive 29.2 is a further development of 29.1 and the original 29.0---’

‘What happened to those?’

‘THEY decided they’d be happier in a LARGER number of smaller pieces.’

‘Oh.’

‘Yeeeeaaaah. But 29.2 is much better! She’s been running all morning, haven’t you Fury?’

I looked at the loco and expected it to reply, by whistling or some such. It hissed a little steam my way, but I wager that was just because the drain cocks were wide open. Which seemed like a sensible precaution, considering. Entrapta grinned at the fruit of their labours, dropping right back into their conversational flow.

'She's a good girl! A VERY good girl! And she's based on the London, Midland & Scottish Railway experimental project of the same name: locomotive number 6399. Though *visually* not tooooo dissimilar to the Royal Scot express class, as used on high-speed services between London and Scotland, the Fury project uses a completely different boiler concept with three stages. Hold on, Adora… Things are about to get WEIRD!!'

They bopped over to the engine and started pointing at things, beckoning me to follow.

'You'll know that an ordinary steam locomotive has a single boiler, filled with water aaannnddd *tubes*. And that the tubes are filled with hot air, pulled forwards from the fire, which use convection to turn the water into steam. So then the steam operates the cylinders and turns the wheels, through a constant cycle between vacuum and steam expansion, right?'

'Of course.' I did know that – plus quite a bit more too – and it was rather lovely not to need to pretend I didn't. 'And it all operates at around 200psi of pressure.'

'EXACTLY! Ha-ha! But you can throw allllll of that away with *Fury*. She operates at 1800psi and 900psi and 250psi all at once.

Welcome to the world of high-pressure superheating! This little engine has more power than any locomotive EVER before. Bwah-ha! See the firebox?' They pointed. 'Its internal components and operations are pretty plain and conventional, but its walls are made out of super-pressure tubes. Pretty neat, RIGHT?! THOSE are filled with distilled water. THAT transfers heat to a high-up drum *here*. And THEN the DRUM works as a secondary boiler and builds steam for a high-pressure cylinder located inside the chassis.'

We scuttled forwards, towards the smokebox.

'Naturally, exhaust from that cylinder has to go sooommmeewhere… Does it go out the smokestack? Ha-ha! NO! It feeds into the two external low-pressure cylinders, which are also fed by the primary boiler, which is heated the conventional way, by the same fire that warms the hyper-pressure tubes. Isn't it FASCINATING??!?'

'It is! It *really* is. But why make it so small?'

'Because tiny choo-choos go with tiny chew-chews!' They rummaged through their leather apron, grinned wider still, and produced a paper bag. Its brown borders framed the daintiest Welsh cakes I'd ever lain eyes on. 'Do you want one? They're like tiny cwtches!! And oh! Adora! Do you want to drive? That way I can hook up my dynamometer car and collect valuable DATA!'

This was the moment of every young chap's dreams: taking the controls of a steam locomotive, towering over its brass bands and

crimson lake, while a beautiful gentlewoman skims and straddles just behind your buttocks. What Ho! Catra climbed aboard the four-wheeled pommel house that formed a carriage; Glimmer jumped on just a little further back. My guide, meanwhile, had abandoned me for the American-styled caboose they were busily hooking to the rear. When they hopped on and blew me a guard's whistle, sending a green flag flapping, I gathered that they weren't coming back.

In many cases, this might have been a very poor idea. But I'd been waiting for this moment all my bally life! Plunging myself wrists deep into action, surveying a footplate so small it'd be better termed a fingerplate, I flicked a few gravelly spoons on the inferno, opened the blowers, and wound the reverser to full cut-off. Funny name, that, I've always thought. For the record, that screw controls forwards movement as much as rear. A shiver ran through me. Catra purred over the clamour:

'Enjoy yourself, Adora. Your happiness matters.'

I… I just needed a moment. I was a terribly lucky not-quite-girl. Building boiler pressure, dropping the brake, resistance was bally futile. Two fingers dragging on the chain, I trilled the whistle long and triumphant. Regulator up. Let the exhaust beat once, twice. Slam it shut on three and ease it back open. *Fury* thump-thump-thumped past the bunting, shouting noisy doggerel up the earthworks that curved steadily towards the tunnel. Playing injectors off ejectors, winding back the gearing, I found full power and gloried in the rounding fuss as our train built up speed.

The tunnel's inky mouth loomed. Miniaturised lamps fought back with miniaturised light. Completely unaware of what lay ahead –

of where I might be leading the two passionate women at my back – I drove us into the darkness full speed ahead. Whistle screaming, skin prickling, heart rushing, Sir Adora threw herself into the intoxicating, terrifying unknown. Very vaguely, my ears pricked to the sounds of Glimmer and Catra in robust discussion. But did I care? Not enough. Not when I had power and prestige at my fingertips.

Too soon, the game was over. And another was afoot. Stepping off the steamer, offering Entrapta my kindred spirit with such earnest entirety that we two – of all folks – caught one another in a deep, disastrously dirty embrace, I found myself thrown back into apparent gentility, eddying with the underneaths that are just that little bit too obscure to see.

'Dory! Meowmeow and I agreed – we're going to play our way round the rest of the fête. Coming?!'

She didn't wait for an answer. Frankly, I'd have been concerned if she had. It wouldn't have been Glimmer. Wrapped round my soot-flecked hand, her grasp hurled me at the next kiosk over, where a friendly but heretofore unknown face smiled from the cut-out centre of a balsa wood and crepe paper circle. An architectural donut, if you will. The ring curved at sternum height – though Lady Brightmoon would no doubt deem it somewhere nearer the clavicle – and bobbed with very blue water.

Upon those waves thronged a few hundred rubber ducks, quacking and quaking their way through an eternal cycle. Uniform, unblinking. It sent shivers through me. To think. Was this how those fellows who packed the trains into the City every weekday morning felt? Heavens. Why did they do it? What

compelled them to pursue such a sordid existence, when one could wait around in bed for a gentlewoman to convey freshly-squeezed juices and varying egg dishes into easy reach? Work really is a dashed strange concept.

I was suddenly very sad – and I'll tell you why. It hit me in waves, gradual yet relentless, like the ones that rocked the duckies and sent their metal-tipped heads clinking, that *this* might be how Lady Meowmeow felt. Trapped. Stuck inside an endless cycle she never asked for. No other options. No way out. Crouched and increasingly damp, I probed painted eyes, found no answers, and began, very lightly, to cry. What torture. That wasn't living! Not as I knew it. My bath time buddies were so rich and free and full of life; treacherous fate had denied these fellows the same. It--- it wasn't fair.

'Do not worry!' beamed a voice from above. 'The ducks are not real! They cannot be upset!'

'Well,' I coughed, 'that's a weight off my mind. But what if the fowl afloat are a metaphor for something? A real life *synecdoche* for something bally dreadful? What then?'

'Hmm,' said my new friend. He really weighed it over. 'I do not know! But I thank you for the chance to think about the question! Would you like to hook a duck? You are guaranteed to go home with a wonderful prize!'

'But what of the duckies, my good chap? Sir Adora de l'Horde swoops in to manipulate the masses for her benefit, and what do

the daily grinders get in response? Do we give them enough? Do we give them anything?!'

'These are very good questions!' he agreed. Then he looked around his perimeter, all furtive and mysterious. And he saw what I saw. Namely, Lady Brightmoon doing everything possible to push the Lady Meowmeow's buttons, cheeks flushing and brow beading, while Catra stood, unmovable, examining her claws. The duck-wrangling gent beckoned me closer. 'Earlier I was not telling the truth! I do have answers! Would you like to hear them?'

'You know, I think I might.'

'Oh! Wonderful! Praise be! Dear Adora, did you know Etheria is a fascist construct that pursues a hate-filled screed of individualist exceptionalism both within our borders and beyond them? The capitalist culture of modern Etheria seeks to destroy the individual through alienation from labour, from others, and from self. And this is very bad! By promoting the paradoxical concepts that each one of us must rely on their own person to fulfil their needs whilst pledging our time and energy unquestioningly to faceless enterprise, this nation fosters destruction in its own people.'

'Goodness. That *does* sound rotten.'

'Yes, it is egregious. Our common heritage has been appropriated by a self-selected few. It can be very sad. But have hope! It does not have to be this way! It did not used to be! There was a time before, when people worked together, cared for one another, lived in accord with nature, shared in the prosperity of their community.

There can be such a time again! Oh, but it will not be easy. Property is theft, but it is also despotism.'

'I… don't follow?'

'When the owner of an object and its user are different persons, as is common in our society, exploitation is created. Very sadly, the user cannot simply escape the injustice when the whole nation and its empire have been constituted around the concept, giving the masses slim choice. They must submit to their suffering or depart society. This is why we must abolish property! We must overthrow the Prime! We shall dismantle the aristocracy! We must stand up for all those underfoot! We can do it! We are going to win in the end!'

He winked at me. A victorious, subversive wink.

'What did you just say?!'

'We are going to win in the end! Truly, Adora, we shall.'

'Yes, I thought that was what you said. Where did you get that line, if you don't mind me asking?'

'From the She-Ra! One of my partners is Entrapta! They know much about them!'

‘Very good. Well… I don’t quite know how to tell you… but *I’m* the She-Ra now.’

‘Praise be! I had suspected!’

‘Because I was interested in the ducks?’

‘No! Because you transformed on the cricket green!’

‘Yes, I suppose I did.’

‘I was quite surprised! Now, Adora, it is your turn to gaze in wonderment! I, too, was once a de l’Horde. Now I am not! And that is much better! I am your uncle’s brother. Perhaps that also makes *me* your uncle! I am “Wrong” Hordak – it is a pleasure to meet you! Would the two women who desire your affections now like to hook a duck?’

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Chapter 35

Chapter Summary

'This here---' *ska-squeak* '---is my latest and most important bathing bud.'

'Apart from me, right, darling?'

'Apart from Catra. His name - Quack Sheppard. Bath-tised for 1700s London's greatest folk hero, authority opponent, master thief and jailbreaker---'

'Whom many researchers now understand as genderqueer.'

'Speaking of which, I think it's high time I added another tag to our tale: Trans Adora.'

'I'm proud of you, my love.'

Chapter Notes

Content warnings apply for the below chapter only - Spoilers may be present in the warnings. This story does not include any of the four Archive Warnings topics, but does occasionally feature other topics that may require content notes.

Chapter 35 Content Warnings (CONTAINS SPOILERS):

Classism – Related, present, towards major character
Stigmatisation of sensory aversion – Related, present, towards major character
Stigmatisation of sensory need – Related, present, towards narrator
Gender Dysphoria – Narrated, present, bodily dysphoria, top dysphoria, experienced by narrator

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PART 9

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‘Twas in these inauspicious climes that the Battle of Glimra began. Two women stepped up to the booth, where Wrongcle – “Wrong” Hordak, my possibly probable uncle – bid them a cheery “Good Day!” Glimmer nodded in return, propping herself on bended elbow, against the edge of the booth. She looked round to me and pulled off the kind of move that elevated her link to cousin Double-Trubel: a combination grin, flicked chin, and eyebrow waggle. All the while, she chewed a toothpick, as if that was the most natural thing in the world to do with a glorified splinter.

Her spare hand plunged into her fur and produced an object more pearls than purse. It yawned open to reveal enviable amounts of folding. She took a note without looking and slammed it on the surface. The paper flopped down with a squelch, since, understandably, the counter was the most water-logged place this side of a paddy field.

‘Gimme a duck hook,’ she drawled, redundantly, ‘to hook a duck.’

Wrongcle bowed assent. He could hardly do anything else, given his role at the village fête. Mid-way through Thursday afternoon would have been an inauspicious time to start an international revolution. That felt like more of an all-day effort.
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Lady Brightmoon took her pole, examining its length with professional rigour. Her hands swept along its shaft, weighing its strength and rigidity, hunting for any bend or buck that might give the stick a personality of its own. I could see it in her eyes. She wanted to pound Catra into submission. Three feet to the heiress' right, and another three feet back, my gentlewoman enquired about her own role.

'Good afternoon, sir,' she began. 'I hope you, Entrapta and Castaspella have been well since we last saw each other. How much for one attempt at your game? I shouldn't need a second.'

'Yah, Meowmeow, it's alright. I've got this.' Glimmer threw more cash onto the mire. 'Ohmigosh. Some of us carry enough cash to *fucking* cover our needs, *don't* we Adora?'

'I'm sure I'm charmed, madam,' Catra bowed in reply. 'W. H., sir, could you pass me my pole from here? Entrapta may have mentioned my thoughts on water.'

'Of course! I would never want to make a friend uncomfortable!'

Lady Meowmeow took her stick and positioned herself at its extreme. She squinted down its length, sniper-like, adjusting her stance until she was as far from the ring-a-ring-a-river as possible. Treating the situation as an open invitation, Glimmer plunged in with her own apparatus. Her hands grabbed the wood hard enough to splinter – one almost up against the brass cap holding

the hook in place, the other barely further back – as she threw herself at the ducks so hard that their faux-tufted heads banged and bobbed at freedom.

'Come here. Come *here*. I demand you! Argh! Stay still you little *FUCKWITS*!! Shit fuck cunt SHIT.'

'Excuse me, madam! It is not in the spirit of the game to rock the booth!'

'Grr-aaaahhh! Uh. *Cunt juice*!! FINE. Fine.' Glimmer shrugged back, marshalling most of her missing composure, or hoping she had, at least. 'I just need to get my eye in, Dory, you know how it is. Meowmeow? Oh *good*, you're still here. Let's take it in turns? First to get a duck wins?'

'As you wish, madam, but I'm quite happy to cede the next attempt to you.'

'What kind of smartass game are you playing, *valet*? Cuz *fucking* warned me about you.'

'I suffer heightened senses around water, especially when it is not under close control.'

'In *plain* Etherian, douchestick?'

‘I get nervous,’ Catra deadpanned. ‘If it’s all the same, madam, I would prefer to wait until the grass around the booth dries out.’

‘*Weak*. I mean, like… Dory, your serving-girl is a *coward*! But okay, I can go again.’

She swaggered forwards, tucking the pole under her arm with billiards bravado. This time she went right up to the water line and hunched, forcing herself onto the same level as her prey. Glimmer stalked round the circle, in pursuit of the optimum angle, then stopped. She had found it. She could stare into the whites of the duckies’ enamelled eyes. Sliding the pole parallel with the water’s edge, she skimmed the wood from shore to shore, halting our feathered friends in their tracks. A freezing twist turned her mouth.

The ducks bobbed to a halt. Fast as a water-trained leopard, by which I suppose I mean a jaguar, Glimmer slammed her stick into the base of the pool, attacking from underneath. Hither and thither, sunburst rubber flew, spilling bath time buddies into the centre of the ring. Wrongcle scooped them up and dropped them back, but the Brightmoon bloodlust would not be denied. Again and again, the pole writhed and smashed at the water, trying to force its curve into the hole atop any of the creatures’ heads. But she was fighting from the wrong angle, with water and whole ducks between pole and goal.

Glimmer screamed, drew back, then flew at them. She tried to plunge the spike into a flank, a wing, a juicy and tender underside, just for blunt metal and rubber resilience to deny her.

My chum stamped at the ground, churning and splattering mud, darting Catra out of harm's way. A new approach hit the Countess as she did. The stick *could* come from underneath, if only the ducks were inverted. Raising her pole into a pike, she slashed and smashed at her enemies, trying to turn them upside down.

But buoyancy and the shape of a bird combined forces and became a more than equal foe. Every time Glimmer got a duck the wrong way up, every chance she had to get the hook close, the target responded to her incoming force by flicking back to right-side swimming. 'Why you… *Shitting* ducks… I oughta… *FUCK you sideways on a crap-soaked merry-go-round*,' my princess enunciated with ever-increasing furore. She had entered her end game.

Circling back, eyes shot through with pinkish rage, Glimmer plunged a glove into the icy depths, forced a duck upside down, and held it there. Single-handed, her pole fumbled and stabbed at the elusive connection. Which it did not find.

'Why is *everything* so hard?! Why is the whole pissing world against me?! Why does a *VALET* get what I *want* and I fucking don't?! WHY??!!?'

She was taking it quite hard, especially since Catra hadn't had her go yet. It wouldn't be long now, mind. Short of any other solutions, Lady Brightmoon hurled her stick into the middle distance, showing a twirling aptitude for the javelin, then simply lifted a duck onto dry land.

‘There.’ She rasped wetly, unevenly at Wrongcle. ‘A duck. Gimme my prize.’

‘But you haven’t won! I am sorry! You have not hooked a duck! Grabbing a duck is not hooking a duck!’

‘What?!?! Do you know who I am?’

‘Yes!’

‘Do you really mean to tell me I – one of the most noble women in the country – can’t have something?! Something I *want*?’

‘Yes! And now it is time for your friend to take her turn!’

‘That *valet* is not my fucking friend.’

‘I really do appreciate the clarity, madam,’ Catra oozed. ‘Heavens forbid we become confused. Sir Adora, please choose your prize.’

Scrutinising the shelves, I ran my proverbial fingers through the variously appealing produce therein. Confections and calligraphy had their temptations. But they could not compete. As soon as I set my eyes, I knew my prize.

‘That!’ I cried. ‘I mean, *her*. It has to be her!’

‘The stuffed toy?!’ Glimmer spat feathers. ‘Dory, really? I thought we talked about this. We *definitely* talked about this! You’re my knight, remember? And knights don’t get themse---’

Catra sucked her cheek in the Countess’ direction, then, in an uncharacteristic display of rudeness, cut her conversation short.

‘Excellent choice, sir.’

Bent fingers, cracked knuckles, loosened wrists that traced in looping circles. Lady Meowmeow made sure she’d got all three before planting her feet back where they’d been before Glimmer had decided the field needed an impromptu watering. Thighs set in a diagonal A-frame – weight spread evenly between the two – Catra gave me a marvellous view of her rump. Bally good stuff! But not the point. Flicking her tail into a balancing question mark, she was the model of supreme stability. She had the ideal base to lift her pole onto a long, strong, straight arm, bracing with the cupped bend of the other.

Both eyes still open, but one narrower than the other, she dropped and angled her head to match the pole. Its hook reached to the centre of the pool and not one hundredth further. She was very still, very quiet. Lifting her apparatus to a watching brief, she schooled her breaths to a steady rhythm, ears twitching to

something only she could her, then flick-twisted in to catch the first duck she targeted.

'Praise be! We have a winner!'

'You'd hook a duck… for me?!'

'Naturally, sir, and much more besides.'

We cuddled, I pecked her cheek, and Catra handed me the snuggly-softy who had so recently stolen my heart.

'Whee! Oh, Catra, thank you! I'm going to call her *Mint*, after Peppy the Glacier Mints mascot!'

I snuggled Mint tight, not caring a flea that the whole world could see. What a nice feeling that was.

'*Fine*,' a less than whelmed Glimmer griped. 'Urh. I guess that means Meowmeow won the first round. But that won't last long. Come *on*, hurry up and let's do round two *already*!!'

Off the Countess stomped, and what choice does a chum turned knight turned protectorate have at that point but to follow? Duty called, after all, but not loudly enough that I'd unhook my palm

from Meowmeow's hand. We clomped our ways across the grass, past sizzling meats and book club meets, cutting through the writhing mass of sugar-swilling and booze-abuzz humanity, to a tall and decidedly unsteady painted wooden tower.

'Come one, come all, and test your strength against the mighty Skyhawk, aviator of the seven skies!! Do you have what it takes to outrun *these* guns?' The moustachioed migraine leapt from his booth and flexed to the very maximum his exercise regimen would facilitate. Not being one to comment negatively on matters sartorial, which belong vividly and absolutely to the individual, I umm and ahh at the relational of his leather flying jacket, but our narrative must progress. It was a wind-battered and feeble old thing, you see, which had clearly been sized for a Skyhawk several thousand bench presses younger. Goodness only knew which *Dragon's Daughter* it had initially called home.

What one could contemplate – what, indeed, one had no option but to think about – was how tightly it hung around his figure. The chiselled vee of his ribcage was in firm, full view; his shoulders seemed to burst sideways. I felt a pang of something, followed by a destabilising quease of recognising what it was. Envy. I wanted… No, I *needed* that upper body. And lick me five ways from Tuesday, the life and times of Sir Adora had NOT equipped me with the psychological tools to process that----------

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Chapter 36

Chapter Summary

'I've said it before and I'll say it again, sir. Fuck your aunt. Fuck. Your. Aunt.'

'But not my family. Because you and Bow and the others are my family. They're just my relatives.'

'And you never have to see them again, if you don't want to.'

'I'm thinking about it, Catra. I am. If tonight goes how I think, that really could be it for me and house de l'Horde... except for my noble steed, of course. He's on the way over, you know, so us and him can gallop into battle together!!'

'Adora? Do you mean---?'

'DID SOMEBODY SAY *SWIFT WIND*?? SWEETIE, ARE YOU ENGAGED?? AND DOES IT SMELL LIKE EGGS IN HERE??'

Chapter Notes

Content warnings apply for the below chapter only - Spoilers may be present in the warnings. This story does not include any of the four Archive Warnings topics, but does occasionally feature other topics that may require content notes. Chapter 36 has extensive content warnings. If you just need a quick overview, please find a shorter list of the chapter's content warning themes below the main list.

Chapter 36 Content Warnings (CONTAINS SPOILERS):
Gender Dysphoria – Narrated, present, bodily dysphoria, top dysphoria, extensive, experienced by narrator
Denial of self – Narrated, present, extensive, experienced by narrator
Internalised transphobia – Narrated, present, experienced by narrator

Internalised homophobia – Narrated, present, experienced by narrator
Abuse, abusive parenting – Narrated, present, extensive, directed at narrator
Transphobia – Related, present and historic, directed at narrator
Homophobia – Related, present and historic, directed at narrator
Misgendering – Related, present and historic, directed at narrator (Misuse of commonly gendered terms i.e. 'woman')
Encouragement to self-harm – Related, present, directed at narrator (Occurs in dream state, no real bodily harm occurs)
Self-harm, with knife – Narrated, present, experienced by narrator (Occurs in dream state, no real bodily harm occurs)
Knife violence – Narrated, present, experienced by narrator (Occurs in dream state, no real bodily violence occurs)
Physical harm, thorns and tendrils – Narrated, present, experienced by narrator (Occurs in dream state, no real bodily harm occurs)
Physical harm, goring, trampling – Related, present, brief, vaguely described in passing (Occurs in dream state, no real bodily harm occurs)

Chapter 36 Content Warnings, Themes:
Gender Dysphoria
Self-Denial
Queerphobia
Familial Abuse
Self-Harm

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PART 10

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Adora. My dear Adora… I had such high hopes for you. Why would you disappoint your Aunt after all these years that I've cared for you? Everything I did, I did for your future. Look at the sacrifices I made, the battles I waged, all that money I spent on your education, and see how I never begrudged a single penny of it. You were my ward, Adora: mine to protect. I raised you as my daughter, and this is the thanks I get?

Acrid sulphur burned and swirled, cut through with a sickly, ominous grass-stain of green. The sun choked. The fair rotted away. Catra and Glimmer and that ridiculous aeroplane gent and everyone else dissolved before my eyes. There was only Aunt Shadowtha, grinding slow but exceeding tall. My time was up. She had come for me. But no. But no. I didn't want to go.

I scrabbled backwards, stumbling, trying to find my feet, but the ground was glued dirt, lifeless and stuck. My knees popped and my ankles shattered. She was looking through me. I couldn't stare back; I couldn't not. There was no light. Or joy. The gloom strangled it all. My fingers raced, searching for any kind of crag or lump I might haul myself up against, or a stick or stone to ward off my demise. She was getting closer.

The field was gone. I wanted to scream. I could not scream. I wanted to cry. I could not cry.

The ground was a dry and searing roar, so flattened smooth that I had to submit to its order. Why fight? Nobody listened, not really. They never had. My words flew out and the world guessed at them, picked at them, built them into shapes that ballooned into

sentences I'd never meant, until what I really wanted to say was smothered dead. I was Adora, the charming fool. The knight errant.

The shell. My flesh was worth no more than my thoughts; they were the sum of me and they were nothing. I was barely worth punishing. It was a miracle Auntie still bothered. Every time I stumbled forth and tried to fill even a little of that hollow that churned and gaped through my centre, all I could do was hurt people, like a buried mine, hurling up the earth and destroying, destroying. My shrapnel wounded every damned individual in my orbit, jagging shapes that just can't be.

My palms stopped scrabbling. Inky tendrils weighed me down, spearing through my skin as they coursed through the empty space, pinning me down. They grew and grew like vines – until they had no end and I had no start. Good. I was just a sack of mud who'd raked up her own funeral pyre. Without the classroom and the cane, the etiquette manuals and the honour of the family name, there wasn't one bit of me left worth keeping. Rebuilding me would only be a waste. They could knock me down and start all over again.

My chin jerked in Auntie's talons. She'd caught me. Game over.

How deeply you resisted your instruction, little Dory. You hit and you cried and you hid like a child, as if you truly believed your petty resistance could change your course. My patience was severely tested, but I never abandoned you: not when you refused to let the maids dress you in the clothes I had picked out for you; nor when you tried to lead that poor girl in your

dormitory astray. I could see you were wilful. It only meant I had to prune you, so you could grow in the right direction.

I knew I would triumph, and my ultimate victory draws so near. You wouldn't want to disappoint your dear Auntie at the last. Think how well you represented us at school, once I removed those temptations, and how far you advance the de l'Horde name by serving the Countess Dryl and the Chesham Place Brightmoons. You have progressed so far, Adora. It all depends on you. Success is within your grasp, so long as you do what I say.

Her claw shaved my cheek, peeling open what lay beneath. She squinted at what she found there. Her head shook.

Why do you seek to disappoint me so, after everything I sacrificed for you? I can see what you've been doing. Adora, down this road lies your complete destruction. The family will fall behind you, the de l'Horde name will crumble beneath you, and all because you abandoned your duty. A shameful end. Almost twenty-five years of constant instruction, and your selfishness could still undo it all. If only I'd acted sooner when your insubordination returned, we might have corrected your course once and for all. Well. I suppose it's better late than never.

She stepped back and I slumped into the thorns. A knife appeared in her hand.

You want to be a good daughter, don't you, Adora?

I wanted to be something to someone. It had to beat living like a useless husk, always tripping over my own two feet. There was so much confused possibility beyond the lines. How could I touch down on firm ground again, when everything I felt and uncovered out there floated me even further from the life I'd spent so long learning to live? Okay. I nodded. Yes, Aunt Shadowtha. Put me back between the lines.

Good girl.

The blade throbbed dull obsidian as she released it from its sheath. Reflex tensed me for a blink, until submission could take over and I sagged towards my fate. This was right. This was how it was always going to be. I was the heir to the de l'Horde house. What the family required, Adora had to do. Through glazed, milky eyes, I waited for the rip that would take me back, home.

This hurts me more than it hurts you.

Her gloved hand offered me the handle, holding its lustreless ebony mere inches away from me. The tendrils shot back. I got to my feet, in a trance, feeling her shadow loom over me.

Take the knife.

'No, no, Auntie. I can't do that. I accept my punishment.'

Take the knife.

‘All I know how to do is get things wrong.’

No, Adora. You have led yourself astray, and you will bring yourself back to me. After so many years of defiance, you must want to rest, so take the knife and follow my instructions carefully. Good. Haven’t I always wanted what was best for you? So many hours invested in your learning, shaping your duty to family, your duty to Prime, your duty to Etheria as the heir of a great house, teaching you to love service and purpose. That is who we raised you to be inside.

She took my hands and raised the dagger to my sternum.

Three small removals, and you can be that woman again, I promise. Ever since you were small, I never possessed the power to correct your strongest misapprehensions. That was my failing. I will finally correct it now. ***Listen to me****. You are the Lady de l’Horde, Baroness and heir to the Marchioness of your house. I instructed you to be of use to all deserving nobles, as befits your role, which you warped into your knightly delusions. How you clung to it! How you wounded me. Adora, you have never been a Lord, Baron, Baronet or knight, and you must never again style yourself Sir. Do you understand, Lady de l’Horde?*

The tip cut through my shirt. The metal tanged against my skin.

You have been a disgrace to your name and to me, the kind soul who raised you. Surely you can see this must end. A good, pure Lady dresses as Etherian etiquette dictates. Demure femininity, Adora, which you opposed at every turn. Look where that got you. We can tolerate your tomboyish afflictions no longer; your fixation on trousers, suits and sporting goods ends now.

Blood curled around the end of the blade. Aunt Shadowtha loomed above me. I wanted to be normal. I was going to be good. I clutched the handle and squeezed on the pressure.

Well done, Adora. Your eagerness will please the Hord High Akmiral. Search within yourself for the third blockage. You cannot be free until each one has been entirely expunged. I worked so hard to remove them, but my powers were no match for your spiteful impulses. Only you can do it now. Ever since I heard how you debased dear Lady Brightmoon, I knew this day must come, and now you betray yourself with a house girl… It can never be love. My sweet, misguided Dory, this has gone on long enough. Let Auntie save you. Do as I say. Locate these stains on your spirit, take the blade, and ***cut them out****.'*

Falling forwards, my chest buckled into the blade. The hard part was done. It was all about to be over. I could be normal again. I still had a chance – this one, particular chance – to be a Lady my family loved. The knife jagged against something solid. I gasped. My eyes closed. Finally, silence---

'Oh HELL no! Adora, do NOT put that creepy-evil-spirit-stealer knife any further into your gooey bits. Maybe even take it out of there, okay? *Carefully*. We don't want you getting Adora goop all

over the floor of… wherever *this* is. Can you do that for me, sweetie?'

That voice. It wasn't Shadowtha.

All you do is rot that poor girl's mind. Look at her – an adult woman still relying on your comfort. You made her weak! I should have destroyed you when I had the chance…

Oh, but that voice? Definitely was.

'Yah, but you didn't. Soooooooooo… *fwoooop!* Upsie-dupsies!'

What is the meaning of this? You will unhand me and pay the price for what you've done.

'You know that gets wider the further it goes, right? And you know struggling and thrashing around like that is only going to push you further down, right? I'm asking because you don't seem to know.'

Gaaaarrrrrrgggggghhhh! You are making a powerful enemy.

'That 'plane has *flown*. And crashed. And caught fire. When you stand against power, power generally doesn't invite you for tea

and apples. Annnddddd… I hate to be picky, but didn't *you* already call me a "corrupting influence" or some other angry-ass fuddy-duddy words for happy and different?'

You will---

'Not be speaking to you anymore! Because not everything is *about* you, Ms. Marquioness of Creepy Entrances and Never Buying Adora the Train Set She Wanted for Christmas. I'm here to talk with my friend.' The same voice shifted tone remarkably, becoming all soft and close and concerned: calmness against a backdrop of squelching fury. 'Adora, hun, how's it going with that knife?'

'I--- can't get it out.'

'Okay. That's okay. Maybe we---'

Hah-hah! She'll never remove it now, will you Adora? You know we need it. You're going to be a good girl for Auntie!

'Adora, I'm just going to go put something down. Don't go anywhere.'

I didn't. There was a choking viscera groan like black pudding being pushed off an ice cream cone, then a thud. Smoke tanged

my nostrils. Angry syllables flooded my ears, until a muffled stomp made them stop. The friendly voice came back.

'It's like I was saying, Adora. Maybe we can get the knife out together, but I need you to open your eyes first. Can you do that for me?'

I lifted my lids, slowly, half-blinking, somehow afraid that popping them too fast would cause unknown and irreversible damage. The world was a dark blur, but its centre was a bright, white---

'Swif---?'

'DID SOMEBODY SAY SWIFT WIND?'

'Swift *Wind*?'

'Hay! Always nice to meet a fan! And, yes, Adora, Swift WIND. Two words.'

'But – all these years – I was just calling you Swift.'

'And you were *sooooo* close to getting it right. But it's Swift *Wind*, because I run so fast and my hair does… *this*…'

Swift Wind shook his mane with barely-concealed self-attraction. I couldn't blame him. He looked bally magnificent. There were, quite possibly literally, stars in my eyes. Each strand of his auburn hair flew curved and glimmering out behind him, a cornucopia of colours and triumphs.

'*Horsey!*'

'The best horsey.' He rustled his flowing locks to a stop. 'But Adora, sweetness, we're here for *you*. Why did you plunge that blade into your ribcage? They're such pretty ribs.'

'It's not the bones I'm having problems with---'

'Oh? Then what? You can tell Ol' Swiftie!'

If you've never seen a horse cross their hooves, I can you tell you this – it's quite the uncanny sight. I doubt any other steed could have done it. Swift Wind sunk towards the floor, fixing a compassionate eye occasionally on mine, while something dark and grumpy thrashed around by his hind legs. Up close, I could see his horn had taken on a vaguely rose-ish hue.

'Swift Wind?'

‘Adora?’

‘Where’s Aunt Shadowtha?’

‘Where she belongs, babe.’

‘And where *is* that?’

‘Under my hoof.’

‘Okay.’ And, you know, that really did feel *okay*. ‘Why?’

‘Oh, you know, the usual. She kept trying to grab at you when she was gored on my horn, and that really cramped my whole vibe for this. I can’t set you free from your family – no, your *relatives* – if your Auntie literally gets her claws into you.’

‘No, Swiftie--- Why does she belong under your particularly dashing clip-cloppers?’

‘You’re the one with the spooky-hate-blade in your chest: why do you think we might be better off with her trapped there?’

‘Because of the knife, for one…’

‘Which represents?’

‘Which *represents*… How she doesn’t love the niece she has, only the cookie-cutter she always wanted to have.’

‘Yah-HUH! Sing it out, sweetie!’

‘I like girls! And I’m not a girl! But she won’t ever accept that – and I shouldn’t wait around expecting her to get better. She’s not going to. And it doesn’t matter. Because I can live my *own* life.’

‘Yeah! I’m so proud of you, hun!’

No daughter of min---

‘Swift Wind?’

‘Yes, Adora?’

‘Can we get rid of Aunt Shadowtha now?’

‘Adora, I’m going to blow your mind, but this is all happening inside your head. Try taking the knife out, only *this time* believe you can do it.’

‘It came straight out! And I’m not hurt!’

‘That’s my not-girl! Now banish that awful woman! You can do it! I believe in you!’

I scrunched up my nose, thought about it and *poof!* Aunt Shadowtha disappeared in a burst of angry smoke. The whole wherever-we-were brightened, lightened, filled with colours, then thronged with fruit trees.

‘Alright, Adora! Apples!’

Swift Wind got to munching a particularly robust Egremont Russet. He looked happy. I didn’t want to disturb him. Alas, my brain got to thinking, which meant my mandibles primed themselves for a particularly large and existential question.

‘Swiftie, how are you here?’

‘Oh, I’ve been here for a while. I was just waiting for the perfect moment to make my entrance. You seemed busy, you know?’

‘I mean… How did you *get* here? Where were you before?’

‘I wasn’t anywhere before. I was nowhere, then I was here.’

‘Who brought you here? Who made you so magnificently flesh and blood?’

‘You did? The power of love made me real?’

‘Really?’

‘Have you got a better answer? This is *your* out-of-body experience, Adora.’

‘So you’re inside my head?’

‘Muh-huh!’ they said, cheerfully, through a mouthful of apple.

‘So you’re not real?’

‘ADORA!!’

‘What?’

‘Are the self-assertions and self-revelations you just made not real? Is you overcoming your Auntie’s hideous, insidious, creepy-deepy control not real? Was the way you nearly sliced and diced your way back into people-pleasing conformity not real? Is this apple not real? Is this crisply refreshing, subtly nutty flavour not real?’

He gestured. I took a bite of the Russet. It definitely tasted of all the things he said it did, which one generally found dreams didn’t.

‘What even is reality?’ Swift Wind went on, ‘If this is the only environment I’ve ever known – and I’m pretty sure it is – then isn’t this *real* to me? So can *real* mean different things to different people? The very nature of reality can only be validated by the individual, so what’s to say – from my perspective – that anything other than the dazzling steed known as Swift Wind is actually real? What if you’re just a simulacrum put here to enhance *my* journey towards a more equitable society and perfectly conditioned hair?’

My head was starting to hurt.

‘So do you or don’t you exist in my world? The one with the fête and everything? Can I find you? Are you real there?’

‘I don’t know.’

‘Oh,’ I sighed, sadly.

Swiftie put a comforting hoof on my shoulder.

‘But I’ll tell you one thing I know *is* real, Adora: my love for you. I love you and I’m proud of you. I’ll always be here for you.’

‘Can… Can we go for a ride together?’

‘I’d like that.’

We were hot to trot. Over hill and across glade we galloped, just like I’d always imagined. The wind tangled through our mutually spectacular hair and I simply couldn’t stop smiling. Swiftie whinnied his assent and we raced forwards, plunging towards a sparkling river, where we looked – enchanted – at our joint reflection.

‘This isn’t quite right.’

‘How do you mean, Adora?’

I gestured at my chest.

'*Oh*. You know you can fix that, hun? In here *and* out there.'

'How?'

'Same way you just shook off your witch-in-law, sweetie.'

I thought really very hard and… *Greyskull's honour*! It worked! My chest! Look at my chest!

'Haha! Hahahaha!! Oh my Horde – Swiftie, Swiftie, look!!'

'Adora! Look at you! You've lit up like a fucking Christmas tree!'

'Oh my… I…' I started crying. *Happy* crying. An ache I hadn't know was aching just… stopped. My body was so quiet and… *good*.

'HOW DO I DO THIS OUT THERE?!'

'I don't know, Adora, I'm a spectacular, ethereal horse. But I think I know someone who will… *The girl*.'

Swift Wind waggled where his eyebrows would be, if horses had eyebrows, which they don't.

'The girl?'

'You knooooowwwwwww??! The one you've told me SO MUCH about!!'

'Glimmer?'

'No.' His face fell. 'Not Glimmer. I don't like Glimmer.'

'Because she tried to break us up and throw you in the bin?'

'Because she tried to break us up and throw me in the bin, yes. That's not a high-quality friend you have there, Adora. Take it from a magical horse.'

'So you mean…'

'The new girl! The one you've been whispering to me about the last couple of nights!'

‘Catra?! You were listening? You know about Catra?’

‘What *don’t* I know about Catra, Adora?’

‘WHAT?!’

‘Um, you *told* me, Adora.’

‘In *confidence.*’

‘Which I haven’t broken?’

‘I… Well… Um… No, no you haven’t! What’s your point?’

‘That she seems really good for you, Adora. You should see how happy she makes you! I hope you don’t mind me saying, but most of the time we’ve known each other, you have *not* been happy. At *all*.’

‘No… No, I haven’t.’

‘And now you can be! With her!’

‘Yes. Yes, I can.’

‘But will you?’

‘You know, I think I will!’

‘Yay, Adora! You’re making a good decision, hun. Do you know she drove all the way back to London to get me – *and* she talked to me for the whole drive back? She’s nice! She’s cute! She’s a really good fancy-suit-Lady! Catra Applesauce Meowmeow gets the Swift Wind stamp of approval.’

And, to prove it, he lifted himself up to his glorious full height, found a particularly glimmery stretch of riverbank, and stamped his front left hoof three times, whinnying and laughing like the family I actually deserved. The family he is.

‘Thanks, Swiftie.’

‘I think you know what you need to do now, don’t you sweetie? Go back to her, Adora, tell her what you told me.’

~~~ ‘*I love you.*’ ~~~
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‘Adora? *Adora?*’

I came round in Catra’s lap, her lambent blues and yellows welling up over me. We just had to stop meeting like this.

‘Catra…’ I leaked from somewhere too, too far away from safety. ‘My chest… *Please*… I can’t… I can’t take it… Not… for… another… moment… So… many… years… without… understanding… but… really… really… needing… it… to… be… *right*… It… hurts… *so*… much… Catra… make… it… stop… *PLEASE*… It… won’t… stop… aching…’

‘I know, Adora. I understand. I’ll make it better. By the time the sun comes up tomorrow, it’ll all be better, I promise.’

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Chapter 37

Chapter Summary

'Wow, Adora! You... are... DRUNK!'

'Pfftt... Swiftie! I've only had *half* a bottle of champagne. And Catra's brandy. And Catra's other secret brandy she thinks I don't know about.'

'Really, Adora? I meant in the chapter. Where you watch Ladies Meowmeow and Brightmoon compete for SHADOWY reasons. Why are you DRUNK now?'

'Dutch courage, Swift Wind, old chap. For when you and me and Catra ride into the Horses of Paard-liament. Tonight! For She-Ra reasons!'

'Excellent cross-language pun, sir.'

'Th--- *hic* ---ank you... Catra... my smoogly-boogly!! MWAH!'

'Err-- Catra? Are we trusting Drunk Adora to write the whole plan?'

'Worry not, sir. The matter is quite in Hand.'

'... ... ... Is that another horse pun??'

Chapter Notes

Content warnings apply for the below chapter only - Spoilers may be present in the warnings. This story does not include any of the four Archive Warnings topics, but does occasionally feature other topics that may require content notes.

Chapter 37 Content Warnings (CONTAINS SPOILERS): Vehicle incident, airplane - Related, historic, mentioned in

passing
Incitement to insurance fraud - Related, extensive, attempt to involve narrator
Bodyshaming, transphobic - Related, brief, towards main character, related to character's gender-affirming treatment
Possessiveness - Related, extensive, towards narrator
Intoxication, drunkenness - Narrated, narrator is drunk
Classism - Related, extensive, towards main character and minor character
Bigotry towards cross-class relationships - Related, extensive, towards narrator and major character
Perceived homophobia - Related, towards main character (no homophobia is intended)

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PART 11

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‘*I’m the great Skyhawk, I am, I am,*

Want to heave a mallet? Then I am your man!

Raise it high, then race it down,

Get the big bell ringing and you’ll toast the town!!---

Ah-ha! Customers! You finely luscious ladies are back! You couldn’t stay away, could you, from the breeze-braving beefcake? Hurr!! *FLEX*!’

One must intrude, here, to confirm that, yes, the jodphured jockstrap really did *say* flex. Tomorrow felt a very long way away. He pumped his arm again, bursting his sleeve along its loosely stitched inner seam. The leather jacket moved something in me. I'd need one of those. Its contents? Less so…

'Wait!' cried he, with the crushing inevitability of the wittiness-less party guest who plops himself down next to one just after one has embarked on the soup course and finds oneself slurpingly trapped. 'I know you! Muscles Lady! The one who gave *Dragon's Daughter IV* its "final flight"… for now!!'

'Um--- yes--- that's me? The mighty She-Ra--- Adora. How's the rebuild coming on?'

'Oh!' Skyhawk exalted. 'Terribly! You couldn't have done a better job finishing off if you'd tried.'

He winked at me.

I blinked back.

'Well… Did you, Adora?'

'Did I *what*?!'

‘Don’t play cute, kid. We’re too tall to pull it off. Trust me. I still can’t go back to Gstaad---’

‘Eh?’

‘Did you… y’know… sink the ship to kill the captain?’ He waggled his eyebrows, and his moustache, and his biceps, and his triceps. ‘Because that would have been a GREAT ruse! The best!! We could’ve split the insurance payout – if only I’d had a policy in place… Say! Kid! How about we meet in three months over Munich way and see what you “make” of *Dragon’s Daughter V*?’ His lips wavered and the fellow’s eyes got very wet. ‘I’m up to my eyeballs in it, Adora. The Admiral is coming for me. This may surprise you but there’s not much moolah in crashing ‘planes. So… what do you say??’

‘We… just came to play the game? With the mallet.’

‘A HAMMER?! No, no, no, land lubber. Then it’s too obvious we did it on purpose! It won’t wash.’

‘Does it need to?’

‘YES!! Or I am *RUINED*!!’

‘Seems a dashed strange thing – to wallop a bell in secret. The whole fact there *is* a bell works against you for one.’

‘Oh!’ gasped Skyhawk. His expression morphed a dozen times or more. ‘Oh. Ooohhhh! O-kay! You came to play---’ He pointed at the tower, ‘with the---’ he gestured towards a mallet, ‘to see if you can hit---’ and his finger jabbed aloft, at the big, vermillion school bell overhead. ‘So you’re not here to do some very helpful insurance fraud? You’re here to try the fairground game?’

I shook my head.

‘Well! Why didn’t you say so? Penny a go! Come one, come all! All funds raised go to a very special lady!’

Lady Brightmoon beckoned.

‘What do you say, brave knight? Bet you… shit… *twenty* guineas you can do it in one. Then, after, *ohmigosh*, me and Meowmeow can find out who’s a better match for you. Okay?’

Seemed fair enough, provided one read no subtext into it. And I did not. I just picked up the hammer and hit the bell.

‘Shit! Ohmigosh! That’s my *knight*! MY knight! Now, uh, *Meowmeow*, guess you go next…’

‘With please, madam.’

Catra raised the hammer with all her might but, alas, the life of the valet calls for charisma and smarts, wisdom and dexterity long before it even pauses to consider the value of a robust constitution. As for strength, the less said the better. Bulging muscles are hardly the key to Lady Meowmeow’s superlative charm, and nor did her role require them. I had our household more than covered in that regard. Except here, in this misguided, internicene joust, where I did not. Could not.

Mallet hit plank – and the lead raise itself a bare few feet. “Damp squib!” extolled the signwritten note next to this less than lofty height. The cheek of it! I had a good mind to fight that sign.

‘Ha-ha-ha!’ roared our aviator acquaintance, his fists balled on his hips. ‘Poor show, eh?! Never mind. We can’t all be Skyhawks!’

‘I shall try to contain my disappointment, sir.’

‘Now, now, sweet Lady, I won’t have that! Skyhawk – that is to say, finely facial-haired me – is nothing if not a proponent of fair play! It is the law… of the skies! The LAW OF… ADVENTURE!!’

How this newfound ruleset accommodated incitement to insurance fraud, I really couldn’t say. Catra demurred.

‘Thank you, sir, but I must decline. I fear a second attempt would not improve my fortunes.’

‘But will a third?! Come on now, my sky princess, for you receive three strikes to your donation.’

Moderate fury burned inside me – or perhaps it was the cider that had somehow materialised in my mitts, vanished, refilled itself, and rapidly started disappearing again.

‘Now, listen here,’ I slurred, ‘the Lady says no and that settles it! No means no!!’

‘Okay, okay, Sir Adora, easy!’ Skyhawk wilted. ‘I was only having a little fun.’

‘*Not* at her expense.’

‘Awwh, *Dory*!’ a familiar voice tinkled somewhere behind. ‘How cute!! *Sooooo* noble! My knight really *does* stand up for *anyone* – even fucking *cowards*!’

‘If she doesn’t want to play, Glimmer, she doesn’t have to. Why should she?’

‘Err… Maybe because it’s in the spirit of the game, Adora? And--- and--- it’s in the *RULES*.’

‘Oh dear,’ Catra purred, ‘Adora knows how strongly I feel about regulations.’

‘We have to play each game to the fucking full!! Shit, how else can we *fairly* declare a winner? So get swinging!!’

Open-mouthed, I stood agog – or, perhaps more accurately, *agrog* – as the earth swayed on its axis. Surely this was the moment my worlds collided for real and very much likely for worse. Catra stepped back, curling her shoulders. Half a thought suggested I stick my head between my legs and brace for impact. But Lady Meowmeow meant different. She walked back to the attraction and struck it twice, no more successfully than before.

‘Not my strong suit,’ she shrugged. ‘Experiences vary but, for me, oestrogen has destroyed any pretence I had to upper-body strength.’ She grinned that wonderful lopsided smirk of hers. ‘There are worse trade-offs…’

‘Pfft… I *suppose*… If you’re happy being weak, then *good for you*. Don’t know how well that’s gunna play with Dory, though, just sayin’…’

Lady Brightmoon swung her weapon like a cocky croquet stick, stepping into the bell-ringing arena. Squat and sure, she threw it back so far it grazed her couture-clad navel, then slammed it through a half-turn, gripping tight enough to burst a knuckle. THWUMP. The lead shot halfway up the tower. Turn two threw it a mite higher.

'Looks like we've got a *winner*, huh?' she cackled. 'But… But! Dory – *watch this!!*'

Her teeth and eyes hummed enamel, the way they always do just before Countess Glitterbug tries something supremely ill-advised. She shot back, then elastic-swung towards the aviator's game. Its clapboard crucifix didn't stand a chance. She was a warrior princess of yore. But with much more expensive cologne. Something stirred inside me, I'm not afraid to say. She-Ra is all about this kind of fellow: action and feeling and the intertwining of the two. The static-brightness burred. Ms. Floaty-C snapped against my side. My Madam tugged at my attentions.

And I could guess what came next. *Slam*. Her eyes clasped shut. *Wham*. She disappeared in a puff of pink. And the cloud, for once, wasn't her cigarette fug. **Bam.** Lady B rematerialised way, way above. Barely a dot silhouetted in a cloudless sky. The dot became a ball. Became a shadow. Became a shape. She was falling. Fast. Mallet and all. Outlinery turned to finery. Ink switched back to pink. And a laughing, screaming, sparkling bundle raced towards her strike point.

'Addddooooorrrrraaaaaa!!' she Doppler affected, one leg folded over its sister. Her dainty shoe clicked against the sky. Its hand-made movement implied that even *this* – this downward plummet

so extreme that even Hephaestus would go darting for the handrail – was somehow *dull*. Or duller than what she could be doing. Glimmer winked my way. Her mouth lapsed into a wet, lascivious smirk, bracketed by a double dimple. Cripes.

'Look at me *now*!'

It was an order. It was an evocation. It was unavoidable. Double-figures to the throne hurled herself from the hip, twirled a semi-sphere in the sky, and went face-down towards her prize. There she was. A woman on fire. She was the *scandalous Brightmoon heir* who preened for the press cameraman. She was the *Countess Dryl* who snooted down-nostril from the Buckingham ledge. She was the *Lady Glitterbug* whose amorous intrigues painted an Oxford box-social static when two of her boyfriends met three of her girlfriends met… *me*. The cold, painted beauty. The centre of things. The tide. The moon.

The enemy of the sun, raging from a painted eyebrow. Mirror image and eternal enmity. Tied into mocking confusion, never sure what to make of the warmth or the light or the giving, growing spirit forever beaming out of her opposition. Glimmer was all of the above – in the most sumptuous manner imaginable. Barely-there silk rained from her midriff as her thighs thrust and her waist yawned her shoulders free. She floated off from her weapon: a masterpiece mid-violence. A tendril bound them. But that was enough.

Hammer hit plank. Splinters flew, lead shot. Up, up, the marker went, scrubbing through her previous best. Eclipsing Catra. Faster. Faster. It raced, accelerating, straining for the ultimate victory. Swelling. Vibrating. So. Nearly. There. Breath strained at my

corners, unstitching me. Then. Glimmer gone. Glimmer come. Saccharine smoke choked to my waist, where her hand found me. She squeezed. The bell tolled.

'What do you think, Dory?! Looks like I *got* you *there*.' She smiled undeniable force my way. Shooting through me. I couldn't move, let alone stammer. 'Pretty fucking good, right? I can always meet you, you know. Always match you. *That*'s what makes us so great together---'

Her touch fell to my hips, fingers spreading. I felt myself getting warm. I didn't know what to think about that. Oh, but she. She did.

'Guess you could say we're level-pegging. Now. Dory. Don't you *want* to see me play with my coconuts?'

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They didn't look so shy to me. Bold as brass, they were, perched atop their cuppy-towery-poley things. Five coconuts. Arranged like the dots on a die, provided the die had rolled a five. That was if you were looking at them from overhead, of course, from a hot air-balloon or the likely imminent *Dragon's Daughter V*. I somehow doubted that number IV was ever making it back into the sky. Being tempted towards mass-scale criminality by her owner had rather cast a cloud over the whole affair.
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Better not to think about it. So. Coconuts! Rum looking things, I have to say. All hairy on the outside yet slickly silk within. Not to mention the juices that gush forth if you tickle them just right. Oh – and the *flavour*: how damned lucky I always feel when I breath in that intoxicating fug of sweet and fresh and deep and musk that sublimates into this uniquely impossible olfactory experience. My tongue flicked at the thought. And I was suddenly looking at Lady Meowmeow in a very yearning kind of way…

She gazed somewhere quite else, closing one eye in the direction of the topical tropical. From where we stood – in a kind of verdant, oblong penalty box, which Scorpia had kindly demarked with rope and that kind of clumpy white groundskeepers are so keen on using – the fruits stood very far-off in the horizontal plane. We could see the front three quite clearly, but our knowledge of the back two leaned more heavily on fate – or on taking a couple of steps to either side. I'm informed it's a matter of angles and refractions and I'm already boring myself, so shall we get on with what happened next?

Catra had three wooden balls between her paws: two in the right, and one in the left. This wasn't as strange an affair as it initially appeared. Though it hasn't been relevant up before now, and won't become important again until it very much it does, the lady of my dreams is a left-hander. It's the only sinister thing about her, if we're taking the jocular aspect and attempting a Latinate witticism.

But best not to make too much light of it. Though she's loathe to talk too much about her earlier years, she has told me how her schoolteachers would tie her writing hand behind her back to discourage her from using it. When she broke free of those bounds and used it anyway – because Catra – they'd cane her.

“What a pity,” she’d added at that point, “that being told I can’t do something just makes me want to do it more.”

So she held that first projectile south-paw, clutching the spares like a tennis player might grasp at her surplus supplies. She thought about putting those two in a pocket, started the action, but skittered that particular action to a rapid halt when she remembered that the balls were too large and too splintery for something as finely cut as her suit. I stepped forward to grab them. It was good to feel like I was helping. So good, in fact, that I couldn’t resist a little narration:

‘I’M HELPING!! WOOOOO!’

You will remember, by this point in proceedings, I was drunk. The scotch egg could stem the tide no more. My cockle-cheering, participatory cider, followed by two Daiquiris, then another Daiquiri, plus the *almost* three additional pints I’d washed down but not told you about, had somehow proved to be my undoing. Amorous slurring ensued.

‘WOOO! THAT’S MY GIRLFRIEND! MY *GIRLFRIEND!!* I’M GONNA MARRY HER ONE DAY! GONNA GET DOWN ON MY KNEE AND PUT A RING ON HER FINGER AND MOVE HER INTO A PRETTY HOUSE WITH NICE SOFAS – BECAUSE I THINK SHE’S THE KIND OF LADY WHO REALLY LIKES A NICE *hic* SOFA – AND THEN WE’LL GET ALL THE MONEY FROM AUNTIE AND SHE WON’T HAVE TO BE MY VALET ANYMORE AND THEN--- AND THEN SHE’S ONLY GOT TO WORRY ABOUT WHAT WE CALLS OUR CATS? DOGS? HAMSTERFISHRABBITS?? *hic* ERR… I DUNNO WHAT KIND OF PETS SHE LIKES BUT I’LL GET HER THAT KIND – OR

KINDS – THEN WE'LL WALK THEM TOGETHER AND GO TO PUBS BY CANALS AND MAYBE EVEN GET A CANAL BOAT?

'AND SHE CAN WEAR FANCY CLOTHES ALL THE TIME IF SHE WANTS BUT I'LL GET ONE OF THOSE FARMER JACKETS WITH ALL THE TWEED AND THE WAX COATING AND THE FIRM BITS ON THE ELBOWS AND WE CAN EATS PIES AND DRINK ALES BY FIRES AND THE PUB PEOPLE WILL ALL BE REALLY FRIENDLY… UNLESS THEY'RE NOT FRIENDLY… AND IN *THAT* CASE I'LL MAKE THEM FRIENDLY BY TELLING THEM THAT I'M THE SHE-RA AND I SAY GAY IS OKAY SO IT IS OKAY AND IF YOU DON'T LIKE IT THEN I'LL TAKE ALL THE BRASS HORSESHOES OFF THE PUB WALL AND REARRANGE THEM LIKE *BEEP-BOOP-BEEP* SO YOU DON'T KNOW WHERE THEY GO ANY MORE AND THEN YOUR PUB WON'T TELL A COHESIVE BUT HOMELY NARRATIVE OF AN ETHERIA LONG PAST AND PEOPLE WON'T LIKE IT AS MUCH! SO THERE!!

Evidently, I was beginning to warm to my subject.

'JUST YOU WAIT!' I gargled merrily onwards to nobody in particular. 'YOU'LL SEE!! YOU'LL ALL SEE! MY GIRLFRIEND IS SO FRIGGIN *HOT* AND SMART AND ***HOT*** AND SHE COULD BEAT ALL YOUR GIRLFRIENDS IN A FIGHT. EXCEPT SHE PROBABLY COULDN'T. BUT I'D SIGN ON AS HER SECOND AND FIGHT FOR HER AND I'D WIN BECAUSE *I'M* THE SHE-RA AND WINNING IS SOMETHING I DO. A SONG PLAYS IN MY HEAD AND EVERYTHING. NO. REALLY. IT DOES! *hic* THE SONG HAS WORDS AND IT TELLS ME I'LL ALWAYS WIN IN THE END SO LONG AS I USE THE POWER OF FRIENDSHIP. BUT I DON'T *hic* REALLY KNOW WHAT LADY PLUMERS COULD DO IN A BOUT YET. MAYBE SHE GETS THE PLANTS TO FIGHT FOR YOU? OR IS YOGA A LOT MORE DANGEROUS THAN I THOUGHT?'

‘Oh no,’ Scorpia reassured me. ‘Yoga is really gentle when Perfuma leads it. And it really stretches out my spine! Which is good news because I… have… a LOT of back pain. You know, these ladies,’ she snip-snipped her claws, ‘I love ‘em but I’ve got to say they’re pretty big. Pretty hefty on the old vertebrae!’

A useful interlude and an interesting recommendation for a gentle addition to my pre-breakfast routine both. I recognise that *now*. *Then*, I blithered on regardless.

‘MY SONG HAS PICTURES,’ I blurted out, adding greatly to the discourse, ‘AND THE PICTURES CHANGE SOMETIMES AND SOMETIMES THE PICTURES HAVE PEOPLE I DON’T KNOW YET OR PEOPLE I *DO* KNOW BUT DOING THINGS THEY WOULDN’T REALLY DO. AND CATRA IS IN IT AND SHE SMILES AT ME IN THIS CRUMPLY WAY WITH HER EYES SLIGHTLY STARTING TO CLOSE THAT JUST MAKES ME *FLOOD*. AND THEN I *hic* REALLY WANT TO TAKE ALL MY CLOTHES OFF FOR HER. AGAIN.’

‘Again?!? *Dory*, ohmigosh, you’re such a *dog*.’

Oh, yes, of course. Glimmer was here. It was becoming a recurrent theme of this fête that I completely forgot the Brightmoon heir had come with us, which seems a trifle silly when you consider that she and Catra were embroiled in competition to see who was best or something. Had I been a smarter fellow, or a more abstemious one, I might have picked that moment to quell my tongue. I was not – so I did not.

‘DID YOU HEAR?? GLIMMER. *GLIMMER!!* DID YOU HEAR??? I JUST KNOW I’M GONNA ***MARRY*** CATRA ONE DAY!’

‘No. No, Adora. You’re not.’

‘ERR, YES, GLIMMER, I *AM*.’

‘How can you wed that--- that *valet* when it isn’t allowed? Hmm? You even think of that, Dory? It isn’t legal for you to ruin your life as the new Mrs. Meowmeow – and *I* don’t think it should be.’

‘ERR… WHAT??!’

That was very much what I was thinking, but it wasn’t what I said. Not at that exact second. *I* got my angry interrogative in a good half-second later but, just like on the treacherous climes of Cannock Chase, I’d been beaten to the line by good old Scorpy. She was looking very tall all of a sudden, with her tail curved over fit to kill.

‘Okay. So, hey, Glimmer, I’m going to need you to spell out just what you think is so wrong about two ladies--- oh gee, Adora, sorry, are you a lady?’

I blew hard out of my cheeks.

‘UMM… PASS. I’M *DEFINITELY* A LESBIAN, IF THAT HELPS.’

‘Okay. Cool. Thank you. That *is* really useful and accurate and good and I’m sorry if you felt put on the spot, Adora. Now. Gee. Where was I? Glimmer? Yeah – *Glimmer*! That *is* right – right? You know me… I’d forget my stinger if wasn’t safely attached to my metasoma. But I’m pretty sure I was talking to Glimmer.’

‘That’s quite right, madam. You were asking her ladyship why she so fervently opposed marriage equality.’

‘Thanks Catra! That’s my wildcat – always helping people find the right track. Or that’s what Perfuma says.’

‘I’m flattered she talks about me at all.’

‘Gee – you should be. You’ve made a BIG impression. She really thinks you’re the best… And don’t even get me started on how much she likes you and Adora together. She thinks you’re just, like, the best couple. We both do!’

‘High praise.’

Even squiffed eight ways from Swithin’s Day, I could tell this wasn’t really progressing like any ordinary fracas. Perhaps the She-Ra really *did* need friends to win her fights. Perhaps this was what that looked like. The absences of blood and men clutching

their noses, calling me unladylike, really spoke up in this approach's favour. But I still felt quite adrift. Which, I suppose, gives some context for why I downed my… sixventh? consecutive glass of foamy apple, staggered into the middle of our little menage, spread my arms like radio antennae and slurringly pronounced…

'*GIRLS FIGHT… ING?!*'

A key turned in a mental lock. I could see it in Scorpy's face. This was good news – maybe – but quite unintentional, like tipsily pawing at the hotel safe and stumbling on its combination, freeing the family jewels just minutes before Aunt Shadowtha enacts her threat to get you sent on a yearlong naval commission to the Labrador Peninsula *without* sufficient scrounge to afford the passage home again. Just a little insight into the harmonious de l'Horde family life, there. Best not dwell! Especially when Madam Blackstone had started swelling with remembered emotion.

'Gee. I was *angry*, wasn't I?!'

'WOO!! YEAH! *hic* PROCESS AND ARTICULATE YOUR FEELINGS! TELL HER! TELL HER WHAT YOU THINK ABOUT WHEN SHE TRIED TO TAKE YOUR FLUFFY HORSE AWAY!! WOOOO!'

Oops. I was a little confused, but you can't deny I had the spirit.

‘Glimmer, okay, Gilmmer,’ Scorps stepped back into her righteous indignation, ‘you really have to tell me why, in your world, you reckon two Lesbians can’t get married. Because, you know, that really hurts my feeling… because I’m a Lesbian… who might want to get married one day… to another Sapphic. Maybe the Sapphic I’m dating. I don’t know. It’s a bit early to say. I’m not as brave as Adora. I don’t even know what me and Perfuma *are* as a couple yet, you know? But – gee – the point still stands: I should be able to marry whoever I want to. Or whom. Whichever one is the right one.’

‘Well *duh*, Scorpia, give me *some* credit, why don’t you? Of *course* I don’t think weddings should just be between one man and one woman – I’m not a fucking *nun*. And--- *shit*. *Obviously* you should be able to marry Perfs if you want to. You’re both the right sort.’

‘Gee. What are you saying? That Catra ISN’T?’

‘Err, I knew you wouldn’t understand!! No. How comes nobody sees this but me?! NO. No, no, no, no, *CLEARLY* chunky-diarrhoea-shitting **NO**!! What on *EARTH* makes everyone think a jumped up *fucking* scullery maid somehow gets the right to marry an aristocrat? Is it because she knows big words? Is it because she dresses up in fancy woollen suits – which are probably stolen, by the way? Could somebody explain it to me? Because this is *real life* and everyone around me is treating it like some shitty little romance novel!!’

‘Catra should get to marry Adora, and Adora should get to marry Catra, if they want to, because they love each other. That’s it. That’s FINAL.’

Thus spake Marriage Scorpia, the heroine we needed and, I hope, one day the heroine I'll do enough to deserve.

Glimmer didn't like that.

'Nuh-uh. Blackstone. Scor-pi-a. I really feel like you're not respecting me as a person--- Don't you dare raise your fucking eyebrow at me Meowmeow, you oozing sardonic cunt welt!!--- Shut up. Just *SHUP UP*. Everyone. *Now*. Scorpia. You're not respecting me as a person and that makes me feel pretty fucked off, actually. And it's not just my *me* you're not getting – it's basic and fundamental fact. Dory is a *de l'Horde.* Does that mean nothing to you?? Okay, you're not a *real* aristocrat "Scorpy" so maybe you don't understand just how big a shitshow this is… Let me explain. Adora is *really important*. Marrying the HELP would taint her. Forever. And we *definitely* couldn't be friends with her any more.'

'Err. Gee. Where to start? No. I absolutely *could* still be friends with her. With both of them. One of my favourite new people all coupled up with my other favourite new person? That sounds pretty darn good to me, right?'

'How aren't you *seeing* this? Did your mums sell your dignity when they flogged Daddy your estate?! Is that it? Has living in that pissing *milquetoast* townhouse broom cupboard warped any understanding you ever got through your dense head about how all this works? Ew. I bet you've been using--- *blech*--- the underground. Ew ew ew. *Public transport*. Ew.'

‘BUT I *LIKE* THE TUBE!’ Wonderful. Somewhere inside pint eight – don’t ask where I got this latest draft, I really can’t recall – a few soggy braincells had shaken off some of the alcohol and projected me back into the fray. ‘NO – I LOVE THE TUBE! THE CURVED CARRIAGE ROOFS, THE LONG, LONG, FLUFFY SEATS THAT RUN DOWN THE SIDES, THE SPINNING TURNSTILES, THE BAROQUE AND ANCIENT VAULTS AT BAKER STREET, THE BLACK GUNK THAT GETS UP YOUR NOSE, THE SHEER NUMBER OF CHOICES YOU CAN MAKE FROM KINGS CROSS-ST. PANCRAS, THE WAY NO-ONE EVER ENGAGES YOU IN ANY KIND OF CONVERSATION AT *ALL*. GLIMMER. *GLIMMER.* I CAN TAKE A LOT – BUT IF YOU BADMOUTH THE UNDERGROUND THEN IT’S--- IT’S CURTAINS FOR US.’

‘Dory – no. You don’t like the *fucking* tube. You like the backseat in the Brightmoon Rolls-Royces… or my *Duesenberg*… Don’t you want to ride and drink and laugh in my Duesenberg again? Together.’

‘Who are you to tell her what she wants?’ Scorpy really did seem rather cross. ‘Watch your gosh-darn tone, your Ladyship.’ Correction – she was *furious*. ‘That’s *Adora*. The noble knight who changed my life. Remember that. Thank you.’

‘Ex-*fucking*-actly!! She’s a metherfucking noble.’

‘M*e*therfucking, madam? With no o?’

Catra crumpled herself in a half-amused-half-threatened-half-anarchosocialist-half-tired kind of a look. That adds up to a round two, I'm well aware, which is just as it should be. My maybe-girlfriend was – and still is and always will be – worth two of any other woman I've met. No offence meant to the feminine multitudes, you understand, but Madam Meowmeow was, even then, just so thoroughly the lady for me. I drunkenly enquired after a kiss and received it. Deeply. Heir Brightmoon went about having a thermic reaction.

'Could you butt out, thief-maid? In case it escaped your attention, I'm talking about you and not even slightly *to* you. So fucking rude! See, Scropia? *ADORA*? This is what I mean. How can Adora *consider* getting hitched to that little… *monster*. It's a BAD romance. Objectively. It's steaming dribbling *DONKEY SHITE*, that's what it is!! Meowmeow is so crude and sloppy and imprecise and unrefined.'

'Do we mean the same person?' Scorps interjected. 'Catra? *Unrefined?* Can you point to the woman *you* think is Meowmeow?'

The real Catra flicked fluidly back and threw her first ball. It knocked over the central 'nut.

'I hope, madam, you'll find me quite *sharp*.' She showed claws. 'Sir Adora, my next ball, please.'

It hit the coconut blunt and central, shivering its hirsute density onto the precipice. The crowd drew its breath. Rather implausibly, the fellows thronged around us were rather more enthralled by

the sporting action than our epic argument. I deposited the third and final projectile into my lover's waiting palm. She touched her lips to my knuckles.

'A kiss for luck.'

Snap. Gush. Melted. And can you blame me?

Catra drew back: the Babe in Ruth. She stilled her breath, spied her aim, wound up and… and… clipped the platform. The crowd exhaled in "Bad Lucks!" and "Good Tries!" But they hadn't met a Meowmeow. Patience, good people. Her plan was still unfurling. The coconut jerked; it shivered; it paused pregnantly. And then it fell.

'Gee. I've never seen *that* happen. Catra! Folks! We have a winner!'

Scorps lifted Meowmeow's hand in prize fighter revelry. Glimmer flattened straight through that. She had the bit between her pearly chompers, plus an obnoxiously acrid cigarillo. Cuban, naturally. It smouldered and choked as she spied the nearest coconut, took side-stance aim and hurled.

'She *can't* marry---'

Ball one flying.

‘--- a *common* convict---’

Ball one? Miss.

‘---who knows her way---’

Ball two aimed.

‘---around a *dishrag* better than a debutante ball---’

Ball two chucked.

‘She JUST *CAN’T*!!’

Ball two? Hit. *Just*.

‘She should--- *No*--- She *MUST*---’

Ball three raised.

‘---marry someone---’

Ball three pulled back.

‘---who’s *actually* on---’

Ball three aimed.

‘---her *own*---’

Ball three shaking.

‘---*LEVEL*---’

Ball three flying.

‘---someone who gets her---’

Still flying.

‘---someone who can give her what she really needs---’

Still flying.

‘----someone who fits her---’

Still *somehow* flying.

‘---someone like---’

Crack!

‘--- --- --- ***<u>ME</u>****!!!*’

The coconut ripped itself in two. But it didn’t fall. The ball ricocheted back – perilously close to the crowd – and my inner cricket captain caught it mid-air.

‘*Dory*. Fuck. *Me*.’

One didn’t much know what to say to that. None of the others did either. We stood around in stony silence – the eye of a clapping, cheering storm – stuck in a querulous silence. Glimmer broke it, for much the same reason she snaps so many other things. She’d spotted something to gain.

‘*Scorpia Blackstone* – my prize. Now, thank you.’

‘Err… Did you win? I--- This is pretty awkward but, ah, well, I don’t think you beat Catra. Hitting the coconut off the stand is the aim of the game, that’s what Perfuma told me. And – gee – I really don’t want to mess this up. I’ve got to do a good job. For her. And she was really SUPER clear: the fruit has to hit the floor.’

‘That’s not right---’ Glimmer started. But there was a question in it, which germinated into a crafty pause. ‘You’ve just said the ball has to *knock* the coconut onto the ground, didn’t you?’

‘Yes? Yes.’

‘Then Meowmeow hasn’t done it either. Surprise *surprise…* she broke the rules. Her third ball – the one that actually *did* anything – hit the fucking *STAND*!’

‘But, gee, does that really matter? The coconut still fell off.’

‘YES, it *MATTERS*. We’re playing for real stakes here, Blackstone, so we have to get everything right. It’s only FAIR that she’s disqualified and *I* get the victory instead.’

‘I don’t know about that, your Ladyship.’

‘What *do* you know? Go and get your *girlfriend* and we can settle this once and for all, fête organiser to fête organiser.’

Reluctantly, Scorpia went. Anxiously, she and Perfs returned. A lot of hushed mumbling followed, coupled with increasingly frantic gesticulation. Meowmeow shrugged beautifully, and filled the time by filling me up a carafe of ice water and making sure I drank it. When I’d finished, she strongly recommended I get cracking on another. Well. I obeyed. Without question. She has that sort of impact, you know.

The gripes and grumbles continued just out of mental sight. “Really I don’t think it’s in the spirit…” said probably Perfuma. Scorpia came in with: “It’s about getting the coconut. And, gee, frig, wildcat *got* that coconut…” The third voice was having none of it. The foot-stamping “FOR FUCK’S SAKE” made that crystal, but tones more conciliatory followed hot on its heels. “Fine. Perfuma, what can I give you? What about this? If you enforce the proper rules and disqualify that *Alley-Cat*, then I *promise* I’ll go easy on that shitty cheesecake.”

Not for the last time in my life, room-temperature mascarpone had landed the deciding blow. The scores – Glimmer: Two. Catra: One.

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Chapter 38

Chapter Summary

'Yer knnoowww, *Catra*, I REAAALLLLYYY *hic* luuuurrrrrvvvee you - and this is the GIRLFRIENDS and egg races chapter... It's the right time to take our relationship to the next LEVEL!! Let's get MARRIED!'

'Are you suggesting a short engagement, sir?'

'Yes! *HIC* Let's get married NOW. B'fore we go on the quest... 'Cos it could be DANGEROUS... And I wanna fight with my *WIFE*!! I'll She-Ra myself sober in three, two, three and... For the Hon-*hic* of Greyskull!! Ah, there we are! Dry as a June afternoon, my love, and deadly serious about the old nuptials.'

'But how do we hold a wedding - in *here*?'

'With ease! With haste! With the documents Swiftie liberated on the way over! With... Mermista, can you come in here? We need a witness! We're getting married.'

'Like, right now? That's--- that's TWISTY. I approve.'

Chapter Notes

Content warnings apply for the below chapter only - Spoilers may be present in the warnings. This story does not include any of the four Archive Warnings topics, but does occasionally feature other topics that may require content notes.

Chapter 38 Content Warnings (CONTAINS SPOILERS):
Trauma response, oversharing – Narrated, present, experienced by narrator
Abusive parenting – Recalled, historic, experienced by narrator
Blackout – Narrated, present, brief, no injury occurs

Gender Dysphoria - Narrated, present, brief, experienced by narrator
Classism – Related, present, extensive, towards major character
Intent to cause physical injury, Tripping – Related, present, repeated, towards major character

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PART 12

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Fowl play. It's a clucking shame. This time, Glimmer really had over-egged the pudding. But you can't make an omelette without breaking those ovoid fellows, or so Lady Brightmoon squawked. The cock crowed thrice, you know. I stood. I gawped. She must have thought I was henpecked. Not so. I was spitting feathers – and there was egg on her face. Because Catra was the *fox* in the henhouse. The Countess had challenged her to a game of chicken. And the Countess had lost. All in the name of *l'oeuf*.

Culinary chaos marked the fourth skirmish. Date and mate stood on the start-line – thronged by six more combatants to their left and a half-dozen more, plus me, to the right – staring fresh hatred into one another's eyes. They jutted their weapons straight out ahead, waiting for their precious cargo. And so did I. Mine was wobbling around quite a bit, mind, while theirs were each surgically still.

That was a damned impressive feat. The more I looked at mine, the more it moved. Sweat beaded my brows. The tools of war are a mighty responsibility – and I took my duties deadly seriously. Another breath swelled the de l'Horde lungs, my heart oozed unctuous slow, and I did my best Perfuma. *I hate… Cacti? Cacutuses? Cactis? Hmm. I hate spiky plants*. Good, good. It was working. My touch lightened and my wrist freed up. I was finally worthy of my weapon. Sir Adora deserved to take up the wooden spoon.

Our fellow fighters thronged the start line. Some put a foot over, others pushed at the racers around them. And then the mind games commenced. "You're a poo-poo head!" said one. "Nuh-uh!! I'm rubber and you're GLUE---" another crackled. "Last one there's a rotten egg!!" roared a third. Now that was a popular battle-cry. Spoons thronged the skies as these war-hardened adversaries cackled in the face of fate. "YOU'RE A POO-POO HEAD!" "NO! **YOU'RE** A POO-POO HEAD *TIMES A HUNDRED!*" "YEAH, WELL, YOU'RE A POO-POO TIMES ***INFINITY!!***"

Truly. They were warrior poets, through and through. But we three rose above it – and not just because I was over twice their height. Heck, even Glimmer towered a good foot above all but the most strapping of these strangers. We stood in silence. Catra exuded confidence. Glimmer prickled primogeniture. And I was sweating sodding bullets.

At the Coconut Shy, I'd pouted something proper about not having a go myself, so both Ladies had positively insisted I muck in with game four. That was terribly kind of them… and really not too smart of me. I heaved. I reeled. My snot slid off to a start a new career as a specialty liqueur.

‘Are you feeling alright?’

That wasn’t Catra – or Glimmer either. Those two were still busy trading squints. Straining with formality, like a colander in a bow tie, the caring question fell from lips I can’t say I’d seen before. They belonged to a face starched impassive but bearing the legacy of what must have been one corker of a fight. A similar energy percolated the rest of the woman in front of me, who stood flagpole upright in a pair of whitest-white jodhpurs, riding boots more reflective than the bathroom mirror – plus maybe twice as smooth as the features I see there every morning – and a consciously outdated tailcoat in midnight blue.

‘Gosh, you look dashing.’

‘Pardon?’

‘No, no, not like that! A thousand apologies, truly. I’m sure you don’t want an unsolicited opinion on your appearance. And… and… I didn’t mean it like *that*. I *have* a girlfriend, you know. Well. A date. But I’ll be damned if she’s not putting out signal upon sign upon synchronised swimming routine for more! She’s entering this race with me, truth be told, so do accept my gratitudes by the bundle for setting up this little bit of our situation. I REALLY appreciate all the tireless work you’ve put in behind the scenes.’

‘I see. Then congratulations are in order, sir. Congratulations. Speaking frankly, my Ladyship has long desired your hand, so I’m very relieved to see this development. I look forward to serving you.’

Primly proper, she bowed, deeply, her ancient threads shimmering the shades of the deepest sea and furthest sky. What a colour! When a Black Tie invitation hits the doormat, I always say, only the terminally unimaginative take the thing at its word. I love a bottle green or a dusky purple or a deep, deep red velvet – note to self, encourage Catra to let me buy her suit in deep, deep red velvet – yet not one of the above exhibits the supine classicism of midnight blue, which benefits too from being the only hue explicitly and always allowed by society rulebooks.

It’s the colour I wore the first time I escorted Glimmer out. And to every swish *soiree* we’d attended since. In fact, there can’t be a woman in the world who better knows how true I stay to blue. And – for her part – she goes out of her way, every time I wear it, to say how good it looks on me. If she had it her way, Glimmer once told me, she’d have hunky women in midnight blue at her beck and call twenty-four hours a day.

‘Wait. *What?!*’

I stared at the lady opposite in utter abstraction. She was tall. Strong shoulders. Clearly worked out. And she was wearing finely-tailored midnight blue. In less than time it takes to split a second, she’d spotted my confusion and replied in kind:

‘*Wait*. What?!’

‘Did you think I was *dating* Glimmer?’

‘I couldn’t say.’

‘Does Glimmer want to date *me*?’

‘I shouldn’t say.’

‘She wants to get *married*?’

‘I oughtn’t say.’

‘But you *did* say. *And* you think that *I’m* the chap she dreams of marching down the aisle. So. Who do you think I am?’

‘Here’s your egg. Good day, sir.’

She dropped the ovoid on my spoon and hastened away down the line, doing everything in her power to avoid looking back. Catra received an egg. Glimmer insisted on picking her own, straight from the basket, guided by the mystery woman, who bowed and

whispered “Your Ladyship” to her at least twice. My suspicions were firming up nicely…

If only my swishing, sloshing yolk and its attendant albumen could do the same. The protein partners danced the tango around their shell, rolling egg and spoon and arm around in writhing fury. Bucking and hopping, dancing from brogue to brogue, I was putting on quite the show, or so the spectators seemed to think. They whooped and cheered in their multitudes. Faces lined the course from end to end: a veritable swarm of smiles, extending as far as the eye could see, provided said peeper didn’t want to look further than about a hundred feet. “She-Ra! She-RA!” went the chant. “SHE-RA!!”

I could definitely get used to that! With a flick of my billowing, bleach-hued locks and the squared-off set of my chest, Sir Adora de l’Horde threw off the tedious weeds of a never-really-loved aristocrat and put on the looks of a gosh-darned hero. The chanting intensified. Only two or three of the throng hadn’t got the message. They were shouting “Go Timmy! Go Timmy!” and “You can do it Alice!” respectively. Dashed odd, that! Not wanting that lot to labour in vain, I thought I’d spare them the effort with a quick clarification.

‘Excuse me,’ I gleamed. ‘Hi! I’m not called Timothy *or* Alice. It’s Adora, actually. Sir Adora de la She-Ra, pronouns… currently under construction.’

The fellows stared blanky back.

‘We’re not cheering for you.’

‘So you’re quite evil, is that what you’re saying? You stand against truth and light and so forth? Pardon the inquisition: I wouldn’t want to draw my blade unnecessarily! Makes a damned mess, you know.’

And now they looked horrified.

‘Timmy is our *son*. Alice is our *niece*. We just wanted to support the kids.’

‘And you do that by *encouraging* them? With *positive* messages? I’ve never come across that before…’

‘Beg pardon? How is that any of your business?’

‘I’m dreadfully sorry, of course it isn’t. And I’m sure you’re doing a smashing job. Please do accept my heartfelt apologies. It’s just--- I didn’t know a family could be that way… That’s *amazing*. You’re amazing. Really. That’s--- that’s inspirational.’

‘Are you okay?’

‘Why do people keep asking that? I’m fine! I’m *fine*. It’s just--- I got a bit squiffy… and my friend doesn’t like my date… and I think I just learned *why* my friend doesn’t like my date… and it really seems like maybe my family definitely never loved me. Oh. Look at that. I’m crying. Again. Maybe I’m not alright. Well. Sorry, sorry. I’ll go back to being the She-Ra now. Stiff upper lip and all! Good luck to Alice and Timmy!’

‘*Sir*,’ came the voice as I stepped back. ‘I’m sorry.’

‘Catra, why?! You didn’t abandon me to loveless boarding schools for my entire childhood. You didn’t get my bunkmate moved to a different dorm because I got caught kissing her. You---’

‘But I have failed you. I let myself be distracted by the games, when my focus should have been you.’

‘I shouldn’t have spilled my guts to those strangers, should I? It’s all too, too much today. The colours, the people, the *emotions*. Everything is SO loud. And I can’t get away from it.’

‘Yes, you can. Say the word, sir, and we go. Immediately.’

‘Leave where? The fête?’

‘Shugborough Hall. The country, if that’s what you need.’

‘But what about Glimmer’s competition – or my apology? I came here to set things straight with the Duchess. I can’t show my face around Auntie before I do. I just can’t!’

‘I’m not suggesting you do.’

I reeled – and I don’t think it was down to the liqueur. Not this time. My so-called “friend” conceivably harboured romantic feelings for me. Not one of my relatives really cared who I was or tried to love me. I was gay. I needed a flat chest more than my lungs crave air. I ached for folk to always call me “sir” and sometimes call me “they”. I was the She-Ra. I was in *love*. And now… now… Catra was trying to tell me that a knight isn’t beholden to their duty.

I dropped my egg.

It landed on Catra’s shoe. The yolk broke and oozed through the intricate leatherwork, but my Lady didn’t flinch.

‘Adora, you’re suffering. I won’t stand by and let you get hurt. I have to protect you, as your gentlewoman… and as your girlfriend.’

BANG.

That was it. I'd finally had an aneurysm. The most beautiful woman in the world wanted to go steady with me. The panic. The relief. The *elation*. My blood pressure shot so high that it might never come down, straining at my vessels until my brains finally exploded into chunky goop. I blacked out.

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I awoke on the floor – in the arms of *my girlfriend!!* The future Mrs. Meowmeow-de l'Horde cupped my nape and stroked my spine with a selkie's allure and a Grecian goddess' surety, her thumb tracing me out in gossamer silk. Her lips were parted – just – with infinite care, and the way she looked saw all of me, inside and out.

'*Adora*,' she said. 'Your pulse is normal. And I love you.'

As condensed milk is to the scourge and the lie and the basely Machiavellian evil that we call skimmed, so the feeling that flooded me now was to joy. It fizzed away at the substance of my legs, bunched itself all together in my thighs, then shot quicksilver chevrons across my mid-riff, searing so deep and true that it boiled the marrow in my bones. I almost floated off the floor. My spirit ached to sing and dance and proclaim to all the world: *Catra Applesauce Meowmeow – I adore you!*

My treacherous teeth and turncoat palate had other ideas. While my mind raced to put these thoughts into words, quite unaffected by what was actually nothing more than a substantial but very amenable shock, the de l'Horde mouth galloped through the
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stable door with nary a backwards glance for the hay it left behind. The love of my life held me; I beheld her. We leant closer, her heat sparking against me, and the words came bright and clear.

'What was that noise? Golly gee! Don't say it was the starting pistol? Catra – you've got to get running!'

'Sir?'

'The race, the race! An Etherian doesn't welch on her responsibilities. You stood on the start line, so you've got to finish. Run! Run now.'

'No?!'

'Catra, please. It's important. I promise I'm alright, and you can come right back after.'

'This really matters to you?'

'Absolutely.'

She looked utterly torn, and more than a little mournful. Shrugging out of her jacket, she folded its woollen checks beneath

my head and kissed my crown, just once. With that, she was off. Glimmer had a halting and faltering 30-yard lead, but she hadn't reckoned on the skills of a valet extraordinaire. Lady Meowmeow swept forth, smooth and sure as a sixteen-cylinder Cadillac, the egg never so much as rocking. She closed half the gap; she slammed shut the rest. Glimmer glanced over, agog. As far as I could tell from the far-off floor, my *girlfriend* winked back at her.

Countess Dryl didn't find that too droll. A barge became a lunge, which morphed itself hideously into an outstretched leg. Lady Meowmeow stumbled, twirling and corkscrewing through the air. A thousand breaths held. Perhaps that's an exaggeration, but it must have been at least a dozen, not to mention the spattering of indignant tuts and *Well-I-nevers*. These spectators were on the right side of history. My own lungs prickled, praying, waiting – for Catra to land square on her feet.

Her shoes hit the ground in perfect synchronicity but the only adult opposition was far, far ahead. Catra looked back, saw me, I fancy, cheering her as hard as my tonsils let me, then swelled up with a fresh and fiery purpose.

'That's my girlfriend!' I cheered. 'That's my *girlfriend*!!'

Tweety birds spun round my head from the effort but she had to know: I was so damned proud of her! Whether it was our love or Glimmer's treachery that spurred her, Meowmeow dug deep. Ten yards between them. Five. Three. A blink.

You're squashed, glitterbug! Catra drew alongside – again. Glimmer tried to trip her – again. And there the similarities

stopped. Just as Lady Brightmoon zagged left, my *GIRLFRIEND* slammed on the stoppers, so fast I'm sure she'd seen it coming. The look on Glimmer's face was a picture… I assume. She-Raic sight is good, but it's not *read nuanced expressions from 80 feet away* good. Glimmer grabbed against the air, and her egg plummeted. She lunged after, scooped it off the floor and kept running, the egg balled up in her fist.

Now, I'm no great eggs-pert in how breakfast looks before it's breakfast, but something stunk. The Brightmoon heir threw herself into a sprint, desperate to salvage the win, only she was too late! Lady Meowmeow was half a shadow from the finish line. Glimmer screamed "FUCK!" – again, I assume, but that's a pretty safe guess – then sent the egg flying. It streamed past Catra and landed at Ms. Midnight Blue's feet. Whole.

'Please applaud, Great Haywood village fête. We have a winner.'

'I win! Ohmigosh! I *fucking* win!!'

Lady Brightmoon bopped jubilantly, up and down, her boots clattering across the grass… and onto her egg. Which still remained absolutely entire and unruffled and ovoid. Ms. Midnight Blue flinched. A rather screwy state of affairs, I'd say. Dusting myself down, I decided this all merited closer examination. The hand wedged into Meowmeow's hip said disgruntlement, and the crowd roared quite a bit worse. "Cheat!" crackled against "Foul play!" – and even the sweetest cheers for little Timmy and Alice got swamped beneath the exacting enunciation of a more familiar name.

‘Glimm-AH!!’

Where the Duchess had flown in from, I really couldn’t say. She could damn well go back there for all I cared. Every Brightmoon could, even the one with the nice dog and unfettered access to horseys. I really was *that* cross. Whilst I pawed at Catra’s jacket, fretful and inexpert, grinding in much more dirt than I set free, the Shugborough matriarch towered over Ms. Midnight Blue, glitterbug and my ***GIRLFRIEND*** with statuesque authority.

‘Young lady – I demand to know *what* is going on *here*! *Now*!’

‘Muuuuummmm… For fuc--- *goodness*’ sake… Can’t I have one lousy minute to enjoy *anything*?’

‘Not until you answer my question, madam. No.’

‘Is it really that hard to work out, *MOTHER*? I won the egg-and-spoon race. And Dory’s *valet* is saying I *cheated*!! It’s an offence to my honour--- to the *family* name.’

Angella All-The-Other-Names Brightmoon twirled a very angry *pasodoble* towards my sweet amore, a bull in search of a red rag. My trot shifted into a headlong gallop. How turgid! How tremendously, terribly unfair! This whole get-up had been rigged from the start, with entrapment for pudding. The pledge of the She-Ra coursed through me – but the Duchess was *just* too quick with her inquisition. I couldn’t get there quite in time. Drawing

herself up to full height – a willow tree in a hurricane – she spat words like her daughter sprayed bullets.

'Is this true… *you*?'

Catra chewed her cheek raw – and said nothing.

'*IS IT TRUE?* I am *speaking* to you. *Answer me!*'

Silence. Stillness. Her Grace flared her stately nostrils. I sprinted. Ms. Midnight Blue twitched, checked over Catra, peered portentously towards Glimmer – wedding planning, perhaps – then twitched again. She looked like a lemon eating itself as I brushed past, hand on my pommel, planting myself between Angella and my beloved.

'NO! I roared. 'Hear me out, Duchess Brightmoon. Catra won the race fair and square – and she's my ***GIRLFRIEND***.'

'How typically de l'Horde,' the Duchess snarled. 'An *embarrassment*. Whyever did my daughter make a friend like *you*? You make her a laughingstock, you attack my husband, and now you *DARE* to intervene in my affairs. Are you *really* going to accuse the Brightmoon heir, for the sake of a *servant girl*?! You are a stain on your House, Adora de l'Horde, and you are no longer welcome at---'

‘Your Grace, wait!’ Sometimes salvation comes from unlikely corners: other times it pours forth from a well-dressed woman hopping like she needs the water closet. ‘What Adora says is true. Her Ladyship did not win the race. She cheated. The de l’Horde staff is the victor – and she raised no complaint.’

‘*Butler Juliet, WHAT THE* ACTUAL *FUCK*??!’

Glimmer was not taking this well. My own mandible hung wide open, while I processed that Ms. Midnight Blueliet was the Brightmoon butler, had a name, knew mine, and had interceded on the side of fair play, with seemingly complete disregard for her own personal safety. Watching her fight a very hungry tigress would have been less shocking, and definitely less risky.

‘That’s *Major* Juliet, madam. Call me sentimental, but I will not let good women suffer for what they did not do.’

‘*Tha*-nk you, Butler,’ said the ice-chilled acid that had once been the Duchess. ‘*Glimm-AH!!!*’

‘Lady Glimmer,’ burred Major Juliet, cutting a defensive line around her charge and whisking her away, ‘you are *extremely* late for your next meeting.’

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Chapter 39

Chapter Summary

'If anyone here should have any, like, objection--- Nah! We can skip that bit. Glimmer isn't here, amirite?! Though she is in Chapter 39 - objecting to a LOT - and WOW that gets BIG. Volume-ending big. There's your story info, so let's totally do this wedding... Catra Applesauce "Apfelmus" Meowmeow, do you take Sir Adora de l'Horde to be your fuck-the-lawfully wedded... spouse? wife?'

'Mermista, you brilliant eel! Spousewife! That's exactly what I am!'

'M'kay. To be your spousewife?'

'Of course I do! I love them utterly.'

'And do you, Adora, take Catra----'

'Yes! Yes yes yes yes! I'll marry her today, I'll marry her tomorrow, I'll marry her a hundred-thousand times if she'll have me... She makes my life so bally wonderful. I'm positively fizzing to make her my WIFE!'

'Sweet. By the power vested in me by this magical horse and his stolen paperwork, I now pronounce you Ms. and Sir---'

'Gosh, we didn't talk about this bit. Meow-Ra? De la Meowmeow? Or I might just take your last name, Catra, if that's alright by you?'

'We'll decide later, sir. Kiss me - we're married!'

Chapter Notes

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any of the four Archive Warnings topics, but does occasionally feature other topics that may require content notes.

Chapter 39 Content Warnings (CONTAINS SPOILERS):
Possessiveness – related, present, extensive, towards narrator
Objectification – related, present, extensive, physical and personal, towards narrator
Manipulation – related and narrated, present, extensive, towards narrator and major character
False accusations – related, present, extensive, towards major character
Relationship interference – related and narrated, present, extensive, towards narrator and major character
Forced separation of romantic relationship – related and narrated, present, extensive, towards narrator and major character
Exile – related and narrated, present, inflicted on major character, impacts narrator
Physical violence, swords – related, historic, brief, by narrator (no lasting injury occurs)
Physical violence, biting – related, historic, brief
Physical violence, character winded – narrated, present, brief, by narrator (no lasting injury occurs)
Threat of accidental physical injury, arrow – narrated, present, by narrator (no violent intent, no injury occurs)
Threat of physical violence, whip, sword, hand – narrated and related, present, towards and by narrator, towards major character
Classism – related, present, extensive, towards major character
Weaponisation of privilege – related, present, extensive, towards major character, includes weaponisation of influence over police force and legal system
Cultural appropriation – related, present, brief
Vehicle accident, car – related, historic, brief

See the end of the chapter for more notes

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PART 13

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Whether it was the boldness of the butler who'd discovered she really did have a heart, or Micah making an appearance to diffuse his wife at exactly the right moment, or, most likely, that Catra and I are both pretty good at running, we made it to the final event unscathed. The scores were level between our players: two-two. Winner would take all, whatever it was that Catra and Glimmer had agreed to played for.

'What are you two competing over, exactly?' I asked my *girlfriend*. Catra was now my *GIRLFRIEND*. We were *girlfriends* – i.e. Sapphics, and, more specifically, in our case, Lesbians, bound by a common fancy and a strong desire to take things further. There was no knowing how far we'd go. It was terribly exciting. Inestimably jocund, even. Thus, I'll confess I was struggling somewhat to care about anything else. Still. Of all the questions I hadn't been asking, the one I'd just voiced seemed like the most important.

Hard-boiled chicken-gifts don't appear out of nowhere: and I wanted answers. If Glimmer's games really *had* been spontaneous, then why did my egg splutter asunder and hers merely thud? In an illusion of clumsiness, I'd knocked Catra's cargo off her spoon whilst we beat our hasty retreat – she'd encouraged my detectively wiles the day before, hadn't she? –

and watched with grim certainty as it too went splat. Lady Brightmoon was up to something, and I needed to know what Lady Meowmeow had seen.

‘I really don’t know, sir. She refuses to say.’

‘Well. Keep an eye out, will you?’

‘Remember, Adora, I’m only here so long as you want to be. Tap my shoulder twice and we can pack up, leave, and never come back. You don’t even have to say anything, sir.’

‘But I have to stay – for my duty. The chivalric knight---’

‘I will never need you to be any kind of hero. I want you to be yourself, true, free and safe.’

‘That’s it?’

‘That’s it.’

‘First, can we find out what Glimmer’s up to? Play the game, please, but be careful.’

‘As you wish, sir.’

She shivered almost imperceptibly as she walked off to the activity table. In a life riddled Swiss cheese-like with errors, not going with her, right there and right then, ranks as the worst of the lot. I’d rue this moment so, so dearly in the days to come, conjuring up its every element and imagining what I might have done differently. The straw bale poking my rump screamed: “Tell her you love her too!” The horsefly worrying at my wrist murmured: “Manure-for-brains nincompoop! Sweep her up in your arms and run!” And the wind cried “Catra…”

‘Okay, folks!’ announced my erstwhile Oxford chum. ‘Welcome to Bow’s Bow-tiful Bow-n’-Arrow Bow-stravaganza… with Bows!’

He was dressed like Robin Hood – or perhaps Piers Gaveston. He was in his element, hoary leather quiver bouncing off his hip.

The archers took their lanes. Glimmer leaned over to Catra and whispered something so repellent that Catra recoiled as if her hand had just been jammed into a blast furnace. Bowregard, eminent professional and amateur theatrical, breezed on by like nothing had happened.

‘Back in the olden days, every man of fighting age had to practice with their longbow every single week. It was important stuff, archers! The Prime even banned tennis and football so all of Etheria could really focus on their sharpshooting. Every Sunday, up and down the country, village greens would fill up with archers

carrying bows the height of a full-grown adult – the Etherian longbow---'

'*Acccttttuaalllyyy*… I think you mean the *Welsh* longbow.'

'Entrapta?!' I gasped. One presumed the Etheria-despising boilersuit was they. 'Why are you here? What happened to Fury?'

'She and I had… err… a *falling out* – so I thought I'd spend some time with much more *primitive* tech. Welsh bowmen had their weapons under SOOOO much tension that most modern athletes wouldn't know how to draw the string back – yet they still fired TWELVE rounds a minute… Isn't that *FASCINATING?!*'

'That's right!' Bow enthused in the tone of voice most commonly reserved for Sunday school teachers. 'Which is why we're not using longbows today!'

'*Awwwhhh!!* I bet the *She-Ra* could fire one!'

Bowregard broke character, ever so briefly, to give me a *look* that cocked his head towards Glimmer and waggled both eyebrows in asynchronicity.

'She saw me fight her dad, Bow. I think the secret's out.'

‘*Ohmigosh*, Bow-tie. Ha-ha-ha! I can*not* tell you how much Dory’s new muscles just Fuck. Me. Up. *Hmmmmmmmm-ummmm*!!’

‘Alright, thank you Glimmer.’ Though still adopting the air of a career educator, Bow slipped it sideways a rung or five. Ecumenical guidance was out; the lagging desperation of a last-minute substitute was in. ‘Today we’re going to be using *short* bows, which are called that because they’re only between 36 and 60 inches tall. So they’re short, okay? Which means they’re better at hitting close-up targets like these…’

Bow stepped back with a flourish, to reveal a paper archery target pinned to two bales of hay. This was not a surprise. All the other archery lanes had the same and he hadn’t obscured those.

‘Ta-da!’

Entrapta clapped. Out of politeness, I think, Catra joined in.

‘Come *ON* already,’ sighed Glimmer. ‘We *don’t* have all day to fuck around here, Bow… Just give us our bows, so I can beat Meowmeow and pick up my prize and be *done* with this…’

‘Not so fast. Do we have any left-handers here? I know you are, Catra--- *Wait! Oh no!* I’m sorry. I didn’t mean--- Adora told me your name… your *first* name… and I--- Can *I* call you Catra?’

‘It’s what my friends call me.’

‘Okay. Sorry. Okay. So, *Catra*, you’ll need a left-handed bow. Does anyone else? And, Adora? Are you playing?’

Ever since ancient Scythia, short bows have been the choicest cavalry weapon out there, which meant they had a long history with horses, which maybe suggested that learning how to swing one could stomp me one step closer to some real-life horsey experience of my own. Naturally, therefore, I sallied forth, only for Glimmer to ‘helpfully’ guide me to her right, ensuring she stood between me and the woman I love. *Apt*, I think they call that.

‘Okay, everyone!’ Bow had some of his pluck back, now his pupils were all busy grappling with our equipment. ‘Time for the rules. You have five arrows: you’re aiming to score the most points you can by firing them into the target in front of you. Sorry they’re so low, guys… Perfuma made me set them up for the kids. There are five coloured rings to hit and their value goes up in twos – so white scores one, black scores three, all the way to gold scoring nine. Cut the line between two colours and you get the higher score. Miss the target and you score zero. Hit someone *else’s* target and you still score zero – I really didn’t think I’d have to say that, but ever since Alice bit Timmy…’

Hmm. Maybe I hadn’t missed out. Maybe positive parent-guardianship wasn’t such a swell thing after all.

‘Anyway. Five colours, five arrows, bullseyes aren’t worth anything extra! Have fun, archers! May the best shot win!’

‘And winner takes all, doesn’t she *Alley-Cat*?’

Catra looked away.

And we were off. What Entrapta, Major Juliet and I achieved doesn’t really matter, not in this context, but Dickens to decorum! I got two shots in the gold! Though the other three hit black, grass, and almost-but-not-quite-Bow’s-shoulder, raw potential is just that. Raw. Glimmer’s Butler still beat me, mind, with an efficient spread of inner blues. I got the distinct feeling she’d done this before.

Her boss was a tad more scattergun. A miss, a scream, a left-skewed red, a right-leaning gold, a black. By my count, that was 19 points, two outside my score and within eminent reach of the ultimate gentlewoman. Catra dropped into a practised A-frame, weight spread evenly between her feet, lifted the bow with one straight, smooth, unwavering arm, and loosed five arrows… into the black ring. They clustered perfectly together, none more than half an inch from the next, yet not one even threatening to land in the next zone.

‘I WIN!! I WIN! FUCK YEAH! SUCK IT, *VALET!*’

Glimmer celebrated, almost entirely to herself. That wasn’t enough for her.

‘Dory, come party with me! I’ll tell you what we *wooooonnnnn*…’

She grabbed my wrist and I pulled away. The Countess tutted and teased and tried to jerk me back – as if *that* was going to work when I was in She-Ra mode – but I only had words for my gentlewoman.

‘I don’t understand. Catra, didn’t you hear Bow’s announcement? The inner rings are worth more.’

‘I know.’

‘But you didn’t hit them?! Why?’

‘Her Ladyship told me what we were playing for, sir, and I will have no part in it. I refuse to win that prize that way.’

‘Well!’ I palpitated with curiosity. ‘What is it?’

‘Your heart.’

‘We should go.’

‘Right away, sir.’

Our hands clamped together, and I’d swear our pulses aligned, squeezing fervently as one. That’s the funny thing about the games that Glimmer plays, I reflected, looking back on figurative myriad Oxfordian and post-collegiate engagements. The only way to win them is not to play. Turns out the bookish kid that passes every lunch hour in the library – every class has one, you know, and I’m informed Catra filled the role during her own schooling – had the jump on us all. Disengage from the mainstream throng and live life on your own terms, that’s the way!

The afternoon sky glittered sapphire; her feet and mine tread in time; we walked around Glimmer and marched off, off towards the sunny uplands, then our packing, then our *lives*. She said: “I love you”. I said: “I love you” back. We kissed, then I nestled my lips in the warmth of her cheek.

‘And,’ I murmured into her warmth, ‘I promise I’ll buy you a replacement wardrobe. I’ve ruined enough of your finery – and you were *so* fine in it. No expense spared.’

She laughed from her eyes, crinkling, dimpled thrice up her cheeks.

I adored her. And my work here was done. Shugborough could busy itself fading into the distance, and I wouldn’t even start to miss it. Bowregard was safe from his schoolish folks. Scorpy and Lady P were at the start of a beautiful adventure. I was the She-Ra. As for the Duchess, I’d done what I could, which is all any

mere mortal can hope when it comes to impassive matriarchs and their weaponised aristocracy. All that was left was protecting Catra. And that's what I intended to, starting by getting her far, far, *far* away fr---

'*Halt!* Stop RIGHT there, darlings.'

Catra squeezed my hand. Twice. We got ready to run. But I paused – just long enough for our latest acquaintance to cut in ahead. They twirled in front of us, plucked a riding crop from their boot and slapped it hard against an open wrist. My heart shivered… in a way that, um, called for later examination. Our uninvited third grinned a coquette smile. Their chin flicked right, just to make space for all their teeth.

They were the very model of a modern huntress – a debonair Diana. Their hair tousled, their cheek ruddied, their jods positively hpurred. They were our audience; they were our performance. Arcing well-plucked brows, the fox-flattener drank us both in from the top of ours heads to the tip of our--- well, *Catra's* tail. Emotion inflected across their features, bouncing the kind of nuances I can't hope to report, before snapping back to that unnerving smile. Memories started to stir.

If only they'd Hawthorne-strained into the mental cocktail glass a touch quicker, all of this next bit might have been avoided. Alas. I never have been too terribly quick on my feet when crisis arrives. Give me just three minutes to work it all out and I could have played it right: deck this supercilious bastard; scoop up Catra; cheese it for the nearest train station; *never* look back. Well. Hindsight makes heroes of us all, even those of us who are

technically legendary figures already. As I said, alack and all the rest…

Instead, I froze. This was not in the plan. Not that there *was* much plan. I really hadn't gotten any further than taking Catra by the hand, taking all our stuff back home to the flat and then… finally… not to put too fine a point on it… *taking* Catra. If you catch my meaning. If you don't, well, that's quite alright. I'll spell it out:

Me and Lady Meowmeow were plotting a jolly good rump sesh – hour upon hour of smashingly invigorating Lesbian intercourse. What the swishing, snapping leather good now caressing our cheeks had to do with that, I absolutely could – or rather *hoped to* – say. But having it in the hands of a portentous stranger? I don't think that really jammed my scone…

Hide kissed our cheeks, stopping us dead. The hunter had our attention. And they loved it. Yet more teeth showed, shouting gothic doom, like a great white shark, all dolled up in Whitby jet, visiting an ossuary. Their spare hand slid out of their pocket, exposing blood-red nails sharp enough to pierce our throats. Convulsion gripped me. Catra squeezed, again. Her feet trod into a weary, wary stance, ready to fight. The hunter's top lip twitched as they clamped their fingers hard into their lapel.

'What *do* you two *THINK* of my OUTFIT? Do you know, darlings? I *believe* the jacket… is… CASHMERE.'

Their teeth almost bisected their head. They pivoted around, twirling their left flank into view with a sick flourish. Its loose-woven thread wore a mark, a blur---

'Run,' Catra hissed. 'I'll catch up. I promise. If you love me, Adora, run.'

---a footprint.

No. No, no. No no no no no no no…

I bolted. The hunter fizzed green-speckled void, cackling. They grew thinner, angrier, two feet taller, and jagged straight into my path. Their tail whipped round and I fell headfirst – into the arms of Marquioness Double Trubel-Brightmoon.

'Behold, kittens, peripeteia ARRIVES! Didn't I PROMISE it would? My darling Adora, you're not going anywhere.'

'What---' I choked. 'How did--- Why are you doing this to us?'

'SURPRISED, darling? You *reeeeaaallllyyy* shouldn't be. I've *nevvvveeerrrr* cared for VALET parking.'

‘It’s me you want,’ Catra measured out, colder than an Arctic wind. ‘Let Adora go, then we can talk.’

‘Ah! Ah-ha! Bless you, Alley-Cat, you *reeeaallllyyy* DON’T change… Look around, kitten, you’re NOT in *any* position to negotiate. The village people were *very* helpful when a “detective” went door to door for their statements. Several witnesses saw a be-suited woman *convey* my Bentley into the post office, and that’s several more than you needed if you want to get away with it. Whom, I wonder, might *I* have met yesterday who answers that description, and JUST sooooo *happened* to be wearing two parts of a deep red, Scottish cashmere three-piece, kitten?’

‘I thought you didn’t care for suiting, liege.’

‘I *DON’T*. But I care *very* much about my racer and how *I* should be DRIVING it to FRANCE right now, *not* trying to pull it out of a wall.’

‘Le Mans!’ I gasped. ‘If it’s a car you need, take mine: Frazer-Nash SuperSports. 1928. She’s a sporty girl when you give her a chance. Handles like a dream.’

‘Oh, Adora, they WILL write *books* on you. Do you *really* think some one-point-five litre roadster can replace my Blower? At the highlight of the international racing calendar? Where *I* am going to drive FAST and quaff champagne with wealthy hot people? *Darling*… Noooooooo.’

‘Then I’m warning you. I tried being nice.’

‘So did I, once. It did NOT suit me.’

A swift elbow to the ribs and I had Trubel-Brightmoon winded, just long enough to get a grip on Ms. Floaty-C.

‘Oh, Adora, darling, PUT it away.’

‘No. I’m leaving here. With my girlfriend. **Now**.’

‘GIRLFRIEND? Con-grat-u-l*ations*, kittens. But I *REALLY* wouldn’t. Go now and you’ll be walking Alley-Cat here *straight* into a gaol cell.’

‘She didn’t do it.’ My blood was fire in my mouth. ‘You don’t have a scrap of concrete proof.’

‘Ah-ha-ha-*ha*-ha-ha… How ADORABLE! I have enough, your Lordship. She isn’t LIKE you or me. Darling, the case rests on reasonable doubt, so *who* is the jury going to believe? The wronged Marquioness, or the *tragic* commoner with prior offences?’

‘Then we’ll go, won’t we Catra? To Berlin.’

‘Ding! Wrong AGAIN. Split for Germany and I provide eye-witness testimony that she assaulted the Count. We heard it for ourselves, remember? And *I* have a veerrrryy distinguished pair of ears on my side. Speaking of which, darlings, MY work is done---’

‘Shit. Cuz. What is it? What couldn’t wait?’

‘I caught THESE two beating a hasty exit, which is SUCH a shame, when you have soooooooo much still planned for your “buddy” Adora.’

‘Dory? *No*. Wha---? No!’ Glimmer tremored my way, studiously ignoring Catra. ‘Don’t you *want* to spend the summer together… *please*?? *Why* would you go?’

‘My moment!’ Double-Trubel drew themselves up to full height. I wanted to mince them where they stood. I wanted to vomit. ‘Sparkles – brace yourself. For your delight and *delectation*, I PRESENT the woman who… stole… *my*… Bentley.’

‘Oh! Ohhhhh! I KNEW IT! *I **FUCKING** KNEW IT!! Cuz was RIGHT.* Fuck you, Meowmeow, you greasy anaemic SHIT. Once a thief, always a thief--- and a *filthy LIAR*--- and--- and--- a *homewrecking **CUNT**!!* Guess it caught up with you in the end, huh? I won, remember?! And now I’m claiming my prize. Whatever-the-fuck-you’re-called *VALET*, I’m officially dismissing you from Dory’s service, effective *immediately*. And you are *SO* fucking *banned* from the entire Brightmoon estate, plus anywhere

else we happen to be, plus anybody we happen to know. Which means Adora. *FOREVER*.'

'What do propose to do, madam, if your words have no power over me?'

The claws were out. Literally.

'If you don't leave, I'm calling the police. *They'll* do what I say. How's *that* going to go for you?'

'You can't stop us, Glimmer.'

'What *US*?!'

'Catra is my **girlfriend**, Glimmer. You won't stop us seeing each other.'

'She is *USING* you, Dory! She's just after your money. You belong *here*, where it's safe!'

'**Catra is my girlfriend.**'

‘Catra is a *thief*--- a *violent* recidivist criminal. If she drags you aware from here, I’m calling it in as a kidnapping, no matter what you say. Why can’t you *SEE*? She’s put you under her spell. I am NOT fucking well going to let *her* hurt you!!’

‘Adora is my girlfriend, madam. I *never* hurt the Sapphics I date.’

‘*Get off my FUCKING property, VALET*.’

‘I refuse.’

‘Then you go to jail, for kidnap and theft and leaving the scene of an accident and destroying public property and anything else my *lawyer* can work out. For a *very* fucking *loooonnnggg* time.’

‘And if we go?’ I seethed, itching for the fight. ‘If I go with her? You can’t stop us.’

‘I can answer that one, sweetie,’ Double Trubel caramel-smiled. ‘Should you two be RECKLESS enough to leave together---’ They warped into their Catra approximation. ‘---then tomorrow a hundred people get to watch Valet Meowmeow perform a MUCH more public and *MUCH* more heinous crime. I DO relish the chance to play the VILLAIN, kittens!’

‘Butler Juliet!’ Glimmer barked. ‘Escort the valet onto the next train. We’ll send her things on. Maybe.’

Ms. Midnight Blue wrenched Catra's arm. She pulsed forwards, tears in her eyes, choking a whisper so hoarse and quiet only I could barely make it out.

==

'Adora, don't give up. Trust me, please, if you can. This isn't over. I *lo*---'

I kissed her with my heart and my mind and my soul, holding onto her cheeks so tight, even as they fell away into the Major's clutches.

'I love you too.'

I hope she heard me. And then she was gone.

I would have fallen to my knees. I would have wept and wept and wept, until tears and time lost all their meaning. I would have slain the Brightmoons where they stood. I would have done all of this, if Glimmer hadn't scooped me up, my sword in her sleight-of-hand, and cheerfully informed me:

'There! All done! She was a piece of *shit*, Dory. Don't you feel *so* much better? We're going to go and get you an ice cream – my treat! – and then, *ohmigosh*, we're going to have the *BEST* summer. Together.'

As I was walked back down the hill, Double-Trubel purred to themself.

‘And… SCENE!’

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END OF VOLUME 2

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Chapter End Notes

Hey, readers. That's the end of Volume 2... But Volume 3 starts next time with Chapter 40 - and it's the final Volume of the main plot! (After that there's a happy-ever-after Coda, because trans characters and lesbian characters deserve SO many more of those.)

Will Catra make it back? Does their love endure? Is Swift Wind a real, tangible, three-dimensional horse? All of these questions... have already been answered in the chapter intros. But Volume 3 does more (or will do, once I've written it...). It's big. It's dramatic. Mermista finally actually appears in the main story. It features substantial historical queer research I would LOVE to bore you about in the comments. There's a portentous scene about devilled eggs.

Thank you so much for reading and subscribing and kudosing and, especially, commenting - it really, really helps my motivation to keep going and finish this!! And thanks to OpiumPoppy x

Chapter 40

Chapter Summary

'Well, wifey, look like we've made it to Part 3... the section where you're barely to be seen. Gosh, that made me gloomy! Can I have a kiss?'

'Of course, my dear spouse-wife, sir!'

'I really love you, you know. REALLY love you! On that note... this chapter is rated Mature, just below Explicit, reader-folk. I love Catra quite a bit in it, then move on to a vigorous spot of self-love, if you catch my drift.'

'Adora refers, of course, to the masturbatory arts.'

'Get a *room* you two! Swiftie and me are still, like, *right* here...'

Chapter Notes

Content warnings apply for the below chapter only - Spoilers may be present in the warnings. This story does not include any of the four Archive Warnings topics, but does occasionally feature other topics that may require content notes. This chapter is rated Mature.

Chapter 40 Content Warnings (CONTAINS SPOILERS):
Possessiveness – Related, off-screen, implied, towards narrator
Interference with romantic relationship – Related, off-screen, implied, towards narrator and major character
Physical violence, throwing – Narrated, historic, brief, towards major character
Relationship interference – Related and narrated, present, extensive, towards narrator and major character
Forced separation of romantic relationship – Related and narrated, present, extensive, towards narrator and major

character
Exile – Narrated, historic, inflicted on major character, impacts narrator

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VOLUME 3

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PART 1

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Rat-ta-ta-ta-tat.

Catra? Please. *Please*. That was her knock. I threw off the sheets and hurled myself at the door. My hands shook. I couldn't work the dainty key in its little lock fast enough. Palpitating fingers clammed frantically against the mechanism, making all my movements sausages in a pea souper. I rattled it. It rattled me back. Tears welled up. My nightshirt dripped sweat and regret.

Rat-ta-ta-TA-tat.
~~~

‘Catra!’ I cried. ‘Catra, I’m sorry--- I couldn’t--- I’m sorry. I’m trying. I--- I *can’t*.’

I pushed my head against the door and memories shuddered through me. The night before. Our real, private beauty. Just her and me. Everything. Four chimes pealed off the mantlepiece. Rosy-fingered Dawn started its odyssey through the sky and the net curtains. A sigh shuddered through me. The clock ticked away its hours: twenty-four since we’d said goodnight; twelve since we were wrenched into goodbyes.

What a difference a day made. I’d barely closed my eyes – I hadn’t slept at all – like I might never stop being awake. Purple stars shot through my vision and strange shapes lurched in corners, shaking me off my feet, sapping my strength. Lying had been agony. Standing hurt worse. My muscles screamed for relief they just weren’t getting. This wasn’t Sir Adora de l’Horde. Dull eyes skulked on the darker, the harder, the much more real than before, but my heart bled such intense and gorgeous longing. *O strange new world, that hath such Meowmeow in’t.*

But it hathn’t. That was the damned problem. She’d been the void, the absence since yesterday teatime. The scene had played in my head over and over and over again. Every detail was like seeing it all for the first time. Glimmer smirking, coldly, maliciously. Perfuma running from the tent, her hand pale against her cheek. The confusion writ large across Bow. Scorpia snarling as she faced up to the Countess. The Duchess watching from high above her marble cheekbones. Entrapta trying to block the way to the car. Failing. Major Midnight Blue hurling my girlfriend into the jitney like cheap rags. And the look, that indescribable look in Catra’s eyes. Her defeat and fury and persistence and--- and--- *her Love.*

My hands seared against the timber, rattling the door like I could pull the thing off its hinges, or like my furtive, amateur wrenching might dismantle the frame, send it crashing down around us and reunite me with the woman I'd sworn to adore, if only I tried hard enough. It didn't move. My voice was too desiccated to speak, too hacked around by the lonely night and its tears. *Sweet Lady Meowmeow, you asked me to trust you. Please, please*, I begged silently, *trust me back.* I heard nothing.

I fell back on the key, wrenching it with all my might. I pushed it harder, deeper into its slot. I pulled it back. Teased. Waggled about. My sword-hand itched for absolution. And didn't find it. Ms. Floaty-Cane had abandoned me in my hour of need. She wasn't at my side, or by the broken pile of last night's clothes, or hidden in the chests and cupboards. Nothing was – nothing I *recognised*. Wait. These weren't Lady P's rooms. I knew I couldn't smell yuzu…

Wait, Catra, please. Don't go. Not again.

My pulse spiked and my feet raced, tearing up the inch-thick Wilton and scuffing acres of American walnut. Inlaid gold. Heavy-handed Japonaiserie. Mirrors on mirrors on mirrors. A marble vanity choked with Parisian tinctures and pearl-handled brushes. Reds on pinks on purples. Four-poster. Leather-lined restraints clinging to the bedhead. So many wardrobes. Excess, wherever I looked. But just one more door.

It flung open – no key here – and I rushed towards the freedom of… a bathroom? At least, that's what I *think* it was. Straight lines

and square pillars in bare tin foil with tangerine highlights looked nothing like any washroom I'd ever seen, but the place had a sink and a bath and a water closet, so that's what it had to be. Which meant the windows didn't open. Which meant I still had no way out.

Rat-ta-ta-TA-tat, only more muffled this time.

She was still there. Thank the First Ones. I just had to get to her, somehow. Perching on what might just as well have been a butcher's block as a sink top, I ran myself through the available options, and drew a pint of water. It would have been rude not to, given my environs, and it solved the scratchy throat problem, if nothing else.

'CATRA!' I bellowed, forgetting that no self-respecting Etherian nobility wakes up this early, barring Lady Plumers. She was probably humming to a flower or giving her What Ho! to our friendly neighbourhood gas ball by now. Some of her set might also be awake – it wasn't out of the question – but only because they hadn't got to bed yet. Given the likeliest reasons for that, those folk would appreciate my volume even less than the somnolent snoozers.

Noisiness, I reflected, was hardly *our* friend either. There was something quite self-defeating about having a clandestine meeting at a holler, which went some way to explaining why we'd so far managed this girlfriendly reunion without resorting to language. Or, in another word, Whoopsie-Daisies! A whole dratted field of them. Draining my glass, considering smashing it in a fit of passionate pique, deciding that was really a bit much, I snuck back to where I'd started.

‘I can’t get the door to unlock. And I love you.’

‘Have you tried turning the key anticlockwise?’

I hadn’t, so I did. The bolt cracked loose.

‘Okay. On my signal, open up just enough to let me in. We need to make sure nobody sees us.’ A pause. ‘Alright, now!’

It happened in a blur. The door creaked and a female figure stood before me, bleached out by the low sunlight, triumphant.

‘You’re not Catra.’

‘No, lad, I’m not.’

This was not a great start. The woman patted flour off her arms. It fogged through the room. She was holding a rolling pin in one hand, clutched like a bludgeon, and a package in the other. It was square and lumpy, wrapped in brown paper, with a twine bow holding it together. The postage was paid with a positive armada of green, low-value stamps. It had my name on it.

‘This is for you. I thought I’d bring it up directly, before a certain *someone* could “deliver” it someplace else.’

‘Why would they do that?’

‘Because this parcel was sent overnight from central London. And I think we both know who it’s from. Don’t take a genius.’

I peeked at the address, weighing up the flourishing precision of its handwriting. My heart leapt. It really didn’t take too much brains at all.

‘Why are you helping me?’

‘Your Catra paid us a visit when she got back to Shugborough---’

‘She’s here?!’

‘No, no!! Sorry duck, I’m meaning when she returned night before last. She told us… enough. Helped with th’ dinner prep after. Seems like a good egg, that one. And did she have nice things to say about you! I’ll admit I were cynical, seeing as you’re upper house and all… I’ve seen it too many times, seen how us little folk get hurt… but then along came th’ festival. Rotten business, that. But you? You’re the She-Ra returned! When you spoke ‘bout restoring dignity to the people, it really sounded like you meant it. And… well… One good turn deserves another, as they say.’

She proffered the parcel with the grin of someone being much more sincere than I'd ever thought I deserved.

'Th---thank you! But who are you? And how did you get my post?'

'I'm the Baker and I'm the baker.'

'Eh?'

'It's up 'fore the sun in my line of work. Get them ovens warming and start working on th' first dough. Your fancy sort aren't too keen on waiting for your toast points, you know, and I can do wi'out that aggro. Surely, it can be a hard life, but it comes with its advantages… like being th' only one around t' take th' first post of a morn.'

'But your name? You must have a name?'

'That I do. But nobody ever much wants to ask it. Not that I'd tell 'em if they did… and as I suppose you have. Better to keep your work and your life unmingled, that's what I always say. And that's best left at that when there's a tray of brioche still wants making for breakfast! Fare you well, then, She-Ra! To th' Rebellion!'

The mysterious Baker left as swiftly and subtly as she arrived, leaving me holding a bundle of infinite possibility. Drawing the curtains – this seemed like a sensible precaution, since I'd just learned my enemies were everywhere – I locked the door again and closed off the bathroom, before depositing myself cross-legged on the bed with the curtains shut. By hook and by huff, the string untwirled like starch-drunk ribbon. Two more tugs and the glue was gone. The brown outer layer sighed open.

Inside, a swaddle of deep red crepe, taped gently around the shadows of unknown items. They sat beneath a letter with my name on it, traced in her so characteristic curl.

Adora.

My Sweet Knight,

I am as safe as I can be. Your Ladyship has hurt me, unwisely; I am recovering. Worse, she has hurt you. This was not your fault. You did nothing wrong. My love for you is never dimmed by the actions of others. You are still my girlfriend. I still love you.

Trust me, if you can – we will not be apart for long. I promise.

Until then, please take these gifts as tokens of my love. The first fulfils another promise – that I value and support you as you. Read its notes carefully, and look after yourself. The second

carries on from the night that ran out on us. Open it in private. The third is a pledge. Keep it with you. We will use them.

With all my love,

Your Girlfriend,

Catra.

The wrapping paper offered up no further clues, but its dainty folded edges and sparing, precise adhesive said so much about the woman who'd wrapped its contents. How I missed her. Newsreel flickered across my mind's eye: Catra dusting herself down on the train home, a figure of first-class dignity, unravelling her next steps into an exactingly kept notebook, its cover wrought with tastefully expressionist florals. Catra alighting at Euston and breathing in the City we both called home, with all its giddying possibility. Catra stepping back to the flat – or wherever she lived, I still wasn't too clear on that – and washing up for the evening.

A new collar, maybe a whole new shirt, matched with a silk or cellulose summer jacket – underwritten, maybe, by a pair of brogued and intricately burgundy loafers. Now that really would look good on her. I pictured myself taking her in, holding her hand, swooping up to the small of her back and drinking her with kiss on kiss on kiss… But that was fantasy more than conjecture. Deep beneath, my sternum ached. Yesterday was a long way off.

She stepped off the front porch, clear as day, into one of those dusky, dusty summer's evenings London can be so good at, when you have the moolah to make them good. I hoped she had. I'd left ten bob on the enamelled sideboard for flotsam and the like – I wished hard that she'd taken it and had a lot of fun. It wasn't out of the question. She'd slugged my spirits soon enough, hadn't she?

But--- No--- I was off into make-believe again. My girlfriend hadn't passed a night on the tiles. Maybe an evening of entrancing dancing or a devilish dawn, but it couldn't have been the whole thing. Sapphic Soho or *The Monocle* or wherever had waited for as long as it took to assemble my presents.

That left me a little giddy. So seldom had anyone sent me pretty, petite gifts before. Old Bowregard and Lady Glitterbug never forget the old birthiversary, don't get the wrong impression, only their offerings always take on singularly oily – Bowregard – or well-oiled – Glimmer – kinds of aspects. Precious bagatelles were something entirely… else.

Two celluloid spools spun delightfully into parallel possibilities. Catra cross-legged in her abode, wherever it was, combing through the glittering prizes of her life well-lived, laying them out before herself, picking just the right ones for the Lesbian she loved. Catra treading Camden and Carnaby Street, skimming the Kings Cross waterways, letting her feet lead her down, down, through the tedious work-a-place regions and into Piccadilly, combing the shops and stalls and markets for treasures I'd adore, lingering outside the glass plates that stud Savile Row, dreaming of the presents I'd buy her back, until finally turning tail to the bright lights and big names on Oxford Street.

I smiled so sadly. Catra packing her prizes into a gleam-polished satchel, grinning softly to herself. The letter writing at her bureau. Her careful weighing of paper stock and pen. The letter, the notes. Nimble, gentle fingers creasing edges and twisting string. A flourish for the address. Her self-assured strut to her local Post Office, knowing I'd like what I found. Brows knit in concentration as she picked out the precise stamps that saved me before. The disarming smirk that got the clerk onside, ensuring her package went last night and not this morning, then the hip-skating saunter into the evening, just ever so slightly clouded by the risk the bundle wouldn't reach me.

Rustling barely louder than the blood pounding through my ears, her gifts were here; and she wasn't. *My Lady, I will wait for you.* I saw her beaming in my Frazer-Nash, roaring to dinner; cackling at the table, eyes creased and cutlery tinkling against the china, surrounded by friends on all sides; Catra dancing through the dawn, free, wild, happy, Soho and hidden. She should be here – I should be there.

No.

We both should be someplace new. Somewhere we could make ours.

The present was a first part of that, so beautiful and potential. If I opened it, would she be gone again, far beyond what I could see? I lay down with my arms across her, and slept.

‘Uh, Adora, what are you doing?’

‘Swift Wind?! I’m--- I’m sleeping. Leave me alone.’

‘Your girlfriend sends you a super secret three-part present that somebody wants to STEAL, delivered by a radical baker who managed to find you in a frou-frou NIGHTMARE roomcthat you have no IDEA the location of aaannnndddd…. You want to NAP?’

‘Come here, horsey, you look so soft. *Yaaaarrrrhhh!!* I just need to close my eyes.’

‘I don’t think that’s a GREAT idea, Adora. I – babe – sleep is important for staying ALIVE and whatever but, as your noble steed, I’ve gotta say I sense danger.’

‘Like?’

‘My horn feels like it’s very close. Maybe in the next room? Are you sensing it in YOUR horn? Ahh! AHH! Adora! Where did you horn go? You don’t HAVE one!!’

‘Nope. I’ve just got a pillow.’

‘Please stop fluffing me.’

‘But Dora needs nap!!’

‘Okay, Adora, you sleep, and I’ll wake you when it’s time to open your present.’

‘Do I have to? But--- *Catra*.’

‘Sent you the package to OPEN. Did you think SHE was inside it? Huh. Aunt Shadowtha really DIDN’T get you many presents.’

My eyes slipped shut, matching my physical sleep with a bit of metaphysical shut-eye.

‘Mh-dora! Mh-dora!’

‘What, what?’ I’m up. Gee, what is it, Swiftie?’

‘The room! I’ve figured it out! Who likes lots and lots of quote-unquote girly things AND I have a super good reason not to like?’

‘Gimmer.’

‘GLIMMER. So, as your bold and beautiful sidekick, I REALLY think you should open that parcel now. It’s from Catra… Glimmer doesn’t like Catra… Glimmer is nearby… y’know what I’m saying? Plus it’s REALLY nearly BREAKFAST and didn’t the flour-to-the-people lady say there’d be brioche?’

‘Right, yes! Let’s *rise* to the occasion. No more *petty pain*!’

‘ADORA?!’

‘Yes, Swift Wind?’

‘Those puns… are… AMAZING---’

‘Really?!’

‘---LY BAD. Later, babe!’

The sticker peeled away, ripping just a little of the crepe, which was indescribably glum. It was meant to be perfect, just the way Catra made it. But the triptych within still was. The three parts spilled out: a bundle wrapped up by a silken handkerchief; a silver card case engraved with her initials; the crispest of buttermilk envelopes. Each came accompanied by a lilac tab, where her looping hand reported one, two or three. What was it she always said? *Never seen a rule not worth breaking*. And I wouldn’t want to disappoint now, would I?

Number Two. The case. The gift to open in private, and a day at Shugborough wasn't going to get any more secluded through waiting… A token of our love – a reminder of that precious, pounding bewitching hour. My stomach fermented. Some little voice of a hunch prompted me to check the door was locked – and the bathroom door too. I'd have turned a key in the bed curtains If there'd been a way to do it. As it was, an eyes-averted rummage through the bedside table produced the clicker for the handcuffs, so I snapped them shut for good measure. They didn't look very police regulation, but one really can't be too careful.

The clasp shuddered open and I teased the second gift – i.e. the first, from my perspective – just barely open. Perfume swam out, vanilla and basil and sandalwood and just a hint of musk, or so the bottle had said, when I'd taken the label for a good squinting the day before. It was, unmistakably, Catra's scent. It prickled through me, intoxicating in teasing velvet, beckoning me to open the case all the way. And there she was, smirking lopsided, bursting off the paper.

Her bare bursts were beguiling, Medusa.

Everything went very warm, and I had a sudden urge to take my clothes off. Lying; draped; flat-backed on firelit parquet; arms reached over her head like a diver, tracing every fathomless curve of her stretching hips. For the Honour of GREYSKULL!! Flicking through the photographs, savouring each more deeply than the last, going back and over again – and again – the smallest sugar paper ribbon fell into my fingers.

‘*Yours, my love,*’ it read. ‘*For you and you alone, to enjoy however you see fit, with my love and my full consent. Catra.*’

She didn’t have to tell me twice! Sweeping the fellow gifts off the bed, fricasseed in urgent, driving passion, I folded down, down into myself, plunging a hand between my thighs. A poison kiss, a shiver. I cracked open, raising one strong finger up, sweeping, circular, brushing. Such undeniable beauty! Greyscale grinning from her photos, Catra swam through me, drawing my rasping breath into her spare, crisp collarbones, the subtle nudge of her hip bone, the rich, vivid, endless curve of her breasts, her sculpted cheekbone…

Faster, deeper, my touch collided in my core, jerking my neck to her voiceless name. I melted and I coursed. The pictures danced. Curling coils, two fingers dove inside me, cupping and pulsing. I crackled, and the lights ran stars. I could see her. Hear her. I wanted her *so* badly. How could--- This--- This had NEVER been wrong. It was beauty. It was the purest connection. And I was climbing – climbing – clima---

‘Wakey-WAKEY, Adora, *kitten*.’

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Chapter 41

Chapter Summary

'Dancing, loving, *looking*, first-time binding, clothing... This chapter has almost everything that makes an Adora very happy indeed! Except a Catra. But I've fixed that since - and I'm even cheerier now we're wifeing!'

'Not forgetting that you're no longer binding.'

'Yes! Because, dearest reader-doodles, I've had my top surgery since then! It was a BIG weight off my chest.'

'Not a claim I can make for my augmentation, Sir Adora, but my feelings are much the same.'

'It's one heck of a chest you've got there. And a damned good chest I've got here. Isn't bodily congruence just the greatest?! We've got a few minutes before we're off to Westminster - let's go and celebrate!!'

'Err, you two? YOU TWO?! Don't you dare make me introduce another chapter! No. Nope. They've gone. To have some more Catradora time. ... Okay, so this is Chapter 41 and junk. Just to warn you - it IS Mature rated, 'cause Adora starts it with, like, one more present participle... Wanking.'

Chapter Notes

Content warnings apply for the below chapter only - Spoilers may be present in the warnings. This story does not include any of the four Archive Warnings topics, but does occasionally feature other topics that may require content notes. This chapter is rated Mature due to a brief masturbation sequence.

Chapter 41 Content Warnings (CONTAINS SPOILERS): Manipulation – related, extensive, use of external and

unconfirmed threat to direct another's action, towards narrator
Refusal to accept responsibility – related, wilful misconception, towards narrator and major character's relationship
Class-based discrimination – narrated, related, off-screen, towards household staff
Gender dysphoria – narrated, brief, in relation to extensive gender euphoria, experienced by narrator
Chest dysphoria – narrated, brief, in relation to extensive gender euphoria, experienced by narrator
Violent impulse, choking – Narrated, brief, by narrator, no choking occurs, no actual violence or injury occurs
Forced separation of romantic relationship – Related and narrated, present, extensive, towards narrator and major character
Exile – Narrated, historic, inflicted on major character, impacts narrator

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PART 2

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No! No no no… Not **now**!! Catra scrambled back into the case, as I tucked the photos and the whispering words behind them into invisibility. The pillows could hold them for now. It was still early, not even seven. They had no right to think I was awake, whomever the knocking they was. Unless they'd seen--- *Don't be daft, Adora*, I chided, *it couldn't be*. That was hours ago. And the Baker had checked.

Except--- Had I seen her before? Was there any proof she really had been a breadsmith? I knew it – I knew I should've challenged her to make a loaf! Still. Sleep. I should fake being asleep.

I lay there, rigid, looking fixedly at the ceiling, heart pounding, um… *other place* also pounding.

'Sweet darling, it's *NO* good holding out on *meeeee*. I KNOW you're awake. How could you not be?'

Silence, from me.

'Don't *let* me get impatient. I'd simply *HATE* to try the door handle. All that rattling brass is just so UNCOUTH, don't you agree? Adora, kitten, extended pauses soooo rarely *improve* a drama – and it's COLD out here. I'm *shivering*!! Have some *COMPASSION*!! We both know you're awake, but you expect me to pine at your doorway like we're in some Restoration comedy of manners. How… how *MATINEE* of you!! Really, She-Ra, farce is *suuuuuuuccchh* a low art form.'

They were not going away. Neither was the heat between my legs – and it very much felt best that never the twain should meet. I--- could--- stall?

'Yes?' I gasped. 'Hullo? Who the devil are you?'

‘*Hey, Adora*. Maybe I’m *her*. You’d like that, you bad little sir, wouldn’t you?’

What if… I thought about the photos – the woman draped across them – and folded shut against my hand, trying to stifle a scream. I fizzed and I radiated and my vision went all fuzzy. So I think it’s safe to say I would have liked that eventuality, yes.

‘Who are you really?’ I probed, once I’d got my breath back, then added: ‘That was a bally mean trick you played just now, if you don’t mind my saying so.’

‘Yes, kitten, I *suppose* I can see that. But you HAVE to understand! I was getting bored. So. Are you ready to welcome the magnificent Double-Trubel into your abode, comma, life?’

‘Why would I do that? You sent her away.’

‘I solved a CRIME, darling. I’m a *hero*!’

‘No dice, chap. You threatened to set her up – my girlfriend. Whatever you’re selling, I’m not buying.’

‘I *do* wish you’d reconsider. Darling, I’m not going anywhere. And neither a is a certain Sparkles. Either you and I have a friendly pre-*dejeuner-petit* talk about your… *predicament*, or you can

waste the next several hours waiting for the full force of Glimmer's surprise entirely unprepared.'

With full and free will, the de l'Horde would have tread and fled to a third option: out of the bedroom window in full She-Raian pomp and straight back to London. Only, it wasn't that simple. There was Catra's safety to think about – her very liberty. I teased open object three, her promise. A pair of tickets, first class, express, home to the Smoke, dated for tomorrow night.

She was coming back for me, just like she promised.

Until then, I had to stay where she could find me. I was tied into Shugborough.

Solace 'til the Solstice – and a treacherous game of Solitaire I fully intended to survive.

'D.T. old chum,' I schemed. 'There's no use standing out there like a lemon---'

'Wonderful, darling. I knew you'd see it my way…'

'Not so fast! Who made you the mayor of mornings, eh? A good knight has their own routines to attend to, no matter the obstacles blocking their path.'

‘But I--- Oh no, *hang on* there. *THEIR*, Adora?!? As in they, and them?’

‘Well. Yes, actually. I’m trying those out, as it happens. Been thinking about it ever since the day before last, and that self-assertion screed of yours.’

‘I WAS good, wasn’t I?’

‘You’re thought-provoking, I’ll give you that.’

‘So is it they *et cetera* I should be using for you? I want to get it RIGHT – *always*. These things *MATTER*!! Look at me, Adora.’

‘I can’t.’

‘Don’t deny the premise!’

‘I literally can’t. There’s a door in the way.’

‘Then open it?’

‘No, not yet.’

‘Hmmph… Fine. Anyway, Adora, you have to know I am *deadly* serious. *If* you wish to tell me, what are your pronouns?’

‘The they set, but also the original she.’

‘Cross however many hearts I currently possess, I promise to honour them both entirely, darling.’

‘And I should trust you?’

‘On this? ENTRIELY. Everything else? Let’s see how the mood takes me.’

‘Great sales pitch for our chat, there. That’s sarcasm, by the way. I don’t use it often, but I thought you deserved it.’

‘And I am *honoured*, really! Now, won’t you walk with me, Adora?’

‘If you want any chance of that, you’ll leave me be for the next half-hour – and keep Duchess and Countess Brightmoons out of my hair to boot. No peeking. No eavesdropping. Got it?’

'Your wish is my cat-mand, *mes chatton*. *Adieu!*'

That ought to do it. As their high heels clipped retreat down an assumed hallway, I had the performer's jealous need to be someone special working for me, not against. They'd blab after our coming encounter, sure, but the Marquioness would sooner die than let the others get to my door before they'd got their scoop. I had a slice of seconds to myself, guaranteed, and one last gift to unwrap.

Its paper shrugged out of its Swiss log shape in an explanatory crumple, and a letter fell out.

Read Me First looped the script on its envelope. I looked from the notepaper to the bundle of springy foreign fabric underneath, and readily agreed that this time I'd be doing exactly as I'd been told. It seemed to be for the best. So said the note:

Adora. You deserve to be yourself; you deserve to be free. Never forget that. I heard your chest dysphoria and I promised to help. Sir, I wasted no time at all in making good on my word. Even though this solution isn't permanent, I truly hope it brings you some measure of comfort and of gender dysphoria – that overwhelming joy and rightness that burns away dysphoria's pitch dark night. I am so proud of you.

Enclosed is a Boyshform *binder. In some ways, this garment bears similarities to the bust-reducing brassieres that the Flappers wore for the first half of the last decades, but its purpose and use are very different. While the fashion-forward women of the 1920s*

aimed for a smaller – but still coquettishly feminine – chest, the Boyshform *and its competitors – all, sadly, since defunct – hid their real market in plain sight… if you can call naming your product* Boy-*something hiding!!*

Binders reduce the wearer's visible chest tissue as much as possible, sometime achieving an entirely flat chest. They sell predominantly to trans gentlemen, trans masculine folk, and others experiencing that kind of chest dysphoria. Naturally, my experience goes in the other direction – a quick break here, Adora, for you to look at gift two, if you haven't already – so your Boyshform *comes courtesy of my friend Mr. J. Starr. He also offers the following advice.*

"Adora! Hey, Jewell here. Please read ALL the following points before putting your Boyshform *on…*

- *Make sure your skin is dry and clean*
- *Always bind with your nipples pointing forwards – NOT down*
- *If it hurts, take it off. Ditto if you're very short of breath*
- *Do not sleep in your binder*
- *Do not exercise strenuously in this binder*
- *Be careful in hot weather or when walking and exercising. You may get hotter quicker or feel shorter of breath*
- *Enjoy yourself!! Check yourself out! You've earned it!"*

I can't wait to see you wearting it, sir. The world becomes a better place whenever any one of us becomes a little more ourself. Take care, Adora. I love you – and I believe in you. Enjoy the Boyshform*. If you ever want to permanently flatten your chest, I promise – no matter what happens with us – I will do everything I can to make sure you can access surgery. Guaranteed.*

Yours,

With all my Love,

Catra.

Tears fussed my view as I held and beheld my *Boyshform*. Happiness hugged me where Catra couldn't. I beamed from the inside out, letting the light and the heat break through the staticky grit I'd been holding onto for so long without even knowing it was there. The hurt frothed off, stinging just a little from the whipcrack recognition that I could have had this - all of this – half a lifetime earlier--- if only I'd stood up--- if only Auntie hadn't been so, well, Auntie---

But what good would that do now? I'd been myself then – and I'd be even more myself now. *Be kind*, I imagined Catra saying, her claws combing through my hair. *Embrace that child, Adora. They did the best she could – and you arrived here in your time. I love you*. Or, you know, something like that… She knows how to say that kind of thing far better than your resident jock in the pony-pricked pyjim-jams!! Well… Not exactly *in* my night clothes at this point…

Beaming with – literally – naked glee, I smiled in a way I really don't think I ever had before. I'd been happy, tickled, excited… *in love*. But never this. It bubbled up from somewhere else and it came BIG. The *Boyshform* rattled in my grasp. It didn't look quite

like you'd imagine: the lace trim struck an unnecessarily gentle tone; and the satin body was devilishly refined. Looking closer, I could see the tell-tale punctures where the binder had been darted once, before someone had pulled at those threads to make an even straighter and more masculine shape.

Its remaining stitches held magic. Reaching a way my shoulders didn't really want to go, the seven claps snapped into position – *and there I was!!* I lit up like a fucking Christmas tree.

For the next several minutes, if you'd been there, you would have watched Sir Adora de l'Horde checking themselves out, over and over. And smiling at myself. These mystery rooms were good for that. They held an awfully excessive quantity of mirrors – enough to put Versailles to shame, even – standing or hanging in a veritable smorgasbord of aspects. And I looked at myself in every single last one of them. It was a victory lap, *sans* the garland. I danced from pillar to post- considered blasting the gramophone – thought better of it – giggled.

So grateful. So proud. Was---? Yes, YES!! This was what *actual* gen-u-ine happiness felt like: a flat chest and the love talented, caring, beautiful *Catra!!* Ha-ha! How had I gone so long without it?! Why had I ever accepted anything less? Oh – screw that philosophising hooey! I had happiness now – and I wasn't letting go. Not today. Not ever! Not bally well likely!

It was the full side-on view I liked best. That really was *truly* irresistible. Just straight down, skimming the sternum, scarcely swelling away from my collarbones and snapping back ot the chest wall just as fast. I cried a bit more. But, you know, in a good way! What this really needed was an outfit to properly show

me off, more than my current clothes could, wherever they actually were.

Prodding the brass button marked "STAFF" seemed awfully impersonal. Didn't Glimmer take the time to learn their names? But I pressed it anyway, and waited. I shook and paced with needling impatience of a lit and bloody big firework waiting to go BOOM!! At last – At Last! After three agonising minutes, a knock rattled neatly at the door wood.

'How may I be of assistance?'

'Apfeulmus Meowmeow is the greatest performer ever to tread the boards at… um… that Berlin queer nightclub place, you know the one.'

'Very good. Anything else, your Lordship?'

'Yes, as a matter of fact, there is. Just had to make sure you weren't someone--- else first.'

'No, I'm not *them*, sir.'

'Good! Marvellous, in fact! Now, my good fellow--- Hang about, what's your name?'

‘Busgirl, sir.’

‘Really?! Biblical, is that?’

‘Her Ladyship, the Countess Dryl, forbids us to use our names, sir. It humanises us too much.’

‘Horde, what rot! We won’t be having any of that here. As is you aren’t people!!’

The door flung open. More accurately, ‘twas I that hurled the thing on its hinges, before rowing it quite a long way back. I was only wearing a binder, after all.

‘What Ho! I’m Adora – they/she – and I like horseys, mechanical things that go, and books. Oh! And my girlfriend.’

Busgirl cocked and loaded her expression, gradually assimilating the whats and whyfors of the situation.

‘Mathilde,’ she said eventually, with slow and breathing deliberation. ‘I am Mathilde. She/her. I, too, appreciate equine majesty. I love to cook, and I value no-one more than my sister.’

‘Family bones, eh? Hell of a thing that! Or so I imagine. I’m an only child myself.’

‘That doesn’t preclude you from having a sister, sir. Cass is my found family.’

‘*Choosing* your relatives, you say? So Auntie and the Akmiral wouldn’t get precedence simply for being flesh and blood? I can go out and select my own nearest and dearest, like Bow and Catra, say? Well, I never. What a concept! For a family who doesn’t want to chat with them, the Brightmoons certainly do hire some fascinating thinkers! Before we get any deeper into that, mind, Ms. Mathilde, I’m in need of some weeds – something to go with this rather natty *Boyshform*. See if you can rustle me up a set of cricket whites, would you?’

‘Of course, si---’

‘Adora!’

‘Of course, Adora.’

Well – she was as good as her word. Tick and tock, click and clock, then Mathilde was laying a starchy set of sporting wear atop my bedsheets. I chance some more grinning. It felt good! Don’t go misunderstanding. I was missing Catra like crazy and so dashed melancholy that the girl of my dreams wasn’t here to share this terribly special moment… But there was a certain fringe

benefit to being by myself at that precise moment. As I shuffled into this most absolutely natty of outfits, I didn't have to contend with Lady Meowmeow's absolute disdain for wearing exercise clothing off the pitch!

Sweet Horde, I looked good. REALLY damn good. Hel-LO Adora! *Hey, Adora*. The peplum cotton skimmed tight over my chest; rolled sleeves crumpled past my elbow without a single self-conscious spike about what that might to do perceptions of my upper body; the knit vest clung and tugged so, *so* close to my ribcage. I just looked *right*. So giddily, wonderfully correct.

Yum! Catra better watch out. She'd soon be getting some naughty snaps of her own, if I had anything to do with it. Ah, Catra… I waltzed around my room again, imagining her in my arms, her eyes pooling in the flickering candlelight as she peered up at me and asked--- Snap! Clap! A tango beat struck up and we were shaking, we were shimmying… The drums struck, pounded and pulled together, shivering sweat, her perfect endless curve against my perfect chiselled flat.

'Having fun, Adora, darling?'

'Ah… Oh…'

Gidden heavens and dammit, I'd left the door ajar, which gave Double-Trubel the perfect opportunity to walk straight through it. They floated across, tutting.

‘Now, now, Adora, is that *REALLY* how you dance? Kitten… *no*. That will not do! It’s tango, darling. Tango is art. Sure, you have the passion, but *what* is that reallllyyyy worth without the PRECISION?! Darling – *DEVASTATE* me. If I cut you, you should bleed earthy, irrepressible sensuality. Don’t be so… *Etherian*. Here – may I?’

I nodded and they took my wrists, slamming the door shut, flicking their jaw into the sharpest line this side of a chef’s knife.

‘You’re leading, aren’t you?!? So *LEAD*, darling!!’

We moved across the room and they me as their marionette – stabbing me up, jerking me stopped, shaping my body into violent, controlled longing.

‘Make me FEEL it!! Tango is fluid yet exact – *fury in form* – scream in shape!! Melt, darling. Melt sharper – INTO her!!’ Their hips bounced and ground and ground. ‘It’s yearning – it’s SEX, kitten – delicate and brutal, ragged caress. You *WANT* her, Adora! Don’t downplay it – amplify! You yearn for her – you pine – and you HATE *me*! Make me feel it!!’

We twirled. My breath was fire in my mouth. They arced, rolled. Smirked. We slammed in at each other and She-Ra screamed to me. Together, burning, we rush back, an upright snarl, deep into the into the drop. Thump. And my grip was still racing, blinding, feeling for their neck…

‘*That*…’ they sang, hauling themself back to a cross-legged repose on the edge of the vanity and booping me on the nose, ‘That is tango. The Alley-Cat *will* be impressed!! Speaking of which, it’s just about time you stopped holding out on our walk. Come---’ As they rose to their feet, sliding a stray strand back into their bleached coiffure, they stopped to sniff luxuriantly at the livid bedroom air. ‘---if you haven’t already!’

And they led me out of the room with an inscrutable little smile.

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Chapter 42

Chapter Summary

‘Okay. So. Double-Trubel, amirite? They are twisty, and duplicitous, and march to their own drum. They would make a GREAT Mer-Mysteries character – but do they make a great person? Do they like Adora? What is, like, their deal? Read this chapter and find out, I guess. Also Scorfuma are in it and they are just the cutest. I can say that – because Catradora are still out of the room being euphoric and junk. But I’d say it even if they *were* here. Because Scorpia? She’s a BABE.’

‘“But Mermista!” I hear you cry, but not really, because I can’t actually hear you. “Where are YOU in this story? Will we be waiting forever?” It totally seems that way – it’s true – but the wait is, like, almost over. Three words for you: Chapter. Forty. Six. I will BLOW your minds.’

Chapter Notes

Content warnings apply for the below chapter only - Spoilers may be present in the warnings. This story does not include any of the four Archive Warnings topics, but does occasionally feature other topics that may require content notes.

Chapter 42 Content Warnings (CONTAINS SPOILERS):
Manipulation – related, extensive, towards narrator
Touching without explicit consent – narrated, brief, non-intimate area, narrator touched, narrator not upset or harmed
Refusal to take responsibility – related, impacts major character and narrator
Transphobia – implied, brief, historic, off-screen, no detail
Threat, violent and non-violent, verbal – related, present and historic, towards narrator, major character and minor character
Threat of violence, physical – related, confrontational, towards minor character, becomes physical violence

Physical violence, grabbing, lifting, binding, gagging – related, extensive, two minor characters against one minor character, part-magical (No lasting injury, no blood or gore, no weaponry)
Forced separation - of lesbian romantic relationship, narrated and referred, historic and ongoing, impacting major character and narrator

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PART 3

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'*Wonderful* chest, Adora, darling!! *CONGRAT-U-LATIONS!!*'

The Marquioness ran a wan finger down my whites, humming appreciatively.

'It SUITS you, darling, if you're asking for my opinion. A flat chest makes you so wonderfully… *REAL*. If Sparkles says so much as a *syllable* against it, I promise, I'll **SCRATCH** her eyes out clean out. That goes for anyone.'

I started at the fervent figure of J. T. Trubel-Brightmoon, burning so bright as they clicked out their oath of allegiance. Acid gleamed against their teeth. They saw something I couldn't see – and looked unto it hard. As we crunched gravel towards the formal

gardens, they clutched me by the arm, caressing like they'd never let go. They were *deadly* serious.

'Don't look so surprised, darling. I *never* play when it comes to gender.'

Lock-stepped, our unlikely duo skimmed past the Romanesque faux-temple – the building *I* would have chosen for a clandestine contretemps – and kept going. The wreckage of the rose gardens. The lawns. The steps. And, finally, we were at the water's edge. Of all the locations on the Brightmoon estates, this was… *easily*… the least impressive. Grey-brown water trickled between brown-grey banks.

Stepped topiary loomed up behind us – accusing windows seared from high above – but the view straight ahead was decidedly un-decadent. Where were the florals and the follies Glimmer always boasted about? Not here, that's where. It was the most un-Double-Trubel of locations. Standing there, they looked like a peacock in a newt enclosure. Fascinating creatures, newts! But not even the most fervent Finker or fancier could call them the most *aesthetic* animal.

A pair of the blighters struggled out of the murk. They were visibly relieved to jettison the dun, slow-flowing ditchwater from whence they came – right up until the moment their beady amphibian eyes spotted the riverbanks. I watched the hope die in the little blighters. Where they stood was nothing special, everything ordinary. The grassy-muddy vee had made a half-hearted attempt at ruffle-haired wilderness, once, before giving up and pining for a quiet life in the suburbs. It was a lawn part-timing as a place for water to sit.

That wouldn't do. Sensing the veritable out-of-office of grandeur, Double-Trubel hurled us around and into the rim of a spluttering fountain. We'd travelled twenty feet onto a different planet. The marble cherubs wept tears of pure pretence as they clapped birdishly into an insufferably dainty repose. The Marquioness evoked them with an exaggerated origami surrender of standing. I sat down.

'Beautiful morning for a murder, isn't it?'

'Hang about!?' This was – in a word – unexpected. 'Did you bring me out here to kill me?'

'Oh *no*, Adora. Not you. That would be *terrrribbblllyy* crass! I refer, darling, to the dying screams of my poor, sweet Betsy. Oh! How she shakes and bucks even as we speak, while the surgeon warms their hopeful tools and offers up a prayer the patient *might* survive. But the ODDS!! The odds are so long, so stacked against her… And what can *I* do but SIT here, *helpless*, on the very day the two of us should have frolicked through France? Is my agony not *PALPABLE*? Oh! Oh Betsy, my dear, dear Betsy!! *Ne me quitte pas*!'

'*Goodness*. I'm so sorry – that's dreadful! Double-Trubel, my liege, if there's anything I can do---'

Trubel-Brightmoon slid towards me, sighing, and collapsed into my embrace, staring through me with the most plaintive, bleeding

appeal I'd ever seen play across a pair of eyes.

'A--- *Adora---*' they struggled out, at length, '*ADORA--- Sweet, dear Adora---* You could--- You might--- Can't you just--- *TELL* me why your squeeze was driving her?'

'The **car**. This is about the Blower?! And, what, you're trying to get me to implicate my girlfriend, so you can get her banged up?? NO!! No dice. She didn't crash your precious Bentley, D. T., and that's all I've got to say on the matter.'

'*Fair enough.*'

Double-Trubel extricated themself from the fountain's edge the same way a python frees their serpentine mind from the thought of a jolly good meal. Starting at the very base of their spinal column – and the pit of my stomach – they curved release through each vertebra in order, rousing their diet-panged frame from the inside out. It was a spellbinding production. With the Marquioness, it always was. At the very, very end of things, as metacarpus flickered into proximal, then middle, then distal, and reached searing release in ten louchely sharpened fingernails, they drawled in my direction:

'Can't blame a talented, ethereal beauty for trying. Well, come on, kitten. Our stroll awaits. I *hardly* think we mounted our excursion to spit feathers.'

‘Would it kill you to be a bit clearer?’

‘Now that we’re at the waterfront, Adora, we are going to walk around it, and talk... *candidly*.’

The pause – like every pause a Brightmoon ever made – simmered with threat. But the expression those words sallied forth from shot itself through with entreaty and something one could almost mistake for understanding. In the set of that mouth, Double-Trubel teased potential apologies. Their nose quivered with nostrils of regret. They unfurled a hand down to me, and I took it.

‘You won’t regret this.’

‘Somehow, I already do.’

‘A-ha! Not the first time I’ve heard that, Adora, and unlikely the last. Yet still I persevere! I’m an inspiration, *really*.’

They were hooked right round my tricep again, squeezing its neighbourly bicep to pivot us onto a gravel footway, tree-covered and rapidly retreating from clear view of the house. We walked in the one thing I’d thought my exercise buddy could never act out: silence. *Silence is Golden*, as Aunt Shadowtha likes to hiss, but her ward always finds it stifling and painfully awkward. I itched inside myself. I was desperate to chat – and close to cracking.

A pupil sidled my way, daring me to break our uneasy entente. Double-Trubel cleared their throat part way. Then thought better of it. The colour in their complexion was draining down to the plughole, dripping out of their neck. They huffed in air. Fiddled with the silken ribbons holding their production of a shirt together. Drummed their fingers against their cane. Flicked their chin, to ruffle their hair. Worried a bobby pin loose, only to wedge it bloodlessly back into place. Their cheeks went hamster-swollen. They couldn't hold it back a second longer.

'Adora, I'm impressed!' they gasped. 'Such interrogative talents, darling, building irresistible tension in your audience – i.e. *moi*! You really could carve a living on the legitimate stage, if you ever needed the work. You've a presence built for Ibsen, sweetie, or one of the less crushingly sad Chekov flits.'

'If you want to chat theatre, there are better people in that house than me.'

'Really? That's NOT the impression *I* get, Adora. Cousin Sparkles is a pure-born charlatan, so perhaps you get by hiding your passions from her. But you absolutely can NOT hide them from me... No. Not at ALL.'

'Go on. How have you worked that out?'

'Your girlfriend simply *DOESN'T* date uninterested Sapphics, or uninteresting ones. She never has.'

‘You know her well, do you, that woman you threatened with jail?’

‘Patience, Adora. We're getting to that – pinky promise! But won’t you take a compliment first? You’re much sharper than you look. Take that building---’

The Marquioness pointed at a hideous caricature of a hut, daubed in icing-vivid primary hues that failed to disguise how its builders had never ever seen a dwelling like it before.

‘What do you see, darling?’

‘A pagoda, but not a good one. It’s all ill at ease with itself, like... well... like me in a ballgown. The paint job and those dreadful windows throw the roof curve right off, like they’re too stiff and formal and dashed Etherian for the concept. I really doubt it’s been anywhere near China – the more I look, the less it’s like the illustrations in my *encyclopaediae*.’

‘Not encyclopaedia***s***, kitten? I REST my case! And – for the record – I like you much more when you’re yourself. For what else can we be, if we even want to start to aspire to live well?’

‘We can be kind. We can be thoughtful. Oh, I don’t know, perhaps we can even be the kind of fellow who doesn’t fit up Catra for crimes we know she didn’t commit?’

‘We know that, do we?’ Double-Trubel smiled the dictionary definition of wryness. ‘Glimmer looks at this abomination and just sees a place to play cards and drink gin.’

‘Stop changing the subject.’

‘Me?’ Double-Trubel recoiled in self-conscious disgust. ‘Darling, when did I do that? We’re still *absolutely* on topic.’

They swept me over a bridge, pausing mid-way to lace us against the ironmongery.

‘Quite the view,’ they intoned. The river sat, brownly. ‘Aren't *you* quite the water baby, Adora? A boat race winner, no less, and in your first year! That's *TREMENDOUSLY* impressive. I wonder what it was like to spectate from the sidelines---’ Their eyes distorted into mine. ‘---And who was watching? Come, Adora!’

Crunching hopscotch under a copse of fir trees, our feet picked paving slabs past a neglected memorial and into a twinkling clearing.

‘Now, kitten, what DO you see here?’

I saw a bench and thought it rather germane to tell the fellow as much. Unlike the pagoda, the four-legged assemblage held no hidden depths to dismantle. It might be made from wrought iron curlicues – and painted with that thick, impenetrable monochrome Auntie's make-up regimen saved for especially formal occasions – but it was still, at its orthodox and quotidian heart, a bench.

'That,' I therefore enunciated, as one might to a disinterested pet terrier, while the creature itself dreamed of ablutions, beefsteak and lady terriers, 'is a bench.'

'No, Adora, it is not,' said Double-Trubel, who disproved their point immediately by sitting on it.

'Yes it is,' I replied. 'You're sitting on it.'

Even the rummiest, crummiest old philosophers had to cop to that point, lest they bump buttocks with the floor. And yet!

'No, darling, it *ISN'T*.'

'Yes it IS! You're---'

'Adora, sweetie, who cares where I happen to be resting? This is *not* a bench. *Reaaallllyyy*, I thought you'd be able to see that… Tut! Just when I was getting my hopes up that we might be able to have a *mature* conversation…'

Because, as any good Etherian knows, what better sign of adulthood can there be than an abject refusal to discuss the matters of the day until all parties involved have strutted around the gardens for an hour or more, pitching and answering logic puzzles? I folded my arms and *huffed*. Glimmer and Aunt Shadowtha had put me on the receiving end of that weaponised exhale countless times before, you see, so I knew only too bally well how utterly it can devastate a previously-friendly conflab. Take that, Double-Trubel!

Except… the Marquioness took nothing. While I huffed and puffed like the Golden Arrow starting uphill out of Victoria, my songstrix Sphinx crossed their legs and chewed on an end of liquorice root.

'Where *are* my manners?! Want some, kitten?'

'Won't that put you off breakfast?'

'Oh, darling, no… *Breakfast?!* This figure doesn't keep itself.'

'But you're a shapeshifter.'

'As are *you*, Adora. Yet you still CLEARLY work out, don't you?' They'd got me there. 'So… the sooner you just SIT DOWN, the quicker we can *both* get on with our riotously irrational existences. *Okay?* Chop CHOP!!'

Not having too terribly much to say to that, I parked my pristine whites on a seat of nearly entirely matching hue.

'Very GOOD, Adora, kitten. Are we ready to discover what we *really* see here?'

I nodded an increasingly weary assent. Through my bobbling peepers, I spied the possible topic of our discussion – a pair of women, dressed like laundry day, dancing back and forth across patchy clay, heaving heavy, tree-scented air. They were playing tennis. They were laughing, rushing, touching each other tenderly on the elbow or a freckle-tanned forearm. Horde damn it, these fellowesses were… frolicking! And good for them, eh! But as I watched Perfuma and Scorpia seal their love with a kiss between sets, my spectating blurred with the growing, aching conviction that it should have been ME out there. Me and *Catra*…

Double-Trubel acted like they saw nothing. They simply said: "Marvellous!" Another silence crossed between us, broken by tinkling laughter as Lady P served one straight into the net. Trubel-Brightmoon refolded their legs – employing a kind of motion not entirely unlike an anatomical lecture in the art of Chinese paper cutting.

'Don't they look like they're ENJOYING themselves? When we watch them – *here* – we see the burgeoning relationship between two Sapphics… from a *NEW* angle.'

‘What are you saying, D. T.?’

‘We see *love* – and THAT is what I brought you here to discuss…’

Their final sibilant hung like a Christmas tree decoration, dangling, awaiting Epiphany. And it would be waiting a bally long time, for our presence had just been detected by the world’s most charming two-day-old Sapphic couple, if such things were adjudged in competition, which they damned well ought to be. Would have cheered up that village fête no end, let me tell you!

‘She-Ra!’ cried the one who stubbornly stuck to calling me that. ‘What are you *doing*?! Do you need help? Get--- Get away from them!! Remember what they did to Catra!’

‘*Daaarrrrlllinnggg*, what *DO* you mean to imply?’ Double-Trubel drawled. ‘I presented Madam Meowmeow with a *series* of options. She simply selected the one most amenable to her.’

‘That’s a LIE,’ screeched Perfuma, rattling balled up fists. She was starting to glow. The trees bent in her direction. The rather apt Forget-me-nots beneath the bench burst to life and went in for the kill against Marquioness Trubel-Brightmoon’s ankles. One would be hard pressed to call this the Power of *Friendship*, but it was certainly strong, and it was definitely racing in on my side. A rose shot out its thorns, straight into Double-Trubel’s liquorice stick. They put it down with a flourish and a smirk.

‘Perfuma, what are you *saying*? Do you accuse the Prince and Marquioness of Shugborough’s FINEST family?’

‘Yes. Yes I DO. Of being cruel and manipulative and a big old MEANIE-BA-BEANIE!!!’

‘Old?’ Double-Trubel coughed. ‘*OLD?* Lady Plumers, maybe I should remind you of the REVELATION that recently came to light – the one that imperils your position in our gardens.’

Boof. Just like that, the fight went straight out of her. Lady P withdrew, shaking like a leaf, to drape her pearls and her sorrows over Scorpia’s ample shoulder.

‘Ah. Gee. That – I really wish you hadn’t done that,’ Scorpy sighed.

‘*Funny*…’ laughed Double-Trubel, folding their legs again. ‘I don’t.’

‘Well.’ Scorpia dusted herself down. ‘I do, see. Nobody makes my girlfriend cry! And nobody makes Adora’s girlfriend leave---’ old Scorps was giving off a spectacular scarlet glow all of a sudden, ‘---the fête---’ why, she was positively luminescent, ‘---before the Wildcat---’ which, it appeared, was a more common trait than I’d previously anticipated, ‘---even had the chance---’ but still nowhere near as impressive as her mel… *musculature*, ‘---to taste---’ or the claws now tightening around the Marquioness, ‘---the CANDY FLOSS!’

Hollering out her sticky-saccharine invocation, Scorpia was something legendary. I just gawped. Here she was: avenging Atlas of the Sapphic community. I gawped some more. This woman thought she needed a knight?! What rot! She *was* a knight, and a strong one at that. With a crushing, guttural roar, she flicked her claw and slammed Double-Trubel across her free shoulder. They were winded, they were stuck, and they had more to fear from Lady Plumers.

The threat nullified, the gardener raced in, her magic and her confidence restored. She conjured vines – pretty ones, with flowers and leaves and the like – then set diligently and delicately to the work of wrapping the Marquioness up like a spool of thread, whistling as she worked. Hands on her hips, she stood back when the work was done, nodded, frowned, nodded again, then hopped to her final touch.

'Mmm-Hmm!' cried Double-Trubel. 'MMMMM!!'

Perfuma had gagged them with a particularly succulent early season plum. This was either a waste of good fruit or the very best thing you could do with it. As the Marquioness themselves might have said – if they could – it was all a matter of perspective. Instead, they kicked their pointy heels at the sky. Lady Plumers giggled as she grabbed my hand and led our verdant procession back to the bridge.

'Do you want to do the honours, She-Ra?'

Perfuma smiled with the kind of brightness I'd come to expect from her – but had never imagined seeing in this *precise* situation. Way below, the waters swirled brownly, and the newts watched on.

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Chapter 43

Chapter Summary

'WOW. This is, like, peak Double-Trubel here. Grey-ish morals, great outfits, transformation sequences, characters, vague but believable threat. Adora so gets their fill of them this chapter - and *really* has to reckon with her and Glimmer's "friendship" too. It's intense. Like the river it's set on, Chapter 43 *goes* places. Speaking of travel or whatever, I don't actually know where Catra and Adora are right now, but Swift Wind is getting SUPER excited to go "meet" the Horde Prime Minister.'

'I don't believe in cops, bosses OR politicians, Mermista, but I DO believe in apples. And kicking ass.'

'Did that, like, sound a lot cooler in your head?'

'Err, I'm a magical flying unicorn? Everything I do is cool, okay?'

Chapter Notes

Content warnings apply for the below chapter only - Spoilers may be present in the warnings. This story does not include any of the four Archive Warnings topics, but does occasionally feature other topics that may require content notes.

Chapter 43 Content Warnings (CONTAINS SPOILERS):
Violence, binding and gagging – Narrated, present, brief
Violence, throwing person – Narrated, present, partially by narrator, consented to (no physical harm or injury occurs)
Enabling – Narrated and related, present, impacts narrator
Exile – Narrated and related, historic and ongoing, major character exiled, narrator impacted, major romantic relationship disrupted
Infidelity, perceived – Narrated and related, present, brief,

perceived action of narrator (no infidelity takes place)
Queerphobia – Narrated and related, historic, brief, impacts narrator
Classism – Related, present and historic, partially acted, multiple occurrences, towards major character
Vehicle incident, boat – Narrated, present, brief, minor (no physical harm or injury occurs)
Manipulation – Narrated and related, present, extensive, partially acted, targeted at narrator
Gaslighting – Related, present, extensive, partially acted, targeted at narrator
Sexualisation – Narrated and related, present, extensive, acted, targeted at narrator
Non-consensual touching, sexualised, no consent sought – Narrated and related, present, multiple brief occurrences, targeted at narrator
Kidnapping, perceived – Narrated, present, impacts narrator (no actual kidnapping takes place)
Exhaustion – Narrated, present, experienced by narrator
Fainting – Narrated and related, present, experienced by narrator (no physical harm occurs)

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PART 4

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‘Oh, no, no,’ I demurred to the vengeful Lady Plumers. She smiled brilliantly back at me, flicking her jaw with quizzical glee, as if I’d been both terribly polite and dreadfully unpredictable by not immediately accepting her offer. The river ambled under the bridge where we still stood. Double-Trubel chafed at our

shoulders. ‘Isn’t it a bit of a long way down?’ I asked. ‘And the water seems awfully… *wet*, don’t you think?’

‘Gee, it IS very brown, Perfs. What would Glimmer think, my love? Maybe Adora’s right. Maybe we should just dangle J. T. over the edge and scare them a bit. Ah, you know, to stay in the Brightmoon good books! Sort of.’

Any chance of that had probably passed already, I reflected, gazing down into the febrile waters. As much as I welcomed old Scorpy’s change of heart, the fact remained that a major noble had been attacked, bound, gagged and marched to the very precipice of a dunk in the old drink. The fellow could hardly forget a thing like that – and I highly doubted their Aunt would either. Granted, a judicious brake slam would stop the situation getting worse, but that wasn’t the same as making it better. The Marquioness – feeling similarly – spit out their stone fruit. It hit the river with a *thwump*.

‘Do you know WHY *Hamlet* is *SUCH* an underwhelming piece of theatre, darlings?’ they sighed.

‘Ophelia never gets a girlfriend?’

‘Alas no, Adora…’

‘Hang on! This is literary analysis, your liege, old chap,’ I spluttered, rather affronted. ‘There are no wrong answers.’

‘I… *disagree*. *Hamlet* is profoundly disappointing, my kitten’s darling, because the title figure spends so *veeeerrrrryy* long TALKING and almost no time at all DOING.’

‘So you want us to throw you off the bridge?’

‘*Adora…* I’m *merely* stating it would be more DRAMATIC!’

‘So… err… Gee, you heard ‘em, Perfy.’ Scorpia began, somewhat bluntly, by tipping one of the finest bandleaders of their generation over the parapet.

‘Wait! Scorpy, stop!’ Lady P broke away, rushing towards her love, clapping her hands in a more agitated manner than usual.

‘*Thank* you, Lady Plumers. I *KNEW* your inner---’ Trubel-Brightmoon stopped quite abruptly there, on account of the replacement peach Perfuma had magicked into their mouth.

‘Scorpy,’ she went on, ‘I really think She-Ra should be the one to dunk Double-Trubel.’

‘I couldn’t possibly, your Ladyship! I saw how they offended you!’

‘But, She-Ra, they banished your girlfriend!! Adora---’ She clasped my hands, knitting her fingers between mine. ‘---It’s okay to feel your feelings! Let them in! Say hello! Right now, how do you feel?’

‘Pretty bloody angry, truth be told.’

‘So push them off the bridge!’

‘Hmm… Alright, but only if do it together.’

‘Goody! Well done She-Ra! Feel those feelings!’ She clapped again – until there was no more clapping to be done – then hoisted a thrashing pair of the legs aristocratic into her grasp, leaving me with the talky end.

‘No hard feelings, old chap,’ I reassured Double-Trubel – as they jettisoned a second soft fruit like an especially stylish dummy.

‘Really, Adora? I expect SOME hard feelings, or I’ll start to *fret* I haven’t done my job properly… Do you want another go?’

‘Fine,’ I coughed, rapidly taken in by She-Raic emotion. ‘I’m actually really rather cross.’

‘Yay! That’s it, She-Ra! Marquioness Trubel-Brightmoon, go boil your head!’

And, with that, we two Sapphics unceremoniously dumped a rather high-ranking nobleperson into the drink.

How fortuitous it would have been, at this precise moment, if another Brightmoon denizen had been approaching from out right, such that they saw Lady Plumers at this task – plus, perhaps, the stoic, overseeing might of Ms. Blackstone – but hadn’t clapped eyes on me. Better still, the Shugborough swells could have chosen literally any other moment for their morning constitutional, allowing the matter to pass as unremarked as mashed potato on a school dinner side plate.

Yet these occurrences were not to be, withering at the cold, consistently corporeal reality of an “Ah! Good morning, Sir de l’Horde!” sounding to my left.

‘What Ho, your Grace!’ I sounded in guileless riposte, tucking my hands tight behind my back. I never can tell why, but Auntie always suspects me less when I *just stand up **straight** for once*. Duke Brightmoon narrowed his gaze, and I began to fear that I-and-we were not going to get away with this. Or that he’d decided to stop being quite such a good sport about his attempted murder.

‘Wait a minute!’ bellowed he. ‘**Adora!!**’ I tensed reflexively. ‘That isn’t the same woman who hung around next to you yesterday. Egads! Say you’re ethical and communicative! Don’t tell me my precious moonbug has thrown in her lot with a CAD?!’

‘Oh no, sir,’ Perfuma twinkled, ‘though I would be flattered to be mistaken for the She-Ra’s girlfriend---’

She squeezed my arm constrictor tight and I received an unwelcome suspicion that Scorps suddenly liked me a little less. This was not helping our cause. Micah cocked an eyebrow and – more impressively – spelt out an entire question with his facial hair. It said: *If you two aren’t girlfriends, then why does this tableau look so girlfriendy, and why are there so many lengths of sturdy but non-chafing rope on my bridge?* Quite a question, I dare say, and one Lady P swiftly endeavoured to answer.

‘Scorpia here is MY one-and-only! And she’s terrific at it!’

‘Blackstone, you say?’ The Duke stroked his beard with obvious satisfaction. ‘Spiffing choice! There are few women like her and all that! I’d be a proud man if my daughter found someone as strong and dependable.’ There was no avoiding it: he was looking straight at me. ‘Sir Adora – where **is** that Catra lady of yours? Lover’s tiff? Terrible shame! I was hoping we could go riding together.’

‘Well… Gee… No, Mr. Brightmoon, sir.’ Scorpy scuffed the planks beneath our feet, her feud seemingly forgotten as she took up my cause. ‘Wildcat – Meowmeow, I mean – was locked in a competition with Glimmer at the fête and, darn it, I don’t know how it ended, but Lady Brightmoon was REALLY steamed and then – before you know it – her cousin, the Marquioness, was blocking the way, and Glimmer was shouting, and Catra was thrown in the back of a taxicab, never to be seen again.’

Duke Brightmoon looked terribly serious as he assimilated this information, right up until he didn't.

'HA HA!!' he boomed through a sunrise smile. 'You girls – and Adora – know how my moonbug gets. So hot-headed! Just give it a day or two for her to cool off and it'll all go back to normal!'

Though rushing with warm-blooded friendliness, his attendant back slap hit me like a blade. *Et tu, Glimmer's dad?* Well. The answer's in the question. He was on his daughter's side. That shouldn't have been too surprising but, still, the *principle*. The chivalry. The knightly code. Everything he'd said at yesterday breakfast. Wasn't he going to follow through, preferably with squires and steeds and armour and lances? Couldn't we crusade Catra back here?!

'Right!' the Duke pronounced with Imperial finality. 'The morning ride! Are you com--- Wait, wait!! I'd forget my head if it wasn't screwed on, I swear--- That mighty splash I heard, Adora, as you seemed to drop something into my river. Anything I should be worried about?'

Gifted with Lady Meowmeow's presence or her wit, I might have thought of something intelligent to say or, at least, have had an external marker for when to stop talking. As it was, I simply knew that this fellow saw me as a gentleman of honour, and that I wanted him to keep regarding me as such, so I opted for the truth.

‘Not really, no. We threw your nibling off the bridge.’

‘I see! Why?’

‘Because they insulted Lady Plumers’ and my Lady’s honours.’

Micah nodded gravely, hefting his not inconsiderable upper body over the railing. ‘J. T.!’ he hollered at the silty shadows. ‘Is what Sir Adora says true?’

Double-Trubel, reclining-cum-bobbing on the mire, deigned to look up and sighed wetly. ‘*Yes*, uncle. But I had JUST *cause*!!’

‘**Bah!** What justice can there be in demeaning two young women of maidenly virtue?’

‘It will all come out in *time*. Patience, dear uncle.’

‘Are you going to leave it there? Pah.’

‘*No*, uncle.’ They flopped damply in our direction. ‘I *BEG* forgiveness, darlings, for the CANDOUR of my words. Now you’ve thrown me in the river, I do hope we can *conclude* the whole… affair.’

The twinkle I saw in their expression made me disinclined to do so, but Scorpy saw otherwise. 'I--- Gee. Okay. But we DON'T forget about Catra.'

'I'd shake your hand, snippers, but, y'know---' They gestured around themselves, then stood up and began wading towards the back, only to halt, like they'd been struck by lightning. 'Damn, darlings, HOW could I forget? Flutterina can fly!'

A greenish crackle, a static snap and the bipedal manifestation of a Fondant Fancy stood before us. '*Unkie*,' she tremored, her pointer fingers touched together. 'I know wu've got impowtant busy-ness wiv Adowa, but can I bowwow them just for a wickle bit? Pwetty pwease??! Pwetty pwease with chewwies on top?!'

Flutterina batted a century with her extendable eyelashes and, Horde damn it, if it didn't knock Micah for six.

'Awwh! I can't say no to that face. How about it, Adora? See you at the stables in an hour?'

And – without waiting for anything approaching a reply – off he strode.

'Thank wu, Unky! Thank wu! Luv wu! Bye-bye!' Once Duke Brightmoon was out of sight, my wrist chilled to Flutterina's

vicelike grip. There we no smiles now – just a jagged slash of determination. ‘Come on, Adora, darling. We’re going to the boathouse.’

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Mouldering in a sadly officious shade of brown, the Shugborough boat shed was somehow even more inglorious than the river it served. It augured precisely nothing good at all, so it’s just as well we spent so little time there. After shaking out her wings and baying Ladies S and P an altogether too forceful farewell, Flutterina had soggily marched me along the opposing riverbank, transforming back into Double-Trubel as they went, before dragging us wholesale across another, more ornate bridge and thrusting mismatched fingers at our destination.

‘There!’ they announced. ‘And we’re going inside, so get walking.’

‘In these shoes?’ I protested, which was a reasonable if compact objection to my probable kidnapping.

‘If I can do it in dance heels,’ they replied, proving they could, ‘then I can’t POSSIBLY see *why* you could have a problem. Would it kill you to hurry it up? I’m trying to get this done before Glimmer wakes up, *remember*?’

One not very good-natured argument later, we were inside. And muddy. We stood on a three-plank pier and surveyed a modest
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squadron of rowing boats.

'You'll recognise THESE, I suppose,' Trubel-Brightmoon opined, pointing at the first, 'so you can drive. Climb aboard, darling.'

While I complied, slotting the least flea-bitten oars into their supports, the Marquioness flung open the front doors with the nearest thing to a flourish those old shutters could manage. Rotten enough to bend but not yet so rotted as to break, they sighed open to limited effect, Double-Trubel holding one aloft like a curtain as I paddled through.

They jumped in just as we escaped into the light, reminding me I was quite possibly in the process of being denied my freedom. What rum luck that would be! I needed that liberty to save Catra – and all of Etheria in general, for that matter. Straining the old grey goo, I did my utmost to think back to how Aunt Shadowtha and the Hord Akmiral had taught me to act in just this situation.

'I'll die before I give up the family secrets!'

'I doubt your family has any *really* juicy skeletons, darling. Didn't they try to hide your queerness – or am I just filling in the blanks? Either way, I don't have much confidence in their ability to filter the beautiful from the damning.'

'How did *you* know Auntie is ashamed of me?!'

This was not going the way I expected. Neither was the boat, which bobbed and meandered towards a water hazard weeping willow, chiefly because I'd stopped rowing it.

'Like recognises like, Adora, darling. I'm sorry that's happening to you, and I'm sorry it happened to me.'

This was good? I'm sure I remembered something about engaging hostage takers in personal conversation, to give one more time to think of an escape plan. I ventured:

'You've got a long way from that, though. How's it going with your theatre business – in the West End, I seem to remember you saying?'

'*ADORA*!' They brightened measurably. 'So *few* people ask about my acting! It's all music, music, music… and there's SO much to tell of the stage! Alright, darling, okay. I'll *spill*! We're rehearsing for this new musical play – well, sort of new. It was written for Broadway, and it was a SMASH there, but it's groundbreaking here and *I* have one of the leads. *Naturally*.'

'Naturally.'

'But the male lead I'm cast against?! What! An! Ingenue! Darling, he has so many fine theories you'd swear he was a PHILOSOPHY

degree… He never learns the lines… And DON'T get me started on his dancing!! *Why*---' Double-Trubel stood up. They looked a lot more dramatic, but they also looked a lot more like someone being attacked by a willow tree. '---*WHY* are we over here? Row THAT way!'

Fear spiked in my chest again. Distraction had come to the end of its road; the time had come to try directness.

'Are you planning something wicked?'

'Ah-ha! *ALWAYS*.'

'With me?'

'Don't flatter yourself, Sir Adora.'

'Then why get me in the boat?'

'Because we need to take a *journey* together – literally *and* metaphorically.'

'After which?'

‘You get out, a wiser and a sadder man, to rise the current morn.’

‘Coleridge!’

‘Almost.’

‘Is that why we’re on a boat? The Ancient Mariner?’

‘NOOOO…’ Double-Trubel stepped to the bow with a fuzzing flourish and turned to face me. ‘*This* is why we’re on a boat, my big, *brave* Dory!! Sparkle sparkle!’

Language pales when faced with the unenviable task of articulating the rank horror one feels when presented with the image of your friend, who is *not* your friend, and, quite possibly, is not your *friend*, gyrating towards one in an exceedingly small vessel. If pushed, I’d call it decidedly un-spiffing.

‘Cripes.’

‘Oh, Dory, ohmigosh! Don’t sound so *surprised*, m’kay? Don’t we know each other well enough by *now*? How can you be shocked?! You just can *NOT* be fucking surprised by this, silly!! I mean, get real, how much of *this*---’ Double-Trubel gestured at Glimmer’s admittedly rather lovely curves, ‘---*haven’t* you seen before?! Hmm? You’ve kissed these… You’ve touched these… You’ve fucking *squeezed* these!! Ohmigosh, turns out there isn’t much

left for you to uncover, you *saucy* cunt!!' Glimmerish gasped. 'But--- But--- Those last, *secret* areas, Dory… They're some of my *BEST* bits!! Just right for a best friend – who knows, deep down, she wants to be something… *more*…'

'I--- I don't know what to say.'

'Shush-shush, my bold, strong *protector*.'

'I have a gir---'

'Ohmigosh, don't you *get* it?! I don't need you *fucking* talk! … We're beyond words babe.' She pressed a finger to my lips. 'You know that. So row, my gorgeous Dory, just frickin' row, and let me tell you about the last time we were in a boat together. What it really meant!'

At moments like these, a chap is wont to call out for mummy. I found myself restricted from doing so on two quite vital counts. One, I have about as much idea as you whom my mother might have been and, two, this left me with Aunt Shadowtha *in loco parentis*, who'd either say I was rendering the Brightmoons a service or that I was ruining the family name forever and ever, amen. And Horde knows which.

Thus, I settled on two actions that decades of heirly de l'Horde duties had taught me to do well. I nodded. And I rowed.

Glimmeresque draped herself around me, puddling into my lap, ringing little circlets of touch across my chest.

'Harder!' she panted. 'Harder, deeper! Come *on*, Adora. *YES*! Ohmigosh, keep that stroke going!!'

'Steady on D. T. – that's damn steamy stuff!'

'Darling, it's MEANT to be. And *DON'T* make me break character again. You have been warned--- Ah-hum! Row, my Gabriel, row! Sparkle-sparkle! *PHWOAR!!* Oh, *Adora*, fuck sticks and sucked dicks! *Look… at… you!* Ah! It's Henley allllll *over* again… You and me, in that tiny little boat, alone – urgh, except for Bow – as you ground and pulsed and… and *SAVED ME*. Ohmigosh. Dory, you don't know how you've *rescued* me! Before we met, I was just a pearl in the country, stuck in the muck, but *you…* my big, brave knight… *YOU* dived in so fucking deep for me. Don't you want to go deeper? *Shit*, you can't deny it. I *know* you do.'

'What I want is my girlfriend back.'

'The *FUCKING VALET*??!?!'

I'll give Trubel-Brightmoon this – the utter venom they packed into those two words utterly convinced me and conveyed me. I could have sworn I really was talking to their hot-tempered relative.

‘Glimmer – that’s ENOUGH!’

Glimmer-Trubel recoiled as the air around us crackled whites and pinks and blues. The rainbow thundered through me and Ms. Floaty-C snapped to my side. I hadn’t even said those five little words. The oars splintered in my fists like burnt-out matchsticks. The boat rocked port to starboard, red to green, left to right, pitching back and forth all the while, slumping that scrambling, no-good Brightmoon into their seat. If they wanted drama, then, by the First Ones, they could have it.

‘*Dory*,’ they wailed. ‘What do you *mean*?! You can’t--- No! No! I just wanted to recreate our special day together. You’re – *SCARING* me!’

And that complicated matters rather, as the chivalric knight of yore, no matter which history you read, would *never* terrorise their Lady. All told, however, nor does the courageous sword-bearer splash idly by when their other Lady is unjustly banished from the Kingdom. So I was on something of a sticky wicket, not least because too much of my brain was busily perceiving Double-Trubel as their cousin.

Battling feelings and rivercraft alike, I wrestled mightily, this way and that. Complicating factors were one fight; foamy brownish moisture hellbent on getting inside the boat was the other. Each formed the most splattering of distractions. I was going in too many directions at once. I let the minutes slip away from me. I fell out of She-Ra. And the actor pounced, toying with my

bewilderment. A fug of fruit-flavoured smoke and she was back, all Glimmer, wrapped entirely around me.

'Addoorrraaa,' she teased, 'you careless *hunk*. Brr!! You've got me all *soaking* wet… But I *promise* I won't tell…'

'Fat lot of good that did me last time.'

'It's not *my* fault the photographers were there, babe. How could it be? But I do---' she squeezed my forearm, '---*LOVE* an audience. Picture it, Adora! Think back! You and me – close as close can be – on public fucking *display*. Feels good, right? And you can have it every… single… day, if you just *realise* what I've been *trying* to tell you. For soooooooo long!'

She coiled even closer, one hand cupping up my shoulder, the other touch spidering further and further up my thigh, grazing her lips to my ear with a sultry whisper:

'Row, Adora! Row upstream, where the others can see us. We're going to make *magic* all over again, just like that day. Sparkle *sparkle*.'

I ground the oars hard into the water and heaved. I wanted dry land. Whatever the rules were to this unfathomable game, I just wanted it to be over. My ribs ached. My shoulders screamed. My lungs were ripping.

‘I know what you want. I know what you *need*. Imagine walking hand-in-hand with your girlfriend – no shame or other hurtful *shit* to get in your way – wherever you want, whenever you want, and nobody can *ever* tell you no, because the Lady on your arm *demands* respect. From the whole world. And she *always* gets it. Can your humble-ass *SERVANT-GIRL* give you even a pissing little fragment of that?! I think not. Just… *DORY*!! Open your motherfucking eyes! Why the *FUCK* would you settle for street-stall hamburger, when you’ve had a cunt-spangling banquet right here in front of you all along?!?’

‘Gli…mmer,’ I panted, peering at my passenger through a shrinking, dot-studded gaze. The words crawled out, barely. My chest. My *chest*… ‘Watch… Your… Tone… She’s… My… GIRLFRIEND!’

‘But I’m your *LADY*!! Adora? Adora! Kitten? No. No no. No no no no no – don’t faint on me, sweetie!’

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Chapter 44

Chapter Summary

'Reader-doddles! Your She-Raic spousewife returns, ready to introduce a packed chapter of Brightmoon family values. D. T. Duke. Duchess. All have dreams and schemes. Each has a future mapped out for me... but what did they have planned for Catra? Read on and see. Say, wifey, what were *you* up to while all this was unfolding?'

'A wonderful question, sir. After assembling your gift package, Jewell and I took in a performance of Die Zauberflöte. An apt choice, in the circumstances. The following morning, my dear friend Huntara helped me pre-empt the plans others may have laid for you and me, both inside London and beyond.'

'Gosh, Mrs. Meowmeow, my love, you really do think of everything!'

Chapter Notes

Content warnings apply for the below chapter only - Spoilers may be present in the warnings. This story does not include any of the four Archive Warnings topics, but does occasionally feature other topics that may require content notes.

Chapter 44 Content Warnings (CONTAINS SPOILERS):
Fainting – Narrated, brief, caused by incorrect binder usage, by narrator (no injury occurs)
Exile – Narrated, related, historic and ongoing, of major character, impacts narrator
Forced separation of romantic relationship – Narrated, related, historic and ongoing, of major character and narrator
Violent impulse – Narrated, related, brief, by narrator (no violence occurs)
Manipulating others' relationships, attempted – Narrated, related, extensive, impacts major characters and narrator

Physical violence, sword – Related, historic, brief reference (no lasting injury occurred)
Autistic Overwhelm – Narrated, present, extensive, experienced by narrator
Incorrect pronoun usage, accidental, brief, immediately corrected, towards narrator
Misgendering, accidental, brief, immediately corrected, towards narrator
Threat of outing, gender – related, present, unresolved, towards narrator
Threat of outing, sexuality – related, present, unresolved, towards narrator
Threat of outing, presumed polyamory – related, present, unresolved, towards narrator
Parental interference in personal relationships – related, present, extensive, towards major character, impact major character and narrator

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PART 5

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I awoke – and haven't I used that word more often in our little ditty than I've had breakfasts?! – with Double-Trubel bent over my chest, their hand pressed to the veiny expressway of my wrist.

'Sir de l'Horde! I have *NEVER* been *more* SORRY, darling!! I--- Adora, I--- just--- assumed---'

‘That I’ve got the secret hots for Glitterbug?’

‘Oh, Horde, *no*!’ Trubel-Brightmoon looked all at once scandalised and mournful, fretful and earnest. ‘My error was to believe that *you* – a fellow shapeshifter – would simply *morph* your way to a congruent chest.’

‘I wish,’ said I, entirely accurately, while fervently wishing that wishes could be wished true. ‘No… no. I told you, it doesn’t work like that. I can be Adora or I can be She-Ra.’

‘Soooo… *darling*… Would it be MUCH toooooo insensitive to ask…?’

‘I’m binding, yes.’

‘Then I’m afraid it reeeaaallllyy ought to come off until you’ve recovered.’ I winced at them, and they returned the lemon-sucking look that might be empathy, or sympathy, or – in this very particular scenario – both. ‘I know – I *am* sorry. Believe me, Adora, I would NEVER have considered the boat stunt if I’d thought for one second---’

A tangle of aggrieved indignation harked through me, which was, in all probability, a good sign, but reached me as a very angry one.

‘Physical injury, that’s the line, is it? You can scare me out of my wits, tamper with my relationship, torture my girlfriend and, what, drape an apparition-opprobrium of your own flesh-and-blood all over me, but a hurty chest is the step too far?’

‘Yes – No – *Hfffmmpph* – It’s more *COMPLICATED* than you can see right now.’

Jerking myself upright, tangling the clasps undone, I let Boyshform hang limp and breathed in rage.

‘Then simplify it.’

Double-Trubel nodded, barely, released themself from me and descended daintily on fresh, flower-strewn bit of riverbank, zig-zagging their legs out to the side and clicking their knees together, smoothing their skirts with infinitesimal care. They took a deep breath and exhaled a confession:

‘My cousin is quite madly in love with you.’

‘I know.’

Everything the Marquioness had so carefully arranged came crashing down around them. Their mocking mask – already wavering – fell full away. For two fantastic and terrible seconds, they looked at me so clearly I could see straight back into them.

Their lungs sagged out a moan – and it sounded *emptied*. That sound. It was real. And Double-Trubel couldn't let it stand. Their eyes sharpened; their lolling jaw snapped shut. The mask was back.

'*Ooooooohhhh!!*' They flicked their chin off one knitted knuckle to the other with oleaginous, careful glee. 'She believes you're *entirely* unaware – what a *DELIGHTFUL* surprise that you're not… Sir Adora, I *knew* you wouldn't disappoint!'

'So why bother with the boat ride?'

'Becaaauuusse---' the Marquioness looked suddenly bored, '--- Sparkles won't SAY it. She expects you to just… *fall* into her lap, no work required. I agreed to hurry the process along – *for a price*.'

'Let me guess. A rebuilt Birkin Blower?'

'Oh, darling Adora, *NO.* They're so last year. She's buying me the new Speed Six.'

'Right. Just so we're clear. You exiled Catra for a **car**?!'

'Tut! Don't be so *common* about it. This isn't some basic automobile: it's a *Bentley*, darling!!'

‘Why are you so afraid to **ever** have **any** real feelings AT ALL?!?’

Trubel-Brightmoon sighed, hazily. ‘Heroines, villainy, they’re *such* monochrome concepts…’

‘And you’re going to tell me “real life” is shades of grey?’

‘Heavens no, Adora! My existence bathes in glorious technicolour, thank you. I know what *I* think is right and what *I* think is wrong – and I stick to it – and who cares what the world says back?’

Moral grandstanding is one congealing plate of kedgeree coming from such a cold-hearted scoundrel. Put another way, there comes a moment when the gadabout cad turns bounder, and I’d had my fill. Stumbling to my feet, I grasped the blade at my hip with the unerring conviction that hollers, “For the Honour of---”

‘Wait, wait, WAIT! Cool it, kitten’s whiskers. *Before* you cut my head off, darling, allow me to give you a worked example. To wit: I REALLY wasn’t pleased when the Post Office incident put me out of my race before it began, yes, and helping dear old *cuz* seemed like the best way to make good the loss, so my agreeing to speak with you was – shall we say – a *healthy* bit of pragmatism.

‘But I NEVER intended to convince you to DATE her. Adora, my characterisation was *exactingly* accurate, if I do say so myself, because I will *not* lie to you. Our spirits are too alike. Honey, dating Sparkles would be a *NIGHTMARE* I couldn’t possibly

recommend. *Ergo*, I only swore to make her feelings clear, *not* to get you to act on them.'

'And Catra?'

'If *I* hadn't stuck the knife in, Sparkles would have had her out by sundown *anyway*. You know how her Ladyship feels; you can't possibly deny that's where this was always going. So why not make SOME good of the inevitable? This way, I get my car – nothing else material changes – and I free up the funds to really *PURSUE* my ethics. Adora---' They held me back as we loitered on the cusp of the stables. '---Glimmer told me how your relatives control your money. Which means, shamefully, they suppress you, a situation I will not let stand. So. *Darling*. Should you ever want that weight off your chest for good, tell me. I'll pay for your top surgery.'

And the Marquioness – this lying, cheating, vengeful, concealing, game-playing rum heel – fixed me with a look so truly, genuinely understanding it made me doubt. Off I tottered to the horses and Duke Brightmoon's hearty handshake, befuddled as a lamppost in a vaudeville routine.

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'Upsie-dupsie!' the man who wanted to be merely Micah boomed. 'To the bravest go the spoils, good chap. Ha-HA! Horses smell fear faster than they taste their own feedbag but take the reins in hand and you'll have a friend for life. Isn't that right, Mysty?'
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His merle-flecked mare whinnied assent so bally fervent you'd swear the pair were joined at the brainstem. Less luck struck the de l'Horde camp. Five times I put a foot in its stirrup – and five times the horse wriggled its rump at just the right moment to send me stumble-hopping. I'd spent a lifetime studying equestrian theory, but my practical exam was fast turning into pony plop. I opened my fragile horsey heart to this snow white steed and what did he do? He clip-clopped all over it.

If Catra had been here, like Scorpia was for Perfs, I'd have succumbed right there and then to the almighty temptation to sob on her shoulder. My lips would whisper, "Why is it all so bally hard? Why can't we be happy? Why can't I just love you?" And she would purr back something brave or reassuring. And somehow, together, we'd find the answer that kept evading us. It'd be the end, and we would win.

Chin up, de l'Horde. That wasn't happening. Our final act still waited in the wings, the ticket burning in my shirt pocket. She was coming. But not yet. Today needed other answers and what better fixative than the ancient magic of Welsh rainbows or some such? Greyskulling hard and fast, I was up and on in a leap, which called for nods at Horsey and His Grace alike.

Sure, boasted my jaunty jawline, *I, an accomplished equestrian, have done this a thousand times before!* What to tell you, dear reader, but that I was back on my balderdash? Pleasure ponies excepted, I'd ridden horseback, oh, about a thousand times less than my expression implied. Aunt Shadowtha strenuously disapproved, you see, and my boarding schools hadn't come with their own stables.

Well! No longer was my dream denied! As Micah scorched a path across his considerable estate and down onto the Chase – which, come to think of it, still largely counted as his estate – my hands melded to the reins, my tootsies to their jangling holds. We murmured a ping-pong match of unparalleled connection, Horsey and me: walked with calm fluidity; put on our fanciest game faces at a trot; bounced and jounced and joyfully reverberated when we dashed into a canter for mile upon sandy mile of deserted forest.

My hand softly clutching his mane, his back shaking and shimmering his every thought and move and feeling back into me, Horsey and de l'Horde were set to constant, crackling transmit and receive – and it was glorious. I loved it, every bit as much as my family feared I would. The novels were right: a knight needed her loyal steed, and I had found mine.

Waves frothed from Horsey's hooves along the waterfront; our heads, drenched in shadows, tracked hundreds of feet beneath the riches of thick, endless evergreens. I could go on. I *would* go on, maybe forever. Enchanted vistas stretched ahead – an ideal world without fences or borders – and we charged at them… only to trip over Duke Brightmoon's booming garden fence.

'Terrible shame your missus couldn't come! Lovers' tiff, was it, kiddo? Ha-ha!! I've had a fair few of THOSE in my time and I'll tell you this: a good woman always comes round to her righteous chap in the end.' Guiding our horses to a halt, Micah slapped me sportingly across the shoulder blade. 'Own up to your wrongs, don't let her feel too bad about hers and you'll be tangoing by teatime, guaranteed!'

‘I really don’t think we will,’ I murmured.

‘Heavy one, eh? Tough break, kiddo. Hope you haven’t done anything to besmirch her honour – I want the right and proper sort around my Moonbug.’

‘Actually, sir, your daughter is why she’s gone. Glimmer sent Catra away.’

‘Oh,’ said Micah, then, ‘Oh,’ before embarking on a perilously long period of saying nothing at all. Mysta turned tail and Horsey dropped in behind, their clippity-clop underscored by fatherly lamentation. ‘I was afraid this might happen… Glimmer isn’t too good at sharing, you understand? Not that I’d change her for the world… But you really do love her, don’t you, chap? Well – Ha-HA! They don’t teach you this in the parenting books… There’s got to be a way… The happiness of my little girl comes first – always! But the doesn’t mean we can cast your woman aside… Hmm… HMM…’

Duke Brightmoon was a very vocal thinker. He was an awful lot louder when he turned back to me, his pondering done. ‘Ah-ha! Kiddo, I’ve got it! Glimmer likes you – you like Catra – so you date both of them!’

This was not the proud Etherian tradition I’d been brought up to revere, nor was such a concept anything a Duke might ever be imagined to support. It--- it was inconceivable.

‘For the Honour of Greyskull!’ I blurted, shocked, reeling, clinging to my horse. ‘*FOR THE HONOUR OF GREYSKULL!!*’

The light raced through me, faster than ever, and – well – there’s no delicate way to put this… The ancient She-Raic forces exploded *into* Horsey.

‘Alright, Adora! Way to go – you brought me into your real world!’

‘WHAAA??’

‘I not make myself clear, sport? Date your Catra woman, but also date my darling daughter. A fine fellow like you has my full support!’

‘WHAAA??’

‘Adora, ADORA! Here come my wings – poof! poof! – and… there… goes… my HORN!’

‘WHAAA??’

‘Give it a year or two, Adora, and you’ll get the wedding bells ringing. You know, sport, I’ll pay for both ceremonies. Tell your

Lady Catra she doesn't need to scrimp or save – I won't begrudge any expense. She needs to feel like a princess too!'

'WHAAA??'

'Can I--- Hello. Hellllooooooo… *Yes*! I can talk! Swift Wind is in the building.'

'WHAAA??'

'Naturally, we'll build Catra another house on the estate. No-one said your lovebirds have to share a nest.'

'WHAAA???'

'La. LA. Hummm… Hm. La-la-la-LA-la-la-la. Yes, Adora! It's not just talking. I can… SIIIIINNNNNNGGG!'

'WHAAA???'

'Won't be the first time I've done that for family. Ever hear about my sister, sport? Glimmer's aunt. Ha-ha-HA! Finest woman you could hope to meet, that's our Cassie! So much so that two separate ladies asked for her hand – and now she's Mrs. Cassandra Tasp-Peller. Rings galore but she's the happiest lass

going. You'll see when I introduce you – stars all-but whirl around her head and what!'

'WHAAA???'

'Hey, Adora? Excuse me? Adora? Is this a good time for me to get in on the conversation?'

'I'm really not sure---'

'Afraid of a little trouble in paradise, eh, Adora? Ha-ha! Cassie fretted about the same – and I'll tell you what I told her! Love conquers all! The heart wants what it wants! Chase your happiness, all three of you! Life's too short and what! Why talk about anything but love?'

'Um. Err. Well, your Grace, there's quite a bit more to consider---'

'Like COMMUNISM! Micah, Micah! It's me, your horse. Have you ever considered how you're self-serving capitalist scum pillaging nature and people as you twist the planet to your own sick, selfish ends? As Emma Goldman once said---'

'I think that's enough about Ms. Goldman, Swiftie.'

‘One of your exes? No need to be embarrassed – just so long as you treated her with same honour and kindness I know you’ll show my baby girl!’

‘Yes--- But---’

‘Adora! I never knew you dated a famous bisexual anarchist. Take it from a horse, babe. That’s HOT.’

‘No, Swift Wind, I didn’t---’

‘Chatty lad, that horse of yours. Ha-ha! And what an attitude! He’s never been like that before.’

‘Yes. Quite. I’ve a sneaking suspicion my being the She-Ra has something to do with it.’

‘Err, except my politics, babe. Those are my own. Micah – here are my demands. Liberate Cannock Chase and its animals… redistribute your wealth across the local villages… universal brassic income… pay reparations for---’

‘HA! You sound just like good Sir Adora here did yesterday!’

Like no many knights before me, I'd been cut out of the conversation between a senior noble and my feisty, dependable, anti-authoritarian steed. Not for the first time, I wished I had a handbook on how to be She-Ra. And another explaining my way to an authentic Adora. Beneath and alongside me, the Lords sparred with the Labour movement.

'Ha-*ha*! Don't I already do enough to keep my locals happy? How often do you meet a Duke giving as much as me? I pay well, you know, up at the house. Offer bonuses and tips. And how do you think the village schools get funded? We even set up scholarships for the bright ones! Ha-HA! New doctors and engineers don't appear out of the ether, do they, my foalish fellow? Some of us still BELIEVE in this great country – and I put my money where my mouth is! The fête and the Christmas Ball don't come cheap but I don't begrudge a penny!! Ha-ha-HA! Enough of this red rot and let's get back to something we can all agree on: Adora!'

'Who is *the She-Ra* and will bring everything you cling to crashing down to make a better tomorrow, babe. Action, Equality, Apples for All!'

'Bit dramatic that, ha-ha-ha! I'm sure kiddo here will usher in a new era at Shugborough but – good gravy – I welcome it! Fresh blood keeps the heart pumping! Whatever it takes to make my Moonbug happy! YES SIR!!'

'About---' I gestured every which way around me, the very model of a legal clerk scrabbling for case notes as their freshly-proofed pile flies away on an open-window breeze, '---about all of this. Can we just take a breather? Stop us getting off on the wrong foot?'

‘Excellent idea, Sir Adora! Once again, your inner chivalry and sense of right shine through. Look at us rabbiting on out here, when we could be consulting the woman who matters most of all. Back to Shugborough, post-haste! *Sha*!’

Duke Brightmoon ended his speech with a hefty slap across my back, and a heftier one for his horse. Off we went at a gallop, thundering with uneasy trepidation of what or whom might greet me at the end of the trail.

‘Great job, Adora,’ Swiftie spluttered as we gave chase. ‘Take ‘em down from the inside. Very sneaky and totally Swift Wind approved. Destroy the Brightmoons! Atta babe!!’

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Duchess Angella Brightmoon impaled her long, thin French omelette with a long, thin fork, and slit it with a long, thin knife, working her long, thin fingers with long, thin precision. I sat opposite, splayed across a velvet confection formed almost entirely from fuzz and impracticality. At the nine to our twelve and six, her husband, Micah, drew himself jovially toward the circular marble table, which swam with the uncalorific accoutrements of a wealthy woman’s luncheon. Cucumber was heavily in attendance.

Duke Micah Brightmoon ran a casual hand through his hair and smiled encouragingly my way. He wore the musky-muddy detritus of our ride better than I did. His flecked and enhanced; mine
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smeared against the concerningly expensive everything. But I had my Boyshform back together, so I can't say I felt too upset about my appearance. I was thinking about it quite a lot less than earlier, actually, which was just as well, since I needed every last one of my mental faculties to even approach the matriarch silhouetted against the tri-part windows and chewing her egg whites with unconcealed threat.

'*Cara mia*,' Micah began, with a hearty laugh that eclipsed his plate of skinless chicken escalope, 'the time is come to discuss our gorgeous Glimmer and Sir Adora here---'

The Duchess cut straight past her husband in a silverware flicker, besetting me with a long, thin grimace.

'*You are the She-Ra.*'

'Maybe she is, cookie-schmukums, maybe she's not,' the Duke raised one giant palm to declare. 'What matters is she's Adora---'

'Miss de l'Horde, you have already disarrayed my family. As the She-Ra, you now intend to destroy it.' She placed her cutlery together with polite finality. '*I shall not allow it.* Speak. What do you have to say for yourself?'

What didn't I have to declare? The whole rotten business was a scrambled pile of misapprehensions, each so tangled in the next that I hardly knew how to pull out any single, particular thread, let

alone tie said string up into a nice enough bow for the kind of near-deity who called the Horde Prime Minister a personal friend. I pondered. She stared at me. Both halves of Staffordshire's torquiest power couple did, which only reminded me that I was fast stumbling into a similar pairing myself. The walls were closing in. Since we were sitting in breakfast nook, they didn't have far to go.

'Sorry.'

The word percolated about the place. It had tripped from my lips. Across the table, the Duchess put down her lemon water and very slightly arched a long, thin eyebrow. I took this as encouragement to continue.

'Your Grace, I came here to apologise, from the bottom of my heart, for what happened with Glimmer at the regatta. Believe me, if I had it my way, I'd go back and stop the whole thing before it started. I wouldn't even look at the rowing boat.'

'Don't you see, *cara mia*? She's a good kid---' Micah slammed my knee with the kind of force that causes internal bleeding, pushing me to wince a smile back, '---and Moonbug absolutely *adores* her. Doesn't our darling daughter deserve to get what she wants?'

'The de l'Horde girl almost *killed* you, *mon chér*. I could have *lost* you. How can you sit here and champion her?'

Gosh, there was a lot of she-ing and her-ing flying about. Did I need a little prompt to carry around, to help people get my words right? And what might one call such a thing? A pronoun… pin?

'Beg pardon, your Grace, but I use "they" as well as "she" and I'm not a girl, though I am a Lesbian.'

'Thank you,' the Duchess replied, surprisingly, 'I shall take note of it … Micah, *they* were two seconds from slitting your throat!'

'Bwah-ha! All in a day's sport, my dearest! They didn't mean any harm by it. That was the She-Ra talking, wasn't it, kiddo?'

I nodded and watched this… healthy marital debate unfold. From where I was sitting, it was both quite affirming and very concerning.

'Mon chér! That is *worse*. They aren't in control of their power.'

'Who is at that age, eh? Glimmer, Adora, all the rest of those kids – they are who they are and they feel how they feel. Who are we to stop them?'

'We are our daughter's *parents*, Micah! De l'Horde, does your ward know you're here?'

‘Auntie? Why, yes! She thought it was a capital idea.’

‘She didn’t plan it herself?’

‘No at all! You can thank my girlfriend for that.’

‘*Who?*’

‘The Lady Catra. Fine figure of a woman,’ the Duke added helpfully.

But Duchess Brightmoon only repeated, ‘*Who??*’ It shot out in a sharpened, rising intonation this time.

‘Ah!’ I replied. ‘I see! You weren’t properly introduced to her. That’s entirely my fault, your Grace. Let me clear it up for you. The Lady Catra and Meowmeow, my gentlewoman’s gentlewoman, are one and the same.’

A sage nod sealed this information – or so I thought. Duchess Angella fell silent for one relieving moment then, like a mechanical owl, burst back to life with another clockwork: ‘*Who??*’

‘*Cara mia*, the girl who won the egg-and-spoon race.’

Placing both hands very neatly in her lap, the Duchess said, ‘I see.’

To make sure she really did, I added one final clarifier. ‘I love her.’

‘And love is what we’re here to talk about! What matters more, my turtle dove? Our precious little Moonbug loves Adora here. Heart and mind! Body and soul! And I’m positive Adora here feels the same!’

‘Actually… I… You see… Glimmer is very important to me and… now that I think about it, were those dates? Cripes! I think they were. We’ve certainly kissed a bunch.’

Oh, for a brain and a mouth that can keep my thoughtstreams safely on the inside. Micah was beaming at me.

‘There you have it – young love! Only, these kiddos, they’re not so young anymore. It got me thinking. We know what Glimmer wants – and I NEVER tell my baby girl no, not if I can help it! She and Adora are a great fit. Adora and Catra are besotted. Ergo, *cara mia*, don’t you think we should help these lovebird pairs get married??!’

The Duchess did not answer the Duke directly. Her entire attention honed on me.

‘*Does your Aunt know you intend to wed my only daughter?*’

‘No, becau---’

‘*Is she aware that you’re also dating your valet?*’

‘Not exactly. The la---’

‘*How much have you told her about being the She-Ra?*’

‘Technically? Nothing, as of yet.’

The long, thin humph the Duchess now let loose was every bit as dreadful as a scream, and likely as close to one as she ever got. The Duke took her hand in infinite, sympathetic understanding. How fervently I wished there was someone present to take mine, so long as that woman wasn’t Lady Brightmoon. That friendship was getting complicated enough already.

‘*You wish to enter our family when you can’t be honest with your own. Micah, summon a car. Shadowtha de l’Horde and we have much to discuss.*’

With a hushed furniture swish and call for servants, a tight "Good day" and a "Hang in there, kiddo!" encouragement, the elder Brightmoons traded Shugborough Hall for Wimpole Street, Marylebone. Until they came back, Glimmer ruled the roost. Neither of these facts was even remotely comforting.

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Chapter 45

Chapter Summary

'Behold a Glimmer of remorse, readers. If only she wasn't accompanied by more than a glimmer of... everything else that characterises my experiences with Lady Brightmoon. She's lucky I wasn't there. I'm not a violent woman. Usually. But the claws would have been *out*. That's my *spousewife* she was terrorising.'

'Woah, wildcat, babe, save the righteous anger for Horde Prime!! The hour has come, you two, so saddle up. Time to show that moody sorta-monarch and his acolytes what Lady Catra Applesauce Meowmeow and Sir Adora de la Meow-Ra are made of!!'

'Err, are you not, like, *forgetting* something?'

'Oh, yeah, thanks Mermista! Adora masturbates again this chapter! It's rated Mature! SWIFT WIND AWWWAAAYYY!!!'

'No! I meant--- Eurgh--- About leaving me here and junk? Whatever. Next chapter it's FINALLY all about me.'

Chapter Notes

Content warnings apply for the below chapter only - Spoilers may be present in the warnings. This story does not include any of the four Archive Warnings topics, but does occasionally feature other topics that may require content notes. This chapter is rated Mature due to a brief masturbation sequence.

Chapter 45 Content Warnings (CONTAINS SPOILERS):
Touching, no consent sought – Narrated, extensive, towards narrator
Genital proximity, no consent sought – Narrated, extensive, towards narrator

Sexualised comments, no consent sought – Narrated and related, towards narrator
Trans character coerced into wearing non-congruent clothing – Related, towards narrator (apology follows)
Gender dysphoria – Narrated, experienced by narrator
Denial of trans character's expression – Related, towards narrator (apology follows)
Coercing trans character to remove transition aid, attempted – Related, trans character refuses to remove binder, towards narrator (apology to trans character follows)
Cis mourning pushes out trans joy – Narrated and related, towards narrator
Drug use, assumed – Related, brief (no drug use occurs)
Non-consensual viewing of nudes – Related, brief, towards major character (narrator attempts to stop) (full apology follows)
Justification of harmful actions – Related, by harmful character and on behalf of harmful character, impacts narrator

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PART 6

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On learning her parents had flown their gilded coop, Glimmer reacted in the most Glimmer way possible. She called a party. And she made me her date. I was in my rooms when it happened, busily… um… let's say *remembering* Catra. For the fourth time that afternoon. They really were exceptional photographs. Very---*artistic*. I'd liberated my belongings – repatriated thanks to Lady P – and found my gentlewoman's gentlewoman's magenta satin

shirt tucked safely inside my cases. The shirt Catra wore when we met. I wrapped it round me and swaddled myself under the covers. It still smelled of her. Irresistible.

Tip-tu-TAP-TAP-TAP went the door – which was terribly rude of it.

'Come back later! I'm a bit busy… err… going to win in the end.'

'Ohmigosh, *Dory*?!? Are you *shitting* me? You are *NOT* about to keep me waiting – not when I've just picked out what you're wearing tonight! Come on! Let me innnnnnnn!! I want you to see it. *Now*.'

'Five minutes?'

'You've been avoiding me allllllllll daaayyyyyy!! And that's *so boring*. Especially when I've got *SO* much for us to be doing together.'

'Quit it, Glimmer.'

'Three minutes. Or I get the master key. I'm wai-*ting*!!'

Really. Is it too much to ask to steal a fistful of finger-blasted minutes to masturbate over one's star-crossed girlfriend without

being interrupted by some over-sexed Brightmoon? Honestly. This apartment was like boarding school all over again. My minutes three-ways elapsed and the Catrine card case disappeared beneath the pillows, just in time for the Countess Dryl to burst thoughtlessly into her guest suite, brandishing twin dress bags like heavy artillery.

She clicked them into a cannon of a garderobe, threw a package I very much did not like the look of at a Chinoiserie sideboard, heedless of the thumping risk to its intricate gilding, then launched herself wholesale onto the bed, nestling face-mercifully-up between my hips, and thrust a pile of papers into my countenance. *Vogue*, June 7, 1930.

Glimmer was a disciple of *Vogue*. Living inside her orbit these past few years, I couldn't fail to learn a little about the iconically flickable fashion title. You could call me a disciple of a disciple, if you will, like those fellows who dutifully jotted out the gospels. During my devotions, I'd learned that, for a scanty 35 cents an issue, the *Vogue* faithful were purchasing a pamphlet chiefly concerned with feminine power, eye-wateringly expensive gowns, and how the purchase of the latter granted a lady indisputable access to the former.

Not really my cup of tea, in all honesty. But those paintings and pen-and-inks they ran, of tall, spare, severe women glowering and showing off their collarbones? I had no objections to those. None at all. But Catra was prettier.

'Get to the features!' mewled the woman rolling around between my thighs. Her jerks and jabs made me wish I'd put a pillow on

my lap and in her way. Without placing too fine a point on it, I was turning quite… sensitive down there.

'God-*damn* Adora, *someone's* feeling hot!'

'*Why Not Visit the USSR?*' I croaked back.

'Uh. Not that one. *Obviously*.'

'*A Guide to Chic Maternity Clothes*?'

'No! Go to page 65 – *PARIS! In its New Clothes!*'

No especial expert was needed to figure out this was the likely preamble to whatever fresh terror dwelt in the garment bags.

'The half-forgotten feminine attributes are ours for the taking---' Glimmer squeezed at my waist. 'We can by young and pretty, brilliant and alluring---' She stroked and cupped my chin. Then she turned it. 'And the world will know. Will know *us*, Dory.' She trembled into my eyes and stopped just short of kissing me. 'Open the bags,' she instructed, '*please*. Try them on. For me.'

Talk about a rock and a hard place, but I had even less desire to lock lips with the "friend" who'd exiled my partner – my *girlfriend*

– without getting to know her, so I thudded dutifully over to the dresser. The first gown was a non-starter: metallic gauze, apparently mailed direct from Paris at great expense. I wondered how much it might cost to ship it back.

Whatever the price, I'd gladly pay it. The horrid thing clung and curved and accentuated, glittering three or more exaggerated, feminine shades under the artificial lights. On Catra, it would've been a dream. Straddling my shoulders, it was a nightmare. One where I got slowly, surely swallowed by a python. Which is also exactly what it looked like.

So dress two it would be: a black lace evening number that draped almost all the way to the floor, oozing with an attitude that stridently implied funerals were the new height of fashion. Though it "sculpted" my hips – Glimmer's words, not mine – at least the bodice ran loose enough to team up with my Boyshform and keep everything appropriately flat. I twirled, joylessly. If I absolutely had to wear a dress, I suppose this was – fine.

Glitterbug whipped away the dressed for the big reveal. In a whirling, swirling instant, she snapped diamonds to my neck and shackled gold across my wrists, drowned me in floral mists and smeared my eyes in kohl, all *en route* to one of an unnecessarily large number of floor-length mirrors.

'Ta-DA!! You chose the 1930 Chanel, Adora?! I fucking *knew* you had good taste! Ohmigosh, Dory, you look good enough to eat. Good enough to date. I'd date you, Adora. *Adora*. I'd *date* you.'

‘I heard you, Glimmer.’

‘Fuck-a-duck! Wouldn’t it be so *bad* if we went to the party together?! Like--- *together* together?? So out there, right?! Everyone would think we were girlfriends. *Ohmigosh*! We’d be the talk of the evening. Should we do it? We should totally do it. Now your clingy fucking *valet* isn’t here to stop us, we can just---’ she slowed down to stroke me, ‘---dooooo ittttttt… Know what I mean?! Huh? *HUH*?! … Wait. Dory. What’s that *thing* you’re wearing?’

Oh, yes, I’ve forgotten to mention, as I then forgot to remember, that this particular Chanel had one teensy, tiny, drafty, giant shortcoming: someone had forgotten to sew on the back.

‘That’s my binder.’

‘You *don’t* bind!’

‘Evidentially, I do.’

‘But, Dory, it *ruins* the lines! If you *HAVE* to wear a bra, I bought you a Maidenform. It’s *definitely* your size. You’ll love it. It makes your girls look bigger *and* rounder. How great is *that*? You’re so welcome!’

‘Oh. No, thank you. That’s pretty much the opposite of what I’m going for.’

‘Can’t you at least take the binder off? It. Ruins. The. Lines.’

‘*Glimmer*! No. I’m not taking off my Boyshform.’

Glimmer went to sit on the bed and do some crying. I felt pretty rotten myself. She laid down, tucked an arm under the pillows and… wait… giddy goodness… *that* needed nipping in the bud! Over I tottered, fast as these accursed high heels would let me, as Lady Brightmoon conjured the card case from its hidey place.

‘Adora?! Someone’s been *naughty*… What is it? Snuff? Blow? Speedball? Ohmigosh, it’s *NOT*?! Adora. Is it *heroin*?!?’

‘Er, no, none of those, my Lady. But I really do need you to put it down, *right now*. I made a promise.’

‘Awh, come on, Dory! One little peek, okay? I’m just *DYING* to know your secret vice.’

I lunged at the case. It was no use. In this damned dress, I was a cannonball firing through a wedding cake. I’d get there, but not quickly. And with a maximum of mess. *Click*. Glimmer worried the clasp and the case swung open.

‘*Dory*…’ she encanted. ‘Dory – FUCK! ***FUCK***!! Your valet is ***HOT***!!!’

‘**PUT THOSE BACK**! Glimmer, put those back, I swear to Horde. Those are **NOT** yours to look at.’

To my infinite and eternal surprise, she did. No muss, no fuss, no backchat. Lady Brightmoon carefully arranged the images back into their slots and handed me the case. I received them dumbstruck. Glimmer dismounted my mattress without making eye contact or saying another word. Traipsing around the bed, she picked up that horrible “enhancing” brassiere and bowed slightly, shaking her head. And off she walked, out the room and away, clicking the door shut behind her.

In that awful instant, I was prepared for the Countess to do quite a number of different things, but I wasn’t ready for her to do… *that*. I didn’t even know how to process it. How to even start. So I went and procured Bowregard, who’d taken some earlier advice of mine and decked himself out in a very fetching jewel purple tuxedo jacket.

‘Oh, hey! Boyshform – that’s a great brand!’

‘Thaks, Bow. I--- Did I tell you I’m using “they” as well as “she” now? And I’m a Lesbian, but not a woman.’

‘Congrats, Adora! Permission to hug?’

Granted, I’m not much one for a squeeze, but this time a cuddle seemed pretty darn fitting.

‘It makes me SO happy to see you being you, Adora. Because I love you. Because… you’re family.’

‘Bowregard! I’ve gave you permission to hug me – not to make me cry!!’ I wiped a tear out the corner of one eye. But a happy one. ‘I love you too.’

‘You know you could have just asked for my old binders, if you want them?’

I did not, but I did know a lot about the incredibly frantic Glimmer situation, which I took great pains to explain.

‘So,’ I concluded several minutes later, ‘there it is. What do you reckon?’

‘Okay. Adora. You know that Glimmer loves you, right? Not love like a friend, the way I do, but loves you romantically and--- erm---- and---’ Bow suddenly looked very flushed, ‘---and--- *sexually*.’

‘I had an inkling.’

‘For how long? Have you just been going ALONG with it?!’

‘Since Major Juliet let slip that Glimmer wanted to make me the next Duke Brightmoon. That was yesterday afternoon.’

‘*Oh*. Just before she got rid of Catra.’

‘Yeah.’

‘Oof… Okay, okay. Here’s how I see it, Adora. Glitterbug has been pining over you ahm… pretty much from the first moment she met you, if I’m being honest. She has NOT been subtle whenever she talked to me about it. And she has talked about you a LOT.’

‘And you never thought to tell me, old sport? Shouldn’t a chap be made aware of the ladies who do and do not think they’re gravy, so to speak?’

Bow squirmed like a fish, on a line, having an existential crisis, with a similar aversion to taking on air. Eventually, his brow prickled and his ears started to twitch. I’m no doctor but that didn’t look great. Using every last bit of my very unenviable medical knowledge, I patted him square on the back. Hard. He gasped and things went back to normal, at least as far as his breathing was concerned. The slumping to the floor was less

ordinary, the tears not unexpected, and the arms wrapped around my lower legs very unwelcome indeed.

'I say,' said I, thinking that was enough of that. 'That's enough of that.'

Bow sobbed in reply, 'But… Adora… I… am… SO… sorry… I've… been… a… BAD… friend! Glimmer… made… me… pinky… promise. Oh… NO!! Now… I've… told… you… and… been… a… bad… friend… to… her… too… That's it! That's IT! I'm… the… WORST… friend… **EVER**!!!'

What patent rot! The kind of gent who helps a chum comb an entire forest in pursuit of said chum's crush, having only met the potentially-amorous Lady on the briefest and most boisterous of levels, can not ever, on any level, be considered a bad friend. I told him as much, which had the welcome side effect of drying his eyes. Seeing no reason to stop while the going was good, I continued towards a recently-realised revelation: Bow's positions here was a lot like my own.

While I handled the delicate balance between firebrand friend and captivating crush, Bow had battled – what? – *years* of maintaining his two closest and most mutual buddyships without betraying, nay wounding, either friend with news of a secret attraction – that wasn't even his own! My nerves were all-but shot already; I couldn't begin to imagine how Bowregard was facing down his umpteenth month of this tension tumble without making like a pressure cooker. It would have destroyed a lesser man. But Bow was no lesser man!

‘Okay. Like I was saying---’ he slapped his hands on his own legs, thank goodness, as we clambered back onto topic, ‘---Glimmer REAALLLLLYY likes you, Adora, and she always thought you’d just… start liking her back, you know, if you spent enough time together. So when she see you here with *Catra*…’

‘She sees that another woman has got what she wants…’

‘More than anything else in the world. And I don’t think Glimmer’s a bad person. Okay, she does REALLY questionable things – especially over these last couple of days – but there’s a reason we’re still friends?’

‘Was that meant to come out as a question?’

‘No?? I mean, she is very… sensitive, right? I think she’s not taking you having a girlfriend well because it proves she can’t “win” you by inaction – that she had to DO something if she wanted a chance of dating you.’

‘Which obviously meant abandoning Catra on a hill, attempted murder by meringue, oh, and treating me like a fairground prize? Instead of just, I don’t know, *asking me out*?’

‘Hey, HEY, I never said she did the right things. She REALLY didn’t.’

‘But how does this play into her leaving my room just now?’

Bow stroked his beard. It was definitely getting thicker. Did I want a beard? Hmm. Perhaps not. He ventured on:

‘Okay – she saw something she shouldn’t. What was it?’

‘A private gift. From Catra.’

‘But was WAS it, Adora?’

‘It was *private*, Bow.’

‘Oh? … OH! … Adora, you saucy minx! Hmm. So. Maybe Glimmer is embarrassed? Maybe she didn’t set out to do the wrong thing – because who does? Or maybe the private gift reminds her of something she doesn’t want to know…’

We didn’t wait long to find out. A half-ashamed knock tinkled at the door – a greeting party for a very small voice.

‘Adora – I’m sorry I ran off. I’m sorry for what I did. Could I come in to apologise? If that’s okay? Please?’

She could, I decided. She stood there, shamefaced, her ankles eaten by an especially expensive rug.

'I didn't mean to see those photographs. I wish I hadn't, Dory. I've--- I've gone too far. I crossed a line. I'm so *mad* at myself. And I'm sorry about the binder too. If that's you, that's you, and I should support it. So I do. You look really good. It's just… I picked that dress out especially for you and I'd really like it if you still wore it tonight. Only if you're still coming. Only if you're okay with that.'

'I'll think about it.'

'There's one more thing, Adora…' She wobbled red and pink and steaming and melting and deceptively sweet, like a jelly on an Aga. 'I've liked you for a long time. A *really* long time. *Girlfriend* liked you. I told Bow, and I should've told you, and I'm sorry I didn't until now. But better late than never, amirite? Ha… … … … ha. *Fuck*. This is awkward. I knew it would be! After all those *stupid* things I did… Why are you *LIKE* this, me??!? Stupid, *STUPID* Glimmer!!'

She circled to the back of the room, tracing round and round, sticking her balled-up fists against her head. '*WHY* couldn't you have done this *years* ago?! … You've had so Horde-damn-shit-fuck-cunt-puddling-long! … And you pick the time when she's *just* got herself a fucking *girlfriend*?? … A girlfriend who just *had* to come across *SOOOOO* clever and thoughtful and sensitive and… just… *everything*?? *THAT'S* when you stepped into the ring?! *WHAT THE ACTUAL* ***FUCK*** *IS* ***WRONG*** *WITH YOU??!?*'

Bow and I exchanged increasingly concerned glances.

'*Okay*!' she finally announced. 'Okay. *Adora*: I am in *LOVE.* With you. I want to date you. I want to be your girlfriend.'

'I **have** a girlfriend. Catra, remember? You **banished** her.'

'I know, *I know*… But I literally just got a telegram. And Daddy says you'll marry me *and* Meo--- *Catra*. Both of us. Separately. And--- and--- That's *okay*. I'd do that. I'd do that, for *you*, Dory. That's how much I love you and… hmpfh… *respect* her. So! What do you stay we start tonight?'

'And just **how** do we do that without Catra here?'

'I'll send a car for her, first thing tomorrow, I promise. I swear. I'd give you anything. So, please, Adora, I'm *begging* you, please, come with me tonight?'

I looked over, deciding. Bow somehow managed to nod and shake his head at precisely the same time. *Helpful.* Glimmer extended a gloved hand. I smiled. We were doing this – but the "we" was me and Catra. I grasped the Brightmoon grip, kissed the Brightmoon knuckles. She had *no* idea what tomorrow really had in store. I grinned even deeper. Little did I know, we'd have to survive tonight first…

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The Mer-Mystery of Blood-Borough Hall: Part 1 - The Arrivening

Chapter Summary

'Cometh the hour, cometh the motherfucking *me*!! You better be ready to get your Mer-Mystery on - 'cause it was a dark and stormy night, the sky split like a skull under a hammer, and I had just stepped out the taxi to ascend the stairs to Shugborough Hall. What unholy terrors would I find within? Whose secrets would I reveal? Would any of those, like, hoity-toity toffs live to see the morning? Who would *I* want to kill? You're going to read on. And you're going to find out. And you're going to see that I, Mermista, am the greatest detective in the history of... EVER.'

'So sit back - do NOT relax - and enter The Mer-Mystery of Blood-Borough Hall. ... I'm, like, really good in it.'

Chapter Notes

Writer's note - This is maybe my favourite chapter of the whole novel. Enjoy!!!

Content warnings apply for the below chapter only - Spoilers may be present in the warnings. This story does not include any of the four Archive Warnings topics, but does occasionally feature other topics that may require content notes. This chapter is rated Mature due to death, dying and murder described with some physical detail.

CONTENT WARNINGS CONTAIN EXTENSIVE SPOILERS!!

Chapter 46 Content Warnings (CONTAINS SPOILERS):
Death - narrated and related, perceived and real, multiple instances, some physical details
Dying - narrated and related, perceived and real, multiple instances, some physical details

Murder - narrated and related, perceived and real, multiple instances, some physical details (actual murder acts unseen)
Blood and bleeding - narrated and related, real, some physical detail
Desecration of a corpse - related, present, brief, light physical detail (no actual corpse desecration occurs)
Faking death - narrated and related, present, some physical details
Fear of murder - narrated and related, present, extensive, continued, experienced by narrator and others
Cultural appropriation - related, present, repeated, continues despite warning by global majority character
Manipulation, by threat - related, present, towards narrator
Fighting, suggested - narrated and related, present, by narrator (no conventional violence occurs)
Classism - related, present, repeated
Status used as a weapon - related, present, repeated
Physical violence, unarmed – narrated, present, elbowing, winding (no lasting injury occurs)

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PART 7

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Skyhawk was dead, to begin with. The Red Drawing Room turned in on him. Its tinsel-trimmed walls glittered the beating of a hideous heart. Our party, with its copious cocktails and unexpected bonhomie – the latter fuelled by the former – was at its end. There lay the aviator, sprawled artistically across the chaise longue, his final breath rattling from his lungs, his fingers ossifying into claws against the velvet. Foam spilt from his lips and

frothed down, down, like an awful waterfall, until it pooled into the spilled and sticky dregs of his champagne. Skyhawk's moustaches twitched their last.

'I--- Oh no! I killed him – I was the one who gave him that drink.' Bow racked his cheeks in gaunt, soul-eating anguish. 'You have to arrest me, straight away. I'm a murderer!'

'I don't think we need to be doing that, old chap.'

'Why? Adora? **Adora**. Can She-Ra bring people back from the dead?!'

'According to the Arth-Red saga – in this *fascinating* 16th century manuscript, which I *believe* is based on a circa 1380 Welsh oral addition to the She-Raic canon – at least one previous Arth-Red resurrected multiple people who'd died in… *"unjust ways"…* Isn't that FASCINATING?!'

'Does it say how?'

Entrapta flipped through the admirably un-unctuous document, their pupils a-patter.

'Errmmm… Yah-no. No. It does not.'

‘Hmm… Let me just… FOR THE HONOUR OF GREYSKULL!! Ah, nope. No. I’m not feeling like the arbiter of life and death. Not even slightly.’

‘What a pity, Dory! You can resurrect me *any*time.’

‘Glimmer. A man is dead.’ I poked Skyhawk to prove it. ‘See. He’s very dead.’

Double-Trubel sighed their way past me, rolling their eyes and their shoulders and anything else a shapeshifter can conceivably roll. A spleen, maybe?

‘Give *OVER*, kitten. Skyhawk is a *looootttt* of things but – regrettably – he is not dead. *Observe*.’

It takes a more confident fellow than I to do what the Marquioness did next. Elucidation stood so treacherously close to desecration. As the room held its collective breath, and Scorpia wrapped a claw around Lady P’s delicate eyes and yet-more-gentle sensibilities, Double-Trubel slurped a very final sip of his sherry and gin and orange thing. ‘Loves! Darlings! That *will* make you gyre and gimble in the wabe…’ But nobody was really listening. ‘Because the drink’s called The Jabberwock?’ Still no response. ‘*Read* a book, you charlatans!’

And with that, they slammed their toe-box into Skyhawk’s side hard enough to draw blood.

‘Yowch! Okay, you got me. Grieve not! I was playing around – your mighty Skyhawk is alive! And sore…’

He scrambled to his feet, kicking the chair out from under him. We gasped in unison.

‘No, really, it isn’t that bad! Nothing a few squats can’t sort out! Care to spot me, Bowregard?’

‘Bl--- bl-bl---’

‘I know, I know. I do look bloody good doing them! Oh, wait. You meant blood. That blood. That blood in a giant pool, just behind me, coming out of---’

‘A body! Oh my Horde, I killed again! With the champagne. Won’t somebody **stop** me?’

‘You don’t need stopping, Bow,’ I sighed, ‘but this *is* bad. Really rum bad. What do we do now?’

‘I am,’ proclaimed a shadow in the doorway, flinging a large, felt hat across the room. She looked up as she did, staring stagecraft at our collective befuddlement. Arising from the shapely sort of bow whose complexity had once derailed my finishing school

experience, the guest smiled in the corner of her mouth. We stood there silently; she did the same, more heroically. Her headgear squelched triumphant onto the devilled eggs.

'That's all very fine and dandy,' ventured I. It had once again fallen on the de l'Horde pluck to fill a conversational vacuum. 'We *are* also. No issues with that at all. It's the fellow on the rug who *isn't*.'

'Okay. Could you maybe give me a chance to finish?' Her hand wedged into her hip. 'I've got a whole thing that I do here, which is really important to setting the mood. If I don't do it, then more people *will* get murdered.'

'Really?'

'Definitely.'

'Really really?'

'I dunno. Maybe, I guess. My name goes before me and junk, so I just assume that puts people off doing more of the poisoning and the stabbing and the strangling and the smothering. It's usually poisoning though.'

Bowregard stuck his hand straight up in the air, then started jumping up and down a little.

‘Ooh,’ he said. ‘Ooh!’

‘Yes? You, the guy with abs and anxiety.’

‘Hello. Hi. I’m Bow, these are my friends. Well, some of them are my friends, the rest are really more people that Glimmer knows. This is my friend Glimmer, holding hands with my friend Adora. Oh wait, you guys? You’re holding hands. Awwhh! Is it like we talked about? Is something happening?’

‘Bowregard,’ Glimmer hissed. ‘Why are you introducing us to the killer? And why are you doing it so *informally*?’

‘Eep! You really think she’s the one who did it?’

‘I don’t know, chums,’ I ventured. ‘She *has* only just arrived. Nobody saw her here before, well, just right this moment. And the hat fling makes for quite the razzamatazz. We couldn’t have missed that.’

‘What if that’s a distraction?’ said Glimmer. ‘We only have her word to go on that she’s ever done it before.’

‘I do it every single time, actually.’ Our growing acquaintance – For what else might one reasonably call a well-dressed stranger

who interferes with one's dining routine? Well. Except Meowmeow, that is. – looked us over with heavy-lidded disdain. 'You guys are r*eally* bad whisperers.'

'She can hear us! Adora, she can hear us!'

'Yes, Bow, I think she got that. *Thanks*.' Hauling me down to height, Her Ladyship continued by whispering into my lughole. She kissed it too, which was quite distracting. 'You're still my brave knight, aren't you? My chivalric Lancelot, as well as my drop-dead Guinevere? Take *control* of the situation. Make sure we don't fucking die!'

'This is taking a really long time,' felt-flinger interjected. 'I don't know if you know this, but it's kind of important not to waste any of that with murders. Evidence degrades and stuff. Maybe appoint a foreman or, like, a representative?'

'I choose you!' rang out my fellow Capital Chum Crewmen with varying degrees of insistence and pleading. Nodding my agreement, I strode purposefully unto yet another date with destiny. Click went my heel, with noble authority, then crack as my whole foot over-turned. Damn these interminably lofty loafers! Glimmer caught my stumble, just, only to push me upright and forwards.

'Hey there, flapper-with-gender-to-be-confirmed. You're the one they're sending?'

‘A jolly good evening to you too. Sir Adora de l’Horde, third Baronet, at your service. Gender in progress, theys and shes gratefully received. It’s customary to kneel, but I don’t much know if I’d ever be able to get up again. We could shake on it?’

‘Yeah, I don’t like to do that.’

‘Then maybe I can interest you in a friendly wave? A bow is out of the question too, I fear.’

‘No. That’s okay. I’d rather ask you a question. Two, really. Are you one of the Marylebone de l’Hordes? And do you know how really, really common your surname is in the Caribbean?’

‘You’ve nailed the old homestead alright, but what’s with the far-flung business? I’ve never heard a lick of a spittle of anything in that ilk.’

‘Of *course* you haven’t. Okay. Presumably you have a question or statement from your group?’

‘Ah, yes! Bowregard – the fellow from earlier – asks---’ I pulled out the hastily scrawled napkin he’d just wedged into my clutches. ‘“Your Murderessness, are you going to slay us?” And that’s it. If I might just add a little post-script of my own, I’d really rather you didn’t. Provided it’s all the same to you!’

Glimmer coughed. A clarification was in order.

‘We are especially keen,’ I added, ‘to know of any designs upon The Right Honourable Her Lady Brightmoon, Countess Dryl.’

‘I’m not here to kill anyone.’

‘Much obliged. Then are you here to keep us from making dates with St. Pete? I’d consider it quite the turn up for the books if you were.’

‘Yeah, I’m not a physician. This is why I really need you not to interrupt when I’m doing my entrance. It answers all these questions.’

I looked at the group, then at the slowly congealing wool-omelette hybrid. The mysterious woman did the same. When our eyes reunited, she was scowling something rotten and her arms were tightly crossed.

‘Would you like to do it now?’ I ventured.

‘Eurgh… It won’t be the same without the hat. I really need something to throw or I can’t set the ambience.’

Unwedging the strapless senselessness that Glimmer had housed so insistently beneath my armpit, I hit upon the perfect substitute. Or so I thought. The woman seemed less convinced. She took its leather mass with wrinkling brows.

'Are you sure you want me to hurl your clutch? I throw pretty hard and it's, like, super valuable. Wouldn't you rather look after it?'

'Yes, *Adora*,' Glimmer echoed. 'That clutch is my very thoughtful gift. Or do you not *value* me?'

'Naturally, I weigh you above silver, and gold, and the other one. Our chumship?' Glimmer scowled. 'Our thing we have going on?' She crossed her arms. 'Our… dash it… our *situation*?' Daggers were stared. 'Okay. Got it. Our *maybe-date* means quite everything to me, dearest err… cough drop, but the good knight cannot let vanity cloud their judgement. A jolly horrible deed has been committed here. I swear my duty to avenge it, no matter the price. So goodbye to the bag it must be.'

'We all already know she's here! I can't understand why she has to throw anything!!'

'Well, I do, so there. Let's try this again. Everyone go back to where you were when I came in. Try to have the same conversations, maybe.'

She stalked across the drawing-ballroom, taking up her mark in the centre of the double doors. With nothing approaching the same grace or urgency, the de l'Horde ankles employed the same time in tottering. Step one was a blighter but step two came good enough. By step four, I was close enough to crash into the tableside. I like to think I styled it out somewhat. Inspired by the poses in Glimmer's catalogues, I threw out my arms in the manner of a sensual, if very tired teapot.

'I am---' the guest began again. So far, so good. She'd done this bit before, if not with such a weighty prop. It spiralled towards us like a discus, tumbling through the firmament, before landing in the punch bowl, displacing three pints of pinkish intoxication over the hors d'oeuvres. '---Whirlpool Mermot, the famous private detective. This is where you gasp.'

'No doubt you've heard of me. Y'know, 'cause of all those cases I solve and junk. To date I've uncovered 37 murders, usually by that thing I do where you all sit down in a semi-circle and I gradually narrate your fucked up lives. It's, like, *notorious*. Not to brag, but some *really* good novels use it now. You should read them. The Hercule Poirot series by Agatha Christie. She's pretty amazing.'

'Um, hi! Hey there, scary throwing things lady,' Scorpia interjected. 'I like those books too!'

'That's cool. You're cool. You have good taste. I came up with that way of solving things; she got it from me.'

‘But wasn’t *The Mysterious Affair At Styles* published in 1921, after Ms. Christie worked on the manuscript in the final years of the Great War? You, erm, how to say it? You don’t look old enough to have been fighting crime back then. Did you know she worked as a nurse and pharmacist’s assistant before she became a writer? It’s where she got all that inspiration and knowledge about the poisons her killers use!! Oh! And she doesn’t actually write down everything for the books herself.’

‘I don’t know about that but I’m pretty sure I’m right. *Anyway*.’ Mermot threw her chin up to the ceiling, then looked back at us all again. ‘You might be wondering why I’m here. Well, I’ll tell you. I’m hunting a case of murder. Murder most foul. I’ve been commissioned to find out who killed the victim, using any means necessary. So many means. You wouldn’t believe how many means.’

Her chin flicked the other way, then back again. It put one in mind of a spring-mounted bobblehead toy, rather. She gazed right at me then and winked. What had I done to deserve this new life, where women kept flapping lids in my direction? My attempt at winking back did not go unnoticed; Glimmer elbowed me hard in the ribs.

‘I *saw* that, *Adora*. Gone off your butler babe already? Just don’t go forgetting about *me*.’

Whirlpool watched the aside out the corner of one eye, without even wavering her oratory flow.

‘Who hired me? I’m not at liberty to say. Perhaps it was one of you. Maybe I came of my own accord. Or you could all have *hideous* hidden enemies, which would definitely track for some of you. But I can tell you this: I will find the killer – and it *will* be *dramatic*!’

‘Hi, err, Mermot was it?’

‘Private Detective Whirpool Mermot, yeah. Who are you?’

‘Lady Plumers. I have a question, Ms. Mermot. Now you’re here, can you guarantee no more of us are going to get murdered?’

‘Absolutely not. I mean, sometimes that’s how it works but I can’t make you all, like, safe and cuddly. My presence can push killers to strike again *really* quickly, so they can get their victim dead before I’ve had the chance to really untangle things.’

‘I understand, thank you. Namaste.’

‘Don’t. Don’t do that. You’re at least twelve shades too white to do that.’

‘Dearest detectivess,’ came another voice. ‘*I* have something to say!’

‘You people are terrible listeners. My introduction is a whole thing, and you’re not letting me finish, and it answers all the questions. This isn’t an open forum.’

‘But mine is really more of an observation than a question! I am Skyhawk! Hello! I am also famous, for my aerobatic prowess! Maybe we should team up?’

‘Yeah, no. I’m not interested. At all or ever. This goes out to everyone in the room: don’t try to do that Roger Ackroyd thing where the murderer cosies up to the detective---’

‘Spoilers!!’

‘---because I know when you’re lying. I’m, like, really good at that.’

‘What if *I* don’t *want* you here?’ Glimmer spluttered. ‘This is *my* house and I *don’t* recall inviting you inside.’

‘I’m not a vampire, I don’t need your permission to pass through doors. And unless you’re the Duke or Duchess Brightmoon – which you’re not – then this building doesn’t belong to you. My client sorted that out with the *real* owners, so yeah. I’m actually good.’

‘*Adora! Do something!*’

‘Well, I’d love to Glimmer, only Mermot here has got you astride one Dickens of a sticky wicket.’

‘*If you don’t, maybe I’ll tell the whole world what you’ve been getting up to? Is that motivation enough?*’

Whirlpool regarded us both with a cocked gaze, saying rum nothing. She rolled and lit a cigarette with her spare hand, puffed on it thoughtfully, then swayed over to us and flicked the butt into my champagne.

‘Trouble in paradise and junk? There’s something going on with all… *this*. Are you girlfriends, or is one of you, like, all bent out of shape because you aren’t? I can’t tell yet. But I *always* get my answer in the end.’ She stepped back, puffing out her chest. ‘That goes for all of you. Your affairs better be in order, because I’m about to uncover them. Every last one. Don’t even *think* of trying to stop me.’

A murmur rippled through the room. Several of our party dropped back into their seats, perfectly entranced. The rest of us followed. Except Glimmer. She stuck stubbornly to Mermot, fighting for prime lecturing position at the head of the coffee table.

‘I am a *Brightmoon*. Do you know what that means?’

‘Way better than you, yeah. I’m still not moving.’

‘This ends *so* badly for you, unless you step aside and watch your tone. I am *not* appreciating it.’

‘Cool. And I don’t like how your family made its money.’

‘Adora. *Adora!* Get in here and protect my honour. *Now.*’

I stood with the certainty of day-old tapioca pudding. Blade and pistol seemed dashed ill-advised when someone lay dead and oozing into the Wilton not thirty yards away, before we even got to the concept of threatening a quite-probably-armed detective. Not just any gumshoe, either. One whose exploits had produced narratives amusing enough to keep the old schnozz buried in the current affairs pages, which I’ll admit is no easy feat.

‘Detective,’ I began. ‘What Ho and all that! Now, I’m terribly sorry, but the bonds of chivalric fealty rather tie me into this… I challenge you to a duel. State your weapon.’

‘You’re really doing this, huh?’

Mermot looked at me. Glimmer looked at me. I did not want to look at them, so peeked at my feet instead. But that only made me crosser. Sir Adora de la She-Ra stands against an open-air toe, it turns out, and yearns quite considerably for the provision of a

cheerful novelty sock. The high-heels failed on both fronts. And isn't there something self-defeatist in a shoe that elevates your ankle pre-emptive of the injury it's about to cause? All this and more I tried to ponder, until I could withstand the huffs and clucks of the two women no longer.

'I'd rather not,' I confessed. 'But I guess we are…'

'Eurgh. Fine. I choose these. There is a *murder* to solve. So be quick.'

Detective Mermot raised her thumbs. I chose the right and we locked palms, leaning so close to each other we could've kissed, had the situation been pretty much opposite to the one it was.

'One… two… three… four…' the detective drawled.

'I declare a thumb war!'

A man was dead. He was on the floor, over there, face down in a pool of alcohol, grime and his own blood. It'd be dashed inappropriate to describe what happened next in lurid, pulpy detail. Suffice to say that I put up a good fight – an honour to my Lady and my house – yet even I couldn't get one over on the angry woman with the soggy hat. She'd had special Scotland Yard digit-strengthening sessions, I'm willing to bet. When she crushed my thumb, it hurt. And it stayed crushed. Physiotherapists, apply to the address within…

I whipped my hand away without crying. Much. Lady Brightmoon rushed to my side with a very real concern. That was something new. When Catra swept in like this, it was beauty and light. Sub in Bowregard and it felt like fraternal care. Scorpia? Attention amongst equals. Maybe a touch too much attention if it was Lady P. Any of those felt *good*. A gentle Glimmer was… none of the above. I didn't know what to make of it.

'Oh, Dory! Adora, my *dear* girlfriend, you're hurting. Ohmigosh! Someone get my *girlfriend* a cold compress. Now! *NOW!!* What are you all standing *around* for?! *Cuz!* Help them, please! Fuck!'

Glitterbug sloshed my way. That's right. *Sloshed*. Through the liquid that, all things being equal, should have stayed inside the gent on the floor. Her ruby-red footprints slurred into the carpet as she circuited the table to take my side. Whirlpool tried to stop her. She got an elbow to the chest for her work. When that wasn't enough, Countess Dryl followed up with a jab to gut. She wasn't about to be denied.

'So – what the fuck do you think you're doing? This is a, like, *crime* scene. You can't just run through it.'

'But my Dory is hurt! *My Dory!* Don't you *understand*?' Swaddling my hand like a wounded duckling, Glimmer raised my thumb to her lips and kissed. With tongue. 'She *needs* urgent medical treatment! The murder has already happened, right? Why risk another *TRAGEDY*? Ever think about that, whoever you are?'

‘*Detective Whirpool Mermot*,’ said Detective Whirpool Mermot, icily.

The compress rapidly wrapped around my hand was less cold than the way this crime fighter was now looking at Glimmer.

‘Eurrrrggh. You are all the worst. Just… the worst. Do you even realise that you’re all suspects in a gruesome murder? That someone in this room has taken away a damn life – and might do it again?’

Hush descended. Everyone present was very still and very quiet, and only one of them through an absence of being alive. Mermot brushed, brusquely, past Glimmer, on her way to the door, which she closed, locked and deprived of its key. As we stood there – decorated, inebriated, useless – she lapped the room, taking the same approach at each window, before donning gloves and a mask.

‘Do not move. Play time is, like, *over*, okay? You could still be in grave danger.’

‘Whaaaaatttttcha doing?’ Entrapta grinned. ‘And can I help?!’

‘I am detecting. Whirpool Mermot famously works alone and junk.’

Entrapta looked terribly put out at that. ‘But I have so many tools… and a robot. Emily could solve crimes! She’s already perpetrated forty-eight of them – the inversion would be *fascinating!!*’

Mermot looked quizzical. I’ll tell you who didn’t, reinvigorated by a swig of liquor and a renewed drive to protect her friends, not to mention an encyclopaedic knowledge of contemporary crime fiction. Scorpia! She swept a comforting claw around the engineer – and challenged the detective directly.

‘Hercule Poirot has assistants. He has a valet – just like Adora does, only not really too much like that really – then there’s Inspector Japp, Colonel Race… Oh! Gee! And how could I forget? Captain Hastings! Ms. Mermot, don’t you remember *The Big Four*? I can still picture the day I got it out of the library---’

‘Like, the public library? That’s… interesting.’

‘Gee, it really was, wasn’t it? Such a huge shift from the other Poirots! And Hastings was danged pivotal to that one.’

‘That book is, like, pure Orientalism and anti-Asian hate. Funny how Etherians only think a lust for power is evil when they’re not the ones going after it… But, really, Lords and Ladies, I’m sure you’re all *great*.’

Perfuma did some crying. ‘Why can’t we all get along? That’s all any of us ever wants!’

This had not been the right thing to say, it transpired. Mermot looked the closest to fighting Lady Plumers I believe anyone ever has been or will be.

‘Christie writes her upstanding Etherian paragon Arthur Hastings as a *plantation owner.* You think the Argentinian labourers only work there because they’ve got, like, a sense of good old-fashioned fair play? Come *on*. And *stay still*.’

Without another word, the teeth-gnashing detective raced round the room with camera and flash, capturing an inexplicable multitude of snaps from the party of a lifetime. Flash went her bulb at the blood spatter, the body, the footprints. Snap and snip it kept going at every entrance and exit. When that was done, she measured and magnified and bagged her way around almost literally everything. Finally, she bade us all step back into reportedly safe positions while she checked out the paintings and, with a grimly authoritative swish, the fireplace. They came back mercifully clear.

‘M’kay. I have my first impressions. And if you did it, you are *so* screwed.’ She flicked her braids with enough precision to let loose a memory, but we’ll get to that later… ‘One – or more likely *two* – of you wiped out that poor bastard down there. No-one is leaving Shugborough Hall until I figure out who.’

‘Ms. Mermot, Namas---’

‘No. Final warning.’

Lady Plumers wasn’t deterred. ‘Detective, I’m really sorry to ask, but who *exactly* are we meant to have, um, put to a really long sleep, if you see what I’m getting at?’

‘Good question, gardener. Only one way to find out!’

Whatever honour the dead are due, the next few seconds did not contain. Mermot crouched down and growled something about the state of her spine. She wouldn’t accept any help, mind, no matter how often I offered. Contaminates the crime scene, apparently. There was grunting, there was groaning and… *splat*. The victim’s face. A victim I recognised.

‘Horde dammit Kyle!’

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The Mer-Mystery of Blood-Borough Hall: Part 2 - Good Memory Gone Bad?

Chapter Summary

'Have you solved it yet? I mean... *I* hadn't solved it at this *precise* moment but the net was closing and the hounds were circling and the traps were getting set pretty damn quickly. Because I am Detective Whirlpool Mermot! And, yeah, I'm better at solving murders than you.'

'Anyway. Welcome back, I guess? Kyle is still dead. One or more of them did it. This time I investigate Adora, produce a really compelling theory, then pivot off in a direction that's, like, *tragic backstory unlocked*. For both of us. Intrigued? Yah. You should be.'

Chapter Notes

Content warnings apply for the below chapter only - Spoilers may be present in the warnings. This story does not include any of the four Archive Warnings topics, but does occasionally feature other topics that may require content notes. This chapter is rated Mature due to ongoing murder investigation plot.

Chapter 47 Content Warnings (CONTAINS SPOILERS):

Death – related, recent, violent, narrator suspected
Murder – related, recent, violent, narrator suspected
Forced separation – related, ongoing, impacts narrator and major character
Homophobia – related, historic, impacts narrator
Denial of queer identities – related, historic, by parental figures, impacts narrator
Financial control – related, ongoing, familial, impacts narrator
Coercive control – related, ongoing, familial, impacts narrator
Blackmail, assumed – related, ongoing, impacts narrator

(conjecture)
Racism – related, historic and ongoing, impacts major character
Weaponised white privilege and class privilege – related, historic, heavily impacts major character
Institutional and structural racism – related, historic and ongoing, impacts major character
White obliviousness – narrated, present, by narrator
Mistreatment of ill minority woman – related, historic, includes real historical person and events

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PART 8

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‘Okay. Wow. So he’s, like, SUPER dead. One of you talked, right? Keep talking, tall one in the Chanel.’

‘Unless I’m very much mistaken, that’s Kyle. He was my valet – until he wasn’t. I’ve got a new valet now, except she isn’t really my valet now either. She’s my girlfriend – Catra – and her hair smells like comfort.’

Glimmer folded her arms very tightly but still somehow found a way to dig her very pointy painted fingernails into my forearm.

‘*Dory*. What does *that* have to do with anything?’

‘Except maybe EVERYTHING?’

The whole room gasped. Well, except one, obviously.

‘Go with it, de l’Horde,’ the detective encouraged.

‘How would *you* feel if a beautiful, smart, courageous woman walked into your life – she was Sapphic – you were Sapphic – you near-instantaneously fell for one another – you spent time with each other – you got closer – you shared intimate secrets – you kissed – you, um… *kissed* – you thought you loved each other--- and then she got **wrenched away** just because someone thought your love was **wrong**?!’

‘And this isn’t the first time that’s happened to you, is it?’

‘How… How did you know?’

‘Err, hello? I’m a SUPER good detective. But the question remains: Is it enough of a motive… for *MURDER*?’

‘I’m pretty sure I didn’t kill Kyle. What would I have to gain?’

Mermot unfolded her arms onto her hips and actually smiled, raising the ghoulish spectre of a possibility that she was actually *enjoying* this. The rest of us were very much not. Apart from Double-Trubel. Predictably, our doyen of drama was savouring every last second. They leaned forward, their tail *en pointe*, grinning awful rows of teeth, positively humming with potential energy.

Wait! Could they be the killer? It stood to sickening reason. The Marquioness knew Skyhawk wasn't the intended victim, and the whole Catra-Glimmer affair proved they had no qualms whatsoever re. using criminality to get what they wanted. I started edging myself away and across the room, as subtly as these cursed shoes would allow.

'Yah. Not so fast, de l'Horde. You're still in for questioning.'

'But, Detective Mermot, I didn't do it!'

'Do you know how many murderers say that? ALL of them. You're such a trope.'

'Don't all the innocent parties say it too?'

Whirlpool sighed very deeply. She did not looked gruntled. At all.

‘Sure. Most of them do. It’s suupppeeerrr annoying. I have to do so much more detecting work that way.’

‘But you’re a detective!’ Perfuma helpfully observed. ‘Don’t you like detecting? I’m a gardener and I love---’

‘Short-haired mystery reader lady, I’m gonna say.’

Lady P gasp-clapped a clean four feet off the carpet.

‘Yes! That’s so exciting! How do you do that?’

‘I’m pretty amazing, duh. And I *do* like detecting – but I LOVE being right. Especially when I get there first, before everyone else. That’s great. But enough about me and whatever. Okay, people! We’re at the part of the night where I go around and speak to you all in turn and work out how you knew the victim, plus why you wanted to kill him.’

‘But what if we really didn’t know Kyle?’

‘Someone’s keen to establish her innocence. Another *killer* move. Don’t worry flower lady – you’ll all turn out to have links with the victim that mean he’s better off dead. It wouldn’t be very, like, narratively satisfying if you didn’t.’

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Whirlpool beckoned us out of the Red Drawing Room and into the Dining Room, with its giant spooky paintings and vague aroma of splattered cream thrown in the heat of passion. It was starting to sour, which made the place really rather whiffy, but we weren't to leave until and unless called on by the detective.

Under no circumstances whatever were we to set foot back in the drawing room. Something about preserving the crime scene or some such. Why that hadn't mattered when hats and bags were flying through the sky, I really couldn't say. Mermot wasn't going to waste another second on extraneous explanation. She grabbed my arm and hauled it into the Saloon, where she'd arranged a pair of chairs. The rest of me followed. It didn't have much choice.

'Listen up, people. I'm starting my interviews. Now. You'll come when you're called and, yeah, you'll like it, okay? Baker here is keeping an eye on the rest of you – so no funny business or anything. Hell hath no fury like a worker scorned, and you'd all do well to remember that. Adora, come.'

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'Tell me more about Kyle,' Mermot instructed as she hauled open the velvet curtains. Running floor to ceiling, they really didn't want to move – but they did. The detective was not a woman to be opposed. A summer storm rattled at the French windows. The milky glass fogged and went an inky blue--- treacherous midnight blue--- hurling her into the taxi---

‘*Catra*.’

‘No. Not Catra. Just keep your girlfriend in your pants for now, alright? Kyle got murdered. Talk Kyle. *Now*.’

Mermot looked deadly serious – and she wasn’t about to break eye contact. In one long, sprawling, bodily sigh, she threw herself across an inlaid table worth more than most folks make in a year and scraped a match along the walnut with an awful *sccrraaacckk*. She cupped it to her lips, where it found the cigarette she’d just pulled from behind her ear. Black with a gold tip. Expensive. Ostentatious. I’d have complimented her on it, had she not been staring at me so intently that I fully expected there’d be another slaying tonight if the next words out of my mouth concerned anything other than my deceased ex-gentleman.

‘Kyle was my valet for two? three? years or so. They say no gentlefellow should be without one, but Kyle really made me doubt it… Has anyone told you about the laundry chute incident?’

‘Err, you’re the first suspect I’ve interviewed, remember?’

‘Yes! Right you are! Suffice to say, I still can’t figure out how he ended up halfway down the tube with all my soiled unmentionables still neatly folded in the kitchenette. I was glad to see the back of him, truth be told, but the end was rum sudden.’

‘You fired him?’

‘No! Quite the opposite. I awoke one morning to a letter stuffed in my slot and no manservant. What a mess! It was weeks before I managed to make contact with him.’

‘You still needed to be in touch? Okay. Was money involved?’

‘I imagine so. When isn’t it? I know he needed the stuff something chronic – but Aunty handles the financials. She was the one to hire him, I think. And she did **not** take well to that letter, let me tell you!’

‘Oh? Was it blackmail? Plleeeeeaaaassee let it be blackmail. My last two cases have been SO boring and WAY too straightforward. The butler literally did it in one of them. Ew. *Generic*. Nobody wants to read that. I’m a Horde-damned genius – I need a way to prove it.’

‘No, nothing like that. Just wanted his last paycheque, and who can blame him? He was leaving the service – off to become an actor. And good luck to him! … Oh. Wait…’

‘Yeah, he’s still dead. Do you really mean that? You were happy to see him go?’

‘Hmm… I was cheesed about how he did it – and I did NOT get on well with ironing my own shirts---’

‘That does NOT surprise me.’

‘---but it all worked out in the end. Made one heck of a space for Catra.’

‘Who your Aunt also hired?’

‘Um – Well – I don’t know about that. She didn’t come with a letter of introduction; she was just **there** one morning. I hadn’t planned for it. Catra was standing in my bedroom and I… Well, I suppose I was in love.’

‘And how does Aunt Shadowtha feel about that? Not good, I’m guessing.’

‘She doesn’t know. Yet. I hope. And how do you know that?!’

Mermot blew out a cloud of horizontal smoke in a very artistic way. ‘I’m the one asking the questions – and doesn’t it seem just a little fortuitous that your old valet happens to flake on a steady, long-term job just in time for this, like, dashing gay stranger to step straight into the vacated role? Because I call that suspicious.’

‘I call it damned lucky!’

‘Yeah, there’s no such thing. You wanna know what I think? Wounded by your family’s complete rejection of your gender and sexuality, you “encourage” Kyle to leave just before the Henley regatta, where you cause such a scene with the aid of your “friend” Lady Brightmoon that the de l’Horde elders are too busy doing damage control to wonder where your new “valet” – if she even *is* a valet – has magically appeared from. While they’re busy sucking up to the Brightmoons, you finally get the free space to romance a girl without your Aunt intervening to rain fresh shit on your suitor – and this time you actually get to build a relationship without all the complexities of being a Lord and heir… At least on your end…

‘But then there’s a problem, isn’t there? Kyle comes back. The money’s all run out and he’s getting desperate. Not to worry, he thinks, he knows what you were trying to do and the kind of places you could go to do it. So he delves into the whisper network and teases out exactly where you’ve built your little love nest. And then he pays you a visit. He corners you and states his terms: you can cough up a hefty, ongoing payment to keep his lips zipped – or he’ll spill everything he knows to the people you REALLY don’t want finding out about this.

‘I’m guessing he gave you a deadline? Twenty four hours, perhaps? It’s usually a day. Two trips around the clock. Blackmailers think that’s super dramatic for some reason. Or maybe they can’t remember more than one time. Maybe they’re super busy. I don’t know. But I *do* know that you panicked. If Kyle didn’t get what he wanted – and fast – then the whole world was about to discover that you’d been cavorting with a girl… and a *lesser* girl at that. We both know your family won’t let that stand.

‘But where do you find the money? You can’t. You still don’t have access to your trust fund – and the miserly stipend your Auntie actually does give you wasn’t going to cover a demand like this. So you do the one thing guaranteed to stem this threat for good. You get Catra far enough way to evade suspicion. You make sure you’re surrounded by friends who’ll vouch for you – on the tiny, tiny chance your Lordly privilege can’t keep you out of the courthouse. And then you kill him.’

‘My Horde, that’s brilliant! But it’s not true – I can’t even open a yuzu without making a mess.’

‘Then why are there strands of your hair and streaks of mud stuck to the drawing room windowsill, huh? Answer that!’

‘Gosh, you’ll laugh when you hear this…’ And I told her, in excruciating detail, what I’ve already relayed to in Chapters 21 through 25, then went back and added 13 through 20 for context.

‘WOW. So you probably didn’t do it. Not that way, anyway. But, Adora, if your memory’s so good, why don’t you remember me?’

We were almost exactly face to face, and hers was apparently a face I’d faced before. I stepped up into the grey goo and started a frantic piece of mental filing, thumbing through the calling card of every major place and time I’d faced to date. Was she a cousin? A collegiate classmate? One of the ladies from those glorious holiday weeks on Ventotene, née Pandataria, which really should have

given me more of a sexuality-based clue about myself? No. She was none of those, so perhaps she dated back to my schooldays… to my boarding… to my dorm, my bunk… Was she?

'Mermista?'

'Bingo.'

'My first kiss.'

'Yeah, I know. I'd say it was pretty great – but it probably wasn't. We were very 14.'

'And very in love – or at least in full-blown crush – as much as kids that age can be.'

'Until that fateful day, with your Aunt and junk.'

'Mermista, I'm so sorry.'

'YOU shouldn't have to be. SHE was the one who got a smart, hard-working brown girl thrown out of the prestigious school her parents worked SO damn hard to afford – and salted the earth to stop me going anywhere else, using that giant, imperialist, might-

is-white and white-is-right privilege of hers – all so she didn't have to face up to her kid being gay.'

'And trans. Possibly demi-girl. Still working that out.'

'Sweet. Cool. Congrats.'

'How could she do something like that to you? How did she get away with it?'

'Oh, *Adora*. Do you even see how much power you've got that I don't – and can't? How Etheria is so rigged towards the white and the rich that you'll get a slap on the wrist for the most depraved shit – and I'd get hanged for waaaaayyy less? Racism is the beating fucking heart of the Etherian project.'

This was a lot to take in. To my shame, in that exact moment, I didn't. In its stead, I asked an I-hope-right-hearted but far more facile question.

'But you were alright in the end, weren't you?'

'There *is* no end, so long as the mindsets that made that beginning still stand. That goes for every shitty bigotry.'

I blinked, starting to tease open the door to this particular horror, with the tiniest inkling that some parts of our society were meant to really hurt me, but others were designed to really help me, and a She-Ra of any note has to stand against all the injustices, not just the ones that impact her. I suppose Catra and Bow and Entrapta and Wrongcle had riffed on this already – heck, I'd even bellowed it out loud at the fête – yet it was Mermista and her blunt, effluent-avoided nature that really kicked those cogs into their next, wider-reaching gear. She didn't have to do that. I'm tremendously grateful that she did.

'Yeah, I've done alright,' she went on, 'even if I never got those shiny qualifications and high-society acceptance my parents wanted so badly. Whatever. I found my niche.'

'Where you get to protect and avenge the downtrodden.'

'I mean, I guess? I just like solving problems and being the centre of attention, honestly. Which is just as well, 'cause this doesn't pay ANYWHERE near as much as you think it does. Turns out the police don't really like being upstaged by a proudly bisexual Etherian-Indian woman too much.'

'Really?'

'REALLY. You know *The Sunday Times* and *The Observer* had an Etherian-Indian Baghdadi Jewish woman as editor-in-chief around 1900? Rachel Sassoon Beer. When she got ill, was she helped back to health? Fuck nah! She was committed and the

newspapers sold out from under her. The establishment is super not in our favour.'

'I had no idea!'

'Of *course* you didn't… But you have some clew, right? You solved the Case of the Missing Girlfriend with your best Ballisterlock Holmes. How do you feel about being my number two for this whole Kyle deal?'

'But Detective Mermot always works alone.'

'Which is exactly why the others won't be expecting it. Go get me the gardener. And, Adora? I'm happy for you. Catra's a very lucky woman.'

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The Mer-Mystery of Blood-Borough Hall: Part 3 - The Mystery of the Red Room

Chapter Summary

> ‘Time to geeeeettt HYPED! It’s the interrogation chapter. Not to brag, but I’m pretty AMAZING at the whole question-and-answer thing. I could have been a barrister or whatever. Watch in amazement as I grill all your favourite characters – Perfuma, Scorpia, Wrongcle, Entrapta, Bow – and gasp in wonder as I crush some of your least favourites, i.e. Double-Trubel and… Skyhawk.
>
> ‘Yah, this chapter has a LOT of characters, and Adora’s there at my shoulder all along. But you wanna know what really makes Chapter 48 the best? It’s got the biggest twist you’ve ever seen. Intrigued? Of course you are. Because I am Detective Whirlpool Mermot and I am the greatest private investigator who ever lived!!’

Chapter Notes

> Sorry it's been a while since the last chapter! I've been busy having major surgery / my very own magical girl transformation sequence!! But this story WILL finish, I promise - at Part 52, just like SPOP. If you like anything about the story, you're always so welcome to leave comments. I've loved the ones you've left so far! 💜 They make my day!! Thanks for reading x
>
> And if you like Meomeow, you might like my other, new WIP multi-chapter fic - Cuttin' on The Ritz. It's a Hazbin Hotel novella set in Heaven/Hell/London and it, too, has a Sapphic couple at its centre, queer rep, neurodivergence rep, a 1930s setting, and lots of historically accurate slang and research. 💜💜

Content warnings apply for the below chapter only - Spoilers may be present in the warnings. This story does not include any of the four Archive Warnings topics, but does occasionally feature other topics that may require content notes. This chapter is rated Mature due to ongoing murder investigation plot.

Chapter 48 Content Warnings (CONTAINS SPOILERS):
Murder – In speech, recent historic, extensive, very limited details of murder
Death – In speech, recent historic, extensive, very limited details
Murderous thoughts – In speech, recent historic, extensive, by multiple characters
Vehicle accident, car – In speech, recent historic, detailed
Exile – In speech, recent historic and ongoing, impacts main and major character
Conspiracy to exile – In speech, recent historic, impacts main and major character
Vehicle accident, aeroplane – In speech, historic, some details
Falling into river – In speech, historic, some details
Desecration of a corpse, suspected – In speech and narrated, present

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PART 9

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Perfuma shook like a leaf as I deposited her in her chair, in what was either a remarkable act of flora-fauna kinship or an incredibly cunning ruse.

‘Ask anyone at Shugborough, anyone at all!’ the gardener gasped. ‘I never said a word to Kyle during his visit. I never even knew he was here!’

‘But what about *before* the two of you came to Staffordshire?’ asked Detective Mermot, slamming her boots down on an unsuspecting chair. ‘You’re a rising star in London gardening, are you not? And it’s pretty well known how much you *hate* succulents. I dunno… but maybe Kyle wanted to discuss that?’

‘Okay, I admit it! I recognise him. I do. I met him once – in Regent’s Park. We discussed a horticultural display they had there. But that was all! I swear!’

‘*Soooo…* I’m more of a water features girl, not gonna lie. Enlighten me, flower power. What was in this garden that was *so* worth talking about?’

‘Adora, did you see the March exhibit?’ Lady P enquired, shooting her pearly pleaders my way.

‘Don’t deflect!’ the detective snapped back. ‘That’s a cheap-ass tactic. Anyway, Adora’s working with me. They’re *not* going to help you. And so I ask – again – what was special about this garden?’

‘It contained flowering plants of the Mexican Peninsula.’

‘In other words?’

‘Cacti.’

‘Why not just say that, huh?’ pondered Mermot. ‘We all already know you hate them. Sure, your, like, violent distaste for a whole group of plants is pretty inexplicable, but it’s not any kind of crime. Why hide it? Yet all you’ve done since you stepped in here is conceal, conceal, conceal… Now. You’re not a *violent* woman, right? But you DID NOT like me challenging your presumptions earlier, so I’d estimate you’re pretty inflexible. And that gets me thinking. Lady Plumers, did you see this cacti display hogging flowerbed space in a world famous park and just… *snap*?’

Lady P sniffed and straightened her back. ‘I helped *refine* the display. Kyle saw that, which is how we met.’

‘Sounds sweet. Too sweet. Now tell me the story honestly. Who asked for your *refinements*?’

‘Um.’

Mermot leaned forwards. ‘Okay, okay, your Ladyship. We can go simpler. Try this one: how did you “refine” the display, when

you're the exact opposite of a cactus expert? Did you, like, repot them? Prune them? Dig them up?! Help me out here.'

Plumers twitched and Detective Mermot was right there, looming over her.

'A man is dead. Compared to that, no-one cares about your renegade flower wrangling. But I'm not about to waste my whole Horde-damn night letting the killer get away. So hurry up. *And spill it.*'

'Cacti are NOT flowers!!' Lady P went the colour of peonies. The windows rattled, and I took that as a prompt to move safely further inside the saloon. Who knew what fresh horticultural Hell she might be summoning from the great beyond. 'Kyle cared! Kyle cared very much! All I did was engage in peaceful protest! I uprooted those horrid, silly cacti and started replanting the flowers that *should* have been on display instead. But Kyle saw me – and he called my selfless work *vandalism*! Can you imagine?! I *begged* him not to report me – I NEED this Brightmoon contract, and they'd never employ a felon – so when I saw him at Shugborough, I--- I didn't know *what* to do!'

'But you *did* see him alive?'

'Yes!'

'Thank you, Ms. Plumers.'

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‘Okay – **I did it**!!’ Bow sat opposite us, all angles, and offered up his wrists. ‘You might as well arrest me now. Eek! But don’t tell my dads!’

‘*Yeeeaaahh…*’ Mermista breathed, through a second cigarette. ‘I’m not gonna do any of that.’

‘Because you need a confession first! Okay, here goes. I sent Kyle the note. And it was a mean note, but I had a good reason, okay? He still had my favourite commemorative teapot, the one with the happy kittens painted on it. But you’ll be wondering why he even had it in the first place! I’ll tell you. It’s… it’s because we dated for three months… when he was Adora’s valet… but it didn’t work out… and now he’s **dead**… and it’s all because I made my teapot request too ambiguous. Eurrgh!! I didn’t want him to come *here* – I should’ve been more clear about bringing it to my student digs!!’

Mermot looked, frankly, bored. ‘One more thing. Who crashed the Bentley?’

‘Adora.’

‘You’re free to go, Mr. Georgeson.’
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And he did, bowing profusely. Once he'd shuffled out, I asked Whirlpool what in all that's First Ones she was playing at.

'He kept glancing up at you and junk,' she replied, 'so you're clearly close and he REALLY cares what you think. But he still dropped you right in it, so we, like, know he values the truth even more.'

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One could not say the same of our third visitor.

'I had *EVERY* reason to want Kyle dead, darlings, or at least *incapacitated*, but what would I ACTUALLY gain by killing him? Why don't we work that through? It might be *FUN*! Let's see… First off, I'd go to jail – though only if my barrister was having a *really* off day, or I told him to flunk the trial – and then my name would be forever linked with notoriety, which is *amazing* for demand, sweeties.

'Second, production of the play would pause – and probably for a long time – but we'd be instant icons when we finally did open. Oh, and three! I'd never have to act opposite that wooden, wall-chewing hack again. *Damn*,' Double-Trubel tinkled, 'maybe I should've killed him! *And maybe I DID*!'

'Out of an uncompromising commitment to your art?'
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‘Of *course*! I’m the star!’

‘Which is funny,’ Mermot Great White Snarked, ‘seen as Kyle was all last week’s papers could talk about. You barely got a mention.’

‘*Who told you that*?!’

‘Glimmer,’ she lied.

Double-Trubel extended themself to their full, terrifying height. ‘Then *perhaps* YOU would like to know that Sparkles isn’t all she seems. She’s desperately in love with Adora – so much so that she abandoned “dear” Catra on a hillside, then all-out banished kitty from the estate after she came crawling back. And do you want to know the worst part---’ the Marquioness pivoted in their seat and locked into my gaze, ‘---Adora? Your precious Glitterbug set up a *spectacular* “accident” – destroying my Bentley for REAL – just to frame the Alley-Cat and get her out of the picture.’

‘No, she didn’t!’ I replied. ‘*I* crashed the Blower!’

Double-Trubel didn’t know where to look. Or what to say. Or what to do. It was like they’d been dropped straight into a vaudeville dance routine after a month practising their best Hamlet. For once, and perhaps for all, I had reduced the Marquioness to something less than the smartest person in the room.

‘But… But… the jacket slung over the seat, with the scrambling footprint. It was too perfect a clue – and I knew Sparkles wanted Catra gone – so who else could it have been? If I may speak *frankly*? I NEED Glimmer onside for the sake of my cashflow… so I just did what I thought she was *asking* of me. Adora… I’m SO, *SO* sorry.’

‘Maybe that’s super touching,’ Mermot drawled, ‘but we’re talking about Kyle, remember?’

Double-Trubel smiled uneasily back into themself. ‘Which is WHY we were talking about *Glimmer*. Isn’t she the one who hired you?’

‘It’s, like, too early to say, *chatton*.’

The Marquioness stiffened and shot for the door, taking their leave, with Mermot’s eye firmly following them.

‘So they’re pretty damn shifty,’ she hummed. ‘I’m *definitely* not counting them out. Great fabrication about the car crash, by the way. Nice work, rookie.’

‘Oh… err… no,’ I ummed. ‘That was devilishly real.’

‘Oh? Oh. Okay. Then get me the engineer.’

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Entrapta and Wrongcle attended together, hand in hand, which was not what we'd asked. Our requests, however, were not something this particular couple even remotely cared about.

'I would rather see a corpse than see a scab!' my uncle announced as he sat down. As an alternative for the more conventional "What Ho!", it was certainly striking. Mermista flicked some ash into a quite ancient, quite hideous vase, then made her instruction:

'Expand.'

'With pleasure. The struggle of labour goes back to the first inequity of settled society: the farm.'

'Less expanded than that.'

'There is an ongoing struggle between worker and management in the London performance industries. Many are not being properly compensated for their labours and a strike has been called. Two days ago, my associates informed me that one up-and-coming actor was repeatedly crossing the picket line for his own advancement. This upset me greatly! The actor's name was Kyle Nieman. I wished to remonstrate with him!'
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‘Which is when things turned violent?’ Detective Mermot queried.

‘Alas not! Kyle was dead before I met him. May his scab spirit know no peace! I wish I could be more helpful.’

‘Okay, Entrapta, you’re up,’ said Whirlpool, switching her attentions to the other half of Etheria’s cutest communist couple. ‘Who crashed that Bentley?’

‘Is that linked to the murder?’

‘Yes.’

‘O---kay? Tyre ruts suggest the *Birkin Blower* accelerated towards the building, implying one or more of three scenarios: a throttle or fuel system failure; operator error; or a deliberate impact. From examining the wreckage, I perceived *NO* signs of mechanical failure or tampering, but Catra isn’t the sort of woman to crash a car on purpose *orrrrr* to leave her jacket behind… unless she did these things for a shadowy, unknown deeper reason… which would be *FASCINSATING*!! But unlikely. And she’s a *HIGHLY* experienced driver in sev-e-ral performance cars… so I can’t see her making such a fundamental mistake at low speed… which means… *Adora*, what do you drive again?’

‘A Frazer-Nash.’

‘And what did you have before that?’ Entrapta asked.

‘An Invicta,’ I replied.

‘And before *that*?’

‘Another Frazer-Nash.’

‘Before *THAT*?’

‘I learned to drive in an Austin Seven.’

Entrapta jumped up, twinkling her fingers. ‘I’ve got it! Adora crashed the Blower, but it was an *ACCIDENT*… caused by a driving career where, before that night, the throttle was always on the right! *She* got the pedals mixed up – and Catra is *innocent*!’

‘That’s exactly right!’ I spluttered, more than a little agog.

Mermot looked unruffled. ‘Cool, cool. Entrapta, did you kill Kyle?’

‘No! I *LIKED* Kyle! He showed a real interest in my datasets. He wanted to know *aaaallllll* about the She-Ra. He said his previous employer sometimes exhibited these flashes of light and moment where she looked just like my She-Ra images, only she never seemed *aware* of the change, and he didn’t know how to bring it up with her. Isn’t that *FASCINATING*, Adora?! There might be two contemporary She-Ras! You might not be the only one! Think of the *POSSIBILITIES*!’

I gawped, once again reassessing my life to date, until I finally managed: ‘Kyle was *my* valet.’

‘Oh.’ Entrapta sounded disappointed.

‘Anything else we should know?’ Detective Mermot enquired, keeping this show on the road.

‘I haven’t seen Emily in 24 hours,’ Entrapta replied.

‘Who?’

‘My *special friend*… She’s a robot. And 48% less prone to bio-incompatible hugs than before her last upgrade!’

‘Which means?’

‘Smothering. She… can… *smother* people?’

‘Fatally?’

‘Absolutely!’

‘And, let me get this right,’ said an increasingly strained Whirlpool, ‘you don’t know where she is – right now – on the night someone has been murdered?’

‘Absolutely NOT!’

This was not reassuring.

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‘I can only assume you wanted to see me!’ announced the mighty Skyhawk.

We had not asked him in and, from the downward-trending line painted across Mermista’s chops, I could tell that the detective shuddered at the thought of speaking at this man again. But when life gives you a complete lemon, you’ve got to make lemonade. Skyhawk slammed himself into a seat, blissfully unaware of all these subtleties. He clapped his hands together –
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just to make noise, I think – whilst spreading his legs so, so wide that you would've had a job trying to sit in the seats either side of him. The regular Tube user in me longed to give him a dirty, silent, ultimately impotent stare. The She-Ra in me wanted to *lightly* stab him.

'I suppose you're wondering how such a famed explorer of the skies came to touch his tail section down at this fine palace…' he declared. Mermista made a sound of absolute deflation, which Skyhawk either ignored or never noticed in the first place. 'Well! I will tell you! I fought for many nights against the Ghibli and the authorities, racing through Europe like an especially rugged, handsome starling, crossed with a… *squid*! I was fast – but cunning!

'Italy wept at my departure – but my creditors did not! Oh no! Not at all! They showed their fangs – and there was a Continental conspiracy hot on my tail. All I had was my trusty sky-steed and my celebrated, dare I say *unparalleled*, aviation talent. Tell the truth, Detectiveress... *Surely* you've heard of my exploits before?!'

'Yeah. *No*. The only Skyhawk I've ever come across is wanted for fleeing the scene of an accident, after crashing a Bristol Boxkite into a Stratford-upon-Avon teashop. Witnesses report he was *crying* as he ran away. And that then a swan spooked him, and he fell in the river. Does any of that sound, like, familiar?'

'It **WAS** very windy that day,' Skyhawk unconvincingly replied.

'You used a provincial high street as a runway!'

‘I had no other choice!’

‘Remember, I can *tell* when you’re lying, ‘kay?’

‘Okay, okay! I thought it would look cool. And I was NOT spooked by a swan! … … … It was a duck…’

‘Wait… How?! Alright. Shut up.’ Detective Mermot nipped any further Skyhawk scramble in the bud. ‘Now we’re telling the truth, what’s your link with Kyle?’

‘Me and Bill were two of the mightiest aeroplane fencers on the Seven Skies! Whatever ‘craft you wanted, we could find one, give it an all-new identity that stood up to the *closest* scrutiny, and deliver it to the cosy bolthole of your choosing! But things went south after the Montpellier Affair… and I skedaddled before the cheque could finish bouncing. Three days and five nights I traversed France, with only my wits, a single matchstick and the love of a chap called Jean-Jacques to comfort me!!

‘So?’

Skyhawk shifted uneasily in his seat. ‘When all’s said and done, Detectiveress Mermot, Bill thinks I owe him a LOT of money – and a half share in the last aeroplane we stole. And I do NOT have fifty remaining per-cent of *Dragon’s Daughter IV* left to give him,

do I Adora?! So, when I spied Bill on a Shugborough footpath this pm, I panicked!! How could I not?

'Of course,' he oozed endlessly on, 'I THOUGHT about killing him. But what if The Admiral came after me next? I didn't fancy my chances against his flotilla! So I thought of something better – *I* had to die… without dying! But the Marquioness saw straight through that, so it's just as well Bill DID cop it. Not that *I* killed him. I didn't. Now, Ms. Mermot, how's about we celebrate with a drink?'

'Wait. Did you say *Bill*? I, yeah, I don't care about any Bill. This is about *Kyle*.' Detective Mermot rolled her eyes like it was a professional sport, and she was the reigning world champion.

'Oh! I thought you said "Bile" – and that that was your fun way of saying Bill,' Skyhawk laughed. 'What a FUNNY misunderstanding! Ha-HA! I've never met a Kyle. Now – that drink?'

'No. Never.'

'Ah! You only like the ladies.'

'Excuse you? I don't date according to gender – I just do not find *you* attractive *in the slightest*.'

The aviator looked crestfallen, then scared. ‘Does… Does that mean Bill’s still out there? Is he coming to get me? Eep!’

‘We can only hope. Now get out.’

Mermista made sure the door hit him as he left.

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‘Ms. Scorpia BlackStone – big B and Big S, my mums merged their names, everyone always gets that bit wrong! Aged 26, unmarried but dating Lady Perfuma Plumers. I’m the daughter of Ms. BlackStone and Mrs. BlackStone, raised in Garnet Hall, just outside Pickering, North Yorkshire. But, gee, we just sold the place to Duke Brightmoon, so now we live in BlackStone Townhouse, Notting Hill.

‘I met Kyle, once, about 1600 to 1620 this afternoon, when he was leaving Entrapta’s garages. Those two had already been together in the back room for 85 minutes by then. I spent all afternoon from 1230 in that workshop, helping fix the ‘plane and the Bentley. I love working with my claws! Kyle and I spoke about darn little. But it got me pretty worried, if I’m being honest, because he asked about the house sale and seemed to know, somehow, that were really darn skint. And, gosh, if I didn’t start to fret that Perfuma would like me less if she found out!
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‘But then I remembered what Wildcat said when we chatted about that the day before: “Money is a means, not an end. We can’t deny that we need it for some parts of life, but the right person sees past it and cares way more about the person. If you love each other, you’ll find a way through.” Or something like that! I’m not as smart as her! I think she was talking about you, Adora. She *really* loves you. Anyway. I went straight to Perfuma and told her all about it – and it was just… okay! Because she’s great. So I guess I owe a “thank you” to Kyle, plus a super sorry that he’s caught up in all this.’

‘So…’ Mermista hummed. ‘Let’s say you *didn’t* do it, Scorpia. You’re super into murder mysteries, right? Y’know, ‘cause you have good taste. So you’ve *got* to have some thoughts about this murder. Maybe even theories?’

‘Oh, gee, yes, I do!’ Scorps pulled a sheaf of napkin-back notes out of her dress. Seeing them spill over the table was quite the impressive production. ‘So I’ve been thinking, working things out, and this isn’t very Christie. It’s a bit Conan Doyle, sure, but I keep coming back to *Le Mystère de la Chambre Jaune*…’

‘What, you think---’ Mermista jerked her head my way, ‘---is the major player? I mean, it’s not like I’m NOT considering that angle.’

‘Gee, no, not Adora! That’s not what I mean!’ Scorpy blushed. ‘I reckon it’s the *other* thing… the FIRST big reveal, y’know?’

‘Oh, Ms. Blackstone!’ Whirlpool smiled. ‘That’s SO good. ‘Kay, my Nimona and Watson – whichever of you gets to be which –

sidekick your asses into gear! We're going back into the Red Drawing Room! Let's see if this good, *good* hunch has what it takes to be a full blown TWIST!!'

Detective Mermot was on the case. She locked the dining room, closed the curtains, barred the doors and clamped her fingers around mine and Scorpy's wrists.

'Ready?'

It was rhetorical. Her spare foot slammed us back into the red room. It had booze. It had blood. And it did NOT have a body.

'Scorpia,' Mermot bowed. 'Has anyone every told you you're a damn *GENIUS??!*'

'Well, gee, Mama really likes my whittling and---'

'That's real sweet, but right now, this second? Honest to Horde, you're *the* smartest person in the room. Yes! YES!! We've got a motherfucking case here, people!'

'Am I getting this right?' I gawped. 'We're **happy** someone's desecrated a corpse?'

‘No, Adora, no.’ The Detective beckoned me closer, smiling out to her elbows. ‘Kyle’s not dead. He faked it AND made it out of a locked room while we were right outside! That’s *RAD*. Aren’t you, like, *super* excited?! Now we have to find him AND stop the real killer before they strike. YES! Ha-ha! I am *SO HYPED*!! Let’s goooooooo… *Be Gay, Screw Crime*!’

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The Mer-Mystery of Blood-Borough Hall: Part 4 - Water Twist!!

Chapter Summary

'The game is SO fricking afoot. We've got mistaken identities, half-formed footprints, concealed tracks, surprise twist characters, locked rooms, violently unlocked rooms, mystery money, cryptic correspondence... the whole Horde-Damn Murder Mystery Shebang. And I - world class investigator, Detective Whirlpool Mermot - am on FIRE. So is my trusty sidekick, Scorpia BlackStone. And Adora is there too, I guess. Chronicling and shit. She's SUCH a Watson. Annnyyywwaayy... you wanna know what happened to Kyle? Then you better read on. Mermista out!'

Chapter Notes

If you like anything about the story, you're always so welcome to leave comments. I've loved the ones you've left so far! 💜 They make my day!! Thanks for reading x

And if you like Meomeow, you might like my other, new WIP multi-chapter fic - Cuttin' on The Ritz. It's a Hazbin Hotel novella set in Heaven/Hell/London and it, too, has a Sapphic couple at its centre, queer rep, neurodivergence rep, a 1930s setting, and lots of historically accurate slang and research. 💜💜

Content warnings apply for the below chapter only - Spoilers may be present in the warnings. This story does not include any of the four Archive Warnings topics, but does occasionally feature other topics that may require content notes. This chapter is rated Mature due to ongoing murder investigation plot.

Chapter 49 Content Warnings (CONTAINS SPOILERS):
Death, assumed – Narrated and in speech, recent historic,

plot focus
Murder, assumed – Narrated and in speech, recent historic, plot focus
Racism – In speech, present, brief, by main character (apologised for)
Child abuse – In speech, present reference, brief, historic instance, impacted main character
Physical violence, grappling – Narrated, present, one instance by main character, one instance impacts main character
Threat of physical violence – Narrated and in speech, present, brief
Unconsciousness – Narrated and in speech, present, extensive focus
Poisoning – Narrated and in speech, present, extensive focus
Faking death – Narrated and in speech, present, main focus

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PART 10

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Detective Whirlpool Mermot – or Mermista, to her ex-girlfriends, such as, I suppose, *me* – strode across the Red Drawing Room with a very large grin indeed.

'Kyyyylllee!! KY-le… Come out, come out, wherever you are. Nobody wants to hurt you, Kyle, apart from the killer, *obviously*.'

This vote of mortal non-confidence achieved about as much as you might have expected, i.e. nothing. But the self-proclaimed World's Greatest Detective was not about to be deterred. With an eery, nicotine-soaked calm, Mermot fiddled methodically with the curtains, the windows and the carefully-inspected underside of every single chair and table.

Hands a-flap and tongue continuously clicking, she walked back across half the room with what she'd later tell me was a "satisfied, intelligent air." She may also have used the word "genius" to describe the moment she drew Scorpy's and my attentions towards the clock-cluttered marble maw.

'Kyle Nieman, you reverse Rue Morgue-ing son of a bitch!'

Coals scattered out of the fireplace. Gilded pokers and firebars followed them. In their place stood the bottom two-thirds of Detective Mermot, pointing vaguely our direction, and asking for a leg up.

'Are you sure that's wise?'

'Oh my HORDE – do you *always* ask SO MANY questions? Of *course* it's wise. I'm doing it in the line of duty.'

'So were chimney sweeps, but that wasn't very clever. Not when very long brushes exist.'

‘But this is different, duh.’

‘Oh. Did you used to be a chimney sweep?’

‘*Excuse YOU?!?* We went to the same school, Adora. What the FUCK?! Why would you even think that? Is this some weird-ass belief that the Indian girl must have had a tough childhood because, what, white Etherians have a monopoly on happy upbringings or whatever?’

‘Horde no! My childhood wasn’t very good at all, really. But--- But that’s not the point. I’m sorry, Mermista. I didn’t mean to imply that – I didn’t think – I’m sorry.’

‘Thank you. And I’m sorry your Aunt is a queer-hating, abusive fuck-knuckle.’

‘She IS?!’ Scorpy gasped. ‘Ah, gee, Adora, that sucks. Do you want a hug?’

‘*Eurrrggh*,’ groaned the chimney. ‘No, she doesn’t. Not now. What they want is for both of you to push me up here, so we can save a life and junk.’

‘I actually would like a hug.’

‘Okay. Understood. Can it wait until I’m like… maybe six feet higher up than I am right now? Please? It bugs me to admit it, but I do *not* have the leg strength to do this all by myself.’

It could wait. Heave, ho and the Detective was scrambling up, up, up and away, shouting back that we needed to meet her wherever this chimney came out, which meant working out which room had that fireplace, just as soon as Scorps gave me that squeeze. And I’ll tell you this – she was a bloody good hugger! The lady was a pretty top runner, too, when we disentangled and started putting parquet beneath our feet. She flew up the stairs three at a time and I was right at her back – until I said those five little words and cannonballed onto the landing, blazing with righteous power as Ms. Floaty-C snapped awake.

‘What do we reckon?’ I hissed, holding us against the hallway wall. ‘This one?’

‘No, Ador--- er--- She-Ra? The next one on the left. Oh, no, sorry! The *other* left.’

‘Be careful, Scorpy. I see white powder on the rug. Could be poison.’

‘And, gosh, look at those scratches! Someone’s tried to pick the lock.’

‘That looks dangerous. Stay behind me, okay? I’m going to kick down the door.’

‘Okay---’ Scorpia paused. ‘But what about the person who sleeps in there?’

‘I imagine they’ll appreciate not being murdered.’

‘Alrighty! Gee, Adora, is it wrong that this is kinda fun?’

‘I hope not. Because that---’ I kicked the door to pieces, ‘---feels pretty darn great. Three, two… NOW!!’

Weapons drawn, we raced into a palatial apartment lined in silk and velvet, gauze and glitter, chinoiserie and mirror upon mirror upon mirror, studded by silver hairbrushes, a pair of handcuffs, the latest issues of Vogue New York… and two very familiar cases, topped off by a cotton horse and a velvet kitty-cat. Oh. Oops. Whirlpool had beaten us here, handily. Filthy and furious, she pivoted our way as the desiccated flying tree bits announced our arrival, her features only softening when she saw it was only us.

‘Okay, get in here you two, and just look at what I’ve found.’

‘Kyle?’ asked Scorpia, hopefully.

‘No. But whoever’s staying here has some SERIOUS questions to answer.’

‘That would be… me,’ I squirmed.

‘Oh? Oh!! *Twisty*. Did NOT see that coming… ‘Kay, Adora, so I guess what I’m wondering is… Why do you have this giant pile of used, non-sequential *rentenmarks* – some apparently blood-stained – labelled *Adora’s Freedom Fund*? Take a tip, okay. Murderers are usually a little more discreet about their getaway plans. I mean, I still catch them of course – come on, I’m amazing – but at least make me *work* for it.’

‘I have a **what**?!’

‘A giant stack of literally dirty money. How did it get here? Spill.’

‘I--- Double-Trubel.’

‘Ooh – good choice of scapegoat, Adora!’ Scorpia clapped. She’d got that off Perfuma, no doubt. Horde, those two were cute, when they weren’t trying to prosecute me for murder. ‘Marquioness Trubel-Brightmoon *is* known to be pretty dang malicious, and there was the whole thing with the gun but, gee, you’ve got too much obvious motivation for blaming them. Oh, Detective Mermot! Where are my hecking manners? Double-Trubel forced Adora’s girlfriend out of Shugborough in revenge for a car crash that, err, definitely wasn’t Adora’s fault.’

‘True,’ I nodded, ‘mostly. But they also promised me all this money. I didn’t believe them at first, but here it is.’

‘For hiring your services to kill Kyle? For buying your silence? Face it, you two have by FAR the biggest motivations for wanting him dead.’

‘No!’ I screamed. Scorpy had got in behind me and locked my arms to my back. ‘No! NO! You’ve got to believe me. It’s for something else. Something really good. It’s--- it’s for top surgery.’

‘Oh my GOSH!’ Scorpia’s restraint morphed instantly into the warmest, deepest hug. ‘Really?! Adora, I’m so happy for you! How can Perfs and me help?’

‘Damn,’ Mermista nodded, naturally with another cigarette, ‘that’s *super* good. But not too twisty. Like, I don’t know if you remember, and I *really* don’t know if it’s my place to say, but you’ve needed this for a *LONG* time. Remember how I used to help you out with the vests and the bandages?’

‘No. No, most of school is just… black… missing. But--- maybe. That--- that sounds right. Greyskull! It **is** right! I remember. I remember! How did I push that so far down for so, so long?’

‘Before we get back to the next variation on the theme that your Aunt is absolutely terrible and possibly the *literal* worst, I’m sorry, Adora, but I have to ask you about this second note.’

She held it up. It read: “Dory – The Valet Problem will be fixed by first thing tomorrow. I promise. Sorry.”

‘Well?’ the Detective probed.

‘Glimmer wrote that. It means she’s bringing Catra back to Shugborough tomorrow, I think. I hope. Say, Mermista, have you looked at *everything* in this room?’

‘Are you asking about the pornography of your girlfriend?’

‘Yes… you didn’t look at it, did you? Please say you haven’t. I promised to keep it private.’

‘Would you relax already? I got here maybe 20 seconds before you. I haven’t even started searching yet.’

‘Then how did you---?’

‘You want the explanation? *Sweet*. The big reveal is, like, my favourite part. So. You know how we were bunkmates and best

mates and first kisses? I could always tell when you were thinking of something your Auntie wouldn't allow – lustful thoughts and junk – because your brow would start creasing just *here*. And whenever you talk about your Catra girl, you can't help smiling and your cheeks goes a shade of red right *there*. Ergo, when I saw both telltales at once, and there was something in this room you didn't want me to find, the only answer was dirty photos. *Voila*!'

'Damn you're good.'

'Yeah, I know…'

My innocence hopefully once again beyond doubt, we set about searching the rooms. From a smudge on the otherwise Brasso-brilliant fireguard, Mermista was convinced Kyle had re-entered the house here, but his person was nowhere to be found. Half a sooty footprint was the sum total of our uncoverings, until Scorpia elbowed into the bathroom and beckoned us to follow. Scorpia had a hunch. A good one.

'Our room had four bath towels today,' she whispered. It seemed like the right situation for whispering. I was glad she agreed. 'How many did you have?'

'Also four,' I replied. 'And I only used one, then left it on the bed for the maid.'

‘Then why are there only two left?’ Mermista smiled. ‘That’s a very good question. Adora, did you dry off in here or out there?’

‘In the bathroom.’

‘Then I’d say the water stains in the carpet are our clue because – trust me on this – it *always* comes down to water in the end. Get back at my side and junk: we’re going sleuthing.’

Use a word like that and it’s images of rushing, racing just-in-times that fill the skull. This was not that. If a second hand was clicking down to portentous doom, our soft-treading trio could neither see nor hear it. What we could perceive was the floor, which had the entirety of Mermot’s attention. Across the room and out the shattered remains of my door, we followed the dribble into the corridor. The Detective stopped: sniffing; scanning.

‘Interesting,’ she laughed, ‘like, what’s out of the ordinary here, you two?’

‘The lights are turned down?’ tried Scorpia. I followed up with an even less spectacular “Nothing?”

‘YES! But also completely no.’ Mermot grinned. ‘The trail goes completely dead – uncannily so. Look. There’s not a *single* footprint going right. The carpet’s just been brushed!’

‘To conceal a crime?’

‘I damn well hope so! And I think I know where.’

She pushed on the door to Glimmer’s room. She would’ve already known it was Glimmer’s room. She didn’t have to be a detective to work that out. It was so much bigger than the rest on this corridor, and its doors were the only ones decorated with sheets of gold leaf and shimmering opal inlay. The interior those doors yielded to was even more aggressively Glitterbug. Everything in here gleamed. Nothing was just one colour. The bed was big enough and tall enough to need its own postcode, and so decked in metal and leather constructions that only the mattress made me completely sure it *was* a bed.

My eye went everywhere… The preponderance of ancient velvets… the paintings… the sculptures… the personal telephone enshrined on a marble pedestal… the photographs of me and Bow thumb-tacked over the bedside chest, surrounded by cut-out paper hearts… and the sheer weight of haute couture fashion piled high and deep over every spare surface. It was a LOT. It was so much, in fact, that Detective Mermot had to wrestle my attention to the papers spilled across the desk, the upturned escritoire and a good four-fifths of the floor.

She smiled. ‘Damp carpet! Maybe even *wet*? Our un-dead victim was here, and for a *while*.’

‘What was Kyle looking for?’ asked Scorpia, ever the attentive student.

‘Torn pages… some handwritten letters missing… but whatever he wanted, he didn’t find it.’

‘Oh?’

‘Yah. If he’s blackmailing Glimmer, it’s just basic logic that he’d put everything back once he had his information. Leave it this way and he gives Glimmer the chance to go on the defensive. Which is *not* good for business. So… What if *Glimmer* is the one blackmailing *Kyle*?’

‘But she doesn’t need the money!’

‘No, Adora, she does not. Think wider. There’s sooooo many other things she could want, and Kyle definitely gives her a route to one of them.’

Whirlpool Mermot wiggled her eyebrows at me.

‘Me?’

‘Oh yeah. But don’t worry, Adora, it hasn’t got far. If it even is that. Because then Kyle would know what incriminating evidence he was looking for – and what we’re seeing here? It was NOT an orderly search. This was a scrabble. A scrabble we probably

disturbed. And our victim still doesn't have what he needs, so *where* does he go? Scorpia, Adora, does this place have a library, maybe?'

'Glimmer doesn't really read,' I answered, truthfully, overlapping with Scorpia's more useful:

'Yes. The Duchess uses it all the time. Basically ONLY she uses it, I think. But it's downstairs.'

'Sweet. Move, move, move!'

We did, quickly, if not directly. Whirlpool insisted on flying by the kitchens first, a building away, to scoop a handful of charcoal from the grave-dead ovens. She didn't say why – and we didn't ask. Our obedience endured as Mermot crouched by the library door with a lockpicking kit, while we shielded her from view.

'No heavy muscle…' she hissed, 'and no showing off. I calculate there probably aren't any connecting doors but there *will* be windows and a fireplace. We've gotta be quiet and quick – get him before he knows he's not cornered. Okay? *Got it*?'

The latch clicked so softly, but a noise was still a noise. Inside the library, there was a rustle, a thump, a fumble. We rushed in. The room wasn't large – furniture cluttered the path to each thin, tall window – and Scorps and I had the jump. She clawed the left leg; I caught the right. A shadowy figure slammed to the floor in a

damp pile of books. There were open pages everywhere, just like Glimmer's room.

Advancing with a look that was three-quarters smug satisfaction, the Detective wedged herself into an armchair, struck a match off its ancient arm, puffed yet another cigarette in deep meditation, then tapped our catch of the day with her sea foam green cane.

'Like… *talk*.'

The figure rolled over, clutching double-page spreads to his bosom like babes in arms. He looked around, very worried, then smiled in relief and recognition when he clapped eyes on me.

'Oh, err, hi Adora.' Kyle grinned, soggily. 'Am I glad to see you!'

~~~

'Can I have my job back?' asked the wet, mousy fellow, once he'd promised not to put himself through the windowpanes or up any more chimneys. 'Acting isn't going too great and Mrs. Shadowtha--- sorry--- *the Marchioness de l'Horde* says you're really struggling without the household help. You don't do well without the structure. So… um… why don't we let bygones be bygones for a bit? Until we've both got something better.'
~~~

‘But I *have* got something better. Much better. She’s just… not here right now.’

‘Not *here*…’ Mermot mused. ‘That’s smart. Damn. Sometimes I even impress myself, y’know?’

‘Care to enlighten the rest of us?’ I ventured. ‘Haven’t we caught the unmurdered victim?’

She winked at me with such heavily implied meaning that Scorpia let out a long, low, impressed vowel sound. I remained none the wiser. Luckily, the Detective followed up with some words, which I always find the more reliable conveyor of meaning.

‘Yah. Duh. But we haven’t caught the murderer. Listen to me, Adora. I want you to go back to the Red Drawing Room. Report on *everything* you see in there. I have, like, a super clever hunch – and I don’t want to take my eyes off Kyle here until I’ve got it confirmed or denied. But probably confirmed. Because I’m, like, the best there’s ever been at this.’

She shooed me out the door with another flash of her eyes-wide smile, flashing the gold caps on a couple of her back teeth. I had the Red Room key betwixt my fingers and tread with no small amount of trepidation towards my destination. I checked the dining room doors first. They were still locked and their inch-thick wood muffled most of the sounds within. Even so, I could tell the occupants were midway through a ferocious argument. And that Glimmer was winning. By shouting loudest.

Good, I suppose. They were distracted, and the Saloon windows were snapped shut too. No-one had been in or out this way. The drawing room doors cuh-cracked as I turned the key in its mighty home. I stilled my breath and cupped my ear. No sounds emanated from within. None at all. Okay, de l'Horde. The moment was now: face a murder scene, alone, in a house you only visited so you could apologise about borrowing a boat. Perfectly ordinary Etherian business. Stiff upper lip.

Wait, what was I doing? The sword cane twitched in my first. Enough of this Prime and proper stuff, Adora! Hadn't we moved beyond this? There's no need to die honourably when you've got the power of friendship and Catra and the small matter of destined, ancient, elemental magic at hand. Five little words – tactically whispered a way back up the corridor, out of drawing room earshot – and Sir Adora de la She-Ra had a far better shot of weathering this almost comically obvious trap.

Flick went a well-muscled wrist and the door fell open. With a mighty *clack* and a *thwack* entirely devoid of nonsense, my burning-white boots imposed themselves upon the suspicion of shadows within. Eyes too blue for words scanned the room, hunting straight for the fireplace. It was clean, pristine, nothing to arouse suspicion. Unless--- Oh, hang on! That thought would have to wait. Because Kyle lay dead on the floor, right where he'd been before.

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'Mermista! Kyle! In the Drawing Room!'
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‘That’s suupppeeerr interesting, when Kyle is right HERE,’ Detective Whirlpool deadpanned.

‘Ah-ha-ha!’ cackled Library-Kyle. His features distended into a skull-splitting, fabricated jag of a smile as he flicked back his chin and glimmered at us. ‘Is that so, Ms. *DETECTIVE*? Oh – how incredibly *drole*, my kittens!’

‘***DOUBLE-TRUBEL?!***’

‘If you *SAY* so, Adora, *chatton*.’

The Detective whipped around so fast her wide-brimmed hat almost spun itself to an unflattering angle. *Almost*. With a pinched flourish, she got it looking as debonair as ever, only now in a slightly dishevelled way. Here was a tremendously dashing woman who meant business. Little Adora had possessed very fine taste, clearly. Her features set in a furious snarl, her chest heaving. Then suddenly she was grinning from somewhere deep in her throat, chewing gum over and over like she’d just spotted an overwhelmingly invisible gambit.

‘Okay.’ She caught me hard in the eye. ‘Me and She-Ra here are gunna go check that out, but we’ll have to lock “Kyle” in here with Scorpia. Like, we weren’t born yesterday. Don’t let him try any funny business, ‘kay, Ms. BlackStone?’

‘Are you sure that’s safe, Mermista?’

‘Would you relax, Adora? Scorpia’s a BIG girl – she can handle herself.’

‘It’s Double-Trubel *I’m* worried about.’

As we swept the door shut, the softest, sweetest woman in Perfmua’s world advanced on Library-Kyle with her tail flicked high and her pincers wide open.

‘I’m sure they’ll be fine. Or they won’t or whatever.’

~~~

‘Okay! Adora! Who’s also apparently She-Ra – or is this another dress-up think? A kink thing? Gotta say, I can see you getting off on the whole muscle-mummy-slash-parent-slash-your-go-to-legal-guardian role… Catra is one, like, super *lucky* girl.’

‘You should see her! I don’t think I’m the one anybody’s looking at when we walk into a room together.’

‘ADORA! Adora. *Adora*, look at me.’
~~~

I looked at her. She nodded.

‘This is NOT meant to be, like, weird or anything – so don’t be weird about it – but you are SO smoking, honestly. VALUE yourself. You have a market. I mean that from an objective perspective, obviously. Like, look at the data. Catra loves you. Glimmer is practically drooling. And Perfuma is not *not* interested, if you see what I mean?’

‘Come on. Really? Me? Little old Sir Adora?’

‘There is literally NOTHING little about you right now.’

‘Because I’m the She-Ra. The real one. I met a very intense rainbow.’

‘Tale as old as time,’ she laughed. ‘Seriously, though, that’s intense. How are you coping?’

‘It’s a pretty big adjustment, honestly. But, at the same time, Life She-Raian is just blending into everything else that’s been going on.’

‘Like what?’

‘The second body? That’s maybe the first? The one that’s just past the door?’

‘Oh, yah, I’m not too worried about that.’

She stepped into the Red Room and straight past the corpse – to look at the fireplace. For all of about three seconds.

‘Alright.’ She stepped back over the dearly deceased. ‘Back to the Library.’

~~~

If I wasn’t prepared for the sight of an internationally-renowned murder solver literally walking over a victim without a second glance, I was even less ready for what we found in the locked library. Scorpia was distraught, her stinger quivering, her eyes on stalks. Library-Kyle was slumped on the floor, unconscious or worse.

‘What happened here?!’ I gasped.

‘I--- Oh, gee. Oh darn. I didn’t mean to! Adora, Detective Mermot, what am I going to do?! He said he wanted a glass of water. And there wasn’t any water. But there was this glass of… brown *stuff*.
~~~

And it looked like drink. I mean, goodness, why would you keep it here in a tumbler, on a coaster, if it wasn't there to drink? So I offered him the drink. And he said no. And I said there was no other drink, and if he was thirsty he should drink it. And he asked if I would drink it. And I said no, because I don't need it, so he could go straight ahead, and I'd explain if anyone asked where the brown stuff went. He wasn't sure. But I promised I had his back. So he said okay. And he drank it. And then--- And *then*---'

Bold, brave Scorpia broke down in fits of tears. Mermot remained unmoved. She walked over to Library-Kyle, sniffed the glass that had slipped from his fingers, and beckoned me over for a smell. I felt awfully callous leaving Scorpy, but Whirlpool insisted. Crouching to the carpet, I took a cautious whiff.

'What do you smell?' asked the Detective, rummaging through her pockets.

At last! A clear answer! I knew precisely what pronged:

'Amaretto di Saronno. Kyle's favourite tipple. Too sweet for my taste. Too… marzipan-y.'

'Right. It smells like almonds. And what did I tell you earlier? Murderers are super basic – and most of these big country house productions come down to…'

'Poison.'

‘Yup. And few poisons are easier to get at than cyanide. You could use a sepia photography kit, insecticides, rat poison, a whole BUNCH of nuts… But it REEKS of almonds, no matter where you get it from. Hence the liqueur. Which is kinda neat, I guess. Though strychnine is the waaaayyyy smarter choice. That’s a common heart medicine – and performance-enhancer – and recreational drug – so you can just make out your victim got their dosing wrong. Now *that’s* neat. Definitely still something I can solve, but neat. Okay, Adora, hold Kyle’s throat open for me, like this.’

‘Isn’t he dead?’

‘Nah, he shouldn’t be. Not yet.’

She poured the charcoal down Library-Kyle’s gullet and started violently massaging his neck.

‘This is super not the ideal solution but it should pull some of the poison out of his gastric system. Especially given we got here so early. It’s not nitrites but sometimes we just gotta compromise… Adora. Get to the kitchens and grab as much sodium bicarbonate as you can get. Baking soda, got it? Now!!’

‘Stop! Stop, stop!’ Library-Kyle spluttered in a black, cakey cloud. ‘I’m not dead! I’m okay.’

‘Adora, baking soda,’ Mermot snapped. ‘Socrpia, you’ve done nothing wrong, alright? But I’m gonna need you to get that soda into Kyle as fast as you can. All of it. Got it?’

Which meant I needed to find the stuff, pronto. Bursting into the strikingly quiet servants’ quarters, rushing to the ink-dark kitchens, I grabbed a jar of the stuff like a rugger ball and tackled my way back into the main house, leaping forth with She-Ra-springy lunges. Detective Mermot grabbed me the second I landed, pivoting us back towards my bedroom.

‘Not the Red Room?’

‘Nah. The first answer we need is right up here, I guarantee it.’ She strode across my room and pointed at the fireplace.

‘Fireplace!’ she triumphantly announced.

‘Yes,’ I told her, ‘it is.’

‘Duh. Obviously. The fireplaces – up here, down there – tell us where the second Kyle came from. Get it? Cause of my heroic climb between them, they should be super covered in soot and footprints. But they’re not. They’re both basically pristine, as if they’ve literally just been cleaned. At one in the morning. After virtually all the staff have been sent back to their bunks. Someone is trying to conceal how they helped second Kyle from your digs to

the drawing room, and they have *not* done a perfect job. Because – look – they've left this tiny pile of white dust.'

'Poison.'

'Nope. All in good time, De l'Horde! We've got a date with a corpse.'

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The corpse looked at nothing, corpsishly. It really was the perfect simulacrum of the dead-but-not-dead Kyle that started all this. It even had the smudge mark where Glimmer walked over him. Consulting Detective Whirlpool Mermot regarded the body with more interest on second acquaintance, not that this constituted a particularly high bar. Just gazing at it would have been enough. In practise, she did quite a bit more, donning her gloves and surgical mask, feeling for pulses, checking temperatures, assessing airways, examining the body for discolouration, puncture marks, scratches and stabbings. At last, she clapped an ear to his chest.

She stayed there for a minute, screwing her face into sharp, dancing shapes, before jumping up and leaping to my side, slapping her palms clean. Mermista was shining from every angle. She was smiling so widely. There she was, again. That 14-year-old girl who'd bust out at night with me to buy jawbreakers, to whisper nothings, to kiss. I hoped she was happier than we could be then. And I was beginning to trust that I could be.
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‘There’s something going on in that chest!’ Mermista beamed. ‘And I don’t know what! Because it is NOT a heart! Yes, yes, YES!! You can’t imagine how bored I’ve been getting of all the contested wills and the warring viscounts and all that tedious crap, Adora, and then *this* shows up?! We’ve got something here. Something really, actually, *bona fide*, motherfuckin’ TWISTY!!’

Red-Room-Kyle snapped his head left, our way, with a sickening crack. His eyes hissed open. He stared and stared and stared into us. Mermista was beside herself, clicking her tongue, dancing from foot to foot, tugging at my sleeve.

‘Adora, Adora! Look. Yes! YES!’

The corpse sat up. And opened its mouth.

‘Skwwwuh!! Ky-chwah! Ch-ch-chrrrrrppp!!’

‘Chur-chur, ch---brrrr. Chwk?’ I replied.

‘Psch. Psch, skwuh-brrr.’

‘Ah, okay,’ I nodded. ‘Fcch-awh-awh kyk?’

‘Chhrrpppppppppp! Pck dchk.’

‘What the actual fuck is going on? This is amazing. Front page material. I am, like, SO brilliantly lost right now.’

‘You shouldn’t be,’ I scoffed. ‘He – or rather she – is speaking Squirrel.’

‘Okay. And you – Adora, lately She-Ra – also talk critter? Is that a magic ancient being thing, so you can commune with nature and junk?

‘Horde, I wish! Afraid not, Mermista, old chumlette. My linguistic prowess is limited to fluent Etherian, passable Squirrel and about three lines of French.’

‘So… Why Squirrel?’

‘Well, they’re helpful little blighters, aren’t they? Move fast, know their way around things, blend into the shadows, sharp teeth. Up tree or down, the squirrel is a veritable Swiss Army Knife of the Etherian woodland. I imagine they see every little thing going, which is precisely what I needed at the time. How else was I going to find Catra on Cannock Chase? It’s a big place, Mermista. When the chips are down, you need a squirrel on side.’

‘Of course.’ She wedged a hand into her waist, like she didn’t believe the words she’d just said – or any of the ones I’d uttered

either. ‘So… Yeah. Who is this not-dead not-Kyle who mimes a fake death, hasn’t got a heart, and speaks – like you claim – Squirrel?’

‘Chr-chr Skrrphh?’ I asked Red Room Kyle, then followed up with the formal, ‘Phh-Chsp,’ for good measure.

‘Msp-msp-msp-tchk-tchk. Bwchpp. Chp,’ Red Room Kyle obligingly replied.

‘Ah, got it, thank you! That’s very good of you.’ I bowed to our visitor, who whirred upright and bowed mechanically in return. I’d had my suspicions, but it was good to get them confirmed. ‘You see,’ I went on, savouring the opportunity to out-detect a Detective, ‘I’ve never met another Squirrel speaker before, but I have *heard* of one. When I made my first crack at Squirrel, all around was chaos and confusion, with the exception of one Ms. Scorpy BlackStone! She’d heard this tongue before – in the mouth of a single, tremendously singular other who lives with her mechanically-minded chum.’

‘Wait. The engineer Entrapta?’ Mermista pinged alight like a fresh filament. ‘Entrapta who spent hours multiple with Kyle – or someone who looked like Kyle – this afternoon? De l’Hoooooorrrrdddeee!! How did I miss the link? It’s so OBVIOUS when you hint at it like that.’

‘I know you’ve got it, but I can do the big reveal, pretty please? I’ve *always* wanted to do one.’

‘Yeah, okay. What have you got, Adora?’

‘Our supposed second victim is nothing of the sort! She’s as right and well as she’s ever been, though she’s got previous for this identity-stealing business, plus petty crime in general. Detective Whirlpool Mermot, may I be the first to introduce you to Emily, the automaton of tomorrow?’

Emily waved at the Detective. Mermista nodded back like meeting a shape-changing robot was an everyday occurrence for her. Perhaps it was. But I’d wager a decent stack that it wasn’t and Mermista was just as cool as a refrigerated cucumber.

‘As you can see,’ I added, with a spark of half-retained scientific mumbo, ‘Emily can now lie in puddles of cocktail, human blood and cetera for hours at a time, thanks to her Catra-suggested Al-something coating.’

Emily modelled her flanks with fitting immodesty. I’d be something of a show-off too, if I represented an epoch-altering advance in the human understanding of science and consciousness. Good for her.

Mermista was giggling. ‘This. This is amazing. Oh, Adora, I have missed you SOOOO bad. Is it always this, like, chaotic? For the whole twelve years since *she* got us separated?’

Hmm. How to summate an adolescence and an early adulthood racked with all kinds of negativity and confusion, replaced very recently with positivity and boundless hope, in a single, sufficiently pithy statement for the Detective to take it all in as one? There really wasn't a simple word for that. Not in Etherian, anyhow. Squirrel is by far the more expressive tongue.

'Ch-ch-Chrrp. B-tsh-Buh-buh-bu-tsah,' I said. And I meant every word.

Mermista comprehended not one syllable. But it didn't matter. When she asked my consent, then squeezed my forearm with the tenderness of someone who was back to stay, I knew she understood.

'Okay, Adora.' She smiled at me. 'Okay. For now, can we get Emily to lie back down there, under a sheet or something? Then we're going to get Scorpia in here. Y'know, since she and Emily are already buddies.'

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The Mer-Mystery of Blood-Borough Hall: Part 5 - All That Glimmer's Not Gold

Chapter Summary

'We're really getting down to brass tacks now! Though maybe that should be gold tacks, given our super ritzy location. I mean... if gold tacks are a thing. I don't know if they are. But I DO know about murder investigations, and this chapter we get back into interviews, which turn out even juicier than last time. Why? Because I have more to ask about than Kyle. And - for the first and, I super hope, last time - I go face-to-face with Lady Glimmer Brightmoon. You wanna see what happens when a Countess comes up against Detective Whirlpool Mermot? Then, like, read on...'

Chapter Notes

If you like anything about the story, you're always so welcome to leave comments. I've loved the ones you've left so far! 💜 They make my day!! Thanks for reading x

I mentioned my other multi-chapter fic - Cuttin' on The Ritz - a Hazbin Hotel novella. That's now finished! Just like Meowmeow will be, hopefully very soon!

Content warnings apply for the below chapter only - Spoilers may be present in the warnings. This story does not include any of the four Archive Warnings topics, but does occasionally feature other topics that may require content notes. This chapter is rated Mature due to ongoing murder investigation plot.

Chapter 50 Content Warnings (CONTAINS SPOILERS):
Death, assumed – Narrated and in speech, recent historic, no real death occurs
Murder, assumed – Narrated and in speech, recent historic, no real murder occurs

Poisoning, assumed – Narrated and in speech, recent historic and present, no real poisoning occurs
Transphobia – In speech, historic and ongoing, extensive, heavily impacts character, by family
Homophobia – In speech, historic and ongoing, extensive, heavily impacts character, by family
Disowning – In speech, historic and ongoing, extensive, heavily impacts character, by family
Slavery – In speech, historic, by families of main character and major character
Systemic oppression – In speech, historic and ongoing, by families of main character and major character
Physical violence, pushing – In speech, historic, deliberate, causes bruising, intent to break bones
Gaslighting – In speech, historic, extensive

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PART 11

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Old Scorpy relieved us in the chamber of describable un-horror, but not before she'd had a quiet word with the two of us: 'Um, yeah, gee, folks… Kyle seems to be fine? If that is Kyle? I'm still not clear on that. But, gee, he did *not* like taking his medicine.'

'Funny, that.' Mermot cocked an eyebrow like it wasn't amusing in the slightest. A poison sigh later, she was face-to-face with the man who'd been my valet – or the person pretending to be that gent. 'Okay, so here's the deal,' she sighed at him. 'I don't think you were poisoned. Either time. But I do think--- no, I *know* you
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were summoned here *by* someone. And I know who. So… Listen. It's great you're alive, I guess, but you do NOT get to ruin this next bit for me. The Final Reveal is MY time to shine – and YOU stay locked in this library until Adora comes to get you? Understand? And do NOT die in the meantime. That'd really ruin my conclusion. Then I really *will* be pissed.'

Kyle shook and nodded and otherwise tried to show his perfect obedience to the well-hatted Lady with the weaponised cane. Said woman entombed him in the bookery without a second thought, then beckoned me back down the hallways until we were comfortably perched back in the Gallery, right where we'd been an hour or two before. So far as the various suspects knew, this was where we'd been all along.

'Go get--- You know what, Adora, dealer's choice. Any one of them except the Brightmoon cousins.'

I chose Perfuma. Being on the receiving end of it myself, I couldn't bring myself to keep bleeding-heart Sapphics apart, when a heartfelt, lips-pressed reunion was on the table. Even if said furniture was splashed in ambiguously unreal human lubricant. That's blood, if you prefer.

The gardener perched herself down in freckled anxiety, smoothing the satin of her ballgown over and over. Her opera gloves were starting to fray where she'd been pinching them up. She looked cold. And lost. I wanted to hug her, which took me by surprise, physical contact so rarely being a me-first sort of initiative. Mermot blew cigarette smoke at the air just above her, then looked through the haze, setting the tone for our second round of interviews.

‘Tell me about---’

‘Kyle? He told me “the boss” wouldn’t like what I was doing to those cacti. But that must have been you, She-Ra, mustn’t it? You’ve got a cactus at home… for *some* reason.’ She visibly shuddered at the thought. Poor Mr. Bunny Ears. I almost felt offended. ‘And we’re friends now, aren’t we?! Yes? Hah. Hu-ha!? So it was all a big misunderstanding… I hope?’

‘Nah.’ The Detective sighed. ‘Let me finish, Ms. Plumers, m’kay? Unless you want to talk about things that aren’t strictly related to the case, like how SO MANY of the so-called “exotic” plants in yours and every other ritzy Etherian greenhouse only made it to this country because they were taken from their home country without permission, payment or, like, even the first thought for how their removal might impact local ecosystems? No? Then maybe we should talk about your orientalising faux-Buddhist bullshit, which conglomerates and reduces a collection of ancient Asian religions and cultural practises into a rich white woman’s rookie fitness regime, devoid of its historic spiritual meanings?’

Ouch. Lady Plumers did not appear to be taking this wide-ranging critique of her life very well. She was on the verge of tears and rebuttal, but Mermot pushed on.

‘So my *actual* question is this: Tell me about Glimmer.’

‘Glimmer?’ Perfs gasped. ‘Not Kyle?’

‘Glimmer. Kyle’s old news. He’s in there with a sheet over him. I want to know about Glimmer. What you like, dislike, suspect, fear. Anything interesting, important, or unusual. Go.’

Perfuma worried her pearl bracelet and her bottom lip. ‘Hmm… I don’t know if I--- Have either of you had a hard time coming out, particularly when it comes to family?’

‘Yes. With my Aunt Shadowtha.’

‘Like, kinda, yeah. With her Aunt Shadowtha.’

‘Oh, okay.’ Lady P nodded as if Mermot’s revelation made entire sense in relation to mine, which it did, of course, but shouldn’t have done to her. ‘I haven’t been… *myself*… allowed to be… No, that’s not right… I’ve *always* been myself… but not always so publicly, if that makes sense?’

‘You haven’t been out as yourself for too long? That right?’ Detective Whirlpool moved in with sympathy and – for once – without the acrid spiral of a cigarette.

‘No! Yes! That’s right. As a girl *or* as a Lesbian.’

‘And your parents took it… not well?’

Plumers nodded. She looked just about fit to cry. Moved by sympathy or empathy – or whichever y-word I mean, since my situation wasn't exactly the same but probably wasn't much better – I offered her a hug. A popular offer, it turned out. Her velvet-clad fingers dug into me like she was so, so scared I'd ever let go. I squeezed her a little tighter.

'It--- it's not easy--- It's actually really hard---' she told my shoulder, 'when the people who claimed to love you whatever happens turn away the second you show them who you really are… When you show them their cookie-cutter child is really their brave, beautiful daughter… and they just don't want to know. They--- my--- They're treating it like I *died*. Like I don't exist. Like I'm not here and finally, desperately *real*.'

Whirlpool shook her head. '*Fuck* me. That's some grade-A cishet bullshit. Parents are fucked up.'

Burning and gorgeous and defiant and loved, the woman in my arms nodded vigorously.

'It's--- It's--- *SHIT*. Sorry. Sorry I said "shit". I don't swear, normally. They just--- I tried to stay, I did. But I couldn't. I was suffocating. It was worse than being closeted. Can you imagine? Being out in theory, all the while being called by your deadname and those false, *evil* pronouns, and no-one ever seeing you? She-Ra, I *couldn't*. I pushed back. Suddenly I was… out. I had to find work, I had to find somewhere to live, and I needed both those things straight away. Glimmer was the friend – the one friend – who was there for me.

‘That’s why it’s so confusing how she treated Catra. Glimmer has been so good to me, and this has been a really nice place to live, right up until you arrived, She-Ra. Catra just flicks something in her head. And that’s so scary! If she can be so… so *callous* to one trans woman, not even caring if she makes things unsafe for her, will she do the same thing to me? What happens if she finds out about my little moment in Regent’s Park? What if Kyle told her already? I *need* this job. I need to be safe here. I’m not really Lady Plumers. My family control the title. And I haven’t got it. I haven’t got anything.’

‘You’ve got us,’ I reminded her. ‘You’ve got me and Catra. And Bow. And Scorpia. Who’s right in there. Can she go, Mermista?’

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Mermista wiped a tear away as she clicked the Red Room doors shut. ‘Shit. Just… *shit*. But we gotta keep going. Get me Entrapta.’

‘Hiiiii!! Caught the killer yet?’ The engineer looked at us both in fervent fascination. ‘And why is Adora in She-Ra form? Why has Detective Mermot been crying? Why are there scrapes of coal dust on your right knee? Does it smell veerrryy slightly like almonds in here? Or is that just me?’

‘Look,’ Mermot sighed. ‘You’re perceptive, right? So you already know Kyle isn’t dead.’
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‘I’d calculated there was a greater probability he was still alive, yes. Based on the publicly available information – plus the details shared in dining room – no-one here benefits sufficiently from his murder. Excepting wanton violence and crimes of passion, murder is generally enacted to create or protect an individual’s personal gain. *Realllyyy*… The task of a detective is simply to collect enough *data* and systematically process it into a series of probabilities assigned to various scenarios and individuals, until the most likely death scenario emerges.

‘So long as the parameters are all properly defined, the *REAAALLL* work at the heart of every investigation is *data-wrangling* and *calculation*. Isn’t that *FASCINATING??!* All the human element needs to do is trust the result! And people are so bad at that! They have hunches, and suspicions, and biases… What if we could do away with all those mortal flaws? Couldn’t this entire process be ultimately automated? How AMAZING!! How AWFUL! Is there a future where criminal culpability is *computationally* determined by machines… provided, of course, this Brave New World has the same thirst for retributive justice… If you can call *that* justice!

‘Note to self: Have I just invented something even worse than Bentham’s *PANOPTICON*?! Can science go too far? Is there a point where human development must choose between ethics and mechanics? Rebuild Emily as a crime-fighter? Do I get her a deerstalker – or is that too *stereotypical*??’

‘About Emily---’ Mermista broke in. This was her fourth, maybe fifth attempt to stop Entrapta’s fearfully fascinating thought stream, and the only one to stick. ‘---Can she take the form of people she’s met before? And of people she hasn’t?’

‘Yes. No. In order.’

‘So that means she’s met Kyle?’

‘I *suppose* so--- She might have seen him when he visited me in the workshops, I guess, but she was pretty busy rebuilding the carburetion for Skyhawk’s de Havilland.’

‘Is a glance enough for her to take a person’s form?’

‘Yes. But not sufficient for her to get a subject’s voice or movements.’

‘Okay. Adora, do the Squirrel words.’

‘Ch-ch-chrrp. Bk-qwk. Rt-CH btkk,’ I obliged.

‘Wow! Is that--- Emily, have you taken She-Ra form?? Can you do the transformation sequence?! I would *love* to see you do the transformation!’

Whirlpool nodded. ‘So that *is* how Emily speaks, when she’s – I dunno – left to her own devices? Cool. Entrapta, tell me about

Glimmer.’

‘Glimmer is the only daughter of the Duke and Duchess Brightmoon, whose *entiirrreee* family history is drenched in blood. Like any other Prime-era aristocratic lineage, they derive passive income from centuries of oppression and land theft, systemically separating the Etherian worker from the means of production. Later on, they did the same in Wales and Ireland, then across large portions of the developing Etherian Empire. The Brightmoons perfected a system of violently thieving what isn’t theirs, then laundering the resultant income into investments and assets. And they do NOT like being reminded of the Indian and Caribbean plantations. But they *definitely* held them. The Brightmoons were slavers, just like the de l’Hordes. But I *thiiiiiinnnk* you knew that already?’

‘Of course,’ Mermista nodded, somewhere between a snarl and a sneer. How could she take this so cooly? That mine and Glimmer’s families had been pivotal parts of dehumanising atrocity?!

‘I d-d-didn’t!!’ I finally managed to stammer out. ‘You mean my family owned--- not *owned*--- asserted ownership and control over other human beings?!’

‘Yup!’ Entrapta replied. ‘Your family bought enslaved people and forced them to work and live in squalid, dehumanising conditions. The wealth you grew up on is derived from slavery. Imperial Etheria is a *hiddeeeeousss* project to enrich an elite at any costs, just like me and Catra were trying to tell you. A couple of days ago? By the stables? Did that not sink in?’

‘No. N-no. I don’t want to be a part of that. What do I do?!’

‘Read a book? Make reparations? Acknowledge your family has done – and probably is still doing – serious harm and work to stop it? We don’t *know*. It’s not our duty to hold your hand.’ Mermista’s arms were folded so tight they’d formed a natural vacuum. ‘Just don’t go making out that you’re the victim in all this. Not that I think you will. But it’s, like, SO exhausting when rich white people do that. You can’t fix this by yourself, by feeling bad, by whatever… If you’re going to help, you’ve gotta know this is not about you.’

She exhaled, hard, turning back to Entrapta. There was still a not-murder to somehow solve.

‘Given all of that, why do you work here?’

‘It’s an ethical *dilemma*… Dilemma number 68, I think? Ironically, I need capital to oppose capital*ism*. And the Brightmoon garages have SO MANY cool machines!! I could *neeeevvveeerr* manage to get all those for myself without working here, and it’s a good front for my She-Ra research. Though I suppose that can be more in the open now? Not so much my first-hand notes on how to bring down the aristocracy! But… um… Adora? You maybe didn’t hear that bit.

‘*Annnyyyyyyway*… Glimmer got me the job here after I fixed her old Isotta-Fraschini. That’s a *car*. It was BADLY in need of valve-lapping and a head skim. She *insisted* I come work for her, especially once she learned I’m *suppppeeeer* queer. She doesn’t

care about much – but she DOES want to protect people like us. Except Catra.'

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Two down, several to go. Wrongcle repeated pretty much the same information, albeit with more of a focus on the present-day injustices inflicted by the Brightmoons. Bowregard repeated his obvious guilt several times, requiring the full crime-fighting powers of Detective Whirlpool Mermot to shift even part of his attention towards Glimmer. When he did, the news was as he'd already said…

To wit: Glimmer was a fundamentally good person, once you got to know her, or so Bow had always thought; sometimes Lady Brightmoon didn't know where the line lay; her recent actions were much too much, and Bow wasn't sure how to broach that with her; but she definitely wouldn't kill someone, even if she had been acting strangely lately; she was madly in love with me and had no idea how to show it; Catra was a flashpoint that Glimmer couldn't work out how to handle; that was no excuse for how Glimmer treated her; Bow liked Catra; wouldn't it all be nice if we could all be friends or girlfriends or something and put all this behind us?

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Skyhawk managed a shorter interview still.

‘Ah-ha! The lovely lady Detectiveress!’ He clomped his boot on a chair. ‘Perhaps you could help me? I’ve been shot through the heart---’ Cupping her hand to my ear, Mermista groaned “If only…” in a very withering way. ‘---and I need your help finding the culprit! She’s tall, smart, stylish, powerful… Yegads! It’s you!’

‘TELL. ME. ABOUT. GLIMMER.’

‘Sure, she can come too if you like! Whatever the Lady wants, the Lady gets.’

‘NO. TELL ME ABOUT HOW YOU KNOW GLIMMER – AND WHY YOU’RE HERE.’

‘I confess!! I don’t know the Lady Brightmoon at all… But her parties, her soirees, her evening functions… are the stuff of legend! Pretty men and dashing women as far as the eyes can see! Where better for a daring pilot to recount the tales of their latest ADVENTURE?! As to why I’m here… I’m here to invite you, Detective Mermot, to let me accompany you to tomorrow’s Midsummer Ball.’

‘Get out. No – not that way. Go to the drawing room, not the dining room.’

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Marquioness Double-Trubel launched themself uneasily over a settee. Their limbs sprawled out in their usual languor, but their fast-flicking tongue indicated a mind hard at work. They said nothing. I thought back to this morning. I knew they couldn't last. I tapped Mermot to tell her as much and her arms crossed at our interviewee like a pair of portcullises. They were trapped. They just didn't know it yet.

'*Kittens*…' they drawled at the weight of silence. 'Doesn't every second count? You MUST have some*thing* you want to say to me? I swear I didn't know the car crash was real – and I really do feel bad about it. Surely you see that, Adora?'

I kept my lips clamped tight.

'I only pushed Kyle down the backstage stairs twice, okay? Even then, my efforts were half-hearted. I didn't *commit* to the role! Heavens knows why… I was aiming to break a bone or two, nothing more, but he got away with bruises. Curses! Those *prima donna* flares aside, I've been nothing but civil in my attempts to destroy him.'

Double-Trubel unfolded their long, stylish fingers and started counting.

'I invited him to drink and dine and drink before a big rehearsal… I questioned his stresses… I espoused the family hardships of a life on the stage to Lonnie and Rogelio, so they'd persuade him to quit… I told him *Pericles* was my favourite Shakespeare and *Hamlet* was trash, hoping to inspire a crisis of taste… I even

implied that only hacks look at the Arts pages… But I didn't *kill* him. That would be *MUCH* too *messy*, don't you agree? And how would that have served ME? If he's dead, the 'papers are going to write about him more, not less!!'

'You're a busy musician,' Mermot smiled. 'It's gotta be tough being stuck all the way up here. You must send a lot of messages – can I see the drafts?'

'No.'

'Because they're, like, super salacious?'

'A-ha-ha! I'm warming up to you, detective. And no, that's not the reason. I've no problem showing you evidence of my intimate life, but I just *don't* write down my own missives. What a waste of time that would be! I dictate them direct to the staff.'

'Cool. Tell me about Glimmer.'

'Sparkles is about the best-worst or worst-best cousin a noble-turned-performer could hope for. She's got oodles of money coupled with a *stunning* need to be the biggest person in the room, so time around her is ALWAYS a net positive for your bank balance. I see a lot of her… and it's at least a little for that last reason. Our mutual loves of parties, clothes and being beautifully, creatively MEAN make us a natural match, you could say. Oh, but by my Muses! The girl has a *temper*. And the girl has the most

crushing crush on Adora. Though it doesn't take a detective to work *THAT* out, does it?! Ah-hah!'

'Anything else?'

'If you told me she killed Kyle, I would be--- how to put this? *Unsurprised*, darlings. That cousin of mine gets what she wants or makes the world suffer. You MUST have figured out that those two spoke this afternoon, of course. Why else would my champagne-shipping cousin be seen ordering a bottle of Amaretto? We know how much Kyle likes – or should that be liked? – his almond liqueur. They've met before, too, or so she tells me. Maybe ask her about those little *tristes*?'

'But you said she hired me. Why would a murderer do that?'

'Ah-ha-HA-HA!!' Trubel-Brightmoon rocked back and forth, bursting out in waves of twinkling, musical giggles. 'Not a MURDERER, darlings! A *GLIMMER*. As if Sparkles could even conceive of being arrested, let alone facing *criminal charges*. Her? The Brightmoon heir? In non-sexy handcuffs? I don't think so.'

'Alright. So, again, why would Glimmer do that?'

'The DRAMA? A final fuck you to the man who couldn't help her get what she wants? Most likely, if you want *my* opinion, she wanted to host the most notorious party of the year, which your presence was naturally guaranteed to achieve. Staffordshire is

boring… *mostly*. No wonder she telegrammed you! Can you blame her?'

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'Is it just me,' I asked, 'or did Double-Trubel tell us a whole bunch of nothing new?'

'Yah, they did NOT want to get to the point. But they still told me everything I needed to know.' Mermista smirked.

'Can you tell me?'

'Not yet. Go get Glimmer.'

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The Brightmoon heir huffed like only a direct heir to the throne could, somehow managing to straighten her back, square her jaw, flick her chin, and sink into her folded arms all at the same time. Her eyes were red. She'd been chewing her nails. Through three layers of undoubtedly expensive kohl, she glowered at the Detective.

‘You didn’t talk with me before. You questioned everyone else. *Why the fuck* did you leave me out? What gives you the right to keep me waiting?’

‘So,’ Mermista lit yet another cigarette, ‘you can like it or you can not like it. I *so* do not care. But this is my investigation, I’m in charge, and a man is **dead**.’ Lady Brightmoon squirmed. She looked like she was about to say something, then stared at me instead, going a soft pink even her practised scowl couldn’t mask. Whirpool Mermot pressed home her advantage. ‘You’re in love with Adora. Which I totally get. Because I’ve kissed them myself and junk.’ Blowing a fine fug of nicotine smoke across the table, she perched her chin on her knuckles, watched and waited.

‘NO YOU *FUCKING* HAVEN’T!!’

‘Sure I have. She kisses with eyes wide open, like they can’t believe they get to kiss a girl.’

‘WHY WOULD SHE KISS **YOU**?! YOU *FUCKING* LIAR!! YOU DON’T EVEN *KNOW* ANYTHING ABOUT EACH OTHER!’

‘I know they sleep with a cotton horse called Swiftie. I know she uses long-distance running to get time to herself. I know she sticks her tongue out the left side of her mouth when they’re really concentrating.’

‘NO. **NO. *STOP!!*** IT’S NOT TRUE. YOU DON’T *UNDERSTAND* HER. YOU CAN’T! NOT LIKE I DO. GET YOUR OWN GIRLFRIEND – WE *BELONG* TOGETHER!!’

‘Did Kyle see it that way?’

‘How would *I* know?’

‘You spent cocktail hour with him this afternoon. You tell me.’

Glimmer went a lot paler all of a sudden.

‘How do you know that?’

‘I’m a super great detective, duh. Which means I also figured out he was afraid of meeting you.’

‘As if! Maybe Kyle thought I was pissed about the last times, but I *got* what I *wanted* in the end, even if it was no thanks to him. I had *no reason* to be mad. I wasn’t mad. I actually offered him a really good deal, which I needed him to be *alive* for. Just in case you think I killed him.’

‘I don’t,’ Mermista smiled. ‘But I do need you to step into the Red Drawing Room with me. Adora, it’s time. You know what to do.’

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The Mer-Mystery of Blood-Borough Hall: Part 6 - Look How Good I Am At Solving Murders!

Chapter Summary

'So, I don't really have anything left to say except - BASK IN MY MOTHERFLIPPIN' BRILLIANCE, FOR I AM DETECTIVE WHIRLPOOL MERMOT!! Gasp in amazement as I totally solve this case - and stand up for my pal Adora - and make some really solid points about the Etherian class syste--- Err, what's that crashing sound?'

'Ah, Mermista, I thought we'd find you here! What-Ho! Did we miss it?! Have you saved the day?'

'I am literally just about to. Did you bring popcorn, Adora?'

'Err... No. But I have procured rather a lot of my family's money, a champagne bottle full of jelly babies, and the Horde Prime Minister's left shoe. Oh! How could I forget? We've also booked passage on a ship, to somewhere we're less... well... wanted by the authorities. Do you fancy coming with us? I'll explain it all on the way.'

'One could almost call it a bonus chapter, sir.'

Chapter Notes

Woo! Penultimate chapter! This unexpectedly epic novel has an end - and it's next chapter! Thank you so much for anyone who's made it this far... I always love your comments! 💜 Thanks for reading x

Content warnings apply for the below chapter only - Spoilers may be present in the warnings. This story does not include any of the four Archive Warnings topics, but does occasionally feature other topics that may require content notes. This

chapter is rated Mature due to ongoing murder investigation plot.

Chapter 51 Content Warnings (CONTAINS SPOILERS):
Death, assumed – Narrated and in speech, recent historic, no real death occurs
Murder, assumed – Narrated and in speech, recent historic, no real murder occurs
Poisoning, assumed – Narrated and in speech, recent historic and present, no real poisoning occurs
Transphobia – In speech, historic and ongoing, extensive, heavily impacts character, by family
Homophobia – In speech, historic and ongoing, extensive, heavily impacts character, by family
Disowning – In speech, historic and ongoing, extensive, heavily impacts character, by family
Slavery – In speech, historic, by families of main character and major character
Systemic oppression – In speech, historic and ongoing, by families of main character and major character
Physical violence, pushing – In speech, historic, deliberate, causes bruising, intent to break bones
Physical violence, pushing – Narrated, present, deliberate (no physical injury occurs)
Gun – Narrated, present (not fired)
Dagger – Narrated, present (not used)
Gaslighting – In speech, historic and present, extensive
Exile – Related in speech, historic and present, of major character, impacts main character
Class hatred – In speech, present, extensive, by aristocracy, towards working class
Dehumanisation – In speech, present, extensive, by aristocracy, towards their staff
Possessiveness, abuse dynamic – In speech and narrated, present, intensifies at end of chapter, by major character, towards main character

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CHAPTER 51

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Kyle and I stood in the Red Room entranceway, looking and listening through a just-big-enough crack in the doors. Detective Mermot whirled around the room something balletic, scraping big ticket furniture against antique flooring until every seat in the room fanned out in a semi-circle, looking towards the sheet-covered not-Kyle and the long, long steps of empty between there and the doors. Whirlpool had built herself quite a stage. With a clap of her hands and a proclamation, she got the audience to match. One by one, the suspects plopped into chairs, minus Scorpia. She stayed standing where she'd been put, an impervious, imperial headstone.

'M'kay. Listen up and listen good, because this is the bit you'll be telling your friends and family and children and whatever about. Do not ask questions. Do not posit theories. In fact… Don't say anything, okay? Whatever it is, it can wait until I'm done. I will NOT let you ruin the ending the same way you messed up my intro. Some clapping is allowed. Gasps are encouraged, not gonna lie. So you better be sitting comfortably, 'cause it's time for THE REVEAL.'

Ten fascinated faces leaned forwards. We were two of them, so all we did was drive our heads into the door. Mermista had her hands on her hips, flicked her head, then pointed hard at the bedsheet.
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‘Kyle isn’t dead!’ Mermista announced. Several gasps. ‘He never has been. And this---’ Perfectly on prompt, Scorpy whipped the concealing cotton away. ‘---This is NOT Kyle. Nah. The real Kyle is alive, well, and waiting just outside.’ It was my turn. I slammed the twin doors open with all my mystical might. ‘Come on down, Kyle. Wave to the people, show them you’re not dead. That’s it. Perfect!! My days, the looks on all your faces. But get this. Not only has he survived, nobody even, like, *attempted* to murder him.’

Kyle himself gasped at that. I elbowed him – lightly – to stop him talking. The chance to see Detective Whirlpool Mermot in full flight is a once in a lifetime thing, no pun intended, so we were making like Catra wouldn’t and damned well following the rules. As quietly as we could manage, we dropped into two spare seats and let Mermot continue.

‘Okay, okay. That’s big, right? And it raises questions. If no-one wants to murder Kyle, why was he even here? Why was he lying in a pool of blood? Why is a second Kyle in that blood now? And who calls a Detective to a crime that hasn’t happened and wasn’t meant to? Let’s tackle those in order, shall we?’

A crash of lightning reverberated off the patio outside.

‘Number One – Why Is Kyle Here? Simple. He was invited… by Glimmer!’

‘You already knew that! We already talked about it!’

‘No interrupting! Lady Glimmer Brightmoon summoned Kyle to Shugborough Hall for a friendly meeting. She welcomed him into her chambers, served his favourite tipple… and put a proposition to him. Would he become Sir Adora de l’Horde’s valet again? He said yes, if he could make it happen. Because that’s what you always say, isn’t it Kyle? Glimmer asked you for loads of favours before, which you always agreed to… for a price. But you never got her what she *really* wanted. She wanted Adora to love her back – and I think she paid you handsomely to engineer meet-cute after meet-cute.’

That did explain how often the car had broken down, or my train tickets had been misbooked, or some message had been lost in translation and Glimmer just *had* to visit me in my apartment.

‘Of course, Kyle couldn’t straight up insert himself as valet, right? Catra is a long, long, looooonngg way down the valet-to-lover pipeline, but Adora hasn’t started looking for new help yet, and it’s pretty suss if an old domestic help flame turns up out of the blue, miles from where Sir de l’Horde lives. Nah, this needed to be plausible. Enter the fabricated backstory – *Adora’s Aunt Shadowtha had sent him here*. But that was pretty weak. Like, I’ve met Shadowtha de l’Horde and she can NOT resist an opportunity to meddle in her ward’s life. Ask me how I know. If Shadowtha wanted Kyle back in his old role, she would have just hired him straight up.’

‘It didn’t hold water. Which got me thinking – why would he even come? Let’s see. Kyle Nieman is set to star in one of the biggest West End shows of the year, but production has ground to a halt since a strike was called. Now, if you’re Double-Trubel, that’s, like,

no sweat. You can afford to walk out until your terms a met: you've got a successful music career to fall back on… plus a *very* rich family. Not Kyle. This show was going to be his BIG break. He's gambled *everything* on this moment and, when bypassing the picket line doesn't get the show back on the road, he's left pondering what else he can do to keep his dream alive.

'So he goes to see the star. Finding the Marquioness isn't hard, right? Either they already boasted to Kyle about where they were going, or our favourite ex-valet put two and two together when he got that invitation from the Lady Brightmoon. It's not a common surname, right? And now Kyle can smudge out two birds with a single stone. Glimmer puts cash in his hand; Double-Trubel strikes up the band. Perfect, right?

'*Wrong*. Because – and this is conjecture – Kyle starts worrying about how his co-star is going to react to him. Double-Trubel told us all about their campaign of terror, focused on undermining Kyle and his creative self-belief at every turn. Maybe that got him undervaluing his real talent levels; maybe it filled him with a burning rage that could only be extinguished by proving the Marquioness wrong. Whatever one is right, the end result is the same: Kyle decided to fake his death.

'Let's walk through his original plan. Kyle, you can, like, stop me if I'm wrong – but I won't be. After arriving at Shugborough, you scoped out the house and figured out this room, *right here*, was where your death would have the most impact. Sometime between then and your meeting with Glimmer, you saw the Duke and the Duchess leave, which basically confirmed there'd be a party this evening. 'Cause, you know, Glimmer is *Glimmer*.

‘So you had a time and a place. Some time during the party, you’d be discovered underneath a settee, drenched in what I’m pretty certain is animal blood from a local butcher. The attending guests would believe you were dead, the coppers would get called, Double-Trubel would hopefully pontificate and then – and only then – you’d spring up and reveal you were still alive. Much applause; the Marquioness is humbled; your working relationship is restored. A legendary party ensues, or *whatever*…

‘Except… It didn’t work out like that. The whole plan went sideways when Lady Brightmoon offered you a drink: Amaretto di Saronno, your favourite. That tumbler set your senses tingling – because it is *not* like Glimmer to be thoughtful, or considerate, or *nice*. Given the topics of the meeting, which would’ve ranged between her offer, your obligations, Adora’s new valet, Adora’s new girlfriend, how those two were one and the same person, and how that NEVER would’ve happened if you’d just stayed a valet *like you should*, you would have suspected Glimmer was in an even worse mood than normal. Which is why, spurred on by too many news reports of too many low-quality slayings, you thought of almonds… *and cyanide*.

‘Now Kyle believes he’s been brought here to die, so he calls on the only people he can trust. The people only he, out of everyone invited to this house, ever *really* sees. The staff. Forget the big death reveal – he can prove his survival or acting talents or both to Double-Trubel later. For the time being, he just needs to escape. And for *Glimmer* to think he’s dead.

‘The first part of his plan stays exactly the same as before, but it splinters off when the assorted nobility file out of the room, aided, unexpectedly, by my arrival. Our wouldn’t-be murder victim didn’t plan for that – and he didn’t call for me. So who did? That’s

simple… It's the person who *meant* to "die" at tonight's cocktail hour: Double-Trubel.'

'*Me*? Kittteenn, MEOW! Be *careful* where you poke those claws. A big cat might snap back… with their lawyers. You can't POSSIBLY hope to *prove* I did something so very desperate as that.'

'Yah, hope doesn't come into it. I *know* I can. Why? Well, aristos, I'll let you in on a little secret: your staff all absolutely fucking *hate* you. And who can blame them? You control the money, the land, the whole Hordedamn country, and string them along with scraps. And if you don't like them, you berate them. Or you dock their wages. Or you fire them. Or worse. Can you *imagine* what it's like to face that, day after day, knowing you've gotta keep a smile pasted across your face for every single second of it, because if you don't work, you don't eat?

'Yes, my sister! Preach it!' Wrongcle cheered, scrambling to his feet. 'Speak truth to the bourgeois swine! Their day will come! Their world will burn!'

'Okay,' Mermot growled, 'did I not just say *no comments until the end*? Sit down. The rest of you, take heed. What that man just said is what basically everyone you employ *really* thinks. I can only imagine that gets awkward when your maudlin, self-fellating boss decides they're too good to jot down their own telegrams. Wouldn't you want to get your own back? If, say, this posh prick has decided to engage a busy professional with bills to pay as an unwitting accomplice to their latest childish mewling for attention, doesn't it get a little too tempting to add a detail to the "anonymous" wire that gives Detective Whirlpool Mermot an idea who to bill for *all her wasted time*?'

Stepping forward, Mermot rustled theatrically through her pockets and dropped a scrap of typeface into the Marquioness' lap: *Murder most foul at Shugborough Hall, Staffordshire. Come quick, I beg you. Yours urgently, M. Chatton!*

Oh, cripes! Double-Trubel was flushing a deep, forest green and kicking their chair out from under themselves, splintering hundreds of pounds sterling backwards across the room. Their handbag flashed open and, quick as a wicket, they had a pearl-handled revolver in one hand and an angry little dagger in the other. They towered over Mermot, hissing, their eyes darting so sharp and furious they flushed almost entirely red.

'*MOTHER**FUCK!!*** *Which* one of them was it?! I'll FUCKING kill them, kitten, I swear!'

'Yah. The fact you don't know is, like, super indicative of how you ended up here. As a matter of fact, it's also the detail that blows this whole case wide open, like I was *trying* to explain. So – again – and for the *super* last time – *you will take a seat and be quiet*. Or I will make you.'

'Ha-ha-huh! Just try and stop me, Mermot!'

Double-Trubel took a step and elbow-barged into Whirlpool, who faltered on her weaker leg. We didn't need to see any more. Before the Marquioness could get another inch closer to the door,

Scorpy and I were right with the Detective, forming a muscle-and-honour-bound human shield.

The Detective smiled her thanks. ‘So I’ve got Scorpia BlackStone and the literal She-Ra on my side, which feels like a *lot* more than you have. I am *warning* you, Trubel-Brightmoon. Sit down. And shut up. This is *my* moment.’

Suddenly shaking like a leaf, the Marquioness elected to do just that, cowing low as they recovered their seat and tried to turn it back into a piece of usable furniture. The Detective hauled herself down low, just a blink from the actor’s face, to deliver her devastating final blow.

‘Here’s my bill. Itemised. I had a *lot* of reasonable expenses.’

Somewhere off to the left, Glimmer laughed and laughed and laughed.

‘I wouldn’t cackle so soon,’ Mermot warned. ‘You’re next in my sights, because we like truth here. Lady Glimmer Brightmoon, in front of this room and the world’s greatest detective, you’ve got a *big* question to answer: Why did you exile Lady Catra Applesauce Meowmeow?’

‘**How** is that relevant to the *fucking* case, huh? And she is NOT *ANY KIND* of a motherfucking Lady. Why can’t you uppity ordinaries get that through your thick heads?! Lady isn’t a word

you just *throw around* because you feel like it. It is a ***signifier*** of particular, special, important social rank that you **don't have**. That you'll never have! You… You're just as bad as your so-called *Catra*. You strut in here and expect your *betters* to endorse your inflated sense of self-worth, like you have *any* fucking place at our tables that isn't picking up our scraps.'

'Fuck you.' Mermot said, slowly, clearly, twice. '*Fuck you.* You owe my friend Adora an answer. Why did you rip Catra Applesauce Meowmeow from the person she loves?'

'Ex-fucking-cuse you?! ***I DIDN'T separate them****.* Not, like, forever. Duh. They'll be reunited tomorrow. You're **overreacting**. Adora just needed *a little time* to get her priorities straight, didn't you Dory?'

'Hmm,' I chewed, deep in thought, and also three or four mastications into a toffee I'd found in a side table. Damned tasty thing it was too! Full of clotted cream. Now, how do you suppose they get the coagulation into the dairy produce, eh? Wait – I say! This is killing the mood, isn't it? And a time when the mood is rather entirely *about* killing. Or… not-killing, as the case may be. Well! Enough of my confection inflection and all that. Back to what the scholars might call a *denouement*. I was certainly ready to denounce Lady Brightmoon – I can tell you that for free!

'Whatever do you mean, Glitterbug?' I said, my lips only partially sealed by saccharine goop. 'My mind is clear as they come – though the less said about this "straight" business the better. I think we're a bit past me pretending to be *that*!'

‘**No**, Adora, I’m **NOT** suggesting you’re heterosexual. You’re so shitting *obviously* gay!! I’m just saying you’re going to be gay for *ME* **first**. Here. Together. Don’t you get it? ***I love you***!! I always have. So please, just this once… *Stay!*’

My jaw hung all the way through the floor. Truth be told, the old lower gnashers likely smashed through the piping, the basement and half-way into the underlying soil. Bow looked every bit as shocked. Scorpia went with a vaguely disapproving tut. Perfuma clapped her surprise. Even Double-Trubel stooped to a genuine emotional response, scattering their invoices to the floor and announcing:

‘*Sparkles*. What the *SHIT*?’

Somewhat inexplicably, Glimmer saw this is an invitation to keep going. ‘Don’t you see how good that would be for m--- *us*? We could have **everything** together. … … And, then, I guess, if you absolutely and *totally* must, I suppose we can work out some kind of a way for you to see Meo--- *Catra* sometimes. Remember what Daddy said? She can live here… ish – but **not** *here* here. We can give her… I dunno… A room in the junior servants’ quarters or something?’

Mermot balled her hands on her hips and stepped back into the ring with a solitary: ‘*Wow*.’

‘***WHAT?!***’ Glimmer panted back. ‘Huh? **WHAT IS IT NOW?!**’

‘I mean, this is just getting *sad*, hun. Be better.’

‘Just *where* do you get off on telling ***me*** what to do?! I’m a motherfucking Countess, and you’re just… a… murder-solving… *worker-ant*.’

‘And there you have it.’ Mermot shook her head and squeezed my shoulder. ‘Your host thinks staff are less than human – and I’m willing to bet she’s not the only one. Think, those of you that have household help, long and hard. How much do you know about their lives, their hopes, their dreams, their families? Do they still exist to you when they walk out of the side door at the end of the day? What have you done to really connect with them as your fellow human being? *Do you even notice when they slip in and out of the room?*’

‘Oh,’ Scorpy gasped. ‘I’ve got it. That--- that’s *good*.’

The Detective grinned, winking at each of us in turn. ‘Time for me to enlighten the rest of them. Suspects, sit back down.’ As far as I could tell, the whole room did just that, myself and Scorpy included. But Whirlpool wasn’t satisfied. Biting her lip, Mermot tried not to smile too deeply. ‘That means you too, Baker.’

A murmur tore through the room. Who was this Baker figure? A professional assassin? A member of the Constabulary, ready to take the guilty for a kip in the clink? Only we three knew the truth. Mermot and Scorps rode high on the reality they’d scrupulously puzzled out; I merely felt lower than a worm for forgetting the woman who’d delivered unto me Catra’s care

package. She'd done me that great kindness and I'd gone and filtered her out, like the sound of train tracks at the bottom of the garden. Just like everybody else.

'So we left Kyle fake-bleeding on the floor, with what he believes to be a *super* real need to get anywhere else,' Mermot announced. The final explanation had begun. 'That's our gasp-shock-horror reveal moment and it is *good*: good enough to fool even the famed Detective Whirlpool Mermot… almost. Because the first Kyle I met *was* the real Kyle. And, honestly, I'd give him maybe nine out of ten for acting the corpse. He suppressed his heartbeat, his expression was totally neutral, plus he didn't flinch when I kicked him *pre-tty* hard. The dude's a sweet actor.'

'Thank you, darling,' Kyle gushed. Stars were swimming in his eyes. 'I'd *love* your constructive criticism. What was it that let me down?'

'Yah, your performance was great. It's your knowledge of crime scene investigation that fell short. By using all that animal blood, you made out like you'd been attacked and bled to death. Which… okay… there was a *relatively* accurate amount of the red stuff all over the carpets. But where was the splatter from the initial attack? There wasn't one – anywhere. That's when my suspicions really started rising. Shit was getting *twisty*!

'So the next thing I do is file you all out of the room. I take Adora to one side – but the rest of you get placed under the watchful eye of somebody else. Anyone remember who? Come on aristos, you can, like, do it. Who did I appoint as your babysitter?'

‘The Baker!’ I gasped.

‘Damn right. Ten points to Sir Adora! Now tell me, everyone else, did the Baker walk into that Dining Room with you?’

‘*Obviously*, kitten. She must have done. It’s what the almighty *YOU* commanded,’ Double-Trubel laughed.

‘Yes,’ said Bow. ‘Yes? *Yes?*’

Scorpia looked less convinced. ‘Ah… gee… You know what? We got so busy with what everyone else was saying that I didn’t think to check.’

‘Eek,’ Perfuma confessed. ‘I don’t think I looked either.’

Mermot smirked in triumph. ‘That’s precisely what this plan relied upon. Unnoticed by all of us, Baker never left the drawing room, just as she and Kyle had plotted. Together, they helped each other out via the fireplace, which led them into Sir Adora’s chambers. From there, they just had to wait for their accomplices to track down Emily – which I’m told is a super common thing that staff here have to do – before convincing the robot to take Kyle’s form.

‘Maybe three minutes later, you’ve got a robot Kyle posted down the chimney and a flesh Kyle looking for the exit. While Baker and the gang scrub away their tracks, our unmurdered victim hits the

showers. It's all playing out super smoothly. Too smoothly. Baker, babe, you actually cleaned the drawing room *too* well. I'd already inspected the fireplace when I first arrived and it was covered in ash and grime and soot and whatever. By rubbing all that off, you basically confirmed you'd been climbing around in there. Oh, and you left some flour dust in Adora's room. That how I know it was you in particular.'

Baker nodded. She had nothing to add. She grinned slightly, and that was all.

'Neither of those teeny-tiny errors told me Kyle was alive, though. Nah. He did that all by himself. After his shower – or maybe during it, I dunno – Kyle is hit by a sudden *urge*. It might be fear. It might be vengeance. It might be greed. It might be blackmail. It's usually blackmail. *Anyway*. This impulse is so huge that he breaks away from the plan. Instead of drying off and shutting up like a good little escapee, he tiptoes down the corridor to Glimmer's room and starts searching. He goes through the desk, the drawers, the impressive lingerie section---'

'How the *FUCK* do you know about my negligee?!'

'Oh, yah,' Mermot nodded. 'We went in there. Your room is trashed.'

'***EXCUSE YOU?!***'

‘It was like that when we got there, honestly, all thanks to Kyle. That dude was looking for *something*… and he didn’t find it. That propelled him to the Library – and his **downfall**. Scorpia and Adora tackled him. It was totally rad. You should have been there. Oh, yeah, the Library is pretty wrecked too.’

Bow gasped in complete shock. ‘*Glimmer!* You have a *Library?!* What other secrets have you been hiding??’

‘So what was it, Kyle?’ Mermot concluded. ‘Were you scared Glimmer was going to track you down and splat you someplace else? Were you trying to warn Adora? Or was it blackmail? And of who? Were you going for gold with Glimmer or any easier payday with the de l’Hordes?’

‘Why would I tell you that?’

The great Detective stood up to her full, towering height and… nodded. ‘Yeah. Fair point. Aight, Mermot out!’

And, with that, Mermista fished her hat out of the cocktail snacks and headed for the door.

‘*Wait!!*’ Double-Trubel wailed. ‘Aren’t you going to *arrest* somebody?! Darling, I’d be so unentertained if this was how it ended. You could at *least* stay for the ball tomorrow? A hip sly like you would be the talk of the town. *Please*. If you’re not there to

introduce me, I'll have to use that *murderously* particular radio host…'

'Nah. Parties aren't my thing. And retributive justice has, like, super questionable societal value.' Mermot paused. Right on the cusp of the window from whence she'd entered, so many hours ago, she turned and beckoned me over. 'Adora, I see you and I value you. If you ever need a proud bisexual woman to be your friend *and* support your relationship, all at the same time, you know where I am.'

'And what is ***that*** supposed to mean?!' spat Glimmer. Her sparkle-soaked bob butted between Mermot's business card and my waiting hand. Before I knew it, I'd been pivoted by the waist and marched halfway to the stairs.

'The *fucking* cheek of that woman. Urgh! *Why couldn't I just have* ***one*** *little cocktail party without someone else causing a* ***scene****?* All I wanted was to spend some real quality time with my girlfriend.' Glimmer squeezed my hand hard enough to splinter bone. Her gaze – and there's no other way of putting this – unrobed me. 'It's *suuuuuuucch* a shame I'm so tired now… and that it's *soooooo* late… and that we have such a *BIIIIGGGG* day tomorrow. *Sigh!* I guess we'll just have to go to bed.'

'Ah, okay! Goodnight Glimmer!'

I started striding back to my own quarters, already envisioning the moment Catra and I could finally be reunited.

‘*Noooooooo*, Adora,’ a voice called after me. Then a hand was on my waist, and another cupped my rump. ‘It’s time for *you* to **take** *me* to bed, if you like? Tonight could be your *lucky* night…’

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Chapter 52

Chapter Summary

'What Ho, reader-doodles! Adora here, back in the seat and ready to introduce our final chapter... sort of. Like the linesmen at a soggy Wimbledon, we've got an awful lot of ground left to cover, so get ready to enjoy Chapter 52 in a series of sections. Can Catra make it back for the Ball? What will I wear to the event of the year? How many more vehicles can I crash? Does Swift Wind preside over a communist revolution? Who is Mara, how do I meet her, and why does it make me cry? And - most pressingly - how does one escape from Glimmer's clutches?'

'You don't appear to be trying too hard to escape...'

'Pah! What? Are you *jealous*, Catra?'

'I couldn't possibly say, sir.'

Chapter Notes

Content warnings apply for the below chapter only - Spoilers may be present in the warnings. This story does not include any of the four Archive Warnings topics, but does occasionally feature other topics that may require content notes. This chapter is rated Mature due to a bedroom sequence.

Chapter 52 Content Warnings (CONTAINS SPOILERS):
Possessiveness – In speech, present, extensive, by major character, towards main character
Gaslighting – In speech, present, extensive, by major character, towards main character
Abusive behaviour, lovebombing – In speech, present, extensive, by major character, towards main character
Relationship control/interference – Narrated and in speech, present and recent historic, by major character, towards main

characters
Exile – Narrated and in speech, recent historic and ongoing, by major character, towards main character
Forced engagement – Narrated and in speech, present, by major character, of main character

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PART 13

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SECTION 1

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‘Dory, *DORY*! Ohmigosh, wake up! You’ll never guess who’s here to see you. It’s going to *blow* your fucking mind!’ Glimmer stroked my hair, insistently. My eyes blurred open. It was too early to be up. After last night, today would always be too early to be up. One part fatigue, one part hangover and three parts romantic distress, finished with a dash of existentialism and shaken over ice, I scrambled myself upright and looked around. Lady Brightmoon. Right there. Lady Brightmoon, next to me. In bed. We were *sharing* a *bed*. Correction – we were sharing *her* bed. A bed I was chained to by a fluffy pink handcuff.

‘One bed? We’re in one bed? Together?’
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‘Best get used to it, babe. That was the first night of the rest of your life! Aren’t you just *SO* excited?! We can *finally* be together. You and me, Dory, *forever*… It’s all worked out – just the way I planned!!’

‘No. No it hasn’t! Where’s my girlfriend?!’

‘Uh, she’s right here, babydoll.’ Glimmer rose to her knees, leant forwards and tugged at the satin just about holding her nightgown together. It pooled on the bedsheet. Picking up her painted toes, Lady Brightmoon sashayed closer. She wore nothing but her perfume. ‘It’s okay, Dory. You’re *allowed* to stare. I won’t tell.’ And how could I not? For all the many and manifold ways she’d recently put people in danger, Countess Dryl was still a devastating exemplar of physical beauty, like a cheetah or an especially feminine shark. Sweat prickled against the bedsheets. Suddenly I ran very, *very* hot.

‘*Goodness.*’

‘You’re damn right “*goodness*” – imagine waking up next to *this* every morning. Next to me… I want that more than anything else in the world. And I just *know* you do too. Dory, *my gorgeous Dory*, you were *SUCH* a fucking sweetheart last night. Don’t you remember? Ohmigosh. After that awful Detective Mermaid woman finally quit her yammering, I was *SO* tired and you escorted me upstairs… you literally carried me, your beloved, in your arms and laid me out on the bed. *It was the least a knight could do for their Lady*, you said, *and Glimmer would ALWAYS be your Lady.*’

This rang a bell. But the bell was queasy, and had consumed an insensible quantity of single malt in the early hours.

'You soothed me… You stroked my cheek… You got me my creams… You even cleaned up my drawers and my papers, so we could forget all about Kyle. Wasn't he SO *fucking* suspicious of me?! Why would he even be like that? All I ever wanted was the chance to tell you how I really feel – to show you what you can have. And now I can, and he'll be your valet again, and it's all settled. Adora, I love you. *ADORA, I FUCKING LOVE YOU SO BAD*!! What do you think of that, my future Duke Brightmoon?'

Glimmer leant in with her lips, long, bright and sultry. Oh, no, thank you. Not before breakfast. Quite possibly not at all. I ducked the kiss and sat harder up.

'Now, now, my glitterbug, let's not get too far ahead of ourselves,' I cautioned. 'That's how I ended up getting you here, but why did I stay the night?'

'It was late. You were tired. Your room has no door. Plus it's full of soot and servant footprints. Why would you want to go back there? *My* bed is so big and so comfortable, with space for *way* more than two… The time was getting *super* late and you were so strung out, babe. I was worried about you! You needed to be held. You had to know everything would be alright. So you decided to stay, and we spooned, and you drifted off in my arms. You're really fucking *cute* when you sleep! I love you so much, Dory. I'd do *anything* for you. Seriously, *ANYTHING*. Look around, babe! I even went and got your stupid horse and this… cat thing.'

‘Melog. That lovely kitty is Melog.’ The sight of Lady Meowmeow’s felted friend in the hands of her enemy was too much to bear. Her glassy feline eyes bore accusingly into me. The cuddly cat’s peepers, I mean. Not Glimmer’s. Melog was right. I’d sworn to protect my girlfriend and I’d failed for now – but I was *not* down for the count. Scorpia and Perfuma were on my side, plus Entrapta and Wrongcle, while Bow was moving a bit in the right direction. Double-Trubel was also doing *something*, though who’s to say whether their machinations aimed to help, hinder or utterly ignore?

Regardless, I’d found some strength in numbers. The Power of Friendship was within my grasp. So was a sword cane. I might need both before this Midsummer’s Day and Midsummer’s Night were through. We *were* going to win in the end.

‘*Glimmer* – I’m asking again. Nicely. Don’t make me ask, well, not-nicely. Where is Catra?’

‘Fuuuuccck, Dory, is she really *all* you can think about? When I’m right *here*?! Urgh. Your pet girl-toy has tickets for the morning express out of Euston, okay? Don’t you *trust* me, your beloved? I promised you I’d bring her back and she’ll be here after luncheon. Daddy explained it all. You can’t help who you love – *clearly* – so I’m not gonna fight it anymore. Pinky swear. We’ll be like Aunt Cassy. *Meowmeow* can stay in a gardener’s cottage or somewhere and be your *mistress*, while *you* marry *me* and we live together in the main house.’

At some point, I presumed, somebody was going to ask me for *my* thoughts about all this. I just didn't know *whom*. The Duchess would likely sooner launch me into the Thames then welcome me into the family. Duke Micah was so enthusiastic about his more equitable version of the Two Ladies Solution that he sooner embrace socialism or kick his dog than let me go. And Glimmer was Glimmer.

Glimmer, with her distractingly wonderful tits and insistent smile. Her interpretation was even worse, asserting, as it did, that one Lady can dictate a knight's relationship with another, altogether separate Lady. *The Divine Madam Meowmeow is **not** my bit on the side*, I wanted to shout. Unfortunately, the kink-flare between Lady Brightmoon's waist and her remarkable hips was particularly pronounced from this angle, and she was encouraging me to feel that warm, scented curve for myself. Which I did. For I am not made of stone. I am made of Lesbian.

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Some minutes later, we made our way back into clothes. Boyshform, linens and a mustard-yellow silk cravat for me, the latter a gift from the Lady Brightmoon. Countess Dryl wore emeralds the size of your thumb and a dress bedecked in hand-spun lace and not much else.

'Ohmi-shitting-gosh,' Glimmer gasped. 'We're leaving our visitor waiting!! The one I told you about. Did you guess who it is, Dory, did you?!'
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‘And the guest isn’t Catra?’ I asked, a little deflated.

‘*Adora*, I told you. I ***said*** I’m sorry for sending her away, and she’ll be on that train later. First class, obviously. So stop worrying about it!!’

‘Then I don’t know. Who is it?’

‘Who knows more about me – about *us* – than anyone else in the whole world?’

‘Bowregard?’

‘Hmm… Maybe? But it’s not Bow.’

‘Entrapta? They’re a pretty perceptive sort – and they have got a *lot* of data.’

‘The mechanic?! Piss off. Think London, babe. Think Oxford. Think nights out. Think *messy*.’

‘Oh, Horde, Glimmer, do I have to? I’m queasy enough as it is…’

‘Diddums. You’ll be fine. We’ll open a window or something.’

Lady Brightmoon swept me into the Atrium without another word. Round and uncluttered – with doorways jumping off it to all sides – the room had the impression of a grand but unusual porch, and much the same purpose. It was a glorious waste of space. For several seconds, I forgot we were here to meet someone. Thanks to the various stressors involved with all my previous arrivals and departures, I’d never really taken the time to look at this room. The walls were a rich red, overscored by a chandelier. There were several yellow, stone faux-pillars.

But the perplexing stars of the show were a clutter of marble statues. Up until that point, I’d lived my entire life without seeing the Duchess Brightmoon as a nymph or Duke Micah as a cheeky faun. I could have gone the rest of my days without seeing these and been quite happy, but now I had. So that was… something. Prize of place, however, went to a prideful centaur who wore a simulacrum of Glimmer’s face and – as I could now confirm – a strikingly accurate renditions of her breasts.

Over these marble-ous nipples, my gaze locked with the two strangers in our midst: a red-haired fellow with a distinctly pirate-ish air and, holding their hand, an artistic woman in glasses.

‘*Adora*!’ Glimmer bounced, fit to burst. ‘Come meet our guests!’

I did as I was told, skirting past the statue with a second glance and a second thought. Connoisseur of horseys that I am, the centaur’s animal aspects struck me hard with their familiarity. The

tail, the markings… There was no doubting it. The sculptor had used Glimmer for the human features, but the equine features belonged, undeniably, to Swift Wind. I stared at the stone again – processing this unknown collision of my worlds. My head hurt. But that might just have been the hangover.

'Introduce yourselves!' Glimmer demanded, in the dog trainer tone of someone too used to saying something and having it happen. The stranger who looked a bit like they might know Blackbeard bowed and announced themselves, with the energy of a person quite familiar with introducing themselves. It was all terribly cordial for a fellow who'd been left in a seatless, windowless room for the time it took me to touch a Countess quite a lot.

'Your Ladyship, Countess Dryl and Lady Brightmoon,' they smiled, 'what an honour to renew your acquaintance. I am the noted Society columnist Nathaniel Artemis, and this is my wife Mary.'

'How do you do?' asked Mary, a question that struck me as rather too existential for a Saturday morning. I silently wondered if she knew Mermista and her abstract declarative routine. Fortunately, Glimmer took Mary's query as either too rhetorical or too boring to answer, and set about ushering me towards Nathaniel instead.

'Isn't this *so* exciting, babe?! This is the journo who's always scribbling about me in the gossip pages. He did the *BEST* piece on our Henley trip, with a cartoon and *everything*. Ohmigosh, it was soooo *FUCKING FUNNY*!! Did you see it? Adora? Did you?'

I had not. Society pages made me think of sitting with my Aunt in that stifling, dust-choked drawing room of hers, trying to memorise whose feet I was supposed to kiss and whom I was allowed to be really very rude to, provided I said horrible things in the right way, which was not an energy I wished to invite into my flat. Or into any other part of my adult life, for that matter.

'But you've been out of my column for a *week* now---'

Somehow juggling their wife, Lady Brightmoon, a pad and a pen between just two hands, Artemis sighed disarmingly towards glitterbug, never letting their gaze leave hers. Glimmer blushed – scarcely hiding how thrilled she was by the attention – then gradually stumbled us up a corridor and into a room I hadn't seen before. This was the Verandah, my self-declared girlfriend announced, despite its being of a distinctly indoors persuasion.

Its walls groaned with bone China – commemorating a long past Brightmoon who'd sailed around the world for… *reasons* – providing an ever-present reminder that Shugborough's owners held the deeds to a preponderance of the local potteries. A billiards table dominated one half of the floorspace below, while card tables and chairs in Edwardian filigree ate up the rest. We sat down at the latter, where Glimmer had been provided with tea, cake and a peacock feather fan. She flapped it in pure ostentation. Nathaniel watched encouragingly. Mary and I formed a silent bond over our mutual love of wordlessly wolfing down Battenburg and avoiding awkward conversation.

'It's not my fucking fault,' the Countess eventually announced. 'I *try* to be interesting, Nate, but Staffordshire is so shitty and

provinciale. The commoners here are just… *bleurgh*. London has all life's art!'

'Of course,' Nathaniel cooed, 'but I know you, Glimmer. You must have some way to delight me!'

Munching ruminatively on a Rich Tea, I locked rolling eyes with Mary, and pondered just what had been artistic about the time I held Glimmer's hair back while she vomited into a plant pot outside *The Ritz*.

'Oh! I do! So I've brought you to Shugborough Hall, the Brightmoon family seat, where I've made a kind of Queer Paradise for my friends, my acquaintances… and my *girlfriend* here. Say hello to Sir Adora de l'Horde. Girlfriend. Official.'

'*Your* girlfriend?' Nate Artemis scrumpled up his face with the trepidatious uncertainty of a used hanky. 'That's not what I've got in my notes.'

'Then your notes are wrong. And I'm about to make them wronger, so *pay* attention.' Iron scudded against rug and a box whipped out of Glimmer's dress. Before I could complete the mastication of my morning biscuit, the tormentor of my one true love was down on bended knee and saying, 'Adora de l'Horde – you're going to be my spouse.'

'I am?!?' said I – in the medium of sprayed crumbs.

‘Yes, you are! We’re announcing it to the public at tonight’s Midsummer Ball. Which, by the way, Mr. Artemis, will *also* be attended by my cuz Double-Trubel *and* Consulting Detective Whirlpool Mermot, who saved us from a murder last night. So… Yeah. You want to stick around, trust me.’

‘Excuse me,’ sidled the journalist, cornering me and me alone. Glimmer stood by the door, her foot tap-dancing impatiently. My fourth finger throbbed where she’d screwed a diamond knuckleduster to it. I was in no mood to talk. But the newspaperperson insisted. ‘Aren’t you in love with your valet?’

‘How the Dickens did you work *that* out?’

‘I’m a writer – it’s my business to know what’s really going on.’

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Chapter 53

Chapter Summary

'In many ways, my spousewife approaches this chapter like her ordinary morning. They acquire a balanced breakfast; they learn the issues of the day; they converse with friends; they masticate over a riddle or two; they wish - lovelorn - for my unparalleled presence. On this occasion, regrettably, they have to go without that last one.'

'Yes! Where were you that morning, Catra? Whilst I was tramping my escape through the physical and figurative Brightmoon wildernesses? I was up to my ankles in mud and you were---?'

'Plotting our escape, sir, and embarking on a first-class trip home into your arms. But that, dear readers, is a story for another installment...'

Chapter Notes

Content warnings apply for the below chapter only - Spoilers may be present in the warnings. This story does not include any of the four Archive Warnings topics, but does occasionally feature other topics that may require content notes.

Chapter 53 Content Warnings (CONTAINS SPOILERS):
Possessiveness – In speech, present, extensive, by major character, towards main character
Relationship interference – Narrated and in speech, present and recent historic, by major character, impacts main character
Forced engagement – Narrated, present, by major character, impacts main character
Exile – In speech, present and recent historic, of main character, impacts main character

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PART 13

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SECTION 2

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Feeling like a lion at the London Zoo, I stalked off into the bush for a bit of quiet reflection. A spot of gazelle jerky wouldn't have gone amiss either. But the leg-striped bounders were in short supply around Staffordshire, so I settled for a hard-boiled egg from the breakfast table. Diamond sparkled off my mitt as I took a chalky, disconsolate bite. Against the top-carat gold, my finger throbbed greyly, turning ruddy red when I girded myself and tugged at it. The ring stuck fast. I was still engaged.

Glimmer wanted to talk about this. She had dreams for our tomorrow and all the days after that, which she'd minorly modified to accommodate the inconvenience of my actual girlfriend. The wedding was already planned. All I had to do was turn up, look pretty, and say most of the right words in some of the right places. *Meowmeow* could come if I absolutely insisted. Perhaps she could be a bridesmaid. Countess Dryl airily declared herself not *too* concerned, so long as Catra kept herself out of the way.
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I sighed deep, like Double-Trubel at the height of a performance. Except I really meant it. With things the way they were, maybe Catra would take so many steps back that we wouldn't be girlfriends anymore. Yesterday's rubber duckies floated across my consciousness. Cripes. I chewed sadly on a second egg. None of them asked to be part of a fairground stall, did they? Duckthew and Duckily and all their quackers pals never chose to go round and around in circles for the amusement or enrichment of the big fellows with the pointy sticks. Who could blame them for flapping away to freedom?

It was in this morose mood that I trudged across the gardens and circuited the lake. My sad chin barely left my sternum. Passersby found my What Hoing distinctly anaemic. At least I'd got out by myself. Over at the Hall, Lady Brightmoon barked at assorted staff to clean this, hang that, or place the other outside, all the while giving an exclusive interview to Nathaniel Artemis.

`*Tonight is the party of the year*,' she told him to write. The instruction was not quiet: I could make out every word from my perch by the fountain, where I'd paused to work on a third egg and a first-rate plan. `*NO! Wait… Try this. It's the party of the FUCKING DECADE!! Yeah, I know 1930 is the first year of ten. I know what a decade is, shit-brains. But no-one can POSSIBLY beat this. Double-Trubel performing; Whirlpool Mermot sleuthing; a King Arthur…*'

Uh oh. The red-headed stick figure that was Artemis snapped to attention. They looked at Glimmer. They whispered something to his wife. He asked the Brightmoon heir to repeat herself, I think, because Glimmer repeated my hyphenated sort-of-name even

more loudly than before. The trio stopped dead on the patio. Swivelled glances were exchanged in multiple directions, compelling my Lady to clarify:

'*It's something old and important? She's always been a knight, and now they've upgraded into an Arthurian figure? What do you mean "Who am I talking about?" – I'm saying Adora's gonna be there, shitnugget! My fiancée, Adora, is a She-King-Arth-Ra.*'

We were on the move. The journalists strode down the steps towards me, Glimmer hot on their tails, leaving me with a pressing conundrum and a half-eaten breakfast. I did *not* want to talk to a newspaper personality about being the She-Ra, when I still didn't really know what that meant myself. Lectures and rainbows and dream saleswomen had barely got me clear on the basics! But I'd learned well and fast that some Etherians – namely the table-toppers with access to lawyers, guns and money – were about as anti-She-Ra as you can get. It seemed unwise to start making headlines before I'd figured out how best to handle them.

Plopping mournfully into the pool, my hard-boiler fired the starting gun. I was off. An Aunt Shadowtha invective fired across my synapses. *Always ask more than you answer, Adora. A reporter is never off the record. Make them your eyes, your ears, but never your memory*. I twinged. Realisation hit that Auntie wasn't going to be the She-Ra's biggest fan – and that I had a mighty tongue-lashing coming for *concealing the truth from the family who raised you*. Yikes. But she had been right. With this one statement – doubtless imparted during yet another interminable deportment lesson – my matriarch had unwittingly saved the day.

My grip on Ms. Floaty-C loosened. The five special words died on my lips. If the ‘paper people saw me transform, they’d have their proof and my silence would be redundant. I had to outsprint them the old-fashioned way, using the de l’Horde ingenuity and the good old-fashioned muscle power. And to think – Bowregard says I eat *too many* eggs for breakfast… I’d like to see him outpace a race-ready newshound!

Damn it! The crew was quick and loafers are not a sporting shoe. Gorgeous but devilishly impractical, my summery slip-ons threatened to undo me. Dash my unwavering commitment to fashion! Their front halves pinched solid. Amidships they were all at sea, slopping-flopping away from my ankles, yet their hand-stitched rears seemed dead-set on rubbing my tendons raw. I couldn’t run fast and I couldn’t run far. Not in these.

I wavered, thinking of yanking them off and turning old-school Olympian, but they begged for a shoehorn I wasn’t carrying. Where-oh-where is a gentlewoman’s gentlewoman when you need one? Come to me, Catra! Well. She was doing, as far as I knew, but even the greatest girlfriend-and-ex-valet can’t jump a hundred miles a second. I hopped and bopped. The loafers weren’t coming off. Every second I wasted, the journos got closer. I had to go. Somewhere. Somehow. Now.

But where? My room was out – it was still down a lock and, for that matter, a door *to* lock. The glasshouses were, well, glass. A bit too see-through for hiding purposes, plus Perfuma seemed pathologically incapable of calling me anything but She-Ra. Damn. *Damn*. The path ahead split in two. I could go right, to the boathouse, gambling that Double-Trubel had left it like we found it… and that the binder blinder didn’t repeat itself. Or I could

swing left, under the trees, making for the stables. The stables! Where I could find…

'Did *somebody* say SWIFT WIND?!'

'Swiftie! Thank the First Ones! Go, go, go. But try not to look magical.'

'No flying?'

'Nope.'

'No talking?'

'Not unless it's to me. And quiet!'

'No communism?'

'Maybe. I'm… I'm thinking about it.'

'That's not all you've been doing, Adora, baby! Look at that rock!!'

‘Can… can that wait? It’s a whole thing – like an awful riddle – and I can’t unscramble it.’

‘Oh, oh! Like a word puzzle? Crosswords! You like those. Have I got something for *you*, Adora!’

‘Great. *Fantastic*. Just make sure it’s hidden and far away and we can go RIGHT NOW!!’

‘You’re the boss! If there was a boss! Which there isn’t! And there shouldn’t be!’

Swift Wind reared back on his hind legs, whinnied, winked at the assembled crowd – which, I hoped, just looked like an ordinary blink from their perspective – then rushed us away. My jaunty wave and crisp “Ta-Ra for now!” met Glimmer more fashionably than I feared. She swelled three sizes, the beaming re-centred centre of attention.

‘They really fucking *live* for their exercise,’ she explained to her once-again-attentive listeners. ‘Let me show what we’re doing to the gardens. *Ohmigosh*. It’s an inside-outside thing. You have *got* to meet our gardener!! She’s *SO* sweet, no shitting!!’

We galloped on and on, away from Shugborough, horse and rider in perfect harmony, the house retreating in the distance…

‘Oopsie!’ Swift Wind eventually announced. ‘Ha-HA! Oh, Adora, you’re going to laugh about this. I got turned around. We’re going the wrong way!’

Minutes later, dear, devoted Swift Wind screeched us to a halt in front of a very large stone in the wilderness mood, but the aristocratic location. For all his tantalising trot and galvanising grot, it hadn’t escaped my attention that my one-and-only-corn had carried me left, then left, left again, and once more left on our journey *away* from the denizens of Shugborough Hall. We were back where we’d started – or very close to it.

With a consoling stroke of his mane – for I’m not really in any place to criticise when it comes to lacking any real sense of direction – I persuaded Swiftie to clip-clop back a few paces, so we could get a better look down the path where his shoes now stood. Ah. Yes. That confirmed it. This was, in very concrete fact, the same path I’d fled from a few moments before. Our position had shifted by all of a few hundred feet.

‘Impressive, am I right?!’ my horse smarmed.

‘It’s--- certainly *something*.’ I was stuck for anything else to say – but Sir Adora was hardly about to abandon their lifelong codes and standards. A good knight is *never* mean to a horse. ‘I very much appreciate you stepping in and up like that.’

‘No problem, Adora! And look what I found for you! You’ll love it… It’s--- it’s--- *CROSSWORDY.*’

‘Swiftie… It’s a big fake gate with a carving on it.’

‘Uh, no, Adora. It’s a *monument*.’

‘What’s the difference?’

‘The Shepherd’s Monument is shrouded in *mystery*.’

‘Oh, Horde…’ I groaned. ‘After last night, I think I’ve had enough Mer-mystery for a lifetime. Did Kyle put you up to this?’

‘Wow. *Some*one’s a mistrustful Mx! Adora, my feelings are *very* hurt. I thought we had a special bond! *Clearly* not!’

A haughty huff emanated from his snow white nostrils. He clip-clopped a single hoof in grief-stricken rebuke. I felt bally dreadful, as well I ought. Swift Wind could hardly take the blame for anything that might more accurately be dumped on Kyle. Horde damn it, Kyle.

‘I’m sorry, Swiftie. What did you want to show me?’

‘Okay! Adora. This monument is like… *hundreds* of years old and *no-one* has *EVER* worked out what it means. See that painting of shepherds with happy, rosy faces? Some say they’re allegoric. Or religious. Or just really pleased with the life of an ancient, land-bound agriculturalist. But, yeah, we can disregard that last one. The proletariat won’t look that happy until they’re rinsing the last drops of bourgeois blood from their hands, know what I mean?’

‘Um. Swiftie. I’m a Lord – and a Baronet – and one day I’ll be a Marquioness. Your future doesn’t look too terribly rosy for *me*.’

‘Yeaahhh… But today isn’t too hot for everyone else, huh? You’ve been learning about this! If you have twelve apples and the next eleven people you meet have no apples, then there needs to be a *redistribution* of apples.’

‘That’s *food* for thought. Get it?’

‘Your puns delight and amaze… yourself. And, really, it’s just you who likes them, Adora. But you’re a good one. With me and Catra around, you’re *definitely* going to get it. Eventually. Plus you’re She-Ra, so standing up for the downtrodden is basically your whole thing. I bet you’ve already got something big planned for Shugborough! Something to *really* burn those aristos up!!’

‘Those are my friends!’

‘Then your buddies stand for bad things – I don’t know what else to tell you, babe. Maybe they should think about their position in society a bit more. What they uphold, what they benefit from… What they’re *deliberately* ignoring…’

‘They’re not bad people?’

‘But they *and you* participate in pretty nasty stuff. And are you really saying *Glimmer* is a good person? Garbage can Glimmer? Send Catra away Glimmer? *Win Adora in a game Glimmer?*’

‘Fair point,’ I had to concede, ‘but what does any of this have to do with the mystery?’

‘Oh, yeah, that’s what we’re doing! Adora and Swift Wind, solving an ancient riddle, finding the Graaaiiilll!! Gonna be forever young, gonna have a lot of fun, with your paaaaal Swiiiiift Wind!! Yeah! So. Adora. Look at those letters carved around the monument.’

‘DM,’ I read. ‘It says that twice – once at either end. Between those, the inscription looks like O U O S V A V V. Am I getting that right?’

‘Totally! Do you know what it means?’

‘No.’

‘Damn. Can you… work it out?’

‘Hmm. I don’t think we’re looking at First Ones – it’s not jumping out at me – but I can’t shake the feeling this is *very* old and *incredibly* She-Raic.’

‘Soooo… What do you want to do about it?’

‘We could take it to an expert!’ Swinging one suddenly ambitious foot out of its stirrup, I gave Swiftie a mighty pat and spat a little elbow grease into both palms. ‘Keep a watch out, okay? I think I can lift this, but we don’t want to be *seen* taking it. Right-o. Let’s do this! FOR THE HONOUR OF---’

‘Or, Adora, and bear with me here, we could sketch it? And write the letters down? With this pencil?’

‘That seems like a hundred times less fun.’

‘And about a million times less obvious.’

‘Well… yes. Okay.’

Tongue prodding from my lips at a jaunty diagonal, I lost the next little while to scratching out my best impression of art class. I scribbled. I cross-hatched. I held the pencil upright in front of my face and squinted at it, chiefly because I'd seen an enthusiast sketcher do that once at the Tate. I felt very accomplished until I looked at the result.

'It's… Adora… It's… *redolent* of your early work?' said Swiftie.

'*What* earlier work?'

'The sketches you used to do of me and you on adventures?'

'So you're saying I'm as good as a very mediocre four-year old?'

'Woah, Adora! I never called you *ordinary*. You're a lot of things – but never that! And… err… look! Some of your stick figures even have the right number of limbs.'

'Alright, alright!' I sighed my way back into the saddle. 'It's the idea that matters. Entrapta's a clever chap. They'll know how to fill in the rest.'

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Chapter 54

Chapter Summary

'Auntie always said one should judge a chapelette by the company she keeps. If that's true, then my wife must be smart as tuxedo, sharp as a claw and terribly, terribly intense. All of which *does* ring true. Say, Catra, does that mean my Aunt Shadowtha was actually *right* for once?!'

'I highly doubt that, sir.'

'Yes, yes. I'm starting to see it from that angle myself – especially after the night we've just had. Either way, this chapter is all about Entrapta. The fellow had plans, you see, with Catra and me at their centre. And let's just say they didn't agree with Glimmer's direction of travel!'

Chapter Notes

Content warnings apply for the below chapter only - Spoilers may be present in the warnings. This story does not include any of the four Archive Warnings topics, but does occasionally feature other topics that may require content notes.

Chapter 54 Content Warnings (CONTAINS SPOILERS):
Gun – Narrated and in speech, present, fired, pointed at main character (no characters harmed)
Shooting – Narrated, present, fired at inanimate objects only
Physical violence, sword – Narrated, present, wielded by main character (no characters harmed)
Deprivation – Narrated, ongoing and recollected
Discrimination – Narrated, ongoing and recollected, queerphobic and racist
Arranged marriage – Narrated and in speech, upcoming, of main character, by major character
Planned murder – Narrated and in speech, upcoming, of major character (plan later abandoned)

Cultural appropriation – In speech, historic and ongoing, allegorical

See the end of the chapter for more notes

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PART 13

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SECTION 3

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‘Adddooorrraa!! I am SO wonderfully happy to see you! After last night and its… *unscheduled* field testing, Emily is back and BETTER THAN *EVER!!*’

The engineer cackled from somewhere far inside their garages. Deeper still inside this blood-and-oil hellmouth, chains thrashed and motors whirred, ringing out a meshed symphony of an upcoming and distinctly post-human age. The *maschinenmensch* had come to Shugborough – and she was, quite unmistakably, cocking a gun. My blood ran cold. Emily’s hydraulic oil pumped colder.
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My sword would *not* sleep in my hand. Rainbows flashed with five little words and I was She-Ra, bravely backed by my noble Swift Wind. Our lights seared into the darkness, illuminating paths amidst mangled Blowers Bentley and scorched Moths de Havilland. Glimmer's Duesenberg – huge and dreadful – glittered behind the robot. The new Babel. Emily nodded our way. Her lower jaw hung loose and a gatling gun dropped from her mouth.

Swiftie bucked. Old Ms. Floaty-C seared against my fingers. And Entrapta laughed and laughed and laughed. Now, to be clear, this was no mere giggle. Their hands reached to the skies; their back arched; their goggles glistened in rapt, near-religious fervour. They were seeing something we could not see. The smile drawn tight across their gums told me that much. Ragged cackling consumed them and, if my own peepers didn't deceive me, their skin flushed a deeper shade of damask.

'Look at her, Adora! Really look!! Isn't she FASCINATING? Isn't she SOOOOO *technologically ADVANCED??!*'

I didn't know about that – but I understood just too damn well what bullets had won me. By the powers of Greyskull, I was *not* about to let any weapon threaten my Lady Catra ever again. Beckoning Swift Wind onto my back foot, I advanced, chest high and feet sure. I'd had enough of this place. Enough of its taunting residents and their attempts to disrupt my *girlfriend's* life, her dignity, and her love of me. If Emily had gone rogue, then I'm sorry, Entrapta, but she would have to be destroyed. Floaty-C coursed green, red, gold as I prepared my upswing.

'*NOOOOOOOO!!!*' Entrapta screamed back, hurling themself between my blade and their precious automaton. Dash it, had the

fellow never heard about knife safety?! I caught my shoulder just in time, hurling my ribs hard right to fix my trajectory. Even then, the death blow barely missed our shaking engineer. A pair of unctuous gauntlets tore into my skorts.

'*Please*.' Entrapta entreated me. 'You can't interrupt now… We're *SO CLOSE* to the most important moment in the *entire* demonstration. Don't you understand, Adora? I'm trying to give you *DATA* – data you'll need – *tonight*. Swing that weapon and BOOF – there goes your best chance at creating a ***REVOLTUION!!***'

'Just what have you got in mind?' I spluttered back. 'In case you haven't noticed, Emily is pointing her gun right at us!'

'Oh? Ohhhhhh… You think she's going to fire at you, don't you? *O-kay!*' Entrapta loosed a few fingers, to scribble in one of her omnipresent notebooks. 'Demonstration note 172.1: Adora interprets the viewing phase as a direct physical threat---'

'Err, aren't you forgetting something, scary spanner person? So does Swift Wind!'

'Ah! *Hiiiiiii* – are you the She-Ra's equine companion? The She-Ra *always* has an equine companion… apart from those two times in the ninth century with consecutive Arth-Reds patrolled the Valleys with a friendly otter. Some questions: Would you prefer to be an otter? Did you exist before Adora summoned you? How did that feel? Are you an *ordinary* horse? Are you… mortal?'

‘I am NOT some everyday stallion, babe, *please and thank you*. I am SWIFT WIND. And why don’t we ask the questions, since you’re the one pointing walking weapons at us? Like – WHY?’

‘For FREEDOM! To finally overthrow the regal, noble and aristocratic systems that have oppressed Etheria and its illegal occupations since before time immemorial!!’

‘Is this---?’ Swiftie whinnied. ‘It is! It’s Robots for Communism! Adora? *Adora.* I think we’re going to be okay. I think this greasy-oily, purple-hair-person has the *right ideas*.’

‘Weee-llllll… My approach is more like socialism with various anarchic elements.’ Entrapta clarified.

My steed relaxed and I did not. Truth be told, I felt – and looked – rather confused. Entrapta scrambled their way up the side of a nearby Rolls-Royce, so they could grab me by the substantial soldiers and fix my gaze. With their goggles hauled high over their forehead, I could watch their pupils snap and race. The fellow literally fizzed with excitement.

‘Adora,’ they trilled, ‘I *resolved* my ethical dilemma. Remember? The one about working for the Brightmoons? How could I do it, when I despise what the family name represents? But why would I walk away, when I had all the space, technology, and acceptance here that a queer engineer could *possibly* need? Ha-ha! It was… trrrriiiiccckky.’

Entrapta shook their head, averting their gaze. I stood, silent, for whatever was about to appear next. We weren't waiting long:

'But! Then it happened: Glimmer sent Catra away. And suddenly EVERYTHING was *CLEAR*. We're going to get your girl back, Adora, then we're going to build something *totally* new and SO incredibly old: a utopia for everyone like us; and freedom for all. Isn't that what the She-Ra is all about?!'

'I… Dash it, yes. Yes it is!' I pipped back.

They had a way with words, did Entrapta, and their enthusiasm was bloody infectious. Movie clips raced through my mind of the London I'd never consciously seen. But it was there. My Horde, it was *always* there. The rough-sleepers huddled in doorways. The children selling newspapers, at an age when surely they should have been in school. The old and the disabled hauling home their shopping, for want of a bus fare. The hungry. The tired. The queer folk – like me, *like us* – whose connections, wealth and skin tone couldn't insulate them from what society sent their way.

'We're going to build communities,' the engineer rushed on, 'where we care for each other. Where rest is a right. Where we have *enough*. Where we are LOVED – all of us. Where every last individual can pursue their talents and desires… Where you and Catra can live openly, together, without putting her at ANY risk. The way the world used to be, before modern Etheria began.'

‘Preach, sibling!’ Swift Wind whinnied.

‘How?’

‘Ha! Ha-ha! I’m SO glad you asked, Adora!’ Entrapta grinned, hurling themself back to the floor and rushing over to their automated apple of their eye. ‘Glimmer gives her preferred gay and trans and so on people a slot in her safe space, according to her desires, so long as they follow her rules to the letter. You must have seen that yourself, right? I mean – she’s done it to you. And if you don’t leave today, will you ever be able to go? At all?’

They gestured at the ring throbbing on my right hand.

‘I mean… We’re only engaged. That’s still more than I’d like – a *lot* more – but it’s not like Glimmer has lashed me to the mast *forever*. Folk break off engagements all the time! It could be years before she pushes me down an aisle.’

‘Do you *really* believe that? Or are you just trying not to panic?’

I chewed that over for a second. It didn’t need a second – a second second, I mean. Gosh. Isn’t Etherian a tricky tongue? Let’s try again: I found myself with no purpose for more than one but fewer than three seconds. Anyway, I didn’t have to ponder for long:

‘Hmm. *Cripes*. She could be plotting a wedding for tonight, so far as I know, before Catra and I get the chance to bounce.’

Entrapta grimaced. ‘That’s my hypothesis. Take a look at the data. Glimmer sent down three messages to my quarters this morning. Ah-hum. “One: Entrapta, prepare the Duesenberg for a long journey. Which means FILL the bar. No skimping. Two: Entrapta, my car needs to be more… *white*. Add ribbons or boards or paint or something. Fast! Needed tonight! Stop fucking about with your fake-Kyle and GET ON WITH IT! Three: Make me an arch. A big one. In white. Big enough for two people to stand under, face-to-face. Do NOT make it big enough for three.”’

‘What is it you always say? The data never lies?’

‘*Yeeee-aaaaaahhhhh…*’

‘Well!’ I proclaimed. ‘That puts me on a Dickens of a sticky wicket.’

‘Adora, babe, you can just say we’re *fucked*,’ Swift Wind helpfully advised.

‘Quite, quite. So, Entrapta, how exactly does this tie in with your demonstration and this revolution of yours?’

‘Like I was saying, Glimmer is *VERY* selective with who she extends any offer of help to. Furthermore! Any offer *from* Glimmer

always turns out to be more of an offer *to* Glimmer. Whether it's me or you or Bow or the nice gardener lady, the Brightmoon *modus operandi* is TOTALLY focused around what the family can *take* from other people. They don't give. Not unless it comes with strings.'

'I'm following.'

'I hate that philosophy – I oppose it *COMPLETELY*. But it isn't the year 700 anymore. And now SO *MANY* of Etheria's resources are hogged by the Brightmoons, the de l'Hordes, and all the other families like yours, who don't plan on *ever* giving their resources back. And I like to be… *pragmatic*. To start a new world where we all give to each other, we're going to have to *take* first. Or – to put it more simply – which side has the guns?'

'Glimmer. And Double-Trubel.' I hummed, tensing at the memory. 'Those two have more firepower than the average army base.'

'*Exactly*. For my plan to work, we'll need to be fast, decisive, and direct. We'll need someone who can shoot back with *complete* accuracy and no fear. We'll need Emily. Okay, okay, you're going to want to stand back---'

Entrapta shepherded us towards the garage doors, with their robot dutifully at our heels. When we were as far from the cars as we could get, they stuck their saturated fingers in their mouth and whistled. Emily hummed a barely-perceptible whistle, pivoted round, and slammed five rounds straight through the windscreen of Glimmer's Duesenberg, laid out in a perfectly straight line.

‘You’re not planning on killing her, are you?!’ I tried to clarify.

‘Don’t worry, She-Ra! There won’t be ANY blood on *your* hands… that’s the beauty of my plan. Isn’t it ***FASCINATING***?!’

‘You… You haven’t answered my question. Are you going to kill her? I don’t want her to *die*!’

‘Sure,’ Entrapta nodded, winking at me. ‘*I* understand.’

‘I bally well hope so! I couldn’t be more clear if I tried. Entrapta, I do not want to *marry* Glimmer, but I don’t want you or Emily to *murder* her. Okay? There has to be another way.’

‘Fine… Emily, lovely, go to option five.’

Emily squawked, then let loose another hail of bullets. They landed in all four tyres and the radiator, which vented its watery guts with a hiss. That was more like it. If our ‘bot buddy could do that again when it counted, then all we’d have left to manage was our daring escape. A thrill ricocheted through me. If my life has any particular goals, I’d have to say the daring rescue of a beautiful damsel ranked first, with the outwitting and outrunning of baddies placing a very close second. Tonight I’d get to do both. It was all quite spiffingly Hollywood!

With gold and silver goals secure, why not complete the podium? My mind wandered to whatever that might be and my pocket burned with the answer. Of course! The scrunched-up sketch! I pulled out the papers and smoothed them flat, beckoning Entrapta to take a closer look. Ever since I'd devoured my first tale of derring-do, I'd desperately desired to solve an ancient mystery: and here one was, right in front of us.

'What do you make of this, huh?' I asked our accomplice. 'Swiftie spotted it on a posh rock just off the formal gardens, and these seem to be letters along its top edge. It's not any First Ones language – I can tell you that much – but it doesn't make much sense in my native tongue either.'

'The Shepherd's Monument!' Entrapta gasped. 'Uh! I've been waiting *FOREVER* for someone else to notice it and bring it up. I am going to BLOW your mind! You're right, it's *not* Welsh or Etherian. Because it isn't in any language at all… These aren't even letters.'

'Hang about. It clearly reads "DM O U O S V A V V DM"… doesn't it? It definitely seems like the mason carved it that way on purpose.'

'Oh, they probably did. But only because the Brightmoons never try to understand the land they claim as their own. *Typical* imperialists. They spotted a section of the Chase they liked and ported it home in this sanitised form to "*improve*" it.'

'So where's the original?'

‘Carved into the side of a small sandstone cliff, *waaaaayyyy* off the beaten track. The rock is covered in these weathered, ancient shapes that seems a bit like letters – sort of – if you can’t tell what you’re really looking at. But *I* can. *I* have the *DATA*. As soon as I saw it, I knew. Adora, wait here.’

Entrapta disappeared through a side door I hadn’t even noticed, then set to rummaging around a storeroom. Three to four minutes of noisy silence followed, then they returned with a victorious grin, a massive sheet of paper and a brace of photographs.

‘What’s that?’ they asked, gesturing at the second snap.

‘That’s me.’ I replied. ‘It’s a drawing of the She-Ra, I mean.’

‘Yes – EXACTLY! So now we look at the other image – the one of the cliff – and what do we see?’

I squinted. It was one of those optical illusion thingies. Straight away, I saw the letters, skewed and overlapping, as they ribboned down towards the forest floor. But I knew that wasn’t it. There was another angle I wasn’t seeing yet, and that I really needed to properly perceive. Good thing I had magic eyes, then. I lit up my peepers in searing turquoise, channelling the full strength of my powers at the pictures… and… *snap*!

‘My word! Or, rather, no words at all – and no letters. The scratches in the stone are a portrait… of another She-Ra… from long ago… who was also *here*… on Cannock Chase.’

Revised reality swirled round me like a hurricane. I needed to touch that rock, to commune with the one who’d come before. I couldn’t say why. I just felt compelled – as if it were more vital than air or water. Only the toll of the stable-top clock could break me from this ancient, mystical trance, which is precisely what it proceeded to do, striking noon in twelve humming peals. I blinked and stood up, though I didn’t forget. I just… prioritised. The past could wait. The future was beckoning me – to the unlikely environs of Stafford railway station. Catra’s train was coming in.

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Chapter End Notes

Hi! Thanks always for reading!! Not only is Chapter 52 growing into its own whole finale plot, I've had a ton of idea for more Inimitable Meowmeow short stories for after I finish the novel :)

Just in case any of you like historical facts, the Shugborough Inscription is a real life mystery from the 18th century. No-one's ever solved it.
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Chapter 55

Chapter Summary

'All aboard and all change! Hear the rails sing; hark as the whistle moans. A train was coming to Stafford - a train that should contain the Lady Catra Applesauce Meowmeow. Can you imagine how excited I was? How scared it would all go wrong somehow?'

'Yes, Adora. Yes I can. I couldn't stop thinking about you - I would've done anything to have you safe in my arms.'

'Awwhh! Anyhow, with Shugborough distracted by party prep, all Swiftie and I had to do was charge into town and find the station, then my beloved future-wife and I would be reunited. The first part we accomplished splendidly. The second? Well. I suggest you read on...'

Chapter Notes

Content warnings apply for the below chapter only - Spoilers may be present in the warnings. This story does not include any of the four Archive Warnings topics, but does occasionally feature other topics that may require content notes.

Chapter 55 Content Warnings (CONTAINS SPOILERS):
Trauma/PTS response – Narrated and in speech, present, extensive, experienced by narrator
Emotional abuse, familial – Narrated and in speech, historic and ongoing, extensive, experienced by narrator
Transphobia – In speech and narrated, present and ongoing, experienced by narrator and main character
Exile – Narrated, present and ongoing, of main character, impacts narrator
Train carriage collapse – Narrated, present, by narrator
Sword – Narrated, present, used by narrator on inanimate

object
Homophobia – In speech, present, targeted at narrator

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PART 13

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SECTION 4

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Stafford station is – unquestionably – in Stafford. This was no secret. Swift Wind and I were very aware of the fact before we saddled up and rode out, and we were no less certain when we rocked up in the eponymous county town. Ten miles had thundered beneath Swiftie's noble hooves, leaving but a matter of feet and inches between me and my beloved. All we had to do was find where *precisely* Catra would be stepping off the lunchtime express.

'How hard can that be?' I asked my steed. 'London has, what, thirteen termini and I could navigate those with my eyes closed. Finding the only trainshed in town should be a doddle! Right. Now. Where do we think that smoke is coming from?'
~~~

‘Err… Adora, babe, you’re gonna need to be more specific. *Which* plume are we talking about, hun?’

‘The one that gives the most railway-like impression, obviously.’

‘Which is? Come on, Adora, I’m a magical horse that used to live in your subconscious. I’ve never seen a train in real life. What am I looking for? They carry people, right? So are they… like… big mechanical horses?’

‘Not quite.’ I mused. ‘They’re more like tipped-over tea kettles, lashed to the insides of a wristwatch, pulling along several sitting rooms, running on metallic snakes, looking dashed pretty all the while. I really think you’re going to love them. *I* like them. Does that help?’

Swift Wind sucked air through his teeth. His lips blew like sails in the wind. I suddenly felt terribly anxious; it put one in mind of all the times Auntie had summoned me to *explain myself*. The memories rattled through me. My heart leapt and my hands clammed up. It was like being plopped right back there, shaking spinal cord and all.

‘I don’t have to tell you everything… I don’t have to tell you **anything**!! I can play with whomever I want, okay?’

‘Adora?’ I just about heard Swift Wind say. Only he didn’t sound like Swift Wind. He sounded like Aunt Shadowtha.

‘No. No no. **Don’t**. Please. *Please*. I’ll be good. I’ll be your little Dory… See? Please, Auntie, don’t be upset. ***Auntie?*** I’m sorry, I’m sorry, I’m sorry, *I’m sorry*…’

‘Oh. Adora, *babe*.’ Swiftie flicked his mane up into my fingers, tangling his hair through my fingers. His voice was almost his own again. But not quite. Not yet. I’d disappeared somewhere cold and the heat of his neck was only slowly bringing me back. Gradually, carefully, I worked my way home, trying the tricks Lady P had taught me. Breathe in for four, hold, abjure cacti, then out for the same. Real sounds returned to me: Swift Wind nickering and purring; hooves clopping on cobblestones. Then my eyes were clear. Wimpole Street was gone. I was in Stafford with my *real* family.

‘I’m sorry, Swift Wind.’

‘Don’t be sorry. Adora. It’s your Aunt who oughta be sorry. I’d gore her in real life for what she did to you, hun, if that’s what you wanted.’

‘She wasn’t *that* bad---’

I tailed off.

‘…’ said Swift Wind.

‘Yes, but---’

‘…’

‘She did some great things for me, didn’t she?’

‘…’

‘No,’ I corrected myself. ‘She *was* that bad. She still *is*.’

‘Yeah.’

‘Swift Wind, can we have a nuzzle?’

‘Of course, babe.’

I clambered down from my mount and we went cheek to cheek. His coat was velvet against my skin; my chest stopped aching quite so badly. My noble steed was here for me, just like he always had been, like he always would be. Eyelids flickering, fatigue crashed through me. I could have fallen asleep right there, pooling on the pavement.

Just one thought kept me upright, like the pole up the back of a scarecrow: a revelation I couldn't unsee. This new life of mine, out of the de l'Horde shadows, wasn't as simple as Swiftie and Catra and Bow and Scorfuma and Entrapta and Wrongcle wanting to love me. Or me loving them back. I had to *let* their love in – trust it – make my home inside it. And I really, really wanted to. *Now.* We were going to win in the end.

Out came my pocket watch, its butterfly-hinged lids fluttering open to reveal the stark truth of the present moment. The big hand was on the X and the little hand was inching undeniably towards the I. With my other hand, I rummaged for the one book that never leaves the enquiring traveller's side: *The ABC Alphabetical Railway Guide*. What this monthly tome doesn't know about railway timetabling simply isn't worth knowing, unless, of course, your journey neither starts nor ends in central London. In those situations, you're either stumped or reduced to flicking through a *Bradshaw's Guide*, which amounts to pretty much the same thing.

Stafford, thank Horde, holds a reputation as a major station, so finding the right train would be as easy as the letters on the timetable cover. Alpha, beta, and chums, that is. Sweet Lady Meowmeow would be chuffing straight up from the capital, so all I had to do was flick to the letter S and start hunting. Seaforth & Litherland… Spital… Squirrels Heath… Ah-ha! There it was. Now to decode the appendix letters. The R stood for restaurant car, which I certainly hoped Catra had used to the fullest. Exile from your new love is liable to work up *quite* an appetite. I should know!

But what about the G and K affixed to the two most likely trains? The latter indicated that said service wasn't running on Saturdays after mid-May, which was useful information, given today was very much a Saturday. My Lady love wouldn't be arriving at 28 minutes past the hour, then. As for the G, that crafty curler meant the train ran *only* on Saturdays from mid-May onwards. So it had to be the one! My cheeks and… *other* places flushed with vindicated anticipation, right up until I looked at the arrival time. Three minutes past one.

I'm no horologist, but that certainly appeared to be an unlucky thirteen minutes away. An expert might call such an interval "not very much time at all". In other words, we needed to hustle *and* bustle. Remounting my faithful family member, I looked all around us for the telltale smoke. This taught me two things: one, that Stafford contains myriad forms of the stuff; and two, that our current location was not where we'd been before.

'Where are we?'

'Oh, Adora,' he grinned, 'I know this one. We're in Stafford!'

'But where in Stafford?'

'I can see a castle?'

'Hmm. I don't think many railway stations have crenelations.'

‘They’d be a *lot* cooler if they did. Say, Adora, here’s a neat idea. What if we *nationalised* all the trains under collective ownership? Pretty cool, riiiiigght?’

‘Not now, Swiftie. I see steam engine smoke! Go… that way!!’

Off we rocketed, heads down and chests pounding. We thundered down a main road, hooked a hard right and caught sight of a huge, decidedly Victorian redbrick building. Bijou steam engines clunked and whistled their way along one side, back and forth, while men in grease-soaked overalls tinkered in nearby sheds. To the untrained eye, we had searched and we had found.

‘Alright!’ Swift Wind whinnied. ‘Way to go Adora!’

Alas, my own, faintly glowing gaze had been too well schooled. I saw no platforms, no station concourse with porters and ticket vendors. The locomotives, for that matter, were much too small for the Etherian rails and weren’t hauling any passengers. Most damningly – and, in hindsight, most obviously – the letters arcing high over the main wall formed neither “Stafford” nor “station”. Instead, they read “W. G. Bagnall Limited – Locomotive Works”.

‘Dash it, we’ve got turned around. This isn’t it. We’ve got---’ I glanced at my watch, as it chattered in my shaking fingers, ‘--- nine minutes?!?’

‘Where do you want me to go?’

‘To the station!’

‘Which is *where?*’

‘I don’t *know*… What is your horn telling you?’

‘Left?’

‘Perfect. Let’s go.’

Calmer, more Meowmeowian minds might have consulted a map or asked a friendly local for directions. Sir Adora and Swift Wind, meanwhile, charged off on a hunch. The mood had taken us. I *had* to be there, no matter the cost, as we tried to explain to the fellow whose car we slightly, accidentally trampled. He was jolly cross! The policeman he summoned wasn’t too happy with us either, asking whether I had Motor Vehicle Insurance for my horse. I did not – because Swift Wind is not a motor vehicle. Though verifiably true, this statement did not endear me to the officer, who opened his notepad and started taking notes.

‘Sir-ma’am-sir?’ he said. ‘Please give me your name and address.’

Cripes. I really didn't want to do that. After all the boat-sinking and court-trying that kickstarted this whole sorry affair, the de l'Horde appetite for further legal trouble was precisely nil. Worse still, the watch in my waiting claw was counting down a minute every 60 seconds, with only seven of them left to go. What I desperately needed right now was some token that could immediately extricate me from a situation. As luck would have it, my grey goo reminded me, I had just such an object screwed to my hand.

'Don't you know who I am?' I asked, putting on the kind of elocution Auntie had paid a finishing school to instil in me. '*I* am affianced to Countess Dryl, heir to the Duchy of Brightmoon. *Ergo*, send any repair bills to Shugborough Hall. Good day!'

'Look at you, future Duke!' Swiftie gasped as we galloped away. 'You're warming to the role.'

'I am *not*. And look – railway tracks!'

'Cool idea, Adora! I'll swoop down and follow them.'

'Noooooo!!' I squealed, hauling at Swiftie's mane. 'And sorry. Sorry for doing that. But we are **NOT** jumping onto the West Coast Main Line. Do you *want* to get run over?'

'Then what are we supposed to do?'

‘Find a way of going alongside them. Follow that road!’

Faster, faster, faster, we plunged towards destiny and a good girlfriend. Gravel plumed in our wake as we burst through the station doors, then tiptoed through the ticket hall, to the bemused gasps of station workers and passengers alike. Swift Wind apologised. This made matters worse – horses not generally being known for their grasp on the Etherian language – so we beat a hasty exit onto platform one. A local train occupied the track. That wasn’t our target.

‘Keep going, Swiftie. She’ll be arriving on the Down Fast line.’

‘What does that mean?’

‘The express route away from London.’

‘That doesn’t help, Adora!’

‘Err… no, of course. Um. Jump up on that shed there and we’ll take a look.’

‘Oh yeah! I can fly! Why didn’t we think of that earlier? We could have been here so much faster!’

I didn’t have an answer for that. Neither did he. What the fellow did have, however, was wings. Within seconds, we were atop the rickety iron structure, looking out over the four glistening tracks of the main line. In the distance, I heard a whistle, long and shrill. Thunder came after, syncopated and beating fast. My watch struck one exactly. Our train was coming in.

Glistering crimson burst into a view: an express locomotive at the head of twelve spotless coaches. Sweeping down to meet it, my feet tapped impatiently against the platform. She was here! Catra was finally *here*! Two days had never felt so long. The engine swept past me, hissing and clanking. *Lady of the Lake* said its nameplate – which matched my thoughts exactly. Lady Meowmeow: the divine; the supreme; the woman who’d gifted me the power to shape my own destiny. As the carriage windows whipped past me, third class and first, corridor and compartment, I searched desperately for my dear, sweet Meowmoeow.

But I did not find her.

Not to worry, not to worry. There was still half a train to my right. I just had to take a look down there and I’d find her. Walking, then jogging, then running, I goggled the glazing all the way to the tail lamp. Catra was still nowhere to be seen. Cripes. Had something happened? What had Glimmer – or Double-Trubel – done now?! I must have been vibrating again, because Swiftie nuzzled his muzzle softly into my shoulder.

‘Don’t worry, Adora, babe! We can only see one side of the train from here. What if she’s sat on the other one?’

‘You’re right!’ I barked. Good old Swift Wind! He knew what to do. If only I could inspect the right-hand side of each carriage, then I’d find her, and we’d live happily ever after. Impeccable thinking! All I had to do was hop off the platform.

‘*Adora*. Are you trying to walk on the track? The track you just told me was super unsafe?’

I sighed. Deeply. ‘Yes…’

‘Wouldn’t it be better if *I* – your friend who can fly – hovered safely above train level to check those windows, whilst you see if she steps out from any of these doors?’

‘Yes.’

That really did seem like a perfect plan. Back and forth, I paced the platform, hunting for her bewitching eyes, listening for her heart-piercing laugh. By the Honour of Greyskull, I even sniffed the skies for her trademark scent, intermingled with the coal and the oil. I found nothing – and the clock was closing in on three minutes past. Perhaps she’d missed the station call? Or fallen asleep? Heavens – she was going to miss her stop! And then--- And then--- Would she keep riding, out of my life forever? I couldn’t let that happen. I had to board the train.

‘Swift Wind!’ I shouted from an open window. ‘I need to search the carriages. You’ve got to stop this train from leaving, whatever it takes!!’

‘On it, comrade!’ he replied. ‘Time for this stallion to put on a dog and pony show.’

Muffled by the wood and glass, I heard singing, then shouting, then a loud thump, then more singing:

‘*I’m a talking horse,*

You wonder why? Of course!

I used to live, inside a mind,

Of a person who is very kind,

Then one day I got free,

To share my communist theory.

See this apple in my hoof,

Well, don’t just stand there aloof---’

It sounded like he had it covered, so I could put my shoulder to the grindstone. Which also – quite inadvertently – meant dunking it in a soup urn. In the ensuing fracas, I confirmed that Catra wasn’t perched on any of the restaurant car’s seats, but a substantial quantity of thick ox-tail soup now was. When I tried to clean it up, the shouting only got worse, which I took as my cue to leave. The kitchen and parlour came next, boasting plenty of

scratch but no Meowmeow, before I burst into the open third-class carriages.

With seats either side of an open vestibule, these were a cinch to check, but the news was bad. After examining the brake coach – she wasn't hiding amongst the parcels or hobnobbing with the guard either – I turned on my heel and set off for the corridor coaches that made up the back half of this wretched express. Tears hung at my eyes and my feet started to sprint. This couldn't be happening. *Please*.

'For the Honour of Greyskull,' I muttered beneath my breath. I was searching compartment after compartment – finding disgruntled businessmen, confused families, secreted lovers, gnawing emptiness, but never Catra – when the phrase dropped from my lips. I barely noticed I'd said the words – but She-Raic transformation waits for no fellow. While I hauled down the very last carriage, the tight corridor got tighter and the walls splintered. A window exploded to my left; passengers scrabbled away to my right, plastering themselves against the opposite wall.

'Sorry!' I gasped. 'Sorry! That… happens sometimes. I'm not going to hurt you – quite the opposite. I'm just looking for my girlfriend. Have you seen her? She's about this tall, and terribly beautiful…'

A woman scrunched her nose at me. I was – to her – a very bad smell. She spat one word from her lips. It wasn't a useful one.

'*Homosexual*.'

The infinite rainbows flickered inside me. I burned. Ms. Floaty-C snapped into my hand. The only way out was through. I would not stop now. In an expert sweep, my blade cut my shoulder loose. The carriage wall and half its roof fell away. Turning in what was left of the corridor, I faced this woman and her bigotry: the evil that Catra had suffered every day of her damn life.

'Yes I am.' I told her. 'I am a Lesbian – and I am **so** proud of my girlfriend. I would do **anything** to protect her – I'll fight this whole world if I have to – because my love is stronger than your hate can ever be.'

The woman said nothing, or perhaps she did say something. I didn't want to hear it. There were two compartments left to search. I stepped carefully onwards, scanning every seat. Empty. All of them were empty. That--- that couldn't be. I hurled the doors open, searched the luggage racks, ripped open the seats. No Catra, no Catra. No. She hadn't made it. Something had happened to her.

Back on the platform, watching the dishevelled train retreat into the distance, I was ready for war. Smeared in soot, Swift Wind lay down at my heaving side.

'You didn't find her?'

'No, Swift Wind.'

‘Sooooo… are we going back to London? To search for her there.’

‘No, Swift Wind. Catra promised she’d return today.’

‘You’re going back to Shugborough?!’

‘Not yet. I want answers first – and it’s time I got them. We’re riding to Cannock Chase.’

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Chapter 56

Chapter Summary

'Hey, Adora? You never told me about the... details of your living history lesson before. Do you want to talk about it?'

'Isn't that what I do with this chapter, Catra? All the facts and figures are right there! The reader-doodles can see how I communed with a past She-Ra and... a certain historic, warmongering invader. It... it was really something. Yes. Something.'

'You don't have to put on a stiff upper lip any more, remember? You're safe with me. You can be soft or fragile. You can have needs.'

'Then what I think I really require, Catra, is... is a hug. A big one.'

Chapter Notes

Content warnings apply for the below chapter only - Spoilers may be present in the warnings. This story does not include any of the four Archive Warnings topics, but does occasionally feature other topics that may require content notes. This chapter is rated mature due to depictions of violence. I don't believe they reach the graphic threshold, but you might think differently. As always, check the content warnings!

Chapter 56 Content Warnings (CONTAINS SPOILERS):
Exile – Narrated and in speech, present and ongoing, of major character, impacts main character
Electric shock – Narrated and in speech, present, of main character (non-fatal)
Blood – Narrated, historic, extensive
War – Narrated and in speech, historic, extensive
Manipulation – In speech, historic, of notable character

Physical violence, crushing – Narrated, historic, by notable character
Physical violence, stabbing – Narrated, historic, by notable characters and main character, one fatal incident, two possibly fatal incidents (no graphic details)
Physical violence, strangling – Narrated, historic, by notable character, of notable character, possibly fatal (some detail, not graphic)
Death, presumed – Narrated, historic, of notable characters

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PART 13

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SECTION 5

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The sandstone wall loomed over us. Its cut and curling crags looked nothing like letters – and everything like me. The jutting chin of defiance led the shoulders of never skipping arm day. A mane of hair spilled either side of searing eyes. Ms. Floaty-C swept overhead, a mighty minute hand striking the hour of righteousness. It was enough to make one feel bally patriotic for an Etheria I'd never truly known – but might uncover yet.
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‘Isn’t it *FASCINATING*?!?’ Entrapta squealed.

I’d found them here, setting up some kind of experiment that called for a whole swamp of crocodile clips. They snipped against the foliage, all the way around the ancient portrait, before squiggling away into bifurcated bits of *Dragon’s Daughter IV*. What Skyhawk thought of this went unrecorded. Bow’s reckonings were far more accessible. Alongside the mighty Scorpia and her luscious landscaper, my old uni chum had bunked off from the big house to be here.

‘**Adora!**’ he gasped. ‘Any news on Catra?’

‘*No*. We’ve just been to the station. She wasn’t there.’

‘Wait… Didn’t Glimmer say she was sending a **car**? When we were all together in your bedroom? Before the---’ Bow lowered his voice. ‘*Before the **murder***?’

His tone was terribly clandestine, especially given nobody had died. Yet. My present day swordcane itched to make like its ancient iteration and swing free until we got some answers, because Bowregard was right. Glimmer had promised to dispatch an automobile to Maison Meowmeow – wherever that might actually prove to be – only to knock her pledge back to a train ticket once outside eyes were off her.

Viewed charitably, the Countess Dryl had merely bifurcated my girlfriend's travel plans: do the lengthy schlep from London by rail; then offer a car for those tricky final miles to the Shugborough Hall steps. Quite sensible that approach would be too! But my brows knit. If that *were* her plan, then wouldn't I have spotted a chauffeur or chaffeuse in Stafford, ready to whisk Catra up to the house? I had seen nothing of the sort.

One of two possibilities now loomed more likely. Either the Countess Dryl was expecting my beloved to walk ten miles with her suitcases, which would be the very height of rudeness, or Glimmer had started lying to me. Gosh. That *really* sugared my cream! To think – Glitterbug had said anything and everything to get me into bed – and her plan had halfway worked. Watching all this play out across my face, Scorps strode over with a soothing word.

'We--- I--- Can I say "we" for the both of us, Perfy? Yes? Okay. *We* see that you're a good person, Adora. And we are one-hundred per-cent on Team Wildcat! Whatever it takes to get you two back together, we'll do it. So. What do you need? A huuuggg?'

Surprising even myself, I took the embrace from her, Perfuma and Bow alike. It warmed my cockles… and steamed my muscles. I was ready for war. We *were* going to win in the end. And the She-Raic forces were going to help us.

'I've had rather enough of this Shugborough business,' I announced from the front of the group. 'This ends tonight. I *will* find Catra and we *will* be going home together. If she wants to. Which I hope she does. But I'm relatively certain she likes me back. Does she like me back? Oh Horde, have I thrown away a

possible marriage for a girl who doesn't like me? That's ridiculous. *Is* that ridiculous?! We've only known each other, what, a couple of days. But when you know *you know*, right? RIGHT?!? I know she said she was my girlfriend… only… that *could* be platonic. But it's probably not platonic?'

'That's right babe! It's probably not platonic! Woo!! Let's do this. Apples for all!' my noble steed replied.

'Ch-fflkh. HP!!' added Emily. It was a very wise addition, drawing deep on the aphorisms that form the bedrock of Squirrel language. I started to feel a little more assured. When Lady P stepped up to say her piece, my confidence grew further still:

'I agree with Emily. Even though I'm not sure exactly what she just said, I understand her spirit and her intentions perfectly! They're radiating from her aura. Okay, maybe you have only known Catra since Tuesday. And maybe she has been separated from you for two of those five days. But when you *are* together, there's an energy between you like I've never *seen* before. You're meant for each other, She-Ra. You just need to believe!'

'Belief is part of it, but cold, hard knowledge is the chap I need to find first. I think I became She-Ra for a reason – and I've got to find out why. I'm positive this carving can tell me, if we can only find a way to communicate with it.'

'*SCIENCE*!!' Entrapta replied. 'What we need is *science*! Everybody take a battery and connect it to the circuit at one of the red junctions on my command. I'm soooooooo *happy* you see it my

way, Adora. Without you, Experiment 192 could never go ahead, which would be awful! How many times do you get to recreate history? And how many times does your recreation of history get to recreate history?! This--- It's--- *HISTORIC!!* Ha-ha-ha-HA!'

'Wait,' I replied. 'What?'

The engineer did not immediately respond. They were too busy pushing me into the centre of a chalk X that they'd drawn just ahead of the She-Ra carving. Looking out at the crowd – and the sparking wires – I noticed that the rest of the chalk hadn't gone to waste. Entrapta had drawn a semi-circle with it, much farther back, behind which they and the others were rapidly retreating. They all had goggles. I, notably, did not.

'Adora, stand *perfectly* still. The texts report that the She-Ra has to stay precisely in position or… *bad* things happen.'

'What kind of bad things?' I asked.

'It varies!' came the reply.

'Do I want to be doing this?'

'Yes! Yes you do! One 17th century text and three medieval sources describe occasions when a She-Ra successfully

communed with one of their predecessors. All it takes is physical contact with a She-Raic monument – which we've got right here – and a bo… o… l…ng.'

'Entrapta? You kind of trailed off… What was the second thing?'

'Put your hand on the carving! We're making the lightning artificially but, if my calculations are correct, this *should* still work. Ready? Three, two---'

I gasped. This was all getting a bit too serious. 'Wait! Did you say light…'

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'…ning?'

The word fell into noise and the smell of blood. Dust bloomed where I stepped, sandstone clawed from the crags. I still stood in Cannock Chase but my friends were gone. The tree canopy thronged thicker, overhead, dropping me deep into the shade as I picked along an uncertain path long lost to my own time. Screams clogged the sky. My ancestor had not lived in peace.

Better safe than sorry. Whispering the five famous words, I drew my blade and retreated behind a ridge of knotted bushes. Another She-Ra was here and she might need my help. *I* certainly needed
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her. There was no use getting caught up in some ages-dead conflict before I could even set eyes on her. Eyes on stalks – back straight – thighs coiled and ready to strike – Ms. Floaty-C firm in my hands – I followed the sound. Never leaving myself open, darting from tree to tree, I let the volume grow.

The ground ahead swelled, the path fanning wider until it plunged down, down into a shallow valley. It was just a spit of ground. It was barely big enough for a cricket match, let alone the battle unfolding beneath my feet. Two sides were at war. One marched in chainmail. Their colours were black and green; their fighting was clinical. In straight lines they advanced, swords drawn and shoulders high. When one man fell, another stepped forward to take his place. No tears were shed. No-one remembered the names of their dead.

They were brutality refined. One man led them from far behind. He flicked a finger and another battalion attacked, killed, took ground, died. Then another. Then another. When those failed, and they so rarely failed, he sent his horses. His face was a mask. He had told them to end lives – to end their own – and they had obeyed. This was only what was expected. From the saddle of his bone white mare, King Prime the Conqueror settled the debt of his ambition in human blood.

Against him, what chance did the other side have? I'd studied Etherian history since my childhood. I knew the way this ended. The year must be 1086, when the glorious King Prime I asserted his allodial and ultimate control over every scrap of land in Etheria. His power was in letters, law, and the sword. None dared oppose him, such was the superiority of Prime. This must be true. It was what they wrote in the history textbooks.

Except… Nobody had told this lot. Hair flowing and lances at the ready, the local population were fighting back. And fighting hard. Their numbers were small and getting smaller, yet still they fought on. Absolute hatred seared through their eyes as they split and pincered, flying round the edges of the Horden battle packs to take one life here, one small victory there. Arrows flew. They fell back, then exploded onto the clearing from new, hidden angles. They raced from behind the trees; they tripped Prime's forces into gulleys and over tree roots. They knew this land.

Again, they disappeared, leaving one sole fighter behind. She was thin and tall. And I recognised her. *The Cane Saleswoman.* Wrapped in blue, her chin flicked high, she raced across the arena, pulling the Horden soldiers up to the north, carving just enough space for a flash of light I knew even better. It seared down into me, bleaching my eyes. In the haze I saw a shape too like my own.

'Now She-Ra! Now, my love!! We are *going* to win in the end. We made a promise. We keep each other safe. I love you.'

The She-Ra – not me, the other one – hurled herself into the valley, crushing three, maybe four soldiers under her boots as she landed. Her sword was high and swift, cutting through another dozen before they even understood what hit them. King Prime flicked his fingers and another wave followed. She saw them off… at a price. Blades slashed at her arms. Her stance crumpled. She was struggling. She wanted to fall back. The light in her eyes flickered. She *needed* to stop.

‘No! No no no. You are the fucking **She-Ra**,’ the Saleswoman screeched. ‘You have a duty to this place. What are they meant to do without you? *What the FUCK will I do*? Ohmigosh. She-Ra, do you hear me? *Keep. Fighting.*’

Fire burned in my throat. My brain was burning. Before I even knew the actions were my own, I’d smeared my skorts, my boots, my whole entire She-Raian get-up in a muddy disguise, spotted a gap in the treeline and leaped, screaming. Some soldiers scattered towards me. Not one of them got close, not that I’d ever have noticed. They were shadows to me, barely there. All I could really see was this other, ancient She-Ra – my kin across the ages – as she heaved herself up with her sword.

Spitting blood, shaking slightly, she threw her blade ahead and followed the momentum. She was running straight at the only man who could end this for good. Her head dropped and sacrifice scratched across her features. Her back foot dug in and she launched, high, cleaving her sword straight through King Prime. There was no way any man could survive it. The green light bled from his eyes. The She-Ra had won.

She’d won! A smile creased her tired face, warming her glowing eyes. She turned to us – to the Saleswoman, to me – with victory on her lips. She was so happy, so relieved. Until the second blade sliced through her back. She crumpled to the jagged grip of her attacker, who jerked her neck round so hard it nearly snapped. He hauled her up to his height and the valley emptied. Mist choked around us. He set his teeth and looked hard at me, through fresh, green eyes.

‘She-Ra… in two of your manifold generations. Why do you look so surprised? Did you truly believe that no other could carry your power? That I was another *simple* mortal? I would laugh. I could not allow that.’

‘King Prime is dead,’ my predecessor gurgled. ‘This war is over.’

The green-eyed man smiled so coldly. ‘You miscalculated. You thought yourselves worthy to challenge me, but you are nothing more than the shadows of a lie, tangled through the ages. The King is dead? Then long live the King.’

‘What are you saying?’

‘I am old, far older than you imagined. When one vessel fails, I simply elect another. Thus, Prime shall reign eternal. You must understand. After all, She-Ra, we are the same.’

‘We are nothing alike!’ The words were out of mouth before I could hear them. Prime snapped his gaze to me, squeezing the ancient She-Ra’s neck as he spoke.

‘I see all. I know all. Just as you can. But I have honed these powers in a way you never shall. This land will conform to my control and---’ He grinned wider and closed his fingers. The She-Ra stopped moving. ‘---so shall you.’

I just about remember rushing at him, screaming, with tears in my eyes. Ms. Floaty-C flew up and flickered all the colours of the rainbow, exploding when we hit him hard enough to kill. But the mists came in too fast. I didn’t see him fall. I lost sight of my predecessor in the clouds. The lights blinded me. And then I was on my knees, sobbing, somewhere far across the chase, sometime neither past nor present.

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Chapter 57

Chapter Summary

'Readers, prepare to meet Madame Razz and her Mara, She-Ra of the late 11th century. I wish I could have met them myself. I wish I could thank them for the care, love and wisdom they shared with my beautiful spouse-wife, at the time when she needed it most. They were good women. If only I'd got back to Adora a little earlier--- '

'No, Catra! You were right on time. I mean... You have been missing for hmm... 21-and-a-half chapters of the narrative now, if we include the Duesenberg Dumping, but that was *hardly* your fault. What matters is you returned when it really counted. Was it this chapter? I guess the reader-doodles will have to read on and find out!'

Chapter Notes

Content warnings apply for the below chapter only - Spoilers may be present in the warnings. This story does not include any of the four Archive Warnings topics, but does occasionally feature other topics that may require content notes. This chapter is rated mature due to depictions of death.

Chapter 57 Content Warnings (CONTAINS SPOILERS):
Bereavement – In speech, historic, alluded, impacts notable characters
Blood – Narrated, historic, injury of notable character
Death – Narrated and in speech, historic, of notable character
Transphobia – In speech, historic and ongoing, impacts notable, narrator and major characters
Exile – Narrated and in speech, ongoing into recent historic, of major character, impacts narrator
Arranged marriage – In speech, upcoming, of narrator, impacts major character

See the end of the chapter for more notes

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PART 13

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SECTION 6

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‘You’re a good demigirl, trying to stop it. Trying to save my Mara. But it can’t be done. No. She really fought though – every last step of the way. That was my Mara. So brave. So strong. Ayh. But she was a stupid, stupid girl in the end… Too eager to please.’

‘Who are you? Who is Mara?’

‘Me? Nobody remembers me. No-one puts Madame Razz in their stories. Oh, but my Mara… *I* remember *her*. She was the She-Ra, just like you. And she was m--- Silly Razz! That can wait! There isn’t time, there isn’t time… And I still have so many berries left to pick. You want to know who Mara is? Then you go and talk to her! I know she wants to meet you… *Adora de la Meow-Ra*.’

‘Meow-Ra? *MEOW-RA??!* Wait. Wait! What do you mean--- Am I going to--- *Catra*---- Are you telling me it’s going to work out?’

‘You ask so many questions, dearie. Questions Madam Razz
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cannot possibly answer until it's happened to you. Your Catra Meowmeow--- It might happen; it might not. That's up to *Adora*! You and her, only you and her, Adora! Oh, how I hope it does, though. Come, come, time is short! Go and speak to her. There's no reason why that sword should slice through another Lesbian hand-binding!! So go! GOOOO ALREADY!!'

The short woman with the thick lenses turned her hunched figure back to the bushes. I stood there, uncomprehending. She sighed and extended a bony, bejangled arm at the figure of She-Ra past.

'Go! Don't make me tell you again! Leave me to my berries.'

So I went. I put one boot in front of the other and walked over to the woman in white. Mara huddled in the scrub, her feet and her left fingers scrabbling to push her back up against a tree trunk. She gasped and blood sputtered out: three little drops, grouped on the ground ahead. They were so red, so small. And then they washed away in the salty tang of a tear. It wasn't Mara's. It was mine.

'I met Razz,' I told her. 'She said you wanted to see me.'

'She was right. Hey, Adora.'

'Is--- Is there anything I can do?'

'To save me? You're about eight and a half centuries late.' She laughed, sadness tinged with satisfaction, and sounded so much like Catra that it hurt. 'But thanks. Can you help me up?'

'Sure.' I threw myself into it – back and heart and all. She wrapped an arm around me and crackled, breaking endlessly into pieces. With a groan that was still somehow a smile, Mara brushed the hair out of my eyes, blushing.

'I wonder – did I look that good when I was She-Ra?'

'*Yes*.' The word came out a little quicker and a little firmer than discretion might have demanded – but who gives a fig for decorum at a time like this? It--- it doesn't matter. Not when she's dying – or dead already – or dying again. And she *was* beautiful. 'You must have made someone very happy.'

'I tried. That's all any of us can do… try. And hope it works out.'

'Did it? For you?'

'You're funny, Adora. And sweet. But we can both see the blood. I know what's coming. We don't need to pretend I survived. Cannock Chase on this summer afternoon… that was the end for me. There are worse places to go, I guess, even if I wasn't ready. Not even close.'

She closed her eyes a second, nose twitching gently in the late afternoon sun. The smile on her lips foamed slightly pink. Her breathing laboured. Mara tried to shift herself against the tree – but a deep, resonant crack jerked her still. I wrapped myself around her again, taking some of her weight, trying desperately to stop… *this*. To blanket her from the pain.

'This--- This isn't *FAIR!!!*'

'No, Adora. It isn't. It wasn't.' She rolled left, groaning. My hands held her ribs. They were sticky with blood. 'That's why I wanted to talk to you. You have to know what it really is… to be the She-Ra.'

‘It means I’m the protector of Etheria. That I stand up for the way things should be, not the way things are. That I’m – that we are – the bravest and strongest knight going!! We march into battle for nature and nation and the oppressed and freedom, no matter how great the cost might be.’

‘Who told you that? Light Hope?’

‘The travelling saleswoman who sent me the sword-cane? Tall, wears a lot of blue, rabbits on and on and bravely on about duty and destiny? Comes to me in dreams? Is that the fellowette?’

‘Yes. Not quite how I knew her. But yes.’

‘Then that *was* her, on the battlefield?’

‘And on every other battlefield. She wanted me to be the face of our war. To step up and fight every time the Horden Invasion took another step into Etheria. To win.’

‘The She-Ra’s duty.’

‘Is it? The first She-Ras worked for safety and community and connection with our natural world. They weren’t just machines of

war. I wish I'd remembered that. I wish I'd told Light Hope I was more than a weapon.'

'You're not the *original* She-Ra?!'

'Not by centuries. I'm not even First Ones – my parents were Jute and my community was mostly Saxon. We weren't Celtic. We were just the latest… Migrants? Invaders? Additions to the Etherian story? Choose whichever term you like best. But it won't change the fact that plenty of Celts were driven from their lands before the Horde, and the rest were pushed out or occupied, brutalised or forced to assimilate when Horde Prime arrived.'

'Did you know the other She-Ras? And the Arth-Reds?'

'We all knew the tales. But actually meeting them? That was harder. That takes magic – your predecessors have to leave a message. I met a couple the same way you found me: by visiting the shrine at the place they died.'

'And what did Light Hope want? If it wasn't to protect the Celts?'

'Light Hope wanted a lot of things. She wanted the Horde out. She wanted to look after her people – our peoples. There's nothing wrong with that – in theory – but she thought I should give everything to do it. That it was all on me and the She-Raic powers. She… wanted *everything* from me. My strength, my skill, my duty, my bravery, my friendship, my obedience… and my love.'

‘What did you do?’

‘I gave it. Or I tried. I thought I had to. That’s what you need to know, Adora. You aren’t a resource to consume. You’re not a sword to swing and reforge and swing again until the blade breaks for good. You’re a person. With hopes and dreams and needs.’

Mara looked me straight in the eye – blue burning into equal, brilliant blue – like she was sealing a pact. Like she’d never look away until she knew I really understood.

‘But what were your needs?’ I asked. ‘Did you get them?’

‘Yes and no.’ She smiled and her cheeks crumpled up until they half-closed her eyes. ‘Light Hope was not what I wanted. She was so hungry for all of me – my every last bit of focus and unquestioning devotion – but there can’t be love in a pair like that, where one person gives and the other demands---’

I thought about Aunt Shadowtha. I thought about Glimmer. ‘I know what you mean. I didn’t. But I’m learning.’

‘Good. I’m glad. And I’m proud of you. I wish *I’d* listened when one of the Arth-Reds told me that. There would have been less pain, less glory. But I don’t regret fighting for the things that

mattered to me. **Really mattered**.' She swallowed, her throat trembling, as a tear webbed her lashes. 'I fought to be myself – to be the woman I am – to be **free**.'

'I'm trying to person I really am too. It's--- it's a lot of things. It's *good*.'

'It *really* is. I'm a woman who happens to be trans, Adora. I get it. And I'm proud of you.'

'Are you saying I'm *not* the first trans She-Ra?'

Her laugh tinkled as she stroked my cheek. 'No, Adora. Not by a **long** way. I knew that – and I knew there'd be more of us. It was such a big part of why I fought – so you wouldn't have to. Are we there yet? Do you live in a world where you can just be **you**, without any fear of pain or violence or loss or isolation? Has it finally happened?! Come on, Adora, make me the happiest ancient queer with not long left to be alive!!'

'No. Not yet. But I will take up your fight, I promise. Because---' Emotion flooding, catching, filled my throat. 'Because I want that too. I want the next generation to have it better.'

'Our day will come.'

We held each other in complete understanding. So warm, so complete in our trust and our belief.

'I fought for something else too,' Mara wheezed through a smile. 'For the love of a good woman.'

'For Razz.'

Her whole face burned bright when she heard the name. 'Yes. For Razz. Always for Razz, my love, my wife. It didn't matter what duties and wars I was thrown into, my real loyalties were always to being myself and loving Mara. I should have shouted them louder, more fearlessly. I learnt that too late.' She sighed, again. 'So, Adora, that's what I have to ask you: What do you want?'

'A flat chest,' I shot back. 'A world where I and the people I care about are safe and free. And Catra. My girlfriend, my love, Catra.'

'Then go get them. Go get her. Never apologise. And cherish every second.'

'I will. Thank you.'

I rose and turned to go. Mara was cold, crumpled. But she was smiling – and she wasn't talking to me anymore. Her voice came out like a mountain stream, thin but so, so full of purpose.

‘Look at that – a rainbow! You know what that means… We’re going to win… in the end… You and me… Together… Together forever…’ Her lids dropped heavy and final. They weren’t going to open again. ‘I loved being your wife, Razz. I loved our life. I’m sorry I have to go now. But it won’t be long. **I love you**.’

And she was gone.

And I was gone.

Gone, back to the dusty clearing with leaking eyes and a burning heart. *Mara*, I whispered to the mists. *Mara, I won’t forget you. I won’t let you disappear.* The silence didn’t answer. Mists swirled around me, thick with the scent of fire. My tongue furred over. Cold caught my lungs. Shapes moved inside the abyss and all I could do was watch:

Wide shoulders atop grasping hands, tearing at the air… Fists that shook like they wanted to scream… A gentle hand cupping a chin… Crashing… Screaming… War… Tangled limbs… Jumping… Flying… A field choked with bodies… Two shadows knotted around a third… One stepping forwards, growing taller… The other fading… cast away… A victory march… A funeral pyre… A wedding… and… and the tall, tender shape of a beautiful woman. No. Of the most beautiful woman alive.

‘*Catra*?’

The fog fled from her as she stepped forwards, her outline so sharply defiant it scorched the clouds. Light and heat were in her. The rays dappled my skin, flooded it, and, so gradually but so certainly, I began to thaw. The moon wanted me. She held me tight in her jagged, owning grasp, but her darkness could not hold me a second longer. The night was through. My summer sun had returned to me.

‘Is it really you? Are you real? It’s been--- Plea--- Can I hug---?’

Her arms plunged around me like a dream. She drew me close, deep. Our skin fuzzed against each other like it was overlapping, the distance between us shrinking to atoms as our hearts beat love in matching time. My cheek touched hers and we breathed each other in. Vanilla. Sandalwood. There were no words. We didn’t need them. Wrapped in her soft warmth, I felt safe in a way my life had never let me be before. This. Her. She was where I could build a family.

We stayed like that for a time I didn’t care to measure. Her lips fell on my lips, my cheeks. My kisses strafed her like starfall. I ran fingers through her hair as she sculpted the flatness of my chest, our appreciation of the other absolute. *Our love*. Slowly, slowly, the sounds of the forest reunited with me: the rustle of birds; the sway of a distant lake. There was no fighting, yet there was no sign of Entrapta and their experiments either.

‘How did you find me?’

‘Love,’ said Catra. ‘Love and logic. When I saw our friends around the She-Ra memorial, I calculated that you’d be communing with your ancestor. Knowing that this was the sight of Mara’s final battle, I set out to find her… resting place.’ My girlfriend was quiet for a moment, contemplative. ‘Are you alright?’

‘Maybe. No. But I’m so grateful I met her. Catra, I love you, and I want to make that count.’

‘I love you too.’

‘You weren’t on the train.’

‘I know. I thought I’d be safer not going where Glimmer expected me. I’m sorry – I didn’t mean to scare you.’

A dam deep beneath my sternum burst and I cried into my deep love’s shoulder. ‘Oh, Catra, it’s been **awful**. There were so many Brightmoons. They were dancing and taunting and transforming and squeezing and flirting and propositioning and proposing and splashing and threatening and leaving and scheming and dying and not-dying and murdering and not-murdering and handcuffing and undressing and trying to tangle me up in three-way marriages that put you in the potting shed or something and---’ The air heaved into my lungs. ‘And I can’t let them hurt you again. I’m so sorry I couldn’t--- I *didn’t* stop them before. We have to go.’

‘Will it be that easy?’ Catra asked. She was looking at my engagement ring.

‘Glimmer wants to marry me. Tonight. That’s why we’ve got to run – run and never look back.’

‘She won’t let you go so easily. No. We need a more permanent solution and I just might have one.’ Slicking back her hair, raising a mischievous and perfectly-plucked eyebrow, Meowmeow reached into her jacket and produced a hide-bound notebook. As she flicked through its pages, every last one swam with diagrams, tables and paragraph upon paragraph of her swooping cursive hand. A smile spread over her lips and my heart leapt. ‘If this goes to plan, you’ll be free from Glimmer and the Brightmoons by midnight, with a chance to confront your Aunt and Uncle too. All you have to do, Adora, is trust me. Can you do that?’

‘*Yes*. Wherever you tread, my sweet Lady Meowmeow, I pledge myself to follow.’

‘I love you,’ she replied, ‘and love doesn’t trap or trick. Love is freedom. Hold still, please?’

Her claws clicked out of her left hand as she lifted mine to her lips and kissed. I held my breath. She turned my palm up to the sky, rested it over her thigh and *flicked.* The diamond fell to the floor with a soft clump, surrounded by a cut halo of gold. The colour rushed back into my finger. I was free. And I was in love.

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Chapter End Notes

She's back!! It took 18 chapters this time but she's back!
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Chapter 58

Chapter Summary

‘Righty-ho, Reader-Doodles! We’re back after an unscheduled break with a proper tip-topper of an instalment. This time---’

‘Actually, Adora, do you mind if I handle the introduction, my love? This is a Catradora story, after all, and we’ve had Fifty-Seven chapters from the Adora perspective. Chapter Fifty-Eight is here and it’s time to hear from Catra. Readers, have you been wondering where I’ve been since I met my village fate? Read on and find out.’

‘I don’t know about the readers, but I sure wonder what you got up to. Nothing too scandalous, I hope?’

‘That rather depends on your perspective, sir.’

Chapter Notes

Content warnings apply for the below chapter only - Spoilers may be present in the warnings. This story does not include any of the four Archive Warnings topics, but does occasionally feature other topics that may require content notes. This chapter is rated mature due to depictions of death.

Chapter 58 Content Warnings (CONTAINS SPOILERS):
Transphobia – Narrated, historic familial and present societal, experienced by narrator
Rejection – Narrated, historic familial and present societal, experienced by narrator
Physical violence, manual – Narrated, present, experienced by narrator
Exile – Narrated, present and ongoing, experienced by narrator
Homophobia – Narrated, present societal, experienced by

narrator
Racism – Narrated, present societal, experienced by narrator

See the end of the chapter for more notes

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PART 13

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SECTION 8

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Sorry, Adora. You might want to take a break for the next chapter or two. It's time for another perspective. *My* perspective. You weren't there to enjoy *this* adventure with me, after all. The readers could benefit from my inimitable expertise, don't you agree? You do? *Purr-fect*. Now, let's see. After Fifty-Seven chapters, the basics of our situation are pretty well-established, so far as my newly-acquired girlfriend knew them. So are my *charming* personality and the *devastating* depths of my beauty. Suffice to say, *I've got a lot, a lot of what I've got*…

But you already know *that*. There's no need to re-tread familiar ground, so where do we begin? We could dart like Dickens and depart from the start, with the facts of my birth. *Whether I shall turn out to be the heroine of my own life, or whether that station*
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will be held by anybody else--- No, these paragraphs mustn't show. I'm not one to dwell on the fellows who brought me into the world, only to take one look at the *real* me and say no, ***no***, thank you.

Better, then, that we bounce like the Bard and slip into swelling statements? Do I take centre stage and tell you about the great and fated? Do you want to hear how *I've had a bad life. If I want something, it's taken from me. If I win a fight, I lose the war*? From my shared flat in Soho, scraping together train fare, a second career in tatters in just as many years, it sure felt like it. I could have broken down and wept – torn my chest – cried out that I'd lost it all. And I did. But I didn't stay stuck in self-pity. That isn't the way of Catra 'Apfelmus' Applesauce Meowmeow. Not anymore.

So, why don't we start the afternoon before that ugly twilight, with my finely-tailored ass installed in a Rolls-Royce. It wasn't easy to tell Adora *goodbye* – and not just because I'd been bundled into the car before I got the chance to speak. I don't blame Major Juliet. She needs a job, just like the rest of us. But did she really have to jab me in the ribs? I won't tell her how to do her job, but that felt excessive. We'd shared, what, four words with each other in our entire lives. What had *I* done to deserve a new bruise?

Well. You and I both know my crime: I'd got in the way of Glimmer lots-of-names Brightmoon, the Lady who takes the 'o' out of Countess. That's the thing about me and my friends. We're always going where we're not wanted. Just look at Entrapta, stumbling over the bonnet of the rearing Phantom as Juliet tried to motor away. To anyone else, it hopefully looked like an accident. Yeah, no. It wasn't. As they stumbled along the radiator

grille, my engineer friend flashed their palms with a message meant just for me.

A number, a dot, a number, a dot, a number, a little letter "p", a number, a number.

Entrapta doesn't waste words, not when someone else could say them better. That's what this note was: an invitation to read. A Deuey-Decimal library reference, a page number, and a line. I got them down, fast. The car drove quicker, until it screeched to a halt ahead of Stafford railway station. Major Juliet didn't say a word. She just unfolded herself from the chauffeur's seat and started playing around under the bonnet. Damn. Glimmer wasn't taking chances. I was *almost* impressed.

Working fast, the butler extracted the distributor cap and a handful of spark plugs. This Rolls-Royce wasn't going anywhere without Juliet's say-so. News of my automotive… *accomplishments* must have been spreading. Once the dirty business was done, I was hauled out of the cabin and towards the platform. Juliet clamped my arm like a copper on a night raid – and had about the same sense of humour.

'You'll be sending on my luggage, I presume?' I grinned.

She didn't laugh. She didn't even look my way. No. Major Juliet just advanced towards the ticket office and booked my passage back to London. Single fare, third class. The Brightmoon generosity knows no bounds. Waiting for the lunchtime Up Express, the conversation got no better.

‘I *do* know how to catch a train.’ I trilled. I used my best domestic service voice and everything. ‘One has to do it quite often when one lacks the scratch for a fine automobile of one’s own.’

This one *did* get an answer.

‘Yet another reason you don’t compare to Mistress Brightmoon.’

Ouch. *Brutal*. Satisfied with her riposte, Major Juliet snapped back to her straight-ahead stare, only breaking her silence to manhandle me aboard an empty compartment. The silence gave me time to think, which was Glimmer’s second mistake. Her first was thinking she could ever beat a woman like me. After what I’ve been through? There is no force on this Earth I will *ever* allow to stop me from being fully, completely myself, in life or in love.

Chewing over the situation, I had a tawdry little revelation. Lady Glimmer wasn’t the kind of woman who delights in quiet victory. Just getting rid of me wouldn’t be enough. She’d want to know that she’d destroyed me entirely, so she could sleep soundly in the knowledge that she was an undisputed *winner*. Well, I’d give her what she wanted. What can I say? I’m kind like that. And I’ve missed acting.

Dropping to my seat in mock defeat, I looked on Major Juliet with wide-eyed horror as she slammed the compartment shut and produced a skeleton key. I ran towards her; I scratched against the glass; I tried to haul the door back open, fighting her progress

towards the lock. My claws fought and flustered, but – what do you know – she slid the key into the barrels and *click*. I was trapped. I shouted. I wept – which *I* can do without thinking about children getting hurt.

The Major snarled at me and stepped back towards the platform. I ran across the compartment and tried the window, hauling at the leather strap, throwing my shoulders and my back at the mechanism. It didn't budge. Of course it didn't. But I tried again, and again. *Juliet*, I screamed. *JULIIEETTT!! ADORRRA!! ADORA, HELP!!* My cries drowned under the whistle; the train pulled away. Major Juliet tracked my progress with a flick of her head, watching this latest grubby nuisance retreat from her Mistress's life for good. As she slid out of view, I made my final play. I screeched, I balled my fist and I threw--- myself back into the seat, for a comfortable ride back to Euston.

When a man is tired of London, he's tired of life. When a woman like me is tired of London? Let's just say it makes *way* too much sense. Tired and cashless – with *no* idea how bad my hair looked – I trudged away from the station via the back streets. I--- I just couldn't--- I was over it. Plans and futures danced through my head like impossible dreams, but the here and now was disapproving stares and enquiring eyebrows. These weren't my people. And, oh, they make sure I know that. Every. Single. Day.

Not until I staggered into Soho did the weight begin to lift. This is where us queers and undesirables *belong*, and isn't that just totally ***shit***?! Yeah, I know. I'm Meowmeow, the refined, intelligent voice of wit and reason. But, right then? Right now? I couldn't and I can't do it. **This fucking sucks**. There's one city in all of Europe where I feel really, actually *safe*, and I was run out

of that town on the whim of a soulless noble who doesn't even grasp the gravity of what they did. Thanks, Double-Trubel.

Trudging up the steps to the shared flat I'd left barely a couple of days before, I was *angry.* More than angry. Literally fucking *shaking* with rage. What was my crime?? Oh, that's right, I'd been myself. A self-actualised woman – a trans woman, if you'd rather. A Lesbian. A worker who dared not to adore the aristocracy. Anything other than the snow-whitest shade of entrenched Caucasian. And my punishment was to get ground down time and time and time again, until I might finally have the good sense to give up and accept scraps. Because Etheria would *never* give me anything more.

My nails scored against the handle as I rattled the door. It slammed open. I didn't mean to do that. Staggering one step, then two across the threshold, I collapsed onto the doormat and wept. It wasn't graceful, but it was honest and – for that one moment – it was what I needed. The tears fell deep and unctuous, as if they were saturated with decades of awkward, voiceless pain. I had been *so* strong for *so* ***very*** long. I'd taken every hit and never yielded to my attackers; my whole adult life, I'd stood tall as the protector of friends, colleagues, girlfriends.

But a woman is not made of stone.

And strength is more than standing tall.

It's in *being*, with all the radical vulnerability that requires. I cried, reader. I let the tears flow for Adora and the forces swirling

against us, then for the constriction and isolation they'd suffered under. I wept for myself and the girl I'd been. I cried out the loneliness I'd known most of my life. I mourned the trusting nature I'd lost so young, and felt just how badly I wanted to build it up again, now I had people worth trusting. I cried for the girls and the kids just like me, wishing I had some way to save them from everything I'd had to suffer.

Conviction burned deep in my chest. I was not a child anymore; my life was my own to build, no matter how many times people tried to tear it down. I would prevail. My tears dried. I was going to free myself and Adora too, if she'd have me. And, *yeah, she would*, I told myself, my strength shifting into self-belief. What was it my chivalric She-Ra was so keen on saying? *We were going to win in the end.*

'Mother Mara, you sure know how to make an entrance,' scoffed Huntara from her place at the stove. The congee simmered beneath her, spreading the fish we couldn't quite afford amongst the old rice we could. She grinned wide, totally unperturbed to see me. Happy, even. Flashing a smile – still missing three teeth from the Compton Street raid last November – she gestured to a spare seat and told me to sit. Our third flatmate shunted me a glass as I took my place at the kitchen table.

'I'll cut to the chase, Wildcat.' Jewell growled. His voice was *really* coming in. Good for him. 'What are you doing back so soon? You fuck it up with that de l'Horde doll already?'

'That's not *quite* how I'd put it. There were… *complications* in our domestic arrangement.'

Huntara raised an eyebrow. ‘Fuck, you move fast! Are you sayin’…?’

‘That we’re girlfriends? Yes. Unfortunately, there are other laborious and nearly inestimable restrictions at present.’

Jewell tutted. ‘Save your highfalutin’ language, Cat. I’m guessing you need your room back?’

‘For one night only. But there’s something else I need first. Do you still have your old Boyshform somewhere? And could you explain how to use it, in writing?’

He nodded. He knew the gravitas of those questions, and he didn’t waste any time. Once he was out of the room, I took a pencil from the pot and started sketching out everything I knew, everything I needed to know, and everything I needed, starting with the library reference. That caught Huntara’s attention. Turning down the heat, she made her way over to the table and peered over my shoulder at the developing lists.

‘That’s quite the collection,’ she hummed. ‘How are you going to pay for all this? You a kept woman now?’

‘Hardly. I didn’t ask a penny off Adora – and I haven’t got one to my name either. All my belongings are locked up in Shugborough

Hall.'

'Not ideal. So, what? Crack open the piggy bank?'

'No. We need that money for a train ticket I'm not planning to use.'

'*Luxurious*!' Huntara laughed. 'What are we now, millionaires?'

'Our opposition are. If we're going to outwit them and get Adora safely to somewhere she can call home, we have to be cunning.'

'Okay, you win. You've intrigued me.'

'I thought I might… Step one, I need a ballgown, preferably without spending any of the money we don't have.'

Huntara mock-gasped. 'But, Catra! You do know we're different sizes, don't you? I can't imagine *how* you're expecting me to magic up a dress to your dimensions at *such* short notice… Wait--- You're not asking me to---?'

'Your methods are your own,' I smiled. 'I wouldn't dream of interfering with your *singular* techniques.'

‘And just what are doing while I “sew” you a dress and Jewell scribbles you a how-to guide?’

I smiled at her, twirling a key between my fingers. It sparkled in the lamplight. ‘I’ve got an idea of how to entertain myself. Say, Huntara, can you spare me a couple of pennies?’ The coppers skidded across the counter. I tucked them into the jacket and bowed with a *very* formal deepness. ‘Much obliged, my dear Lady. See you at sundown.’

The receiver buzzed as I clicked the coins into the tray. Thumbing the local ‘paper I’d picked up along the way, I selected the right professional and dialled. A well-spoken man picked up; a well-spoken woman answered him. In my most velvety valet tones, I offered up the address of a certain bolthole in Belgravia and asked how soon he could be there. No, an hour should be quite sufficient.

Any sooner would have been *too* fast. I needed a minute to comb out my hair and change my collar, after all, before I could hit the streets and race across to the *much* more exclusive patch of London where I’d said I was already. A girl’s *got* to have standards – and standards take time. With less than ten minutes left on my pocket watch, I nodded stiffly to the doormen and let myself into Sir Adora’s flat.

Mail that mattered went on her desk; missives from Aunt Shadowtha were filed somewhere… else. Showtime. I had coffee simmering on the stove before the steam iron had risen to temperature. I buffed boots, turned down the bed, selected

outfits for the imaginary evening ahead. My heart caught in my chest. This was an act, sure, for the benefit of a man who likely wouldn't make it past the doormat. But it felt so *real*. Here it was: the life I could have with my *girlfriend*. A girlfriend I could even – maybe – if we took the right precautions – be seen with in public.

Concentrate, Catra. Adora was trapped in Shugborough for the night. If Glimmer got her way, she might not leave tomorrow. Or ever again. Aunt Shadowtha wouldn't waste a second sinking her talons back into little Dory, either way. A shudder ran through me. My girlfriend deserved better. We both did. And it started now, with the buzz of the doorbell. Practising in the mirror, I arranged my most distraught-but-uptight scowl, then let in the locksmith.

'Thank Prime and country you're here!' I proclaimed. 'My *eternal* gratitude to you for attending us at such short notice, Mr. Etterington. Sir de l'Horde has been beside herself with worry. She lost the apartment keys last night and positively insisted I oversee replacement of the locks. The whole affair has been a terrible shock to her. How quickly can the job be done? Will an hour be enough?'

It would. It was. Paid handsomely for his handiwork, the locksmith left the way he came, his discretion assured, after just 52 minutes. A pair of fresh door keys sat in my breast pocket. Two more stood in Adora's bedside cabinet, just where I'd calculated she might leave them. These didn't open the front door – but I didn't need a second guess to figure out what they *did* do. Bless them, Adora has a strong, clear heart. Before I stepped into the picture, their key loves were Sport, Swiftie, and *Speed*.

Ten minutes in the Mews found a row of garages. Working out which one belonged to Sir Adora took only really, *really* mild detective work. It was the one with an Oxford University Boat Club crest and twin horses painted on its doors. The lock cracked, the doors creaked, and *there* it was. Polished aluminium slung between four tall wheels. No windscreen and no running boards; one door and scant luggage space. Scorch marks from the exhaust; strike marks from flying gravel. *Swiftie* – Adora's treasured Frazer-Nash SuperSports. An automobile for the automobile obsessive… and my ticket back to Shugborough. Express, naturally.

Her sports car needed a little tender loving care before I could hit the road. I changed the oil and greased the chains, swapped the spark plugs and set the timing for mile-after-mile of wide-open throttle. Call me over-cautious, but I had a funny feeling Adora and I would be needing a speedy getaway, if my Midsummer Night's Dream played out like I was planning. Stealth wouldn't hurt either. As the light started to die in the hazy June sky, I scraped off the de l'Horde family crest and fitted a less-than-legitimate replacement numberplate.

The night passed fast. Back in Soho, I stowed the Nash under an oilcloth in a back alley, collected photo prints and ran to the post office, crossing every claw that Adora got my gifts. All the while, Huntara sewed like her hands were hydraulic. The night came in around us as Jewell and I darted across London, begging favours and booking tickets we might never use. Making the impossible happen.

We scooped up the evening 'papers, then the night 'papers. We searched for the engagement announcement that was sure to come. Nothing yet. We packed the car, checked the route.

Huntara kept sewing. Sometime after midnight, I joined her. Sometime before dawn, the dress was done. I crashed. I slept. The sun climbed back into the sky and I clambered behind the wheel. Time to go. Before the City started its breakfast, I was away, flying west, smirking and certain. Next stop, Oxford. Today was going to be a *good* day, Adora.

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Chapter End Notes

Woo! This fic is back! Thanks for bearing with me... I've not been able to write for a while.....
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Chapter 59

Chapter Summary

'Hey, readers. You're in for a treat - another chapter from my perspective. It's not quite ducking trifle or smashing up trains, but I like to think we'll still have fun. It starts with a place I never thought a girl like Catra A. Meowmeow would be allowed to tread - the University of Oxford. And, oh, there's plenty to be learned as I tread its hallowed halls.'

'Ooh! OOH! Did I ever tell you *I* went to Oxford?'

'Yes, sir. Repeatedly.'

'Good, because I did. There's a mark where I bumped my noggin in the boathouse and everything. You know what's also good? This chapter - and the fact it brought Catra back to my side. As you might have noticed, readerdoodles, that's where I really like her to be.'

Chapter Notes

Content warnings apply for the below chapter only - Spoilers may be present in the warnings. This story does not include any of the four Archive Warnings topics, but does occasionally feature other topics that may require content notes.

Chapter 59 Content Warnings (CONTAINS SPOILERS):
Exile - Narrated and in speech, present and ongoing, of major character, impacts main character
Relationship interference - In speech, present, of major character, impacts main character, offscreen
Transphobia, homophobia - Alluded to in narration, ongoing, towards major character

See the end of the chapter for more notes

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PART 13

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SECTION 9

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I looked up at the summer sky. I wasn't expecting it to have answers – it had just been that kind of a morning. In my breast pocket sat a piece of paper with an address written on it. An envelope. It wasn't *that* envelope, the one that Adora had risked life, limb, Bentley and jail for. But it *was* the closest copy I could make. Don't worry – this wasn't revenge. As much as I disliked Glimmer, there was simply no way I'd punish Bowregard for her actions. No. I refuse to descend to her level.

Honestly? I no longer cared what the original letter contained. Bow had it back. He wasn't going to send it and any involvement I had with its contents ended there. My new envelope was completely empty. All it carried was an address I'd written from memory. An address I badly needed to find. Since the inky hours before the sun came up until now, minutes before the clocks struck nine, I'd been stalking the Oxford streets in growing desperation, trying to put a place to a name.

And I had not succeeded.

Ducking under the Bridge of Sighs, I checked the envelope again. Really *scrutinised* it. There had to be some clue here, some hidden meaning, that would unlock these ancient university streets. I could locate some of the city's thirty-something colleges by now, sure. My problem was working out which one was which. When they all boast the same sandy brick, the same old oak doors, the same surly porters and the same complete absence of any kind of signs or labels, that's easier said than done.

'Where,' I asked the bridge, '*Where* is Jesus College?'

The Bridge of Sighs did not reply – but one of its windows did open. Tinted cigarette smoke blossomed out, followed by a bundle of furs and smiles. The woman all this belonged to waved at me. I waved back. She waved some more. I bowed slightly, bringing a valet's formality to the situation. She gasped, then started to climb even further out the window. I started rushing forwards to catch her.

This was *not* the morning I wanted… and it wouldn't turn out to be the morning I had. With a flick of her wrists, the student summoned an ice ladder and slid cooly to a halt by my feet. She bowed very slightly. I did the same. She smiled some more, winked, and offered me a cigarette.

'*Chào chị!*' she shouted. 'Why are you looking up at me like that?! Not that I'm complaining. Anyone dressed like you can look at me *all day*.'

Okay, I admit it: I smiled until my snaggletooth pulled at my lip. I'm not immune to flattery. I don't try to be. Cocking my hips to emphasise *just* how good my curves looked in that suit, I set my voice to a crackly drawl and summoned up all the Vietnamese I knew:

'*Cảm ơn em*… but I'm going to have to disappoint you. I already have a girlfriend.'

'Boo! She's *super* lucky.'

'I like to think I'm quite fortunate too.'

'Yeah? Tell me about her?'

'I could – for hours – but I've got pressing matters to attend to first.'

'And they're more important than your *girlfriend??!* Maybe you're *not* hot…'

'Hey now! I'm in Oxford *for* her, okay? I just need to take care of a few things before I head north to pick her up.'

‘North? Where are you going??’

The student looked at me with keen interest. They say university education is best suited to enquiring minds. My new acquaintance was proof of that. She smiled at me, waiting for an answer. I weighed up my options. From the quality of her coat and the fact she could afford three years out to study, she had to move in the loftier circles of Etherian society. She might know any number of the souls I’d left in Staffordshire. She could be friend or foe – and it was better to find out which.

‘Shugborough Hall,’ I replied.

‘No way?! I’m going there! Tomorrow! I have an invite in… *here!!* Ah-hum: “A Midsummer Night’s Scream – The Brightmoon Ball Returns with a Once-in-a-Lifetime Surprise!!!” There are three exclamation points. Look. See? Anyway, I’m going because *I’m* buddies with *the* Countess Brightmoon herself. And I’ve got a plus one… which needs filling. Fast.’

I raised my eyebrow and set it to stun. The grin on the student’s face got wider and wider.

‘Hey! *HEY!!* **You’re** off to Shugborough, right? Do you have an invite?!’

‘I do not.’

‘Sweet! Then you’re my plus one! No take-backsies!!’

She nodded. I shook her hand, bowing slightly, but her countenance clouded.

‘Wait. Isn’t your girlfriend already there? Why can’t she take you??’

‘She wasn’t granted a plus one or – more accurately – she wasn’t given a choice.’

‘I see,’ she said. ‘I *see*.’

‘I hoped you would.’

‘I do. *She’s* trapped in Staffordshire. *You’re* in Oxford on a secret mission. And *Glimmer* can sort all this out for you. I’ll telephone her as soon as I’m through with class!!’

‘**No!**’

My claws slashed out; my tail jumped on end. Shit. This conversation was losing altitude and I’d just pushed down hard on

the joystick. The student froze, her pupils like pinpricks. I had one chance to rescue the situation. If it didn't act fast, it'd slip away from me for good. Forcing my breath steady, I slicked my hair back and extended an olive branch.

'No, *thank you*,' I continued, 'and a thousand apologies for your dress sleeve. Would you allow me to mend it for you? It's the least I can do.'

I smiled a lop-sided grin and she started to soften. Her eyes sparkled again. She held out her arm and let me work. As the needle darted discreetly through the satin, she got curious. My new friend cupped her hand and lowered her voice, beckoning me closer.

'Is this… ***Lesbian drama????!??***'

I nodded. She weighed that for a second.

'Why don't you want me to tell Glimmer? We're super good friends. I'm sure she'd work it out.'

'I'm certain she *could* but my plan relies on the utmost discretion… until the very special moment when it doesn't.'

'Ooh!! Can I be a part of that?!'

‘Absolutely. In fact, if you’d still like to take me to the ball, I can give you a key part in proceedings.’

‘Tell me more!’

‘Oh, of course. We’ll dress to the nines – I have a ball gown packed especially – and make our entrance arm-in-arm. The doorman will announce me as your accompaniment, nothing more.’

‘Don’t you have a name?’

‘*Meowmeow*, I’m Meowmeow. It’s a pleasure to be meeting you.’

‘Frosta. Princess Frosta.’

‘Charmed, I’m sure, Your Royal Highness.’

I paused my needlework to hinge myself over my hips. Frosta giggled.

‘Don’t be silly! I’m just a student… who likes ***smashing things!!*** Will that be useful?’

‘Maybe… not straight away, though. For the first few hours – from our arrival to the big event – we’ll just be ordinary party guests. We’ll dance; we’ll chat; we’ll sip champagne under the stars.’

‘**Boring**.’

‘Oh, but there’s a twist. I’ll be hidden behind a mask.’

‘Ooh, ooh! Intrigue! I’m back in.’

‘I thought you might be. Now, this is the important bit: under *no* circumstance *whatsoever* can my mask come off.’

‘Until ***THE MOMENT!!***’

‘Very good.’

‘YES!!’ Frosta was bursting with excitement. ‘So. Um. What **is** the moment? When will we know it’s arrived??’

‘My mask comes off precisely one second before Glimmer reaches the end of her big speech.’

‘WAIT… Are we ***ruining*** this party?! I ***LOVE*** ruining parties!!’

‘So you’ll help?’

‘Uh… ***YES!?!*** Ohmigosh. Just imagine the look on Glimmer’s face!! This is gonna be SO fucking funny!!’

‘I like to think so.’

I savoured the thought, if only for a second. That was the main course and I had plenty of work left to do on the starter. Reaching for the envelope, I showed its address to Frosta. Maybe an Oxford student could make sense of this city’s cryptic conurbations. Mara knows *I* was out of ideas.

‘Jesus College,’ I said. ‘Do you know it?’

‘What? Yes! I’m on my way there now. I’ve got… *urgh*… a ***tutorial***. And I have **NOT** done the reading.’

‘Perhaps you could lose a minute or two helping this suave stranger find the Chair of First Ones?’

‘Uh, I ***WISH***, Meowmeow. He’s the guy I’m meant to be seeing. But. **But**. I’ll take you there anyway. Maybe you can storm in there ahead of me and just… like… start asking all your questions? Seriously. Ask ALL of them. **Please**. And take your time. I need a reprieve to finish this chapter. Please, Meowmeow? Pleeeeeeeeaaase??’

I held out my hand. ‘We have a deal.’

Minutes later we stood in front of another nondescript wooden door in another butter-yellow wall. Frosta lifted the identikit knocker and a grim-faced guy from central casting answered. She showed him a card and got us ushered through into a warren of spiral staircases and lopsided corridors that ended at the carved chancel of an ancient office door. She knocked again – more hesitantly this time – and a voice within summoned her. Squaring her shoulders and catching her breath, Frosta pulled up the door latch… and pushed me straight through into the room beyond.

‘PROFESSOR, THIS IS MEOWMEOW!’ she shouted. ‘I FOUND HER OUTSIDE HERTFORD. SHE NEEDS TO SPEAK TO YOU. URGENTLY!’

The man to whom she was shouting swivelled in his seat and lowered his glasses to look at me. Framed by three piles of textbooks, he cleared his throat. There was silence, apart from the sound of the crackling fire. It might have been mid-June but this room was freezing. The man cleared his throat. He was waiting for me to become interesting.

‘Sir, may I presume you are the esteemed Jesus Chair of First Ones? I have a query regarding Celtic and pre-Medieval society.’

He softened. Instantly.

‘I am. How can I help you? Are you looking to enrol?! Are you a history student??!?’

‘I… have an *intimate* interest in the She-Ra.’ I answered, honestly.

‘Who doesn’t?! What do you want to know? I’m sure you’re already aware that the earliest She-Raic records date back to the eight century, though that’s not to say our knowledge is anywhere *near* complete. There are older texts that I suspect reference even more ancient She-Ras but – alas! – I can only make out so much of the early Sagas. Argh! What I wouldn’t give for just **one** fluent First Ones speaker.’

‘I might be able to help with that.’

‘Wait. Are you saying you can **read** First Ones??’

‘No,’ I said, ‘but you might want to sit down. My girlfriend *can* comprehend First Ones perfectly. She can read it, write it and speak it… … … because she’s the new She-Ra.’

What happened next is a blur. I remember Professor Georgemann's teacup dropping to the floor and shattering against the hearth, followed straight after by most of Professor Georgemann. Frosta raced over to extinguish the fire; I darted for a pillow to cushion the esteemed academic's fall. The professor went a *bad* shade of red and my fingers had to go down his throat, to dislodge his morning fondant fancy. I hadn't meant to shock him so badly. Really, I hadn't. It's just… There's no gentle way to say your future spouse is the latest manifestation of an ancient magical power not seen in centuries.

When he came round, Lance Georgemann had questions. I did my best to answer them, while asking the most urgent of my own.

'Who… Who **is** this new She-Ra? Would I know them?'

'Yes, you've met them before. She's your son's best friend, Sir Adora de l'Horde.'

The professor fell off his chair again.

'That's not good,' he eventually replied. 'The Marchioness de l'Horde won't like that.'

'Which part?' I laughed. 'That her niece Adora is the She-Ra, that Adora is dating a commoner, or that Adora is dating a girl?'

‘All of it, I suppose. It’s hard to pick which one that witch will hate most. Pardon my language – but she’s awful.’

‘*Quite*. That brings me to my first request. Adora and I might not be able to go home after this all plays out. Could we seek safety with your family, just for a day or two?’

‘Yes. I’ll have to check with my husband, but yes. Adora’s a good kid. If she picked you, I’m sure you’re fantastic too. You don’t deserve… *what might come next*. You’ll always have a home with us if you need it.’

‘Thank you,’ I said. I was trying to choke back a tear. I was failing. ‘*Thank you*.’

‘Don’t mention it. Now, Meowmeow---’

‘Catra, you can call me Catra.’

‘Now, Catra, where is Adora right now? Is she safe?’

‘She’s at Shugborough Hall. And no.’

‘Duke Brightmoon’s place? And she’s in trouble? I find *that* hard to believe.’

‘The Duke has been nothing but a gentleman. His wife, the Duchess, is less enamoured with the She-Ra. His daughter actively despises me.’

‘AWWWHHH!’ Frosta shouted, followed by, ‘WAIT?! YOU’RE DATING **ADORA?! ADORA DE L’HORDE??** OH, GLIMMER’S GONNA BE ***SO*** PISSED. SHE’S WANTED ADORA FOR LONGER THAN I’VE KNOWN HER. FUCK! SHE’LL DO ***ANYTHING*** TO GET HER… AND TO GET RID OF YOU. YES!! THIS IS GETTING ***DRAMATIC!!!*** I’M SO ONBOARD.’

‘Your student has outlined the basic gist of the problem. Glimmer might be a kind and reasonable woman in every other aspect of her existence. I wouldn’t know – but I do know this. When it comes to Adora’s love life, she is *not*.’

Lance stroked his beard in deep thought. ‘Oh. Oh dear. Do you think it might help if I had a little word with her? Just a tiny one? These situations can be **so**… *delicate* – but you and Adora deserve the freedom to date each other in peace.’

‘I… I appreciate that. A lot.’

‘ARE YOU **CRYING?** SIR! YOU MADE MEOWMEOW CRY!! I’VE ONLY KNOWN MEOWMEOW FOR AN HOUR BUT I---’

‘It’s okay, Frosta. I’m just not used to feeling so accepted and so safe. Not in Etheria, anyhow.’

Dabbing my eyes against Lance’s handkerchief, I tried to calm myself, but he offered a hug, I accepted and the tears came hot and fast. I cried for what I’d lost and what I’d never had. What I might never hav--- *No*. That was how Etheria wanted me to think – and I was done with it.

As the warmth of his palm smoothed the hair over the back of my neck, I was struck by something that wasn’t quite a revelation. I *knew* these facts already but here, now, for the first time I was *feeling* them. Here was a fellow queer of colour who was married, who’d raised a wonderful son, who owned a home, who held a prestigious role, who indulged his passions, who lived openly and safely and with so much love. If he thrived like this, I could too. I *would* too.

But first – the questions.

‘Sir,’ I asked, breaking away, ‘would you give Bowregard permission to attend the Brightmoon Ball? Adora tells me he’s incredibly keen to attend.’

‘Oh – why not! He’s been studying so hard this year. He deserves a break!’

He started reaching towards his ‘phone, but I moved faster. Dumping Bow in the shit was *not* part of my plan.

‘Allow me, sir. I’ve taken enough of your time already. I’ll telegram him the second I leave your office. Before I do, though, could you possibly help me identify this book reference? My friend Mx. Entrapta Geonor gave it to me. I have reason to suspect it concerns the She-Ra in Staffordshire.’

‘Good hunch! No, great hunch! Here… it… is…’ Mr. Lancemann plucked a book from the base of a now very precarious pile. ‘And the page number iiiissss… Here we are! “Two Deaths, One Legacy – The Battle of Cannock Chase.” It’s a good one. **Very** dramatic. She-Ra Mara slays King Prime the Conqueror, only to be cut down by the new king, Prime Rufus II. Take a look: this map shows the exact location.’

‘Perfect! Thank you. Now, I’ve got just one more question: how would an Oxford graduate go about correcting an error on their degree certificate?’

‘Is this about… *the situation*… with Adora?’

‘Yes. She earned her high second-class degree and I get the *strong* impression she’d like her efforts to be recognised. I really want to do that for her.’

‘Say no more. I’ll have the corrected certificate made up before we leave.’

He was as good as his word. Early the next morning, I tucked the vellum into the Frazer-Nash and led the Austin saloon of Messrs Georgemann and Lancemann north, out of Oxford, towards our date with destiny. Frosta sat to my left, her nose deep in the morning ‘paper. An hour later, she broke her silence.

‘Meowmeow, babe, did you SEE this?! Glimmer’s just announced her engagement.’

Sometimes I hate being right…

Turning onto a secluded gravel side road, I shepherded Frosta into the Austin and gave George the directions to Lichfield station, where he’d agreed to meet my friends. Huntara and Jewell weren’t missing tonight for the world but I wasn’t taking any chances. They’d have to enter Cannock Chase under cover and they absolutely could *not* be seen talking with me. We were just about to cross the border into Brightmoon Country – who knew *who* might be watching?

Alone with my thoughts and my ballgown, I kept on going, spearing onto the chase with a flying cap pulled down hard over my face. Twenty miles to go. Ten. Five. Zero. I hid the Nash where no-one would ever think to look for it, dropped the distributor cap in my pocket and waded into the forest. There I waited for hours, barely daring to breath, until I finally saw her appear through the mist. *Her*. My heart bound tight in my chest.

Hey, Adora.

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Chapter End Notes

Thanks for bearing with me... far too much life and hospital has been happening. But hopefully *this time* I'll finally fet the story done and give Catradora their happy 1930 ever after!! Thanks always for your comments, they really encourage me to keep going. I'm really grateful you've stuck with me through so many chapters :) x
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Chapter 60

Chapter Summary

'Two Lesbians stand in a forest, bits of forest still stuck in their hair. Don't ask what they were doing. Forest things, that's what.'

'ADORA?!!?'

'What, Catra? I told them *not* to ask, didn't I?'

'Surely our *sophisticated* readership don't want to hear about us... makin' whoopee. They'd much rather hear about our plan, our friends, and the last few hours before our fight for freedom. You keep telling them we're going to win in the end. Well - it's time for us to prove it.'

Chapter Notes

Content warnings apply for the below chapter only - Spoilers may be present in the warnings. This story does not include any of the four Archive Warnings topics, but does occasionally feature other topics that may require content notes. This chapter is rated Mature for sexual references.

Chapter 60 Content Warnings (CONTAINS SPOILERS):
Exile - Narrated and in speech, present and ongoing, of major character, impacts main character
Relationship interference - In speech, present, of major character, impacts main character, offscreen
Gun - In speech, present, brief

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PART 13
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SECTION 10

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‘Adora! Eeeee!! You’re back! According to my calculations, there was a… 42.7% probability of that occurring. Science doesn’t care for our human emotions but I *am* happy that you’re back. Explaining your *peeeeerrrrmanent* absence from our timeline to Catra would have beeeeen… a… *suboptimal* event in my friendship with her. But! You appear to have ***found*** Catra instead. How *FASCINATING!!* Did you locate her inside the memory or another, deeper She-Raic dreamstate? Did Mara guide you? Or is Catra now *also* a She-Ra? Is the state of She-Radom transferrable by heightened emotional or… *physical* connection?’

Her fingers wrapped around mine, I felt my dear Meowmeow warm up ever so slightly. Was she? Yes – yes, she was. The boldly debonair starlet of my dreams was *blushing*. Colour flushed up her cheeks like oils impregnating a canvas. Gosh, how *I* wanted to impregnate *her*, were such a thing possibly with present medical technology. Alas, ‘tis currently not to be. But I’d keep my head up. One can never tell what the future might hold. That’s the scrumptious thing about it. Now my sweet Catra was back by my side, we had time. Tomorrow… and tomorrow… *and* tomorrow…

Oh, hang about! Scratch the Scottish play! This wasn't the time for a tragical climax. Other kinds of climax? Well. A gentlewoman never kisses and tells – but do remember the following facts. Number one: we'd been ripped apart for almost 48 hours by now. Number two: absence makes the heart grow fonder. Number three: the photos in the silver cigarette case make the heart grow throbbier still. Number four: Catra Applesauce Meowmeow is a distractingly attractive woman. Number five: Sir Adora de l'Horde is a very distractable fellow. And number six: it would positively unprofessional for the She-Ra to go into battle distracted.

And we wouldn't want that now, would we? Frankly, what we did in that forest clearing, then up against that sturdy tree, then at that exciting angle I'd never seen before is both none of your business and the eminently sensible thing to do in the situation. We shouldn't have to account for ourselves – this isn't a trial! I should know. This whole story started with me attending one.

What I *will* confess is that we'd lost track of the time. The sun had arced across the sky. Three hours had leapt out of the afternoon and time was running short. As Catra and I staggered back from whence we'd come, all eyes were very much on us. Our friends wanted an explanation. I could tell this from the way they looked at us: Swiftie winking; Perfuma bopping up and down on her dainty heels; Bow wide-eyed; Entrapta rapt; Scorpia cocking her head. They wanted to know what in the merry biscuits was occurring, and I was just the fellow for the task:

'Righty-ho, friend-a-roonies!' I began. 'Let's get the facts straight. Well. Not *straight*. Let's get the facts assorted flavours of queer, as it were. Though, yes, I did travel into a magical state and commune with a historic She-Ra called Mara, Catra was *not* there. She arrived through other, secret means from other, secret

locations. When her inimitable meowmeow appeared to me, I was overcome. I overcame. We had a lot to… *discuss*. That's why we took so long to head back here. But now we're back and ready to get this bold, brave, justice-driven, romantical show on the road. Any questions?'

Bow tentatively raised his hand. 'Adora – why are you covered in mud? Was there a lot of mud in the past?'

'No comment.'

Entrapta cocked her head at us. 'Soooo… just out of curiosity… the panting-screaming noises we heard in the forest approximately 27 minutes and 14 seconds ago… Were theeeeeeyyyyy---?'

'**No comment.** Does anyone have any actual *productive* questions about the plan we're about to make?'

'Ooh,' Perfuma exclaimed, swaying gently. 'I have a question. Catra, sweetie-pie, what's in the dress bag?'

My girlfriend smiled, devastatingly. 'A gown like you've never seen in your life.'

'Does that mean you're going to the Ball?' asked Scorpia.

‘Yes. But not the orthodox way. We’ll get to that shortly.’

Perfuma raised her hand. ‘Me again! Can I see the dress?? I didn’t know you wore ballgowns?! I bet it looks *dreamy*.’

‘Oh, it does.’ Catra smiled. ‘You’ll have to wait, though, just like everyone else. I don’t want to ruin the surprise.’

Next up was Swiftie. ‘Wait. Does that mean you’re *invited* to the Ball? After everything that’s happened? Err, Adora, did I miss something? When did Catra get an invitation and when did Glimmer, you know, become a good person?’

‘I’m not sure she’s a **bad** person necessarily---’ I started to reply.

Swiftie shook his head. ‘No, no. You’re right. She’s an ***AWFUL*** person.’

‘That’s maybe a… *bit* strong? I don’t like what she’s done to Catra – not one bit – and I can’t say I was too stoked to wake up handcuffed to her bed… this… morning…’

My words tailed off. It seemed to be what my audience wanted. There was a collective silence, you see, in which six jaws dropped and twelve eyes trained on me. A natural punctuation was

needed, so everyone could catch back up. One of them ummed, another erred. Catra squeezed my hand twice, tight, signalling something unclear but comforting. Far away, above the trees, a great tit tittered. I got the sense that it was time for me to speak again, before the situation could be completely misconstrued.

'What I mean to say,' I began, 'is that I slept in her bed, alongside her presumably, until such time as she woke me up. From her own recollections, I'd been a very chivalrous knight to her after last night's murder escapade and positively insisted on putting her to bed. Now, I don't remember that, but I *had* gulped down quite a few of those absinthe-heavy things Double-Trubel kept brewing. Anyhow, Glimmer tells me that it just made sense for me to stay the night… and there was only one bed… so there you go.'

Perfuma cocked her head and made a lengthy, considered, musical kind of sound. 'She-Ra? Honey? What happened next? Because the way you're telling it makes it sound awfully like you two had i-n-t-e-r-c-o-u-r---'

'Wuh?! Now hang on just a minute! I did no such thing. Not with Glimmer, anyhow.'

To my left, there was the soft but very certain sound of Catra burying her head in her spare hand. Oopsie-doopsie.

'If I might revise my prior statement,' I persevered, 'no gentlewoman of any great repute would ever besmirch the squeaky-clean reputation of her Lady. Of any Lady. But – for the record – I deny entering into… umm… "carnal relations" with

Glimmer. When it comes to my actual girlfriend, well, it's none of your business. Which is neither a confirmation nor the opposite. It is simply a statement of--- of--- my Sapphic fealty and loyalty and principles. Or some such. If my girlfriend wants to disclose any more, then that's up to her and her alone.'

'We fucked.' Catra deadpanned.

'Ohhhhhhhhhhhhhh,' Entrapta hummed, 'is *that* why you've got an invitation to the Midusmmer Ball now? The three of you finally put your tensions aside and got busy – as a tension resolution mechanism?'

'That's not what I meant be "we" – at all.'

'Then what *did* happen with the Countess? Adora, tell us, please. We just want to understand.'

If in that moment Lady P had possessed popcorn, I am entirely convinced that she would have started munching down on it. Nevertheless, I had committed to clearing up the situation and blue sky clarity was precisely what I intended to provide.

'To the best of my knowledge, we simply slept until fairly late this morning. I awoke to her laying next to me, quite chaste, in silky pyjamas. Of course, she did then clamber on top of me and let all those clothes fall off a bit. But it's not what it sounds like! I swear it didn't go any farther than that. And nor would it! Glimmer

offered me a polly-which-what set-up with her *and* Catra, but that's just not for me. I'm a one woman demi-woman – and Catra is the woman for me, maybe forever.'

Bow gasped. 'Oh my Horde, Adora. I was **trying** not to ask but I keep looking at it and looking at it and looking at it and--- and is that a **DIAMOND RING** in your pocket??'

'This? Yes, I suppose it is.'

There then exploded another, much noisier period of disruption to our little chitchat. Bow ran round in little circles. Entrapta made a squealing kind of sound. Reared up on his hind legs, Swift Wind couldn't stop smiling and congratulating us. Perfuma and Scorpia positively leapt into each other's arms and went round and around and around. Suffice to say, news of a Catradora engagement was rather well received. Our friends were bally ecstatic.

What a pity, then, that this wasn't a real proposal. I *wanted* to marry Catra – I knew that much already. You don't get literally physically sick with loneliness for just anybody, you know. Nor do you destroy a train for a mere passing fling. When I looked into those eyes, I felt something deep and soft and thrilling that I'd never experienced before. I felt *home*. So that's what I did then, surrounded by the pandemonium of misplaced excitement. I stared as deep into her gaze as she'd let me.

Her sapphire blue giggled at me, winking slightly, laughing at the misunderstanding but giddy at the joy so many people felt at ours. It was a look that said no, not today. We've only known each

other a few days. It's too early. But the liquid gold of her left eye? That told a very different tale. It looked straight into my heart and said *I want this too*. It told me to wait a little longer, but not too long. It sparkled with kisses on collarbones and breakfasts in bed, sun-speckled holidays and cuddles on cold, dark nights. It wanted eternity and a family. It said *Marry me*. And that's when I knew I would.

We *were* going to win in the end and our friends were going to help us, just as soon as they stopped running round in excited little loops. The afternoon was running away from us. I'd be expected back at Shugborough any time now. All of us who came down from the house would be. What we needed was a plan: one that got us away from the De l'Hordes, away from the Brightmoons and off into our happily ever after. Pronto. Everybody would play their part – if I could only get them to listen. Lucikly, a She-Ra has one failproof way to command a room. *For the Honour of Greyskull!*

The clearing dropped back into silence. Radiating power, compassion and a faint shade of blue, I motioned for them all to sit and listen. They did, on a nearby log, as it happens.

'I didn't propose. Catra and I aren't getting engaged – yet. Glimmer got down on one knee to me this morning and pushed this ring onto my finger. The Press was there, so it's a safe bet that news of our affiancing has hit the 'papers by now.'

'It has,' Catra confirmed, showing me the mid-day social pages.

‘That means my Aunt and Uncle will have seen it, if they haven’t learnt the news another way already. As you all know, the Duke and Duchess left Shugborough yesterday evening. They were going to London – to speak with my Aunt Shadowtha. I thought it was to tell her I’m the She-Ra but maybe they meant to announce my engagement… and my sexuality. I just don’t know. And I didn’t *want* them to do any of that.’

‘Wait,’ Perfuma gasped, the trees bending in towards her, ‘the Brightmoons ***outed*** you?? No. **No**!! I won’t take that, She-Ra. You deserve **SO MUCH** better. I thought Shugborough was giving me safety but--- but--- I can’t stay somewhere that people would do **THAT**. You’re my friend and I’m going to help you, whatever it takes.’

‘And me, obviously. I can’t speak *directly* for your Wrongcle or Emily, but I’m 87.26% certain they’ll also agree.’

Bow twitched his cheeks. ‘I still want to believe Glimmer can be better than this – that she **is** better than this – but the whole situation I’ve seen unfolding this weekend? It needs to end. You and Catra deserve respect. And arrows. Did I mention that I brought my arrows?’

‘You did. And good, thank you everyone. We’re going to need every last one of you to make this work. We’re balancing a lot of needs tonight, all of them equally important. As the She-Ra, I have a responsibility to cuddle-wuddle up to nature and protect the rubber duckies of the world from swirling around and around and around, forever shoved about to win us pretty little prizes but never able to reach those prizes themselves. Tonight the carnival comes down! Who’s with me?’

‘I am?’ asked Scorpy. ‘I think? Adora, gee, that was a beautiful speech you had there – very evocative – but do you think you could ever so slightly clarify what any of it meant?’

I looked at the beefcake belle with utter perplexion. As far as I could see, my evocations had been as clear as they come. I really wasn’t sure how else to put it. This, of course, is why one becomes girlfriends with the smartest woman one has ever met. Catra held me closer and clarified:

‘Adora wants to take her role as She-Ra seriously. After meeting Mara, she realised that Cannock Chase was fenced off by Prime the Conqueror for his personal use, then passed through generations of royalty. It was taken from the people who lived here once in harmony with nature. The local flora and fauna have been badly hurt too; the woods aren’t as wild as they used to be. Adora wants to change all that for the better, don’t you… *babe*?’

The word ricocheted through me like whiskey. I liked it. A lot.

‘Yes, *darling*, I do. And tonight is our best – maybe only – chance. While the Brightmoons and their staff are all distracted up at Shugborough, the She-Ra will help the local villagers take back Cannock Chase. For good. It’s going to be very dramatic.’

Scorpia nodded. ‘Okay. I get it completely now. Except… I still don’t. If you’re engaged to Glimmer, won’t she notice that you’re

not at the party? I'm pretty sure she will. **I'd** definitely notice if Perfuma wasn't there, you know?'

'I *do* know and that's why I'm absolutely going to be there. The "She-Ra" battling for the forest and its people won't be the actual She-Ra. With no-one to fight back against us, the She-Ra doesn't need to be anything more than a figurehead. So long as she can throw back her hair, wave her sword around and be a bit tall, she'll get the job done. She doesn't even need to talk – and it's actually quite important that she doesn't. I don't think Staffordshire's human inhabitants speak any Squirrel.'

'Oh!' Scorpy gasped. She's a smart duck, that one. She'd only gone and got it. 'You're going to use Emily!! Because she can look exactly like you, just like she pretended to be Kyle last night. You're copying the murder – and being in two places at once.'

'Exactly. Emily is the perfect accomplice---'

'Because of the machine gun mounted in her mouth.' Entrapta nodded.

'What?! **No!!** Don't use that! The whole idea is that reoccupation can be non-violent. No-one has to get hurt, nobody needs to die. After what I saw with Mara, I…'

I trailed off. Catra held me close, tight. She understood. If only Mara could have seen us. I still think about her, you know. Often.

I’ll never break my promise to her. I’ll keep fighting, until the kiddies like us can grow up into the safest, most loving tomorrow you can imagine. But I digress. After a discreet cry-hiccough, I threw myself back into the breach.

‘All Emily needs to do is look like me and ride on Swift Wind, so long as that’s okay with you, Swiftie?’

'APPLES FOR ALL!! THE STREETS WILL RUN RED WITH APPLEPEELS!’

‘I’ll take that as a yes. As for the whole talking business, I was going to ask Wrongcle to take first shift. He knows what’s what re. revolutions and I don’t think Glimmer knows who he is, so he won’t be missed at the house. After that, it’s Catra to the rescue.’

‘You’re missing the party?’ Perfuma gasped. ‘Aren’t you going to fight for your demi-woman?! Think of the romance!! It could be like a movie picture. Won’t you let it be like a movie picture???’

‘But of course. All in good time, Lady Plumers. Adora simply means that I’ve *organised* the next stage of the plan, not that I’ll be in the forest myself. I’ve stationed two very close friends in the villages around Cannock Chase, where they’ll gather the locals and share the plan. Later tonight, they can take over and let Wrongcle head to the Ball.’

Bow stepped forwards, flicking his slightly bearded chin. He was about to be **heroic**.

'No! **I** will take over from Wrongcle. My dads might be at the party, where they'll see I'm totally not in Cambridge. Then they'll the worst thing imaginable… they'll feel disappointed in me. I can't risk that – and I owe Adora so much. So I'll skip the party and lead the fight!'

Catra purred, her snaggletooth showing. 'An admirable sentiment, sir, but entirely unnecessary.' She slipped a letter from her pocket and passed it to Bow, who read it once, made a squeaking noise, then read it again. 'As you can see, your fathers entirely support your attendance at tonight's little shindig.'

'How… How did you do this??! I mean… Thank you! How? HOW?'

'I have my ways. Speaking of which---' Catra reached into her jacket pocket and pivoted to face me. She smiled even wider. I had no idea what was coming. '--- Sir Adora, may I present you with the undergraduate degree you ***earned***. Courtesy of the University of Oxford, I'm delighted to present you with a Second Class degree in Etherian Literature, conferred with Honours.'

My friends clapped and whooped. The world went a little blurry. I held the parchment in my hands. It was more precious than gold to me. Here it was. My achievement, recognised. All my hard work was rolled up in that script – and it was **enough**. The people who loved me – my *real* family – were here and they were proud of me.

‘You did all this… for me?’

‘This is only the beginning of what I’d do for you.’

‘Thank you, Catra.’

‘You can thank me later tonight, when we’ve got forever to enjoy it. Right now, we need to finish the plan. Okay, group. You know what’s happening here on the Chase. Do not share the details with **anybody**. That’s vital. As for the rest of you, you’ll be going to the party as normal. Have fun – and don’t intervene to help Adora before I reveal myself.’

Scorpy scrunched up her face. ‘You’re planning to hide? In *that* dress? Which is beautiful, by the way.’

‘Yes, I’ll arrive in disguise. You all need to treat me like a total stranger. As far as you’ll pretend to know, I’m just Princess Frosta’s eccentric date. Got it?’

The group nodded.

‘Good,’ said Catra. ‘My mask comes off the moment Glimmer pulls Adora to the front of the room for a speech.’

‘How do you know she’ll do that?’

‘I doubt Glimmer is going to pass up an opportunity to be the centre of attention – or to show Adora off.’

Bow nodded thoughtfully. ‘Hmm. That **does** sound like Glimmer. What do you want us to do then, when you’re revealed?’

‘Anything and everything you can to help us. I think we’re going to need it.’

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Chapter 61

Chapter Summary

'Sir? This newspaper "article" appears to contain a number of... mistruths. One is somewhat tacken aback that it was printed.'

'Quite right, Catra, but what's with the formality?'

'Witnessing the ways Countess Dryl tried to enshare you fills me an incandescent rage which borders on the homicidal, sir. To use my valet voice is to restrain my anger.'

'No need for that around me, wifey!! Curse away! As our readers are about to discover, Glimmer only went ahead and tried to spring a surprise wedding on me. I'd reckon that calls for pretty bally strong emotions.'

'As you wish, sir. To put it mildly, Glimmer is an absolute, sorry excuse for a steaming pile of---'

Chapter Notes

Content warnings apply for the below chapter only - Spoilers may be present in the warnings. This story does not include any of the four Archive Warnings topics, but does occasionally feature other topics that may require content notes.

Chapter 61 Content Warnings (CONTAINS SPOILERS):
Violent ideation - Narrated, present, by main character towards major character (no violence occurs)
Outing - Narrated, recent historic, of main character
Forced wedding - Narrated and in newspaper article, upcoming, of main character

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PART 13

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SECTION 11

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What's black and white and red all over? If you've just said "Glimmer in a distractingly decolletage-forward and floor-length gown" then, well, you're absolutely right. There she stood, atop the steps into Shugborough Hall, looking every inch the marzipan matriarch. The Queen of Hearts could hardly have seemed more saccharine – or much more utterly terrifying. Betwixt her painted lips stood a Cheshire cat smile that didn't *quite* meet her eyes. But I was rather more worried by the thing that she clutched between her chiselled fingernails.

It's a homophone, you see. Blast it… This would really work quite a lot better if we were chatting in person. No matter – we'll persevere nonetheless! Dear reader, I'm obliged to ask again, as I asked myself, *What's black and white and read all over?* Note the extra "a" I've inserted this time round. That's the crux of this schoolground joke. "Read" and "red" sound the same but have different meanings, you understand? Marvellous.

Now we've made it through the lexicographical chicanery of Glimmer's big opening, we can get back to the very thing she was

holding. It was a newspaper – the very thing that's re*a*d all over. This one was dated to that lunchtime. In other words, it was almost literally hot off the presses and its NEWS!! was about as BREAKING!! as any news has ever been. There, written in block capital leaders, shrieked the headline…

GLIM GLAM HORDE HITCH!!

'DORY!!! Whaddya fucking think?!? Ohmigosh! Take it in – take a look – we made THE MOTHERFUCKING COVER!! Ahhhhhhhhh! This is the best day of my LIFE! Eek! Just look at the picture they used of us two… I look so scrumptious – so ***cunty*** – like I could have been made for Schiaparelli – like a goddess of beauty and victory and *sex*. I'm SO jazz. Adora, don't you see it?! I'm soooooo fuckin' with it. I'm the bee's knees. I'm ***the*** hotsy-tots tot!! *And* my tit is out juuuuuuust enough to cause a scandal. IT'S PERFECT!!'

She stopped for a skidding, hacking breath. I tried to get a word in edgewise.

'Wh---?'

Naturally, I failed.

Glimmer's aspiration took but a section of second, before she plunged headlong back into her stream of screaming-ness.

‘Ahhhhh!’ she said. ‘AHHHHHHH!!! Look! ***LOOK CLOSER!!*** For fuck’s sake Adora, try to understand what’s going on here. *There’s* the picture of you – all muscles and chisel and chinbone and *hunkishness* – looking utterly *EXCELLENT* in that new outfit of yours. You know, the one with the skirty-shorty thing. The one that turns you into **the** coolest cat this side of Chicago.’

The image was grainy, but there was no mistaking it. There she was, covered in mud and glitter, trying to wrap her arms around me. And there *I* was, pupils terribly dilated, sword cane still glowing in my hands, Duke Brightmoon clapping me hard on the back. This was from the Village Fête. Which meant there’d been a photographer tailing us. Ergo, the national press had witnessed my fight with Call-me-Micah… and splashed She-Raic pictures across the front page. Hmm. The sword-cane saleswoman wasn’t going to like that…

Emotions knotted through my brain like tangled rope around a wavering pier. I’d barely knocked the mud off my boots and tonight was already getting complicated. Light Hope was going to find out and pull me back into the Art Deco abyss. The general public were going to start asking questions about who She-Ra was and what I was about to do about it. *The Horde Prime Minister – that immortal fellow who’d killed at least one She-Ra before – was going to come across this article in his daily briefing and… and… what… order my assassination?!*

‘Dory??!? Why are you smiling like that?! Are you okay?’ Glimmer asked. ‘Oh, duh, of course, you’re shocked. I am too, honestly. They only wanted to use ***two*** piddly little pages, but Daddy pulled a few strings and the editor gave us full coverage over pages one

through four!! Eeeek! Isn't that exciting?!? They've profiled the both of us… and covered *everything* about us at Oxford… and detailed every tiny little detail about our party tonight… Ooh! Ooh! The writer even got access for special interviews with Daddy, and Mummy, and your Auntie, and the Hord Akmiral---'

Her words tapered off beyond anything I could hear. My pulse was pounding through my brain. The Brightmoons were a curse, I swear it. Every last one of them. They'd outed me to my family. As queer. And as She-Ra. Worse, they'd wrested that control from me and pasted the result across the media for the whole world to see. And now Glimmer expected me to thank her. And… and… Fuck that. *Fuck her.*

The She-Raic fire was burning in my eyes, threatening a spontaneous transformation right there and then, fuelled by the fires of rage and a lifetime of aching, lonely pain. It clawed at me. The tears flowed fast, hot down my cheeks. For once – just this once – Lady Pearl Bonnibel Glimmer Luna Ami… something, maybe Amy? Extra Long Name Brightmoon, Countess Dryl, needed to see that there's such a thing as other people, and that her actions impacted other people's lives in ways that couldn't just be undone.

She… deserved to get what was coming to her.

My grip scrambled toward Ms. Floaty-Cane, letting her loose from her home at my hip. Her grip was snug in my hand. I was Saint George. Glimmer was the thoughtless, spiteful little dragon, spitting flame and acid across the landscape of my life, destroying everything her manicured talons touched. I wanted to raise the blade… to look her in the eyes… to bring the sword crashing

down, down through her skull, until this so-called-friend-slash-forced-fiancée of mine had been cleft entirely in twain. Which is an olde timey was of saying two.

I didn't, though. That wasn't in the plan – and I'd sworn to my real Lady, my love, my life, *my Catra*, that I'd stick to her dazzling scheme, come what may. As the hilt bit into my palm, begging to let fly, I forced my mind back to Catra's soft words and her cunning intellect, the glint of her sapphire and gold as she outlined the steps that would lead us to our freedom. I was on a reconnaissance mission. Everything we'd do tonight depended on what I uncovered now.

'Read!' Glimmer implored me, apparently oblivious of my deep, dark desire to turn her into mincemeat. 'Ohmigosh Dory! Read read read read ***read*** already!! Don't make it so that I yelled at the journalist for nothing. Or do you not *like* that I got him to write down every last detail of upcoming nuptials?!'

'No, Glimmer, I do,' I replied. I hadn't expected her to make this information-gathering gig quite so simple. Still, I'm not one to complain. If a job needs doing, it might as well be dashedly simple. I nodded, she made positive noises, then, for quite a while, neither of us said anything more. Smugly satisfied, Glimmer dangled the 'paper in front of me and lead me by the nose, winding us up the steps and along the passageways that wound, eventually, to her bedroom. I let her take me. *Remember, Sir Adora*, I told myself. *You're here to gather the facts, not feel your feelings. Not yet. There'll be time enough for that later*.

Rolling back my shoulders, I stuck on my stiff upper lip. To all but the most expert, heterochromatic gaze, I was shipshape and

Etherian proper. I played the role of the dashingly aristocratic affianced – and I played it *gallantly*. Glimmer lapped it up, cooing at my resolve and squeezing my muscles. She brought me – or, rather, her servants brought me – platters of eggs and snifters of brandy. I'd entirely paused my rage, which meant I finally had time to read the paper…

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GLIM GLAM HORDE HITCH

Brightmoon Heiress Wooed By de l'Horde Hunk – Wedding Bells Ring Tonight

Your Slice of Society Life – By Nathaniel Artemis, with extra reporting by Mrs. M. Artemis

STAFFORDSHIRE, ENGLAND *Big news this morning from Society's biggest personality, Countess Dryl. Glimmer 'Sparkles' Brightmoon – heir to the Brightmoon Duchy and notorious gal about town – has cooled her wicked ways and settled down with a shock engagement to university pal and fellow aristo 'Sir' Adora de l'Horde, Earl Scorkin and future Marquess Frighte. Announcing their engagement with a pair of darling cushion-cut diamond rings on 24 carat gold bands, the happy couple exclusively told this reporter:*
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"This is aristocracy for a new age – the Jazz Age. Forget the stuffy conventions and dry dinner parties of our parents and our parents' parents, where [****] like lineage and land deeds meant everything. This is a marriage of LOVE! Sure, it doesn't ***hurt*** *that we're uniting one of the most noble Hordian houses in the country with perhaps our foremost military family, but the real reason to go through with all this is simple… We fancy the pants off each other!"*

But did the course of true love ever run smooth? Countess Dryl revealed it did not. Though she and her spouse-to-be met at their Oxford college, where the Brightmoon heir studied Art History and the de l'Horde doyen pursued a mixed programme of Etherian Literature and Mathematics, the two barely registered the importance of their first meeting.

"It all started at a College Ball," says Countess Dryl. "Our eyes met across the room and that should have been that. We shared a dance, then a kiss, then a long goodnight… but neither of us imagined it would ever become anything more. I was too caught up in the dazzling lights of London's nightlife – your regular readers all know Go-Go Glimmer! – and Adora was too obsessed with that infernal sports car of theirs. That's right, we're both wild young things!"

Only this year have the pair realised the errors of their tearaway terrors and reconciled their deeper feelings. After five years as friends, ranging regularly across the London, Paris and Italian Riviera scenes, it slowly dawned on our caliente couple that maybe, just maybe, their handholding wasn't all that chaste. Cupid had sent them a collect call and, at last, these noble numbers were ready to neck. As the timorous twenties turned into the flirty thirties, love was in the air.

"It was New Year's Eve when I finally got the message," Earl Scorkin sighs, laughing easily at their earlier tomfoolery, "Glimmer got up on tiptoes, right under the mistletoe and just winked in my direction. It sent a shiver down my spine – and instantly steeled my resolve. Enough of being a cad about town! My studies were done, my military service awaited, and it was time to get myself a wife. The second I kissed her, as the clock struck midnight, I knew it had to be her."

Dating started slow, with languid dinners at The Ritz and long weekends at the pair's numerous country estates, before the couple finally broke into the open on 4th July, at this year's Henley Regatta. A remarkable rower – once called The Pride of Oxford, for winning the Boat Race in their first year at the famous university – 'Sir' Adora caught eyes and sighs for the majesty with which they propelled their beloved down the Thames.

There was just one problem: the boat, provided by an unscrupulous local, began to sink from under them. Undeterred, Earl Scorkin scooped up the fashionably curvaceous Glimmer in their sport-strengthened arms and saved her from the threats of the briny deep. Not satisfied with a daring rescue, and under the dazzle of a dozen press photographers, 'Sir' Adora then hopped to their feet and rushed Lady Brightmoon straight to her train. What a knight for our benighted age! As the watching girlies swooned, and less fantastic fellows vented their envy, Glimmer strengthened their resolve. This couple ***would*** *be wed, whatever it takes.*

Enter your intrepid reporter, invited to Shugborough Hall this very morning to bear witness to the dazzling proposal. Truth be told, we'd been in the region for several days – witness our headline

pictures of the happy couple canoodling at Shugborough's famed summer fête – but it was still a thrill to step inside this illustrious 18th century mansion. There, on what can only be described as a luxurious indoor veranda, the happy couple took turns to go down on one knee and declare their eternal love.

It was an honour to be present – to bear witness – to see this sheer force of nature take shape. For, just as soon as rings were on fingers, Earl Scorkin and Countess Dryl raced off to attend to vital planning of their immediate nuptials. That's right, folks! After turning affianced this very morning, these love-struck lambs are flying through the world's most whirlwind engagement to get married tonight… on the stroke of twelve.

The drama continues with the venue. Marrying at home might sound fusty to you, but Lady Glimmer has a terrific twist up her sleeve. Tonight is the Brightmoon family's famed Midsummer Ball – this year titled 'A Midsummer Night's Scream' – where attendees will sway to the salacious swing stylings of 'Double' Trubel and gasp at the near-magical detective skills of none other than London's Detective Whirlpool Mermot. Guests are set to include celebrity gardener Lady P. Plumers, up-and-coming stage star Kyle Nieman and fellow it-girl Princess Frosta.

The great and good scarcely come bigger or better, yet they'll all have to step aside when the lucky couple sweeps into the Drawing Room to take their vows… right there on the dancefloor, while the jazz band swings on. So modish! Countess Dryl is set to wear a cascading, bespoke pearlescent number by her adored Elsa Schiaparelli, while Earl Scorkin will cut a dash in a Savile Row dinner suit of pure white satin silk. Food is by Fortnum & Mason. Drinks are the fanciest Bollinger, Dom and Krug. Dancing is set to continue until sunrise.

Watching on will be their respective parents and guardians, travelling down by Rolls-Royce as we speak. Said Duchess Brightmoon, 'A. de l'Horde, Earl Scorkin, boats depths far beyond the ordinary. Though the de l'Horde rank may fall beneath our own, I fully support my daughter's right to choose a love match. In fact, I'm pleased. It is far better have Earl Scorkin's strengths within than outside the Brightmoon family." Fellow matriarch, Marchioness Frighte, agreed: "I have dedicated my entire life to instilling in Adora a sense of duty, especially to her betters. Though the unusual particulars of her marriage are a surprise, I have decided to overlook them in favour of celebrating the long-desired connection between Houses Brightmoon and de l'Horde. I trust that both families shall rejoice tonight."

The High Hord Akmiral of His Prime's Navy, 'Sir' Adora's other living relative, continued: 'I am tremendously proud of Adora. They have repaid my trust in them handsomely, and have, at last, done enough to earn an enduring place at the de l'Horde table. Their strength shall be our future." Gushing stuff! Duke Brightmoon, famed fencer and equestrian, kept it simpler: "Adora?! Cracking chap! Great on a horse. And have you seen their duelling skills? Phwoar!!"

Phwoar indeed! This hotshot hunk was last spied in the duelling ring at Shugborough Summer Fête, where 'Sir' Adora engaged in a spirited faux-fight with Duke Brightmoon himself. There were laughs and smiles all round as Earl Scorkin appeared to swell to several feet taller their usual height, seemingly glowing with blueish light as their muscles flexed and pumped. A firm fan of showmanship, Adora swirled their two-handed blade overhead as they and Duke Brightmoon play-acted through a scene from ancient myth, where King Arthur battles the miserly King John.

*But was this **really** just a display from a children's story? This journalist had his doubts. Luckily, Countess Dryl herself today agreed to set the record straight: "Adora has always been a knight but – just recently – they've upgraded into a true, blue Arthurian figure. It's form of magic, though – of course – she's always been magical to me. I guess now everyone can see it! Earl Scorkin is the She-King-Arth-Ra." In other words, you're looking at the resurrection of King Arthur.*

What a legendary catch! And what a wedding! Intrigued? Well, our reporting doesn't stop there. Your trusted society correspondent – moi, Nathaniel Artemis – shall be present at Shugborough Hall tonight to report on all the nuptials, all the naughtiness, and every last shimmering, Glimmering detail of a night for the ages. We wish the Countess and Earl all the best of luck – here's hoping the Dream Works!

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'So – whaddya think?!' Glimmer gasped. 'I told them to title it "Glim's Glam Bitch Hitch" but *apparently* there are decency laws or whatever. It's a great piece, though, right?! Makes you sound like a dreamboat, which is one-hundo per-cent accurate. And yes, we ***are*** getting married tonight. It'll be a proper whirlwind wedding, a tiny affair with just 300 guests and a seven-course meal. Ah! Isn't it SO romantic?!?'

I gawped at Glimmer like a particularly befuddled goldfish. I knew she was brazen. I understood that she adored attention and would do anything to get it. But a surprise wedding? That was
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self-obsessed showmanship beyond what even Catra had accounted for. We had to act fast and revise our plans priorities. My liberty – heck, the shape of the rest of my life – depended on it. I'd get the news to Bow and his crew straight away… just as soon as Glimmer had helped me into this white silk suit she'd acquired. If I was going to run the risk of being kidnapped-slash-married, at least I'd get to look good doing it.

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Meowmeow: The Final Chapters. Part 1 - Adora vs. Light Hope

Chapter Summary

'Mind your manners this chapter, Reader-Doodles. Or have manners in your mind. Or somesuch. Catra, what am I trying to say?'

'That this is the end, sir. And we won.'

'Quite right! As my wonderful wife just implied, our tale is winding up to its epic conclusion. Bear witness as I fight my greatest and most grating foes, one by one by one. First into the ring? A certain Madam Light Hope.'

Chapter Notes

Heeyyyyy!! I'm back! And it's time for the final, final chapters of this epic She-Ra epic. I'm so flattered if you're still reading - and I'd love to hear from you in the comments xx

Content warnings apply for the below chapter only - Spoilers may be present in the warnings. This story does not include any of the four Archive Warnings topics, but does occasionally feature other topics that may require content notes.

Chapter 62 Content Warnings (CONTAINS SPOILERS):
Coercive control / manipulation - In speech, present, extensive, by multiple characters toward Adora
Possessiveness - In speech and narrated, present, extensive
Threat - In speech, present, toward Adora
Death - In speech reported, historic, minor character
Physical violence - Narrated, present, magical toward Adora
Murderous ideation - In speech, present, no murder occurs in chapter

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MEOWMEOW: THE FINAL CHAPTERS

1 of 4

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Here it was, unignorable, like a wet horse in your living room. The night in question. *A Midsummer Night's Scream*. The sun ducked low toward the treetops, its oily orange splaying across the rivers of Double-Trubellian consternation. Willows whispered at the bench where Lady P rushed to my aid. Far, far away, 'cross field and forest, wind presumably whistled through the Bentley-shaped mail slot I'd left in the local post office. Who's to say? I wasn't there. Oh no. I was *here*.

And where, precisely, was this nebulous "here" of which I speak? Well, it wasn't back in the Big Smoke, I'll tell you that much. Nor was it in the arms of my dear Meowmeow. Per my previous missives, the gentlewoman's gentlewoman found herself about as far away from my tender embrace as it's possible to get, thematically speaking. She was hiding her identity, you see, as she quickstepped and foxtrotted her way across the dance floor. She'd employed this most cunning of technologies called a "mask" or, for the more Francophile amongst our number, a "masque", as in "masquerade". It concealed her face really rather effectively.

Her tail? Not so much. Still, who am I to question the methods of a master valet-turned-girlfriend? Catra was the only fellowette *I*
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knew with a tail, but Glimmer might very well have invited other thus-appendaged individuals to her party, one supposed. I really ought to have asked her – for *intelligence* reasons. You know, like a spy.

It must be said, though, that espionage agents are generally better at escaping situations than I was. You see, I'd popped out for a cigarette some thirty minutes ago now, neglecting to remember to remember three very salient facts in the process. First off, I'd never huffed or puffed the beautiful 'baccy in my entire life. Secondly, the Countess Dryl is never without her smoke sticks. And, third and finally, she'd spent the last five years trying to convince me to try one.

Ergo, that fatal halved hour ago, as the party preparations reached their zenith, I cried off for a smoke… and Glimmer came with me. *It was an excellent idea*, she said. *Why, the wheeze was positively precocious!* By avoiding the start of "our" party, "we" could pull off the ultimate exemplar of arriving fashionably late. All the 'papers would talk about it, apparently.

So that's how, as the windows started to glow and D.T. began shouting at their band, I found myself lapping the Shugborough Hall gardens with my betrothed. There was the ruined rose garden; there was the still-smouldering crater from my little aeroplane-throwing excursion. *Here* was the wrong eternity.

'You're going to **love** being married to me, Adora,' said Glimmer. 'You **have** to be – or else!! I'll get you the fastest cars, the finest champagne, the most gourmet meals, the highest fashion. Yes! YES!! Ohmigosh, it's gonna be a twenty-four-fuckin'-seven carnival for just the two of us!! Shugborough will be your *everything*.'

I shuddered.

'Yes…' I ventured. 'That's certainly *something*.'

'Isn't it *just?!?*'

She squeezed my arm so tight her scent infused itself into my jacket sleeve. There'd be no getting that out. I was marked – as hers. And hers alone. We rounded the She-Raic rock and its long, looooonnnng shadow cast a chill into my very soul. The rainbows had stopped cascading. Ms. Floaty-C spoke not to me, not least because she was presently ensconced in Emily's metallic embrace. In her place, there was only an icy blue… and the call of that damned cane saleswoman.

'*Adddooorrrrrraaa… Adorrrrraaaa!!*'

'Can't you see I'm busy?' I brain-cried back. Or however this whole thing worked. I was back in the void that might be the inside of my head, anyhow. 'Excuse my language but I've got bigger problems than your balderdash to deal with right now! So… buzz off!!'

'*Addddorrrrrraaaa… You have to leeeeeetttt gooooooooo…*'

‘What? The same way you made Mara let go of Razz? The way that got her killed when she could have been picking berries? Which – *by* the way – sounded like a really nice Lesbian date. That ***you*** interrupted – forever!!’

A bright and blinding white flashed through me. Well, *that* was new. The whole transformation thingamy whirled by with a fresh intensity, no sword required. I grew into new muscles – muscles *on* muscles. And I had a **much** niftier headpiece. Very nice it was too. Reminiscent of the Catra, in fact. Alas, its chunky *je ne sais quoi* wouldn’t keep my attention for long. My hands made sure of that.

On my right, there appeared a ring as stunning as it was singular. Twirly-whirling up and over itself, the strands of its glittering structure held a pair of gemstones. One sapphire. The other citrine. And, well, it doesn’t take an expert to figure out just whom they were meant to represent. The fact they were glittering from the third finger on my left hand held a pretty obvious meaning of its own. *I was meant to marry Catra* – even the mysterious forces of She-Ra knew it!!

Well, thundering magical rainbows and the bright white light you call your best buddy, you could count on Sir Adora! I *would* marry her – even if it was the last thing I ever did. Given the way Light Hope was snarling, it very well might be. She saw the ring and lunged at it, screaming hard enough to curdle my blood.

‘*Addddorrrrrraaaa. Adorrrraaaaaa,* ***no!!*** *You will* ***NOT*** *make her mistake. I forbid it. Etheria has called you for more – more than this perverted love for an ordinary woman.*’

‘Catra is **anything** but ordinary.’

‘*She’s low born. She holds no special power or position. There is nothing in her you can use to advance Etheria and its goals. Adddoorrrrrraa!! Turn to Glimmer. Glimmer is the one who can give us--- give **you** everything. You must! You were called! Smite our foes – and bring Etheria back to its Eternal Triumph.*’

‘*There* it is!!’ I laughed. ‘You can’t even pretend like you care about people. It’s all Etheria this, Etheria that.’

‘*Only Etheria matters*.’

‘Pfft. Fascist much? I **don’t** play those games, Light Hope.’

‘*There is no choice. Our people suffer – the trappings of the invader must be purged – at **any** cost. Etheria must be made pure.*’

‘And how are you planning on doing that? Are you going to sacrifice me – like you did Mara?’

Light Hope glitched, her face banding horizontally, its blues guttering into ghostly greys. Radio static clamoured at the air, so loud that my ears screamed. She was on me now, her arms

plunging ice cold into my own. Shadows engulfed the ring. It burned, searing unfathomable chills through my very bones. Light Hope looked up at me, somewhere between snarling and tears. Her eyes were red and darkening by the second.

'*She was never meant to die. She wouldn't **LISTEN**. I had a plan. I had a plan… for us. And she had to go and ruin it… for the sake of **that** woman.*'

'*That woman* was her **wife**.'

'*I miscalculated the depth of her misplaced affections. Etheria suffered for my mistake. **I** suffered. I have been suffering every day since. But I will not repeat my error. Adora, you will cast Catra aside and embrace Glimmer, to use her power and reshape Etheria. That is an **order**.'*

'Haven't you heard? I don't take orders any more.'

In her rush to censor my relationship, Light Hope had wholly ignored what was going on my right hand. Oh, but I hadn't. What was first a blur had progressed, first to a flame, then to a golden outline and now, finally and only now, into my thrusty right-hand woman. Ms. Floaty-C flashed into my grip and it was *on*. One slash cut the shadows from the arm. A pulse of light came next, knocking Light Hope off balance, but still my opponent clung on. Her grip cut deeper and we started falling down, *down* into an eternal void.

‘Swift Wind!’ I shouted. ‘Swiftie, buddy, I know you can hear me. So how’s about we show this tyrant what a *real* team looks like?!’

‘You got it, Adora! Ghostly mind horse, attack!!’

Swiftie swept down-up-sideways into view, some kind of magical rope dangling from his muzzle. Spinning and sparkling, he wrapped it tight round our foe and squuueeeeeeezzed. Light Hope stared up at me, her eyes frantically searching, diamonds fluttering away from her form. I smirked back at her, one eyebrow lofted high into my forehead’s sky.

‘And *that’s* how we do it in Adoratown.’

‘No. **No**. How--- How?? It’s impossible – you can **not** have had a plan for this.’

‘We *never* do.’ I said. It wasn’t meant to sound like a brag – or maybe it was? ‘Swiftie, get her out of here.’

‘Got it. You want me to kill her, right?’

‘Not *really*... I just need her to go away to some place I’ll never ever see her again.’

‘*Mm-hmm.*’ Swiftie nodded. And possibly winked. ‘I’ll take her *away*.’

He flapped his wings twice and the rope went taut, jerking Light Hope off my arm and into the sky. The void dissipated. In its place, an orchard of apple trees swam into view. Swift Wind knew where he was going.

‘No. No no!! **NO MURDER!**’ I cried after him.

‘O-kay Adora! Swift Wind and Light Hope! Off on adventure! Gonna ask some questions! Then “not” do a mur-der!!’

He galloped off into the evaporating distance. I went after him but the forest was evaporating, step by step, until I stood on the edge of a jet black precipice. The world behind me was collapsing. The future up ahead was a sharp and shadowy bundle of unknowns. But I couldn’t stay here, perched on the perilous ledge where I’d found myself. I had two options. I could fall back into the clutches of the past. Or I could jump. Like that was even a choice. I’d come too far to turn back now. I closed my eyes, thought of Catra… and leapt feet first into the unknown.

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Meowmeow: The Final Chapters. Part 2 - Adora vs. Glimmer

Chapter Summary

'Did I stab Glimmer? No, your honour, I did not. Quite the opposite! What you've got here is Sir Adora and her softest and most emotionally articulate, sitting on a hillock and talking it all out, hoping for some full and frank apologies.'

'Was that successful, sir?'

'Ah... well. It could've gone better, in all honesty.'

Chapter Notes

Heeyyyyy!! Three to go... and it's time for Glimmer to feel feelings. I'm so flattered if you're still reading - and I'd love to hear from you in the comments xx

Content warnings apply for the below chapter only - Spoilers may be present in the warnings. This story does not include any of the four Archive Warnings topics, but does occasionally feature other topics that may require content notes.

Chapter 63 Content Warnings (CONTAINS SPOILERS):
Class hatred - Extensive, toward working class / Catra

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The fall was endless. I couldn't tell you when it stopped, only that it did. My head thumped. An oozing tang ricocheted against the back of my throat. I coughed slowly, then suddenly, jerking awake into the orange glow of the Shugborough evening. A face peered back at me from the pale shadows and a dreadful certainty came over me. Tonight would be no victory lap. As Hercules beheld his labours, so Sir Adora de la Surname Pending had a raft of foes to defeat this cursed night. Light Hope had only been the beginning. Next up was---

'Glimmer.'

'Ohmifuckingosh Adora, yes, it's me!! Do you know how much of a shitting *fright* you gave me? We were taking this romantic little walk around the gardens – you were professing your undying love to me – and then, **boom**, you fell over into a coma or something. That was so fucking RUDE!! Could you, I dunno, maybe ***warn*** a girl next time?!'

'I'm sorry,' I replied. Yes, I was about to pitch battle against her, but that was no reason to be impolite. Hauling my head out of her lap, I smoothed back my hair and removed my jacket. Laid down by my side, it made for the perfect picnic rug. I gestured for Countess Dryl to sit.

'Dory!! Do you have **any** idea how ***fucking*** much that tux cost me??'
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‘It can’t be worth more than this moment.’

On reflection, this might have sounded romantic. Glimmer certainly took it that way. That was… regrettable. And definitely unintended. All the heat fell out of her. She checked my temperature, bowed to me a little, then, ever so gradually, pulled her thoughts into an honest-to-Horde apology for her reaction just then. She wanted to know I was alright and she hadn’t meant to react that way. She was *trying*. And, yes, if her beloved so desired, she would sit on the suit jacket. As she dropped to her knees and pivoted onto her white silk seat, I tried desperately to cool the situation, courtesy of the least amorous picnic known to man.

‘Here,’ I said, reaching into my trouser pocket, ‘a hard-boiled egg. For you. I picked it up at breakfast.’

Glimmer wrinkled her nose. To my surprise, she plucked it out of my hand. Were that not shocking enough, she proceeded to knock the fluff off its outer layer and pop the blasted thing into her mouth whole.

‘Mmmmmmm,’ she trilled. ‘I can see why you like these.’

‘No you can’t!’

She laughed. ‘No, no, you’re right. I can’t. Not *at* all. Adora, why don’t you just eat *normal* food, like quail or caviar?’

‘Because I like eggs.’

‘Even when they’re like *this?!*’

‘Especially when they’re like this.’

‘***That*** is an objectively wrong opinion.’

‘You can’t control what a person likes… or who they like.’

‘I know,’ she said, after a long silence. ‘*I know*.’

‘Then why do you keep trying to get rid of Catra?’

Glimmer looked into the distance, her hair dancing in the pollen-sweet breeze. There were tears in her eyes.

‘Because *I* love *you*. Shouldn’t that count for something? I’ve loved you since the first time I met you.’

‘At the college party? *Really?*’

‘Yes, really! There was just something so real about the way you pledged yourself to me. It made me feel so… **fuck!!** It made me feel *complete*. I never had any real friends growing up, let alone people I wanted to spend my life with, so the idea of my very own knight in shining armour was just… intoxicating. Don’t say you didn’t feel it too?’

‘I mean… I liked you, Glimmer, I did. Sure, you were a little overbearing sometimes, but we had fun together. We were friends – mostly – until I came up to Shugborough.’

‘Which is when you finally realised we were meant to be lovers?’

‘What?! No. The opposite of that! Glimmer, the way you’ve acted this week has been unacceptable. I don’t want to be friends with you if you’re going to be like this – and I definitely don’t want to *marry* you!!’

‘Oh-ho! I see how it is… Sir Adora gets her first taste of heavy petting and suddenly she can’t think straight.’

‘I’m not sure any of the people involved here have ever thought *straight* per se…’

‘You know what I meant!! You’re throwing your life away for a *servant* – even after I offered to give her the gardener’s cottage or whatever! You can fuck her on the side, Adora, I’m ***okay*** with that---’

‘Are you?’

‘*Yes*,’ said Glimmer, in a way that suggested that no, she very much was not, ‘so long as you come back to me each and every night. This isn’t a fairy tale, Adora, where you can just run away into your wet dream fantasy. You *have* to see that you matter *SO* ***FUCKING*** *MUCH* – and that you’ve got a future in the aristocracy. You can’t turn your back on that. You belong here. You *belong* with me.’

‘I don’t.’

‘Err, we’re engaged, dipshit.’

‘I’m going home to Catra.’

‘Fuck! Adora, do you even hear yourself? You’ve known her since ***Tuesday***… and now, what, you want to leave your whole life behind for her?’

‘That about sums it up, yes.’

‘You don’t even *know* her – not like I know you.’

‘There are things I’ve told her that I’ve never revealed to anyone. Glimmer, she’s different. She’s special.’

‘She’s a violent thief and, oh, get this, Daddy says her papers don’t even check out. She could be *anybody*. Even her name is a lie.’

My eyes flashed. I felt Ms. Floaty-C snap into my hand. ‘You take that back. **Now**.’

‘I--- Fuck. I’m sorry, okay?! I went too far. I know---’ She made a sick hacking kind of sound. The next few words seemed to cause her genuine physical harm. ‘I know that she’s a good person, really. I’ve heard enough of what she’s been doing around Shugborough to know that… I was wrong. She’s already almost indispensable to half the people here. And she’s not too hard on the eyes either.’

‘Are you *jealous* of her?’

‘Have you ***seen*** her figure?!’

‘Many times, yes.’

I'd swear she blushed a little at that. 'I just… I can tell a smart and beautiful woman when I meet one, okay?'

My voice quavered. '*I love her, Glimmer*.'

Glimmer sagged, pulling me into her arms. 'I know you think you do. And I'm not saying you shouldn't have any kind of a relationship. She likes cars, right? She can be our chauffeuse. Fuck it, I'll **give** her my Duesenberg and she can drive around having a great time. She can be safe and happy here too and, yes, you two can have your special time every now and then. Just like Auntie Cass and her girlfriend. But you can't ***marry*** her!! You're meant to marry me. Here. Tonight. And I *promise*, just as soon as we come back from our honeymoon, we'll go down to London and get her. Deal?'

It wasn't everything – but it was progress. Every happy ending has to have its beginning, I guess. For a moment there, I almost wanted to believe that we were heading toward that kind of finish, where Glimmer tearfully apologised for all her wrongs and pledged to steadily become a better person. Give it a week, a month, a year and this wedding nonsense would all be forgotten. She'd whoop when Catra and I walked down the aisle and then, yes, maybe my real wife and I would come settle down on this gay old estate.

Okay, I might have been getting ahead of myself there. But some of the above did go ahead and happen – immediately. Glimmer hauled us to our feet and hugged me deep, the sensation of reconciliation blossoming between us. She apologised again and

again, the tears curling down her cheeks, hoping I could find it in my heart to one day forgive her. She'd give Catra money. She'd give her land. Hell, if her mother consented, she'd try to find Catra an aristocratic title of her own. She wanted tonight to be a happy night. I held her until the crying stopped.

'Let's go back to the house.'

'I'd like that, Adora. We don't want to miss the ***whole*** party.'

'No we don't.'

'We *really* don't – not after I paid the local church so much to transport its altar.'

'Sorry, what?'

'For our wedding, silly! We're still getting married tonight, remember?'

Oh. Drat.

I'd really thought she'd given up on that. But no. For the next three hours we swept across the terrace and the Red Drawing Room alike, waltz giving way to Charleston before settling into a

damnably sultry tango, Glimmer stopping wherever she could to show me off. *We were getting married at midnight, didn't they know?? Wasn't it totally exciting??* She glittered like diamonds; I felt like death. And through it all, the faces were watching, watching. There was Call-me-Micah, beaming his approval, next to the cold inscrutability of his wife. As for Aunt Shadowtha? She'd someone found a way to look disgusted and greedily satisfied, all at once.

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Meowmeow: The Final Chapters. Part 3 - Adora vs. the de l'Hordes

Chapter Summary

'Things are hotting up in Shugborough Hall - where we lay the scene for our penultimate chapter-oo. I stand on the dancefloor - filled with dread and about to wed. Catra is still nowhere to be seen. Aunts and Uncles and aristocrats and Glimmer are all closing in on me. They're burning up, they're so desperate to see me get married. Why, the situation is a powderkeg. And you know what they say about gunpowder - it only needs one spark to blow.'

'Hey, Adora. How can I be of assistance?'

Chapter Notes

Anyone still reading? You have my heart and my gratitude! I know this was a looooooooooong story..... but we're almost at the end!!

Content warnings apply for the below chapter only - Spoilers may be present in the warnings. This story does not include any of the four Archive Warnings topics, but does occasionally feature other topics that may require content notes.

Chapter 64 Content Warnings (CONTAINS SPOILERS):
Unarmed strike - Narrated, present
Gun - Narrated, present, fired
Shooting - Narrated, present, no injuries caused
Homohobia - In speech, present, extensive
Transphobia - In speech, present, includes misgendering
Fire - Narrated and in speech, present, extensive
Parental abuse, physical, emotional and financial - In speech, present, extensive
Threat of violence/murder - In speech, present, implied
Class hatred - Extensive, toward working class / Catra

See the end of the chapter for more notes

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MEOWMEOW: THE FINAL CHAPTERS

3 of 4

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‘*Queerly* beloved, we are gathered here tonight--- *some of us more so than others*. I mean, really, who wears ***pearls*** to a secret wedding? YUCK. The humanity of it. Where’s the drama? Whither the *occasion?* What’s that, Glim-Glam? Yes. Urgh. I get it. You’re marrying her for their muscles. That’s not surprising, baby – I know your tastes better than you think. Honestly, everybody, you ought to hear about the night Sparkles here met the Hereford women’s rugby team. I mean… Ow! Ouch! Quit it!!’

Glimmer rushed the stage and flicked Double-Trubel on the temple. *Hard*.

‘Do the ceremony **properly!!**’ she screamed. ‘We don’t have all **FUCKING** night, cuz, so hurry up and get me and Adora wed. *NOW!!* Or do you want everyone here to know what *really* happened to that Turner portrait??’

Double-Trubel adjusted their smock. What with its bustier and the thigh-high leg slit, I was beginning to suspect it wasn't a regulation Church of England garment. That's before we get started on the rainbow of sequins draped around their neck. They glistened as D.T. cocked their head and smiled as sweetly as their personality let them.

'O-kay. You got me. *Neither* of us want those kinds of secrets to come out, now, do we?'

'No. We don't.'

'So get your couture-clad curves back down there and marry your Prince in grass-stained armour, sweetie. We're restarting this whole deal in one hundred, ninety-nine, ninety-eight---'

'Fuck. Cuz. Can't it be in, like, *ten* seconds, maybe?!'

'Ew. ***No****. Sparkles*, we need to rebuild the drama… so… everyone… talk amongst yourselves. I'm getting a martini or three.'

The room murmured. My heart beat hard enough to make my ears sick. Faces swam around me, some familiar, some new. There was joy and anguish and fear and Entrapta, who had abandoned all of this wedding business to examine the finger foods. Well. I'm glad *one* of our team could stay calm. The rest of our clandestine clan were biting their pincers or pulling at their dresses, scanning

exits or… wait… were those Bow's dads?! Did Bow *know* his fathers were here? Oh. Giddy goodness, they were coming over here. Quick, Adora, think of a lie, fast.

'Bowregard has started a new life as a foreign country, sirs. I haven't seen him. I don't--- Who even is Bow? Do you have a son?'

'We have several, as you know,' smiled George.

Lance nodded. 'And we love them all equally… even if they don't want to be renowned First Ones scholars. Maybe some of them would prefer a more hand-on career, like Bow.'

'How do you---? I mean. Who's Bow??'

'You don't need to do that, Adora. We know Bowregard has been here with his friends, apprenticing with *quite* the distinguished mechanical engineer. Somebody very special told us all about it – and suggested we might want to be here tonight.'

George smiled with inscrutable meaning. Thank Horde for Lance and his discernible emotions. Bouncing like a bunny-wunny, he checked Glimmer wasn't too close, ducked in by my cheek and whispered… 'We *really* like your girlfriend. She's just a wonderful fit for you!'

‘We would like to offer our spare rooms for the start of your “honeymoon” together,’ George added. ‘Your new life begins here, Adora. It gets better.’

‘But what about you-know-who? Where is she? I’ve looked round-and-around the crowd and she just isn’t here. *Please*, tell me she hasn’t given up on me.’

Lance gasped. ‘She would *never!!* Trust your woman! When you’ve met… *the one*---’ Lance grabbed his husband by the shoulders and squeezed. ‘---you don’t ***ever*** let go.’

‘Your girlfriend is a formidable lady,’ George nodded. ‘Don’t doubt her.’

‘Do you know the plan?’ I hissed. ‘If there even *is* a plan?!’

It was no use. They were off.

‘Goodbye, Adora! Try to enjoy the big night – you’re just having pre-wedding jitters. It’s all gonna work out, we promise…’

And then they were gone. In their place stood my most elusive figure in our entire sordid tale – my uncle.

‘Cadet, I am well-pleased. Do not be afraid – your gender and sexuality are of no consequence to me. You were instructed to raise up the de l’Horde name and you have succeeded ***mightily***. I am *very* impressed, Adora. No… greater affection is required. *Earl* de l’Horde, you have made your family **proud**. Continue like this and you shall make a fine family man and a *great* nobleman, supported by my wealth and my name.’

He nodded, once, the flick of his chin imbued with centuries of ancestral meaning. A lump caught in my throat. Even a week ago, this would’ve meant the world to me. But that was another life, one where duty was my purpose and the two rings being pressed into my palm were the only future that lay before me. The Hord High Akmiral bowed, then departed, leaving me to stare at my ancient, inherited wedding band and a brand new de l’Horde signet ring.

Family above all.

There was silence, then music, then mumbling, then more silence. Double-Trubel swung their hips to the front of the stage, slurring quite a bit more than before.

‘Thwweeeeee… twoooooo… wwooooonnnnee… *hic*. Al*right*, let’s do this thing. Ah-hum. Dearly beloved, we are gathered here in the sight of all seven of my Transformations and also possibly God, in sight of *this* congregation, to celebrate the union of… *fuck*, GLIMMY, do I really have to say your whole name? Fine. *We’re here to celebrate the union of Lady Pearl Bonnibel Glimmer Luna Amity Angela Brightmoon, Countess Dryl and Earl Adora de l’Horde.* Wait. Adora? Do you not have any middle names? That’s--

- wow. I've never met an aristocrat without at least four names before.'

'Just. Say. The. *Proper*. Words.' said Glimmer.

'Really, Sparkles? *ALL* of them?! There's *pages* of this drivel...'

'Then, I don't know, just skip to the important bits.'

'*Me-ow*. Okay, whatever. Adora, Glimmer, do either of you know any big old reason you shouldn't be wed?'

'I---'

'They don't,' snapped Glimmer. 'And neither do I.'

'Noted. Now I cast that question out to everybody else. If anybody here should know of any just reason why these two shouldn't be bound together in holy matrimony, then speak now or forever hold your peace.'

And that was when it happened. Right on cue, the grand Red Drawing Room doors slammed open and a masked woman in a satin ballgown *strode* down the aisle, her curves flowing like an ocean made of caramel. The room held its collective breath. The

lady kept walking, *walking*, every eye in the room trained on her sultry form, until she could go no further. She had reached the altar. My heart was burned against my ribs. This was it. This was ***it****. This was IT.*

The room was silent. Catra stared down at the altar, her back bent, her tail starting to rise. Tipping her head very slightly my way, her gold and sapphire gaze caught mine and I *knew*. There was nothing in the world that could stop us. I nodded. She raised her hands to the mask and spun on her heels, going face to face with the entire Etherian elite. She was brave. She was sexy. She was my girl, my one and only. We were getting **out** of Shugborough Hall ***forever***.

'I object – because I *love* her.'

Catra thrust her arms out wide and the mask fell to the floor. The room gasped, even though this wasn't a surprise to a good dozen or so of the other people here.

'Oh *no*! What a *shock*!' Perfuma shouted. Bless her, she was trying her best to sell it, despite having all the acting talent of a prize sunflower. 'Scorpia, did *you* know that Adora was in love with Catra… I mean… *this perfect stranger*?'

And then, sudden as a summer shower, she fainted into the sideboard. Oh, wait. A quick correction. She *pretended* to faint, winking my way as she and Scorpy cleared us a quick path to the exit. Clever them. Lady P was no actress, but her subterfuge skills were off the scale.

As Scorpia "made some space" around the fallen gardener, the rest of our gang swung into action. Mermista started an "urgent investigation" that just so happened to block the aisle. Fumbling the wedding rings, Bow ducked down and obstructed the last remaining route Glimmer could use to follow us out of here. As for Entrapta? They'd tied up my uncle in conversation about a new type of interlocking gear mechanism.

Only Glimmer was still; only Glimmer was silent.

Fists balled so tight they were going white, she just stood there. Her eyes twitched and her mouth hung open. She was getting redder by the second, totally blindsided by the perfect execution of a dashed excellent plan. One eyebrow raised, Catra leant in toward her and gently touched her chin.

'There's your jaw,' purred Catra. 'You're welcome.'

'*I'LL* ***FUCKING*** *KILL YOU!!*'

Ah. Yes. We really should have seen that coming. Glimmer lunged at Catra, tears and hatred stinging her eyes. Sparks flew from fist to not-quite-face as Catra rolled away, scrabbling up the stage, preparing an exit plan where we both went straight out the nearest window. Alas, it was not to be, for the delay had given Glimmer time to reach inside her bodice and find the revolver she was now emptying at my girlfriend. Not ideal, that. And *not*

something I'd be allowing. The rainbows roared through me and Ms. Floaty-C snapped back to my side.

'*For the Honour of… No. Wait. Light Hope was terrible. Um. Ah-ha!* ***For the Honour of Meowmeow!!***'

White light flashed through me but it wasn't like before. It snagged and stuttered, growing cold and sickly, falling away into the shadows biting their way up my right arm. *No*. *No, She-Ra. Don't desert me now.* I had to stop this sapping force. I had to **fight** it. Eyes flickering open, I spun to face my nameless enemy, sword already in hand, but what good is even enchanted steel against the ancient evil of the dowager aunt?

'*Adora*.'

'Auntie.'

'My precious girl.'

'I'm not a girl.'

'You have a golden opportunity here to redeem yourself and lift your family to the highest heights. I will **never** accept your perversions but I can be persuaded to… *overlook* them if it connects us to the Brightmoon Duchy. *Think*, Adora. You can have wealth, power, unbridled access to anything you might require –

and you still get to satisfy your strange lusts. *Deal* with your valet and marry the Countess. That is an *order*.'

'I won't be doing that. **I love Catra**.'

Aunt Shadowtha's nails gripped deeper into my arm. She was starting to draw blood.

'*Insolent child*. You will do as I say or face the consequences. I raised you from birth to serve the de l'Horde name – I gave you the finest education, the best and most generous upbringing money could provide – and you would throw that all away for a common invert street whore?!'

'You TAKE THAT ***BACK***.'

My words reverberated from deep inside me. The room flooded with a bluish gold. Way above us, the ceiling and chandeliers started to shake. Not that Auntie seemed to care. Freezing with ancient rage, she grabbed at my shirt and yanked me so close I could almost taste her. She smelt of gardenias and hate.

'I shall do *nothing* of the sort. Go with her and you will **never** see your home, your trust fund and any part of the de l'Horde estate *ever* again. And don't go thinking that will keep your precious Meowmeow safe. You'll let your guard down eventually. She is queer vermin and I *will* make sure she is handled accordingly.'

‘Don’t you **DARE** touch her!!’

The ancient rainbows stopped flowing. Those waterfalls were swirling now, building, whipping around inside me into a bundle of light and heat and colour and noise so intense they were eating me from the inside and all I could do was *scream*. And **what** a scream. The ground shook. The stage collapsed. The chimney fell in through the fireplace; the paintings thundered to the floor; the windows exploded under the weight of my hate and my fury and my *love*. Oh, and the walls. The walls began to burn, slowly at first – smouldering tiny wisps of smoke – and then fast. *So fast.* Flames erupted down the wallpaper and the Red Drawing Room was ablaze.

‘What have you *done?!*’ Aunt Shadowtha screamed. I didn’t answer. I was *done* with the de l’Hordes, once and for all. Kicking her away, I scrambled to grab Catra, only to find Double-Trubel emerging from beneath his parapet.

‘Is the fighting over? A gunshot scar would play *murder* with my profile. Oh, good, you’re both here. Dearly beloved blah-blah… Do you, Sir Adora *et cetera* take her, Catra ‘Apfelmus’ Applesauce Meowmeow to be your lawfully wedded wif---?’

‘**Not** the time D.T.!! Get Glimmer and get out of here.’

‘But I had this whole speech – I was switching back to the side of good! It was going to be my big redemption arc and oh, kittens,

won’t you *think* of the DRAMA?!?’

‘This’ll be more of a tragedy if you don’t start getting people out of here,’ said Catra. ‘So *go* already!!’

We fought forward, together, aiming at those huge oak doors. Bow was three steps ahead of us, gathering people up from every pew, leading the shocked and scared by the hand.

‘Everybody! Exit via the windows if you can or follow us to the doors. We need to leave *now*. Scorpia?! *Adora?!* The doors. Open the doors!!’

We rushed toward them but, before we could get there, they just swung open. As if by magic. Oh, but it wasn’t magic. It was something far worse. It was Skyhawk.

‘Greetings!! I, the *famed* aviator Skyhawk, have just *expertly* landed my aircraft in your drawing room. And, though I am not at *all* to blame, I wanted to alert you there that there may just be the *tiniest…* …fire.’ His words trailed off as he finally looked *into* the room he was entering – and saw the growing inferno. ‘Oh. ***Never mind…***’

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Chapter End Notes
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Hi there! SleeveGarters here. I started writing this story nearly three years ago and I'm so SO excited to be on the verge of finishing it. I'm surprisingly emotional too... I'm really gonna miss this novel when it's over. Every comment really has meant a lot - I'd never really written fiction before this story. I guess I was inspired by how much I (still) love Catradora!!

I'd love to know what you're thinking on the cusp of the finale - please do comment if you've got anything to say :)

I've got another Catradora idea coming for after this novel... but much, much fluffier and more modern xxx

Meowmeow: The Final Chapters. Part 4 - Adora vs. Everyone & Everything

Chapter Summary

'Evil's coming and shadows are all around. Danger surrounds us but it will *not* get this good knight down. We're on the edge of greatness, turning a house fire into... um... a different kind of light.'

'I'm right beside you, Adora, ready to fight. In this final chapter, we find every bit of strength and promise to never let each other go.'

'And that, Reader-doodles, is how you win in the end.'

Chapter Notes

I diiiiiiidddd it!!!! Wooooo!! Thanks so much for reading, for comments, for sticking with this story!! Full notes about the story and thank yous from me are in the Afterword at the very end!! :)

Content warnings apply for the below chapter only - Spoilers may be present in the warnings. This story does not include any of the four Archive Warnings topics, but does occasionally feature other topics that may require content notes.

Chapter 65 Content Warnings (CONTAINS SPOILERS):
Guns - Narrated and in speech, present, several, multiple fired (no injuries)
Shooting - Narrated, present, several shots (no injuries)
Threat of violence/murder - Narrated and in speech, present, several times by several characters
Swords, axe, bladed weapons - Narrated and in speech, present, some used for threat, some used for violence
Abusive parenting - In speech, present and historic, brief
Unarmed violence - Narrated, present, brief, for good cause

(no lasting injury)
Axe attack - Narrated, present, causes major injury, some description (magically heals)
Blood - Narrated, present, moderate description (magically heals)
Wound - Narrated, present, brief description (magically heals)
Pain - Narrated, present, extensive
House fire - Narrated and in speech, present, extensive, some peril/risk to life (no injuries or death)
Improvised weapon attack - Narrated, present, brief detail, causes unconsciousness, no lasting injury
Loss of consciousness - Narrated, present, no lasting injury

See the end of the chapter for more notes

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MEOWMEOW: THE FINAL CHAPTERS

4 of 4

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Fire. The house was very much and absolutely on fire. Flames licked down the walls as the plaster melted and popped from the ceilings, shattering into the furniture like the angriest meringues. Ancient horsehair cushions burnt like matchsticks. Gold-rimmed sofas melted into angry puddles. Sparks skittered and, *woof*, there went the tables, their antique varnish burning musty-sweet. People were panicking, milling, doing literally anything other than actually *leaving* this literal Hell.

‘Move!’ I shouted. ‘Get out of here already, dash it!’

My words choked under the crash of the collapsing roof. Burning timbers crashed to the floor but, still, half the room just wouldn’t be budged. Fine. Desperate times call for matching measures and all that. Clutching Catra to my chest, I thrust Ms. Floaty-C up into the air, screamed and ran straight *at* the wedding guests. Scorpia rushed to my side and joined the roar, wildly swinging a fire axe at Etheria’s best and brightest.

‘Hi, sorry, hi! I’m *Scorpia* and this is *Adora* and, oh, this darling kitty is Catra and… well… This could be a little awkward but if you don’t hurry up and get out of here we’re going to get angry. And we will ***not*** be resolving our emotions with a cup of tea and some nice biscuits. *No*. We’re… um… going to have to attack you.’

‘What she means is that you’re all going to get into the garden or else,’ drawled Detective Whirlpool Mermot. ‘Also I have a gun now.’

She did. And she was pointing it just to the left of Aunt Shadowtha’s head.

‘This is an *outrage*---’ Auntie was saying.

A warning shot flew past her. Mermot pulled back the hammer and aimed straight at my matriarch's head. She would not "miss" again.

'Err, no,' Mermot said, 'the outrage, as you call it, was when you got me expelled from school for kissing your niece. I'm still pretty mad about it. So if you don't want me telling Scotland Yard you died a slow, agonising death in this house fire, you'll shut the fuck up, go outside and stay out of Adora's way already.'

Aunt Shadowtha crossed her arms and glowered. But she did go. The rest of the room followed her – and not one moment too soon. As Scorps axe-waved the last guest onto the lawn, the flames finally found their way to the cocktail bar. And that was the end of the Red Drawing Room. Glimmer had stacked the drinks cabinet so high with naval-proof rum and extra strength gin that the whole thing detonated like a landmine, erasing everything in its path. The entire north wing sagged like wet gingerbread, but significantly more on fire than that implies.

Molten glass slammed through the sky above us as the final windows gave way. We needed to be further away, down the steps, past the fountain. The attendees didn't need telling twice. Now they could see the blaze from the outside, the assembled party guests were suddenly a lot more invested in running from it. Calling instructions, blocking off exits, we got them all down to the waterfront and started counting heads.

'How many people are meant to be here tonight?'

‘You’ve destroyed my home, de l’Horde. Just *why* would I want to speak to *you*?’

Ah. Quite reasonably, the Duchess had decided she didn’t like me again.

‘Because, your Grace, there are more important things than bricks or mortar,’ I replied. ‘There are human lives at stake.’

‘What about *my* family and *our* life?! Or does that not matter to the She-Ra?’

‘We don’t have time for this. HOW. MANY. PEOPLE?’

‘Are you *threatening* me with that sword? I knew your kind were a threat to Etherian values but I never *dreamed* you’d murder your better in cold blood.’

‘I don’t want to kill you. I want to *save* lives and--- Forget it. Where’s your husband?! MICAH!! *MICAH?!?*’

‘Sir Adora, good to see you! Such a shame the wedding got delayed, don’t you think? Will it be next week you try again – or maybe August?’

‘You still want me to marry Glimmer?!’

‘Of course! Anything for my little girl!’

‘So you’re not mad about---’ I gestured at the inferno. ‘---all of this?’

‘Pfft. It’s only a house. We’ve got others.’

‘Micah, how many people are meant to be here tonight? Guests *and* staff?’

‘Well, there was a guest list of three hundred but we had… hmm… seven no-shows. Ha! They’re off the Christmas card list. Well, for this year, anyhow. You can’t stay mad at people for too long now, can you?’

My jaws ground into each other. This was taking *forever*. When it comes to fires, that’s time you simply don’t have to spare. Trust me. I’ve started enough accidental blazes to know. Still, this was by *far* the biggest, which almost feels like it should be an achievement. The blaze was getting its orangey-yellow teeth into the centre section now and its suites upon suites of bedrooms. Anybody trapped up there didn’t have long. As my eyes adjusted to the glare, I could’ve sworn I saw a single shadow *inside* the blaze. **Fuck**.

‘Okay, *okay,*’ I said, trying to speed the Duke along, ‘so that’s two ninety-three, plus me and Glimmer?’

‘Not forgetting that lovely Catra of yours!’

‘You were *expecting* her to show up?!’

Micah cocked his head.

‘To her own wedding?! Of course. And I just *loved* the way she did it. Late, fashionable, fashionably late. She had it all going on! Ah, I can just picture you and your two blushing brides promenading around the gardens here at Shug--- Ah. No. Scratch that. How does Upton House sound?’

‘*Focus*. *Please*. How many servants are on the property tonight?’

‘A full 56 – we brought a few occasionals up from the villages and put them to work in the kitchens. For handsome pay, of course!’

‘Yes. How didn’t I see that before?! You know your staff really well, don’t you? Can you ***please*** go and count them *now*?’

Practically pushing him into the gaggle of maids and cooks, I ditched the Duke and raced off to find Catra. She was precisely

where I expected, diligently counting and recounting the assembled party guests. Even Glimmer. Who was looking decidedly Miss Havisham in her torn and smeared wedding gown. She was starting *daggers* at us. But that really wasn't our biggest problem right now.

'*Catra,* I've got the numbers and---'

'Perfuma is trapped in the building.'

'I'll go and get her.'

'*No*. You won't. Don't you remember what the flames were doing to the staircase when we left? It's too fragile to bear more than the slightest bit of weight. You or Scorpia *can't* make it up there – but I can.'

'What? No? *Catra?!* As your girlfriend, I explicitly forbid you to go in that building.'

She shook her head, a tear playing against her lashes.

'There's no-one else with the experience and slender build to save her, sir.'

‘But think of the danger!!’ I grasped for her hands. ‘I don’t want you to get hurt. I *care* about you.’

‘You just have to trust me, Adora. I can’t stand by and watch a woman suffer. It’s not who I am.’

‘Can’t I at least *help?!*’

‘You can – by putting *us* first. That’s all I need you to do.’

‘I will, always.’

‘So go the boat shed, get us a skiff and wait there, ready to row for our new life. We’re ***not*** popular here and we *really* ought to make a quick exit.’

‘By rowing? I’m good, Catra, but I’m not faster than a car. Or a train. Or another, faster sort of boat.’

‘*Trust me, okay?* I *need* you to do that… and… I’m sorry.’

The words hit me hard – but her foot hit me harder. Stamping her full bodyweight on my left tootsie, Catra slammed herself down through my arms, hit the floor and started running, running so fast I’d need to give it my best and brightest just to catch up.

Well, she hadn't reckoned on the power of the chivalrous She-Raic forces crossed with an obsessive gymnasium habit. On my marks, get set, g----aarrrwwwwwwfffffgggghhhh!!

Ping.

Something wet raced up the inside of my left leg. The pain that followed it was indescribable. Crumpling to the floor, I began to feel the blood gushing, spurting. The corners of the world went purple-black. I was on the floor, gasping, wheezing, breathing in grass. Off in the distance, the fire woofled and flashed. There was thumping. Splintering. Screams. And the smell of blood. Oh Horde. *Oh Horde*. Had Catra? Or Perfuma? I rolled over, desperate not to see the worst.

Oh. Phew. Neither of those lovely ladies had fallen to their deaths. That wasn't their blood spraying like an arterial fountain all over the flowerbeds, thank the Dickens. It was mine. There was an awful lot of it and it was hurrying out the holes where my calf muscles used to be. So that was okay then. Jolly good show and all that! I just… felt like… it was time to… float up… to that lovely… white… tunnel…

'No, ***Adora***, don't go towards the light!'

'I'm not dying, Bow. I'm just taking a rest in this very fluffy waiting room.'

‘That sounds like *DYING* – which you are **not** allowed to do on my watch, okay?!?’

Bowregard clutched me to his chest, like a messy, woozy babe-in-arms. Either he was burning hot or I was getting very, *very* cold. The coming night blurred overhead. It was a beautiful time, don’t you think, for a not-quite-girl to smear viscera all over their friend. Not that Bow seemed to mind. He was too busy jabbing a finger at Glimmer and shouting.

‘What do you think you’re doing?! You hit Adora with an *AXE!!*’

‘Because she was trying to run into the house, duh!! Did you want me to just *let* my spouse and your friend die horribly?!’

‘And potentially fatal axe wounds are better?!’

‘Let me near her. I need to talk to her.’

‘NO. You’re not going anywhere ne-aarrrggghh!!’

Bow dropped to the floor and the hands around me changed. They were firmer now, bloodier, more insistent. Her fingers dug deep into my shoulders, pinning me to the bench as her gore-streaked face glared down at me. Glimmer had me in her claws and she was *never* letting go.

‘Don’t you GET it, Adora?!? I *LOVE* you. I always have. So PLEASE, *just* this once, ***stay***.’

But she didn’t love *me*. The person she loved was the dutiful servant, the fellow aristocrat, the Oxford beefcake, the strong chivalric knight, the society darling, the dream she’d constructed over years of parties and picnics, at-any-price adventures and gilded escapades. Just like Aunt Shadowtha, the Hord Akmiral, my teachers, my tutors, Duke Brightmoon, Light Hope and almost everyone else I’d ever met, she loved the noble facade I’d been raised to be.

She loved Sir de l’Horde.

And Sir de l’Horde was gone.

White-blue light surged through me, stripping back each cell and polishing it to a new and blinding shine. My wounds closed. My bones knit. My muscles grew back. I was stronger than I’d ever been, sharper and shining with conviction no man or god could shake. Pulsing gold from ever pore, towering taller than She-Ra ever had before, from this day forth I was *Adora*. And I used my powers for love.

‘Goodbye, Glimmer. I have a boat to catch.’

I strode away, chest held high. I'd done it – the nightmare was over. And I was bloody well proud of myself. Boots crunching against the gravel, I took those final steps to the boat house, ears straining for the matching footsteps of my one, my true, my equal. *There* she was. I spun round, bracing for a kiss that could save the universe and… um… had she meant to bring *quite* so many of our enemies with her?

'***There*** they are!! GET them!!'

Ah. Yes. Turns out telling Glimmer how we planned to escape was a pretty bad idea. She was hot on our tails, swinging her axe in one hand and a gun in the other. Micah – having finally understood the idea that I was *not* going to marry his daughter – was packing pretty serious firepower too. And that's to say nothing of the de l'Hordes. If looks could kill, we two would already have been very dead. Catra raised one exactingly-plucked eyebrow at the sight. She looked *perfect* and remarkably unruffled for a woman who'd just battled a building-eating fire.

'I think we'll be taking our leave, sir. This way. And could you carry me?'

'Why?'

'*Please*.'

Darting through the trees, we tumbled down a bank and into the front of the boat house. Ah. That'd be the why. There was no longer any way in here that didn't involve getting very wet indeed. Peering into the gloom, I dimly made out the metal bars blocking the doors – and our pursuers. The jetty was gone too, drowned under the weight of a thousand very jagged offcuts. They peered out above the waterline like a tetanus iceberg.

'Careful, Adora. You *don't* want to catch yourself on any of those. Entrapta was very… obliging.'

Picking my way round the scraps, I lifted us into the front boat. It was the only one that hadn't been scuttled. Catra *had* been busy. Whipping blankets off the stern, she revealed an outboard motor and tugged it into life. We were *off*. Away we went, through the shattered remains of the boat house doors and onto the river. But we weren't out of the woods yet. Literally *or* figuratively.

As the trees scraped at our bows, one final bridge stood between us and our possible freedom. Half of our attackers were still stuck by the sunken boats but, oh, the other half were in hot pursuit. They were running, they were sprinting, then they were *at* the bridge, leering at us, spitting, shaking fists, brandishing weapons. A shot fizzed past us into the water. Catra snarled, scrambling for an umbrella. We huddled together and *waited*. The next shot bounced off us. And the next.

'Alclad armour,' she explained. 'Courtesy of Entrapta.'

'Ingenious! But… were you *expecting* us to get shot? Um. Again?'

‘A good gentlewoman is always prepared.’

When the bullets finally subsided, she handed me an oar. It didn’t *appear* to be very technologically advanced. In fact, it just looked like an ordinary wooden boat paddler.

‘Catra, what is this?’

‘I believe it’s a scull, sir. Made of English oak, if I’m not mistaken.’

‘And just what are you expecting me to do with it?’

‘You’ll know when the time comes, Adora.’

For the next ten minutes or so, the time didn’t come. Then, very suddenly, it did.

‘*Sparkle-sparkle, bitches!!’*

Glimmer warped into sight and flew towards our boat, triumph already etched in her glittering grin. It was almost tragic. She thought she’d considered all the angles. She didn’t even see the oar coming. *Thwump*, it went, knocking Countess Dryl very much unconscious. Now, I know what you’re thinking. *It isn’t very polite to knock a woman out cold*. That’s true. If I may over a

counterpoint, however, nor is it the best of manners to attempt a murder, so I'd like to believe mine and Glimmer's actions cancel out.

So I told Lady P and her trusty Scorps when they met us on the riverbank, some half-an-hour later. Entrusting the unawake but unharmed Glimmer unto their care, I watched as Perfuma dutifully tied her up with her prettiest but strongest vines and heard the tales of Catra's heroics. She had literally run through fire for Perfuma. After that, the now-engaged Ladies Scorfuma were quite willing to do *anything* for us, which on this occasion meant driving down to the agreed location and getting the Countess out of our hair.

There were hugs and mutual *good lucks*, then they were gone. Tip-toeing back to our boat, Catra lifted the engine out of the water and handed me back my oars. The next section of river was too quiet for a motor. We'd stand out from the noise alone. So I sculled, my back heaving, the starlight glittering off Catra's cheeks as we laughed and talked and planned a thousand tomorrows.

'So what do we next? Go to Oxford?'

'To wherever we want, Adora.'

'And where would that be for you?'

‘America? Berlin, for your surgery? *Paris?* We could leave Etheria far behind.’

‘I’d… I’d like that. At least for now.’ I smiled – and it was a *real* smile. One I wanted to last forever. ‘But how would we get there? We’ve got no funds and nothing more than this boat.’

‘Your answer… is… just about *here*.’

Catra grinned and nodded up at the bank. There was a road – and by the road there was a gravel spit – and on the gravel there was a 1928 Frazer-Nash Supersports.

‘*Is that my car?!*’

‘Repainted and fitted with new numberplates to disguise it. Oh, and I took the liberty of filling the boot with all the cash I could… *requisition* from your Aunt’s place. If we leave now, we can make tomorrow’s Golden Arrow to France. I booked us a couple’s cabin for the crossing… I hope that’s okay?’

‘It’s *more* than okay. Why, Catra, you’re the cat’s whiskers.’

*This was a **new** life – for both of us*. I jumped up with glee, then down… and *down*… and down into the river below. The boat was going under. I’d stamped a hole in it. But, oh, what did it matter, when I had *her?!* Scooping the inimitable Lady Meowmeow up in

my arms, I took her shoulders, she cradled my head and we *kissed.* It was ***everything***. Just me, my Lady and a sinking row boat.

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THE END

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AND THE BEGINNING

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Sir Adora and her Lady Meowmeow will return in The Code of the Meow-Ras and other short stories.

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POSTSCRIPT

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‘Strike up the horns and strum the double bass, that’s us over and done with… at least for now. It all got a bit dramatic for a moment there, didn’t it? But all’s well that ends well. And this has ended up very well indeed! I got away *and* got the girl, just like I promised way back at the beginning of this whole endeavour. So it’s a bally great thanks for reading from one Mrs. Meow-Ra…’

‘And so long from the other Mrs. Meow-Ra. … *Hey, Adora, we’re actually* ***married!!***’

‘Yes! I know! And I think we should kiss about it!! Right now!!’

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Chapter End Notes

That’s it! You’ve finished The Inimitable Meowmeow. I hope you enjoyed reading it as much as I loved creating it. I’ve always wanted to write a full novel and I’m SO proud to have finally achieved that goal. That said, I kinda wish this story could go on forever… Meowmeow was total joy for me these last three years (I started ages before I got brave enough to start posting it) – and your comments were a big part of that.

This is the first story I ever put out into the world and I’m flattered and grateful you had something to say about it. Thank you. I particularly want to say a huge thanks to everyone who kept commenting on a load of chapters – PinkStorm, Utter_Immolation, Favre_the_Undead, Marlolcat_28, Ri2 and Crack_Fic_Casey. If you're all still reading, thank you!! I wouldn’t have finished without the encouragement I got from your comments. I hope you maybe find my next Catradora fics and enjoy those too…
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Speaking of new stories, there's definitely more Meowmeow coming. But in much shorter stories! I've got ideas for meeting Finn, another Mer-mystery, Adora's top surgery, an ocean liner voyage to New York etc. Outside of that? My next Catradora fic is gonna be My Fayre Lady – a friends-to-lovers fake dating romp where besties Adora and Catra head to a wedding fayre… and discover they're more than just friends…

Now! Perhaps you want to know just a little about how this story came together. I've been a Catradora shipper since Season 1 in 2018. They're the couple that got me into fandom and I still absolutely love them. I also adore P.G. Wodehouse's Jeeves & Wooster novels. Gotta say, they've got a *very* gay and neurodivergent vibe that mapped onto Catra and Adora really well. When my friend OpiumPoppy came up with the idea of blending the two, I fell immediately in love with it. What followed was meant to be 5000 words tops and… well. It wasn't!!

As this story started to grow into something bigger, I decided to map it onto 1930 England as accurately as possible. Wherever I could, I've also drawn on my own experiences. So, yes, I've roared down country roads in vintage Bentleys, shivered in Oxford college bedrooms, navigated disastrous village fêtes and got lost on Cannock Chase, which is a real place. Shugborough Hall is the real deal too. If you ever find yourself in England, you can take a tour of almost everywhere I used in this story (only the bedrooms come from elsewhere – they're based on the Art Deco designs in Upton House, Warwickshire instead).

Oh, and Catra's suits all come from my own dapperly lesbian wardrobe!!

The history in this novel is also as true to life as I could manage. The Berlin club where Catra and Double-Trubel worked was one of the largest and most successful queer spaces in 1920s Berlin, while the nearby Institut für Sexualwissenschaft provided hormone therapy and pioneered

some affirming surgeries for trans people. The idea of Glimmer bringing queer friends to live with her as a way of keeping them safe also has a basis in real lives from the era. Fuck-the-law gay weddings were definitely going on then too. I can totally recommend various books if you want to learn more about our brave LGBTQ+ ancestors.

Everything She-Ra/Arth-Red comes from research into Indo-Celtic languages. "Arth" is the basis of the name Arthur and literally means "bear" – bears having a special position in early Celtic divinity. Just as Horde Prime steals and rebrands the She-Ra legend in this story, so the real life Norman-English and French aristocracy stole Arthurian legends from the Welsh and rewrote them for their own purposes. Arthur originally fought against the Anglo-Saxons, not with the English.

Last – but not least – I structured the novel around the series of the show. Each "season finale" chapter had a big plot development to go with it:

Chapter 13 – Catra and Adora hold each other for the first time
Chapter 20 – Glimmer throws Catra out of the Duesenberg
Chapter 26 – Catra and Adora reunite, have sex for the first time
Chapter 39 – Glimmer banishes Catra from Shugborough
Chapter 52 – Glimmer makes Adora her fiancée

Then chapters 53-65 are "Season Six" where Adora starts putting herself first. Why did Catra get to narrate two chapters? Because that's the number of Wooster stories written from Jeeves' perspective.

I'd love to know what you liked about this story, favourite sections, what stayed with you, what you would've liked to see more of… anything Meowmeow that's on your mind, really. As for me? My favs were the Catradora closeness of Chapters 13 and 26, the whole Cannock Chase/Perfuma

crush/Bentley crash arc from Chapter 22 to 25, the Mer-Mystery sequence and, of course, our happy ending.

Thank you again for reading, from the bottom of my Catradora-shipping heart. What's my next BIG big SPOP project, you ask? I'm making myself a Princess Prom suit for a Catra cosplay – wish me luck!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!